



THE LONG GRACE

TABLE SCRAPS

LORE · ENGINES · SONGS · GAMES · CARDS ·
LEXICON

EVERYTHING LEFT ON THE PLATE

NOTHING WAS WASTED. NOT THE HOOVES, NOT
THE HIDE, NOT THE EYES.

[CARVED OVER THE WEIGHHOUSE DOOR, SATED]

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▼ WHAT IS LEFT ON THE PLATE

Nothing was wasted. Not the hooves, not the hide, not the eyes.

– CARVED OVER THE WEIGHHOUSE DOOR, SATED

INVENTORY OF A RIM ROAD LOST-PROPERTY CUPBOARD, THIMBLE CROSS WAYSTATION, TAKEN AFTER THE THAW OF 642. THE CLERK'S HAND GROWS SMALLER AS THE LIST GOES ON.

One phrasebook, Oathen, much thumbed; the chapter on condolences torn out. One bail-bucket, Brinehollow, initials scratched inside: T. & S., always. Three gloves, left hand only, grey, lined with lead. A child's reader with a page of Hallowboard coloured in, carefully, in brown, all eight sides. A clockwork thing that ticks when nobody is in the room. A candle, unlit, labelled in Wick Tallow's shop-hand with a name the clerk knows. A pair of dice, bone, one of them warm. Forty-one place cards in a ribbon, all blank but one. A recipe for bread in a hand that is not quite a hand. A deck of cards,

the top one turned up: Company. A dictionary, A to K only, with guest underlined in red.

Claimed: none. Do not open the cupboard after dark. Do not count the cards.

The Long Grace core book gave you the Table. *Seven Tables* gave you its people and the pieces of its gods. **Table Scraps** is everything else: the things that lie about on the Table after the meal, the things people carry, sing, cook, build, play and say.

It is a book to be used in pieces. Hand a player a page from the Book of Exits before they go to Oathen. Read the Ferrying Song aloud at a Sallowreach funeral. Cook the Fatlands wake-loaf (the real one, which is only bread) for your Tablenight session. Deal the Lack Deck on the table and let the dice decide when someone has to draw. Look up a word in the Lexicon and find a story in it.

EVERY SCRAP ON THE TABLE WAS PART OF
SOMETHING ONCE. MOST OF THEM REMEMBER.

[CUTWRIGHT'S PROVERB]

▼ WHAT THIS BOOK CONTAINS

- ◆ **Part One: Found Pages.** Twelve in-world documents, reproduced at length: an Oathen phrasebook of safe speech, a year of the Cradlewrack Tally, the Long Count, an Unfed child's reader, the Seamer's pattern book, the Netwatch Register of the Called, Bed One's Words, the Rim Road Company handbook, Wick Tallow's candle catalogue, the Weighing Almanac, the Glovemaking's Ledger, and confessions to the Bench. Each comes with notes for the Carver.
- ◆ **Part Two: Engines and Songs.** The machinery of the Grace, with parts, workings, rules and failure tables; then the hymns, lullabies, work songs and curses of the seven lands, a calendar of 365 proverbs, the graffiti of the Rim, and the bedtime stories every land tells its children, with the true events behind them.
- ◆ **Part Three: Food and Play.** The Table's Cookbook, each grim recipe paired with a real one for your own table; trinkets,

keepsakes and the contents of dead people's pockets; and a dozen in-world games with complete rules you can play with ordinary dice, cards and coins.

- ◆ **Part Four: The Decks.** Printable cards: the Lack Deck for disastrous rolls, the Grace Deck for perfect ones, the Hunger Deck for bodies that change, Pall Cards for villages going mad, Tablenight Cards, and Market Cards. Each deck also has a roll table for groups who do not print.
- ◆ **Part Five: The Lexicon.** A dictionary of Table-speech and its seven dialects, A to Z, with slang, curses, euphemisms, trade cant, titles and etymologies.

A WORD ON THE REAL RECIPES AND THE REAL GAMES

The recipes marked **For Your Table** are ordinary, safe food: bread, stews, cakes, pickles and jellies, themed to the dishes they accompany. Nothing on the Table's own menus should ever be cooked. The in-world games use ordinary dice, cards and coins and can be played for buttons, sweets or nothing. The Table plays for higher stakes. You do not have to.

CONTENT

Everything in the core book's content warning applies here. These pages contain graphic body horror, murder, cannibalism, desecration of the dead, blasphemy, and suicide and madness spreading through communities, always as tragedy and never as instruction. Sexual taboo, cursed bloodlines and necrophilia are implied only, and concern adults only. Keep using Lines, Veils and the Grace.



PART ONE

FOUND PAGES

*Documents of the Table, reproduced: phrasebooks, ledgers, readers,
registers, catalogues and confessions.*

CHAPTER 1

FOUND PAGES I

Documents of the Table

Paper is the only thing on the Table that keeps its word without being made to.

– INSCRIPTION OVER THE DOOR OF THE CUTWRIGHTS' COLLEGE READING-ROOM, THIMBLE CROSS

Read it to me again. Slower. I want to hear where it goes wrong.

– A KEPT GRANDMOTHER OF LASTGATE, TO THE GRANDSON READING HER THE SEAMERS' BILL

The Table writes itself down constantly, because writing is the only way a frightened people has of pretending a thing is finished. Every land keeps books, and every book is a confession of what that land cannot stop. This chapter reproduces six of them at length, as they might be found by the Guests: on a stall at Gristmoot, in a dead man's satchel, nailed to a barn, pressed into a child's hands at a border post, left open on a Netwatch bench at dawn with the ink not yet dry. Each is given as a long excerpt, mostly set as in-world text, and each is followed by **Carver's notes**: the hooks that bring the document into play, the rules for using it, and the secrets it holds that its writers did not know they were keeping.

The documents are meant to be handled. Print them, read them aloud, cut them into slips and hand them across the table one page at a time. A Guest who finds a page should be able to read it the way their character would, which means slowly, by bad light, with something important smudged.

USING FOUND PAGES

- ◇ **As handouts.** Every excerpt here can be given to the players in its own words. The Carver's notes cannot.
- ◇ **As clocks.** Several documents (the Tally, the Long Count, the Register) are records that go on being kept. If the Guests return to the source later, add entries. The numbers should always be worse.
- ◇ **As evidence.** Each document contains at least one thing that, put beside another document in this chapter, says something nobody on the Table wants said. The notes point these out. Let the players find them first if they can.
- ◇ **As objects.** A found book has weight, smell and a price. A Guest carrying the Register of the Called on the Mile at night is carrying something the Netwatch will want back.

▼ THE BOOK OF EXITS



Every foreigner who comes up Treaty Stair into Tacit is sold a copy before they reach the top. It is a small, square, felt-bound book, the size of a palm, printed on the grey canyon paper that does not crack in the heat, and it is the most widely owned book in Oathen after the Book of Questions in Cradlewrack and the Pantry Lists in the Fast. Its proper title is longer than most of its entries. Its common name is the Book of Exits, and the Bench of Clauses has issued it, revised it and quietly withdrawn pages from it thirty-one times since 412 A.G.

The Book is a phrasebook of safe speech: sentences for the ordinary business of life, each one tested by the Under-Drafters of the Hall of Conditions (the Bench's own testing, which is done on volunteers, prisoners and Forsworn who have broken ground to spare) and found, in its printed form and in its stated situation, not to bind beyond its meaning. Merchants carry it. Rim Road factors carry two, in case one is stolen. Oathen mothers give it to their children at the Unbitting, with the dangerous pages pinned shut. The copy reproduced here is the thirty-first printing, of Grace 640, bought at Quillhouse by a Fatlands barrel-factor named Abel Strake, whose marginal notes in a broad, greasy hand are given in brackets. He was carrying it when he came apart on the Wending road in Carving 641. The Book was found in his coat. It was open at the chapter on haggling.

THE BOOK OF EXITS, or, Safe Speech for the Traveller, the Factor, the Bride, and the Child Lately Unbitted. Being Phrases Proved Before the Hall of Conditions and Found, as Printed and in Their Places, Not to Bind Beyond Their Meaning. Compiled by the Under-Drafters of the Bench of Clauses. The Thirty-First Printing, Grace 640 A.G. Sold at Quillhouse, at Treaty Stair, and at the Felt Market, three lacks, with errata slip.

THE PUBLISHERS DO NOT WARRANT, AND THIS IS NOT A PROMISE, THAT ANY PHRASE IN THIS BOOK WILL PROTECT ANY SPEAKER IN ANY SITUATION. THE PUBLISHERS STATE ONLY THAT EACH PHRASE HAS BEEN SPOKEN, IN THE SITUATION GIVEN, BY A PERSON WHO WAS AFTERWARD FOUND WHOLE, AS FAR AS THE HALL COULD SEE.

TO THE READER. This book does not promise you anything. Read that sentence twice; it is the safest in the book, and the

drafters spent eleven days on it. You have come into a country where your words are physical, where what you say is weighed by a god that is no longer outside you, and where a careless sentence will open you along a scam you did not know you had. We cannot teach you to speak as we speak. That takes a childhood in the bit. We can give you sentences that other people have survived. Use them as written. Do not improve them. Do not add "truly" or "really" or "I swear" for warmth. Warmth is how foreigners die here. If no phrase in this book fits your situation, the phrase that fits is silence, and silence is always available, and is never rude.



Silence is always available, and is never rude.

THE BOOK OF EXITS, PREFACE; PRINTED ON THE
BACK COVER OF EVERY EDITION SINCE THE NINTH

OF GREETING

OF GREETING, AND OF THE FIRST WORDS SAID TO A STRANGER.

1. "I see you." For good morning, good evening, and well met. It is a true statement about the speaker, and it cannot be broken while your eyes are open. Do not say it to the blind. (They are not offended; the Hall simply has no ruling.)
2. "You are here, and so am I." The greeting between equals in the Galleries. Answer with the same words. It is a pleasantry, and it is also a statement of fact; if either party is not, in some sense, here, it is better that the matter be raised early.
3. "Well met, I think." Never say "well met" alone. A meeting that turns out ill makes the speaker a liar after the fact, and the Book of Ruptures records forty cases of split lips at the end of bad bargains begun with those two words.
4. When asked "How are you?", answer "As you see me." Never answer "Fine." Never answer "Never better." (The second has been heard as a vow of decline.)
5. When introducing yourself: "I am called Abel Strake." Not "I am Abel Strake." The Hall has twice ruled that a person

may not, in the god's hearing, be the same thing as their name, and has twice been unable to say why.

6. When entering a house: "Am I let in?" When letting someone into yours: "The door is open, for the present." Never "make yourself at home." That is a promise of a home, and it has been kept, in at least one case, by a guest who would not leave for nineteen years and could not be removed without breaking the host.

7. When parting: "If able." The answer is "Go on." This exchange binds neither party, and it is how every Oathener says goodbye to every other, including at deathbeds. Do not say "see you soon." Do not say "take care," which is an instruction, and is not rude, but may be heard as the beginning of a bargain.

8. Before eating with strangers, the common grace is signed in Oathen. If you must say it aloud, say: "Lack keep away, so far as I may ask it, for the length of this meal." It is slow. You will be thanked for the slowness.

[In margin, Strake: said the grace short at the Quillhouse table first night. Clerk put her hand over my mouth like I was her own child. Did not know whether to be grateful or knock her down. Was grateful.]

OF REFUSING MARRIAGE, AND OF ACCEPTING IT

The Book's longest chapter is the one foreigners read least. It is written for the Unbitted, who at twelve are thrown into the canyons' furious courtship economy without a single safe sentence of their own, and it is the chapter Oathen parents read aloud at the Unbitting supper while the child, newly mouth-free and terrified, sits with lips pressed together.

OF REFUSING MARRIAGE, AND OF ACCEPTING IT, AND OF THE MANY THINGS BETWEEN.

Marriage in Oathen is a Solemn oath and is drafted, not spoken. Nothing said at a proposal is a marriage. But much said at a proposal is binding, and more harm is done in the canyons by refusals than by vows. A refusal is a promise about the future. Draft it as one.

11. "I do not, at this hour, intend it." The plain refusal. It describes your intention, which is a fact about you, and it leaves the future to the future. It is cold. It is meant to be.

12. "Not in this draft." The kind refusal. It is understood by everyone in Tacit to mean no, and it binds the speaker to nothing at all, since there will always be another draft.

13. "My kin have not drafted it." The delaying refusal. True of every unmarried person in Oathen. Use it to buy a season.

14. "I am honoured, I believe." Use before any of the above. Do not omit "I believe." A girl of the Shadeward said "I am honoured" to a suitor she despised, in 588, and her cheeks went red and stayed red, in two round blotches like a doll's paint, for the rest of her life. The Hall calls it the mildest rupture on record. She called it something else.

15. NEVER SAY: "I will never marry you." It is a Plain oath at the least, and the canyons are small, and the years are long, and people change, and families need water-shares. The Hall has records of seven women and four men who said it at sixteen and married the same person at thirty. The Breaking for a broken refusal is the heart. You will know the shape of it from the street.

16. NEVER SAY: "I could never love you." "Could" is a boast of incapacity and is heard as a vow. See 15.

17. NEVER SAY: "Over my dead body," to a parent, of a match. See the chapter of Phrases That Have Killed People.

18. To accept, say: "Let the drafters begin." Do not say "yes." A yes at a proposal is an unbounded promise, and the drafters have nothing to draft it down to. A boy of the Cisterns who said yes in 604 was held by the Hall to be married to his suitor in every respect any reading could find, including some the suitor had not intended, and the families settled the matter in a way the Hall does not print.

19. To one who asks again after refusal, say: "You have my answer, as given." Then go indoors. The second asking is a pressure; the third is a weapon; Oathen courtship has killed more young people by asking than by answering.

20. To a suitor who threatens to harm himself: say nothing at all. Go to his kin, and sign it to them. Anything you say to him will be weighed against what he does next, and you will carry it.

[In margin, Strake: thank the god I'm married already & in the Fatlands, where a wedding is two words and a ham.]

OF HAGGLING

OF HAGGLING, AND OF THE SPEECH OF THE MARKET.

The Felt Market of Tacit is the quietest market on the Table, and the most dangerous for a foreigner, because every price is a statement and every statement is weighed. Haggle in handtalk if you can. Since the Lack of 640 the Hall can no longer say that handtalk is entirely safe, but it is safer.

21. *"It appears dear to me." Never "It is too dear." The first is your perception, which is your own; the second is an assertion about value, and the Hall has no settled reading of value.*

22. *"I have seen it cheaper, I am told." A foreigner's favourite. It is safe only because it is absurd: you are saying that you have been told about your own seeing. The Hall permits it on the grounds that no god could be bothered.*

23. *"I would pay four, today." The "today" is the exit. If you come back tomorrow and pay five, you have broken nothing.*

24. *"That is my offer, for this hour." NEVER say "That is my last offer." See the chapter of Phrases That Have Killed People.*

25. *"Done, by these terms." Then sign the bargain with the closed right hand on the open left. Do not shake on it. A handshake is a Plain oath in its own right, independent of the words, and both of you will carry it.*

26. *The seller's phrases. You will hear these; they are not lies, and you should not be insulted. "Fresh this morning, I am told." "It weighs what the scale says." "My mother bought from this stall." "I have no cheaper, in this basket." Each tells you exactly how far the seller will stand behind what they say. Learn to hear the distance.*

27. *NEVER SAY to a seller: "You'd sell your own mother for that." It is an accusation, not a promise, and so it binds the seller to nothing. But the Hall has three cases since 630 in which the seller later did exactly that, at a fair price, to the Vaults, and in each case the seller swore that before the remark they had never once thought of it.*

28. *NEVER SAY: "I'll take the lot." You will. You will take it whether you have the money or not, and whether you want it or not, and the Bench will not intervene, because the seller heard you.*

[In margin, Strake: 28 is how Corlie Brass ended up with four hundredweight of sour cheese and no wagon. Laughed at the time. He walked it home. Carried it, I mean. Had to. His back went like a bow at the Rim boundary and he walked the last nine miles bent with a wheel of cheese on it. God help me I laughed.]

[In margin, a second note, smaller, Strake: 24. Do not forget 24.]



Learn to hear the distance.

THE BOOK OF EXITS, §26; THE PHRASE OATHEN
MOTHERS USE WHEN TEACHING CHILDREN TO
LISTEN TO STRANGERS

OF CONDOLENCE

OF CONDOLENCE, AND OF SPEECH IN THE PRESENCE OF THE DEAD.

The dead in Oathen stand in the Witnessing Vaults with their faces outward, and they hear. Speak at a wake as you would speak before the Bench, because you are.

31. *"I grieve with you, as I am able." The common condolence. Do not say "I share your grief." You do not, and the Hall has held that a grief claimed and not felt is a lie of Weight 3, and the mouth has gone in the middle of a eulogy.*

32. *"She was known to me." For speaking of the dead to the bereaved. It is true, it is modest, and it promises nothing about how she was known.*

33. *"There may be things I can do. Name one, and I will consider it." NEVER say "If there is anything I can do." It is an open promise to a grieving person, and grief asks for impossible things. The Hall's file on this phrase is the thickest in the Archive of Readings after the file on "always." It contains the case of the cooper who said it to a widow at her husband's niche, and was asked, in handtalk, very calmly, to bring him back; and what the cooper then attempted to do in the Vaults, for nine nights, alone, with his tools; and what the Keeners found.*

34. *NEVER SAY: "I will never forget her." Memory is weather. When you forget, and you will, you will break at the place where she touched you last, and you will not remember why it hurts.*

35. *NEVER SAY: "She is at peace." It is a statement about the condition of the dead, made in their hearing. The dead have Testified, on four occasions recorded in the Vaults, that they are not.*

36. *To the dead themselves, in the niche: "Stand well." It is a wish. Wishes do not bind, so far as the Hall has ever found, unless a Sayer makes them.*

37. *At the wake meal, if asked whether you will come to the anniversary: "That is my wish." Never "I'll be there."*

[In margin, Strake: said "she was known to me" at old Dellow's wake in Sated last spring out of habit and his daughter slapped me. Fatlands people want you to say you loved them. Wrong book for home.]

OF WAR, PARLEY AND THE HOLDING OF PASSES

OF WAR, OF PARLEY, AND OF THE HOLDING OF PASSES. Revised after Wending Pass. Read with the annexed Ruling of the Bench on Military Speech, which is not reprinted here, and which every officer of the Canyon Watch is required to have by heart.

41. "We are minded to hold." For the defence of any place. Never "We will hold." Never "to the last." Never, under any circumstances, "to the death." See Wending Pass, which every child of Oathen knows, and which this book will not rehearse.

42. "Advance, if able." The order of attack. Every soldier who hears it may stop when no longer able, and many have, and lived, and been flogged, and lived.

43. "You may come to harm here." The only threat this book will print. It is an observation. It is also, in the experience of the Watch, more frightening to an enemy than any vow of slaughter, because the enemy understands that the speaker is under no obligation to stop.

44. NEVER SAY: "I'll kill you." To a foreign soldier it is a boast. To you it is a Plain oath, and if you do not kill him, by your hand, you will break, and the Breaking for an unkept threat is the hand that did not do it.

45. At parley: "We come to talk, and intend no harm while talking." Draft the length of the talk before you begin.

46. In surrender: "We lay these arms down, as of this hour." Do not say "We will not take them up again." Your captors will want you to say it. Do not. Make them draft it.

47. To the wounded on the field: "Help is sought." Never "Help is coming." Help is not always coming. A sergeant of the Watch said "Help is coming" to a boy at the Gullet ford in 612 and held his hand until he died, and held it for an hour after, and when the relief came he could not open his fingers, and they are still closed, and he carries the boy's last grip in a hand that no longer opens.

[In margin, Strake: all very well for soldiers. When the Reckoners come at the wagons on the Wending road what am I meant to shout, "you may come to harm here"? Yes, says the clerk. Shout that.]

PHRASES THAT HAVE KILLED PEOPLE

The last chapter of the Book is printed on red paper, and since the twentieth printing it has been sewn in so that it can be cut out by parents. Most foreign copies keep it. Most Oathen copies do not. It

is the only part of the Book that the canyon-born read for pleasure, in the way other peoples read ghost stories, and it is the only part that grows: each printing has added one or two. The Breaking in Oathen is never fatal by itself, and the chapter says so in its first line. Then it explains, case by case, the ways in which that is no comfort.

PHRASES THAT HAVE KILLED PEOPLE. The Breaking does not kill. The Hall has never recorded a Breaking that killed by itself. What kills is the sentence: what it binds the speaker to do, or to be, or to suffer, after. These are the cases the Hall has found most instructive. Each phrase was spoken by an ordinary person in an ordinary hour. Read them to your children.

I. "I'M STARVING." Hodd Varrow, Slate-Clerk, Tongue-line, at the Course, 611. He said it at the fourth hour, coming in from the archive to the felted kitchen of his house on the Bench Terrace, as men have said it at the fourth hour since there were kitchens. His wife laid the table. He sat. He ate bread, figs, the green cheese, a bowl of goat stew, a second bowl. He said, puzzled, that he could not taste it, and that he was still starving. He ate everything in the pantry. By the ninth hour his cheeks had fallen in like a tent with the pole pulled out, and his wrists were as thin as a child's, and his belly was full and round and hard under his shirt, and he died at the table at the eleventh hour, weighing, the Bench's physicians found, five stone and two pounds, with the whole of his pantry in him undigested. At the Course, a figure of speech is no longer a figure.

II. "THAT IS MY LAST OFFER." Mattick Sone, wool-factor, of the Felt Market, 597. He said it, and was refused, and went home, and the next day offered again, higher. His tongue split at the first word, lengthwise, in two neat halves like a snake's. It healed so. He went on trading by handtalk. Six years later, at a sale, he offered a bid on a bale of felt with his fingers, and his fingers broke at the first sign, all ten, outward. The god had held that he had made his last offer, and every offer after it was a lie. He could not buy bread. He could not offer to pay for it. He could not offer to work for it. He sat in the Felt Market with a bowl, and did not hold it out, because holding it out was an offer, and was fed by people who were sorry for him until people stopped being sorry, in his eleventh winter, which was very cold.

III. "OVER MY DEAD BODY." Orlen Tace, felt-dyer of the Galleries, 623, of his daughter's marriage to a Forsworn of the Breakdowns. The daughter married. On the morning of the marrying, when she came to the felted door of the marrying-room in the Hall with her drafts under her arm, she found her father lying across the threshold, dead, warm, his eyes open,

his arms at his sides, in his good coat. No mark was ever found on him. The Hall ruled that the marriage could not go forward unless she stepped over the body, as the oath required. She stood for an hour. Then she stepped over him. The Hall's clerk records that she did not look down. The Hall's clerk records also that her husband had to lift her the last part, because her legs would not do it.

IV. "MARK MY WORDS." Fennick Ash, an apprentice of the Ledger, 631, said in jest to the chisel-masters at the cliff face, of a wager about the Kept Rain. The words of the wager were found the next morning carved into his back and chest and arms, in the Ledger's own letter, a finger deep, in red, the edges of each cut as clean as stone-work, and the wager itself, which he lost, carved a second time across his face. He lived. The Ledger now has a rule that apprentices may not speak at the cliff at all, and a slate-boy who forgets is struck, hard, across the mouth, by whoever is nearest, out of love.

V. "NEVER AGAIN." Pask Dorrow, lift-hauler of the Shadeward Wall, 629, after the cable of the ninth-tier lift slipped and dropped him forty feet before it caught. He crawled out onto the ninth tier and said it. He never rode the lift again. He could not. When he went to the stair, his legs would not climb it, for the stair was a way of going between tiers and the god held that it counted. He lived on the ninth tier for eleven years, on what his neighbours brought him. In the dry summer of 640 the ninth tier's cistern failed, and the tier was cleared, and Pask Dorrow sat at the lip of the lift-shaft and watched it go up and down full of water-jars for six days, and died of thirst on the seventh in sight of it, with his neighbours shouting up at him from the eighth, weeping, telling him to come down.

VI. "TAKE MY WORD FOR IT." Ysolt Varne, a Surety, to a principal who doubted her, 633. The principal did. In the morning Ysolt Varne woke with her mouth full of blood and no tongue, the root smooth and sealed as if it had never grown, and her principal woke three streets away choking on a second tongue behind his own, warm and heavy and moving. The surgeons of the Murmuring House cut it out of him. It went on moving in the basin for a day. Ysolt Varne asked, on a slate, to have it back, and was refused, on the ground that it was no longer hers.

VII. "I'M DYING TO KNOW." Wenna Calloway, Tongue-line, nineteen, at the Course, at the reading of her grandmother's will in 638, which ran to ninety pages, and which the Clausewright read aloud in its entirety while the family sat in silence, and in which the matter Wenna was dying to know, which was whether the old woman had left her the house in the Cisterns, was the last clause. The Clausewright read it. The

house was hers. She smiled, the family say, and then her face changed, and she said, quite quietly, "Oh. Oh, I see," and laid her head on the table, and was gone.

VIII. "I SWEAR ON MY MOTHER." Callum Dree, water-thief, 627, before the Bench, falsely, on the Grave Weight, with his hand on the cold face of his mother in her niche in the Vaults. He was released for want of a Breaking, because he did not break: he was not Tongue-line, and he was lucky, and the god is not always quick. He went home. In the morning his wife came down to find the old woman standing in their kitchen, dry and dark and brittle as a fig, her lips drawn back to the gums in the Vaults' look of having just heard something, her hand still raised where it had been laid on his. The Keeners say the dead Testify when an oath on them is broken. They do not usually walk three miles to do it. She stood in that kitchen for nineteen days. She said nothing. She did not need to. On the twentieth day he went to the Bench and confessed, and was sentenced, and swore the sentence, and the old woman was found that night back in her niche, and has not moved since. Callum Dree's sentence was to carry water for the household he robbed, for life. He does. He is very careful with it.

IX. "I'D DIE FOR YOU." Tamsin Ure, of the Canyon Watch, to his betrothed, Halla Ure, the night before their drafting, in 635. He was Tongue-line, at the Appetite, and it was a plain promise between people who loved each other. In the Lack of 637 she took the canyon fever, which kills one in three in the Galleries, and on the ninth night it broke, and she sat up and asked for water, and he was found in the next room, at the moment of the fever's breaking, dead in his chair, with a cup of water in his hand, unspilled. The Hall records that the oath was kept. We print it because people still say it at weddings. We would ask you not to. We would ask you not to love anyone so much that you will say it. We know you will not listen.

[In margin, beside IX, Strake, the ink very dark: Mags. If you are reading this I did not say it to you because I am a coward & not because I would not.]

The errata slip tucked into the back of Abel Strake's copy is dated Lack 640, and is printed on the cheapest paper in the canyons. It carries one line: "§§ 3, 22 and 'For Today' (Children's Supplement) are withdrawn pending ruling. The Hall regrets." The slip does not say what it regrets. Strake's note under it reads: *bought the 31st because the 30th had a slip in it saying the same about the 30th.*

CARVER'S NOTES: THE BOOK OF EXITS

Getting a copy. Any Guest entering Oathen can buy the Book for 3 L at Treaty Stair, Quillhouse or the Felt Market, and every Oathen-born Guest already owns one with the red chapter cut out, or a parent's copy with it still in. Abel Strake's annotated copy is a better find: it can be taken from his body on the Wending road, or bought from the Breakdowns' book-sellers, who strip the dead.

Speaking from the Book. When a printed phrase fits the situation the Book names (greeting, refusing a suitor, haggling, condolence, war), a Guest may say it word for word instead of rolling Conditional Speech. The phrase carries the Exits written into it and is treated as **Clean**: the Carver must honour any reasonable reading. It cannot be improved, shortened or decorated; a single added word ("truly", "I promise you") makes it an ordinary sentence and the roll must be made. Using a phrase outside its situation (saying "If able" to a dying man asking whether you will avenge him) gets no benefit, and the Carver may call the roll at +4 Difficulty, because the god heard you reach for a formula.

Being heard to use it. An Oathener hears Book-speech at once. It marks the speaker as foreign or newly Unbitted: -2 on Persuade and Haggle with the canyon-born, who think it a little comic and a little sad. A Guest who uses it in the Breakdowns is mocked loudly; the Forsworn speak as they like.

The widening. The Book was tested in an Oathen that no longer quite exists. Each time a Guest speaks from the Book after the first in a scene, the Carver rolls a d10 in secret. On a 1, the phrase is one the Hall has since found unsafe (as the errata slip suggests), and it carries no Exits at all. The Guest does not learn this until the oath is tested.

Hooks.

- ◇ *The Thirty-Second Printing.* The Hall of Conditions is drafting a new edition and needs the phrases tested again, on volunteers, under the widening. It pays 20 L a day and swears its testers to secrecy at Weight 3. One of the testers before them has not come back from the testing room on the Bench Terrace, and the door is felted from the inside.
- ◇ *Mags.* Abel Strake's widow in the Leanings of Sated has never been told what her husband wrote beside the ninth phrase. Delivering the book is a kindness. Mags Strake will read the margin and then ask, very calmly, how he died, and whether he said anything; and the Guests who were there will have to answer her.
- ◇ *Number 24.* Strake's second note tells the Guests he was frightened of §24. His fellow factors say he made his last offer for a load of Fatlands barrels on the Wending road and was refused. What he did next, and who was waiting for him, is the reason the wagons were found standing empty with the oxen still yoked.

Secret. The preface was written in 412 by an Under-Drafter named Ysolde Marrick, and its first sentence, "This book does not promise you anything," has been reprinted unchanged in every edition. Since the Lack of 640 writing has begun to bind, and the Bench's sealed ruling (which the errata slip does not mention) holds that every

printing of the Book is, in part, its compiler's word, sworn before the god, that the phrases are safe. Ysolde Marrick has been in her niche in the Vaults since 451. Since the thirtieth printing she has been heard in the Vaults at night, by the Keeners, reciting the phrases, one by one, in a dry whisper, and stopping at the ones that have since failed, and making a small sound at each, like a woman who has pricked her finger. The Hall has told no one. If the Book is ever wrong in a way that kills a reader, the dead woman will Testify, and nobody knows what a Testimony looks like from a person who has been dead for two hundred years and who is, by the Book's own preface, not promising anything.

▼THE TALLY OF CRADLEWRACK, VOLUME 641



The great ledger of the Tally-house on Tally Hill in Kest has been kept without a missed day since 131 A.G., and each year is bound as one volume: a slab of oiled paper between boards of red-stained ash, chained to a reading-desk in the long cold gallery under the clock-room where Lark Ninedays keeps the interval. Anyone may ask to see any page. The scribes will bring the volume, open it on the desk, and stand at the end of the gallery while you read, because people who find their own lines struck through have done things to the pages, and to themselves, in that gallery, and the scribes are tired of cleaning it.

What follows is a copy of selected pages from Volume 641, as it stood in late Carving, made by a Cutwright surveyor of Thimble Cross who paid the Tally-house a platter for nine days at the desk and was asked, on the tenth, to leave. Her copy keeps the five columns of the Tally (the number, the household, the bearer, *what*, and *stays*) and the house shorthand: *sp.* for speaking-born, *o.b.* for

old-born, *g.* for born-grown, *pt.* for a Part, *w.b.* for *without bearer*. A ruled line in the fifth column is *struck through*. She added her own notes in the margin, marked here as the surveyor's. She was careful, she says, to note the hand in which each entry was written, because the Tally-house keeps its scribes in rota and each evening's page is the work of one hand, and that is how she came to notice the entry that is not.

THE TALLY OF THE BIRTHS OF CRADLEWRACK, OF EVERY KIND, IN EVERY PARISH, VOLUME THE SIX HUNDRED AND FORTY-FIRST. Opened at the Unbricking, first day of Grace, by Rufus Ochre, Tallyman, in the presence of the Midwife-Paramount, who knocked upon the boards. What is it. Does it stay. Let it stay.

GRACE: THE OPENING PAGES

NO.	HOUSEHOLD	BEARER	WHAT	STAYS
1	Seele, the Old Lying-In, Kest	the mother, Bryony	girl, whole	stays
2	Gorse, Seam St., Kest	the mother, Ilse	boy, whole, <i>sp.</i> ("again?")	stays
3	Thrале, Tarnbrow	the father, Owen	<i>g.</i> , woman of about twenty	stays; to the Companies
4	Rudge, the Capped Well	<i>w.b.</i>	a knocking, under the millstone; entered by order	— — — —
5	Danner, Cleave	the mother, Wenna	<i>pt.</i> , right foot	surrendered
6	Calloway, Mortar Rise	the grandmother, Elspet, 79	twins, <i>o.b.</i> , both older than the bearer	stays
7	Corse, Rimwatch	the mother, Ada	boy, whole	stays
—	(a space left)	<i>w.b.</i>	one, hungry	
8	Knocker, the Stillyard	the mason's wife, Una	"one"	— — — —
9	Lintel, Kest Low	the mother, Hessa	girl, <i>sp.</i> ("I was here before")	— — — —
10	Furrow, Rudge	the mother, Nettle	boy, whole; cord would not cut, cut on third trial	stays
11	the Unbricking, Apron St.	a bricked room, opened at dawn	a girl of about six, in a shift, asleep	entered by order of the Lying

Surveyor's notes, Grace. Entries 1 to 11 and the unnumbered line are all on one evening's page, the first of the year, which by custom is written by the house's eldest scribe, Merriam Gage, in her large round hand. All except the unnumbered line. That line is in a narrow, slanting, very black hand, the

ink of which has not faded with the rest of the page, and it sits as the eighth line on the page, where it has pushed entry 8 down without renumbering anything. The house's fair copy, made for the Lying, omits it. When I asked Mistress Gage about it she looked at it for a long time and said that it was

not her hand, and that it had been there when she came in the morning to sand the page, and that a line nobody had written was not a line she was permitted to strike. The fifth column is empty. Not ruled. Not “stays.” Empty. No other entry in the Tally since 131 has an empty fifth column. I looked.

On entry 11: the Unbricking opens every bricked room in the country on the first day of Grace, and what is found is entered. The girl was found asleep in a room on Apron Street bricked by Ebbe Knocker’s men the previous Lack, which had had no one in it when it was bricked. She woke and asked for her mother. She did not know her mother’s name. The Lying took her. The line has no fifth column entry either, I noted at first, and then saw that it does: very small, in the Lying’s purple ink, “to be asked later.”

On entry 2: the mother, Ilse Gorse, appears again in Carving, see 4,411. She bore a speaking boy in the first week of Grace,

and a speaking girl in Carving. The boy’s word was “again?” The girl’s, by the evening crier’s report, was “cold.” Mistress Gorse has asked the Attendance that she be cut for the Barren Order. The Attendance has declined until the interval is known.



A highlander with no line in the Tally does not exist.
A highlander with a ruled line does not exist either.
Nobody has ever said what a highlander with an
empty column is.

THE SURVEYOR’S NOTES, VOLUME 641

PLENTY: THE MIDDLE PAGES

NO.	HOUSEHOLD	BEARER	WHAT	STAYS
1,201	Latch, Mortar Rise	a door of Agnes Latch’s make, held eleven days	a breath, warm, which left by the window	entered by order
1,202	Fenn, the High Fold	a ewe of the fold	lambs, eleven, one head among them	surrendered
1,215	Pym, Wet-Nurse’s Row	the late Hollan Pym, d. 4 days	boy, whole, crying	stays
1,216	Pym, Wet-Nurse’s Row	the late Hollan Pym, d. 5 days	“the same again”	— — — —
1,340	the Dilation, the north rim	the rim	stone, round, warm, with a pulse	entered by order
1,341	Rudge, the Capped Well	w.b.	a knocking, under the millstone	— — — —
1,388	Cord, Cordway	the late Hanne Cord, by her cord	girl, joined, cord to the bearer	stays
1,389	Aubrey, the Queen’s House	(sealed by the Crown)	(sealed)	(sealed)
—	(a space left)	w.b.	one, hungry, at the door	
1,402	Morwen, the Hall	(sealed by the Council)	(sealed)	(sealed)
1,450	Ochre, Tally Hill	the mother, Rosamund	boy, whole	stays
1,451	Crèche, Pang-house 4	w.b.	g., man of about sixty, weeping	stays; to the Companies
1,452	Crèche, Pang-house 4	w.b.	g., woman of about sixty, holding the hand of 1,451	stays; to the Companies
1,519	Marrin, Rudge road	the father, Corrie Marrin	pt., left hand	— — — — (see note)

Surveyor’s notes, Plenty. The Plenty pages are in the rota hands, chiefly the twins Ede and Ada Crewe, who copy in tandem, one beginning a line and the other finishing it, so that every entry in their weeks has a small hitch in the middle where the pen changes. The unnumbered line of Plenty also has the hitch. “One, hungry” is in Ede’s hand. “At the door” is in Ada’s. I showed it to them. They said, together, that they did not remember writing it, and then, separately, Ede that

she did, and Ada that she did not, and then they would not look at each other, which I am told they have never before been seen to do. The line sits as the eighth line on the page. It is the eighth line on its page again. I have begun to count.

On 1,215 and 1,216: the late Hollan Pym, cousin of the wet-nurse Dolour Pym, died in labour and was delivered four days dead of a living boy, whom Dolour has. On the fifth day she bore again, on her bier, before the Attendant could reach her.

The Attendant's word for what came is "the same again." It was answered. The Lying's purple note beside it reads "she is to be bricked, and watched."

On 1,388: Sister Maeve Cord of the Uncut has been joined to her mother by a living cord for forty-one years. The mother, Hanne, has been dead six. The cord has not noticed, and in Plenty it bore, through the mother, into the daughter's lap, a girl joined to Hanne by a second cord. The Attendant asked the First Question and wrote "girl, joined." She asked the Second and wrote "stays." I am told she then went out of the house and stood in the road for an hour and was sick in the ditch, and that the Uncut kept a feast that night, and that the girl is thriving, and that Hanne Cord's face, in her coffin of glass in the Cordway chapel, has a little colour in it for the first time in six years.

On 1,519: a Part, the left hand, borne by a man of Rudge. The fifth column is ruled. Below the ruling, in a different ink, a note: "surrendered to the Opinion, who reports that it was cut,

and that the pieces were burned in her presence, and that the Assemblers' men were at the door before the fire was out." Below that, in the Lying's purple: "Inquire of the Opinion." Below that, in a hand I take to be the Opinion's own, small and furious: "I have answered."

On 1,450: the Tallyman's sister-in-law. Rufus Ochre entered his nephew himself. It is the neatest line in the volume. He wrote "stays" and then wrote it again, slightly larger, beside the first.

CARVING: THE PANG PAGES

The pages of a pang week are different. The interval has stood at nine days since the Shortening, and every ninth day the Tally doubles, then trebles. The Carving pages of Volume 641 run to forty entries an evening, in three and four hands at once, cramped, blotted, with the house's shorthand pushed to its limits. The surveyor copied one evening entire. A part of it is given here.

NO.	HOUSEHOLD	BEARER	WHAT	STAYS
4,301	Gage, Mortar Rise	the mother, Clemency	girl, whole, asleep	stays
4,302	Gage, Mortar Rise	the mother, Clemency	girl, whole, awake, sp. ("let her sleep")	stays
4,303	Corse, Rimwatch	the father, Tam	o.b., woman of about ninety; asked for her own mother by name; the name is the bearer's mother	stays (see note)
4,304	the Stillyard, Low Wall	the wall	"one, warm"	-----
4,305	Seele, Cleave	the mother, Isolde	pt., an ear, which hears	surrendered
4,306	Breech's Gate	a woman of the Fatlands, not present	(entered from the Marshal's report)	(not answerable)
4,307	Dell, Tarnbrow	the mother, Rowan	boy, whole	stays
—	(a space left)	w.b.	one, hungry, waiting to be asked	
4,308	Danner, Cleave	the mother, Wenna	pt., left foot	surrendered
4,309	Tarnbrow, the moor road	the road	prints, very large, leading north; entered by order	entered
4,310	Crèche, Pang-house 9	w.b.	g., man of about thirty, in a uniform of the Companies, mid-stride	stays; to the Companies
4,311	Lintel, Kest Low	the mother, Hessa	girl, sp. ("I was here before")	-----
4,312	Lintel, Kest Low	the mother, Hessa	girl, sp. ("I was here before")	-----
4,313	Lintel, Kest Low	the mother, Hessa	girl, sp. ("I was here before. You did this before.")	stays, by the Opinion's hesitation

Surveyor's notes, Carving. I am not able to describe the noise of a pang evening at the Tally-house. The runners come in from the parishes all through the dusk with their oiled papers, and the scriveners copy standing, and the crier on the steps outside is reading the first entries to the crowd before the last

have come in, so that the reading and the writing run together, and the crowd's murmur, "and let it stay," comes in through the windows in waves, and the long silences when it turns its face away for the ruled lines come in too. Four hands on this page. Merriam Gage's round one. The twins' hitched one. A boy called Fen Lintel, a runner made scrivener for the

pang, whose letters slope backward like a man walking into wind. And a fourth hand, for one entry, narrow and slanting and very black, eighth on the page.

I asked Rufus Ochre about it that night. He opened Volume 640 for me, and Volume 639, and 630, and 619, and 600. It is in all of them. Not on every page: on one page in each season, and always eighth. It is in the volume for 501. It is not in the volume for 500. He showed me this without speaking. He has known for eleven years. He said that he has entered it in his private reckoning of the unaccounted, under the heading “w.b.”, with the rest, and that it is in the eleven hundred. Then he said that this is the only one of them he has not gone out at night to find, and I asked him why, and he said, “Because it says it is at the door, mistress, and I have read on.”

On 4,303: Tam Corse of Rimwatch bore an old woman, as men in Cradlewrack sometimes do, through an old scar on his side. She asked, in the voice of a woman of ninety, for her mother, by name: Ada Corse. Ada Corse is Tam’s mother, of entry 7 of this volume, who bore Tam’s brother in Grace. She is thirty-four. The Attendant asked the Second Question for a long while. The crowd outside, I am told, waited, and then turned

its face away, and then turned back, because the crier had not read a ruling but “stays,” in a voice that broke. The old woman lives in Ada Corse’s house and calls her Mother. Ada Corse is said not to object. She is said to be very gentle with her, and to brush her hair in the evening.

On 4,311 to 4,313: Hessa Lintel’s girl of Grace, entry 9, said “I was here before,” and was answered. The same girl, by every mark, was borne again on this evening, twice, and answered twice. The third time she said more. The Opinion, Sabeth Thorne by the Lying’s note, did not answer her. The fifth column reads “stays, by the Opinion’s hesitation,” and the Lying has written under it, in purple, “Sabeth,” and nothing else, and the scrivener who sanded the page says the purple was blotted as if the writer had pressed down very hard.

On 4,306: the woman of the Fatlands. There is one every year at Breech’s Gate. The Marshal sends the report without comment. I have a cousin in the Cutwrights who reads the Marshal’s own hand, and says that this year’s report, like every year’s, is in it, and that the Marshal has begun to sign it, which he did not used to do, with his first name.

I HAVE READ ON. THAT'S MY WHOLE OFFICE,
MISTRESS. I READ ON.

[RUFUS OCHRE, TALLYMAN, TO THE SURVEYOR, CARVING 641]

AFTER THE LAST PANG

NO.	HOUSEHOLD	BEARER	WHAT	STAYS
4,590	Morwen, the Hall	the Duchess Iphigene, through the veil	(sealed by the Council); a note, “red”	(sealed)
4,591	Kest, the Old Lying-In	the Old Lying-In, its north door	a draught, cold; first cold thing entered since 131	entered by order
4,592	Gorse, Seam St., Kest	the mother, Ilse	(the Attendant would not write; the crier did not read)	— — — —
4,593	Calloway, Mortar Rise	the grandmother, Elspet, 79, d. at the bearing	girl, o.b., the image of the bearer	stays
4,600	Tally Hill, the steps	w.b.	a girl of about twelve, in a scrivener’s apron, with ink on her fingers, who sat at the desk and copied this line	(blank)
—	(a space left)	w.b.	one, hungry; the Attendant did not attend; the door was open	
4,601	Seele, the Old Lying-In, Kest	the mother, Bryony	girl, whole	stays

Surveyor's last note. Entry 4,600 is in a child's hand, careful and large, the letters copied rather than formed, the way children copy who have learned to read from one book only. The girl who wrote it sat down at the desk on the evening after the pang while the scribes were at the windows, and wrote it, and wrote her own line, and when Mistress Gage came back to the desk the girl was gone, and there was ink on the chair. The unnumbered line after it is in the same child's hand. The fifth column of 4,600 is empty, and that is the second empty fifth column in the Tally. I have been told since that there are now four. I was asked to leave on the tenth morning, politely, by Rufus Ochre, who said that it was for my own sake and that the volume would be closed to the public for the remainder of Carving, and then he said, not to me, to the volume, "Read on," and shut it.

I have copied the unnumbered line from every season of the year 641. I set them out here in order, so that whoever reads this can see what I saw, which is not that they are different, but that they are the same line, entered again and again, by different hands, as it comes nearer. One, hungry. One, hungry, at the door. One, hungry, waiting to be asked. One, hungry; the Attendant did not attend; the door was open. I have not been able to find out what the Tally-house does when a line is entered and nobody asks the Second Question. Mistress Gage says that in Cradlewrack it has always been held that you knock to warn whatever is on the other side. She says nobody has ever said what you do if it knocks first.

CARVER'S NOTES: THE TALLY

Reading the Tally. Any Guest may climb Tally Hill and ask for a volume. Finding a particular line (your own birth, a missing child, the bearer of a Part) is an extended task: Eye + Reckoning, Hard 14, one hour a roll, 2 Helpings for a known name and year, 5 for anything vaguer. A Lack means the Guest finds a line they were not looking for: a ruled line in their own household, a sibling nobody mentioned, a birth to their own mother in a year they were not born. A Cradlewrack-born Guest who reads their own line makes a Dread 1 check; one who finds it ruled, a Dread 3.

Entries as hooks. Every line above is a person, a Part or a door the Guests can visit. The two Gage girls (4,301 and 4,302) are one asleep and one awake, and the awake one says "let her sleep" every time anyone goes near her sister. Tam Corse's old woman (4,303) remembers being Ada Corse's mother in a life before the Gorging, and wants to be taken to a house in Kest that has been bricked since 310. The prints on the moor road (4,309) belong to whatever Josiah Fenn bore and has been following for eight years. The hand at 1,519 was not burned; the Opinion who reported it is lying, and the Assemblers know it, and so does Hester Lowe, who is now not the only person in Cradlewrack hiding a left hand.

The empty column. The unnumbered line has appeared once a season since 501 A.G. It is not borne by anyone, and it is not answered, because no Attendant has ever been present when it is entered. A Guest who waits all night at the Tally-house desk during a pang (Caul + Resolve, Grim 18, to stay awake and at the desk through the pang's crescendo; a Vigil-born Guest rolls at Hard) will see the page fill with the narrow black hand on the eighth line, with nobody holding the pen. Dread 3. On a Grace, the Guest notices that the ink is still wet, and smells of bread.

What the Tally is for. In Cradlewrack the Tally is the only proof of personhood. A Guest whose line is ruled may be taken for a late Opinion (*returning*) by any Attendant who checks. A Guest whose line is empty, as entry 4,600's, is something the Attendance has no law for, and the Lying-In wants very much to ask them the Second Question.

Secret. Rufus Ochre's eleven hundred: the Tally of 640 shows 1,105 more births than were carried by anyone or anything, and Ochre has been following the unaccounted at night and found three, born-grown, walking north in a line. The Carver should compare this number with the Long Count's total for Carving 640 (below) and decide whether it is a coincidence. Nobody on the Table has put the two side by side. Nobody has both documents. The Guests may.

▼ THE LONG COUNT



Hogget's Barn stands at the end of Kettle Furrow, in Low Tilth, a plain timber barn with its doors propped open and the smell of black soil and chalk-dust coming out of it. Its east wall is the village's own tally, scratched and painted course by course since 629; the core book gives the lower course of it. Its north wall is something else. It is where Pell Hogget enters the numbers that the other villages send him, folded in shoes and hat-bands and the hollow handles of drovers' sticks, every Carving, and it is the only place on the Table where the Reaping is written down in full for anyone to see. Pilgrims come to touch it. The Board has twice tried to burn it. The copy below was made on oiled slate by a Long Count runner named Hennet Callock, who carried it to forty parishes in her boot before the Bailiffs took her at the Tilth causeway in Lack 640; the slate was recovered from the ditch and is now kept, cracked across, in a fold of sacking under Old Mother Rind's pear trees.

The marks on the wall are simple, and every child in Low Tilth can read them: a stroke for each Reaped; a stroke with a cross-bar for

each dusk-shifted who did not walk back; a ring for each Seated; and, since 638, a stroke with a small open curve at the top like a hand held out, for *taken by a hill*. Callock's slate turns the strokes into figures. A half is a half.

THE LONG COUNT, AS ON THE NORTH WALL OF THE BARN AT KETTLE FURROW. Copied fair by H. Callock, Carving 640, by leave of P. Hogget, who says: "Copy it how it is. Don't round. Don't leave anyone off." Mark-key: I = Reaped. + = dusk-shift, not back. O = Seated. Ω = hill. Totals in Pell's hand. The column at the right in Pell's hand also, headed PROJECTED, which he says is not a prophecy, it is a sum.

THE NORTH WALL, LOW TILTH COURSE

YEAR	KETTLE FURROW	BRAMBLE FURROW	HASK'S END	CALLOCK GREEN
629	4	(not sent)	(not sent)	(not sent)
630	5	7, of which + 4	(not sent)	3
631	6	8, of which + 5	6	3
632	8	11, of which + 7	7	4
633	9	12, of which + 9	9	5
634	12	15, of which + 11	10	5, & O 1
635	13 ½	19, of which + 14	12	7
636	16	22, of which + 18	14	8
637	18	26, of which + 21	15	10
638	20	30, of which + 26	18, & Ω 2	11
639	24	37, of which + 31	20	13, & Ω 1
640	27	41, of which + 35	(not sent)	15

THE NORTH WALL, WESTERN COURSE

YEAR	DIMBLE	SORREL BOTTOM	TIDY ACRE	ALL VILLAGES SENDING
634	7	6	2	330, from 82 villages

YEAR	DIMBLE	SORREL BOTTOM	TIDY ACRE	ALL VILLAGES SENDING
635	8	8	3	418, from 103
636	22	9	3	560, from 121
637	9	11	4	673, from 140
638	11	31, & 9	4	790, from 158
639	14	19	5, & O 2	921, from 177
640	20	22	6	1,104, from 196
641	(being counted)	(being counted)	(not sent)	1,231 so far, from 200

MARGINAL NOTES ON THE NORTH WALL, as copied by H. Callock. Each is in the hand of whoever brought the tally, scratched or chalked beside the figure. Pell does not rub any of them out.

Beside Kettle Furrow, 635, the half: “the Pennick baby. Half out of the furrow. Lived a week. Counts as half because Pell says so, and Pell’s the one counting.”

Beside Bramble Furrow, every year, in the same small careful hand: “most of ours are crossed. We owe.” And under 640: “Wren Hollowell’s mam is in the 640 crosses. They put her on the list to make the girl come home. She has not come home. Good girl. Stay gone.”

Beside Hask’s End, 640, “(not sent)”: “We’ve stopped sending. Pell won’t count Amos Tallis because the field didn’t take him. If Amos doesn’t count none of us count. Hask’s End.” And under, in Pell’s square hand, chalk: “I count what the god takes. That’s the whole of it. I’m sorry about Amos. I’ll keep your column open.”

Beside Callock Green, 634, the ring: “old Wilm Rake, who sat down to a table in the far field at dusk that we none of us had laid, and is sitting there yet, and waved.”

Beside Dimble, 636: “a fifth.” Beside Dimble, 637: “first year of the furrow. 9 not 11.” Beside Dimble, 638, 639, 640, in a different hand each year and then in no hand at all: the figures only. Below the 640 figure, scratched so deep the chalk has gone into the grain: “4 lads for this.”

Beside Sorrel Bottom, 638: “the Old Walk.” And under it, in a long column of names written small, thirty-one names, each with an age beside it, none less than sixty-two. Then: “9 more of the young, the same Carving. We did it so the young would be spared. It was asked of us. We were glad. We went out singing, the old ones, Pell, in our Sunday smocks, and we sat down in the Long Ley at dusk with our backs to the village so the young ones need not see, and the field took us one by one and was it any less hungry for the young? Write it down. 639:

19. All young. Write it down, Pell. Somebody write it down.” The hand is old. Below it, in Pell’s: “The Old Walk was 31. They came back in 639. Not to the village. To the Long Ley. They stand in it at dusk with their backs to us and the young go out to them because their grans are calling. 639: 19. I have written it down.”

Beside Tidy Acre, 641, “(not sent)”: nothing. The runner who carried Tidy Acre’s tally came in without it, and sat in the barn door until dark, and would not say. Pell sent a boy. The boy said the village was there, and the doors were open, and the tables were laid in every house, and there was nobody in the chairs, and the field had come right up to the doorsteps and stopped, very neat, like a cloth.

At the foot of the whole wall, in paint, in a large slow hand: NELL.



Copy it how it is. Don’t round. Don’t leave anyone off.

PELL HOGGET, TO EVERY RUNNER WHO COPIES THE WALL; HE HAS LEFT ONE PERSON OFF EVERY YEAR SINCE 637

THE ARITHMETIC

Pell Hogget does sums the way other men pray, and his sums are on the barn door, in chalk, rubbed half out and done again. Callock copied them onto the back of her slate. Most of them are the arithmetic his neighbours already know and say aloud in the inns of Low Tilth: the Reaping in any village doubles every eight or nine years; Kettle Furrow had two hundred and six souls in 629, and at this rate the year’s Reaping will equal the village in 660; Low Tilth will be gone into the wheat before 680. Some of the sums are other things, the arithmetic that people in the Farlands have begun to call, in a low voice, *the sum you don’t do*. Callock copied those too.

ON THE BACK OF THE SLATE, in H. Callock’s hand, copied from the barn door. “Pell’s door sums. He says copy them but say they’re only sums.”

ONE. The doubling. 4 in 629. 27 in 640. Doubles in 8 yrs and a bit. 2nd doubling 648, 54. 3rd 656, 108. 4th 664, 216. Kettle Furrow is 194 souls. "Before 664 the field takes the village in a year. Before then it takes more than half. The year it takes more than half, nobody will be left to bring the tally. So the last number on the wall will be wrong. I want somebody to know it was wrong."

TWO. All villages. 330 in 634, 1,104 in 640. Some of that is more villages sending. Take it out, take only the villages that sent every year since 634: still doubling, every 9 yrs. The Board says there are four hundred thousand in the Fatlands. "I worked it the long way and the short way. The short way, the field takes the whole country in one Carving in 712. The long way, 709. It doesn't matter which. Barnaby will be 87, 84. If he's lucky."

THREE. The eating. Pell took the villages that eat most (by the Bailiff's own Feasting lists, which the Bailiff's clerk copied for us for a ham) and the villages that eat least. "The ones who eat most lose most. Every year. Every village. The fat villages lose two to the thin villages' one. This is a sum you can be hanged for, because it means the Thin are right, and fasting is treason, so I have not written what it means, only what it is." Under it, in another hand, chalk, very large: CORDER LANK WAS HERE. Under that, rubbed nearly out: "and so was the Bailiff, the next day. Barnaby."

FOUR. The house. "Barnaby did the sum for our house. Three of us: me, Barnaby, and [a word rubbed out]. Two of us. If the village goes in 664, and each house goes in turn by the size of the eating, and we eat less than most since his mam, then we go in 661, at the end of Carving, Barnaby first, being younger and hungrier. I rubbed it out. He did it again. I rubbed it out. He did it again in his own blood on the inside of the door where I couldn't reach to rub it, and I have left it, because he is a good boy and he is right, and I taught him." (Callock: I did not copy the inside of the door. I saw it. It is in a boy's hand, brown, and it is the same sum, and it is right.)

FIVE. The one he won't do. Across the bottom of the door, in Pell's hand, a line of figures with a line struck through them, and the strike gone so deep the chalk has been knifed into the wood: 637: 18. 638: 20. 639: 24. 640: 27. "Each one, one short. I know. I can't." That's all it says.

CARVER'S NOTES: THE LONG COUNT

Finding the wall. Hogget's Barn is never locked. Any Guest may go in and read the north wall; copying it takes an afternoon. Pell feeds visitors, answers questions with numbers, and asks them to carry slates to the next villages. A Guest who agrees becomes a Long Count runner; the Bailiffs know the faces, and the slate in a boot is a hanging matter since 637.

Reading it. A Guest who reads the wall closely (Eye + Reckoning, Hard 14) sees that Kettle Furrow is one short every year since 637. A Helping shows the "NELL" at the foot is in the same paint as the 637 figures. A Guest who does Pell's door sums for themselves (Eye + Reckoning, Routine 10) and understands them makes a Dread 2 check. The fifth sum is a Dread 1, and an open door into Pell's grief.

Hooks.

- ◇ *Tidy Acre.* The village that did not send its tally in 641. The tables are laid in every house, the chairs are empty, and the field has stopped at the doorsteps like a cloth. Orrum has never before laid tables inside the Fatlands with nobody sitting at them. Who are they for? (They are for whoever comes to count.)
- ◇ *The Old Walk.* The thirty-one elders of Sorrel Bottom stand in the Long Ley at dusk, backs to the village, and the young walk out to them. Their grandchildren beg the Guests to bring the old ones back, or to stop them calling. The old ones are a worthless sacrifice, given gladly and taken by a field that was not one mouthful less hungry for it. They are also, at dusk, very persuasive. Each of them asks a Guest by name to come and sit a while: Invitation check at Hard 14, as if Orrum offered, because the field has learned it from the Host.
- ◇ *The Bailiff and the Boy.* Barnaby Hogget, sixteen, has done the sum for his own house in his own blood. The Bailiff has seen the third sum on the door. The Cullmasters are drafting the 641 dusk-shift list, and Barnaby's name is the obvious way to stop the Count without making a martyr of his father. The Guests learn of it from Varn Sweetbread's clerk, who wants a ham for the information, and then another.

Rule: the Count as a clock. In a Fatlands campaign, the Count is how the Carver shows the land worsening. Each Carving that passes in play, add the doubling to every village column (multiply by about 1.1 each year, rounded up), and add one village column the Guests know personally. The day the Guests' own village's column reaches its population, it is the last year anyone sends it.

Secret. Pell's total for all villages in Carving 640 is 1,104. It is one short, because Nell is missing. The true figure is 1,105. The Tally of Cradlewrack for the same year records 1,105 more births than were carried by anyone or anything (Rufus Ochre's "eleven hundred"). Neither man has seen the other's figure. The Carver may treat this as coincidence, or as the shape of something: that what the Fatlands field takes at dusk in Carving is born in the red hills, grown, without a bearer, and walks north in a line toward the Sill. If the Guests lay the two documents side by side, Pell Hogget will at last have to put Nell's mark on the wall, because the sum does not close without her; and if he does, the 641 Tally in Kest will record, the same evening,

one more birth without a bearer: a woman of about forty, in a white smock, with a ribboned sickle, who asks for her husband by name.

▼ A CHILD'S BOOK OF REFUSALS



There are few books in the Fast, because paper must be carried in from the Rim like bread, and anything carried in is counted. This one is in every household. It is printed in Wanting from woodblocks cut in 412, on coarse grey Rim paper, folded and stitched with ration-thread, one copy to each family on the Pantry roll, and it is how every Unfed child has learned to read for two hundred years. It is read standing. It has no pictures of food. It has one picture of a table, and the child is meant to find it. The copy here belonged to Abstain Rooke, called Abby, eleven, of Bell Ward, and it carries her additions in pencil; the Hostwatch took it from her house in Carving 641, after her mother brought it to them with her hands shaking and asked them to burn it, and they did not.

A CHILD'S BOOK OF REFUSALS. Set for the Cold Yard schools of Wanting and the Wards, under the Abstinent, by Mistress Meagre Holt, in the year 412. Reprinted from the same blocks. To be read standing, facing the wall or the sky. A child who cannot say the Rules does not eat today. A child who can say the Rules may eat, and must not enjoy it.

[In pencil, on the inside cover, Abby: THIS BOOK BELONGS TO ABSTAIN ROOKE, BELL WARD, WANTING, THE FAST, THE TABLE. IF FOUND, NO THANK YOU.]

LESSON THE FIRST: THE RULES

The Five Rules are the oldest thing in the Fast after the Refusal, and the book sets each as a skipping rhyme, to be chanted in the Cold Yard while the rope turns. The rhymes are coarse, quick and easy, and every Unfed adult can still skip to them, and some do, alone, at night, when the smell of baking comes up the road.

THE FIRST RULE. Never enter a house where the hearth is already lit.

Smoke in the chimney, nobody home,

Warm on the doorstep, warm on the stone,

Who lit the fire? Not your Gran.

Turn on your heel and run while you can.

THE SECOND RULE. Never answer "Come in."

Knock at the door and the voice says come,

It sounds like your sister, it sounds like your Mum,

Bite on your tongue till the tongue goes numb.

Come in, come in. No, thank you. Mum.

THE THIRD RULE. Never eat what you did not carry yourself.

Carry your crust in your own two hands,

Carry it over the empty lands,

If you didn't carry it, it's not bread,

If you didn't carry it, it carries you instead.

THE FOURTH RULE. If you smell bread, walk into the wind.

Sniff, sniff, what's that smell?

Somebody's baking, and baking well,

Turn your face where the cold wind blows,

And never mind what's under your nose.

THE FIFTH RULE. If a chair is pulled out for you, do not thank it.

Chair pulled out and the cloth laid white,

Lamp in the middle, burning bright,

Don't say thank you, don't say please,

Don't you dare go bending your knees.

[In pencil, beside the fifth, Abby: why not thank it. It would be polite. Mistress Holt said because. That is not a reason.]

LESSON THE SECOND: READING

The reading lessons are short sentences of one syllable, built on the Refusal, and they are the first words most Unfed ever read. The Abstinent have changed nothing in them since 412, and they read now like a voice from a hungrier century.

See Nay. Nay is thin. Good Nay.

Nay has a crust. Nay did not bake the crust. Nay did not find the crust. Nay's Dad got the crust from the Pantry and Nay's Dad gave it to Nay and Nay put it in her own hand. Nay may eat the crust.

See Spare. Spare is thin. Spare is thin as a stick. Spare can count his ribs. One, two, three, four. Good Spare.

See Lent. Lent is in a house. The house has a fire. Lent did not light the fire. Bad house. Run, Lent, run.

See the cake. The cake is on a plate. The plate is on a cloth. The cloth is on a table. Nobody put it there. Do not look at the cake.

See the chair. The chair is pulled out. Who pulled out the chair? Not Mum. Not Dad. Not Nay. Not Spare. Not you. Do not sit in the chair.

See the field. Nothing grows in the field. Good field.

See Gran. Gran is at the table. Gran is eating. Gran is happy. Gran is not hungry. Gran is not coming home. Say goodbye to Gran.

[In pencil, under "Say goodbye to Gran", Abby: we did this one in Yard and Wont Garrity cried and Mistress Holt made him stand at the wall and he still cried at the wall.]



See the field. Nothing grows in the field. Good field.

A CHILD'S BOOK OF REFUSALS, THE READING LESSONS; YIELD HARTSELL, WHO HAS GROWN ONE GREEN BLADE IN DEAD SOIL THIS YEAR, LEARNED TO READ FROM IT

LESSON THE THIRD: FIND THE LAID TABLE

The centre of the book is a double page: a single woodcut, crowded and busy, of a farmhouse yard on a Carving afternoon. Children are made to stand before it and point. The cut is crude, black and grey, with the cross-hatched shadows of an old block, and every child in the Fast knows it as well as they know their own hands. The caption reads, *There are nine things in this picture that want you. Find them all. Then turn the page and see if you are still here.* Abby's copy is described here as the Hostwatch tracker who received it described it, item by item, in his report.

THE PICTURE (as described for the Hostwatch). A farmyard, square, stone-walled, the house at the back with two windows and a door. A well in the left foreground. A cart, empty. A row of washing on a line. Two children in the middle ground, a boy and a girl, thin, in Unfed coats, walking away from the house toward the viewer, holding hands. The sky is blank paper. The things, as numbered on the answer page:

1. The chimney. A thin line of smoke goes up from it. There is no one in the house.

2. The door. It stands open a finger's width. In the black slit of it, if you hold the page close, the cutter has carved two letters, very small: C and I.

3. The window on the left. A woman's face, soft and kind, cut in a few lines. She looks like everybody's mother. That is the point.

4. The window on the right. On its sill, a round loaf, steaming; three wavy lines go up from it to show the smell.

5. The well. A white cloth has been laid over its lid, folded neat at the corners, like a cloth on a table.

6. The washing. Among the shirts on the line is a long white tablecloth, and it is not blowing the same way as the shirts.

7. The cart. Its tail is down, and on the tail, as on a step, is a little cup.

8. The ground before the children. There is a chair in the yard, behind them, turned toward them, pulled out. They have walked past it. They have not looked back. This is the one the children find last.

9. The girl's hand. In the hand that is not holding her brother's she has a small card, white, the kind that is set at a place. She has picked it up. She is not reading it. Good girl.

[On the answer page, Abby, pencil: I found ten. Mistress said there are nine. The tenth is the boy's other hand. It is behind his back and he is holding something and the cutter made it so you can only just see. Mistress said it's a stone. It is not a stone, it is a fork.]

[Below, in a different pencil, much later and much smaller, Abby: I looked again this morning and it is a spoon now.]

LESSON THE FOURTH: THE DAMNED, BY HEART

THE GODEATERS, A COUNTING-RHYME, to be said before the evening ration, with a finger touched to each of the six. The Unfed child should know the lands of the damned as the Rim child knows its kings.

One for the fen where the dead won't stop,

Two for the field with the teeth in the crop,

Three for the coast where the sea goes in,

Four for the lamps and the lidless kin,

Five for the hills where the door won't stay,

Six for the canyon that hears what you say.

Six who ate and six who're fed,

*Six with a god growing back in their head.
And one who didn't, and that is we,
Hungry and clean as clean can be.*

[In pencil, under the last line, Abby: Mistress what about eight. Mistress said there are only seven, six and us. I said the table on the colouring page has eight sides. She said colour the seven.]

THE COLOURING PAGE

The last page of the book is a woodcut outline, for colouring, in the charcoal that Unfed children are given one stick of each Grace: Hallowboard, the stone table of the Refusal, seen from above, an octagon on a round chalk hill, with forty little figures in the trench around it, standing with their backs to the stone. The figures stand at seven sides. At the eighth side the cutter has left the chalk empty, and the line of the table's edge on that side is not cut at all. The table simply stops, and the white paper goes out to the edge of the page.

COLOUR THE PICTURE. Colour the table grey, because it is stone. Colour the hill white, because it is chalk. Colour the ones who stood any colour you like, because they are ours. There are seven sides where they stood. Colour them. The eighth side is white. Leave it white. It is someone else's.

[Abby's copy, as found. The table and the hill are coloured, carefully, inside the lines. The forty figures are each a different shade, and each has a name written small under it in pencil: Grandad Rooke, Great-Gran Rooke, and the names of Abby's neighbours' great-grandparents, and some names that are not from the Fast at all. The eighth side is white. Its edge, where the cut line stops, has been bitten. There is a small, neat, crescent-shaped piece missing from the paper, the size of a child's bite or a little smaller, the edge of it faintly damp and puckered, as paper is that has been in a mouth. Beside it in pencil, in Abby's hand, very shaky: I did not. I promise I did not. It was like that in the morning. I left a crust on the sill like always and it was gone like always and this was done and there was nothing on the sill in place of it this time. NOTHING. It always leaves something.]

CARVER'S NOTES: A CHILD'S BOOK OF REFUSALS

Getting a copy. Every Unfed Guest learned to read from this book and can recite the rhymes; every Unfed household has one. A Guest from elsewhere can be given one by a Wanting schoolmistress (a kindness, offered three times and accepted on the fourth). Abby Rooke's own copy is held by the Hostwatch in Wanting, by Spare Tolland, who has not burned it.

Rule: the rhymes. A character who knows the Five Rules rhymes by heart (all Unfed; anyone else after a week in a Cold Yard school) may chant one aloud when Orrum offers, once per offer: a bonus die (the Tooth's d6, but it costs no Hunger) on the Invitation check, provided the rhyme fits the offer (the Fourth for the smell of bread, the Second for a voice at a door). A companion may chant it for them instead, as speaking the Decline. Children chanting it for an adult add two dice; the Unfed say the god likes children best, and listens to them hardest.

Rule: Find the Laid Table. The woodcut is a game the Carver can play at the table: read the description of the yard aloud, once, and ask the players to name the nine things. Every Guest who names at least seven gains +2 on their next Search to notice one of Orrum's offers. A player who names a tenth thing not in the list has found what will be offered to their character next; the Carver should note it and use it.

Hooks.

- ◇ *The Bitten Page.* Abby Rooke has been leaving a crust on her windowsill for a year, and each morning it has been replaced with something better, as the core book says. On the night her colouring page was bitten, nothing was left in its place. Abby is frightened for the first time. Whatever has been answering her has stopped, or been interrupted, or been replaced at her window by something that takes and does not give. Spare Tolland asks the Guests to sit up at her sill. What comes to the sill is courteous and hungry and does not lay anything.
- ◇ *The Spoon.* The boy in the woodcut is holding something different in every copy, and it is not a stone. Mistress Meagre Holt cut the blocks in 412; her house in Wanting is a hearthless ruin, and the original block is in its cellar, in a box, with the boy's hand cut out of it. Somebody has been printing new copies from a recut block. The children who learned from the new copies are the ones who have started walking west.
- ◇ *Forty Names.* Abby wrote a name under each figure on the colouring page. Some are names nobody in Wanting knows. Reft Lammass, Roll-Keeper of Barrowgate, recognises three of them from the Barrow rolls of the Refusal, and they are the names of three who stood at Hallowboard in the ninth winter and whose names have been lost from every record for six hundred years. Abby says she was told them. She will not say by whom.

Secret. The answer page lists nine things that want you. The book's first printing in 412 listed ten. The tenth was cut from the block before the second printing by order of the Abstinents, and its entry on the answer page was chiselled out, so that in the oldest surviving copies there is a blank rectangle after the ninth entry with the faint

ridges of words in it. It said what was standing at the eighth side of the table in the colouring picture. It is the same thing a child finds when they find a tenth thing in the yard, and it has never once, in two hundred years, been the same object twice, because it is always the thing the child wanted most.

▼ THE SEAMER'S PATTERN BOOK



Every licensed shop on Needle Street keeps a pattern book, and no two are alike, because the Seamers' Guild teaches its craft by hand and by rhyme and leaves the writing-down to each shop. The books are working things: thick, swollen, greasy, smelling of cedar and the brown, their pages stiff with lacquer from fingers that turned them mid-job. The pattern book of the Harl shop, at the sign of the Needle and Eel on Needle Street, Lastgate, was begun in 344 by Master Gideon Harl and has been kept since by his daughter Otilie, Kept since 402, who still works at the bench by lamplight with hands her father reattached, and by Otilie's apprentices' apprentices, among them the present Mistress Harl. Its last pages hold Otilie's notes in a thin, exact, slightly shaking hand, and an inspection note from Thessaly Mort, Master Seamer of the Guild. What follows is extracted. The book has over four hundred pages. Nineteen are sewn shut, with the Lid, and the Harls will not open them.

THE PATTERN BOOK OF THE NEEDLE AND EEL, Harl's, Needle Street. Begun by G. Harl, Master of the Seam, in the 344th year, for the use of this shop and no other. Brown is still hers. Black is the god's. Grey is the guild's business, and white is nobody's, and you burn it. A seam is not a healing. A seam is a lid. Begin at the head and work down, so that what must run out runs out at the bottom.

THE STITCHES

THE LID. The first seam and the commonest. For any wound in a Kept body, which will not close of itself in this country, and will stay a wet mouth in the flesh for as long as the flesh lasts. Clean to brown: cut away the black with the curved blade, lift what moves with the tweezers into the vinegar, and leave the brown, which is still the client's and will be wanted. Pack the wound with lint soaked in cedar-and-pitch until it is level with the lips. Draw the lips together. Blanket stitch, waxed gut, eight to the inch, wire at the corners, tied off with the Mourner's Loop. The client will feel every stitch. Talk to them while you work. Ask after their grandchildren. Do not ask after their great-grandchildren, who are often upstairs.

GRANDMOTHER'S PURSE. For the cheek, the jowl, the breast and the belly, which in the Settling come away from the

bone along old seams and hang in pockets. Do not cut the pocket. What is in the pocket is the client's. Empty it into the vinegar with two fingers (the green-bottle favours these; mind the eyes). Pack it. Thread a running stitch of doubled gut through the old holes all the way round the mouth of the pocket, as a purse-string, and draw it up to the bone, and tie it to the wire you have set in the bone. A good Purse holds a face up for a year. A great one is invisible from across a dinner table, which is what families pay for.

THE LADDER. For the long belly seam, chest to groin, in clients past the Bloat. Set rungs of brass wire across the opening every inch, bent over at each end into the flesh like staples. Lace between the rungs with tarred thread. The Ladder is made to be opened, which no other seam is: each spring the family pays for the evacuation, when the lacing is drawn out and the cavity flushed with vinegar and repacked with cedar lint, and the client lies on the kitchen table with the family at the far end of the room, and the smell goes out of the window and down the street, and the neighbours say, "Harl's are at the Pennocks' again," and shut their own windows. Re-lace from the top. The client will want to watch. Let them.

THE HERON. For knees and elbows past the Long Grey, where the joint has rotted to string. Two splints of whalebone, wired either side of the joint, hinged with a brass rivet, so that the limb bends one way and only one way. A client in Herons can walk, sit, and climb a stair, slowly, with a ticking sound. (A factor of Oathen has asked this shop whether a Heron could be set backwards, to straighten the knees of the Forsworn. We declined. It would be the god's knees we were bending, and the god set them so on purpose. G.H.)

THE FLY-FENCE. A close whip-stitch of silk, very fine, twenty to the inch, around the rims of the eyes, the nostrils and the lips, set in the fat just inside the lid, so that the green-bottle cannot get in to lay. It does not stop them. It slows them. Re-set every Plenty, before the breeding.

THE COURTESY. A single strong stitch of gut through the floor of the mouth and the point of the chin, tied loose, under the beard if there is one. It holds the jaw up at rest, so that the

client's mouth does not hang open at table, and gives when they speak. Most of the Unvacated of the Upper Boards wear one. It can be tightened. This shop does not tighten it. (O.H.: this shop has been asked to, by families, forty-one times since 402, and by the Court, twice, of a witness. See the sewn pages.)

THE MOURNER'S LOOP. The last knot of every seam. There is no last stitch in Sallowreach; nothing here finishes, and a knot tied off square is held by the Guild to be bad luck, a sort of lie. We tie off with a loop, open, through which another thread might later be drawn. Every seam in this country is, by the Guild's rule, unfinished. Gideon Harl said it was the only honest thing the Guild ever made law.

THE BLIND. Two stitches through each pair of eyelids, closing them. *FORBIDDEN* by the Guild since 301, except by the client's own request, said aloud, before two witnesses, one living. Families ask for it often: those with Hand-line blood at the Appetite, who cannot bear an open eye in the house, and those who cannot bear to be looked at by Gran. The Kept almost never ask. They are already in the dark of a shuttered attic most of their days. They want to see the light come through the shutters. (O.H.: we have done six Blinds in three hundred years. Four were asked for. Two were asked for by the families, in the client's voice, by a cousin who could do voices, and Father did not know until the second winter, and then he undid them, and the client, Mistress Agathe Rook, looked at him for a long time and said, "Thank you, Gideon, I had begun to think I was dead.")



There is no last stitch in Sallowreach. We tie off with a loop.

THE HARL PATTERN BOOK, ON THE MOURNER'S LOOP

LACQUERS

The Guild's lacquers are its proudest secret and its worst smell. Every shop boils its own, in the back yards of Needle Street, in copper pans over peat, and the street can be told from a mile off in the fog by the smell of hot cedar, pitch and something under them. None of these are to be eaten, drunk, or tried on the living. The Harl book has thirty receipts. Five are given.

CEDAR COMMON. The everyday coat for the families of the Middle Boards. Cedar oil, three parts. Pine pitch, two parts. Beeswax, one part, melted in last. Boil until a drop on cold slate goes hard and does not take a thumbnail. Brush on thin, in three coats, each dried with the bellows. Smells of a church.

Lasts a season, more indoors. Wants redoing in Restitching Week.

COURT LACQUER. For the Upper Boards, and for any client going before the Hall of Hands. Amber resin, ground fine, dissolved in cedar oil over a slow fire for three days. Myrrh, a pinch per pint, for the smell. Gold leaf laid on the cheekbones and the backs of the hands while it is tacky. Nine coats. A client in Court Lacquer shines like a sideboard and smells of nothing a living nose can name, which is the point: the Court does not like to be reminded. Forty lacks the face, a hundred and twenty the whole. We have done the Regent's hands. See the sewn pages.

POOR MAN'S PITCH. For the Sinks, and for those who pay in thread. Pine tar and rendered tallow, half and half, with a cup of vinegar to the gallon. It goes on black and stays sticky and cracks in a month. It keeps out the flies a little and the damp hardly at all. (O.H.: do not take the tallow from Wick Tallow's yard, whatever the price. His tallow was people, and it feels itself go on, and so does the client, and they talk to each other through the coat at night, and neither will say about what.)

FLY-BANE. A wash, not a lacquer, laid under the first coat in Plenty. Vinegar, a quart. Lavender, wormwood and rue, a fistful each, steeped a week in the dark. Strained through linen. Brushed into every seam and fold. The flies hate it. So do the clients; it stings in the open places like salt in a cut, and they will curse you for an hour, and they will thank you at the end of Plenty, when their neighbours are full of grubs.

THE BRIGHT COAT. Gideon Harl's own receipt, from 344, for which this shop is known. Cedar and amber as in the Court Lacquer, with fish-glue to set it hard, and with the ash of the client's own hair, burned and ground, worked into the last coat. Why the hair: because, Father said, it is theirs, and a coat with something of theirs in it holds better. It does. A Bright Coat holds for nine years. No one else on Needle Street can make it hold for more than two, though they have stolen the receipt, because no one else will tell you the last ingredient, which is not on this page, and which Father wrote only on the sewn pages.

COMPLAINTS

The Harl shop keeps its complaints, as every Needle Street shop does, pinned into the book behind the patterns, because the Kept have nothing but time to write them and it would be discourteous to throw them away. There are some hundreds. The Kept complain beautifully.

1. To Mistress Harl. The Purse you set in my left cheek last spring has held admirably. The right, set by your Threader, has not. It now hangs to my collar and I am obliged to hold it up at table with a fork. My great-grandson laughs. I should like it redone, and I should like the boy to do it, so he learns. — E. Coombe, Weir Row, Kept 431.

2. Sir. The hand you sewed to my wrist in Carving is not my hand. My hand was taken by Marrow Jack in Lack, as you know; you said this was “a good match from stock”. It is not a good match. It is a woman’s. At night it writes letters, with my pen, in a hand that is not mine, to a man in the Sinks whom I have never met. The letters are very tender. I do not know what to do. The man has written back. — Corlis Penn, Old Weir Row, Kept 512.

3. Mistress. You have stitched my mouth so neat I cannot laugh. My daughter told a very good story at supper. I wanted to laugh. Something tore. Please come. — A. Dunnock, the Sinks.

4. To the Shop. We wish to complain that you have restitched Grandfather so well that he will plainly last another three hundred years. We did not ask for that. We asked for him to be kept tidy until the Court’s lottery comes round for our ward. He is now sitting at the head of the table every evening in his Bright Coat and he has begun to speak of altering the will. — the Family Hask, Middle Boards. (O.H.: the Bright Coat was paid for by Grandfather himself, in minutes of Closing he had been saving for his son. We informed the family. They did not reply.)

5. Mistress Harl. I am seven. I have been seven since 441. Can you do flowers in the stitches this time, blue, round my neck, where the old ones are. The other Smalls have flowers. I have saved twelve threads. — Pip, below the Landing. (Done, in blue silk, at no charge. O.H.)

6. To the Needle and Eel. I write to tell you that the lacquer you laid on me at Restitching smells of nothing. Not cedar. Not myself. Nothing at all. My wife says I smell like the edge of Dunmere. I have stopped being able to feel the grubs, which in two hundred years I have never once stopped feeling, and I am frightened, Mistress, I am so frightened, it is like a hand on me, and I think I would like you to take it off. — Hal Varrow, Ninth Row, near the Vane estate. (Below, O.H.: went to him the next morning with the solvent. He had finished in the night, in his chair, properly. The family were very good about it. They did not complain. They asked whether we could make the lacquer again. They asked for nine pots.)

THE MASTER'S NOTES

O.H., in the back of the book, the last written pages, Carving 641.

Father began this book three years after the Vigil’s First Night, and he said that in a land where nothing ends a Seamer’s only true work is to keep things the shape they were. I have kept it two hundred and thirty-nine years. My hands are his work; I lost them in the Reckoners’ raid of 402, and he sewed them back that night, and they have never been quite mine, but they are better than mine, which I have never told anyone. I want to set down what is happening at the bench.

Since the Hushes began, thread goes grey in the needle near the Hand-line estates. It goes the colour of ash and it stops being thread; it holds, but it does not hold the way thread holds, it holds the way a door holds that has been shut for good. Thirty-one clients from the Vane and Fallow wards have finished on the bench this year, mid-seam, under the needle, with the shop’s own gut still in them. They do not scream. They let out a breath they have not drawn in a century and they are gone, and the smell comes up out of them all at once, all of it, two hundred years of it, and then nothing, nothing at all, the room smells of nothing, and the Threaders run into the yard. I have stopped sending Threaders to the Vane ward. I go myself.

The Guild’s stock of spare parts on the third floor of the Guildhall is three times the size it was in my apprenticeship. Thessaly will not say where it comes from. I know where hands come from. I have seen the Sump dredgers at the Guildhall’s back door at night with sacks that are not dripping fen-water. I have seen what the Court sends down from the Jar Room, when a jarred man’s pieces are “surplus to sentence.”

And I want to set down that Father’s book has a stitch in it that I have never used, on the sewn pages, which he called the Last Loop. It is a Mourner’s Loop that is drawn closed. It is the only knot in this book that finishes. He said he invented it in 344 for one client only and that it held a man together who could not be held any other way, and that if the loop is ever drawn out, the man will come apart all at once, every seam of three hundred years at once, and that the man was the Regent. I am the only one who knows which thread. I am old. I am not afraid of the Court. I am afraid of the Heirs, who are young, and have begun bringing their grandmothers to the shop, and staying to watch me work, and asking, very politely, about the sewn pages.

[Inspection note, pinned below, in a large square hand: Shop inspected. Patterns in order. Lacquers in order. Sewn pages not

opened, at the shop's request, which the Guild honours. — T. Mort, Master Seamer, Carving 641. And beneath, in the same hand, smaller: Otilie. Burn the sewn pages. I am asking as your friend. I know which part of me Gideon sewed, too.]

CARVER'S NOTES: THE SEAMER'S PATTERN BOOK

Rules: working from the book. A Guest with the Harl pattern book open at the bench gains +2 on Hand + Stitching to restitch a Kept body, and may attempt the named seams: the Lid (any wound; a standard restitch), the Purse (a Kept NPC's appearance improves enough that they gain +1 Standing among the living for a season), the Ladder (allows a Kept body to be opened and repacked; heals a Kept 1d6 Flesh if done each spring), the Heron (a Kept with rotted joints can walk; Lung -1), the Fly-Fence (in Plenty, the Kept client ignores Dread checks caused by its own maggots). The Courtesy, tightened, silences a Kept speaker entirely: Hard 14, and the Carver should make it clear what the Guest has just done to a person who will remember it for centuries. Each seam is an extended task (see the core rules), Hard 14, 3 to 6 Helpings, an hour a roll.

Rules: the Bright Coat. Only the Harls can make a Bright Coat hold nine years, because of the last ingredient. A Kept Guest in a Bright Coat ignores the first Mangling result each session. It costs 300 L and a lock of their hair.

Hooks.

- ◇ *The Letters.* Corlis Penn's borrowed hand writes love letters every night to a man in the Sinks. Its owner was a woman Marrow Jack took apart in a Loft. The man in the Sinks is her husband, and he has been answering, and he wants the hand back, and Corlis has begun, a little, to love him.
- ◇ *Nine Pots.* The lacquer that smells of nothing finishes the Kept who wear it. Hal Varrow's family wants nine more pots. So do the Finishers, and Sister Lorn, and the Heirs, and the Mortuary Court, which wants to know who has been licensed to sell death by the pint. Otilie Harl did not make it. Her Threader did, from a receipt he found on one of the sewn pages, and the Hush-grey threads in it came from the Vane ward.
- ◇ *The Last Loop.* The Heirs want the Regent's thread. Otilie wants it never found. Thessaly Mort wants the sewn pages burned for a reason she has not said, and the Guests may work it out: Gideon Harl sewed part of her too, in 344, with a loop of the same kind.

Secret. The last ingredient of the Bright Coat, on the sewn pages, is a stitch of the Seamer's own hair worked into the client's, so that the coat holds two people's something. Every Bright Coat in Lastgate has a little of Gideon Harl in it, and since 402, a little of Otilie. When Otilie finishes, if she ever does, every Bright Coat in the city will fail at once. There are four hundred and eleven of them, and some of them are on the Court.

▼ THE REGISTER OF THE CALLED



The Netwatch keeps a register on every beat of the Mile, a tall narrow book bound in tarred sailcloth, kept on a hook inside the watch-box at the head of each section and filled in by the Watch-Sergeant at the end of every night by the light of a storm-lantern. The logs record Callings as numbers. The families record them as names. The register does both, in five columns ruled by hand: the name and house, the rope (how the Called got loose), the colour of the last bail-water (which the hookers ask for at the door, because the families always look), whether the Called was recovered, and the signature of the hooker who made the recovery or saw the loss. It is the coast's most exact record of the Calling, and the Admiralty has never published one. The pages below are from the register of the Mile Twelve beat, between the Cooper's Gap and the Sixteenth rail, kept by Watch-Sergeant Corra Vell, from Lack 640 into Carving

641. They were found on the bench of the watch-box at dawn, with the ink of the last entry still wet, and the watch-box empty, and the storm-lantern still burning.

REGISTER OF THE CALLED, MILE TWELVE BEAT, NETWATCH OF THE TIDAL ADMIRALTY. Standing Orders, inside cover: Enter every Calling, recovered or lost. Enter the bail-water as the family gives it, not as you would like it. Enter "Subject appeared expected" where it applies. It always applies. Sign for what you saw with your own eyes and nothing else. No hooker to sign for another. No hooker to sign who is not on the beat. — Lt. S. Reef, for the Watch-Captain.

LACK 640

NAME AND HOUSE	ROPE	BAIL-WATER	RECOVERED	SIGNED
Dunn Pell, 22, net-maker, No. 3 Tarry Row	cut, blade on the floor (own)	blue	not; at the Sixteenth gap	C. Vell
Maudie Pell, 51, his mother	knot undone by hand, neatly	green	yes; fought; wept at the bench	H. Dunmore
Ivo Carrack, 9, No. 6 Tarry Row	slipped; rope intact	clear	yes; asleep throughout; asked for his sister	J. Sallow
Hooker Jem Sallow, 19, of this watch	(on duty, no rope)	(not given)	not; walked off the beat at the Cooper's Gap, lantern in hand	C. Vell
Ada Fenning, 70, widow, No. 1 Coil St.	chain; staple drawn from the beam	blue	not	H. Dunmore
Ruth and Ottery Brine, 30 and 33, No. 1 Coil St.	roped together; ring torn out	green, both	not; seen at the Rail, holding hands	C. Vell
Ivo Carrack, 9, No. 6 Tarry Row	slipped again; rope intact	clear	yes; asleep; asked again for his sister	J. Sallow

Sgt. Vell's night-notes, Lack 640, under the page.

Pell boy went at the second bell. Blue. His mother told us it was blue at dusk and she had tied him anyway and slept beside him and he cut himself loose with her own net-knife and kissed her on the forehead before he went, she says, and she lay there and let him, she says, because he asked so nicely. She went after him. Dunmore got her at Coil Street. She fought him all the way back to the bench and then sat and wept and said she would have liked to have gone with him, that is all, only to see.

Jem Sallow walked off the beat at the Cooper's Gap at the fourth bell. I saw him go. He had his lantern. He was looking west and smiling and he said, quite normal, "Sarge, there's someone on the mud waving," and walked off the end of the boards, sixty foot, and did not fall, I mean he fell, I heard him land, and then I saw his lantern going away west across the Uncovered, steady, not hurrying. I have entered him. His mother has been told.

The Carrack boy: entered twice. See the signatures. I have asked Dunmore whether he saw Jem at the Tarry Row door on

the second night. Dunmore says he did not look. Dunmore says, Sarge, just sign the page.

GRACE 641

NAME AND HOUSE	ROPE	BAIL-WATER	RECOVERED	SIGNED
Pellam Strake, 44, Chandler, No. 10 Lantern Row	rope intact, ankle-loop wet and empty	blue	not	C. Vell
Nan Strake, 40, his wife	rope cut, no blade	blue	yes; Tenanted, returned from the surf Day 31	J. Sallow
Dorrit Ames, 16, No. 4 Lantern Row	rope intact; knots untied and retied around nothing	green	yes; at the gap; said "thank you" in a man's voice	J. Sallow
Line-Hand Esmé Pardoe, transferred from Mile Ten	(on duty)	(not given)	not; seen at the Rail with Jem Sallow	H. Dunmore
Old Mag Kittering, 88, No. 2 Lantern Row	no rope; refused rope for 60 years	clear	did not walk; died in her chair, facing east	C. Vell
Watch-Sergeant's nephew, Tobin Vell, 12, Mile Twelve barracks	roped to the Sergeant	green	yes	E. Pardoe

Sgt. Vell's night-notes, Grace 641.

I am writing down what I know, in order, because the Lieutenant says that is what the register is for and nothing else.

Jem Sallow was entered in Lack, lost at the Cooper's Gap. I wrote it myself. Since Lack, Jem Sallow's name has been signed against eleven recoveries on this beat. The signature is his. I know it: he signed my register for a year and he made his J like a hook, and he always pressed too hard at the end so the nib went through the paper. These go through the paper. I have not seen him. No hooker has seen him. The recoveries are real. The families say a young hooker brought their people back across the mud at dawn, carrying them, gentle, dripping, wrapped in a Netwatch net, and laid them on the bench, and signed the book, and went. Some of the recovered are quite well. Some of them are Tenanted, and came back Tenanted on the very night they walked, which never happens; the Tenanted come back after weeks. Nan Strake was in the surf thirty-one days and then Jem carried her in.

Esmé Pardoe asked to transfer to the Headland. She was sent to us instead, because we were short. She lasted nine nights.

She went off the Rail with her lantern on the tenth and Dunmore saw her go and saw a lantern come up the mud to meet her and he says he knew whose it was by the way it swung. I have entered her lost.

On the twelfth night after, my nephew Tobin walked. I had roped him to me. The rope was cut and I did not wake. In the morning he was on the bench in the watch-box asleep, wrapped in a net, dripping, and he was Tobin, he is Tobin, I have looked at him every way there is to look at a boy and he is Tobin, and the register was open and his recovery was signed. E. Pardoe. Her E is a little crab. It is hers.

I have not told the Lieutenant. If the Lieutenant reads this she will know. I have decided that I would rather she knew.



Enter "Subject appeared expected" where it applies. It always applies.

STANDING ORDERS OF THE NETWATCH, INSIDE
COVER OF EVERY REGISTER ON THE MILE

CARVING 641: THE LAST PAGE

NAME AND HOUSE	ROPE	BAIL-WATER	RECOVERED	SIGNED
Hooker Hal Dunmore, 40, of this watch	(on duty)	(not given)	yes	J. Sallow, E. Pardoe
Tobin Vell, 12, Mile Twelve barracks	rope intact; no knot	blue	yes; wrapped in a net; asleep	J. Sallow
All of No. 6 Tarry Row: the Carracks, five	roped together, the rope taken with them	blue, all	yes, all five, by the gap, walking back up the boards in a line, dry	(thirty-one signatures, the hookers of the Great Pressure Day, 627)

NAME AND HOUSE	ROPE	BAIL- WATER	RECOVERED	SIGNED
Ivo Carrack, 9	slipped	clear	not; he was not with them	C. Vell
Watch-Sergeant Corra Vell, 46, of this watch	cut by own hand, own knife	blue	(the column left blank)	S. Reef

The last entry, in a hand that is not Sgt. Vell's. The ink was wet at dawn.

Sgt. Vell walked at the last bell, with her lantern, and her own knife in her hand, from the bench of this watch-box. She did not cut her rope. She had no rope, being on duty. She cut the strap of the register's hook, and laid the register on the bench, open, so it could be read, and went. Subject appeared expected. I signed for it because I saw it with my own eyes. I was on the beat. — S. Reef, Lt.

[Note added in pencil by the Watch-Captain's clerk, the following morning: Lt. Reef was at the Admiralty all night, at the Watch-Captain's table, from the first bell to the last, before nine witnesses. The register is to be sealed. The Mile Twelve watch-box is to be manned by a full squad of six. The squad is to be told nothing. The boy Ivo Carrack is at the barracks, and keeps asking where his family is, and whether the hookers will bring them back, and the squad do not know what to tell him, because the Carracks of No. 6 Tarry Row are at home, all five, sitting very still around their table with the west door open, and they say they have never had a son.]

CARVER'S NOTES: THE REGISTER OF THE CALLED

Rules: reading the bail-water. The register's third column is a forecast. A Guest who reads a household's bail-water at dawn (Eye + Search, Routine 10; Tolly Brack does it without rolling) learns its colour: **clear** (no change), **green** (that household's next Calling roll is at +2 Difficulty), **blue** (at +4, and the Carver should call a Calling roll that very night). Blue in a Guest's own bucket is a Dread 2 check, and a decision about the rope.

Rules: serving on the beat. A Guest who enlists in the Netwatch (Mile Seven barracks; always short of hands) walks a beat at night and signs the register. Hauling a Called home is an opposed Gut + Labor roll against the Called's Lung + Athletics, as in the core rules; the Called feel no pain and do not tire, and on a Lack the hooker is pulled off the boards with them. Every recovery a Guest signs for is a Dread 1 check, from the look on the face of the recovered. Every loss a Guest signs for is a Dread 2.

Hooks.

- ◇ *The Signatures.* Jem Sallow and Esmé Pardoe, entered as lost, are signing recoveries on Mile Twelve, and the recovered come home wrapped in nets, dripping, sometimes Tenanted on the same night. The Admiralty wants the register sealed and the matter ended. The families want to thank the young hooker. Sitting up a night at the Cooper's Gap with a lantern (Caul + Resolve, Hard 14, not to look west when the waving starts) shows the Guests two lanterns coming up out of the dark of the Uncovered, carrying something between them, and a third, newer one coming behind.
- ◇ *Ivo Carrack.* A boy of nine whose family came home without him and say they never had a son. He was recovered twice in Lack, asleep, asking for his sister. He has no sister in any record. Nobody in No. 6 Tarry Row will open the door to him; through it, the family can be heard saying his name, in turn, slowly, the way a household calls the morning count, and not answering.
- ◇ *The Lieutenant.* Sable Reef was at the Admiralty all night, before nine witnesses, and signed the last page of the register at Mile Twelve. She does not remember it. She dreams every night that she is walking west with the three hundred she saved, and that they are glad she came. The Guests may be the ones who tell her about the signature, or the ones the Watch-Captain sends to watch her sleep.

Secret. The hookers who walk off the beat do not stop being hookers. On the Uncovered, past the Sixteenth gap, the lost of the Netwatch patrol a beat of their own, in a line of lanterns that the Mile can see on still nights and does not mention, and they go on doing the only thing they were ever trained to do: they bring the Called home. They are very good at it. They are better at it than the living, because the Called do not fight them. The register's "recovered" figure on Mile Twelve has nearly doubled since Lack 640, and the Admiralty has been quietly proud of it. What the drowned hookers carry back up the boards is the Called, in their own bodies, with their own memories, and with someone else looking out through their eyes; and the families, who have been

trained for six hundred years not to ask a returned person where they went, are taking them home and thanking the Netwatch. The thirty-one hookers of the Great Pressure Day of 627 are still on the beat. They have signed for more people in the last year than the living Netwatch has saved in ten. Brenna Kelp's arithmetic says the sea is moving into the people a bucket at a time. The register of Mile Twelve says somebody has begun carrying the buckets.

CHAPTER 2

FOUND PAGES II

More Documents of the Table

Everyone on the Table keeps a book. Even the flies have a book now.

— TEAL MALLORY OF WEIR ROW, IN A LETTER TO HER MOTHER ON THE SHELF

The Table writes everything down. It writes because the gods cannot be argued with, only recorded; because a Matron must count, a Weigher must weigh, a Clausewright must quote the exact words; and because in a world where your grandmother may be a hill and your neighbour may be a candle, the only way to keep hold of anybody is on paper. This chapter collects six more of those papers, each reproduced at length as it might fall into the hands of the Guests: in a stolen bundle, at the bottom of a Company strongbox, on a stall at Gristmoot between the sausages and the rope, or folded small in a dead man's shoe.

Each document is set out the same way. A short account says what it is, who made it, where it is kept and what it costs to own. The long excerpt follows in the document's own voice. Then the

Carver's notes say what the document is for at the table: the hook it hangs, the rule it carries, and the secret folded inside it that the Guests may or may not find. Every one of these pages can be handed to players as a prop. Several of them should not be, until the right moment, and one of them should be read aloud only by someone who is willing to be heard.



*Draw what you see. Do not write what you think.
Your successor will need to know the difference.*

THE FIRST RULE OF THE DORMITORY REGISTER,
TAUGHT MATRON TO MATRON SINCE 342 A.G.

▼ BED ONE'S WORDS



Two of flour to one of water, salt, the old starter, knead till it's warm as a cheek.

— THE LIPS OF AVELINE MORNE, BED ONE, AS TRANSCRIBED BY MATRON
CECILY DORM, CARVING 641

What it is. A Dormitory register-book of the ordinary pattern, octavo, bound in grey buckram gone soft at the corners, its pages starched as stiff as the Dormitory's sheets so that they crackle when turned. It is the private notebook of Matron Cecily Dorm, Keeper of the Count, and it contains everything the lips of Aveline Morne, the Sleeper in Bed One, have ever been seen to shape: not only in the month since her lips began to move in earnest, but across the whole of the three hundred years she has lain in the Dormitory, recovered by Cecily from the margins of every Matron's register since 342. It smells of starch, lye and pencil-lead, and under all three of warm bread. There is flour in the gutter of the binding. Nobody has ever put any there.

Where it is. At Cecily's belt, beside the bed-keys, or under her hand on the rail of Bed One. Since Carving 641 pages have been cut from it with a razor and sold in the Pinchmarket on the Slope, four or five lacks a leaf, by a thief who has learned what the names on the last pages mean and charges accordingly. Unique; not for sale; **Taint Dread 4** to read through (Dread 2 thereafter, as one gets used to things), and a reader whose name is on the last pages takes no further Dread from it, because they are past that.

How it is set. Cecily wrote out the old marginal shapes and the new lip-words together, as one piece, in the order and with the spacing in which they were made, and she broke it into lines the way she says she heard it: as a poem. She knew it was a recipe by the end. She did not know it at the beginning, and neither, she says, would anyone. The excerpt below is her fair copy of the whole, with her own notes in the margin.

BED ONE'S WORDS. A fair copy, made by me, Cecily Dorm, Matron, in the Lack of 641, from my own notes and from the registers of the Matrons before me, beginning with Matron Ysolde Harrow, who received Bed One in the Corn Granary in 342.

To whoever has this book after me. Every Matron since Harrow has kept a margin for Bed One. We were taught to: draw what you see, do not write what you think. So for three hundred years the Matrons of the Dormitory drew a little mouth in the margin whenever Aveline's lips were seen to move, and wrote the date, and the bell, and nothing else. Two hundred and twelve little mouths. Nobody ever thought they

were words. They were years apart. They were breathing. They were the face settling, the way a sleeper's face will.

Thaddeus Knell reads lips. He has had to, since the bells took his ears. In Plenty of this year, before she began in earnest, I brought him the registers one at a time and we sat in the Matron's office with a lamp and he looked at the little mouths in order, and he said what each one was. He did not know why I wanted it. I did not tell him. When we had done all two hundred and twelve he would not take his fee. He said, "Matron, that is somebody talking very slowly," and went home and did not ring the next quarter, and was fined.

I have set them out here as she said them. Where a line stands alone with a date, that is one word, or two, in a whole lifetime of nights. You will see the spaces close up. I have not made them close. She has.

I.

THE OLD MARGINS (as drawn by eleven Matrons, read by T. Knell)

Harrow, 342, the first Lack, the ninth bell:

Cover.

Harrow, 349:

her

Harrow, 361, the year of her own lying-down:
face.

(A Matron's note, in a hand I do not know, 361: "Bed One stirred the night Matron Harrow was brought in. The Matron was laid in 1,402. Bed One's lips moved once. Draw only.")

Quenby, 378:

With a cloth.

Quenby, 390, the year of the Patent:

Let her

Aske, 404:

rest.

Aske, 413:

In the warm.

Aske, 429:

In the dark.

(Aske's margin, 429: a little mouth, very carefully drawn, and beside it, which is against the rule, the words "she looks content." Struck through by Aske herself.)

Pellow, 447:

Do not

Pellow, 455:

look

Pellow, 461:

at her.

Mabry, 470:

She is

Mabry, 488:

rising.

Mabry, 491:

She is rising.

(Mabry's register, 491, beside the mouth: "Bed One appears to breathe more deeply than the row. Physician consulted. Physician says not." Mabry asked to be relieved in 492 and was refused.)

Corriveau, 503:

When she has

Corriveau, 511:

doubled,

Corriveau, 520:

knock her

Corriveau, 522:

back.

(Knell, reading the 522 mouth, said "back" and then said, "Matron, I don't like this one," and would not say why. I think it was the double stop. The lips closing on themselves twice.)

Hesketh, 534:

Fold her.

Hesketh, 541:

Fold her

Hesketh, 549:

over.

Hesketh, 551:

Turn her

Hesketh, 560:

and fold her.

Lisle, 567:

Shape her

Lisle, 574:

with wet hands.

Lisle, 580:

Let her

Lisle, 583:

rest again.

Lisle, 588:

Everything

Lisle, 590:

wants

Lisle, 591:

to rest.

(Lisle's margin, 591, the year I was born in Bedside: three little mouths on one page, and Lisle's note, against the rule: "THREE IN ONE YEAR." The capitals are pressed so hard the pencil went through.)

Anstey, 602:

Lay her

Anstey, 606:

in the basket.

Anstey, 609:

Lay her face down

Anstey, 611:

in the floured cloth.

Anstey, 613:

Cover her.

Anstey, 615:

Keep her cool

Anstey, 616:

the long night through.

Anstey, 618:

She will be

Anstey, 619:

better

Anstey, 619:

for the waiting.

Anstey, 620:

Everything is

Anstey, 621:

better

Anstey, 621:

for the waiting.

Dorm, 623, my first year, the third bell, and I drew it myself, and I did not know:

In the morning,

Dorm, 627:

heat the oven

Dorm, 630:

as hot as it will go.

Dorm, 633:

Hotter.

Dorm, 636:

Put the pot in

Dorm, 637:

to heat with it.

Dorm, 638:

Turn her out.

Dorm, 639:

Cut her.

(I drew the 639 mouth the same week I did the first of the four things I did with the pillow. I put that here so that whoever has this book knows I have not left it out.)

Dorm, 640, Plenty:

Cut her once across the top

Dorm, 640, Carving:

with the thin knife

Dorm, 640, Lack, Tablenight, in the dark minute, by touch, because I had my hand on her mouth and the lamps were out: so she can open.

II.

THE WAKING (Carving 641, written at the bedside, by me)

That is three hundred years. Now I will give you one month.

On the first day of the Carving Plate her lips moved at the second bell and did not stop until the fourth. I had my pencil. I wrote what Knell had taught me to see.

Cover her face with a cloth and let her rest in the warm.

Do not look at her. She is rising.

When she has doubled, knock her back.

*Fold her over, turn her and fold her, shape her with wet hands.
Everything wants to rest.*

(The whole of the Old Margins, in one morning. Three hundred years of it in two bells. She said it the way a girl says something she has said every morning of her life. I sat down on the floor of the hall, which a Matron does not do, and the orderly of the row came and I sent him away.)

The second day:

No. Not yet. Begin at the beginning, Avvy. Begin with the old one.

(I have asked everyone. Nobody has called her Avvy in three hundred years. Her grandmother did. It was in the papers from Crumb Street they brought in with her.)

The old one lives in the crock by the oven.

It was Gran's. It was her gran's.

It is older than the street.

It has to be fed every day or it dies.

Every day. Every day. Every day.

Throw half of it away and feed what's left.

That's the hard part. Throwing half away.

You get used to it.

The third day:

Feed it a handful of flour and a handful of water.

Warm water. Warm as a cheek.

Stir it till there are no dry bits. Scrape the sides down.

Put the lid on loose. It has to breathe.

Leave it by the oven. By morning it will have doubled.

It will smell sour and sweet. Like apples. Like a pub.

If it smells like a pub you've let it go too long, and Gran will smack your hand.

(She laughed. Not aloud. The lips did what lips do when someone laughs. The row beside her breathed in at once, all of them, and held it, and let it out. I have never seen the row do that.)

The fourth day to the ninth day, the bread, entire, as she gave it, which I have checked against a baker of the Slope, and it is right, and it is good bread, and he cried when I read it him and would not say why either:

Take the old one when it's at its highest, when it's all bubbles and it's domed and it hasn't fallen yet.

A cup of the old one. Three cups of the strong flour. A cup and a half of warm water. A big pinch of salt, two pinches if you're Gran.

Mix the flour and the water first and let them sit together an hour, before the old one and the salt. Let them get to know each other.

Then the old one. Then the salt, with a splash more water to carry it.

Squeeze it through your fingers till it's all one. It'll be wet and it'll stick to you. Don't put more flour in. Everyone puts more flour in. Wet hands.

Then leave it in the bowl with a cloth on it, in the warm, and every half hour for two hours, wet your hand and lift one side and fold it over the middle, and turn the bowl, and do the next side. Four sides. Like tucking someone in.

Then leave it be. Let it rest in the warm till it's half again as big and it wobbles when you shake the bowl.

Tip it out on the board, gentle, don't knock the air out of it now, it's worked hard for that.

Shape it round. Pull the skin of it tight over the top with your two hands, tuck it underneath, turn it on the board till it holds itself up.

Lay her face down in the basket in the floured cloth.

Cover her. Keep her cool the long night through. In the cold room. She will be better for the waiting.

In the morning heat the oven as hot as it will go, with the pot in it, the black pot with the lid.

Turn her out onto the paper. Cut her once across the top with the thin knife, quick, don't be frightened of it, so she can open.

Into the pot with her. Lid on. Half an hour with the lid on, so she can rise in her own steam.

Then lid off, and the heat down a little, and another half hour, till she's dark as a chestnut and she sounds hollow when you knock on the bottom.

Knock on the bottom. Listen.

If somebody knocks back, she isn't done.

(I asked the baker about the last line. He said it is a thing bakers say on Crumb Street, a joke for apprentices. He said his master said it. He had never heard where it came from. I have looked in every book of the old city I can find and it is not in any of them before 341.)

Let her cool on the rack before you cut her. All the way. That's the hardest part of all.

Everything is better for the waiting.

III.

THE NAMES (from the tenth day of the Carving Plate)

On the tenth day, at the second bell, she said the whole of the bread again, quickly, under her breath, the way you say a thing you know by heart while you are thinking of something else. And then she said a name.

I wrote it down. I did not know what it meant. The next day the person named went to the room. I was told at the Receiving Gate. I put her in bed 58,019 myself.

Since then there has been a name most days, at the end of the bread, where the knocking is. I have written all of them. I have put a line through each when they come in through the Gate. I have not yet had to wait more than a day to draw the line.

(Here, in the book, four leaves have been cut out with a razor, close to the binding. The stubs show the ends of lines in Cecily's hand: —ell, of the Slope, a nudger, and —on Pyre, and —the little one at the eleventh b—, and on the last stub nothing but a long pencil stroke going off the edge of the page, as though the writer's hand had been pulled.)

IV.

THE LAST PAGE, AS OF THE TWENTY-SIXTH DAY

Today she did not say the bread. She said this, once, clearly, with her eyes shut, at the bell when the lamps are trimmed:

There is someone at the door who has not been fed.

Set another place.

I said, "Avvy, who?" I have never spoken to her in the register before. I have spoken to her every day for thirty years, but not in the register.

Her lips moved again. Knell was not there. I drew it. It is the first mouth in three hundred years I have not been able to read, and I have drawn it eleven times on a separate leaf to be sure of the shape. It is a short word. It is a very old shape. The lips come together at the front as if for a kiss, or for the start of the word bread, and then they open wide, and stay open, as if for someone to put something in.

The whole row turned its faces toward the east door after she said it. They are still turned. I have had to tell the orderlies not to try to turn them back.

I am going to sit with her now. I will keep counting. Fifty-eight thousand and twenty-six. Fifty-eight thousand and twenty-seven. Good night, love.

C.D.



Knock on the bottom. Listen. If somebody knocks back,
she isn't done.

BED ONE, THE TWENTY-FIRST LINE OF THE BREAD

CARVER'S NOTES: BED ONE'S WORDS

The hook. The stolen leaves are on sale in the Pinchmarket. Each leaf sold carries the names written on it, and the people on those leaves are still going to the room one a day, whether or not the page has been crossed through. Somebody has bought the leaf with a Guest's name on it, and is trying to sell it back. Or: the Matron hires the Guests to find the razor-thief, and the trail runs through the Slope to an orderly of Bed One's own hall, who sells the pages because he believes that a name sold is a name the room will not take. He is wrong, and he knows it now, and he has kept selling.

The rule: reading it aloud. Reading the Old Margins aloud, in order, inside the Vigil, takes about ten minutes. Everyone in earshot who has gone more than a day without sleep makes a blink check at Hard (14), and anyone who blinks during the reading meets the kind lady in the baker's apron at the soft end of the long room, who finishes the line they were on. Reading the bread section aloud is harmless anywhere but the Dormitory. Reading the last page aloud at the foot of Bed One adds the reader's voice to the row: for a heartbeat, every one of the Counted in the hall breathes in with them.

The rule: the bread. The recipe works. A Guest who bakes it, with ordinary flour, makes an ordinary, excellent loaf and can treat the bread as a **feast's worth of comfort**: everyone who shares the loaf removes 1 Fray, once per Plate. A Guest who bakes it with a pinch of the flour from Aveline's knuckles makes a loaf that never stales (Taint 2 Regrowth, Iss) and that, laid on the table at night, fills the house with the smell of a bakery at dawn; anyone who sleeps in that house sleeps very well, and anyone with the Vigil in their blood does not wake.

The secret the Carver can reveal. The spaces between the words are not random. Set the dates of the Old Margins against the Dormitory's count of filled beds, and they line up: each word came when the Dormitory filled by roughly the same number of sleepers, and as the beds filled faster, the words came faster. The bread is a count. Cecily has worked this out. She has also worked out that the bread has a fixed number of words, that she has now heard all of them but the last, and that the last word comes after the cooling, the hardest part of all, when the loaf is cut and shared. She has not written down what she thinks the last word is, and she will not say it aloud.

The secret nobody knows. The old shape Cecily could not read on the twenty-sixth day is a word older than Table-speech. A Cutwright, or Grandfather Peat in his tank at Quire, could read it. The Carver should decide what it would cost them to say it, and should not let it be said lightly.

Real recipe. The bread in the excerpt is a plain country sourdough and will work in any kitchen: 100 g of active starter, 500 g strong white flour, about 360 ml of warm water, 10 g of salt; rest flour and water an hour, add starter and salt, four sets of folds half an hour apart, bulk rise until half again in size, shape, proof overnight in the refrigerator, bake in a preheated lidded pot at 250°C for 30 minutes,

then lid off at 220°C for 20 to 25 more. Let it cool before cutting. It really is the hardest part.

WHAT THE NAMES HAVE IN COMMON

The Matron has not seen it. Those who read the stolen leaves together, with access to the Dormitory's visiting-books, will. Every name Bed One has spoken belongs to someone who once stood at the foot of a Counted bed for an hour or more a day, for a year or more: mothers, sons, nudgers who lost their charge, a Waker captain whose nudger went down. The room is calling those who love the Counted most. A Guest who has visited a sleeper faithfully is a Guest who should be afraid of this book.

D6	A LEAF FROM BED ONE'S WORDS, AS FOUND
1	A page of the bread, the folding section, with a child's crayon drawing of a loaf in the corner and the words <i>for Pip</i>
2	A leaf of names, three crossed through, the fourth not, and the fourth is the buyer's own
3	A leaf of Old Margins in an old hand, Mabry's, with a little mouth drawn so often it has worn a hole
4	A forgery, sold to the Bedded for twelve lacks, in which Bed One says <i>come home, all of you</i> ; it is being preached from
5	The eleven drawings of the unreadable word, on one leaf; whoever owns it begins to shape it in their sleep
6	A blank leaf, cut from the end of the book. There is flour in its crease. By morning there is a name on it, in pencil, in the Matron's hand

▼ THE RIM ROAD COMPANY EMPLOYEE HANDBOOK



Pay the toll. Keep the peace. Say the grace.

— THE THREE ARTICLES, PRINTED ON THE INSIDE COVER OF EVERY COPY

What it is. *The Book of the Wheel: Being the Instructions of the Rim Road Company to Its Bonded Hands, Waymasters and Factors, in the Ninth Revision (619 A.G.), With the Amendments Since.* A small fat book, palm-sized, bound in oiled black calf with the seven-spoked wheel blind-stamped on the front and a brass clasp that a Hand can open one-handed while holding a lantern. Every Bonded Hand is issued one at Treaty Stair with the iron wrist-ring, and is expected to carry it on the road, to know it, and to lose it never. The paper is good Oathen rag; the print is small; the margins of most copies are full of pencilled amendments, drovers' jokes and the names of inns that water their beer.

Where it is found. In the coat of any Bonded Hand, living or otherwise. Secondhand copies sell at Gristmoot for 2 lacks, because travellers who know what is in it get better service at Company houses; a copy carries no Taint. Every copy issued since 619 has had its Section 14 removed, neatly, with a blade along the gutter, at Treaty Stair, before issue. The stubs remain. The table of contents still lists it.

THE BOOK OF THE WHEEL. NINTH REVISION.

FOREWORD, BY THE FIRST SPOKE.

You have sworn the Bond. You walked down the stair and you looked in at every window, and you saw what the Company does with a Hand who steals from it, and you walked up again with the ring on your wrist. Good. Now you belong to the road.

The road is two thousand four hundred miles of fitted stone, and you will walk most of it. You will be cold on it and wet on it and you will be offered, on it, everything that every land on the Table has to sell, and some of it will be people, and some of it will be gods. This book will not tell you what to think about any of it. The Company does not think. The Company carries. This book will tell you how to carry it, how to be paid for carrying it, and how to come back to the next post with the same number of fingers as you left the last.

Read it in order. Read it again in Lack, when the road is slow. If anything in it seems strange to you, it is because somebody died to have it written down. Sections are numbered as in the Eighth Revision, so that older Hands may find their place; some numbers are therefore missing.

O. Penhallow, First Spoke, from the carriage-house, on the road between Gristmoot and Toll Nine.

SECTION 1. THE THREE ARTICLES.

1.1. *The Company has three laws, and they are recited at every post at dawn by the senior Hand present. Pay the toll. Keep the peace. Say the grace.*

1.2. *These three are sufficient for all cases. Where a case appears to be not covered by them, the Hand will find on reflection that it is covered by the first.*

1.3. *The grace is "Lack keep away." It is said at the gate and at the table. A Hand who omits it is fined one lack. A Hand who*

omits it at a table where there are travellers present who have also omitted it will be asked, by the Factor, at the next post, why nobody at that table said it, and is advised to have an answer.

SECTION 3. TOLLS, AND THE TAKING OF THEM.

3.1. The schedule of tolls is posted on the bone slate at every gate. The Hand will know it by heart. The Hand will not alter it, discount it, or explain it.

3.2. Every lack is to be weighed in the palm and turned once before it is taken. A lack that is warm on one side is to be accepted and not remarked upon. A lack that turns in the palm, by itself, toward a land, is to be accepted, and passed to the Factor at day's end in the separate pouch.

3.3. The Hush Toll is charged on corpses, by the body. The Kept of Sallowreach are not corpses and are charged as Foot, once, at Fogmouth, after which they are not charged again, because they are no longer travelling.

3.4. The Breath Toll is charged on any traveller showing godsign at the Course. The Hand is not required to determine what counts as the Course. If the Hand had to look twice, it counts.

3.5. Of the Cage Toll. Live cargo in a closed cart is charged three lacks a post and is entered as livestock. The Hand does not open the cart. The Hand does not knock on the cart. If something in the cart knocks, the Hand does not knock back, and enters it as livestock.

3.6. The Seal is charged on nothing. A courier under an Oathen oath is to be passed through at once, by night or day, and fed standing, and not delayed for any cause, including the Hand's own death; see Section 13, Item 11.

SECTION 5. DRESS AND BEARING.

5.1. On duty the Hand wears the road-coat, grey, to the knee, with the wheel in white on the left breast and the post number in white on the right. The coat is to be clean at the gate. It is not expected to be clean anywhere else.

5.2. The iron wrist-ring is worn on the left wrist and shown when asked. It is not to be covered, polished, engraved, wrapped in cloth against the cold, or removed. It cannot be removed. Hands who have attempted it are in the window at Treaty Stair, second gallery, fourth from the top.

5.3. Waymasters carry the brass whistle on a cord and the caravan's slate on a strap. Factors wear the gate-keys at the belt and the platter-seal on a chain. Toll-Lords carry the bone-shod staff. No Hand shall carry another rank's mark for any purpose, including a joke.

5.4. Land dress. When working a post within a land, the Hand will observe the following, in addition to the coat:

5.4.1. In Sallowreach, a phial of vinegar or cedar oil at the collar. The Hand who smells of nothing will be taken for a Closer and will not be served.

5.4.2. In the Fatlands, no belt. The coat is to be worn open or tied with a sash. A belt on a thin Hand will be taken for a mark of the Thin, and the Bailiffs will take the Hand to the Gavage, and the Company's protest will arrive afterward.

5.4.3. In Brinehollow, a bail-bucket, carried on the hip, whether or not the Hand needs it. A Hand without a bucket will be thought to have been Called and come back, and will be asked where he went, which in Brinehollow is a grave rudeness, and a fight will follow.

5.4.4. In the Vigil, a pin in the lapel, offered point-out to any guest on arrival, and the Hand's own nudger-cord, worn at the wrist, so that a Waker who finds the Hand drowsy knows whom to fine.

5.4.5. In Cradlewrack, the knuckles of the right hand to be kept bare, for knocking.

5.4.6. In Oathen, the card of safe phrases, and the slate. A Hand who speaks aloud in Oathen does so on his own account. The Company will not stand surety for any Hand's mouth.

5.5. A Hand will not wear a glove at the gate. Travellers must see the Hand's palms when he takes their coin, so that they know the Hand is not a Closer, nor anything else with hands that should not be touched.

SECTION 7. CONDUCT IN THE COMMON ROOM.

7.1. The common room belongs to the Company. The guests are permitted in it.

7.2. A guest arriving after dark is met at the gate with salt in the palm and one crumb. The salt is licked. The crumb is kept and returned on leaving. A guest who leaves without returning the crumb has taken a bite of the house and is not to be let in again, at any post, for any price. Their name is posted on the slate. Do not argue about this. The crumbs are counted.

7.3. The honest bench is nearest the fire and is filled by the Factor's choice. The Hand will seat strangers of different lands side by side. The Hand will not seat a Reckoner beside a Hand-line, nor an Unfed beside a Fatlander who is eating, nor anyone at all beside a Tenanted who has asked to sit with his back to the west, unless the Factor directs it, in which case the Factor has a reason and the Hand does not need it.

7.4. The Night Count. At dusk and at dawn the senior Hand walks the house with a lamp and counts heads aloud, every

room, every bed, the stables, the privy and the roof, and enters both numbers in the ledger. If the dawn count is lower than the dusk count, the wardens are called. If it is higher, see Section 14.

7.5. The head of the table is the Company's chair. Nobody sits in it. Not a Spoke. Not the Factor. Not a guest of any rank who asks. It is to be dusted daily, and laid at every meal with a clean plate and a cup, which are to be cleared unused and washed with the others.

7.7. Fights. The Hand will separate fighters with the pole and not the hands. A guest who draws a blade in the common room is to be disarmed, held, and given to the wardens, who will hang him at the post before the blood is dry, as the Charter allows. The Hand will then mop the floor. The Hand will say the grace over the mop-bucket, as over any meal, because it is the Company's custom, and because nobody now remembers why, and because the one Factor who stopped doing it is not with us.

SECTION 11. IF A TABLE APPEARS IN THE COMMON ROOM.

11.1. It will be found laid. It will be warm. There will be a smell of bread, and of roasting, and of something sweet and brown that the Hand will remember from a kitchen he was in as a child. It will not have been there at the last count. The Hand will know it is not one of the Company's tables, because it will be better.

11.2. The Hand will not sit.

11.3. The Hand will not thank it. If a chair has been pulled out, the Hand will not thank the chair, nor push it in. The Hand will not say come in, or after you, or please, or what a spread, or any other kindness. The Hand is advised to say nothing at all, and to walk backward from the table to the door without turning round.

11.4. The senior Hand will ring the gate-bell three times, slowly, and then three times quickly. This is the table-call. On hearing it, every Hand in the house goes to the guest-rooms and keeps the guests in them. Guests who wish to come down and look are to be told that there has been a fire. In a sense there has.

11.5. The Factor, or the senior Hand if the Factor is absent, will take the axe from the hooks behind the bar, which every Company house keeps for this purpose and for no other, and will break the table. Four blows: a leg, a leg, the board across the middle, the head. He will not taste anything that falls from it. He will not look at the place cards.

11.6. If there are place cards, the Hand will not read them. If the Hand has read them, the Hand is to report it to the Factor, who will relieve him of duty at that post and move him on by the next cart, in the opposite direction from the one he was travelling. The Company does not inquire whose name was on the card. The Company has found that it does not need to.

11.7. The broken table is carried out to the yard and burned the same night, with salt, to ash. The ash is swept into the ditch on the outer side of the road. Not the inner side. Never the Hem side.

11.8. If a guest has already sat, the guest is not to be pulled from the chair. The Hand will not try. Those who have tried are entered in Section 13, Item 9. The table is not to be broken while a guest is at it. The guest is to be screened from the room with blankets, and fed nothing, and the room closed. The guest's account is to be settled from the guest's purse to the end of that day, and closed, and the guest entered in the ledger as departed. The guest will thank you. The Hand will not reply.

11.9. The Hand is reminded that the guest is happy, and that this is not the Hand's fault.

11.10. A Fast traveller in the house at the time of the appearance will know what to do better than any Hand, and the Hand should defer to them, and if necessary, to their axe.

SECTION 12. NIGHTS OF THE LICKED-CLEAN PLATE.

12.1. On the night of the new moon no guest leaves the common room after the last bell. Chamber-pots will be provided. The Hand will empty them in the morning without complaint.

12.2. A guest who insists on going out is to be let out, and the door barred behind him. He will be let in at dawn if he knocks in the right voice. The Hand on the door is the judge of whether the voice is right. The Company will support the Hand's judgement in every case, both ways.

12.3. The Hand on the door will not answer a knock twice. The first knock may be the guest. The second knock is not.

12.4. On Tablenight the gates close at dusk, the extra chair is set at every table, turned to face the wall, and nobody in the house says come in to anyone, for any reason, until dawn. This includes Hands to one another, sweethearts to sweethearts, and mothers to children. A child who must be brought in from the yard after dark on Tablenight is to be carried in, without a word, and the door shut behind with the heel.

SECTION 13. THE DISCIPLINARY SCHEDULE.

13.1. Offences against this Book are punished by the Factor at the post where they are discovered. The schedule below is the

Company's. The Bond is Oathen's, and the Bond does not consult the schedule.

(The schedule is printed as a table; see below.)

SECTION 14. OF THE HEAD OF THE TABLE, AND OF THE COMPANY'S PRINCIPAL.

(Removed. The stub of the page, where the blade has missed the gutter by a quarter-inch, shows the beginning of nine lines: 14.1. The Ch— / 14.2. Whe— / to whom the Comp— / in advance, and— / 14.4. The ledger is to be pre— / and every question an— / 14.6. If the dawn— / not to be ask— / until the wheel—. On the facing page, someone has pencilled, in a drover's hand: ask a Spoke what 14 is. go on. ask her.)

SECTION 15. OF LEAVING THE COMPANY.

15.1. A Hand may not leave the Company. The Bond was sworn as long as the wheel turns.

15.2. A Hand who dies on the road is carried to the next post and buried in the Company plot there, under a stone with the wheel on it, at the Company's expense. His ring stays on. Hands of Sallowreach who die in Sallowreach are carried to Fogmouth and over the Drop, at the Company's expense, and buried properly, by request, which they almost always make. Their families do not always thank us. We do not need to be thanked.

15.3. The question is often asked by new Hands what happens to the Bond when the wheel stops turning. Section 14 answers this question. You will be told it by your Factor when you have need of it.

The disciplinary schedule, as printed at Section 13 of the Ninth Revision:

ITEM	OFFENCE	PENALTY AT THE POST	NOTE IN THE MARGIN
1	Omitting the grace	1 lack	doubled if a Fast envoy is present
2	Asleep on the gate	3 days' wage; 3 nights on the wall	in the Vigil, the Watch's fine as well
3	Short count at the Night Count	a month's wage; demoted a post	if the count was short because a Hand miscounted on purpose, see 9
4	Opening a sealed cart	dismissal to the ranks; the Factor decides what else	there is nothing in the cart; there never was
5	Drunk at the gate	1 lack and the bucket	the bucket is the well-bucket, overhead, at dawn
6	Letting a guest take a bite of the house	the crumb, in lacks, a hundred-fold	10 lacks, then
7	Accepting a gratuity from a Closer	returned, with apology	the Hand to be watched for a week for cold in the fingers
8	Saying <i>come in</i> on Tablenight	a year's wage; moved to another quarter of the Rim	the Hand's room at that post is closed thereafter
9	Laying hands on a Seated guest	none; there is no Hand left to discipline	entered so the record is complete
10	Theft from the Company	none at the post	the Bond sees to it; the stair sees to the rest
11	Delaying a Seal courier	the Hand's own cost, at Oathen	the Company has buried Hands who stood in a sworn courier's road
12	Sitting in the Company's chair	not listed	the Ninth Revision removed this line; it used to say <i>see 14</i>



There is nothing in the cart. There never was. If anything in the cart says otherwise, enter it as livestock.

THE BOOK OF THE WHEEL, MARGINAL GLOSS ON SECTION 3.7, IN A WAYMASTER'S PENCIL

CARVER'S NOTES: THE BOOK OF THE WHEEL

The hook. A Guest who is a Bonded Hand already has a copy; a Guest who is not can buy one at Gristmoot and use it, with a Hard (14) Eye + Lore roll, to pass for a Hand at a Company post for a night. Copies older than 619 still have Section 14 in them, and are therefore worth a great deal to several people: the Wheel, which has been buying them up quietly for twenty years at 300 lacks each and burning them at Toll Nine; the Auditor-General, Lysander Coyle, who wants one for reasons of his own; and the Second Table, whose agents on the Rim have been told that Section 14 contains "the Company's terms of service to the thing that pays it." A drover's widow at Thimble Cross has an Eighth Revision copy in her late husband's sea-chest, and does not know what it is worth.

The rule. Following the Book exactly is good protection. A Guest working a Company house who has read the Book and follows Section 11 to the letter when a table appears gains +2 on every Caul + Resolve roll made against the table's pull for that night, and nobody in the house is lost to it unless they choose to sit. A Hand who breaks Section 11.6 (reads a place card) finds the name on it is their own, and from that night is followed down the Rim by tables, one every Plate, each a little closer to the road.

The secret: what Section 14 said. The full text, as printed in every revision up to the Eighth, is reproduced below for the Carver. It does not name anyone. It is the only document on the Table, outside the oldest carvings, that sets out a procedure for the eighth chair, and the Company swore it at Tacit in 61 A.G., before the Ring Charter, in the Company's first bond, the one the Ledger at Tacit records and nobody has read aloud in five hundred years. The Wheel cut it from the Ninth Revision in 619 because a Factor at Lampwick Halt followed it, one dawn when the count was higher by one, and was found sitting at the head of his table with the ledger open in front of him, smiling, every question in it answered in his own hand, and the last page blank except for the words *paid in full*.

SECTION 14. OF THE HEAD OF THE TABLE, AND OF THE COMPANY'S PRINCIPAL. (Eighth Revision, 588 A.G.; text as sworn at Tacit, 61 A.G., under the first bond of the seven houses.)

14.1. The Chair at the head of every table in every house of the Company is kept for the Company's Principal, who is the party to whom the Company is bound before all others, and on whose account the road was built.

14.2. Whether the Principal has come is known by the Night Count. When the count at dawn is higher than the count at dusk, the Principal has been in the house.

14.3. The Principal is not to be asked a name, nor charged, nor counted on the ledger, nor turned away. The Principal is to be served from the Company's chair as from any other, with the best the house has. The Principal's account has been paid in advance, and the Company is in the Principal's debt, and not the other way round.

14.4. The ledger of the house is to be presented to the Principal, open, if the Principal asks for it, and every question the Principal puts is to be answered truly, by the Factor, in writing, in the ledger.

14.5. The page of the ledger on which the higher count is written is to be burned at noon. This is not to hide it from the Principal. It is to hide it from everyone else.

14.6. If the dawn count is higher by more than one, the Factor is to set as many more places as the count requires, and is not to ask how many more will be needed, nor for how long.

14.7. Bonded Hands are reminded that the Bond is sworn as long as the wheel turns. When the wheel stops turning, the road is the Principal's, and every house on it, and everything carried on it, and every Hand.

14.8. The Company will know that the wheel has stopped turning when the Principal sits in the Chair.

14.9. Until then, keep the place laid.



Ask a Spoke what fourteen is. Go on. Ask her.

PENCILLED IN A SECONDHAND COPY OF THE BOOK OF THE WHEEL, GRISTMOOT, PRICE TWO LACKS

▼ WICK TALLOW'S CATALOGUE



Steady light, sixth bell light, light that will not leave you!

— THE CHANDLERS' CRY ON WICK LANE, LASTGATE

What it is. *Tallow's of Wick Lane: A Catalogue of Lights, With Prices, For the Carving and Lack of 641.* Sixteen pages of coarse reed-paper, stitched with waxed thread, printed by an Heirs' press in the drying-loft over Saul Brindle's tannery (Wick pays in candles), and handed out free at the shop door and at the Rim Market at Gristmoot, where Wick's man keeps a stall each season for the Vigil trade. The cover is a woodcut of the shop sign, a candle with a face. The paper is greasy at the edges, because every copy has been handled by someone who works with fat, and every copy smells, faintly and permanently, of the Lane: hot tallow, lye, singed hair.

Where it is found. Everywhere in Lastgate; in the Lofts, where the Wardens order by the gross; in the Vigil, where Lamplighters' agents mark it up and pass it round; folded in Rim Road saddlebags as far as Mumchance. Free. A copy carries no Taint. The candles do: a common Tallow candle is **Taint Dread 1**; a named candle is **Dread 2**; a few of the stock below are worse, and the Carver's notes say which.

TALLOW'S OF WICK LANE. ESTABLISHED 551.
CHANDLERS TO THE LOFTS, THE HALL OF HANDS,
THE SINKS AND THE VIGIL TRADE. LIGHTS THAT DO
NOT GUTTER.

TO OUR CUSTOMERS.

Friends, here is the new list. The prices are up a crumb or two on last Lack, because the Court has started charging me for the Jar Room ends, which it used to give away, and because the Vigil cannot get enough of us, and when the Vigil cannot get enough of a thing the Lamplighters' men turn up on the Lane with a cart and buy the shop bare by noon. I will not have my neighbours going dark for the sake of a city that will not shut its eyes. So the Vigil price is the Vigil price, and the Lane price is the Lane price, and if a Vigil man tries to buy at the Lane price, my boy will know him by his eyes.

Everything on this list is made in my own vats from my own stock and lit from my own coal, which has been burning since the year 551 and has lit every candle I ever sold. Every candle is rendered three times, strained through linen, poured round a wick of Brinemoss reed-pith, and cooled slow in the cellar so it will not crack. They give a steady yellow light that does not gutter, smoke or spit, and they lean, a little, toward whoever lit them. That is not a draught. It is a selling point.

You will hear them. I will not pretend you won't. Most say nothing anyone could make out. Some say one thing, over and over, the way the Lofts do. I have written down, beside each one on the list, what it says, as best I and my journeymen can make out, so that you can choose. A customer who knows what a candle says will not bring it back.

— W. Tallow, Wick Lane, at the sign of the face.

I. COMMON LIGHTS. UNCLAIMED STOCK, BY THE CANDLE OR THE BOX.

From the Sump-sacks, the Court's unclaimed, and the Guild's leavings. I do not know their names. Nobody does. That is what unclaimed means.

NO. 1. PLAIN SIXTH-BELL. *A hand-length taper, yellow. Burns three nights. Says: nothing you could swear to; a sort of humming. 6 crumbs; 5 lacks the box of a hundred.*

NO. 2. LONG READER. *Thick, for students and clerks of the Upper Boards; doubled wick. Burns six nights. Says: one more page. Very popular with the Court's copyists. 1 lack.*

NO. 3. SINKS STUB. *Offcuts and the bottoms of vats, pressed together. Burns two nights, a little blue at the edge. Says: several things at once, none of them to you. Not for nurseries. 3 crumbs.*

NO. 4. LOFT BOX. *As supplied to the Wardens of the Lofts, a gross at a time; squat, so they will not tip on the ladders. Burns four nights. Says: read to me. The shelved like them; they say they keep each other company. 7 lacks the gross.*

NO. 5. WEIR LANTERN CANDLE. *Short and fat, for a shuttered tin on the eel-traps. Burns a week in the wet. Says: is it cold out there. The weir-men say it is kind company at the fourth bell. 9 crumbs.*

NO. 6. THE BLACK NOON. *Wick dipped in fen-pitch; a smoky flame that flies will not cross. For fly-fronts. Burns one night. Says: a sound like someone swatting, and then sorry. 1 lack.*

NO. 7. DOOR-CANDLE. *For the window by the door, at the Court's door-duty. Burns a night exactly; out at first bell. Says: who's there. Every house on the Boards burns one. Half the city goes to bed to the sound of its own windows asking who is there. 4 crumbs (and a crumb to the Court, which is not my doing).*

II. JAR ROOM ENDS. COURT STOCK.

The rendered remains of the Court's long-sentenced, from the Jar Room, when a jar has been sat on the shelf so long there is nothing left in it that will answer to a name. The Court sold me these free until this year. They are hard candles, white, very bright. Some customers prefer them. They are bright because they are angry.

NO. 8. PENITENT. *Tall, white, dead straight. Burns five nights. Says: I didn't, I didn't, I didn't. They all say that, the Court's clerk tells me. 2 lacks.*

NO. 9. FEN MURDERER. *From a man jarred in 402 for killing his brother in a punt with a pole. Burns nine nights and*

is the brightest thing I sell. Says: the brother's name, and get up, get up. Leans hard. Reading by it you will feel you are being read. 4 lacks.

NO. 10. HEIR OF 288. One of a batch from the War of the Heirs, a young man who killed his father nineteen times; the father kept coming back to his desk; the son was jarred. Burns four nights. Says: stay down. Bought mostly by the Heirs, who light it at their meetings for luck. 3 lacks.

NO. 11. THE FORGER. A clerk jarred for forging Closing licenses. Burns three nights. Says: a very soft scratching, like a nib. Two customers have told me it writes. I have not seen it. 2 lacks.

III. NAMED LIGHTS. FAMILY STOCK, ALREADY POURED.

Families who commission a named candle sometimes find, afterward, that they cannot bear to burn it, or that they owe me for the pouring and cannot pay, or that there are a great many more candles in a grandmother than anyone expects. These are from such families, sold on with their permission or their debt. I give the first name only. A name is a thing you should have to come in and ask for.

NO. 12. IDE. A grandmother of Weir Row, a hundred and eighty years Kept, sold by the family to pay for a great-uncle's restitching. Burns a week. Says: you have cold hands, girl. Very fond of children; leans toward them across a room. 5 lacks.

NO. 13. FENWICK. A carpenter of the Landing. Burns five nights. Says: measure twice. A customer of the Boards reads her household accounts by him and says she has never made a mistake since. 5 lacks.

NO. 14. ALDOUS AND MERRIT. Husband and wife, poured into one candle at their request, two wicks. Burns a week; the flames lean toward each other and will not stand up straight. Says: both talking at once, quarrelling, it sounds like, for six nights, and on the seventh night, before the end, silent. 9 lacks.

NO. 15. THE SMALL. A child of the undercity, two hundred years seven, from one of the Drowned Storeys; given to me by Queen Nell's own runners, who said she asked to be light. One candle only. Burns three nights. Says: a counting game. One for the lamp and two for the wick. I will not sell her to anyone who laughs at the price. 5 lacks.

NO. 16. JOSSE. An uncle, gone Ripe, beyond stitching. Burns four nights, smokes a little, cannot be helped. Says: is it a feast day yet. 4 lacks, reduced.

NO. 17. MOTHER. That is all the family would give me. Thirty candles, one Mother. Burns three nights each. Says: where are you going. Sold singly or the lot. The family asks that the lot not go to one house. 5 lacks each; 120 the lot.

IV. SPECIALTIES.

NO. 18. WEDDING PAIR. Two thin white tapers from one source, twisted together. Lit at the betrothal supper and pinched out at the vow, then kept. Burn: one hour, every anniversary, for as long as the marriage lasts. In Sallowreach that is long. Say: I do, I do, I do, softer each year. 3 lacks the pair.

NO. 19. QUEASE TAPER. Made to the order of Dr. Halloran Quease, of a stock he selects, for his studies. Burns two nights. Says: precisely where it hurts, in detail, and the doctor writes it down. Not for general sale; listed because people ask. Price on application to the doctor.

NO. 20. THE LONG WATCH. For the Vigil trade. Rendered four times, the hardest tallow I can make, a wrist thick. Burns a month and does not shorten, which I cannot explain and do not try to. Says: don't close your eyes, don't close your eyes. The Lamplighters buy every one. Lane price 2 lacks; Vigil price 9.

NO. 21. NUDGER'S CANDLE. For the Vigil trade. Small, with a pin pressed into the side at the half-burn. Says: pinch me. When the flame reaches the pin, the pin falls, hot, wherever the candle has been set, which is meant to be the back of your hand. 6 crumbs Lane, 2 lacks Vigil.

NO. 22. HUSH-EDGE CANDLE. For the Finishers, who walk into the silences with lights. Plain, steady. Burns until it crosses the edge of a Hush, and then it is not burning, and has never been burning, and is not even warm. Says: thank you on the way in. Sister Lorn's people buy them by the box and I let them have the loft free. 1 lack.

NO. 23. SEAMER'S LAMP-WICK. Tallow-dipped wick by the yard, for the Guild's lamps. Says: little things, threadlike, in and out, in and out. The Guild buys it because a seamer working by it never misses a stitch. 2 crumbs the yard.

NO. 24. FERRY CANDLE. For Tam Ruddock's clients waiting in the back room at the Long Farewell. Made from the unclaimed foreign dead, the ones who came across the Drop to not die and then did, eventually, of what they had. Burns two nights. Says: things in other dialects. Tam asks for them. I think it helps his clients to hear someone from home. 8 crumbs.

V. COMMISSIONS.

YOUR OWN. A named candle of your own dead, from your own family, rendered in my own vat, alone, never mixed. You bring them to the back door on Tanner's Boards before the first bell, wrapped, labelled, with the release signed by the eldest Kept of the house. My journeymen do the rest. They are gentle. You may wait in the front shop. You may not wait in the back. You collect in nine days: forty to sixty candles from an adult, depending, and a cedar box. The candle-blessing is yours to arrange. 50 lacks.

YOURSELF. A customer of the Upper Boards asked me last Plenty whether I would take her before she was finished, while she was still Kept, so that she could be the light her grandchildren read by, rather than a woman on a shelf they visit on feast days. I said I would think about it. I have thought about it. I will, for those who ask in writing, before witnesses, with the eldest of the house consenting. The vat is hot. It is very quick, and very slow, and then it is over, and then it is not over. My wife Bess asked me the same thing, in 618, and I did it myself, and I burn one of her each Tablenight, and she is the steadiest light I have ever made. 50 lacks, the same. I do not charge more for a willing customer.

VI. TERMS.

No returns on any candle that has been lit.

No returns on any candle that has not been lit but has been heard, because once you have heard it you will always hear it, and there is nothing I can do about that.

Candles that run in the heat and stand up are not to be brought back to the shop. Send a boy for me. Do not let it out of the room, and do not let it near the stove, and do not let anyone in the house call it by any name. I will come with the cold-barrel and the hook.

Candles are not to be lit in a Hush, on Tablenight by anyone not of the family, or within a bowshot of the Ferrying Post at the midnight bell, for a reason I cannot give, as I do not know it, but my journeymen will not go near the Post at midnight with a lit candle and I have stopped asking them to.

Snapped candles burn as two. Both halves lean the same way. Both halves say the same thing, out of time with each other, which is worse. Do not snap your candles.

Steady light. Sixth bell light. Light that will not leave you.



Snapped candles burn as two. Both halves lean the same way. Both halves say the same thing, out of time with each other, which is worse.

TALLOW'S CATALOGUE, TERMS

DIO	WHAT THE CANDLE BY THE BED SAYS TONIGHT (FOR ANY TALLOW LIGHT, UNNAMED)
1	<i>Turn the page.</i> It says it a breath before you do, every time.
2	Your mother's pet name for you. You never told anyone in Lastgate what it was.
3	<i>It's warm in here. Is it warm in here.</i> Then, slowly, as the night goes on: <i>it's too warm.</i>
4	A bell-count, one to six, over and over, like a child learning. It stops at five once. Something in the house stops with it.
5	Nothing at all. It is the only silent candle you have ever owned. In the morning the wick has been pinched out from the inside.
6	<i>Don't let them put me in the Sump.</i> The flame leans toward the window, toward the deep fen, and stays there.
7	The name of someone in the house, and <i>I know what you did.</i> It is not talking to you. It is talking to the person behind you.
8	A tune. Every Kept in the house hums along before they know they are doing it.
9	<i>Eight.</i> Then it counts down, slowly, to one. Then it folds, and goes out.
10	Your own voice, saying the last thing you said before you lit it.

CARVER'S NOTES: TALLOW'S CATALOGUE

The hooks. The catalogue is a shopping list for the Guests and a map of Lastgate's quieter griefs. *No. 17, Mother:* thirty candles, sold singly to thirty houses, each of which now hears *where are you going* from its window, and the family that sold her would like her collected again, every candle, before the last one burns down; three are already in the Vigil. *No. 9, the Fen Murderer:* a buyer on the Upper Boards has died, properly died, in a house where no one is supposed to be able to, with his chair pulled up close to the candle and his book open; the candle was saying *get up* and he did not. *Commissions, Yourself:* a Kept Guest, or a Kept companion, may find a relative has written to Wick Lane on their behalf.

The rules. A Tallow light used to read, work or watch by gives +1 to Eye rolls made by its light for long tasks, because it does not gutter and it does not let you stop. *No. 2, Long Reader* raises that to +2 and its user cannot willingly end the task before the candle is out (Caul + Resolve, Hard 14, to put it down). *No. 21, Nudger's Candle* lets a Vigil Guest pass one Weariness check automatically per candle. *No. 22, Husb-Edge* is the only light that will tell you, by going out and never having been lit, exactly where a Hush begins; it is Taint Dread 2. *No. 9* and *No. 19* are Taint Dread 3. A candle that runs and stands is a **Tallow-Saint**: treat it as a man-sized Kept thing of soft warm fat (Threat 3 · Flesh 14 · Guard 9 · Attack +4, smothering 2, and the victim catches light · Armor 0 · Dread 3) that wants only to be lit, and to be called by its name, and does not know it no longer has one.

The secret. Wick has been honest in every line of this catalogue but one. The Sinks Stub, *No. 3*, is made of offcuts and vat-bottoms, and the vat-bottoms have not been strained since Lack 640, because what is in the bottom of the vats has started to move toward the north side of the copper at midnight and Wick's journeymen no longer like to put their arms in. Every Sinks Stub sold since then has a little of everything in it, and every one of them, at the midnight bell, leans for one minute toward the Ferrying Post. The Sinks are full of them. On the night a Guest happens to be on the Post at midnight, they will see a thousand little lights in the low windows of the undercity all leaning at them at once, and hear, on the fen wind, a thousand very small voices saying, together, the same short word Bed One said in the Vigil, which none of them can pronounce.

The worthless gift. *No. 12, Ide*, was sold by her great-granddaughter to pay for an uncle's restitching. The uncle is Josse, *No. 16*: he went Ripe anyway, the restitching failed in a month, and he was sold to Wick too, at a reduced price. The family has two candles in the window now and a debt to the Guild still owing. They light both on feast days. The two candles lean toward each other and argue.

▼ THE WEIGHING ALMANAC



Plant at the Plate's waxing, reap at its full, and never be the last in the row at dusk.

— THE ALMANAC'S MOTTO, PRINTED UNDER THE TITLE SINCE 503 A.G.

What it is. *Garbel's Weighing Almanac for the Year 642 A.G., Being the Six Hundred and Forty-Second Year of Plenty: Containing the Calendar of the Fields, the Plate's Changes, the Reckoning of the Reaping by District, the Weights of the Board, Receipts for the Hungry Month, Weather-Signs, Sayings, and Notices.* Thirty-two pages, octavo, printed every Carving at Registry Close in Sated by the house of Garbel and Daughters under licence of the Board, and sold for 3 crumbs at every mill, cookshop and Bailiff's post in the south. The paper is cheap and soaks up grease beautifully; most copies hang on a nail by the stove and are read to tatters by the Lack. It is the one book in nearly every Fatland house, and in many the only one.

Where it is found. Everywhere south of the Chute; in Company houses on the southern stretch; and, lately, in the north, where the Long Count has made its Reaping tables the most-read pages of any book on the Table outside the Lofts. The Board licenses it, reads it in proof, and has twice tried to have the Reckoning removed. It sold out both years. No Taint, but a reader who finds their own village's odds and their own household's weight makes a Dread 1 check, and Fatland readers make it at Dread 2 in Carving.

TO THE READER.

Here is the Almanac again, friend, as it has been since my great-grandmother's day. You will find in it what you always find: when to plough and when to sow, what the Plate is doing, how heavy the Board is, and how to feed a family through the hungry month on less than you'd like. You will also find the Reckoning, which some of you have written to say you would rather not, and others have written to say is the only reason you buy us. I print it because it is true, and because a thing printed in an almanac is a thing you can plan around, like frost. My mother printed it. Her mother printed it under the title Wolf-Odds, which the Board preferred. I have dropped the wolves. The Board has noted this.

Eat well. Lack keep away. And when the light goes red in Carving, come in from the field.

— Mistress Hennet Garbel, Registry Close, Carving 641.

THE CALENDAR OF THE FIELDS.

GRACE. *The Weighing falls on the third day of the Grace Plate; Board Members are asked to fast from the night before for an honest scale, and none ever has. First Furrow on the first fair morning after: the heaviest man in the village pulls the plough and the furrow is fed a loaf, butter side down. Sow the toothed wheat at the Plate's waxing, roots at its waning. Prune the Orchards in the second week, with wax in your ears. Lucky days: the 4th, the 9th, the 15th. Unlucky: any day the soil is warmer than your hand at dawn; sow nothing, it is already full.*

PLENTY. *Second sowing; first cut of hay; cherries from the Bleeding Orchards, which must be stoned at once, before they set their own stones. The fields sweat in the last week. Sweating Night falls when the drip-pans fill without rain; carry the bedding out, sleep on the warm ground, and count your children at dawn, by touching, not by looking. Lucky days: the 2nd, the 11th. Unlucky: the day the Belch first blows; do not marry, butcher, or sign anything with a Union man.*

CARVING. *Harvest. The Plate is full on the 14th of Carving this year and the Almanac's counsel is that no one under three hundred pounds be in the far rows after the red light from the 10th to the 18th. Marbling Morning, the first frost, is expected in the third week; a white vein running east-west across your own yard means a gain in the house, north-south a loss. Harvest Home after the Lists are read. Lucky days: none we will print. Unlucky: the Lists.*

LACK. *Slaughter, salting, the barrels down the Chute. Feed the hills. Tablenight on the longest night; the national fast begins at sundown on the eve. The Almanac wishes every village luck with it, and prints on page 26, as always, the receipts for breaking it gracefully, since you will. Lucky days: the first three of the Plate, when the fat is hardest. Unlucky: Tablenight, for reasons it is not the Almanac's business to discuss.*

THE REAPING NOTICES.

(Being the Almanac's Reckoning of the Reaping for the coming Carving, by district, worked from last year's Lists, the Board's published Returns, and the Long Count, which the Almanac

thanks. Odds are given as one in so many souls of the district who will go out to the field at dusk and not come in. They are a reckoning, not a sentence. Plan accordingly. See the table.)

NOTICE OF BRAWNMOUTH. The Almanac has been asked by the Deacon's widow of Brawnmouth to print the following, and does so as an advertisement, paid. In the Grace of 641, at the advice of the Dowager Hill of Brawnmouth, that the field would be easier on the village if it were given the best of us early, the village gave Deacon Amos Pruett, our heaviest and best, three hundred and eighty pounds, of his own will, to the

Long Strip at First Furrow, with music. He went down singing. The village was promised a gentler Carving. The village has this year lost twenty-two, which is two more than the year before. The widow asks that other villages being offered the same counsel by their hills should know this. She asks nothing else. The Almanac's Reckoning for Brawnmouth is unchanged by the gift, and is printed below at the same odds it would have been.

The Reckoning of the Reaping, as printed (one Carving's odds, by district):

DISTRICT	LOST, CARVING 641	ODDS, CARVING 642	THE ALMANAC'S COUNSEL
Low Tilth (Kettle Furrow)	31 of 175	1 in 5	Go in with the light. All of you.
Low Tilth (Bramble Furrow)	27 of 160	1 in 6	Bell the far rows. Keep the dogs in; they go too.
Hask's End	9 of 61	1 in 6	The hill keeps her bargain. Ask what it was.
Brawnmouth	22 of 230	1 in 10	See the Notice. Unchanged.
Dimble	7 of 88	1 in 12	First Furrow there is not our affair.
Sapwell (Orchards)	40 of 1,100	1 in 26	Trees take fewer. Trees take slower.
Barrelside (the Chute)	18 of 2,400	1 in 130	The yards are paved. Mind the stockpens at dusk.
Sated (the Fold)	3 of 9,000	1 in 3,000	The great are heavy; the field prefers its own weight.
Sated (the Leanings)	211 of 22,000	1 in 100	The thin wards. Weigh well.
The Dusk Acres	not printed	not printed	By order of the Board.

THE WEIGHTS OF THE BOARD. As taken at the Weighing of Grace 641, on the Great Scales, before the Board in full, attested by the Weigher, Mr. G. Tripe, whose scales are true. One vote for every hundred pounds; fractions are not counted. Changes against the Weighing of 640.

(The Almanac prints the twelve heaviest Members. The full roll of a hundred and ninety-six may be had from Registry Close for 2 lacks, or read for nothing on the Weighhouse door.)

MEMBER	SEAT	WEIGHT (LB)	VOTES	CHANGE
Chairman Obb Tullow	the Chair	1,900 (on the dray)	19	none recorded; see note
Lard Gammon	the Fold	1,310	13	+40
Dame Suet Marrable	Marrable Hall	1,240	12	+65; the Dinner continues
Dame Hessaly Gorringe	Gorringe Down	1,180	11	rooted at the Weighing; weighed in situ
Madam Gorrel Fenn	the Fold	1,100	11	abed; weighed by sling
Granary-Master Tobin Sile	Sile's Granary, Sated	990	9	+110; much congratulated
Mistress Brisket Annalow	for the Union	510	5	the Union disputes the scale
Deacon Prosper Hessop	Hessop's Rise	880	8	the Hessops send a new Deacon each year; all weigh 880
Cullmaster-General Varn Sweetbread	ex officio	720	7	-30; <i>unwell</i> , says the Board
Deacon Cobb Lardner	Low Tilth	640	6	-50; resigned his seat, Lack
Deacon Amos Pruett	Brawnmouth	—	—	given to the field; seat vacant
Dowager of Marrable (Hill)	by inheritance	not weighed	40	votes by proxy, through the turf

NOTE ON THE CHAIRMAN'S WEIGHT. *The Weigher records the Chairman, as for the last three Weighings, at nineteen hundred pounds, being the weight of the Chairman at the last Weighing at which the Chairman could be lifted from the dray. The question whether the Chairman's roots, and the soil, cellar-flooring and foundation-stone of the Weighhouse to which the roots now adhere, ought in fairness to be weighed with him, was put to the Board by the Deacon for Low Tilth, who estimated the whole at thirty thousand pounds, or three hundred votes, which would give the Chairman the Board outright. The Board declined, by weight, to consider the question. The Deacon for Low Tilth has since resigned and gone home to Kettle Furrow, where we understand he is helping with the Count.*

RECEIPTS FOR THE HUNGRY MONTH.

Every month is hungry in the south, friend; we know. But the Lack Plate before Tablenight is the hungriest, when the fat is all in the barrels and the barrels are all down the Chute, and the Feasting Laws still want five plates a day off you, and the Bailiff is still coming round. These receipts are cheap, filling, and good for a crowd, and each will go round a family five times if you are clever. None of them has any meat in it of which you need wonder where it came from. The Almanac thinks that you should have, once in a while, a meal you need not think about.

BARLEY AND ONION BROTH. *Take a cupful of pearl barley and wash it well. Cut three onions and two carrots small and soften them in a spoonful of good dripping or butter in your pot, slowly, till the onions are gold. Add the barley, a bay leaf, a pinch of thyme, and eight cupfuls of water or any stock, and a good pinch of salt. Simmer with the lid half on for an hour, stirring now and then, till the barley is soft and the broth thick. Add a handful of chopped greens or a turnip, cut fine, in the last quarter hour. Pepper it. Serve it with bread. It is better the next day, and better still the day after, and so lasts for three of your five meals, which is the point.*

PEASE PUDDING. *Soak a pound of yellow split peas overnight in cold water. Drain. Put them in a pot with an onion, cut in half, a bay leaf, and water to cover by a finger's width, and simmer gently for an hour and a half, skimming, till very soft and nearly all the water is gone; add a little more if it catches. Take out the onion and bay. Beat in a knob of butter, salt and plenty of pepper, and, if you have one, an egg, beaten. Spoon it into a buttered basin, cover it with a cloth, and steam it for an hour in a pan of simmering water, or bake it in a slow oven. Turn it out. Eat it hot in slices, or cold with bread. A pudding of a pound will feed six twice.*

OATCAKES ON THE GRIDDLE. *Mix two cupfuls of fine oatmeal with half a teaspoon of salt and a pinch of soda. Melt a spoonful of dripping or butter in half a cupful of hot water and stir it in to make a stiff dough. Turn it out onto a board dusted with oatmeal, press it flat with your knuckles and roll it as thin as you dare. Cut it into wedges and bake it on a hot dry griddle or in a pan, a few minutes a side, till the edges curl and the cakes are crisp. Cool them on a rack. They keep a week in a tin, which in a Fatland house they will not be asked to do.*

BAKED APPLES FOR TABLENIGHT EVE. *Core as many apples as you have mouths, without cutting through the bottom. Fill each with a spoon of oats, a spoon of brown sugar or honey, a few raisins and a little butter, and a pinch of cinnamon if you are rich. Stand them in a dish with a finger of water and bake in a moderate oven for three quarters of an hour, till soft and splitting. These are the last thing to eat before the fast begins at sundown, and the first thing to eat when it ends, which is usually about an hour later.*

WEATHER-SIGNS AND SAYINGS.

When the drip leaves a skin you can lift with a spoon, the Belch is three days off.

Red sky at evening, the field is eating; red sky at morning, it has eaten.

If the ground rises under your palm at dawn and falls at dusk, all's well. If it rises at dusk, keep the children in.

When the scarecrow faces the village, the frost is early.

A Marbling that runs to your door is a gift. A Marbling that runs from your door is a bill.

Wheat that whispers is ripe. Wheat that hushes is hungry. Wheat that turns its heads when you pass is neither, and you should keep walking, and not look back to see if it is still turned.

A fat man casts a short shadow at dusk. The Almanac has nothing more to say about that, and neither should you.



Wheat that whispers is ripe. Wheat that hushes is hungry. Wheat that turns its heads when you pass is neither, and you should keep walking.

THE WEIGHING ALMANAC, WEATHER-SIGNS

CARVER'S NOTES: THE WEIGHING ALMANAC

The hooks. The Reckoning is the most dangerous table in the south, because it is accurate, and nobody knows where Hennet Garbel gets the figures for districts the Long Count does not reach. She gets them from the Board's own cellar Returns, through the Chairman's Washer, the same channel that sends the Inner Committee's minutes to Kettle Furrow folded in a shoe; the Board suspects a leak at Registry Close and the Cullmasters have been told to find it before the 642 edition is set. The Guests may be hired to protect the press, to find the leak, or to deliver the proofs. Separately, the *Dusk Acres*, *not printed* line has a twin in Hennet's locked drawer: the odds there are given as *one in one*.

The rules. A Guest who plans a journey through the south using the Calendar and the Reckoning, and keeps to the Almanac's counsel, may reduce any one Reaping scene that season by one step of danger: the field's pull is Routine (10) rather than Hard (14) for one roll. A Guest who ignores the counsel on an unlucky day the Almanac names raises it to Grim (18). The Weight Chart is a Clause and Persuade tool: knowing a Member's weight and change gives +2 to bargain with or about that Member at the Weighhouse, because in Sated a man's gains and losses are his politics.

The secrets. The Hessops' new Deacon each year weighs exactly 880 pounds because it is not a new Deacon. Deacon Cobb Lardner resigned because he did the Chairman's arithmetic aloud. Cullmaster-General Sweetbread lost thirty pounds because he has stopped being able to eat at the Board's table since he read the cellar figures for the Dusk Acres, which are his own figures, and saw that the dusk-shift no longer lowers the general Reaping at all. The Cullmasters' whole justification is that the field can be steered with the poor, so the rest are spared; it cannot, and the Inner Committee knows it can no longer be minuted otherwise. Brawnmouth's gift was worthless, and so is every other dusk-shift.

Real recipes. The four receipts are ordinary, safe kitchen recipes and work as written.

▼ THE GLOVEMAKER'S LEDGER



*Never shake her hand, love. Never laugh near her. And never ask her what she's thinking.
She'll tell you.*

— A CEDAR-WARDEN OF HAND STREET

What it is. A tall narrow account-book bound in black kid, the binding soft and cold to the touch, kept for forty years by the glovers Stave of Needle Street, Lastgate: by Josias Stave from 602 to 619, and by his daughter Merrit from 619 to this day. It records one account only. Every pair of gloves made for Lady Corrow Vane, the

Left Hand of the Court, since the year her fingers went grey, is entered by number, with its pattern, its leather, the date it went to Glovehall, the date it came back, why it was replaced, and what it touched while she wore it, as far as the glovers could learn or tell from the leather. There are four hundred and seventy-one pairs.

The ledger is the only record anywhere of the inside of Corrow Vane's life.

Where it is. In the locked press at the back of the Staves' shop, beside the cedar drawers in which Merrit keeps every returned pair, because she has never been able to decide whom it would be safe to sell them to. **Taint Dread 2** to read; Dread 3 to open the drawers. The returned gloves are cold, and keep the shape of the hand that left them. A returned pair worn for a day is **Taint 2 Regrowth (Ossel)**.

ACCOUNT OF THE LADY CORROW VANE OF GLOVEHALL, HAND-LINE, IN GLOVES. Opened by Josias Stave, glover, of the sign of the Open Hand, Needle Street, in the Grace of 602.

On the leather. My lady's hands are cold enough to sting through ordinary kid, and ordinary kid, which in this country is from beasts that do not finish, feels them. I learned this with the first pair. I cut them from good fen-goat, Kept stock, the softest skin on the Boards, and when I fitted them to her, the leather flinched. It tightened on her hand of itself like a face screwing up its eyes, and on the second day the gloves were found on the floor of her chamber, having crawled off her in the night. So there is only one leather that will hold her. It must be finished leather. My lady comes to my yard on the first of each month, and I bring out the kid, and her Glovebearer unpicks her stitches, and she lays her bare hand on the kid's brow, and it lies down. Then I flay it, and cure it in alum and egg, and cut it to her pattern, and the leather does not mind her, because it is past minding. Neighbours come to the yard gate on the first of the month to watch her hand. I let them. It is the only time anyone sees it.

Pair 1. Grace 602. Black kid, finished. Pattern: three joints to the finger, as for any lady. Returned in Plenty. Replaced because: the fingers had grown. Touched: her mother's Closing-desk; the oath-book of the Court; her husband's sleeve, at table, once (he wrote to tell me, as a joke; he is a kind man).

Pair 4. Lack 602. Replaced because: split at the right forefinger, from the inside, as if the finger had tried to come out. Touched: nothing of note. She has been told by the Court not to touch anything of note until she is licensed.

Pair 9. Carving 603. Her first Closing. Replaced because: she asked. Touched: a Kept fisherman of the Glad Century, aged three hundred and four, who had asked for it for two hundred years. She told me, when she came for the new pair, that he said "oh" when it happened, as though he had remembered where he left something. The returned right glove had a smell of river on it that would not wash out. I have it still.

Pair 31. Lack 605. Pattern widened at the palm, the wrist let out, for the lying-in. Touched: the swaddling of her son Teodor, at arm's length, as she gave him to the nurse. Only the swaddling. The nurse told my wife that my lady held the bundle out with both hands straight in front of her, like a woman holding a pot too hot for her, and when the nurse took it she sat down on the floor. Replaced because: the left glove was found in the cot. Nobody would say how it got there. The child was well. I made a new pair and charged nothing.

Pair 92. Grace 610. Replaced because: the right forefinger and middle finger would not open. Touched: the face of the Regent, Ansel Grue, at his own request, in his own office, with nobody else present. When the pair came back the two fingers were bent in, hard, cold as iron, closed on nothing, as if gripping something the size of a walnut. I could not straighten them with the stretchers. I could not cut them with my best shears. I put them in a box and the box is in the press and the fingers are still closed. Sometimes in damp weather the box is heavier.

Pair 117. Plenty 612. Pattern lengthened: a fourth joint to every finger. I cut it the way I was taught to cut a child's glove, with room. Touched: four hundred clients this year, by her count. She brings her little black book to the fitting and reads me the numbers while I measure.

Pair 186. Carving 617. Replaced because: the stitches. The Glovebearer then, Old Halse, had begun to sew too tight, from fear; the wrists came back with the silk sunk into the skin and the leather gone white around it. Touched: Old Halse. She did not mean it. He was unpicking the left wrist and his thumb slipped inside the glove against her palm. He was living. He fell where he stood and rose an hour later Kept, and asked to go on working, and did, and sewed better, without fear, because he had nothing left to fear from her. He sewed until 634. I make his gloves now too.

Pair 199. Grace 618. Black kid, finished, with nine stitches of black silk at the wrist, the Court's pattern for the Left Hand. Her investiture. Touched: the Regent's ring, which she kissed through the glove, and the nine Closers of the Court, each on the brow, each through the glove, so that they would know what it was to be held by her and not finished. Two of them wept. The pair came back with the fingertips frosted, in Plenty, in a warm room.

Pair 211. Lack 619. My last pattern. My hands are no good. I am giving the bench to Merrit, who cuts better than I did at her age, and I am going to ask my lady a thing I should not ask.

Pair 212. Lack 619. (in a different hand from here on) Pattern as 211, cut by me, Merrit Stave. Touched: my father. He asked

her at the fitting, and she said nothing, and her Glovebearer looked at the door, and she looked at my father's hands, which were swollen like plums with forty years of the shears, and she said, "Mr. Stave, there is no license." He said he knew. She took off the right glove herself, which she never does. She laid her hand on his brow the way she lays it on the kid, and he said "thank you," and lay down on the yard stones, and that was all. We are not to speak of it. I am writing it here because this is his book, and he would want the account kept, and because it was the kindest thing anyone in this city has ever done for us, and it is a crime.

Pair 240. Plenty 622. Replaced because: the water. Touched: the moat at Glovehall, to the shoulders, and her husband in it. Lord Merriman went into the moat in the night and she found him at dawn under the weed and went in after him, gloved, and brought him up by the hair. He was Kept by then, of course. She had her hands on him all the way to the bank. The gloves came back full of green water that I could not pour out, as though they were still cupping it, and when I left them on the sill overnight the water was still there in the morning, and warm. Lord Merriman is in the south wing. He declines to be closed. He sent me a note thanking me for the gloves. He says they were the first time she had held him in twenty years, and he would rather keep that than be finished.

Pair 301. Carving 628. Replaced because: split at every seam at once. Touched: a Weir Row family who laughed. The old man was to be closed on Tablenight and wanted to go out laughing, and the house laughed with him, and my lady stood in the middle of it with her hands clenched, and the gloves gave at all ten seams like a burst sausage. She finished him. The family are still laughing about it, I am told. She cannot pass Weir Row.

Pair 344. Grace 633. Touched: the lead mittens of her brother Osric, through the hatch in his door, at the padlock. That is all of him she touches. She asked me if I could make a glove for him. I said that I could make a glove for any hand. She said, "Could you make one that he could not take off?" I said I was not sure that I could make one he could not see through. She said, "No. Of course."

Pair 371. Carving 635. New Glovebearer, Miss Prudence Lisk, a living girl, careful. Replaced because: wet inside. Miss Lisk brings them back herself and does not look at me. They are wet every month now. It is not water. It is salt.

Pair 402. Lack 637. Pattern lengthened again: a fifth joint. The fingers are as long as my forearm from wrist to elbow. When I measure her she lays her hand flat on my bench and I can hear the knuckles settle one after another like beads on a

counting-frame. Touched: nine thousand and some clients since Pair 9, by her little black book, which she reads to me while I measure. And a christening cap in a glass case, the glass only, never the cap. The glove came back with a little round frost-mark on each fingertip, as though she had pressed the glass, hard, for a long time.

Pair 446. Carving 639. Touched: the face of a living rebel in a back room of the Hall, by order, without license, without consent. Replaced because: she brought them to me herself and put them in my hands and said, "Burn these, Miss Stave." I did not burn them. They are in the press. I do not know why I disobeyed her. I think I wanted someone to have to remember him.

Pair 459. Lack 640. Replaced because: silent. The leather of the fingertips, when I bent them, made no sound. Kid creaks. All leather creaks. These did not, in the last inch of every finger, and when I held the glove to my ear and rubbed it there was a place at the very tip where my own fingers made no sound against it either. A little silence in the leather the size of a pea. I have put them in a lead box. My lady's estate has a Hush in the orchard now. I know what this is. I have not said.

Pair 470. Plenty 641. Touched: a pear. That is all she would tell me. Replaced because: the silence in the fingertips had reached the second knuckle.

Pair 471. Carving 641. Pattern lengthened: room for a sixth joint. I did not ask. She did not say. I cut it with room, the way my father taught me to cut for a child, so that it will fit her next year, if there is a next year, and if she has hands. She asked me, while I measured, whether a glover could make a glove for a whole house. I said not a glove, my lady. A glove is for a hand. She said, "Then something to put over it," and looked out of my window toward the fen, toward Glovehall, for a long time, and I could hear the knuckles settle.



It must be finished leather. My lady comes to my yard on the first of each month, and I bring out the kid, and she lays her bare hand on its brow, and it lies down.

JOSIAS STAVE, THE GLOVEMAKER'S LEDGER, 602

CARVER'S NOTES: THE GLOVEMAKER'S LEDGER

The hooks. Pair 212 is a confession to an unlicensed Closing by the Left Hand of the Court, in writing, in a hand any Court clerk could match; it would ruin her, or make whoever holds it her creature for life. Pair 446 names, in effect, a political murder done on the Court's order. The Guests may be hired by the Heirs to steal the ledger, by Corrow herself to recover it quietly (she knows Merrit keeps one; she has never asked to see it, and that is the most frightening thing about her), or by Merrit, who wants it carried out of Sallowreach to somewhere it can be read after the Glovehall Hush has taken everything.

The rules. The returned gloves hold what they held. Pair 92, the closed fingers, can be pried open only by a Guest with Cut 4 or higher in the Hand-line, at a Dire (22) Hand + Godsign roll; what is in them is the Carver's to decide, but it is the size of a walnut and it is whatever the Regent was supposed to finish of, and it is still warm. Pair 240 never empties; it is a carried cupful of water from a Kept moat, which will drown anything small put into it and keep it alive. Pair 459, worn, makes the wearer's touch silent: Filch and Stealth rolls with the hands gain +2, and each day worn is Taint 2 Regrowth (Ossel) and a Dread 1 check, as the wearer's fingertips begin to feel nothing at all.

The secret. Ivo Vane, Corrow's son, who has never touched his mother's skin, buys her old gloves from Merrit, a pair at a time, by night, at a price she cannot refuse, and Merrit has entered none of these sales in the ledger. He wears them in bed. He wears them to sign the forged Closing licenses he sells to the Heirs, and the cold of his mother's hands, still in the leather, leaves on the paper the frost-print the Court's clerks test for, which is why his forgeries have never once been caught. He is wearing Pair 186 at present, the one that finished Old Halse, because it is the only pair that has ever held a living man's hand, even by accident.

▼ CONFESSIONS TO THE BENCH



*The accused will repeat the oath, in its words, from the beginning. The court will listen.
The court will not interrupt. The god does not need the court's help.*

— JUDGE THANE URROW, OPENING HIS ELEVEN THOUSANDTH TRIAL, LACK 640

What it is. Six transcripts from the Breaking courts of Tacit and the gorges, copied out of the Keeners' fair records by a student of the Bench of Clauses for a commonplace-book of "Instructive Cases," which the Bench confiscated in 641 and which has since been copied, quietly, several more times. The Keener of a Breaking court writes down every word spoken, and every sound, in a column of its

own: the sound column is what makes these transcripts famous. In a Breaking court, the sound is the verdict.

Where it is found. The original is in the Bench's archive on the Bench Terrace. Copies circulate among law students at Tacit, among the Forsworn of the Breakdowns, who read them aloud for the pleasure of hearing the great made small, and on the Rim, where

a Company Waymaster at Quillhouse rents one out by the night. Reading these transcripts is safe. Reading the oaths in them aloud, in Oathen, in the first person, is not: an oath read aloud is an oath said, and the Bench has records. The third transcript is **Taint Dread 3** and should not be read aloud anywhere.

I. THE MATTER OF HOLLEN BRISK

BREAKING COURT OF THE BENCH TERRACE, TACIT. GRACE 638. JUDGE T. URROW PRESIDING. THE ACCUSED: HOLLEN BRISK, WATER-CARRIER, OF THE SHADEWARD. THE OATH ALLEGED BROKEN: SWORN TO HER FATHER, ORREN BRISK, BEDRIDDEN, IN 631, BEFORE HER BROTHER. WEIGHT 3.

JUDGE URROW: The accused will repeat the oath.

BRISK: "Father, I will bring you water every day as long as you live."

(Sound column: none.)

JUDGE URROW: The court will wait.

(Sound column: none. The court waited the customary span of three breaths, then three more at the Judge's sign.)

JUDGE URROW: The oath is kept. The court notes that it is kept.

THE BROTHER, from the gallery: He died of thirst. He died of thirst in his bed with a full cup beside him. Ask her where the cup was.

JUDGE URROW: The gallery will be silent or will be sworn silent. The court will put the Question, since the brother has laid it. Hollen Brisk. Did you kill your father?

BRISK: (after a long pause) I brought him water every day. I set it on the shelf by the window. Every day. It was always there. He could see it.

JUDGE URROW: That is not an answer. Did you kill your father?

BRISK: No. The thirst did.

(Sound column: a sound like a wet thread parting. A split, a hair's breadth, at the left corner of the accused's mouth. One drop of blood, no more. The Keener measures it with the rule: one-eighth of an inch.)

JUDGE URROW: The court records a hairline. The god has found the answer nearly true. So does the court. Sentence to be drafted: the accused is to carry water every day for nine years to the Witnessing Vaults, and set a cup within reach of every niche in her father's gallery, and she is to swear that it is within reach. Next.

II. THE MATTER OF THE FORTY PAGES

BREAKING COURT, BENCH TERRACE. CARVING 639. URROW PRESIDING. THE ACCUSED: ALDER MASKE, DRAPER. THE OATH ALLEGED BROKEN: HIS MARRIAGE VOW TO ISOLT MASKE, NÉE VERE, FORTY PAGES, NEGOTIATED ELEVEN MONTHS, SWORN 626. WEIGHT 4. THE WIFE ATTENDS.

JUDGE URROW: The accused will repeat the vow. All of it. The court has set aside the morning.

MASKE: Article one. "I take her as she is, and as she will be, barring only..."

(Sound column, articles one to ten: none. Two hours.)

MASKE: Article eleven, clause three. "I will not lie down with another, nor rise with another, nor..."

(Sound column: the left hand. Each finger, in order from the smallest, folding back to the wrist with five distinct reports. The accused continues reading without being told to. The Keener notes that he does not look at his wife.)

MASKE: Article fourteen. "I will not speak of her in her absence to any person in a manner I would not repeat in her presence."

(Sound column: the lower lip. A split to the chin.)

MASKE: (indistinct) Article nineteen. "I will not spend the household's silver without..."

(Sound column: none. The wife, in the gallery, laughs once, aloud, and is fined.)

MASKE: Article twenty-six. "I will keep her warm in Lack."

(Sound column: none.)

MASKE: Article thirty-one. "I will not let her be alone in the dark at the time of her mother's dying."

(Sound column: the breastbone. A crack, one, long, like a branch under snow. The accused sits down on the sand of his own accord. The Judge permits it. He reads the rest sitting.)

MASKE: Article forty. The last. "And I will love her."

(Sound column: none.)

JUDGE URROW: The court will wait.

(Sound column: none. Three breaths. Three more. Nine more, at the Judge's sign, which is irregular.)

JUDGE URROW: Article forty is kept. The court so records.

THE WIFE, from the gallery: (Keener's note: she spoke without rising, and was not fined, and the court did not look

at her, because it was not looking.) Then I would rather it had broken. Then I would know what the rest of it was for.

JUDGE URROW: Sentence to be drafted. Next.

III. THE SHEPHERD OF SWORN GORGE

BREAKING COURT, BENCH TERRACE. LACK 640. URROW PRESIDING, WITH TWO WARDENS OF THE ECHO SEATED, AT THEIR REQUEST. THE ACCUSED: TOBEN HALE, GOATHERD OF THE UPPER GULLET. THE OATH ALLEGED BROKEN: UNKNOWN. THE ACCUSED HAS BEEN BREAKING FOR THREE YEARS, A PART A MONTH, FOR NO CAUSE HE CAN NAME. HE STATES THAT IN 637 HE FOLLOWED A GOAT INTO A SEALED RAVINE AND HEARD THE ECHO THERE. WEIGHT: UNKNOWN.

JUDGE URROW: Toben Hale. The court cannot ask you to repeat an oath it does not know. The court will ask you instead to repeat what you heard.

WARDEN STANE: Judge, I'd ask you not to.

JUDGE URROW: Noted. The court has the duty of the god's record. Toben Hale, repeat what you heard in the gorge, in its words, from the beginning.

HALE: I only heard the end of it. It comes round. You have to wait for it to come round. I waited a day.

JUDGE URROW: Then repeat what you heard.

HALE: It was a man's voice and it was very young. He said, "I swear, on everything I ate, that when it comes back I will..."

(Sound column: see below.)

(Keener's note, in a different ink, made the same day: The remainder of this transcript is struck by order of the Bench, Lack 640, and the Keener's original sheet burned in the presence of the Chief Clausewright. All persons present in the court, numbering forty-one, have been sworn by the Bench to silence on its contents, at Weight 5, on the bones, and also sworn to the oath the accused repeated, since they had heard it, and are bound by it, as he is. The accused completed it. He did not break while repeating it. He broke after, when the court rose, and had been breaking for an hour when the Wardens carried him out. The Judge's ear-trumpet was found afterward on the bench, closed flat, as if it had been stepped on. Nobody stepped on it. The two Wardens of the Echo resigned their posts that evening, and have taken the Quiet.)

IV. THE MATTER OF CORSE OTTERY, FORSWORN

QUESTION COURT, REMOVED TO THE WITNESSING VAULTS BY ORDER OF THE JUDGE. PLENTY 640. URROW PRESIDING. THE ACCUSED: CORSE OTTERY, FORSWORN OF THE BREAKDOWNS, WHOSE JAW BROKE IN 622 ON A FALSE OATH OF DEBT AND HAS SET CROOKED. THE CHARGE: THE MURDER OF ONA DRAY, A SURETY, IN THE LOW CANYON. THE VICTIM IS STANDING IN HER NICHE.

JUDGE URROW: Corse Ottery, did you kill Ona Dray?

OTTERY: No.

(Sound column: none. The jaw, already broken, has nothing left to break with. The gallery, which is Forsworn, laughs. The Judge waits for it to stop.)

JUDGE URROW: The court is aware of the difficulty. That is why we are here and not on the Terrace. Corse Ottery, lay your hand on the bones of Ona Dray and swear, before her as second witness, that you did not kill her.

OTTERY: (laying his hand on the dead woman's foot, which is cured hard and dark as a saddle) I swear on Ona Dray that I never laid a hand on her.

JUDGE URROW: That is not the oath the court asked for.

OTTERY: It's the one I'm giving.

(Sound column: a dry sound from the niche. Cured leather giving. The victim's jaw, wired shut at her standing, opens against the wire, which parts. Keener's note: the face of the dead in the Vaults wears the look of having just heard something. It is the only time I have seen one look as if it were about to answer.)

THE DEAD WOMAN: (in the accused's own voice, exactly, from inside her) Never laid a hand on her.

(Sound column: a pause. Then the same voice, lower.)

THE DEAD WOMAN: Used the rope.

(Sound column: the accused's hand, on the dead woman's foot. Every bone of it, at once. He cannot lift it off her. He has to be cut free at the wrist by the Vault-keepers, and the hand is left on the foot, by the Judge's order, as testimony.)

JUDGE URROW: The dead have testified. Sentence: the Breaker. Next.

V. THE NINEFOLD AT TALLOW-CLAN NARROWS

REPORT OF THE BENCH'S INSPECTOR OF THE UPPER GORGES, ENTERED WITH THE BREAKING COURT'S RECORDS AS A TRANSCRIPT OF A PROCEEDING NOT RECOGNISED BY THE BENCH. CARVING 637. THE ACCUSED: DAVIT OF THE TALLOW-CLAN, WHO KILLED HIS BROTHER AT THE GOATFOLD WITH A HOOK. THE NARROWS: A NINEFOLD, BY THE CLAN'S COUNT. THE INSPECTOR WATCHED FROM THE RIM AND WROTE, AT THE ELDER'S PERMISSION, BY GESTURE.

THE MOTHER, from the rim: Davit. Did you do it?

(Echo, from the narrows, nine times, dying: did you do it, did you do it, did you, did you, do it, do it, it, it, it.)

DAVIT, from the floor of the narrows: I didn't. Mam, I didn't.

(Echo: I didn't. Sound: the jaw, once, a crack like a stick. Mam, I didn't. The lower lip goes. I didn't. The teeth on the left side, all of them, a sound like gravel shaken in a cup. I didn't. The tongue. I will not write what the tongue did. I didn't. He is on his knees. Mam. He is trying to hold his face together with both hands. The echo does not care that he has stopped speaking; the walls are still saying it in his voice, and every time they say it, it is said again, and it is still a lie. I didn't. The upper jaw. I didn't. I am holding my pencil so hard I have broken the lead. Didn't. The throat, down the front, to the breastbone, and then there is no more sound from him and the narrows go quiet, slowly, the way a bell does.)

THE MOTHER: (to the clan, after the silence) Bring him up. Put him with his brother. Facing in.

(Inspector's addendum: Nobody touched him. That is the clans' whole defence of it, and having watched it I find I cannot answer it. I asked the mother on the walk down whether she had believed him. She said she had believed him until the third echo. I asked what changed at the third. She said, He was still saying it. A man telling the truth would have stopped to listen.)

VI. THE LATE VERDICT

BREAKING COURT, BENCH TERRACE. LACK 641, THE FOURTH DAY AFTER THE KEPT RAIN CAME LATE. URROW PRESIDING. THE ACCUSED: SELKE VARRA, CANYON WATCH, WHO SWORE TO HOLD THE NORTH STAIR OF THE TERRACE AND WAS SEEN BY THE WHOLE COURT TO LEAVE IT, THIS MORNING, TO

RUN FROM A SOUND IN THE CISTERNS. THE BREACH IS WITNESSED BY THE COURT ITSELF. WEIGHT 3.

JUDGE URROW: This is a formality. The accused will repeat the oath.

VARRA: "I will hold the north stair of the Terrace through my watch and not leave it for any cause."

(Sound column: none.)

JUDGE URROW: The court will wait.

(Sound column: none. Three breaths. Three more. Nine more.)

JUDGE URROW: (after a time) The accused left the stair. Forty people saw it. The court saw it.

VARRA: Yes, Judge.

JUDGE URROW: Then the court will wait.

(Sound column: none. The Keener has turned the sand-glass twice. Eleven minutes by the glass. The court does not move. In the gallery a Forsworn begins to laugh and stops by himself. The accused is weeping and does not know where to put her hands. The Judge has lowered his ear-trumpet and is sitting very still with his eyes shut, which the Keener has not seen him do in twenty years of this court.)

JUDGE URROW: (quietly, not to the court) Are you there?

(Sound column, at the twelfth minute, all at once: the accused's knees, both, backward, like a heron's, on the sand. She goes down without a cry. And at the same moment, from the Judge's chair, a second sound, smaller, from inside the red robe: a creak, as of a rib taking a weight it was not built for.)

(Keener's note: I record, because it is my office to record every sound in the court, and every face, that when the accused's knees broke the Judge opened his eyes and smiled. Openly. In front of the court. It was the first time in my service I have seen him do it. I do not think he knew. I have not told him. I am entering it here so that the court, if it ever has to, can hear it read back.)

JUDGE URROW: The verdict was late. The court notes that it was late. The court notes that it came. Sentence to be drafted. Next.



He was still saying it. A man telling the truth would have stopped to listen.

A MOTHER OF THE TALLOW-CLAN, TO THE BENCH'S INSPECTOR, CARVING 637

CARVER'S NOTES: CONFESSIONS TO THE BENCH

The hooks. Each transcript is a seed. *Hollen Brisk* is carrying water to the Vaults every day, and has begun to find the cups empty in the morning, in the niches of the dead, who do not drink. *Alder Maske* broke his breastbone on Article thirty-one because his wife's mother died alone in the dark while he was elsewhere; Isolt Maske wants the Guests to find out where, and with whom, and she does not want to know. *Toben Hale's* forty-one witnesses are all bound by an oath sworn in 419 A.G. by a young man "on everything he ate," to do something "when it comes back"; one of them is a Guest's contact, and has begun breaking, a part a month, in the same order as Hale. *Corse Ottery's* hand is still on the dead woman's foot, and the Forsworn want it back for burial; the Bench will not release testimony. *The Ninefold* is still practised in the Gullet, and the Inspector who wrote the report has asked to be sent back, which worries the Bench more than anything else in it. *The Late Verdict* is the newest: Urrow wants to know whether the god was late, or deliberating, and whether it was deliberating about him, and he will pay the Guests well to find another case where it happens.

The rule: running a trial from these. Read the oath in full; have the player repeat it in character, word for word; then let the silence run. These transcripts are models for the Carver's pacing. Since Lack 641, when a Breaking is due, the Carver may roll a d6 in secret: on a 1 the verdict comes late, from one minute to an hour, and anyone in the court when it lands makes a Dread 2 check, Dread 3 if they were the one who had begun to hope.

The rule: reading the oaths. A Guest who reads aloud, in Oathen, the oaths in the first, second, fourth or sixth transcripts has said them; the Carver should treat any of them as a binding Weight 1 promise for a day, and let the dice and the Guest's conduct decide whether anything happens. Reading the fragment in the third transcript aloud binds the reader to the Sworn Gorge oath at Weight 5. The Bench has only the first eleven words of it on record, and wishes it had none.

The secret. The late verdicts are not the god growing careless. The god has begun to listen for longer, the way a listener does when the speaker has stopped being the most important voice in the room, as though it were waiting to hear something else said first. The Judge's smile is the Appetite of the Witness taking a man who has spent forty years listening for it, and the creak in his ribs is his judicial oath, *neither pleasure nor pity*, beginning to come due.



PART TWO

ENGINES AND SONGS

The machinery of the Grace, and what the Table sings while it works.

CHAPTER 3

ENGINES OF THE GRACE

Machinery and Devices

There is no gunpowder on the Table. There is no need of it. We have found other ways to make a thing go off in a person's hands.

– AMBREL COYLE, CLOCKWRIGHT OF THE VIGIL, IN THE PREFACE TO HIS BOOK OF ESCAPEMENTS, 371 A.G.

A LETTER FROM A RIM ROAD TINKER TO HER APPRENTICE, FOUND FOLDED IN A TIN OF BRASS PINS SOLD AT GRISTMOOT. THE APPRENTICE'S NAME HAS BEEN SCRAPED OFF.

You asked me what the trade is. I will tell you, since you will not stop asking, and since you have good hands and a bad memory, which is the right way round.

The trade is this. Every land on the Table has a god in it that is coming back, and every land has decided to hold the god down with a machine. Not a prayer. Prayers are cheap and everybody has one. A machine. The sleepless have engines that stab them on the quarter-hour. The coast has a bell that rings off a man's chest. The highlands have a clock that runs on a dead woman's brick and a frame for sewing strangers' hands together. The red canyons have traps for words. The fen has wax that makes a small silence and mittens of lead the size of a bucket. The Fatlands have a scale that has elected three governments. The Fast has an axe and an axe and an axe.

None of them work, girl. That is the first thing to know. They hold. Holding is not working. A thing that holds is a thing that will one day let go, and you must sell it to the customer as though it never will, and you must be standing a long way off on the day it does.

The second thing to know is that every one of these engines has a part in it that is a person. Look for it. It is always there. Sometimes it is the operator, sometimes the one who is operated upon, sometimes a body that was put in at the bottom when the thing was built and never taken out again. When you are asked to mend a machine, find the person in it first, and ask whether they would like to be mended, and then do the job anyway, because you have been paid.

The third thing to know is that brass goes green, iron goes red, lead goes white and people go every colour, and you must carry polish for all four.

Mind the pins. Some are dipped.

This chapter describes the great and small machines of the Table: the engines by which seven peoples have tried to hold their eaten

gods in check, measure them, steer them, profit by them, or follow them down. Some are famous and singular, like the *Follow* in its slip at Mile Nineteen or the Great Scales under the bone dome of the Weighhouse. Some are common trade goods sold on every Rim market, like lead mittens and jaw-wires. All of them have a history, an operator, a cost, and a way of going wrong.

Every device is described in the same order. First comes its **lore and history**: who made it, why, and what it has done. Then a **diagram in words**: a parts table and a plain account of how the thing works, written so that a Carver can describe it to the players, or a player whose character has Craft or Reckoning can understand it, sketch it, sabotage it, or build a worse one. Then **who builds it and who uses it**; then what it is like **in operation**, to every sense; then the **rules**; then a **d6 failure table**; then **cost and availability**; then a **hook**.

ENGINES AND THE GRACE ROLL

Using a device that is built for the purpose is normally automatic; the rules for each device say when a roll is needed. When one is, mechanisms answer to **Eye + Reckoning** (setting, reading, calibrating, timing), building and mending to **Hand + Craft**, and anything that is fitted to a living or Kept body to **Hand + Stitching**.

Building a device is a Long Task (see the Rules chapter): the device lists the difficulty, the time for each roll, and the number of successes needed. Materials must be bought first, at the listed cost, and are spent whether the work succeeds or not.

Failure tables. Every device has a d6 failure table. Roll on it when a roll to use the device is a **Lack**, when a device is used past its limits, when a saboteur has been at it, or whenever the device's own rules tell you to. A failure on an ordinary roll is just a failure; the table is for when the thing itself goes wrong.

Sabotage. Fouling a device without being noticed is Hand + Craft (or Hand + Filch for a quick job) against the device's **Sabotage** difficulty. Finding the fault afterwards is Eye + Reckoning at the same difficulty. Each Helping on the sabotage lets the saboteur choose the failure result instead of rolling it.



Find the person in the machine. It is always there. Ask if they want mending. Then mend it anyway.

THE GRISTMOOT TINKER'S LETTER

▼ THE VIGIL WAKING-ENGINE



Tick, and prick. Tick, and prick. The engine does not love you. That is why it never tires of you.

— SLOGAN PAINTED OVER THE DOOR OF THE RATTLEHOUSE ON THE SLOPE

LORE AND HISTORY

In the first winter after the First Night, when the city of Ludmere had lost half its people to the long room and had not yet renamed itself, every survivor needed a nudger, and there were not enough hands to go round. Spouses kept each other awake until one of them failed. Children were paid by the hour and fell asleep on the job. Whole streets went down together in the warm afternoon of the third day of Carving 341 because the last waking person in each house had nobody left to pinch them. What the city needed, said a clockwright named **Ambrel Coyle**, was a nudger that did not get tired, did not love you, and could not be bribed with a minute's rest.

He built the first **Waking-Engine** in his workshop on what is now Lampwrights' Row in the spring of 344: a spring-driven escapement in a walnut case, strapped to the back of a chair, that every ninety beats of its balance wheel drove a steel pin a quarter-inch into the sitter's thigh, rattled a tin clapper by their ear, and tightened a leather strap across their chest until they gasped. He sat in it himself for nine days and nights and came out raving, bloodied down both legs, and awake. The Watch of Watches bought the

patent in 346. By 360 there was an engine in every guardhouse, every counting-room, and every orphanage.

The engines have grown since. The personal kind, called a **coffer** after the walnut case, is now carried on the back like a pedlar's pack and wired by cords to cuffs on the wrists and thighs. The civic kind, the **Great Engine**, fills a whole building: the Rattlehouse on the Slope, a long brick hall built in 388, where four hundred of the city's poorest stand in numbered stalls on a sloped floor while a single driveshaft the length of the hall turns cams that work four hundred arms, each arm tipped with a needle, a rattle, and a cold wet sponge. They pay a crumb a watch. It is the cheapest way to stay awake in the Vigil, and every night the Wakers carry out three or four who failed anyway, still standing in their stalls, eyes shut, the needle-arm going in and out of their thigh like a sewing machine.

Ambrel Coyle died in 371, awake, of a burst heart, in his own engine. He had written in the margin of his last drawing: *I have built a thing that keeps a man from sleeping. I have not built a thing that lets him rest. The city does not know the difference. I am beginning to.*

THE DIAGRAM IN WORDS

PART	MATERIAL	FUNCTION
Mainspring and barrel	blued steel, brass drum	stores the force; wound by crank every watch
Balance wheel and hairspring	brass, steel	keeps the beat; ninety beats to a "prick"
Cam-drum	oak, iron pegs	sets the order of insults: pin, rattle, strap, sponge
Pin-cuffs (four)	leather, brass, steel pins	drive pins into wrists and thighs on the cam's word
Rattle-box	tin, dried peas	clatters at the ear
Chest-strap	waxed leather, ratchet	tightens on the breath, forcing a gasp
Lull-catch	brass feeler on the brow	senses a nodding head and fires everything at once
Wake-glass	small mirror on a stalk	holds a lamp's glare in the eyes

The coffer works like any clock, except that its hands are needles and its face is the wearer. The mainspring drives a train of brass wheels that turns the cam-drum one full revolution every quarter-hour. Pegs on the drum lift levers in a set order: at the first peg a cuff fires its pin; at the second the rattle-box shakes; at the third the chest-

strap ratchets one notch tighter and then lets go; at the fourth a sponge of cold water on a stalk slaps the neck. The order can be changed by moving the pegs, and a good Waker-valet sets a client's drum like a musician sets a tune, so that the insults come irregularly and the body cannot learn them. The cleverest part is the **lull-catch**,

a brass feeler resting against the forehead: if the head drops by more than a finger's width, the feeler trips a sear and the whole drum fires at once, every pin, rattle and strap together. The wearer comes up screaming. That is the point.

The Great Engine is the same thing built into a building. A water-wheel in the Slope's main sewer turns the driveshaft; the shaft runs the length of the Rattlehouse; four hundred cams on it work four hundred stalls. There are no lull-catches in the Great Engine, because the Rattlehouse cannot afford them. Instead there are walkers: Rattlehouse boys who pace the aisles with Waker's needles and look for drooping heads.

WHO BUILDS IT, WHO USES IT

Coffers are made on Lampwrights' Row by six licensed clockwright families, of which the Coyle-Harrows are the oldest, and repaired on the Slope by everyone. The Wakers use them on prisoners and on themselves; the Watch of Watches uses gilded ones with silk cuffs, in which the pins are gold and the sponge is scented; clerks, night-porters, lamp-tenders and soldiers wear plain ones. Parents buy small coffer for children, with blunt pins, and the Watch pretends not to know that the pins are always sharpened within a year. The Rattlehouse is run by a Slope family, the Grainers, under a Watch licence, and is never empty. The Tuckers hate the engines: an engine-wearer does not need a minute's guarded sleep, and an engine that has been fouled is the commonest way a Tucker's competitor is put down.

IN OPERATION

A coffer ticks loudly, by design, because a tick is a comfort and comfort is death, and so the tick is pitched just off the beat of a resting heart, a little fast, so that the body feels hurried by it. The wearer smells of brass polish, sweat and old blood, because the pin-cuffs are never quite clean and the punctures on the thighs of a ten-year wearer are a lace of white scar and fresh scab, weeping clear fluid into the cloth. The first prick comes with a click and a cold small bite, and then the warm thread of blood. The rattle is a sound like a handful of teeth in a tin. The chest-strap is the worst: it squeezes until the ribs creak and the breath goes out in a grunt, and holds a moment too long, and lets go, and the lungs heave in a gasp that is half a sob. In the Rattlehouse four hundred of these happen in one long ripple down the hall, every quarter-hour, a wave of grunts and gasps and little cries, and then a silence full of ticking, and then the boys walking the aisles calling *up, up, up, up* in bored sing-song voices.

Old wearers twitch in time with their drums even when the engine is off. They flinch on the quarter-hour. Some of them cannot hear a clock without their thighs bleeding.



It's not the pin. You get used to the pin. It's the click before the pin. I hear it in my sleep. I don't sleep. I hear it anyway.

RATTLEHOUSE STALL-HOLDER, NUMBER 211

RULES

Wearing a coffer. A wound coffer runs one watch (eight hours). While it runs, the wearer gains no Weariness from the watch's passing, as though they had taken rouse, and gains +2 on all blink checks; the lull-catch fires on any failed blink check before the blink resolves, cancelling it, but the wearer loses 1 Flesh and the rest of their action. Each watch in a coffer costs 1 Flesh from the pins, which heals normally. A coffer stacks with rouse: a character on rouse and in a coffer may shed 1 further Weariness each watch, but must make a Gut + Endure roll (Hard 14) at the end of the watch or gain the *Engine-Twitch* (−1 to all Hand rolls requiring stillness, such as Shooting, Stitching and Filch, until they have spent a full day out of the coffer).

Stealth and comfort. A coffer is Noisy. Its wearer is at −4 to Stealth. In the Vigil this is good manners; abroad, it is a confession.

Torture. A coffer set to a cruel tune by a Waker or a wake-valet is a torture device (see Torture in the Rules chapter): the operator rolls Hand + Reckoning instead of the usual roll, and the subject cannot blink, faint or fall unconscious while it runs. Anyone forced into a cruel coffer for a full watch makes a Dread 2 check.

The Rattlehouse. A stall costs a crumb a watch. A character in a stall makes no blink checks for the watch, but the Rattlehouse is a scene of monotony, and at the end of each watch the GM rolls a d20 for each PC; on a 1 the character has gone under in their stall and must be fetched as described under Falling Asleep, by a Rattlehouse boy whose Tongue + Intimidate is +5.

Building a coffer is a Long Task: Hand + Craft at Grim 18, a day per roll, five successes, materials 60 lacks. Its **Sabotage** difficulty is Hard 14.

FAILURE TABLE (D6)

D6	THE ENGINE FAILS
1	The mainspring breaks with a crack like a slapped face. The engine stops. The silence afterward is so restful that the wearer must make a blink check at once, at +4.
2	The cam-drum slips a peg. Every insult comes at once, every beat, until someone cuts the cords: 1 Flesh per round, and the wearer cannot act except to scream.

D6	THE ENGINE FAILS
3	The lull-catch sticks. The engine runs on, but the head may drop freely now. The wearer does not know. Their next failed blink resolves as normal, in harness, and the people around them assume the engine is working.
4	The tick falls into time with the wearer's resting heart. The engine has become a lullaby. +1 Weariness every hour until it is reset (Routine 10 Eye + Reckoning; the wearer must notice first).
5	A pin breaks off in the thigh and works its way in. Nothing happens for a week. Then, each morning, roll a d6: on 1–2 the wearer loses 2 Flesh and limps all day, until a surgeon digs the pin out (Hard 14 Hand + Stitching).
6	The wearer goes under in the engine and is Counted, and the engine goes on running. Nobody thinks to unstrap it. At the Dormitory they find the cuffs still pricking a sleeping body every quarter-hour, and the body still gasping on cue. Dread 3 for whoever finds it. They may not be allowed to take it off: the Matron says it is the only bed in the row that still breathes on its own schedule.

COST AND AVAILABILITY

ITEM	COST	AVAILABILITY	NOTES
Coffer, plain	40 L	Common in the Vigil; Scarce elsewhere	walnut, steel pins
Coffer, gilded	400 L	Uncommon	gold pins, silk cuffs, scented sponge
Child's coffer	15 L	Common	blunt pins, for now
Re-pegging by a valet	2 L	Common	a new tune for the drum
Rattlehouse stall	1 c a watch	Common	the Slope; bring your own rag

HOOK

The Stall That Never Empties. Stall 400 in the Rattlehouse, at the very end of the hall, has been rented every watch for eleven years by somebody who pays in advance and is never seen to arrive or leave. Its needle-arm is always wet. The Grainers want to know who it is.

The PCs, keeping watch through a night, see the arm working on nothing, quarter-hour by quarter-hour, and on the stroke of the Tablenight bell they see the empty stall gasp. When the Grainers finally open the stall's floor they find that the stall was built over Ambrel Coyle's first workshop, and that under the boards is a walnut chair with nobody in it, still strapped shut.

▼FINN UNDERTOW'S TIDE-BELL MECHANISM



The sea says dawn's at the half-bell. Your chests say it's now. I ring for the chests.

– FINN UNDERTOW, TIDE-BELLMAN OF LOWMARK

LORE AND HISTORY

Lowmark has rung a tide bell since before the Beaching. The first was a ship's bell hung on a post at the harbour mouth, struck by hand when the water turned so the fleet knew when to sail. After the Brimming of 60 A.G., when the first generation was born coughing brine, the bell took on a second task: to tell the city when to bail. For four hundred years the two tasks were one, because the

tide in the chest rose and fell with the tide in the sea, and a bellman needed only to watch the water and ring.

The bell that hangs now on the Headland, called **Old Gannet**, was cast in 61 A.G. from the bronze fittings of the Admiralty's first stranded ships, and it is the size of a small room. In 402 the Bellmen's Company built a tower for it and fitted it with a **tide-engine**: a float in a stone well, the **Tide-Well**, fed by a culvert from the harbour, whose rise and fall turned a pegged drum that tripped

the hammer at each turn of the tide. The bellman’s work became the keeping of the engine.

Then the sea began to leave. The culvert ran dry in 530. The Bellmen kept a clockwork reckoner set by the Salt Assay’s tables instead, and that was well enough until the body’s tide began to drift from the sea’s. By 600 the two were half an hour apart. By 630 they were two hours apart, and the Admiralty had ordered that the bell follow the sea, because the sea was the navy’s business and the chest was not.

The Admiralty had tried, before that, to make the engine ring the chest. In 604 a Tenanted volunteer named **Ysolde Prow**, a net-maker’s widow from Mile Three, was sealed into a glass cistern in the base of the tower with a leather cuff around her ribs and a cord from the cuff to the escapement, so that the slow fill and empty of her body’s tide would drive the hammer. The Bench approved it. The Deepening blessed it. Her family were given a pension and a

plaque. For three years the bell rang off Ysolde Prow’s chest, and the city bailed in time. Then it drifted, exactly as before: a Tenanted chest, it turned out, followed something else, something deeper than the city’s tide, and the engine rang the wrong hours for Lowmark as surely as the sea did. The Admiralty unhooked the cord and went back to the sea-drum. Nobody unsealed the cistern. Ysolde Prow is still down there, thirty-seven years later, in the base of the tower, in green water gone thick as broth, breathing slowly, and nobody remembers whose job it is to feed her. She was the city’s sacrifice to the bell, and she was worth nothing.

Finn Undertow took the rope in 627. For four years he rang the sea, as ordered. Then one dawn he felt his own chest fill, and heard the whole Headland cough with him, a full hour before the sea-drum tripped, and he went down into the gear-room with a knife and a coil of tarred cord and wired the engine to himself.

THE DIAGRAM IN WORDS

PART	MATERIAL	FUNCTION
Old Gannet	bronze, eleven tons	the bell; heard to Mile Twelve on a still day
Hammer and sear	iron, oak beam	strikes the bell when the sear is tripped
Sea-Drum	oak, iron pegs, clockwork	the old engine; trips the sear at the Assay’s tide
Chest-Drum	brass, gut cord	the new engine; trips the sear off Finn’s ribs
Selector lever	iron, brass plate marked SEA and CHEST	chooses which drum commands the hammer
Rib-cuff	tarred leather, whalebone stays	buckled around Finn’s chest, day and night
The Count Wheel	brass, scratched by hand	Finn’s drift-counter; a notch for every minute the tides close
The Prow Cistern	glass, iron bands, lead seal	the old chest-engine; disconnected, still occupied

The tower is three storeys of grey stone. At the top hangs Old Gannet, with its hammer on an oak beam above it. In the gear-room beneath, two drums sit side by side, and a long iron selector lever chooses which of them will lift the hammer’s sear. The **Sea-Drum** is the old engine, driven now by clockwork set to the Salt Assay’s tables. The **Chest-Drum** is Finn’s: a small brass drum with a ratchet, connected by forty feet of gut cord, running over pulleys and down through a hole in the floor, to a buckled leather cuff around Finn Undertow’s ribs. When his chest fills with the body’s tide, his ribs swell; the cord draws taut; the ratchet turns the drum by one tooth; and when it has turned far enough, the sear trips, and the bell rings for the chests of Lowmark.

Finn is roped to the tower, as bellmen always were, so that the Calling cannot walk him off the Headland. But his rope is short, because the cord is short. He sleeps, eats, bails and lives within forty feet of the Chest-Drum. Beside it, on the wall, is the **Count Wheel**: a brass wheel he has marked by hand, one scratch for every minute by which the body’s tide has drifted from the sea’s, and a second ring of scratches counting down the days until the drift closes. By

the wheel, the tide in every chest on the coast will fill at the same moment at the Low Water of Carving 642.

At the bottom of the stair, behind a door that has been bricked and then unbricked and then bricked again, is the Prow Cistern.

WHO BUILDS IT, WHO USES IT

The Bellmen’s Company of Lowmark, which is now Finn Undertow and two apprentices, keeps the engine. The Admiralty owns it and has three times ordered the selector set to SEA; each time Finn has set it to CHEST again, and the city has refused to support the Admiralty’s officers in arresting him, because the city coughs when Finn rings, and it is easier to cough on time. Skerrow and the other coastal towns have their own bells and bellmen, and most of them still ring the sea. The Deepening want the cistern opened, and Ysolde brought out to be walked into the Trench with the honour she was owed. The Wreckwives bring her flowers, which they push through a crack in the bricks.

IN OPERATION

The tower smells of tar, wet bronze, and the sour green breath that rises up the stair from the cistern. It sounds of ticking, of gulls, and of Finn's breathing, which every visitor notices: slow, and deep, and a little too long, and accompanied, at each breath's end, by the small dry *click* of the ratchet forty feet above him. He wears the rib-cuff under his shirt; the leather has worn a raw red band around his torso, weeping at the edges, and the whalebone stays have pressed white grooves into his skin like the marks of a corset. When the body's tide comes, he stops whatever he is doing. His chest fills, visibly, the ribs rising and staying risen; his face goes dark; water comes up into his throat and he bends over his bucket and bails, retching, and above him the ratchet clicks, and clicks, and the sear trips, and Old Gannet speaks, a sound so deep it is felt in the teeth before it is heard. Across the Headland, a mile of Lowmark coughs, together, at once, a sound like surf on shingle.

When the bell rings, a deep, slow knocking answers from the bottom of the stair, three times, and then stops. Finn says it is the pipes.



*Every hour I'm the city's chest. Every hour I'm
drowning for all of you. It's a living.*

FINN UNDERTOW, TO THE ADMIRALTY'S THIRD
ARRESTING OFFICER, WHO WENT HOME

RULES

Ring the chests. While the selector is set to CHEST, everyone in Lowmark who hears Old Gannet bails on time. Brinehollowers

within earshot gain +1 on Calling rolls on any night the bell rings the chest, because they are bailed and steady; they gain the same bonus against drowning effects of their own tide. When the selector is set to SEA, Brinehollowers in earshot suffer the -2 penalty for a missed bailing for 1d6 × 10 minutes each turn of the tide, as the bell lies to them.

Wearing the cuff. Anyone may take Finn's place on the cord. The wearer must be a Brinehollower (anyone else's chest does not have the tide) and must stay within forty feet of the drum. Each turn of the tide, the wearer makes a Gut + Endure roll at Hard 14 or loses 2 Flesh to the cuff's bite as the chest swells against it. A wearer at the Appetite or beyond feels the coast's tide as one swell; they may roll Caul + Godsign at Grim 18 to learn, for one turn, who on the Headland is closest to being Called, as a direction and a distance. A Lack gives them the Want *The West* for a day.

Reading the Count Wheel. Eye + Reckoning at Hard 14 gives the date of the closing. A Helping reveals that the drift is not steady but follows a slow rhythm of its own, four breaths in a day; a Grace lets the character recognise the rhythm as a single great breath taken by something very large, somewhere below, and make a Dread 3 check.

The cistern. Opening the bricks is Hand + Labor at Routine 10. Seeing what is inside is Dread 3. Ysolde Prow is Tenanted, at the Seating, and has not been bailed by anyone but herself in thirty-seven years. She can speak, very slowly, through water. Whatever is wearing her is courteous, and asks after the bell.

Sabotage difficulty: Hard 14 for the drums, Routine 10 to cut the cord.

FAILURE TABLE (D6)

D6	THE BELL FAILS
1	The cord snaps. The bell rings no tide at all until it is spliced. In the silence, the Headland's chests come on unannounced, in the street, at table, in bed; d6 deaths by drowning in the night among the old and the drunk.
2	The ratchet slips backward. The bell rings twice, a turn apart, and half the city bails for nothing and half not at all. Brawls at every pump.
3	The selector jumps to SEA in the night. Nobody touched it. The ratchet has been moved by a hand that left wet prints on the lever, small and long-fingered.
4	The cuff tightens itself. The wearer's chest goes on filling past the tide and will not stop until the cuff is cut: Gut + Endure at Grim 18 or begin drowning on dry stone (1 Flesh per round).
5	Old Gannet rings for the cistern instead of the cuff. Its note drops a full tone. Everyone in earshot at the Appetite or beyond must make a Calling roll at once, in daylight.
6	The drift closes early. For one turn, every chest on the coast fills at the same moment, and the bell rings it, and in the silence after, a mile of Lowmark hears something very large, far to the west, draw breath with them. Dread 4.

COST AND AVAILABILITY

The Tide-Bell Mechanism is **Unique**. A small chest-engine for a household (a rib-cuff, cord and clapper bell that rings the wearer's own tide for the house) can be had from a Mile Six bell-founder for **35 lacks** (Uncommon in Brinehollow, Rare elsewhere); it is popular

with Wreckwives, who strap it to their returned spouses and listen, at night, to see whose tide it rings.

HOOK

The Third Knock. The Admiralty wants the selector set to SEA permanently and has hired the PCs to replace Finn with a reliable

man, quietly. Finn’s apprentices have hired the same PCs to find out what is knocking on the cistern’s bricks. Inside the cistern, Ysolde Prow has been keeping her own count, scratched on the glass with a

finger nail: a count that closes on the same night as Finn’s, and a list of names under it, nine hundred long, every one of them a volunteer from Dagna Hull’s wall.

▼ THE ASSEMBLERS' JOINING FRAME



Whose is the hand? Every mother’s. What does the needle do? It makes the god whole.

– THE GATHERERS’ CATECHISM

LORE AND HISTORY

The first Joinings in the Barn were done on a threshing floor, on straw, by lamplight, with the Part held in place by the hands of six kneeling Seamsters for a whole night while the seam took. Hands tire. In 566 a Seamster fell asleep at the far end of the figure, and the ear she was holding against the figure’s jaw crawled away into the straw and was not found for a week; when it was, it had begun to take root in the floorboards. Dov Marrin’s predecessor, a wheelwright’s widow named **Hanne Spokes**, built the first **Joining Frame** that winter from a cart-bed, a loom and a midwife’s birthing

chair, and every Joining since has been done in it or in one of its children.

There are now four frames in the Barn and perhaps a dozen elsewhere, in the cellars of Assembler households across the highlands, where Gatherers join two or three Parts together before carrying them to the Barn, so that the god arrives in larger pieces. The Attendance has found and burned nine of these lesser frames since 620. They are always warm when found, and there is always something in them.

THE DIAGRAM IN WORDS

PART	MATERIAL	FUNCTION
The Bed	oak cart-bed on trestles, padded with fleece	holds the figure or the receiving body
The Arms	eight jointed oak arms with brass clamps	hold a Part exactly against its seam for a night
Warming Troughs	copper, under the bed, fed from a kettle-stove	keep bed and Parts at blood-heat
The Listening Slab	red clay, hollowed, with a brass ear-cup	where a Part is laid to be Heard before joining
Hum-Pipe	a bone flute with five holes	sounds the five-note tune that calls the Parts
Seam-rack	curved needles, sheep-gut, silver wire	the stitching itself
Cord-Pegs	iron, set in the bed’s rim	where a Carrier’s living cord is pegged, if they are Uncut

The frame is a bed with arms. The receiving body (Herself, or a lesser assemblage, or a living Carrier who has agreed to bear the piece) is laid on the fleece and kept at blood-heat by the troughs. The Part is first laid on the Listening Slab, a hollowed brick of warm red clay with a brass cup set into its side, and a Fitter puts her ear to the cup and listens, sometimes for days, until she knows where the Part wants to go. Then the arms are swung in and their clamps set: soft brass jaws lined with lambskin, adjusted by thumbscrews, one arm for each edge of the seam. The clamps hold the Part against the body, edge to edge, raw to raw, with exactly the pressure of a mother’s hand. The Fitter sews with curved needles, sheep-gut for the skin and silver wire for anything that bears weight. Then the hum-pipe is played, the five notes, over and over, by relays of brothers and sisters, all night, while the seam takes. By morning, in

Cradle rack, the arms can be swung back. The Part is part of something.

WHO BUILDS IT, WHO USES IT

Frames are built by Assembler carpenters to Hanne Spokes’s pattern, and only Fitters and Assembler-Prime may join in them. Seamsters assist. The Attendance keeps two confiscated frames in the Lying-In, and the rumour in Kest is that it uses them, for the births it permits but cannot look at: to sew back what came out wrong. Lazar Voss has drawn a frame in exact detail. The Second Table has paid for a frame to be shipped, in pieces, to a cellar on the Rim.

IN OPERATION

The room smells of hot copper, wet fleece, milk, and a sweetish smell beneath it like a cut pear left out. The troughs gurgle. The clamps tick as they are tightened. The Part, on the Slab, is never quite still: a hand flexes, a tongue curls, an eye rolls in its socket of clay to look at the Fitter. When it is laid against the body, the edges of both wounds are seen to be wet and raw and to tremble toward each other, like the lips of a cut that wants to close. The gut squeaks through skin. Through the long night, under the hum, the seam begins to pulse, first out of time with the body's heart, then in. By dawn the scar is pink, puckered, and warm as a cheek. The worst moment, those who have seen it say, is the first twitch: when the joined hand closes, not by its own will but by the body's, and the whole figure on the bed seems to shiver once, from end to end, the way a sleeper shivers when someone sits down on the bed.



It took at four bells. I felt it take. The whole barn felt it. Everybody looked at the door, as if someone had come in.

SEAMSTER'S ACCOUNT OF A JOINING, PLENTY 639

RULES

The Hearing. Laying a Part on the Slab and finding where it belongs is Caul + Instinct at Hard 14, one roll per day; a Fitter adds

D6 THE JOINING FAILS	
1	The seam will not take. The Part is cold by morning. It is still moving.
2	It takes, wrong side out. The hand is joined palm-outward, the eye facing in. It works.
3	The clamps were too tight. The Part takes, and the brass arm takes with it: the clamp is fused into the flesh, and must stay, or be sawn.
4	The Fitter's ear was against the cup for too long. Her own hearing is joined into the Part: from now on she hears what it hears, everywhere it goes.
5	The receiving body takes the Part and then reaches past it, in the night, and takes one of the assistants' hands as well. The assistant must be cut free (Grim 18 Hand + Stitching) or join the figure.
6	The Part's bearer, wherever they are in the highlands, feels the seam take, at dawn, as a pain in the place it came from. They will come to the Barn. They will want it back, or they will want to lie down beside it. Neither ends well.

COST AND AVAILABILITY

A frame is **Rare**, never openly sold, and costs **300 lacks** from an Assembler carpenter who trusts the buyer, or **900** through the Second Table's agents. Assembler joining-gut (sheep-gut cured in posset) is 3 lacks a skein, Uncommon in Cradlewrack. Possession of a frame in Kest is a matter for the Second Opinion.

her rank. Each Helping reveals one true thing about the Part's bearer or its place in the figure. A Lack means the Part has been heard wrong: it will be joined where it does not belong (roll on the failure table at the Joining's end, regardless of success).

The Joining. Hand + Stitching at Grim 18 (Hard 14 for a Fitter in a proper frame). The frame gives +2 to the roll; without one, six steady assistants are needed and the difficulty is Dire 22. A success means the Part takes by dawn. Inside Cradlewrack this is certain; outside it, the Part takes only on a Grace, and otherwise dies in the night, cold and grey.

Bearing the piece. A living body joined to a Part becomes a Carrier. The Part has Taint 2 Regrowth (Cradlewrack's god, foreign to most) and counts as worn against the skin every day. It feeds through the seam: the Carrier's maximum Flesh drops by 2 for as long as it is carried. It has a will: once a session the GM may have it reach, grip, stroke or point, and the Carrier must win an opposed Gut + Brawl roll against the Part's Threat 3 to stop it. Witnesses of a Joining make a Dread 2 check; the Carrier makes Dread 3 the first morning they see it move.

Building a frame is a Long Task: Hand + Craft at Hard 14, a day per roll, four successes, 90 lacks of oak, brass and copper. Its Sabotage difficulty is Hard 14.

FAILURE TABLE (D6)

HOOK

The Frame in the Cellar. A Rim innkeeper at Knocking Gate has asked the PCs to clear a cellar he has inherited. In it is a small Joining Frame, still warm, the troughs still bubbling, the kettle-stove still lit by someone who comes in at night. On the fleece, in the clamps, are two ears and a mouth, already joined into something like a face, and the face is humming the five notes. It is waiting for its eyes. The innkeeper's own children have started humming them too.

▼ HUSH-WAX LANTERNS



It does not light the room. It finishes a little of it.

— LOFT-WARDEN'S DESCRIPTION, GIVEN IN SIGN, BECAUSE THERE WAS NO SOUND TO GIVE IT IN

LORE AND HISTORY

When Dunmere went silent in 633, the Court sent surveyors to the edge, and the surveyors brought back what they could reach without crossing: a dead heron with every feather perfect, a stalk of grey grass that did not wilt, and, from an apple tree just inside the line, a wild bees' nest. The bees had fallen in rows on the comb. The honey had stopped. The wax, when it was cut, did not smell of anything at all.

A chandler named **Wick Tallow** bought the comb. He had built his fortune rendering the unclaimed dead into candles that feel themselves burn, and he wanted to know what a candle would do that could feel nothing. He rendered the Dunmere wax, poured it into a single taper, and lit it in his shop in the Lower Pilings. The

flame was perfectly still. Around it, for a stride in every direction, there was no sound. The flies in the shop dropped out of the air. And the Kept candles on the next shelf, the ones made from people, stopped moaning in their wax and went out.

Wick Tallow is a businessman. Within a year he had sent gatherers to the edge of every Hush in the country for comb, for tallow from things that died at the line, for the fat of birds that fell. The product is called **Hush-wax**. Rendered into lanterns, it makes a small, moving silence: a little Hush on a pole. The Court declared it a licensed good in 636, since a thing that finishes even a little is a Closing by another name. The licence is never granted. The lanterns are everywhere.

THE DIAGRAM IN WORDS

PART	MATERIAL	FUNCTION
Hush-wax taper	wax or tallow from inside a Hush's edge	the source; burns three hours a finger
Lead cowl	sheet lead, hinged	shutters the silence; open, it spills, closed, it stops
Wick	grey grass from a Hush, plaited	will not burn without Hush-wax around it
Glass chimney	thick green fen-glass	keeps the flame from the air, which it dislikes
Pole or bail	ash, iron	held at arm's length, always
Cork ear-stops	cork and wax	worn by the bearer, out of habit; they do nothing

A Hush-wax lantern is a plain fen-glass chimney in a hinged lead cowl, on a pole or a bail. The taper inside is grey, odourless, and slightly cold to the touch. The wick is a plait of Hush grass, which will not catch from any ordinary flame unless it is wrapped in Hush-wax, and which, once lit, burns with a small, upright, motionless flame, pale as milk, that casts no flicker. Around that flame, while the cowl is open, is a sphere of hush about two strides across: no sound passes into or out of it; flies, moths and fen-midges die at its rim and fall; decay stops within it; and the Kept, inside its light, grow still. Closing the lead cowl stops it at once. Lead is the only thing that does.

WHO BUILDS IT, WHO USES IT

Wick Tallow's shop makes the best, with a small mark of a closed eye pressed into the base of every taper. Hush-gatherers, mostly Heirs and Finishers desperate for money, risk the edges to supply him; a gatherer who leans an inch too far simply stops. The Loft-Wardens buy lanterns quietly and carry them through the shelving on the worst nights, so that the Set-Aside nearest the light can have an hour without pain. Burglars and assassins use them for silence. Kept families buy them to sit by a grandmother's shelf. The Finishers burn them at their services. The Court's Closers hate them, with reason.

IN OPERATION

Inside the sphere, the world stops making sound. A voice is a mouth moving. A footstep is a jolt felt through the heel. The bearer hears only their own heartbeat, carried through bone, very loud. The air goes perfectly dry and smells of nothing, which is the most frightening smell in Sallowreach, where everything smells. Outside the sphere, the fen goes on, buzzing and dripping and moaning; inside it, the flies come in out of the fog and drop onto the boards with tiny dry ticks that nobody hears, and pile in a ring at the edge of the light like black sand. And the Kept in the light change. Their faces slacken. The perpetual small motion of the fen dead, the twitch of the eyelid, the working of the jaw, the restless fingers, stops. Some weep. Some smile. All of them, if the light stays long enough, begin to lie down.



My mother had been screaming for ninety years. I held the lantern to her shelf and her mouth stopped and she looked at me. That was the first time she knew me since I was born. Then I closed the cowl, because it was not licensed, and she started again.

CONFESSION TO THE LOFT-WARDENS, UNSIGNED

RULES

The silence. While the cowl is open, no sound enters or leaves the sphere (two paces radius). Characters inside gain +4 on Stealth against anyone outside and cannot be heard, speak to one another, or cast spoken oaths; Oathen echoes cannot reach them. The bearer must roll Caul + Resolve at Routine 10 each scene or gain 1 Fray from the silence.

The Kept. A Kept creature in the light is at -2 to all rolls and moves at half pace. Each full hour a Kept body remains in the light, roll a d6: on a 6 it finishes, properly and finally dead. This is an unlicensed Closing and a capital offence in Sallowreach. Kept PCs in the light feel no pain and must make a Caul + Resolve roll at Hard 14 to leave it voluntarily.

Taint. Hush-wax carries **Taint 2 Dread**, taken each scene the lantern burns. A Hand-line character at the Appetite or beyond who holds an open lantern gains +2 to any Closing touch, but also gains 1 Hunger each scene; at the Course, a Lack on any roll while holding it begins a small Hush, a pace across, at their feet, permanent.

Burning down. A finger of taper burns three hours. When the last of it gutters, the silence does not vanish at once: it drains out of the sphere in a sudden rush of noise that is a Dread 1 check for all inside.

FAILURE TABLE (D6)

D6	THE LANTERN FAILS
1	The cowl will not close. The bearer must smother it with lead, or carry it open until it burns out.
2	The flame stands still and the silence keeps spreading: a pace more each minute, until someone snuffs it with a lead cap (Hard 14 Hand + Craft).
3	The silence comes off the lantern and stays where it was set down, the size of a hearth, after the flame is out. The Court will want to know whose it is.
4	The bearer's own sound goes out with it and does not come back for a day: no voice, no footsteps, no heartbeat anyone else can hear. Physicians pronounce them dead.
5	A Kept body finishes in the light, and it was not the one meant.
6	Something answers inside the silence: a voice heard only within it, close by the ear, clear as a bell, saying one word. Edda Thrush will want to know which word. Dread 3.

COST AND AVAILABILITY

A Hush-wax lantern is **Rare** and illegal: **120 lacks** from Wick Tallow's back room, **250** abroad, where Vigil buyers want it for sleepless sickrooms and the Fatlands want it to quiet the Bleeding Orchards at pruning. Spare tapers are **30 lacks** a finger. Counterfeits are common: ordinary wax dyed grey, which burns, flickers, and stinks of mutton.

HOOK

The Wardens' Night. Old Bettany Shroud wants a lantern carried up through all nine storeys of the Lofts, one shelf at a time, so that each of her forty thousand can have a minute's peace on Tablenight. It will take all night and every taper in Lastgate. The Court has heard and sent a Closer to stop it. Halfway up, the PCs begin to notice that the shelves the lantern has passed do not start moaning again when the cowl is closed. They lie very still, and very quiet, and on the fifth storey every one of them has turned their head to watch the lantern go.

▼ OATHEN ECHO-TRAPS



A word is a bird. It must land somewhere. We build it a nest, and close the lid.

– ECHO-WARDEN TEACHING, IN HANDTALK

LORE AND HISTORY

The Echo-Wardens were chartered in 422 to clean the canyons of old sworn words, and for their first century they did it with felt, wool, sand and rockfall: smothering. Smothering kills an echo but takes days, and a long echo can bind a dozen travellers before it dies. In 531 a Warden-Tracker named **Iolo Thrane**, who had been a bell-founder before the knife took his right ear, built the first **echo-trap**: a long spiral horn of fired clay, lined with wax, that a living echo would fly into and not fly out of. The word went round the spiral, smaller and smaller, until it reached a wax-lined chamber at the

centre, where it pressed itself into the soft wax like a seal into a letter, and stopped.

The traps worked. They also kept. A trap pulled from the rock forty years later was found to contain its echo still, pressed into the wax, and anyone who put their ear to the horn's mouth heard it, faintly, and was bound by it. The Wardens now break every full trap on an anvil in a felt-hung room, and grind the wax with sand. Not all of them do. Kept words are worth a great deal to the wrong people.

THE DIAGRAM IN WORDS

PART	MATERIAL	FUNCTION
The Mouth	flared clay bell, a forearm wide	faces up-canyon; takes the echo in
The Spiral	coiled clay tube, wax-lined, nine turns	narrows the word and keeps it turning
The Nest	wax chamber at the centre, fist-sized	where the word lands and presses in
The Lid	lead plug on a chain	seals the nest; never removed in hearing of anyone
Felt jacket	wool felt, stitched tight	stops the trap ringing like a bell
Mounting	iron pins, rope cradle	set into the rock at an echo's turning-point

An echo-trap looks like a great clay snail-shell, wrapped in grey felt, with a flared mouth. The Wardens track a living echo by ear, find the bend where it turns from one wall to the other, and pin the trap there, mouth facing the oncoming word. An echo is a sound that wants a wall to strike. The trap gives it a softer one, then another, nine turns down a narrowing spiral of wax, each turn taking a little of its force, until it is small enough to enter the nest. There it presses into the wax and is still. A Warden listens at the felt for silence, then fits the lead lid by touch. Then the trap is carried down, unspeaking, wrapped in a quilt, to be broken.

Smugglers and Forsworn have learned to build traps backwards: with a lid that can be opened. A trap with a kept word in it, unstopped in a narrow place, sends the word out again into the rock to bind whoever walks there. These are called **loaded horns**, and owning one is a crime equal to breaking the oath inside it.

WHO BUILDS IT, WHO USES IT

Echo-Warden potters at the Wardens' house in Tacit build the true traps, and each is numbered and must be returned, full, to be broken. Smugglers in the Breakdowns build cruder ones from cracked water-jars lined with tallow. Grandam Cess, the Vow-Eater, is said to keep a shelf of loaded horns in her back canyon, each holding an oath she has lifted from a client, waiting to be sold to someone who wants that client bound again. The Bench owns a single horn from Sworn Gorge, sealed in lead, taken by Halvar Stane in 611 from the outermost bend of the gorge. It holds only one word. Nobody knows which.

IN OPERATION

A trap being set is the quietest work on the Table. The Wardens move by touch and gesture, felt slippers on rock, breath held. Then the echo comes down the canyon: a voice, thin and distant and urgent, bouncing from wall to wall, the same few words over and over, getting louder as it nears, *I will not leave you, I will not leave*

you, I will not, a man's voice from sixty years ago, and the hair stands up on the Wardens' arms, because every time it passes them they must not hear it. Then it enters the mouth of the trap and the clay begins to hum, a low warm buzzing like a jar full of bees, and the felt jacket shivers, and the word goes round and round inside, smaller and smaller, in a voice that grows tinny and frantic, like someone shouting from the bottom of a well, until at the centre it stops with a sound like a thumb pressed into butter. The Wardens say a full trap is warm for a day afterwards. They carry it like a sleeping child.



I will not leave you. Sixty years it went up and down that gorge. We trapped it on a Tuesday. I hope whoever he was meant it. I hope she knew.

ECHO-WARDEN TRACKER'S REPORT, LOW DRAY, 638

RULES

Trapping an echo. Tracking a living echo to its turning-point is Eye + Search at Hard 14 (Grim 18 for an echo older than a century).

D6	THE TRAP FAILS
1	A crack in the spiral. The word goes in and comes out again, faster, angrier, and now it knows what a trap sounds like.
2	The lid slips in the carrying. The word escapes at the bearer's ear, at full voice, as though they had said it. Bound at full Weight.
3	The trap catches the wrong word: one of the Wardens', spoken under the breath at the wrong moment. Now it keeps that.
4	The wax was soft from the sun. The word is pressed in, but blurred: anyone who hears it is bound to something like it, and the GM decides what.
5	The trap takes two echoes at once, and they are pressed together in the nest. The oath that comes out of that wax, if anyone opens it, is a new one that neither speaker made.
6	The word is too old and too large for the nest. The trap fills and bursts on its mounting, and the canyon rings with it from end to end. Every Warden present is bound.

COST AND AVAILABILITY

Echo-traps are **Scarce** and Warden property; a Warden-made trap sold out of the Wardens' house costs **40 lacks** and a bribe. A smuggler's jar-trap is **8 lacks**, Uncommon in the Breakdowns, and holds a word one time in three. A loaded horn with a known oath in it is **Rare**, and its price depends on whose oath it is: from **50 lacks** for a stranger's idle promise to more than a platter a word for a notary's vow.

Setting the trap is Hand + Craft at Hard 14. Each round the work takes in hearing of the echo, every character without ear-stops must make a Caul + Resolve roll at Hard 14 or hear the words and be bound by them, at the oath's Weight (see Oaths in Oathen). Wax and lead plugs give +4 to this roll.

The kept word. A full trap holds one oath. Anyone who puts their ear to an unlidded full trap is bound by it as if they had sworn it, at Weight -1 (minimum 1), and makes a Dread check of that Weight. Breaking the trap on an anvil destroys the word; grinding the wax ensures it.

Loaded horns. Unstopping a loaded horn in a narrow place releases its word as a living echo for 1d6 hours. Everyone who walks through must resist as above. Using one against a pursuer is a Hand + Craft roll at Hard 14 to place it where they will pass.

Building a trap is a Long Task: Hand + Craft at Grim 18, two days a roll, three successes, 25 lacks. Sabotage difficulty Hard 14: a hairline crack in the spiral.

FAILURE TABLE (D6)

HOOK

The Horn on the Market. A loaded horn has turned up for sale in the Gristmoot black market, and the seller says it holds an oath of Jessamy Quill's, caught in the Gullet in her youth. If it is real, and is uncorked in a narrow place, the Company's notary will be bound by something she said at nineteen. The Company wants it bought. Grandam Cess wants it stolen. Jessamy Quill wants to hear it first, privately, with no one else in the room, which is the one thing no one will let her do.

▼ THE WEIGHING SCALES OF SATIED



Heavy hand, heavy vote. Light hand, light supper.

– SATED PROVERB, SAID OF GARRICK TRIPE’S RINGS

LORE AND HISTORY

The **Great Scales** were cast in 261 A.G., a year after the Weighing became law, by the bell-founders of the Chute, from the bronze of every church bell in Sated that had rung for the Gorging. They stand at the centre of the Weighhouse under the dome of glazed bone tiles: an iron beam forty feet long on a knife-edge fulcrum of black steel, with two bronze pans, each large enough to hold a loaded cart. On one pan sits the member. On the other, the city’s standard weights, cast in lead and stamped with the Board’s sheaf, are added by Weighmen with block and tackle until the beam hangs

level. The result is cried aloud and chalked on the great slate, and becomes that member’s vote for a year.

Every Weighing since 261 has been rigged. The Board knows it. The crowds know it. The proverb says that the Scales have never once told the truth and never once been wrong, because the Board has always been exactly as heavy as it needed to be. The present Weigher, **Garrick Tripe**, inherited the office from an uncle and the methods from a long line of Weighers before him, and has elected three governments.

THE DIAGRAM IN WORDS

PART	MATERIAL	FUNCTION	HOW IT IS RIGGED
The Beam	iron, forty feet	balances member against weights	a hollow at the member’s end, filled with shot
The Knife	black steel fulcrum	the pivot	shaved off-true by a hair; favours one side
Member’s Pan	bronze, cart-sized	where the member sits	wetted with dripping; a pan “sweats” pounds
Weight Pan	bronze	holds the standard weights	the weights are short; see below
Standard Weights	lead, stamped with the sheaf	measure the member	hollow-cored “light lead” kept in a second set
The Lever Below	iron rod through the floor	none, officially	a boy in the cellar presses up on the member’s pan
The Slate	slate, chalk	records the result	the chalk-boy is paid too

The Scales are honest in their bones and crooked in every joint. Garrick Tripe’s methods, as recorded in a confession he has written and hidden against the day the Chairman turns on him, are these. **The pockets:** the member’s Weighing-day coat is sewn with lead, at 200 lacks a vote. **The sweat:** the member’s pan is wiped down with hot dripping before the Weighing “for the member’s comfort,” and a thick enough coat adds the weight of a child. **The light lead:** the standard weights have a twin set, identical, stamped, cored hollow and packed with sawdust, which can be swapped in by the Weighmen at the tackle. **The knife:** the fulcrum was re-ground in 588 a hair off-true, so that the beam favours whichever end the Weigher chooses to hang the member from. **The lever:** an iron rod rises from the root-choked cellars beneath the Weighhouse floor to the underside of the member’s pan, where a boy lying on his back in the dark pushes up, or pulls down, on a signal from Tripe’s left boot.

WHO BUILDS IT, WHO USES IT

The Board owns the Scales and Garrick Tripe keeps them, with nine Weighmen, a chalk-boy, and the cellar boy. The cellar boy is always an orphan, because it is cold and wet down there and the roots move. The present one is **Nib**, aged twelve; his predecessor went down one Weighing in 637 and did not come back up, and the roots around the base of the lever are thicker than they were. Chairman

Obb Tullow’s vote, at nineteen hundred pounds, is the only one on the slate that has never been rigged. The Chairman insists on this. He has sent word to Tripe, three years running, that if a Weighing ever goes against him, Tripe will be sitting on the member’s pan at the next one, and Nib will be told to pull.

IN OPERATION

The Weighing is three days of noise and gravy. The Weighhouse is packed to the dome. The members are brought in on drays and lifted onto the pan by tackle and twenty men, while the crowd chants the weights. The beam groans like a ship’s mast. The bronze pan, wiped with dripping, glistens and smells of roast. Garrick Tripe, in his brass-buttoned coat and his twelve rings, walks the length of the beam with his hand on it, *feeling her settle*, he says, and taps his left boot, and far below in the dark a boy lying among warm roots, breathing loam, puts his hands on an iron rod and pushes until his shoulders crack. The beam dips. The crowd roars. The chalk squeaks. Somewhere, a deacon of Low Tilth has lost his vote to a woman who weighs less than her coat.

◇
She weighed nine hundred and four. Her coat weighed three hundred. The Board weighed her twice to be sure, and both times she came out heavier. That's the Scales.

They know what you're worth.

TAVERN TALK AT THE PIE GATE, WEIGHING WEEK

RULES

Rigging the Weighing. Each method adds weight, and votes, at a price and a risk. Pockets add up to a fifth of the member's own weight; the sweat adds $1d6 \times 10$ pounds; light lead adds a tenth; the knife a twentieth; the lever, up to a hundred pounds either way. Arranging each requires Tripe or his people, a fee (see below), and

for the PCs to do it themselves, Hand + Filch or Hand + Craft at Hard 14 (pockets, sweat), Grim 18 (light lead, the knife) or Dire 22 (the lever, without Nib's cooperation).

Detecting the rig. An observer may roll Eye + Reckoning at Grim 18 to notice that the result is wrong; a Helping identifies one method. Proving it before the Board is another matter: Tongue + Clause at Dire 22, and the Board will weigh the accuser.

Under the floor. The cellars are dark, warm, and full of roots that flinch when touched. A character who goes down to the lever must make a Dread 2 check and, each hour below, a Lung + Athletics roll at Hard 14 or be held by the roots (Entangling, Gut + Athletics at Grim 18 to break free). After a full Weighing down there, roll a d6: on a 1 the character has begun to root.

FAILURE TABLE (D6)

D6	THE RIG FAILS
1	A pocket tears on the pan. Lead shot pours across the bronze and rolls, clattering, into the crowd. The member is stripped in public, then fed, then weighed again.
2	Light lead and true lead are mixed up at the tackle. Every member weighed that hour gains or loses a tenth. Three Board seats change hands. Nobody can say why.
3	The cellar boy pushes when he should have pulled. The beam slams, and the member on the pan is thrown. Bailiffs drag Tripe's boot-signals out of him by evening.
4	The knife-edge, re-ground once too often, cracks. The beam drops a foot and stops, perfectly level, by itself, with nobody on it. Dread 1 for the hall.
5	The roots take the lever. It pushes on its own, from now on, at every Weighing, for whoever the Dowager Hills prefer.
6	The Chairman is weighed and the beam does not move. Nineteen hundred pounds of man on one pan, and the city's full set of weights on the other, and the beam level. Then it dips toward the Chairman, slowly, as if pulled from below. He has rooted through the pan.

COST AND AVAILABILITY

SERVICE	COST	AVAILABILITY	NOTES
Lead pockets	200 L	Rare	Tripe; a vote's worth
The sweat	40 L	Scarce	paid to the pan-wipers
Light lead for a member	150 L	Rare	the Weighmen want a cut
The lever	500 L	Rare	Tripe's left boot; and a meal for Nib
A Weighing-day coat	30 L	Uncommon	empty; legal

HOOK

Nib. The cellar boy has stopped coming up between Weighings. He sends his wages up the lever on a string. Tripe wants him brought out before the Grace Weighing, because a boy who will not come up

will not take signals. The PCs go down among the roots and find Nib quite happy, warm and well fed, and sitting on the knee of something in the dark that he calls the old Weigher, which has been teaching him to feel what each member weighs before they are ever lifted onto the pan.

▼ LARK NINEDAYS' PANG-CLOCK



Thirtydays. Twentydays. Fourteendays. Elevendays. Ninedays. I keep the names in a drawer, like gloves I have outgrown.

— LARK NINEDAYS, TO THE TALLY CLERKS

LORE AND HISTORY

Cradlewrack has always timed its pangs, at first with sun-marks and the memory of old women, later with water. The state's first **pang-clock** was a cistern on the Tally-house roof in Kest, built in 420 when the interval was a full season, with a float that fell a finger a day and a bell struck by hand. Lark's mother, **Ide Thirtydays**, inherited the post when the interval was thirty days, and named her daughter for it; when Ide died in 609 she was mortared into the clock's base, a brick at a time, as she had asked, so that she would always be where the count was kept.

Lark rebuilt the clock in 612, around her mother's brick. Her improvement was to let the pang itself strike the bell. The earth's contraction, felt everywhere in the country, sloshes water; Lark mounted a small brass **surge-cup** on the clock's rim, balanced so finely that the slosh of a pang tips it, and the tipping trips the bell. The bell no longer needs a hand. It rings at the instant of the pang, and the float tells her how long it has been since the last. Every time the interval shortens, she grinds the old graduations off the brass ribbon and marks new ones, and changes her name.

THE DIAGRAM IN WORDS

PART	MATERIAL	FUNCTION
The Vessel	copper, tall as a woman	holds the water that falls
The Float	cork in a brass cup	falls as the vessel drains, marking time
The Ribbon	brass strip, hand-graduated in days	the scale the float points to
The Surge-Cup	brass, balanced on a needle	tips at the pang's slosh and trips the bell
The Bell	bronze, a yard across	the loudest thing in Kest
The Mother's Brick	fired red clay, mortared	the base; Ide Thirtydays inside
The Interval Wheel	wood, notched	a notch for every pang since 612

Water drips at a steady rate from the vessel through a narrow brass nipple into a basin. As it drains, the float sinks, and a pointer on it slides down the graduated ribbon. When the pang comes, the surge-cup tips, the bell rings, and Lark reads the ribbon: so many days, so many hours. She notches the wheel. Then she refills the vessel to its mark, resets the cup, and waits. When the pangs begin to fall consistently short of the lowest mark on the ribbon, she grinds it smooth and re-marks it, shorter.

WHO BUILDS IT, WHO USES IT

Lark alone keeps the state clock, and sleeps beside it. Copies of her design are kept in every Attendance hall, every Foundling barracks (General Tibb times his drills to her bell), and the households of anyone who can afford one. Small household pang-clocks are sold in every market in the highlands. They are all, without exception, less accurate than Lark's, because they were not built on a mother.

IN OPERATION

The roof room is bare and cold, and the clock ticks with its drip, a small wet sound like a tap in an empty house. Lark keeps a hand on the vessel when she sleeps. Before a pang the water warms, and Lark wakes. It begins to smell faintly of iron. The surface trembles in fine rings, then in coarser ones; the copper creaks; the brick under it is warm as a cheek. And at the pang the whole vessel bulges, visibly, the copper swelling outward between its bands like a belly, and the water inside goes pink for a breath, and the surge-cup tips with a click, and the bell goes off like a slap across the whole of Kest. Then the copper eases, the water clears, and the drip goes on. Lark notches the wheel with a knife, and if the notch is shorter than the last, she says nothing for an hour, and then begins to grind the ribbon.

◇
The brick gets warm before the water does. I don't write that down. I just put my hand on it, the way you'd put your hand on your mother's arm in the night to see if she's still breathing.

LARK NINEDAYS

RULES

Reading the clock. Anyone may read the ribbon (no roll). Predicting the next pang to the hour is Eye + Reckoning at Hard 14 with Lark's clock or a good copy, Grim 18 with a household clock, Dire 22 without one. Each Helping narrows it further; a Grace gives the minute. Knowing the pang is coming lets a character prepare: re-

stitch old wounds in advance (see Doors and the Body Is a Door), brick in, or be somewhere a crowning is not.

Lark's arithmetic. With access to the Interval Wheel and the old ribbons, Eye + Reckoning at Grim 18 over a day gives the date on which the interval will reach one day. It is in the sealed letter Orla Kest has read once. A character who works it out makes a Dread 3 check.

The brick. Laying a hand on the Mother's Brick before a pang gives +2 to the roll above. Doing so during a pang is a Dread 2 check, because something inside it pushes back.

Building a household pang-clock is a Long Task: Hand + Craft at Hard 14, a day a roll, three successes, 40 lacks. Sabotage difficulty: Routine 10 (it is a pot of water).

FAILURE TABLE (D6)

D6 THE CLOCK FAILS	
1	The drip blocks with silt. The float stops. The clock reads the same hour for a day, and anyone relying on it is caught by the pang.
2	The surge-cup tips at a cart passing. The bell rings false. Half of Kest bricks itself in for a pang that does not come, and the real one finds them in the street.
3	The water goes pink and stays pink.
4	The bell does not ring. The surge-cup has tipped, but the clapper is held, gently, as though by a small hand.
5	The vessel bulges and does not ease. In a week it bursts, and what is found in the basin is the length of a forearm and warm.
6	Two pangs. The cup tips once for the earth and once, a little after, for something underneath it, and the gap between them is shorter than the interval. Lark has heard this twice now. She has not ground it into the ribbon. Dread 3.

COST AND AVAILABILITY

Household pang-clocks are **Common** in Cradlewrack at **40 lacks** (see the water clock in the Rim Market chapter), **Uncommon** elsewhere. A pang-bell that rings itself a breath early is 6 lacks. Lark's clock is **Unique**, and it is not for sale, though the Second Table has asked.

HOOK

Lark Sixdays. The interval has shortened again and Lark has not changed her name. She has stopped grinding the ribbon. She has been seen at night with her ear to the brick, talking. The Attendance needs to know the true interval, and sends the PCs to read the clock while she sleeps. The ribbon has been marked, in a careful new hand, with a single graduation near the bottom. Beside it, scratched into the brass, is a name she has never used, and it has no number in it.

▼ LUNG-LINE BREATHER TANKS



The prince will receive you now. Kneel at the glass. Speak slowly. He reads lips. Do not tap.

– USHER'S INSTRUCTIONS, HALL OF TANKS, FATHOMHOUSE

LORE AND HISTORY

By 388 the Lung-lines of the House of Vasht could no longer breathe air for long, and the first prince held court from a glass tank. But a prince must travel, inspect the fleet, appear at the Lowering, review the Netwatch, and visit his estates, and the great tanks of Fathomhouse weigh as much as a ship. The Admiralty's glass-wrights built the first **breather tank** for Prince Corin Vasht in 412: a walking tank, an upright glass coffin full of brine on a wheeled carriage, drawn by eight bearers. He rode in it to the Lowering and back, and lost two bearers on the Mile when the carriage slipped, and was very pleased.

PART	MATERIAL	FUNCTION
Water-helm globe	thick glass, brass collar	holds brine around the head
Neck-seal	oiled leather, tallow, brass clamp	keeps the brine in at the throat
Back-bladder	tarred sealskin, two gallons	the reserve of brine
Feed-pump	brass hand-pump, gut hose	pushes fresh brine into the helm
Bleed-cock	brass tap at the helm's base	lets foul brine out, onto the road
Tank-tender	a person	works the pump, every minute, for life

A Lung-line at the Course breathes water and suffocates in air; the water must be salt and cold and moving, or it fouls with the breather's own sloughed skin and the body's exhalations, which are cloudy. The water-helm keeps it moving. The tank-tender walks a pace behind, one hand on the brass pump, pressing it slowly, a stroke for every breath the wearer takes, pushing clean brine from the bladder into the helm while the bleed-cock lets the foul water dribble out at the collar and down the wearer's chest. The bladder is refilled at any salt basin or from the bailing of the household. Carriage-tanks are the same, larger, with four tenders and a cistern-cart behind.

WHO BUILDS IT, WHO USES IT

The Admiralty's glass-wrights at Fathomhouse make helms and carriage-tanks for the House of Vasht and its cadet branches. Commoners' lung-bags are sewn on Mile Six. **Tank-tenders** are a hereditary servant caste, chosen young, trained in the stroke until it is as steady as a heartbeat, and they wear rubber aprons and never go below the fourth stair. A good tender's family serves one prince for generations. A tender who falters for a minute kills their master; the punishment is to be weighted and lowered into the master's tank, to breathe what he breathes. None have managed it.

IN OPERATION

A Lung-line in a water-helm is a thing out of a nightmare walking in daylight: a grey face in a globe of greenish water, hair drifting like weed, eyes huge and black and unblinking, and the mouth opening

The modern breather is smaller and grimmer. There are three kinds. The **carriage-tank** is a great glass case on wheels for the highest of the House. The **water-helm** is a sealed globe of glass and brass over the head, fed with brine from a back-pack bladder by a hand pump worked by a servant who walks behind; it lets a Lung-line at the Course walk and work in air for half a day. And the **lung-bag** is a simple oiled-leather bag of brine strapped over the mouth and nose, bought by commoners at the Course, which holds an hour.

THE DIAGRAM IN WORDS

and closing slowly, like a fish. Bubbles do not rise; the wearer does not breathe out air. Lips read through glass, words written on a slate. The collar leaks a steady drip of cloudy brine that smells of the bottom of a rock pool, and leaves a white crust of salt on the wearer's coat from collar to hem. The pump wheezes, stroke by stroke, behind. When the brine fouls, it fouls fast: the water clouds from the bottom up, the face inside darkens and swells, the eyes bulge against the glass, the hands go to the collar and scrabble, and the tender pumps faster, and faster, and if the bladder is dry, the wearer drowns in air in front of everyone, slowly, standing up, looking out through clouding water at the people who are failing to save them.



Thirty years I've pumped for His Grace. I hear the stroke in my sleep. If I stop in my sleep, I wake, every time, gasping, because I think it's me drowning.

A TANK-TENDER OF THE CADET HOUSE OF VASHT-ENNOR

RULES

Wearing a breather. A character at the Course with Fathom-Body suffers -1 to all rolls for each hour spent in open air beyond the first, cumulative, until they are immersed (this replaces the core rule while the character is in Brinehollow's dry air and not wearing a breather). A water-helm with a tender removes the penalty for half a day before the bladder must be refilled. A lung-bag removes it for

one hour. While helmed, the wearer cannot speak aloud, is at -2 to Search by sound, and gains +1 Armor to the head.

Tending. A tender must make a Gut + Endure roll at Routine 10 each hour. A failure lets the brine foul: the wearer loses 1 Flesh per round until the tender succeeds or the bladder is changed. Combat, running and fright make the roll Hard 14.

Foreigners. A non-Brinehollower who puts on a water-helm drowns, as anyone would. A Brinehollower at the Taste or Appetite who wears one for an hour makes a Caul + Resolve roll at Hard 14; on a failure, they find it comfortable, and gain 1 Regrowth on a Lack.

FAILURE TABLE (D6)

D6 THE TANK FAILS	
1	The neck-seal fails. Brine floods down the wearer's chest and the globe empties in a minute. The tender must re-seal it with tallow (Hard 14 Hand + Craft) before the wearer drowns in air.
2	The pump jams. The tender must pump by mouth through the hose. The brine tastes of the wearer.
3	The globe cracks. It holds for an hour. Then it does not.
4	The bladder was filled from a basin someone was Called from last night. The wearer is calm, and courteous, and faces west, and asks the tender to stop pumping.
5	The foul brine is not foul. It is thickening, and darkening, and moving of its own accord around the wearer's face, and the wearer is breathing it with every sign of pleasure.
6	The tender falters, from exhaustion or malice, and the wearer drowns in front of the court. Dread 2 for all present. The House will want the tender weighted.

COST AND AVAILABILITY

ITEM	COST	AVAILABILITY	NOTES
Lung-bag	6 L	Common in Brinehollow	holds an hour; leaks
Water-helm with bladder and pump	220 L	Rare	Admiralty glass; noble only by law
Carriage-tank	3 platters	Unique to order	eight bearers and four tenders not included
A tender's service	5 L a day	Uncommon	a hereditary tender cannot be hired; they can be stolen

HOOK

The Prince Wants a Walk. Prince Aurel Vasht, who has not surfaced in nine days, asks the PCs secretly to take him out of Fathomhouse in a water-helm to see the sea, the real sea, at the

Trench edge, once, before he can no longer bear the air at all. His tender, an old woman named Sorrel Cask whose family have pumped for Vashts for nine generations, will come, and will pump. On the road west Aurel stops writing on his slate. In the globe his lips are shaping words in a rhythm the PCs have heard once before, knocked from the bottom of the Headland tower.

THE PANTRY'S RATION SCALES



Four months of grain. Six of winter. I can do it to the day. I cannot do it to the name.

- MOTHER STINT AVERY

LORE AND HISTORY

The **Measure** is older than Wanting. It is a brass balance with a beam the length of a forearm and two shallow pans, and it was brought out of Hallowboard in the spring of 1 A.G. by the survivors of the Refusal, wrapped in a blanket, carried by a girl of eleven named **Meagre Avery** who would not let anyone else hold it. Nobody knows what it weighed before. The Unfed say it weighed out the Host’s bread for the great table, and that it is the one thing from Orrum’s house that they kept. The Abstinent say this is a lie and punish anyone who repeats it. It hangs now from an iron hook

PART	MATERIAL	FUNCTION
The Beam	brass, worn bright at the centre	balances grain against weight
Two Pans	brass, shallow, dented	one for grain, one for weight
The Hook	iron, set in the ceiling beam	hangs the Measure; eight notches cut in it
Public Weights (nine)	lead, stamped with the Decline	the true measure, shown to the Line
Stint’s Weights (fourteen)	lead, unstamped, in a felt-lined box	the short measure; one for each list-village
The Ledger	bound paper, back to 41 A.G.	every ration, by name, by day, by weight

Stint Avery’s private weights are fourteen lead discs, each a little lighter than the true half-ration, each scratched with the name of a village and kept in a felt-lined box under her apron. When a list-village’s carter comes to the iron door, she weighs out their measure with that village’s weight. The furthest are lightest. The oldest are lighter. The ones with fewest children are lightest of all. The difference between the true weight and each private weight is a matter of grains: a pinch, a spoonful, a crust. Across a winter, across fourteen villages, it is the difference between four months of grain and six. She shaves the weights herself, with a file, by lamplight, after the Line has gone, and weighs the filings, and writes them in a column in the back of the Ledger that nobody else reads.

The lightest weight is marked *Avery Steading*.

WHO BUILDS IT, WHO USES IT

Only the Keeper of the Pantry uses the Measure, and only Stint Avery has the second box. Forbear Wend knows there is a list but not that there are weights; he believes the list is of names to be omitted entirely, and he prays over it, and Stint Avery has not corrected him, because a short measure keeps more people alive than an omission and she cannot bear his prayers. Two Pantry clerks suspect. One Crumb-Runner, Tarry Moss, who counts his cargo to the bean, knows exactly how much grain goes in and how much is handed out, and has done the subtraction.

IN OPERATION

The Pantry’s ground floor is cool, dim, and smells of dust, sacking, and mouse, which to an Unfed nose is the richest smell in the world.

in the cool dark of the Pantry’s ground floor, and every ration in the Fast has been weighed on it since 41 A.G.

The public weights are a set of nine lead discs, stamped by the Abstinent with a hand held up, palm out: the Decline. Every Unfed child is shown them once, so they know the measure is true. They are true. **Mother Stint Avery**, Avery’s descendant and Keeper of the Pantry, uses them every morning in front of the Ration Line.

She also has a second set.

THE DIAGRAM IN WORDS

Grain whispers from the scoop into the pan. The beam dips, rises, hangs level, trembling. Stint Avery watches it with her whole face. The Line watches her. Nobody speaks; the only sound is the grain and the small creak of the hook. When a list-village’s carter comes in at the end of the day, alone, she takes the felt box out of her apron and chooses the weight by touch, without looking, the way you choose a coin in your pocket, and the grain falls, and the beam hangs level, and it is a lie, and it is the only kindness the arithmetic will allow. The carter cannot tell. Over the winter the people of that village will grow a little thinner, and a little colder, and the old will die a week or two sooner than they would have, and nobody will be omitted, and nobody will walk to the Lean House, and the Seated on the valley road will wave.

The hook has eight notches in it. Seven are worn smooth. The eighth is sharp, as if nothing has ever hung there.

◇

*It is not cruelty to weigh short. It is arithmetic.
Cruelty would be weighing true until the grain ran
out, and then nothing.*

FROM THE BACK OF THE PANTRY LEDGER, IN STINT
AVERY’S HAND

RULES

Detecting the short measure. A character watching the weighing may roll Eye + Reckoning at Grim 18 to notice that the list-village weights are unstamped; weighing a private weight against a public one on any honest scale reveals it at once. Working out the scheme

from the Ledger’s back column is Eye + Reckoning at Hard 14 and takes an evening.

Living on the short measure. A Pantry measure is half a ration. The short measure is less: a character on it gains +1 Pang every **three** days instead of holding steady (see Pangs: Starvation). Over a six-month winter, an Unfed village on the short measure loses its oldest, about one in ten. On a true measure until the grain ran out, it would lose half.

Exposure. Revealing the private weights to the Ration Line is a Tongue + Persuade roll at Hard 14 to be believed. The Line will riot (see Madness in the Community); the Pantry’s grain will be distributed true for six weeks and then run out, and the Lean House will fill. A PC who causes this and then sees the Lean House makes a Dread 3 check.

FAILURE TABLE (D6)

D6 THE MEASURE FAILS	
1	A clerk swaps a private weight for a public one by mistake. One village gets its true half-ration for a month, and another goes on the list to pay for it. Stint chooses which.
2	The felt box is dropped in front of the Line. The weights roll out across the flagstones, each with its village’s name scratched in.
3	A weight is shaved too far. A hamlet’s oldest begin to walk west.
4	Stint’s hands, at last, refuse. She stands holding the Avery Steading weight over the pan and cannot put it down. Someone must decide for her.
5	The beam hangs level before the grain is poured. Something is already in the pan, unseen, weighing exactly a ration. The grain poured on top of it comes out warm.
6	One morning there is a fifteenth weight in the box. It is not shaved. It is heavier than a ration by a great deal, smooth and warm as bread, and it is marked, in brown ink the colour of gravy, <i>Wanting</i> .

COST AND AVAILABILITY

The Measure and Stint’s weights are **Unique**. Common ration scales are **12 lacks** anywhere on the Rim; Fast-made ones, with the Decline stamped on the beam, are **4 lacks** in Wanting and are honest, which no buyer abroad believes.

HOOK

The Back Column. Tarry Moss has done the subtraction and asks the PCs to check it, because he cannot believe it and cannot say it aloud. The PCs find the weights, the column, and the name *Avery Steading*. Then they must decide whether to tell Avery Steading. When they get there, the villagers are thin and cheerful and grateful for the Pantry’s fairness, and have laid a little extra on Stint Avery’s mother’s grave as thanks: a crust, saved from their own short measure.

THE FOLLOW



She is not a ship. A ship comes back. She is a question with rivets in it.

– DAGNA HULL, SHOUTING, AS SHE DOES

LORE AND HISTORY

The *Follow* is Dagna Hull’s answer to the sea leaving: an iron vessel built to chase the water down into the Trench and come back to say where it is going. She began it in 636 after a pressure day burst every port-glass on Mile Nineteen and the water was lower at noon than at breakfast. The Admiralty funded it through Commodore **Lysander Vell**, who calls it a sounding vessel for the fleet’s return. Nine hundred people have chalked their names on the wall of her

shed as volunteers. Someone loosens a dozen of its rivets every week, and the marks on them are the marks of Dagna’s own hammer, struck backward. It has been nearly finished for a year.

THE DECK PLAN IN WORDS

The *Follow* is a riveted iron egg forty feet long and fourteen feet across at the widest, lying on its side in a timber cradle in a slip at the end of the Mile. Its skin is plate iron three fingers thick, overlapped and riveted in courses like the scales of a fish, with eight round glass

ports a hand thick set in brass collars. Beneath, a weighted keel of cast lead. Above, a tarred sailcloth **air-bladder** the size of a barn, deflated and folded in a net cage, which is filled from bellows at the surface to float the vessel and let out by a valve, from inside, to sink it; to rise, ballast is dropped and the bladder refilled from a bank of pressed-air bottles. It has one deck and three compartments, entered by a single hatch at the top, sealed with a wheel-lock and a gasket of tallowed leather.

The forward chamber, called the Eye, is the observation room: a curved bench facing four of the eight ports, a sounding-well (a sealed tube through the floor through which a lead line can be let out and drawn back without letting the sea in), the depth-glass (a mercury column in a brass case, graduated in fathoms by Dagna's hand down to a mark she has labelled *Here I stop writing*), and a lamp-box of whale-oil lanterns burning behind glass. It smells of oil and cold iron.

The midships chamber, the Works, is the heart: the valve-wheel for the bladder, the ballast-releases (six iron levers, each dropping a pig of lead), the air-bottles in a rack, the bellows for the cabin air, a sand-glass, a log-slate, a hand-pump for bilge, and Dagna's hammer

on a hook. Two bunks fold from the walls. A bail-trough runs along the floor for the crew's tides.

The aft chamber, the Stores, holds water, biscuit, salt fish, rope, a spare gasket, a medicine chest, and a bulkhead behind which, according to Dagna's drawings, there is nothing but the lead of the keel. Commodore Vell's annotations, in a neat red hand on her plans, say otherwise.

The secret hold lies behind that bulkhead, between the Stores and the stern plating: a narrow iron room eight feet deep, reached by a panel that unbolts from inside the Stores. Dagna did not draw it. Vell's own riveters built it in a week while she was ill in the Lack of 640. It is lined with lead. It holds four barrels of salt, a rack of flensing knives of grey bone each marked with a course-name, a set of butcher's saws, a folding table, a lead box that weeps cold water, and a rail of iron meat-hooks bolted to the ceiling. There are eight hooks. Seven are tagged in red ink: *Fish*, and six names of other courses. The eighth tag is blank. The hold is for carving.

THE CREW ROSTER

POST	WHO	WHAT THEY WANT
Master and pilot	Dagna Hull	to see where the water goes, and come back to say
Mate and riveter	Hollis Brine	to go down and never come back; and to stop her going
Sounding-man	Hask Tarn, if he will	to call the depth; he has said <i>maybe</i>
Admiralty observer	Commodore Lysander Vell	to carve a god at the bottom of the Trench
Vell's men (three)	Second Table Scullions	wages; they do not know what the hooks are for
Volunteers' place	one name from the wall	chosen by lot; nine hundred hope; four want to know

The *Follow* carries six. Dagna intends the sixth place to be drawn by lot from the wall. Vell intends it for one of his own. The PCs may fill any place: Dagna will take divers, a pilot, or a strong back; Vell will take anyone who does not ask about the Stores.

THE LAUNCH CHECKLIST

PINNED INSIDE THE HATCH OF THE FOLLOW, IN DAGNA HULL'S HAND, CHALK ON SLATE. TO BE READ ALOUD, SHOUTED, AND ANSWERED, BEFORE EVERY DESCENT.

- Rivets. Count the lowest seam. Count it again. Count it with me watching.
- Gasket. Tallow it. Press it. Look at it in the lamp. No dry patch.
- Ports. Eight. Wipe each. Knock each with the knuckle. It should ring, not thud.
- Bladder. Full. Cage net tight. Valve shut, lashed, my knot.

- Ballast. Six pigs. Six levers. Each lever tried and returned.
 - Air bottles. Twelve. Each hisses. Each shut.
 - Lamp-box. Lit. Spare oil. Spare wick. Spare flint.
 - Line. Forty fathoms, marked. Second line, four hundred. Third line I do not talk about.
 - Bail-trough. Clear. Everybody bails before the hatch shuts. Everybody.
 - Ropes. Each of us roped to the ring by the Works. My knots. Hollis checks mine. I check his.
 - Names. Say your name. Say where you are going. Say: and back.
 - Hatch. Wheel it shut. Lock it. Tap it twice for luck.
 - Last: Nobody touches the valve but me. If I am not able, nobody touches it at all.
 - (scratched under, smaller, in another hand)
 - Stores bulkhead: do not knock on it.

WHO BUILDS IT, WHO USES IT

Dagna Hull and forty riveters from the slum Miles built the *Follow*; Vell's men built the hold. Hollis Brine, Dagna's apprentice and the first name on the wall, loosens the rivets at night with her own hammer, taken from beside her sleeping hand, weeping, because he knows from Nerys Colm's invitation that there is no coming back from the deep places, and he wants to go more than anything, and he will not let Dagna go there. Mother Limpet wants to bless it. Four hundred of the nine hundred are Deepening.

IN OPERATION

Inside, the *Follow* is a cold iron throat lit by whale-oil. Every sound rings. The crew sit roped to the ring, knees touching, breath fogging. When the valve opens there is a long roar as the bladder empties overhead, and the egg tilts, and lurches, and drops, and the ports go green, then grey-green, then black. The iron begins to talk: ticks, groans, a long low moan from the lowest seam as the pressure takes it. The air thickens. Ears pop, then bleed. The Brinehollowers' chests fill, all together, out of turn, and they bail into the trough with the iron ringing around them. At the ports, things come up to the glass out of the black and look in: pale, ribbed, too many eyes or none, and at depth, faces, the calm courteous faces of the Called, drifting upward past the ports in their nightshirts, looking in at the lamp with polite interest, and one of them always knocks. On a pressure night in the slip, the iron hums a single note, and the nine hundred come to the shed in silence, and stand.



I wrote her the question: what is at the bottom? She wrote me back one word. I've had it framed. I look at it before I go in to work.

DAGNA HULL, OF NERYS COLM'S LETTER, WHICH SAYS *DON'T*

RULES

The vessel. The *Follow* has 60 points of Hull (treat as Flesh for the vessel) and Armor 6 against blows. Each hundred fathoms of descent past the first, the pilot rolls Eye + Reckoning at a difficulty that starts at Routine 10 and rises one step every hundred fathoms. A failure costs 1d6 Hull as seams strain. At 0 Hull the vessel floods. Each loosened rivet on the lowest seam (Hollis's work, a dozen a week) costs 1 Hull before launch unless found (Eye + Search, Hard 14, per inspection).

Aboard. Every hundred fathoms, all aboard make a Gut + Endure roll at Hard 14 or lose 1 Flesh to the pressure. Brinehollowers make a Calling roll at every three hundred fathoms, even awake, and their companions may hold them only by the ropes. Seeing the Called at the ports is Dread 2; the knocking is Dread 3. The depth-glass passes *Here I stop writing* at nine hundred fathoms. Below that, the GM decides what the line finds.

Rising. Dropping ballast is automatic; refilling the bladder from the bottles needs Hand + Craft at Hard 14 at depth. The valve may be closed by hand from inside, by anyone, at any time, and once closed against the bottles, the *Follow* cannot rise.

The hold. Finding the panel is Eye + Search at Grim 18. What is inside is Dread 2, and Dread 3 for anyone who understands the hooks. The lead box contains a piece of Dromm's flesh from the Beaching (Taint 3 Regrowth, Brinehollow), which still weeps.

FAILURE TABLE (D6)

D6 THE FOLLOW FAILS	
1	The gasket weeps. A thin jet of black water as hard as a nail across the Works. Hand + Craft at Grim 18 to stop it; each round it runs, 1 Flesh to whoever is in its path and 1 Hull.
2	A port crazes. White lines run across the glass like frost. It will hold for 1d6 × 10 fathoms more.
3	The lamp-box goes out. In the dark, the crew hear the iron, the sea, and the slow, polite knocking, moving round the hull from port to port.
4	A ballast lever will not drop. Someone tied it, with a knot from the Mile.
5	The valve is closed by hand from inside. Nobody admits it. The bottles cannot refill the bladder. The <i>Follow</i> goes on down.
6	The stores bulkhead is knocked on, from the inside of the hold, where nobody is. Then the eighth hook rings, like a bell, by itself.

COST AND AVAILABILITY

The *Follow* is **Unique**. A place aboard is not for sale: Dagna gives one to the PCs, or Vell does, or the lot does. A berth on the wall costs a chalk and a name, and the Mile bets on the draw at 900 to 1.

HOOK

Low Water, 642. If nobody intervenes, the *Follow* makes its trial descent at the Low Water of Carving 642, the very night Finn Undertow's count closes, with Dagna, Hollis and four of Vell's men aboard, and the air-bladder rises to the surface without them, its

valve shut by hand from inside. The PCs can be aboard, or on the surface at the bellows, or in the hold, or on the Headland with Finn,

or at the slip at midnight, when Hollis Brine comes with the hammer one last time and finds them waiting.

▼ TABLEBREAKER AXES



Lamp, plates, legs, top, chairs. Chairs last. Every chair. Every one.

– DECLINE MARSH, TEACHING A NEW AXE

LORE AND HISTORY

The first table was broken with a spade, in 46 A.G., by a boy named **Forgo Hallam**, two years after his neighbours were found seated in their kitchen; he broke a different table, in a ruin, before anyone could sit, and walked home, and was sick, and was praised. For a

century Unfed broke tables with whatever was to hand. Then, in 151, a smith of Wanting named **Abjure Coll** forged the first true **Tablebreaker’s axe**, and wrote down the rite for making it, and every Axe since has carried one made to her rite or has carried nothing.

THE DIAGRAM IN WORDS

PART	MATERIAL	FUNCTION
The Head	grey iron, quenched in snow-water	a broad bit for splitting, a hammer-poll for legs
The Haft	ash from a Rim tree, never a Fast tree	the length of the bearer’s arm and a hand
The Notches	knife-cuts down the haft	one for every table broken
The Wrap	linen, unbleached, bound at the grip	never oiled, never with fat
The Gauze-Ring	iron ring at the butt	ties the Rope-Holder’s tether to the Axe’s belt

A Tablebreaker’s axe is a felling axe with a longer haft and a broad grey head, unpolished, its poll flattened to a hammer for knocking out legs. Nothing about it is beautiful. It is heavy at the head and thin in the throat, so that it bites deep and hates to come out, because the wood of Orrum’s tables is like no other wood: it closes on the blade, gently, the way a hand closes on a hand.

The forging rites, as Abjure Coll wrote them. The iron must come from the Rim, bought, never accepted. It is worked at an outdoor forge on bare ground, because a hearth is offered. It is quenched in snow-water or rain, never in a well, because a drawn bucket is offered. The haft is ash from a Rim tree, cut by the bearer, because Fast wood grows in Orrum’s soil. No fat, oil or tallow touches it, ever; it is waxed, if at all, with beeswax from Cradlewrack. When it is finished it is carried, by the new Axe, to the Barrows below Hallowboard, and laid on the warm grass of the mounds overnight, alone, while the new Axe stands with their back to it until dawn. In the morning the axe is cold. If it is warm, it is not blessed, and must be broken and forged again.

Notch-lore. Every table broken earns a notch, cut with the bearer’s own knife on the evening after, in silence. Notches are cut in rows of nine, from the head down; a full haft holds about four

hundred. A notch cut crooked means the bearer looked at the food. A notch cut twice means a chair was missed. A haft with a notch the bearer does not remember cutting is retired at once and buried in the Barrows: it has broken a table the Axe never saw.

WHO BUILDS IT, WHO USES IT

Three outdoor forges in Wanting make the axes, and the smiths are honoured. Tablebreaker bands of three to six carry them; Old Breakers carry the oldest. Rim buyers want them as curiosities and as weapons against Orrum’s tables abroad, which have been found now at crossroads in three lands.

IN OPERATION

A Tablebreaker band approaches a table blindfolded in loose gauze, with wax in their ears and linen over their mouths, so that the food is a blur and the smell is muffled and the voice that says *sit down, love, it’s still hot* is muffled too. The Sniffer leads. The Rope-Holder holds the tether. The Axe goes in. The first blow is to the lamp, so that the food cannot be seen clearly. Then the plates, which shatter and spray gravy, warm and fragrant, across the Axe’s gauze, and the smell comes through the linen and the mouth floods. Then the legs.

The wood does not splinter like wood. It gives, and sighs, a long sound, like a mother setting down a heavy dish she carried all that way for you. Then the top, which splits along the grain, and inside the grain is warm and pink and smells of bread. Then the chairs, every one, while the Rope-Holder pulls the Axe back by the belt each time they lean toward a seat. When it is done the Axe stands in the ruin, shaking, and the band waits in silence until the smell has gone.



Four hundred and ten notches. One I don't remember cutting. I buried it at the Barrows and it was warm when I set it down.

OLD BREAKER SHUN ELLERY, AT TABLENIGHT

RULES

A Tablebreaker's axe is a weapon: **(5) Brutal, Two-Handed; +4 vs furniture**, as in the Rim Market chapter. A Barrow-blessed axe also ignores any warding of Orrum's tables, and a laid table broken

with one is broken: it will not be found laid again in that place for a season.

Breaking a table takes a number of successful Hand + Blades rolls at Hard 14 equal to the number of places laid plus one. While breaking, the Axe must make an Invitation check each round at the table's strength (Hard 14 for a table seen at arm's length; Grim 18 if a card bears their name); gauze and wax give +2, and a Rope-Holder may haul them back once a round (opposed Gut + Brawl against the table's pull, which the GM rolls at +6). Each table broken gives the Axe +2 Want and 1 Fray.

The notch. A character who has broken 100 tables gains +1 on every Invitation check against a laid table; 400 tables, +2. A character who finds a notch on their haft they did not cut makes a Dread 2 check and must retire the axe.

Forging is a Long Task: Hand + Craft at Hard 14, a day a roll, three successes, 25 lacks of Rim iron and ash, then the night on the Barrows (Caul + Resolve at Hard 14 to keep one's back turned until dawn; a failure means the bearer looked, and the axe is warm in the morning).

FAILURE TABLE (D6)

D6	THE AXE FAILS
1	The blade sticks fast in the table-top, which closes on it like a mouth. Grim 18 Gut + Labor to pull it free; until then, the Axe is standing at an open chair with their hands on the haft.
2	The haft cracks along a row of notches. It will hold one more table.
3	A splinter of the table goes into the Axe's palm and will not come out. It is warm. It smells of bread. Taint 1 Regrowth (the Host) each day it stays in.
4	The Axe broke the table and missed a chair. Nobody noticed until morning, when it is found standing whole in the ruin, pulled out.
5	The axe-head comes off on the backswing and flies into the dark. When it is found it is lying on a laid table a mile west, on a folded napkin, at a place set for the Axe.
6	There is a new notch in the haft in the morning, neatly cut, in a hand not the bearer's, and a crumb in it.

COST AND AVAILABILITY

40 lacks, Scarce, from a Wanting forge to an Unfed buyer; Rare and **120 lacks** to anyone else, and the smith will not forge for a Godeater at any price. A Tablebreaker's wedge (+2 to break furniture) is 3 lacks.

HOOK

The Axe in the Window. A Rim pawnbroker in Gristmoot has a Tablebreaker's axe in his window with four hundred notches on it and a card tied to the haft. It is Decline Marsh's. Decline swears it is beside his bed, and it is. There are two of them. The one in the window has one more notch than his, and the card tied to it is in his mother's hand, and says *thank you*.

▼ KEPT-RESTRAINTS



Mittens on the hands. Wire on the jaw. Frame on the neck. Name on the shelf.

– SEAMERS' GUILD SKIPPING RHYME, LASTGATE UNDERCITY

LORE AND HISTORY

Sallowreach has restrained its own for six hundred years, for three reasons: the Hand-lines whose touch has become too strong, the Kept whose bodies are too far gone to hold themselves together, and the criminals of both kinds. The Stitching Laws of 130 A.G. made

falling apart in public a fineable offence and created a trade in braces, binders, wires and frames that is now the Seamers' Guild's second income after thread. The Licensing of 301 made the Hand-lines' touch a sold good, and the lead mitten its lock.

THE DIAGRAM IN WORDS

DEVICE	MATERIAL	FUNCTION	WORN BY
Lead mittens	sheet lead, lambskin lining, padlocked cuff	block a Hand-line's touch	Hand-lines in the Course; Osric Vane
Appetite mittens	wool and wire	stop compulsive closing	Hand-lines at the Appetite
Jaw-wire	silver or iron wire, cork pads	holds a dropping jaw shut, or a biting one	Loose Kept; criminals; screamers
Quiet-wire	iron wire through the lips	Court sentence for the noisy dead	the Kept of Lastgate's lower courts
Neck-frame	iron hoops, leather, brass screws	holds up a head whose neck has rotted	Loose and Ruinous Kept
Shelf-collar	iron, chained to the Loft shelf	holds the Set-Aside on their shelves	the Lofts

Lead mittens are buckets of sheet lead a finger thick, shaped to a fist, lined with lambskin, closing at the wrist with a hinged cuff and a padlock whose key is held by someone else. Lead is the only thing through which a Closing touch will not pass. Osric Vane's are the largest ever made, because his nine-jointed fingers are a span and a half long; they weigh thirty pounds each, and the floors of his wing at Glovehall are scored with the marks of him dragging them. **Jaw-wires** are a Seamer's craft: a loop of wire passed under the cheekbones and around the jaw, padded with cork, twisted tight at the temple, so that a Kept whose jaw muscles have rotted can keep their mouth closed in company. A tight jaw-wire also stops a biter, and the courts use it, as the **quiet-wire**, through the lips, on Kept sentenced for screaming at the living. **Neck-frames** are three iron hoops at collarbone, throat and jaw, joined by sliding rods and brass screws, so that a head whose neck has gone to string can be held upright and turned by hand.

IN OPERATION

Lead mittens are cold, heavy, and always faintly damp inside from the hands' own chill. The arms of a long-time wearer are thick at the shoulder and wasted at the wrist; the padlock rattles against the lead at every step. When the mitten is unlocked, the smell that comes out is of damp stone and lamb's wool and something like an empty room. The jaw-wire squeaks when a Kept speaks through it, the words forced out between locked teeth; the cork pads go black with seepage and must be changed weekly. The neck-frame creaks when its wearer turns, and a well-fitted one lets a grandmother nod at a dinner party with only a faint ratcheting sound from her collar. In the Lofts, nine storeys of shelf-collars clink on their chains all night, a sound like a vast slow wind-chime, and on feast days the families

who come to read aloud must unscrew them, so they can turn the old heads to look at them.



*He asks me to unlock them, very politely, every visit.
He says he'd only use them on the enemy. I ask him
who the enemy is. He says, whoever you like, Corrow.*

LADY CORROW VANE, OF HER BROTHER'S MITTENS

RULES

Lead mittens block any Closing touch completely. As a weapon they are (3) **Stunning** (see the Rim Market chapter); while wearing them, a character is at –4 to any Hand roll needing fingers. Removing locked mittens without the key is Hand + Filch at Grim 18, or Gut + Labor at Dire 22 to tear the cuff. A Hand-line at the Course who wears them for a month gains 1 Hunger a week; at the Brink, the lead begins to grey and cool and, over a year, to finish: it pits, and flakes, and must be replaced.

Jaw-wire gives a Kept character no penalty in company (the Rot track's Persuade penalty is reduced by 1) but –2 to any speech roll. A biter in a tight jaw-wire cannot bite. Fitting one is Hand + Stitching at Routine 10.

Neck-frame lets a Kept at Rot 5 or more act without shedding the head on exertion (ignore head results on What Comes Loose). It counts as Armor 1 for the neck, and is Noisy.

Shelf-collar. A Set-Aside body in a collar cannot be moved without the Warden's key; Marrow Jack's boys carry bolt-cutters.

FAILURE TABLE (D6)

D6	THE RESTRAINT FAILS
1	The padlock on a mitten has rusted shut in the fen’s weep. The wearer cannot be unlocked even by the keyholder; the cuff must be sawn, and the saw passes close to the skin.
2	The lead has worn thin at the fingertip. Something the wearer was touching, a candle, a conversation, a cat, ends.
3	A jaw-wire snaps mid-sentence. The jaw drops to the chest and stays there, and the rest of the sentence is said anyway, from somewhere lower.
4	A neck-frame screw slips. The head turns all the way round, slowly, with a ratchet sound, and goes on talking to the room behind it. Dread 2 for the dinner party.
5	The mittens are off. Nobody unlocked them. The padlocks are lying open on the floor, neatly, side by side, and the keyholder has the only key in their pocket, and is very cold.
6	A whole row of shelf-collars in the Lofts unlocks at once, at the stroke of midnight. Forty of the Set-Aside sit up on their shelves in a long row, and turn their framed heads, and say the same word.

COST AND AVAILABILITY

ITEM	COST	AVAILABILITY	NOTES
Lead mittens, a pair	25 L	Scarce	padlocks extra; Osric’s cost 400
Hand-line mittens (wool)	8 L	Common	Appetite only
Jaw-wire, silver	6 L	Common	iron 1 L; fitting 2 c
Neck-frame	18 L	Common	Seamers’ Guild; adjusted yearly
Shelf-collar and chain	4 L	Uncommon	Loft-Wardens only, officially

HOOK

The Key. Lady Corrow Vane keeps the only key to her brother’s mittens on a chain around her neck, under her gloves. It has been

stolen while she slept. The PCs are hired, quietly, to find it before Osric learns. Osric already knows. He has asked his guards, politely, to tell whoever has it that he is not angry, and that he would like very much to shake their hand.

▼FOUR FURTHER ENGINES

The devices above are the famous ones. These four are less well known, and more often met in the cellars where Guests should not be.

THE CUTWRIGHT'S READING FRAME



Blood is a ledger. We only read it aloud. We do not always read it to you.

– LINEMAN’S SAYING

Lore and history. Before 470, Cutwrights read Cut by taste, calipers and the ledgers, and argued about it. In 471 a Lineman named **Ottery Vane-Sallis**, a Sallowreach cousin of the Vanes, built a frame that let blood read itself. Every Copyist who enters the

College at Quire now bleeds into one, and the result is entered in the Master Concordance.

The diagram in words. A standing frame of black walnut the height of a man, like a narrow loom. At the top, a silver funnel with a lancet beside it. Below the funnel hang seven panes of silk,

stretched taut in silver rings one above the other, each a different weave, from coarse sacking-silk at the top to a silk so fine it is nearly air at the bottom; each is dyed with a reagent from one land (vinegar from Sallowreach, drip from the Fatlands, bail-brine, rouse, Cradlewrack clay-water, Oathen ink, and, at the bottom, Fast rain). Blood is let into the funnel. It soaks down through the silks. Ordinary blood stains the top two and stops. Godsign carries it further, and each land's god pulls it toward its own silk, where it spreads in a figure: a hand, a sheaf, a wave, an eye, a door, a tongue. How far down the blood reaches is the Cut. What shape it makes is the line. At the bottom of the frame, under the seventh silk, there is an eighth ring, empty, and the College will not say what it was for.

In operation. The blood creeps down the silk slowly, by capillary, like ink in a wet page, and as it nears its land's pane it

quickens and branches. A Hand-line's blood makes a grey hand on the vinegar silk, with too many joints; a Vasht's soaks the brine pane and drips back upward. Cutwrights watch in silence, holding silver spoons. The room smells of hot iron and reagents. The frame is warm afterwards.

Rules. A reading takes an hour and a cupful of blood (1 Flesh). Eye + Lore at Hard 14 reads the subject's Cut and line exactly; each Helping reveals one ancestor's secret (a bastardy, a foreign god, the seasoning of an Unfed, a Tenanted grandparent); a Grace gives the decade in which the subject's line can be expected to reach the Course. The frame gives a court-binding certificate of Cut in any land. A Blank's blood soaks no further than the first silk and, on a Grace, a little way into the empty eighth ring, where there is no silk at all. Dread 2 for the Cutwright who sees it.

D6	THE FRAME FAILS
1	A silk tears. The blood runs down to the floor and soaks a figure into the boards that nobody can read.
2	Two lines are shown: the subject's, and a second, faint, that is not theirs. Someone is wearing them.
3	The reagents have spoiled. Every reading for a week is a Scrapling's. Three inheritances change hands.
4	The blood goes on creeping after the reading, slowly, overnight, and in the morning has reached a pane it should not have.
5	The blood creeps back up into the funnel.
6	The eighth ring is stained in the morning, though there is no silk there, in the shape of a chair.

Cost and availability. Rare; College property; a reading costs **50 lacks** from a Cutwright, **10** to a Copyist, and is free, and compulsory, at Quire. A stolen frame fetches **2 platters** from the Second Table, which uses them to choose its meals. Sabotage difficulty Grim 18.

Hook. A Lineman at Lampwick Halt has read a PC's blood for a marriage contract and quietly offered to sell them the result, because the shape on the silk was not any land's.

◇

*I read four thousand bloods. I never once saw the
bottom ring stained. Then I saw it twice in a week,
both from children of the Rim.*

CONFESSION OF A CUTWRIGHT OF QUIRE, SEALED
BY THE ARCHPROVOST

THE SECOND TABLE'S CARVING BOARD



It worked once.

– INSIDE EVERY SIGNET RING OF THE SECOND TABLE

Lore and history. The Second Table has collected knives for two hundred years. In 588 a Carver of the Fatlands chapter commissioned a table to use them on: a carving board for a god. It has been copied since. There are believed to be five, one in each of the Table's strongest chapters: under Dame Marrable's Unending Dinner, in the Height of the Vigil, at the Court in Lastgate, in the Admiralty at Lowmark, and on the Rim.

The diagram in words. A long table of black oak, thirty feet, in nine hinged sections so that it can be folded and carried on three wagons. Its top is channelled like a butcher's block: grooves run from the centre to the edges and down into copper gutters, so that what is carved upon it drains into seven numbered copper basins, one at each of seven places. Each place has a chair of grey bone, a set of grey-bone knives bearing a course-name, and a silver fork with two tines. At the head is a carving station with a windlass, hooks and

saws for jointing something very large. At the foot is an eighth place, set, with no knives, and a chair that is pushed in.

In operation. In practice dinners the board is used for lesser things: the fruit of a Seated hill, the grey fingertips of a Hand-line, caul, a lidless eye. The gutters run with juices that do not smell like any meat; the copper basins warm without fire. The members eat in silence, veiled, and write in notebooks. The bone chairs creak like old men. Nobody looks at the foot of the table.

D6	THE CARVING GOES WRONG
1	The gutters back up. The basins overflow onto the diners' laps, warm.
2	One of the knives will not come out of what it was cutting.
3	What is on the board is not finished being alive.
4	A diner's basin fills with something they did not eat.
5	The board's hinges unfold by themselves in the night. In the morning it is set for eight.
6	Someone has eaten from the eighth place. The plate is clean.

Cost and availability. Not sold. The Rim chapter paid **forty platters** for its board, in 626.

Hook. The Rim chapter's board has been stolen, on its three wagons, from a manor near Gristmoot. The Second Table hires the PCs, through cut-outs, to recover it without knowing what it is.

Rules. The board is the key to a Second Table chapter. Finding one is the end of an investigation (Unique). Eating from it is Taint 3 Regrowth of whatever god was carved; doing so as a Taster or above gives +1 Rank in the Table's ledgers and a notebook entry the members will use against you. A character who sits in the eighth chair, or pulls it out, makes a Dread 4 check, and the GM notes it, and says nothing.

The wagons are found on the road to the Fast, abandoned, with the horses unharnessed and grazing, and the board unfolded in the field beside them and laid, beautifully, with a white cloth.

THE BRINEHOLLOW ANCHORING BED



Tie your own knot. Then check it. Then let someone you love check it.

– ADVICE GIVEN TO EVERY CHILD ON THE MILE

Lore and history. Rope can be cut. In 455, after a winter of cut ropes on Mile Four, a ropewalk master named **Calloway Tench** built his wife a bed that could not be cut out of, and when she was Called anyway, he built a better one. The **anchoring bed** is the result of two centuries of such improvements, and every well-off household on the coast sleeps in one.

The diagram in words. An oak box-bed bolted through the floor to the joists, with iron rings at its four corners. The sleeper wears an anchoring harness of tarred webbing; its four straps clip to the rings by spring-hooks. The cleverness is the **ratchet-drum** under the bed: the straps run through it, and every movement of the sleeper toward the edge of the bed winds the ratchet one tooth tighter, so that the more the Called struggle, the tighter they are held. It releases only with a key on a cord around the neck of whoever sleeps in the other room. A tide-gauge on the bed-post, a glass tube connected to the cellar's indoor tide, rings a little bell at the turn so the household wakes to bail.

In operation. A Called sleeper in an anchoring bed does not wake. They rise against the straps, eyes open and dark, faces calm, and walk in place, and the ratchet clicks, and clicks, and clicks, all night, tightening, and the sleeper keeps walking with great patience until the webbing creaks and the bed groans on its bolts and the skin under the straps is rubbed raw and then rubbed to the bone. Families listen to the clicks through the wall. They count them. By dawn the Called lie still, wrapped so tight in their own harness that they must be cut out of it, bruised black from hip to shoulder, and they thank you, and ask for their rope.

Rules. A sleeper in an anchoring bed cannot walk on a Calling night: failing the Calling roll means they struggle all night, losing 1d6 Flesh by dawn and gaining 1 Fray. On a Lack, they lose 2d6 and the GM rolls on the failure table. Anyone in hearing of the ratchet makes a Dread 1 check, Dread 2 if they love the sleeper. Sabotage difficulty Hard 14.

D6 THE BED FAILS	
1	The ratchet jams tight. The sleeper must be cut free before the straps crush them (Hand + Craft at Hard 14; 1 Flesh per failed round).
2	The key is gone from the cord. The key-keeper was walking in the night too.
3	A spring-hook straightens. One strap free. The sleeper is found in the morning with one arm stretched toward the window as far as a shoulder can go.
4	The bed's bolts have been loosened from below, in the cellar, by somebody standing in the indoor tide.
5	The sleeper walks so long that the floor wears through under the bed, and the whole thing hangs from its bolts over the cellar water.
6	The bed holds. The sleeper does not. In the morning the harness is still buckled, tight, and wet, and empty.

Cost and availability. 45 lacks in Brinehollow, Uncommon; the poor sleep roped to a single ring for 2 lacks. Abroad, Vigil dealers sell them, unaccountably, to the customers of Rook Quarter-Bell.

Hook. A Wreckwife has asked the PCs to sit up with her through a Calling night and listen to her husband's ratchet, because she has

counted the clicks for a year, and they spell something.

THE JAR-SHELF OF THE JAR ROOM



Not to be closed under any license.

– THE RED SECOND LABEL ON THE JARS OF UNLICENSED CLOSERS

Lore and history. The Jar Room was built under the Hall of Hands in 304, three years after the Licensing, when the Court needed a sentence worse than death in a land where it alone sold death. The shelf is a single piece of engineering, a thousand feet long, built by the Seamers' Guild and maintained by the Court's **Jarwrights**, a hereditary office of four families who are not permitted to marry outside it.

The diagram in words. A shelf of slate slabs on iron brackets, running the length of a low brick vault, in two tiers: heads above, hands below. Each jar is thick green glass, its mouth sealed with a lead cap crimped by a press, and a waxed label. The **pickle** is the Court's own recipe: vinegar, alum, honey, lacquer-spirit, and a secret ingredient the Jarwrights say is grief. Under the shelf runs a stone gutter and drains. Above it, a brass rail carries a little wheeled **turning-cradle**, which a Jarwright runs along the shelf once a day to lift each jar, turn it a quarter, and set it back, so the faces inside do not settle against the glass and rot where they touch. Treason jars are turned to face the wall.

In operation. The vault is cold and green-lit, and the air is sharp with vinegar and sweet with honey and, under both, the smell of meat that has been in a pickle for three hundred years. The heads float with their hair rising. The hands on the lower tier tap at the glass. When the turning-cradle comes down the rail, rattling, every eye on the shelf rolls toward it, and the hands go still, waiting their turn, and as each jar is lifted the face inside it speaks, silently, a word the Jarwright has learned not to read.

Rules. Seeing the Jar Room is Dread 2; being sentenced to it is Dread 5. A jarred head can be questioned by lip-reading through the glass (Eye + Search at Hard 14) and remembers everything. Unsealing a jar without the Jarwrights' press ruins the pickle, and the head begins at once to rot properly, and feel it. Stealing a jar is Hand + Filch at Grim 18 and the theft of a sentence of the Court. A Hush-wax lantern held to a jar for an hour finishes the head inside on a 6.

D6 THE SHELF FAILS	
1	A lead cap weeps. The pickle seeps down onto the hands below, and they begin to soften.
2	The turning-cradle jams. One face has been pressed to the glass for a week, and has begun to grow into it.
3	A bracket gives. A row of jars slides, clinking, to the floor, and the heads roll in the gutter toward the drain, mouthing.
4	Two jars' labels are swapped. A man has been serving a forger's sentence for forty years, and the forger is out on a Closing licence.
5	The hands below have learned to tap in time, and the tapping is a message, and the message is for the Regent.

- 6 A small Hush opens in the vault for one night. In the morning the oldest nine jars hold heads that are properly, finally dead, and peaceful, and the rest of the shelf is weeping. The Court hides it.
-

Cost and availability. Unique. A single green jar and cap from the Jarwrights' stores costs **20 lacks** on the black market in the Sinks, where Mother Gall's rivals use them; the Court's pickle recipe has never been sold.

Hook. Henna Farrow has petitioned for her husband's Closing forty-one times and been refused. She has now petitioned for him to be jarred, which is cheaper and permanent and, she says, would at least let her visit him on a shelf where he cannot come home each evening. The Court has granted it. Her husband has not been told.

He is coming home tonight, as usual, and the Jarwrights are waiting in the kitchen with the press.



*We turn them a quarter each morning, so they don't
settle. They used to thank us. Now they just look.*

Looking is worse.

A JARWRIGHT OF THE FOURTH FAMILY, TO A
VISITING VIGIL ENVOY

CHAPTER 4

HYMNS AND
LULLABIES OF THE
TABLE

Everybody on the Table sings. They sang on the night of the Gorging, all seven peoples, though none of them could hear the others. They sang to keep their hands moving. They are still singing for the same reason.

— BRAM HOLLIN, THE LAST MOURNER, TO A COLLEGE CLERK WHO ASKED HIM WHY THE FEN-SONGS ARE SO LONG

Pencilled inside the lid of a hurdy-gurdy case left unclaimed at the Groaning Board, Carving 638. The instrument inside had nine strings. Two had been cut.

Do not play the Lamb in Lampwick. Do not play the Hauling past Lowmark Spur unless you want to be thanked by a man with wet eyes and no breath. Do not play the Ferrying in the fen, because it will not stop when you do, and you will hear it the whole road south. Do not play a wake-song for anyone who is not dead yet, even as a joke, even for money, ESPECIALLY for money. Do not finish the Kest Count. Do not sign along with an Oathener's poem unless you mean every finger of it. Do not hum the Decline where a chair is pulled out. Do not drink the Second Table's toast when a stranger buys it.

Play the drinking songs. Play the chair song on Tablenight. Play it loud. They will throw lacks.

I made eleven hundred lacks in nine years on this road and I never once played the eighth verse of anything. That is the whole secret of a long career.

This chapter is a songbook. It gathers the hymns, lullabies, work songs, curses and toasts that the peoples of the Table sing over their meals, their dead, their ropes and their beds, and it gives each one in full (or as full as any living singer can give it), with a description of its tune, a short history, and a rule for what happens when a Guest sings it at the table. Some of these songs are sung in every kitchen on the Rim. Some are hanging offences. Several have a verse that nobody sings. The Table is like that: every song on it was written after the Gorging or survived it, and both kinds remember what they were sung over.

The tunes are described in words, the way the Rim's ballad-sellers describe them on their sheets: the meter, the mode, the shape of the line, who sings and how. No notation survives the Long Grace in

any form a Rim fiddler would recognise. Carvers who want to sing at the table should borrow any old tune in the right meter. Every one of these songs was borrowed from something older once.

SINGING AT THE TABLE

Most songs need no roll. A Guest who sings a song from this chapter for its own sake, badly or well, simply sings it, and the Carver describes the room. A song's **effect** (given under *At the Table* for each song) applies when it is sung with intent, in the right place, by someone who knows it.

Knowing a song. A Guest knows the common songs of their own land and any song a player chooses at character creation for 1 point of Lore. Learning a song from another singer takes a scene and a willing teacher. Learning a forbidden song takes a teacher who is willing to hang.

Singing well. When it matters (to sway a crowd, to soothe a wake, to lead a hauling line), roll **Tongue + Rites** at Routine (10) for a familiar crowd, Hard (14) for strangers. Each Helping adds 1 to the song's listed bonus, to a maximum of +2 more. A Lack means the singer has started a verse they should not have, or the wrong one; the Carver chooses which.

Singing together. A company that sings together counts as one singer, rolling with its best voice; any Guest who does not sing along gains none of the song's benefits and pays none of its costs, but may be noticed not singing. On the Table that is often worse.

Songs and Pall. A song sung properly at a rite of mourning counts as that rite for the Pall: it lowers the community's Pall by 1d3. A song that is forbidden, sung publicly in the place that forbids it, raises the Pall by 1 whatever its other effects.



*There is no song on the Table without a verse missing.
If you think you know one, you have not been told.*

RIM BALLAD-SELLER'S PROVERB

▼ THE FERRYING SONG



Six for the living, one for the hum, and nobody knows if the eighth will come.

– FEN CHILDREN'S SKIPPING COUNT

The oldest of the fen-songs and the one every Sallowreacher knows first, before their own name, before *may you finish*. It is sung by eel-catchers when the traps are lifted, by ferrymen on the black water under Lastgate, by Seamers' apprentices bored at the tweezers, and by mothers over the cradle, although it is not a lullaby and every mother knows it is not. It has six verses. The seventh is hummed. Nobody knows if there was ever an eighth.

The Ferrying Song, as sung on the Sump Landing. The first two verses are those printed in every Seamers' primer since 130 A.G.; the rest are given as Bram Hollin sings them, who learned them from a ferrywoman of Dunmere before it went silent.

*Down to the mud with the hook and the pot,
Nine days long and the meat not hot,
Grey as a stone and cold as a well,
And it smiled, my darling, and nobody tell.
Hand for the Grue and hand for the Vane,
Hand to be eaten and never again,
The face to the fen-folk, boiled in the peat,
And it smiled, my darling, and still we would eat.
Down to the mere with the punt and the pole,
Ferry the living and ferry the whole,
Ferry the hanged man who asked to come down,
And it smiled, my darling, as we poled him to town.
Grandmother's sewing and Grandfather's wire,
Never the water and never the fire,
Rot to the elbow and rot to the knee,
And it smiled, my darling, and so must we.
Lift up the trap, love, and count what you've caught,
Eels in the willow as thick as a thought,
Fat on the drowned folk who never lie still,
And it smiled, my darling, and it smiles still.
Pole to the line where the red paint is new,
Over go the living, and over go you,
Never the Kept, love, they'd drop on the shore,
And it smiled, my darling, and asked for no more.
(hummed)*

The tune. A slow, rocking triple time, the beat falling on the dip of the pole, in a minor mode that sits low in the throat and never quite resolves: every verse ends a step above the note it began on, so that the song seems to climb without going anywhere. The verses are sung by one voice, usually the eldest in the boat; the whole boat joins on *and it smiled, my darling*, which is sung softly, almost spoken, with a smile, because it is bad luck not to. The seventh verse is hummed by everyone, mouths shut, on the same climbing figure, and it does not end. In Sallowreach nothing ends. The hum goes on until the singer is interrupted, or hands it on.

History. The first two verses are older than the Stitching Laws and are almost certainly older than the Glad Century: they describe the Meal, the nine days of carving Ossel on the mere, the Hands divided between the great houses, and the face boiled by the far-fen Scraplings. The third verse remembers the First Morning, when the hanged thief at the Lastgate landing asked to be cut down. The fourth and fifth are Keeping verses, sung by the poor, and the sixth is the newest: it names the red line at Fogmouth called the Drop, renewed every Grace, across which the living may go and the Kept may not. Each generation has added a verse and none has added an ending.

Eel-catchers pass the hum from boat to boat across the mere at dusk, like a coal carried in a pot. Among the ferry families of the Sump it is said that one hum has been passed hand to hand since the First Morning and never once let fall, and that Tam Ruddock, the Lastgate Ferryman, is carrying it now: he hums it under his breath while he poles the dying of other lands across the border, and he has not stopped since his father put it in his mouth forty years ago. Grandfather Peat, the bog body from the Sump, does not hum the seventh verse when he is sung the Ferrying Song. He sings it, in his dead dialect, to a different figure with eight notes in it instead of seven, and the Seamers who have heard it say only that it is shorter than the others, and sounds like it is asking someone to sit down.



*My father put the hum in my mouth when I was nine
and said, don't drop it, Tam. I haven't. Some nights I
think it's the only thing in the fen that's still alive.*

TAM RUDDOCK, THE LASTGATE FERRYMAN

At the Table. The Ferrying Song is a song of carrying. Sung in a boat or on the road by a company, it grants +1 to **Wayfaring and Labor** for the journey, as everyone falls into the pole's time. Sung to a Kept person, it calms them as nothing else does: +2 to **Persuade, Stitching or Rites** used on any Kept listener for the scene.

Inside Sallowreach, the song cannot end. When the six verses are done, one of the singers must carry the hum. That Guest hums under their breath, softly, all the time, suffering **-2 to Stealth** and to any roll that needs silence, until they **pass the hum** to another willing singer (who takes it in the same way) or leave the land. Stopping deliberately requires **Caul + Resolve at Hard (14)**; on a failure the hum goes on in the throat anyway, the jaw aching with it, and the Guest gains 1 Fray.

Outside Sallowreach, the hum ends like any other tune. A Sallowreacher who carries the hum across the border and lets it

finish has *closed something* and may treat it as their land's **Sop**: remove 1d6 Hunger, and feel the Hand-god in the blood lean toward the next thing that could be finished. Any Kept Sallowreacher who hears the song finish (from just across the Drop, say) weeps, and asks to be told how it ends, and cannot be told.

Anyone, anywhere, who sings an eighth verse invented at the table hears Grandfather Pear's eight-note figure come back to them from the nearest dark water, in a voice that is not their own. **Dread 2.**

▼ THE LAMB AND THE LID: THE LUDMERE LULLABY



It is said the lambs go first. It does not say where.

– CUTWRIGHT MARGINAL NOTE, REGARD STREET

The lullaby that sang a god to death. In the nine nights that Ludmere spent butchering Iss, four hundred and twelve children stood around the hollow in shifts of forty and sang it, softly, without stopping, so that the god would think itself still safe. It worked. Iss never woke. Three hundred and forty years later, on the First Night, every living descendant of those children went to the long room in their first sleep, whole lines at once, and the Watch made singing the lullaby a crime the following spring. It has been forbidden in the Vigil ever since. Singing or humming it costs a season in the Rattlehouse; a second offence, the Lantern. It was the one song permitted in the city on the days the condemned were Bedded, and since Bedding was suspended in 590 there has been no lawful day for it at all.

The Rattlehouse register of forbidden matter keeps the only copy the Watch permits to exist, and that copy has two verses. The Bedded, whose second rank is called the Hummers, know four.

The Lamb and the Lid. The first two verses as entered in the Rattlehouse register; the third and fourth as sung in a Slope cellar by a Hummer of the Bedded and set down afterward by a Waker who was present, before he was relieved of his post.

*Hush now, lamb, the lid is low,
the long room's warm and the lamps burn slow;
lie you down where the sleepers keep,
and the eye won't open while the lambs still sleep.
Hush now, lamb, and count to three,*

*there's a bed for you and a bed for me;
and when the beds are full, my sweet,
the eye will open, and we'll all go to eat.
Hush now, lamb, the knife is wool,
the bowl is warm and the Lid is full;
nine nights long and the cream is sweet,
and the Lidded won't wake while the lambs still eat.
Hush now, lamb, the lamps are lit,
there's a chair at the end and nobody in it;
and when you wake, my sweet, my own,
(the Hummers hum the last line. They say it has never been
sung, because nobody who knew it was awake.)*

The tune. A cradle-rock in a slow compound time, two dotted beats to the bar, the rhythm of a foot pushing a rocker. It is in the old Ludmere minor, which the Vigil's music-masters call the *drowsy mode*, and every phrase falls. The song is famous for its first three notes: a high note, a lower one, and a lower one still, sung on *bush now, lamb*, falling like a lid. Those three notes are the most dangerous sound in the Vigil. People cross the street rather than hear them whistled, and a tenement where someone hums them will be empty of its Wakers' patience within the bell. The song is sung by one voice, low, very close, almost into the ear; a crowd singing it together, as at the old Beddings, sounds like wind in a chimney.

History. Ludmere's children sang it for the Nine Nights, and were given warm milk between shifts to keep their voices sweet. The tune is older than the Gorging; the words were made for the occasion, and the third verse remembers the felt-wrapped knives and the cream-pale flesh of the god. Since the First Night it has been sung lawfully only at Beddings, by the crowd outside the Dormitory while the condemned lay down; unlawfully it is sung by the Bedded in their cellars, by mothers on the Slope who cannot help it, and by the old Ludmere houses of the Height on the Day of Nine Nights, who hum only the first three notes, over and over, while their eldest carves. Ansgar Wakely, condemned to a Bedding that could not be carried out, has hummed it on the lowest floor of the Rattlehouse for nineteen years.

The fourth verse is the Hummers' secret and their sorrow. Its last line has never been sung, they say, because nobody who knew it was awake. In the Dormitory, Matron Cecily Dorm has written down the words that Aveline Morne, the Sleeper in Bed One, has begun to shape with her lips. The Matron has not told anyone that one of the shapes, repeated night after night, is a line in the cradle-rock meter, and that it begins *and when you wake*.



Don't whistle that. Don't. Not even the first bit. My nan whistled the first bit once, on the stair, and the whole stair yawned, and Mrs Callow's boy went down on the landing and never got up.

A WOMAN OF THE SLOPE, TO A RIM CARTER

At the Table. In the Vigil, the first three notes alone are a scene of comfort: every Vigilant who hears them gains **1 Weariness**, and must make a blink check if already Drifting. The whole song, sung

through, calls for **Caul + Resolve at Grim (18)** from every listener; failure adds **3 Weariness** and an immediate blink check, and a listener at Grey (7+) when the song ends falls asleep where they stand. Vigil-born listeners suffer this wherever they are on the Table, because they have never slept and the song knows it. The singer is not exempt. A Hummer who sings it gains 2 Weariness and must roll like everyone else.

A foreigner who has never been to the Vigil hears only a pretty, sad lullaby, and may use it as any lullaby (the Vigil's own rules count lullabies as comfort for Weariness). Sung to a frightened child or a Guest who has just failed a Dread check, outside the Vigil, it removes **1 Fray**, and the listener dreams that night of a long dim room, warm, with lamps, and wakes rested and uneasy.

Sung in the Dormitory, the song does something else. Every Counted sleeper in earshot falls into its rhythm, sixty thousand chests rising and falling in compound time, and the sound of it is Dread 3. Anyone who reads Aveline Morne's lips while the fourth verse is sung learns the missing line. The Carver decides what it is. It should not be comforting. **Dread 4.**

CARVER'S NOTE: LULLABIES IN THE VIGIL

The Lamb and the Lid is a weapon. A Guest who learns it can put a Waker patrol into a blink, empty a street, or end a chase, at the cost of their own eyelids and a season in the Rattlehouse if they are caught. Let them. Then remind them that the Bedded know the song too, and the Second Table keeps a choir of twelve trained in it on the Height, and that both of those groups want the beds filled. Every time the song is sung in the Vigil, the Carver may roll a d10: on a 1, somewhere in the city, a sleeper is carried to the Dormitory who would otherwise have woken, and the number moves one closer.

▼ THE HAULING SONG OF THE BEACHING



Haul and hold, and do not look.

– THE LONGSLAB HAULING SONG

The great work song of the coast, sung by the starving lines that hauled Dromm ashore on ten thousand hooks, and still sung in the first week of Plenty on the Headland at Lowmark, where the Admiralty parades its dry fleet and the names of the seven Hook-Brides are read with honour. Every family keeps some fragment of it. The six lines printed in the Admiralty primers, and chanted by

schoolchildren in the Mile, are not the song but its **burden**: the refrain sung between verses, one line to each heave on the rope. The song itself has eight verses. The sixth was struck from every written copy before 100 A.G., sometimes scored through so hard the pen went through the page, and on the Headland the crowd hums it.

The Longslab hauling song, entire, as the Sounders of the Deepening teach it on the shell road at Low Water. The burden is sung after every verse. The struck verse is given as the Deepening gives it; the Admiralty denies that this is the verse, and will hang anyone who sings it to prove otherwise.

(Burden) Haul and hold, haul and hold,

the deep is warm and the shore is cold.

Haul and hold, and lean you back,

the Fathom comes for the Lack, the Lack.

Haul and hold and do not look,

there's one of us on every hook.

(I.) Nine winters dry and the nets come thin,

who'll go down and bring him in?

Sounder, Sounder, go you down,

the Fathom's lying off the town.

(II.) Ten thousand hooks from the smokehouse wall,

gaff and anchor, set them all,

set them deep in the plate and slate,

the Fathom's come, and the Fathom's late.

(III.) Cold, it's coming from every seam,

the front ones drown and the front ones dream,

lean you back, though your mouth fill up,

the deep is wine and the shore's a cup.

(IV.) Mam at the front and she's gone to froth,

lay her down on the drying cloth,

take her place and take her rope,

haul for Mam and haul for hope.

(V.) He's on the bar and he won't come in,

the hooks are torn through the slate and skin,

Sounder, Sounder, what's he say?

A keeping wants a keepsake. Pay.

(VI.) Tamsin, Orry, Annick Fell,

Hob and Denet, ring the bell,

Lowdy Kettle, Bran's own son,

tie the knot, and the knot is done;

walk the line to the plates, my sweet,

and we'll sing you in, and then we'll eat.

(VII.) The tide came up a fathom and a half,

the Sounders turned away to laugh,

haul and hold, he's off the bar,

and the brides are where the brides are.

(VIII.) Eight ropes down on the Longslab shore,

seven we hauled, and one hauled more;

don't you count and don't you look,

there's one of them on every hook.

The tune. A heaving song in a heavy two, the stress landing hard on the first beat of every bar, where the whole line leans back on the rope together, and a long silent breath on the second, where they take up the slack. It is in a bright, hard major mode that has nothing of the sea's sadness in it, the mode of men and women too hungry to be sad. The verses are called by a single leader, traditionally a Sounder with bleeding ears; the lines answer with the burden, and a good hauling line can be heard a mile off. On the Headland the crowd sings the burden and the first five verses, then hums the sixth through closed lips (a low, tuneless drone, in which the old people of the coast can be heard weeping), and sings the seventh and eighth very quietly, as if they did not want to be overheard.

History. The first five verses tell the Beaching as the Admiralty teaches it: the empty nets, the Sounders going down, the hooks, the water pouring out of the god so that the haulers at the front drowned standing on dry shingle, and the god grounding on the bar on the third night. The struck sixth names the seven betrothed young people whom the Sounders asked the villages to give, tied each to a hook-line with a lover's knot, who walked out along the lines into the god's gills. The Admiralty's official history says the verse was struck from shame. The Deepening, who claim to have kept it in the mouths of the drowned, give the version above, whose last line says plainly what the Lung-line chronicles took two centuries to admit: that the founders found the seven in the god's lungs, in the dark, and ate them with the rest.

The seventh verse is sung everywhere and understood almost nowhere. Abiah Steep, the Purser's clerk who worked the tides back to the year 0 and was hanged for it in 215, wrote in his last letter that he had first grown suspicious because of the seventh verse: *the Sounders turned away to laugh*. Nobody laughs in a hauling song unless the song is telling you something.

The eighth verse is shorter in older versions and longer in newer ones, and in the oldest copy of all, a scrap of sail-canvas in the Hanging Abbey, it is only two lines: *eight ropes down on the Longslab shore, seven we hauled*. The frieze on the Sounding Hall shows eight lines of haulers, the eighth chiselled flat, its rope still carved running into the god. Children in the Mile skip to the burden's sixth line, *there's one of us on every hook*, and some of them, without being taught, sing it the eighth verse's way.

◇

I've sung it on the Headland forty years. You hum the sixth and you sing the seventh and then everybody goes quiet for the eighth and you can hear the gulls. And every year there's one voice still singing when the rest have stopped. Every year. You never see whose.

A MILE ROPE-MAKER

At the Table. As a work song, the hauling song gives **+2 to Labor and Athletics** on any group task of pulling, hauling, rowing or dragging, and on long tasks it reduces the time per roll by a quarter. In Brinehollow, a line of people singing the burden while hauling back a Called sleeper (with nets, ropes or bare hands) gains **+2** on

the opposed roll; the Called seem, for a moment, to remember the rhythm, and to want to be one of the line.

Singing the burden is lawful. Singing the struck sixth verse aloud in Brinehollow is treason under the Admiralty's law of 215, and something more under the sea's. Every Brinehollower within earshot must make a **Caul + Resolve** check against the pull, **Hard (14)**, or **Grim (18)** on the Uncovered or at Low Water; failure means they turn to face west and stand, and at night they will walk. Every Tenanted person within a mile stops what they are doing, turns their head toward the singer, and listens with an expression of great courtesy. A Lung-line noble who hears it coughs up, with the next bailing, something that is not water, and does not show anyone.

Anyone who sings the eighth verse and is listening for it hears one more voice than there are singers. **Dread 2**, and the Carver notes the singer's name.

▼ THE WAKE-SONGS OF THE FATLANDS



We'll sit at board and say your name, and you'll be what we eat.

– THE BOARD SONG

There are no graves in the Fatlands. The dead are served at the wake, by the family, on the best plates, and every cut has its song. A wake begins at noon on the day after death, with a Bailiff's licence pinned to the door, and runs until the board is bare; the jointer leads the songs as he carves, and the family takes them up with their mouths full, so that a Fatlands wake heard from the lane sounds like a hymn sung under water. A child learns the cut-songs at its grandparents' wakes, and a jointer's apprentice is not let to carve a stranger until they have carved their own grandparent and sung every song over them.

The common wake-song, called **the Board Song**, is sung at the beginning and at the end, and between cuts whenever anyone weeps. It is given first. Then the songs of the cuts, in the order of a wake.

The Board Song, sung across the plains while the copper boils.

Remember, she was soft. Remember, she was sweet. Pass the plate along, along; there's not a bit to waste.

Remember, she was heavy, love. Remember, she was kind. Lick the bowl and crack the bone, there's marrow yet to find.

And when you're in the furrow, love, and when you're in the wheat, we'll sit at board and say your name, and you'll be what we eat.

THE FAT (THE RENDERING SONG)

Sung by the women of the house as the belly goes into the copper, while the fat goes clear; slow, sighing, in time with the bubbles. You start a man at the fat because the fat remembers the fire best.

*Into the copper, my dear, my dear,
the fire's been waiting for you all year;
go clear, go gold, go soft and slow,
and give us the warmth you'll not need below.
Skim off the temper and throw to the dog,
skim off the sorrow, the grudge and the grog;
what's left is the sweetness, what's left is the best,
we'll keep it in crocks and we'll eat all the rest.*

THE HEART (THE ELDEST'S SONG)

Sung by the eldest child alone, while searing the heart in its own fat, and not again in their lifetime. It is the only cut-song sung solo, and the only one in which the singer is permitted to cry openly; everyone else at a wake must cry while chewing.

*You kept me warm, you beat me fair,
you sat up nights at the end of my bed;*

now I'll keep you warm in here,
and carry you on when the board is fed.
Thin as a leaf and dark as a plum,
I'll lay you in scales on the blue-rimmed plate;
whatever I am, it's what you've become,
and I'm hungry, Da. I'm hungry. Wait.

THE HANDS (THE PIE SONG)

For a person who worked with their hands. Sung by the whole kitchen while the crust is crimped. The hands go into a pie with onions and small purple turnips; the singers crimp in time, thumb by thumb.

Hands that dug and hands that hoed,
hands that held the plough and goad,
fold them in and crimp them round,
hands go back to the ploughing ground.
Thumb for the furrow, thumb for the seed,
thumb for the hunger and thumb for the need,
a wheatsheaf of pastry to lay on the lid,
and nobody asks what the fingers once did.

THE LEGS (THE SPIT SONG)

A turning-song for the spit, sung by the children of the house, who take turns at the handle; quick and skipping, the only cut-song that is any fun. Fatlands children sing it at play, turning a stick.

Round and round and round he goes,
crackle on the knee and the knuckle and the toes,
walk to the market, walk to the shore,
he'll never walk to the Weighing no more!
Round and round and spit and spat,
blister on the shin and drip on the fat,
first one to the crackling gets the bit,
and the last one turns the spit!

THE RIBS (THE NEIGHBOURS' SONG)

The ribs are the neighbours' portion, given out at the window to anyone from the lane who has brought bread. They sing it at the sill, holding the rib in both hands, before they eat; it is a song of thanks to the dead for having been good company.

A rib for the lane and a rib for the street,
we never once quarrelled, we always would eat;

you lent me your ladder, I lent you my lard,
and now you're the best thing that's come down the yard.

THE SWEETBREADS (THE JOINTER'S APOLOGY)

The jointer's perquisite, fried in toothed-wheat batter and shared with whoever helped. Sung by the jointer alone, under the breath, while the knife goes in. The great jointer Hob Gristle sings it at every joint and not only this one.

Sorry, old lad. Sorry, old lass.
It's only the knife, and the knife will pass.
I'll take what's mine and I'll give what's yours,
and I'll wash the board, and I'll shut the doors.
Sorry, old lad. I knew your face.
I'll say it again at the next one's place.

THE MARROW (THE BELOVED'S SONG)

The marrow goes to whoever the dead loved best. Everyone at the board sings it, turning to look at that person, who must eat the marrow from the cracked bone while the song is sung to them, without stopping, to the end. It is the most dreaded honour in the south. Where the most beloved is disputed, families have come to blows over who must eat it, and who may.

Who did she love the best of all?
Who did she call for at the end?
Give them the bone and let them eat,
the deepest sweet, the deepest sweet.
Suck it out and suck it clean,
the softest thing she's ever been;
now she's in you, root and stem,
and you'll be served to us like them.

THE BONES (THE FIELD SONG)

The last song of a wake. The bones are boiled for stock, then ground fine and carried out to the family's field the next morning. The family walks the furrows scattering the meal and singing to the field by name, as at a grace, and the field is said to answer.

Long Acre, Long Acre, we bring her to you,
the meal of her, fine as the dust and the dew;
take her and keep her and grow her up green,
and we'll eat her again, as she's eaten and been.
Long Acre, Long Acre, we've given her back,

so stay you away from us, Lack, Lack, Lack.

There is no song for the tongue. In the plains it is eaten last, in silence, by whoever the dead last quarrelled with, so that the quarrel is finished. Hob Gristle says that in forty years of wakes the tongue has never once gone uneaten, and that he has never seen anyone eat it who looked as if they had won.

The tunes. Every Fatlands wake-song is in a bright, warm major, in a steady four-square beat that can be kept with spoons on plates, and most are set to tunes also used for harvest and courting. Foreigners find this the worst thing about a wake. The Fat is a slow sigh; the Heart is the only one in a minor mode, and is half spoken; the Spit Song skips; the Marrow climbs on each line and ends on a long held note while the beloved finishes eating. The Field Song is sung in the open in the early morning, and on still days the people of the plains swear the furrows hum the last line back.

History. The Board Song is old, older than the Wake Ordinance of 131 A.G. that made the eating of the dead the law of the land. The cut-songs grew up through the Sweet Reigns, as the wake became the most sacred rite of the south, and the Renderers' Union printed the canonical set on a broadsheet in 302 which still hangs in every Wakeside kitchen. In the year of the Long Count, the songs began to change in the far villages of Low Tilth. The Field Song acquired a new last line there, *and if you come for us at dusk, take only what is due*, and the Board has twice sent Bailiffs to discover who wrote it and twice been told: the field did.

Marigold Chine, who sings to the oldest grove in the Bleeding Orchards, has heard her trees sing the Marrow, in her own voice, with her own name in it.



The Heart song's the worst. You sing it once in your life, and you're holding your own father's heart in a pan, and you have to sing I'm hungry, and you are. Everybody is listening, because they all sang it once too.

A COOPER OF BARRELSIDE

At the Table. A wake at which every cut-song is properly sung counts as a full rite of mourning: **the Pall of the village falls by 1d3**, and Guests who sing with the family are treated thereafter as kin in that parish (+2 to Persuade and Haggle with its people for a season). A non-Fatlander who sings and eats suffers the usual Dread for eating at a wake but gains +2 on the check, because the song carries them.

A Fatlander who walks the furrows singing the Field Song over a kinsman's meal may treat it as their **Sop** (remove 1d6 Hunger), and feels the soil rise under their feet to meet them; on a Tooth of 1 that day, the field takes a little more than bone-meal, and the Guest finds one fingernail gone when they get home, with no blood.

The cut-songs have a darker use. A cut-song sung **to a living person** is understood in every village of the south. The Marrow sung to someone is a declaration of love so absolute it is barely distinguishable from a threat; the Heart sung to a parent is a curse, meaning *I am waiting*; the Spit Song sung under a window is how the Cullmasters' men tell a household that one of them has been put on the dusk shift. A Guest who has a cut-song sung to them in the Fatlands faces **Dread 1**, or Dread 2 if it is the Spit Song and they understand it.

▼ THE KEST COUNTING-SONG



One to ten, the door is shut, and I am in, and you are out.

— THE FIRST LINE EVERY HIGHLAND CHILD LEARNS, BEFORE ITS NAME, WHICH WAITS

The hymn every child in Cradlewrack knows before it knows its letters, sung during the pang, one line to each ten counts. The pangs come every nine days now, a long rolling quake from the deep ground that walks the crockery off the shelves and makes every Course-touched person within a hundred miles cry out, and they last for sixty seconds. For sixty seconds the whole country sings. Families gather in the strongest room of the house, hold hands, and count the quake down; the bricked in the Debt Wall count it

through their slots; the Foundling Companies count it on the drill-ground at Kest, in step; the watchers at the Dilation count it at the rim of the great crowning, a thousand voices, and the hole breathes with them.

The Kest Counting-Song, as the Attendance teaches it, sung through a pang.

One to ten, the door is shut, and I am in, and you are out.

Ten to twenty, knock and wait, the Holder holds, the hour is late.

Twenty, thirty, roll and rise, Mother, Mother, shut my eyes.

Thirty, forty, down and through, whatever comes, it isn't you.

Forty, fifty, nearly done, the waters come for everyone.

Fifty, sixty, still, still, still, and if it stays, it stays, it will.

The Going Back, sung only by the Second Opinions of the Attendance, after a birth they have not permitted, and by one voice in the Debt Wall, all day:

Sixty, fifty, look and see, what it is and what it'll be.

Fifty, forty, ask it plain, and ask it once, and not again.

Forty, thirty, apron tied, the Opinion's on the other side.

Thirty, twenty, hush and hold, the water's warm, the clay is cold.

Twenty, ten, the door is wide, and I am out, and you're inside.

Ten to one, and one to none, whatever came, it's come and gone.

The tune. Hardly a tune: a chant on a single note that rises one whole step every ten counts, so that the first line is sung low and steady, in a mother's speaking voice, and by *fifty, sixty* the voices are high and strained and thin, like the cry of a woman at the end of her strength. Each line takes exactly ten heartbeats, and the singers count the tens on their fingers, folding one down for each count, so that at sixty every hand in the room is two fists. Then silence, and the hands open. The Going Back descends the same steps, one whole tone every ten, ending low, almost under the breath, on *gone*. Midwives sing it with their eyes shut.

History. The counting-song is as old as the pangs, which is to say it was first sung when the quakes still came a season apart and the highlanders used to count them out of curiosity. It became a hymn in the Year of Doors, 310 A.G., when every lock in the country failed in one night, and its first line took on its present meaning: the door is shut, I am in, you are out, whatever you are. The Going Back is the Attendance's, and was never meant to be heard outside a lying-in room. It is sung by the Second Opinion over a birth that

has been answered *no* to the second question, to the end of the count, while the knife does its work; the Attendance holds that nothing should leave the world in less time than a pang. In the Debt Wall at Kest, one of the bricked sings the Going Back all day, from one to sixty and back again, and the slot-woman who feeds it bread has never asked the family who it is, because the family pays.

When the Mothers of the Walk of Aprons went down the ninety-one steps into the Dilation in 619, one at the start of each pang, the crowd counted them down, and at sixty the steps were empty. Lark Ninedays, who times the pangs for the state with a water clock and a bell, has entered in her private ledger that the last pang of Carving 640 lasted **sixty-one** seconds by the clock. There is no line in the counting-song for sixty-one. In the silence at the end of it, she says, every family in Kest was still holding hands with their mouths open, waiting for a line that did not come, and from the Dilation, a long way off, the watchers heard a single knock.



On sixty you open your hands. On sixty-one you look at them. Nobody ever told us what to do on sixty-one.

A NIGHT-MASON OF MORTAR RISE

At the Table. A company that sings the counting-song through a pang together, holding hands, gains **+2 on all rolls to endure the pang**: Endure, Athletics to keep footing, and Caul + Resolve against what the waters bring up. When the land's rule calls for a roll to see whether healed injuries or stitched seams reopen at the pang, each singer may **reroll one d10**. Doors in the room do not drift open during a pang while the song is being sung; the moment it stops, they do.

The Going Back is not a hymn but a sentence. Sung by a midwife over a birth, it is the Attendance's lawful killing, and a Guest who hears it sung in a lying-in room has witnessed a ritual killing (**Dread 3**). Sung by anyone else, over anyone else, it is a threat every highlander understands.

If a pang lasts past sixty while a Guest is counting (the Carver may decide this happens once, as the interval shortens, or roll a d10 at each pang from Carving 641 on: on a 1, it lasts sixty-one), every singer must make a **Dread 2** check, and every door within sight, bricked or not, opens one finger's width and stays open.

▼ OATHEN HANDTALK POEMS



Fingers do not count. Everyone knows fingers do not count.

– SAID IN TACIT, MORE AND MORE OFTEN, BY PEOPLE WHO NO LONGER BELIEVE IT

Handtalk is the sign language of Oathen, used for everything that matters little, and held not to bind. Its oldest signs are the signs of the butchery: *bold, cut, pull, more hands here, it is looking at me, do not stop*. Because it did not bind, it was for six centuries the only language in Oathen in which a person could exaggerate, flirt, joke, curse, or make poetry, and the canyons made a great deal of poetry. A handtalk poem is a sequence of signs performed in silence, with the face still and the hands close to the chest, before a small audience who answer by touching their own lips with two fingers. It cannot be written down without being changed, because the signs carry their speed, their size and their distance from the heart; the poems below are given as sequences, with the shape of each sign and a gloss, as the Quiet record them for teaching.

The greatest handtalker alive is Mirren Osk. Last year she signed a love poem and did not mean it, and three of her fingers snapped. Since then, nobody in Tacit signs a poem without thinking first. That is the end of an art. The canyons know it.

1. *Figs. A children's poem, the first that is taught; harmless, or once was. Four signs.*

The right hand cupped, the left thumb pressed into its palm, once, softly (a fig, ripe).

The flat hand raised above the brow, fingers spread, and lowered slowly to the chest (the sun; it is late in the day).

Both hands palms-down before the body, parting outward (to share; to divide).

The shoulders raised, the fingers spread and held still, the eyes lowered (if able).

Gloss: A ripe fig. The day is ending. I would share it with you, if able.

2. *The Butchery. The oldest poem in the canyons, and the oldest signs. Signed by the Quiet on Tablenight, when Oathen makes no sound, all through the night, by the whole order together in the Hall of Conditions. Six signs, repeated.*

Both fists closed and pulled to the chest (hold).

The edge of the right hand drawn down the left forearm, slowly, from elbow to wrist (cut).

Both fists drawn back over the shoulder, hard, together (pull).

The open right hand beckoning twice, toward the floor (more hands here).

Two fingers pointed at the signer's own eyes, then turned outward, then held still, trembling (it is looking at me).

The flat right hand laid across the mouth, then lifted away and pressed flat on the heart (do not stop).

Gloss: none is given. The Quiet say the poem is the gloss.

3. *Coming to the Hearing, by an unknown pilgrim-poet, before 300 A.G. Signed at the Night of Ears, on the eve of Tablenight, by pilgrims lying with their ears to the warm sand of the Gullet. Seven signs.*

Two fingers walking across the left palm, slowly, a long way (the walk; a whole day).

The cupped hand held to the ear, and the head tilted into it (listening).

The right hand closed into a fist and laid on the tongue, then opened downward (a true sentence, given).

The fist on the tongue again, and kept there (it was eaten).

The cupped hand held to the ear, and the head tilted away from it (it is listening from inside).

The flat hand laid on the stomach and held (here).

The flat hand laid on the stomach, and the signer bowing over it until the brow touches the hand (forgive).

Gloss: We walked a day to its ear. We gave it true sentences. We ate it. Now it listens from in here. Forgive us; we cannot stop talking to you.

4. *The Breakdowns Poem, attributed to Brakk, Voice of the Forsworn, who has nothing left to break; performed on the canyon floor by the Forsworn for coins, at speed, with great vulgarity. It is the only handtalk poem that is also a curse, and Oatheners who watch it laugh with their hands over their mouths. Five signs.*

Both hands opening outward from the breastbone like the covers of a book (my ribs).

The right forefinger stabbing at the Sunward Wall, where the Bench sits (you).

The sign for if able, done mockingly, with the shoulders up to the ears and the tongue out.

Both fists brought together, then pulled apart with a jerk (broken; Forsworn).

The hand turned palm up and flicked toward the Wall, fingers snapping out (soon).

Gloss: Look at my ribs. You, up there with your if-ables: you'll be one of us soon.

5. Mirren Osk's last poem, the love poem of 640. Only the first three signs are given. The Quiet will not teach the rest, and Mirren signs nothing now.

The right forefinger pointed at the listener, held out at arm's length (you).

The right hand laid flat over the signer's own breastbone and pressed until the knuckles whiten (heart; mine; given).

Both hands circling each other, slowly, without end (always).

The rest of the poem is eleven signs long. Those who saw it performed say that it was the most beautiful thing ever made in the canyons, and that she held her hands quite still afterward, and that the sound of the fingers going was like three dry twigs, one, two, three.

The tune. Handtalk poems have no tune and make no sound, but they have a meter, and a good handtalker is judged by it: each sign held for a heartbeat, the pauses between signs counted, the whole poem performed in one breath held and released at the end, so that the audience sees the poet's chest fall. Poems for the Quiet are signed slowly, large, from the shoulder. Love poems are signed small, close to the heart, almost hidden in the lap. Curses are signed fast.

History. Handtalk was born on the night of the Silent Supper from the signs the butchers made to each other over the god, and its poetry flowered in the Honest Age, when Oathen grew rich on trust and needed somewhere to put everything it could not say. The great handtalk poets were the first Clausewrights' children, raised under the bit until twelve, who learned to say everything with their hands

before they had ever spoken. Since last year, when Mirren Osk's fingers broke, the Echo-Wardens have begun to log handtalk in the deep rock, the click and slap of fingers echoing in gorges where fingers make no sound, and a scribe has found that written words are beginning to bind as well. If the Regrowth is widening what Tolm counts, the poetry of the canyons is about to become law.



A poem is a promise you make to no one about nothing. That was the definition. I taught it to children for thirty years. I have stopped teaching it.

A SCHOOLMISTRESS OF LOW DRAY, IN WRITING

At the Table. Performing a handtalk poem for an Oathener, well, is the highest compliment a foreigner can pay in the canyons: +2 to **Persuade and Clause** with that person for the scene, and the respect of anyone watching. The Breakdowns Poem performed among the Forsworn makes a Guest a friend of the Breakdowns for a night; performed anywhere near a Clausewright, it is an insult that will be repaid in forty pages.

Handtalk now binds a little. In Oathen, an Oathen-blooded Guest at **Regrowth 4 or more** who performs a poem that asserts or promises something they do not mean must roll **Caul + Resolve at Hard (14)**, or one finger breaks (1 Flesh, and -1 to Hand rolls until it is set and healed). A Guest at the Course breaks one finger for each sign that was false, automatically. Within the Gullet, the Ledger, or any posted silent gorge, handtalk counts as speech for echoes, and the Echo-Wardens will want to know what was signed.

Anyone who learns the remaining eleven signs of Mirren Osk's poem (she alone knows them; a Hard Tongue + Persuade and a reason she would believe) and performs them meaning every one is bound by it as by a spoken Weight 3 oath of love, to the person they signed it to, for life.

▼ THE LONG DECLINE



No, thank you.

— THE RESPONSE, SUNG AFTER EVERY VERSE

The only hymn the Unfed sing. It is sung at the Laying-Down, when one of the Unfed is buried, and on Tablenight, when every person in the Fast stands outdoors from dusk to dawn with their back to every door; it is sung unaccompanied, very low, almost on

one note, by people who do not have the breath to sing. Its words are older than Wanting. It has eight verses. The Unfed sing seven.

The Long Decline, the seven sung verses, as sung on the walls of Wanting.

We stood on the hill in the snow, and it was laid for us.
No, thank you.
We stood on the hill, and the ones in front lay down, and we stood on them.
No, thank you.
The god lay on the stone with its throat bare, and smiled, and said, you must be starved.
No, thank you.
We were starved. We said it with our mouths full of nothing.
No, thank you.
The god wept, and the snow went soft, and some of us drank it.
No, thank you.
On the tenth morning it got down from the stone and bowed to us.
No, thank you.
It is still laying the table. It is still asking. We are still here.
No, thank you.

The tune. A recitation on a single low note, the verse spoken-sung by a lone voice (at a Laying-Down, the dead one's nearest kin; on Tablenight, the eldest on each wall) and the response sung by everyone, on two notes only: the low note, and a note a half-step above it on *thank*, which sounds less like music than like a starving person's breath catching. The Unfed have no instruments. Some Roll-Keepers say the response was once sung three times after every verse, in the proper form of the decline, and that it was shortened when there were no longer enough people on the hill with breath for the third.

History. The Long Decline is the Unfed's account of Hallowboard, compressed to seven lines: the god laid out on the eight-sided stone, the front rows lying down in the snow, the second rows standing on them, the god's warm tears, the tenth morning when Orrum got up off the table, and the six hundred and forty-one years since. It is sung at the Laying-Down because every death in the Fast is the Refusal repeated; it is sung on Tablenight because on that night, in every house in the Fast, behind the backs of the people standing outdoors, the table is laid. In 559, when Wanting walked nine of its own out to the edge of the warm ground in the Giving, the town stood on its walls with its backs to the west and

sang it, and the Measure-Bearers rang their bells three times and walked back, and the nine walked on.

The eighth verse is not sung. Most Unfed do not know it exists. The Roll-Keepers of Barrowgate know it, and recite it only to one another, on Tablenight, with their backs to the stone. A Hostwatch Cartographer who overheard it once wrote down only that it is the shortest verse, that it does not end with the Decline, and that it begins *And then there was one more*.

CARVER'S SECRET: THE EIGHTH VERSE

The Roll-Keepers' eighth verse, for the Carver's eyes, is this:

And then there was one more, on the side where the snow did not settle, and it said: Thank you.

It is not followed by the response. It does not need one. The Unfed who know it believe it records a stranger at Hallowboard who accepted, which is the worst thing they can imagine, and they do not know who it was, and they do not want to. Do not explain it. If a Guest ever hears it, let them count the sides of the table.



*On Tablenight you stand with your back to the door
and you sing seven, and you hear the plates go down
behind you in the empty house, one by one. Seven
verses. You count the plates. That's all. You just count
the plates.*

A BELL WARD WOMAN, TO A RIM VISITOR

At the Table. For the Unfed, singing the Long Decline at a Laying-Down or on Tablenight counts as saying the Decline at a deathbed: +1 **Want**, and 1 Fray. A company that sings it together while facing one of Orrum's laid tables (with their backs to it, as is proper) gains +2 on **Invitation checks** for the scene; the smell of bread thins, and the chair, very slightly, pushes itself back in. Godeater Guests who sing the response along with the Unfed may also gain this bonus, and an Unfed who hears a Godeater sing *No, thank you* properly, three times, on the fourth accepting a hand or a cup, will think a little better of them, for a day.

The eighth verse, said aloud anywhere on the Table, is **Dread 3**. Every one of Orrum's tables within a mile acquires a place card with the speaker's name on it, and the Hostwatch report that wherever it is said, the Host itself stops walking, wherever it is, and stands very still, the way a man stands in a dark house when he hears a floorboard. For one night it lays no tables at all. The Carver should treat that as the most frightening thing in this book.

▼ OVER, UNDER: THE SEAMERS' STITCHING SONG



*Over for the ones who stand, under for the ones who sit; pull it tight for Gran, my love,
and don't you look at it.*

– THE BURDEN

The work song of the Seamers' Guild, sung in every stitching-shop on Needle Street and in every kitchen in Sallowreach during Restitching Week, when grandmothers are restitched each spring and the Seamers do a year's trade in a fortnight. It is sung in the rhythm of the needle: in on the first beat, through on the second, pull on the third, and the knot on the fourth. Apprentices learn the count of a running stitch, a whip stitch, a wire-tie and a lacquer-seal from the verses, and a Threader can tell from across the shop, by the singing, which of her apprentices is going too fast.

Over, Under, as sung in the Guildhall on Needle Street on the first day of Restitching Week.

*Over for the ones who stand, under for the ones who sit,
pull it tight for Gran, my love, and don't you look at it.*

Here's the thread of the Seamers' Guild, waxed and black and strong,

it held her when the wire went, it'll hold her all along.

*Over for the ones who stand, under for the ones who sit,
pull it tight for Gran, my love, and don't you look at it.*

*Here's the jaw that's working loose, here's the hip that's gone,
whip it round and tie it off, and lacquer it, and on.*

*Over for the ones who stand, under for the ones who sit,
pull it tight for Gran, my love, and don't you look at it.*

*Thessaly Mort has a ledger, and the ledger's very short:
what was hers and what was ours, and what was simply bought.*

*Over for the ones who stand, under for the ones who sit,
pull it tight for Gran, my love, and if she screams, then quit.*

The tune. A brisk four-square beat, every stroke of the needle on the beat, sung in a cheerful, clipped major by a shopful of voices; the tune is the old Lastgate fishwives' reel slowed down to a working pace. The last line of the burden changes at the end of the song, as above, and the change is always sung softer, almost a mumble. Apprentices sing the last line louder for a joke, once, and are not let to sew for a day.

History. The song dates from the Stitching Laws of 130 A.G., when the state took responsibility for keeping the dead in one piece and chartered the Seamers' Guild; its verses have been added to by every generation of Threaders since, and there are said to be more than two hundred of them, of which a shop will know fifty. The verse about Thessaly Mort, who has replaced so much of herself that her ledger of original parts is very short, is recent and sung only when she is not in the room. She knows it. She has, it is said, added a verse of her own, which she sings alone, after hours, over a part of her own body that she is replacing, and nobody has heard the words.

The changed last line, *and if she screams, then quit*, is the only mercy in the Seamers' rule: a Kept person under the needle who screams is not to be sewn further that day, whatever the fee. In the Guildhall this is called the Grandmother's Clause. In the back-alley shops where Marrow Jack sells his stolen limbs, it is not observed.

At the Table. Singing Over, Under while stitching (a wound, a Kept body, a sail, a sack) grants +1 to **Stitching** and, on long tasks, one free Helping toward the total. A Seamer who hears a stranger sing it correctly, with the right last line, will assume they were apprenticed and treat them as a member of the trade (+2 to Persuade and Haggle with Seamers). A Kept person being restitched to the song suffers half the Fray they otherwise would from the procedure.

▼ PINCH ME: THE NUDGERS' ROUND



Pinch me.

– THE VIGIL'S COMMONEST ENDEARMENT, AND ITS MARRIAGE VOW

The street-children of the Vigil, hired by the hour to pinch strangers awake, sing this round as they work, in pairs and threes on the Slope's stairs, and it is the only cheerful sound that city makes after the bells. It is a round: the second voice comes in when the first reaches the second line, the third at the third, and the round can go on as long as there are voices and breath, which in the Vigil is a long time. A pinch is given on the last word of every line, to whoever is nearest.

Pinch Me, as sung by the nudgers on Wicker Stair; a round in four parts.

Pinch me once and I'm awake, (pinch)

pinch me twice for the city's sake, (pinch)

pinch me three and I'll pinch you back, (pinch)

lids up, lamps lit, Lack, Lack, Lack! (slap)

Bell for the quarter, bell for the hour,

rouse in the cup and the cup gone sour,

needle for Waker and pin for the guest,

and nobody, nobody, nobody rest!

The tune. A quick, bright, jiggling tune in a high register, made to carry over street noise and bells, sung by children's voices in a strict round of four. When it is going well, the four parts overlap so that there is always someone singing *pinch*, and someone being pinched, and the whole stair is a ripple of small sharp hurts and laughter. When a child in a round blinks, the round falters on her line, and the others hear the gap. That is what the round is for.

History. Nobody knows who made Pinch Me; the nudgers say it is older than rouse, which makes it older than 390 A.G. It is taught by nudger to nudger, and every child on the Slope knows it by five. The Wakers hate it, because it mocks them in the second verse, and love it, because it works. Pip Eleven-Bell, nine years old and two weeks unpaid, sings the round on the Slope stairs with two others. Lately the other two have been coming in early on her line, to cover the gap.

At the Table. A company singing Pinch Me as a round, with at least three voices, may remove **1 Weariness from every singer** once per scene, as a nudger's pinch (the land's rule allows one such removal per scene; the round counts as it). If any singer is at Grey (7+), the round may also stand in for their blink check for that scene: the singers roll it together, using the best Caul + Resolve among them, because the gap in the round wakes the blinker before the blink is over. On a Lack, the round has gone on with one fewer voice for some time and nobody noticed when.

▼ HOOK HIM GENTLE: THE NETWATCH SHANTY



Subject appeared expected.

– THE STANDARD PHRASE OF THE NETWATCH LOGS

The Netwatch, the Tidal Admiralty's night patrol, hunts the Called along the shore and across the Uncovered with nets, hooks and rope, and drags them home. They sing as they go, low, in a shanty rhythm, and they sing for two reasons. The first is pace: the Called

walk west at a steady unhurried gait, and the song keeps a patrol to the same gait, so that a hooker can come up beside a sleepwalker without startling them into the sea. The second reason is the one the officers do not put in the training: the Called are listening to

something, an invitation, and a song sung close to them in their own coast's tongue covers it, for a few breaths, enough to get the rope on.

Hook Him Gentle, the patrol-song of the Netwatch, as sung on the Raw Mile. The first lines are called by the lantern-bearer; the rest is answered by the patrol.

Lantern up and lantern low, (hook him gentle)

there's pink prints on the salt below, (hook him gentle)

walk him easy, walk him slow,

the sea's not where it used to go.

Hook him gentle, hook him kind,

he's left his shoes and his name behind;

tie him off at the wrist and knee,

and haul him home from the empty sea.

She walks with her face to the west wind, warm, (hook her gentle)

like a girl going home from the harvest farm, (hook her gentle)

don't you shout and don't you call,

she can't hear you, love, at all.

Hook her gentle, hook her kind,

she's left her shoes and her name behind;

lay her down on the drying rack,

and if she weeps, don't give her back.

The tune. A slow walking shanty in two, at exactly the pace of a sleepwalker on salt-crust, in a dark Dorian mode that every Brinehollower hears as homesick. The lantern-bearer calls; the patrol answers *hook him gentle* (or *her*) between lines, under the breath, and joins in full on the second half of each verse. It is never sung loudly. Netwatch patrols on the Uncovered can be tracked across a mile of dark by the song alone, a murmur coming and going on the wind, and the scavengers out there call it *the gentle* and keep clear.

History. The shanty is as old as the Netwatch, which was founded after the First Calling of 118 A.G., when four hundred walked into the sea at Lowmark and eleven came back. It was adapted from a hauling tune of the old fishing fleets, before the sea left; the old verses were about bringing in a catch, and the Netwatch changed *it* to *him* and *her*. The last line, *and if she weeps, don't give her back*, is the Netwatch's whole doctrine in seven words. Lieutenant Sable Reef, who has pulled three hundred Called off the shore with hook and rope, sings it as well as anyone in the service. Her patrol has noticed that she has started to leave off the last line.

At the Table. A patrol singing Hook Him Gentle together gains +2 to resist the pull (as a Caul + Resolve check against the Calling) for the night, and +2 to Stealth when approaching a Called sleepwalker, who will not turn until the rope is on. A Called person who hears the shanty sung close to them hesitates: the Carver gives the hookers one free action before the first opposed roll. The last line is optional. A Guest who leaves it off, as Sable Reef does, and lets a weeping Called person walk on into the dark, gains 1 Fray, and the household's Pall rises by 2 as for a loss to the Pull; a Guest who sings it and keeps the rope tight on someone begging to be let go gains the same 1 Fray, and the household's thanks, and must live with both.

▼ MAY YOUR DOOR STAND OPEN: A HIGHLAND CURSE



You knock to warn whatever is on the other side.

– HIGHLAND TEACHING ON MANNERS

In Cradlewrack it is the gravest rudeness to open a door without knocking, and the commonest curse is a wish that every door stays open. This is the formal version, a cursing-song chanted under a neighbour's lintel at night by a wronged woman (it is almost always a woman, since descent and grievance run through whoever bore you), with a nail in her fist, tapping the door once on every line. A

cursed household will hear the tapping and lie still until it is over, because to answer it is to open the door.

May Your Door Stand Open, as cursed in Rudge, where a well once gave birth; given by a Tallyman's clerk who heard it under his own lintel.

May your door stand open and your lock come undone, (tap)

may your bricks fall outward, every one, (tap)
may your wounds come open on the pang, (tap)
and the waters bring up what you threw in the dark, (tap)
may you bear a hand, and the hand be mine, (tap)
may it knock at your bed at the turn of the night, (tap)
may you ask the Two Questions and get no reply, (tap)
and may it stay. And may it stay. And may it stay. (tap, tap, tap)

The tune. A monotone chant on a low note, rhythmless except for the tapping of the nail, which falls on the last syllable of every line like a knock. The last line is spoken, not chanted, three times, each time quieter, and the three taps that follow are the loudest: three hard knocks, the traditional warning given before opening a door onto something unknown. The curser does not open the door. She walks away. That is the point.

History. The cursing-song dates from the Year of Doors, 310 A.G., when every lock in the country failed in one night and the custom of bricking up rooms began; its sixth line is newer, from after the Gathering of Parts in 500 A.G., when it was first noticed that Parts from unrelated families fit each other. The Attendance has outlawed it twice and stopped trying, because the midwives use it themselves. Agnes Latch, the Doorwright who builds doors meant to stay shut, guarantees her best work against it; her best work held for nineteen days.

At the Table. A Cradlewracker cursed with the song (by an NPC with a real grievance, or by a Guest who has one) suffers **−1 to all rolls to keep a door, lock, bricked room or wound shut** until the curse is lifted by the curser's knocking three times on the door again and walking away, or by the next Unbricking. The cursed household's doors open by themselves at night, a finger's width. A Guest who curses someone with it, and means it, gains 1 Hunger and must make a **Caul + Resolve** check at Routine (10); on a failure the Guest goes into false labour that night, of any age or sex, as the Appetite rehearses, and the body is very sure of what it would like to bear.

▼ WHAT GOES DOWN: THE PURGATION'S EMETIC HYMN



What goes down can come up.

– PAINTED ON THE PURGATION'S ALTAR-BOWLS

The Purgation believes the gods can be thrown back up. At the Weeping Post on Retching Day, and in its halls the length of the Rim, its Penitents kneel in rows before their bowls and drink the Black Draught, a purgative of bitter roots, salt and lamp-oil, and then they retch, for hours, while the Purgers walk the rows with the bleeding-cup, and the whole hall sings. The hymn is set to the rhythm of vomiting. That is not a figure of speech. Its lines are short, its breaths are placed where the body heaves, and the Penitents are taught to bring the god up on the downbeat.

What Goes Down, the hymn of the Black Draught, as sung at the Weeping Post on Retching Day. The Purger calls the lines; the Penitents answer on the heave.

What went down, (come up)
in the dark of the Lack, (come up)
in the nine days' meat, (come up)
give it back. (come up)

What we stole, (come up)
from the stone and the shore, (come up)
from the field and the bed, (come up)
we'll take no more. (come up)
Bitter root, (come up)
and the salt, and the oil, (come up)
turn the belly out (come up)
like a ploughman turns soil. (come up)
Bowl, bowl, (come up)
take what we bring, (come up)
and if it is grey, (come up)
then bless the grey thing. (come up)

The tune. A call-and-response in a slow, labouring three, the third beat left empty for the heave. The Purger calls on a high, clear, almost sweet note; the response, *come up*, is not sung at all by the end of the first hour but forced out, a choked rising grunt from two hundred throats at once, followed by the sound that gives the hymn its rhythm. Visitors who hear a Purgation hall at service from the road say it sounds like a field of animals being butchered slowly, in time. Penitents who have been through it say that after the third hour it begins to sound beautiful.

History. The hymn was first sung in 233 A.G. at the Great Retching, when Hurlo Sweyn, a Fatlands physician, drank his own draught before a congregation of Confessors at the Weeping Post and, after six hours of retching, brought up a hard white thing the size of a thumbnail which he swore was one of Ummer's teeth. The congregation sang him through it. The fourth verse, *if it is grey, then bless the grey thing*, was added in the following century, when the Purgation's halls began to find that what came up, now and then,

was godflesh: a sliver of grey, a fleck of loam, a curl of caul. The Voided, the inner council, have known for a hundred years that they sell those slivers to the cure-shops and the Second Table, and the hymn's fourth verse has paid for a great many halls.

At the Table. A Penitent who drinks the Black Draught with the hymn sung over them gains +2 to **Gut + Endure** against the retching (normally Hard 14 or lose 1d6 Flesh). If the Penitent has Regrowth 4 or more, the Carver rolls a d10 at the end of the service: on a 1–2, something comes up, a sliver of the Penitent's god, and they lose 1d6 Hunger and 1 Flesh and gain 1 Fray. It purges nothing of the Regrowth. It is worth, to the right buyer on the Rim, between 50 and 500 lacks, and the Purgers will offer to take it off the Penitent's hands, as a kindness. The hymn is also a method of the **Long Night** for building Hold: a Guest who attends three services in a week with the Purgation suffers –2 to resist their Hold, because by the third hour of the third night the hymn does begin to sound beautiful.

▼ IT WORKED ONCE: THE SECOND TABLE'S TOAST



It worked once.

– THE WHOLE OF THE SECOND TABLE'S CREED, ENGRAVED INSIDE ITS MEMBERS' SIGNET RINGS

The Second Table, the hidden cult of nobles who intend to eat the gods again, meets a dozen at a time in private dining rooms on the Rim and in the cellars of great houses, and every dinner ends with this toast. It is spoken, not sung, in seven parts, one for each course, each part said by the member who holds that course's name: the Fish, the Bread, the Sweet, the Lid, the Word, the Hand, the Host. The glasses are raised at each course and lowered without drinking. They are drunk only at the end, all together, in silence. The toast is the one thing the Second Table says aloud that is in any sense true, and its members are sworn in Oathen, on their own tongues, never to repeat it to anyone not at the table.

The Toast in Seven Removes, as recited by a Taster who did not finish his plate, to a Cutwright who had paid for his last meal; the Taster was served at the next dinner.

The Fish: To the deep, which held us. We held it better.

The Bread: To the field, which fed us. We feed on it still.

The Sweet: To the door, which let us in. We have not left.

The Lid: To the sleeper, who did not wake. Sleep on.

The Word: To the witness, who heard us. Nobody else will.

The Hand: To the closer, who finished things. We are not finished.

The Host: (Silence. The Host's glass is raised by the Carver of the table and set down before an empty chair.)

All, together: It worked once.

(They drink. Then one of them, in recent years, it is said, always the youngest, turns to the end of the table, where nobody sits, and raises their glass a second time, and does not say anything at all.)

The tune. None. It is spoken softly, in the clipped Table-speech of the High Cuts, with long pauses between removes, at a table set with seven courses and a grey bone knife. Members who have eaten something at the dinner that affects their voices (a sliver of Oathen tongue, a Tenanted heart, a Vigil eye) are excused speaking and raise their glass alone.

History. The toast is as old as the Second Table's first menu, found in the coat of a murdered Gut-line lordling in 412 A.G., and its form has never changed. The second raising, toward the empty end of the table, is new: the Cutwrights who have interrogated former Tasters say it began in the last ten years, at about the time the menus began to carry an eighth line, left blank. Nobody at the tables admits to having started it. Every table does it. Members asked why say that it seems polite.



We raised the glass to the end of the table. There's nobody there. There's never anybody there. Only, the last few dinners, the Host's chair has been warm when the servants clear it.

A TASTER, TO THE CUTWRIGHT WHO BOUGHT HIS SUPPER

At the Table. A Guest who knows the toast can identify a Second Table member by it (any member hearing it quoted will react; **Eye + Instinct, Hard (14)**, to spot it). A Guest who recites the toast in the hearing of a member, without being one, will receive an invitation to dinner within the month, and will be served something without being told what it is. Sincerely drinking the toast at a Second Table dinner, all seven removes, is a method of the **Warm Table** for the Second Table's Hold. Raising the glass a second time toward the empty end of the table, at any table on the Table, is a small thing, and costs nothing, and is noticed. The Carver should note who does it.

▼ TURN THE CHAIR ROUND: A RIM DRINKING SONG



On the Rim we just turn a chair around and drink.

— RIM INNKEEPER, THE GROANING BOARD

The Fatlands fast on Tablenight, the Fast fasts, the fens feast their dead, the Vigil goes dark, the highlands leave their doors open, and Oathen keeps its mouth shut. On the Rim, in every Company inn and waystation, the custom is simpler: the house turns one chair at every table to face the wall, so that nobody can sit in it, and everybody drinks. This is the song they sing while they do it. It is sung at the Groaning Board by six hundred voices at a single table, at Thimble Cross over the dicing-board, at Mumchance in silence on slates, and at the Open Door at Knocking Gate with the curtains pulled back.

Turn the Chair Round, as sung at the Groaning Board on Tablenight. Each verse is followed by the chorus; at the chorus, the nearest chair is turned a quarter-turn, so that by the fourth chorus it faces the wall.

*Oh the fens feast their dead and the dead cannot taste,
and the south fasts a day and gives up by the noon,
and the coast leaves a bowl with the door open wide,
and we're all of us drunk by the rise of the Plate!*

(Chorus) So turn the chair round, lads, turn the chair round,

*we've counted the guests and there's one too many found;
whoever you are, you can stand by the wall,
for there's lacks on the table and drink for us all!*

*Oh the Lid puts its lamps out to prove that it can,
and the hills prop their doors and the canyons go dumb,
and the Fast stand in snow with their backs to the house,
and the Rim stays inside where the barrels are warm!*
(Chorus)

*Oh the god in the middle is laying its plates,
and they say it's come out on the road in the night,
and it stoops at the window and looks at the light;
well, we'll give it a song, but we won't give it bread!*
(Chorus)

*Here's the grace that we say when we sit down to eat,
with a stranger or brother or whatever's at the door:
Lack keep away, and the chair face the wall,*

and nobody sit in it, nobody, never at all!

(Chorus, sung twice, the second time very quietly.)

The tune. A rollicking drinking song in a swinging six, major, loud, with a chorus that everyone bellows and bangs on the table; it is set to a Fatlands harvest tune that the Groaning Board's first innkeeper brought north. The last chorus is sung twice, the second time in a whisper, with everyone looking at the turned chair, and nobody can say when that started either. At Mumchance in Oathen, where nothing loud may be said, the song is written out on slates and passed from hand to hand, and the customers turn the chair in silence and drink.

History. The custom of turning a chair to the wall on Tablenight is older than the Company, from the Thin Years when the caravaneers who built the Rim Road slept in the heartland's old ring-road inns, and found, on the longest night of their first Lack on the road, a chair pulled out at every table that nobody had pulled

out. The song is younger, from the Sweet Reigns. Its third verse was added within living memory, when Orrum's tables were first found laid at crossroads outside the Fast and the Hostwatch began to report the Host walking the Rim at night, stooping to look in at inn windows. Since 638, the Company has issued a standing instruction to its innkeepers that the chair on Tablenight must be turned before dusk, not during the song. It does not say why.

At the Table. Sung in a crowded inn on Tablenight, Turn the Chair Round counts as a feast for the Pall (–1), and every Guest who joins in removes 1 Fray. A chair turned to the wall by the song cannot be laid by Orrum's Steward that night: no table appears at that seat, and a Guest who would otherwise face an Invitation there faces none. A chair *not* turned, at an inn where the song has been sung, will be found pulled out at dawn, with crumbs on the seat. On a Lack while leading the song, the singer counts the company at the end of the last chorus, aloud, as the song invites, and there is one too many found.

▼ CLEAN HANDS: THE RECKONERS' WALKING SONG



We carry our own.

– THE RECKONERS' WORD, GIVEN AT THE BORDER IN PLACE OF A PASSWORD

The Reckoners cross the Rim Road in bands of five to twenty, on foot, carrying their own food, to end the high Cut bloodlines of the Godeater lands in their beds. On the road home they sing this. It is a walking song, sung low, at night, in the rhythm of a long march on short rations, and its verses are a list: the bloodlines the band has ended, one line to each house, named by the Kin-Reader who holds the stolen genealogies. Every band's version is different. The burden is the same.

Clean Hands, the Reckoners' walking song; the burden as sung by every band, the verses as sung by Reckoner-Captain Scant Hollis's band on the road home from the Fatlands, Carving 640.

(Burden) Clean hands, clean mouth, carry your own,

eat what you brought and leave them alone,

we said no on the hill in the snow,

and we say it again on the road as we go.

One for the house on the Brawn by the weir,

the grandmother first and the cradle last year.

(Burden)

One for the house with the field in the hall,

we weeded it down to the root of it all.

(Burden)

One for the cousin at college in Quire,

he wept for his mother. We put out the fire.

(Burden)

Clean hands, clean mouth, carry your own;

we never once ate of them. Leave them alone.

The tune. A steady trudging two, in a bleak, narrow, Fast-born mode built on only four notes, because the Unfed have never had instruments to teach them more. It is sung barely above speech. The burden is sung by everyone; each verse by the Kin-Reader alone, flatly, as if reading a list, which is what it is.

History. Clean Hands dates from the first armed crossing of the Rim in 402 A.G., the Reckoning, and its burden quotes the Long Decline (*we said no on the hill in the snow*). The Abstinents have never approved it: it is the only song in the Fast besides the Decline, and the Keepers say that the Reckoners have made a hymn of murder. Scant Hollis, who has led forty raids and ended nine bloodlines, sings the verses herself and keeps no other trophies. The last line, *we never once ate of them*, is sung by every band. Scour, the Returned, who ate Fatlands meat for a year to keep his cover and came home with godsign under his sleeves, sings it louder than anyone.

At the Table. A Reckoner band, or a company travelling with one, that sings Clean Hands on the march gains **+1 to Wayfaring and Endure** on short rations, and the Unfed among them may treat a day's march on half a ration as *ending a day hungry* (+1 **Want**) even if they were fed. An Unfed Guest who sings a verse naming a bloodline they have helped end gains **+1 Want and 1 Fray**. A Godeater Guest who hears the song sung near them, and is of a High Cut line, makes a **Dread 2** check; if the verse names their own house (the Carver decides, or rolls a d10, and on a 1 it does), it is **Dread 3**, and the band has a Kin-Reader who knows their face.

▼ WHO IS SINGING THROUGH THE WALL?

Rim inns are thin-walled, the Table is full of singers, and a song heard through a wall at night is half the rumours on the road. When

a Guest lies awake at a waystation, roll a d10.

D10	THROUGH THE WALL	WHAT IT MEANS
1	A child's voice, counting to sixty and back, in a room the innkeeper swears is empty	A Cradlewrack family lodged there last week; something they bore is still in the wardrobe
2	A man humming a climbing tune, on and on, never ending	A Sallowreacher carrying the hum south; he cannot sleep until it finishes
3	Three falling notes, whistled, then a sharp slap and a child's laugh	Vigil merchants and their nudger; somebody nearly went down
4	A drinking song with one voice still singing after the rest have stopped	A drunk; or not
5	Somebody signing handtalk to themselves in the dark; you can hear the fingers	An Oathener rehearsing a poem; the echo comes back from the yard
6	A slow shanty, very low, and a rope creaking	Netwatch officers on leave, tying one of their own to the bed
7	<i>No, thank you</i> , three times, then silence, then a chair scraping	An Unfed traveller has been offered something; the chair moved on the fourth
8	A wake-song, in a bright major key, and the sound of chewing	A Fatlands drover's wake; he died on the road, and the family has a licence
9	Retching, rhythmic, and a sweet voice calling <i>come up</i>	A Purgation hall in the next building; they will sell what comes up at dawn
10	Seven voices raising a toast, one at a time, and then a long silence, and then an eighth glass set down	Do not go and look

CHAPTER 5

SAID AT TABLE

Proverbs, Graffiti and Bedtime Stories

Say it plainly. We were hungry, and they were there.

– FIRST LINE OF EVERY HISTORY WRITTEN ON THE TABLE, AND THE FIRST PROVERB TAUGHT TO RIM CHILDREN

From the preface to *THE TABLE ALMANACK, OR A SAYING FOR EVERY DAY*, printed at Quire for the Rim Road Company and sold at every waystation for two crumbs, 637 A.G.

The traveller on the Rim will find that every people of the Table has a proverb for every occasion, and that most of them contradict one another, and that all of them are true in the country where they are said. The Company has therefore compiled, for the convenience of its patrons, a saying for every day of the year, drawn from all seven lands and from the Road itself, so that the traveller may greet his host with something apt. The Company accepts no responsibility for sayings repeated in the wrong land. A saying of the Fatlands spoken in the Fast has been known to start a fight. A saying of any land spoken in Oathen is binding on the speaker if it can be construed as a promise, and the Company's notaries advise

that most of them can. The compilers have omitted the eighth of every list. They were asked to.

This chapter collects the small talk of the Table: the things people say over meals, scratch on walls, and tell their children at night. It is meant to be stolen from. A Carver who needs a line for an innkeeper, a carter, a dying Kept grandmother or a Netwatch officer on a cold pier will find one here, and every line is meant to carry a little of its land's horror in it, the way a proverb carries a whole history in a sentence.

It has three parts. **The Almanac of Sayings** gives a proverb for every day of the year, by season, numbered from the first day of Grace (when the Kept Rain falls on Oathen, or is supposed to) to the last day of Lack. **Graffiti of the Rim** gives forty lines scratched on walls, milestones and privy doors along the ring road, with where they are found and what they actually mean. **Bedtime Stories of the Seven Lands** gives one tale from each land, as a parent tells it at a child's bedside, followed by the true event behind it, which the parent does not tell.

▼ THE ALMANAC OF SAYINGS

The Company's almanac counts the year from the first day of Grace and gives each season ninety-one days, with the last day of Lack left over as the year's ninety-second day of winter, which the almanac calls *the leftover* and the Unfed call the ninth of the Nine. Tablenight, the longest night, falls by the Company's reckoning on the three hundred and twentieth day. Where several lands keep a holy day on the same date (the first of Grace is the Kept Rain, the Unbricking and the Burying all at once), the almanac gives the saying to one land on the day and to the others on the days that follow, which has offended all three.

Each saying is tagged with the land it belongs to. The Rim's own sayings are tagged *Rim*. Festival days are marked in *italic* at the head of the line.

PROVERBS AT THE TABLE

A Guest who quotes a proverb of a land to someone from that land, aptly, at the right moment, gains **+1 to the next Persuade, Haggle or Deceive roll** with them in that scene, once per scene; they are, for a moment, someone who knows how things are said here. Quoting a proverb of the wrong land (a Fatlands saying about appetite in the Fast; a Sallowreach saying about long life to anyone who is not Kept) gives **–2** instead, and may start a fight. In Oathen, a proverb that can be read as a promise is a promise: the Carver may rule it a Weight 1 oath. The Clausewrights recommend only the sayings that begin with *if*.

The Carver may also roll a d100 (or d366, for the dedicated) to find the day's saying when the Guests wake at an inn. The innkeeper has it chalked on the slate by the door.

GRACE

A promised rain comes.

– THE FIRST SAYING OF THE YEAR

◇ **1. *The Kept Rain.*** A promised rain comes; a late rain was promised to someone else. (*Oathen*)

◇ **2. *The Unbricking.*** Knock before you break the wall; it was polite enough to stay in all winter. (*Cradlewrack*)

- ◇ 3. *The Burying*. Cut the grass on the Barrows once, and do not enjoy it. (*Fast*)
- ◇ 4. Restitch in Grace and you'll stand till Lack. (*Sallowreach*)
- ◇ 5. New rope at the Knotting, and the old rope burned, and never the other way round. (*Brinebollow*)
- ◇ 6. A stranger with clean boots came round the Fast, not through it. (*Rim*)
- ◇ 7. Babies are born with their eyes shut; that is the first thing we forgive them. (*Vigil*)
- ◇ 8. Plant the field by name, and it will answer to it. (*Fatlands*)
- ◇ 9. The first word of the year should be a short one. (*Oathen*)
- ◇ 10. A thread waxed in Grace holds a jaw till Carving. (*Sallowreach*)
- ◇ 11. Don't name the lamb till it's stopped talking. (*Cradlewrack*)
- ◇ 12. Bail before you pray; the god can wait, the water can't. (*Brinebollow*)
- ◇ 13. Seed rots, hens lie, and we say thank you anyway, three times, to nobody. (*Fast*)
- ◇ 14. The heaviest man at the Weighing is the one who ate the scales. (*Fatlands*)
- ◇ 15. A lamp in the window is cheaper than a bed in the Dormitory. (*Vigil*)
- ◇ 16. Every milestone counts both ways, and both ways it is lying. (*Rim*)
- ◇ 17. Gran smells of cedar in Grace and of Gran by Plenty. (*Sallowreach*)
- ◇ 18. If able is the whole of manners. (*Oathen*)
- ◇ 19. An open door in Grace lets the spring in; an open door in the highlands lets the spring out. (*Cradlewrack*)
- ◇ 20. Count the house through the wall before you put the kettle on. (*Brinebollow*)
- ◇ 21. Wheat that bites is wheat that's ripe. (*Fatlands*)
- ◇ 22. Eat standing and you'll never be asked to stay. (*Fast*)
- ◇ 23. Pinch the baby; it's how she'll know you love her. (*Vigil*)
- ◇ 24. Pay the toll and keep the receipt; the road remembers, but the Company forgets. (*Rim*)
- ◇ 25. A Closing costs a house, and a house costs a Closing, and nobody ever moves. (*Sallowreach*)
- ◇ 26. Sweethearts swap buckets; married folk swap knots; widows keep both. (*Brinebollow*)
- ◇ 27. What is born on the Unbricking is somebody's, whatever it is. (*Cradlewrack*)
- ◇ 28. The Bench took forty pages to say yes, and then it said if able. (*Oathen*)
- ◇ 29. First Furrow: the heaviest man pulls the plough, and the field pulls the heaviest man. (*Fatlands*)
- ◇ 30. A table in a ruin is a ruin with a table in it; walk on. (*Fast*)
- ◇ 31. Never sit where it's comfortable, never stand where it's warm, never lean. (*Vigil*)
- ◇ 32. Every land is certain the cure is next door, and next door is certain it's you. (*Rim*)
- ◇ 33. A fly in the soup is a fly that's eating; leave it be. (*Sallowreach*)
- ◇ 34. What the tide brings in, the tide has counted. (*Brinebollow*)
- ◇ 35. Lambing Eve: nobody sleeps alone, and nobody asks who's in the cot. (*Cradlewrack*)
- ◇ 36. A man of few words is a man of many years. (*Oathen*)
- ◇ 37. You look heavy, and I mean it kindly. (*Fatlands*)
- ◇ 38. If you smell bread in Grace, it isn't. (*Fast*)
- ◇ 39. Starkers' Day: throw a bell in the basket, so the baby knows what morning sounds like. (*Vigil*)
- ◇ 40. The Hem is knee-high, and every knee on the Rim knows it. (*Rim*)
- ◇ 41. Mittens on the child and the door on the latch, and both of them pulled tight. (*Sallowreach*)
- ◇ 42. A dry man drowns twice. (*Brinebollow*)
- ◇ 43. First we ask what it is; then we ask the mother; then we ask whether she wants it to stay. (*Cradlewrack*)
- ◇ 44. Say less, and say it once. (*Oathen*)
- ◇ 45. The pig and the parson come up out of the same furrow. (*Fatlands*)
- ◇ 46. A thin child is a clean child; a plump child has been somewhere. (*Fast*)
- ◇ 47. Sleep is a long word for a short life. (*Vigil*)
- ◇ 48. Lack keep away, and if Lack won't, buy it a drink. (*Rim*)
- ◇ 49. Grandfather's had his say since 212; let him finish. (*Sallowreach*)
- ◇ 50. Mind the west window; it's the only one that looks back. (*Brinebollow*)
- ◇ 51. A door that opens itself was never yours to shut. (*Cradlewrack*)
- ◇ 52. An Oathener's yes is a contract; his perhaps is a will. (*Oathen*)
- ◇ 53. Eat the pie your mother made of your father, and say it's good, because it is. (*Fatlands*)
- ◇ 54. No, thank you; no, thank you; no, thank you; well, just a little. (*Fast*)
- ◇ 55. A yawn is a rumour your body tells. (*Vigil*)
- ◇ 56. On the Rim, every chair has had a stranger in it, and one of them was you. (*Rim*)
- ◇ 57. The Kept don't grudge, they wait. (*Sallowreach*)
- ◇ 58. What the sea took, it wrote down. (*Brinebollow*)
- ◇ 59. Nine days is long enough to fall in love and short enough to stay married. (*Cradlewrack*)

- ◇ 60. Hear twice what you said once, and you'll say half. (*Oathen*)
- ◇ 61. The orchard screams in Grace so the jam won't in Carving. (*Fatlands*)
- ◇ 62. The god is warm, so wear your coat. (*Fast*)
- ◇ 63. Rouse at the bell, and rouse at the half, and rouse at the bell again. (*Vigil*)
- ◇ 64. A Company man counts the wheels, a carter counts the miles, a wise man counts the passengers. (*Rim*)
- ◇ 65. Lay Gran out on the sill for Restitching Week; she likes to see the flies go by. (*Sallowreach*)
- ◇ 66. Rope before bread, bucket before rope, name before bucket. (*Brinehollow*)
- ◇ 67. Born old is still born. (*Cradlewrack*)
- ◇ 68. Never promise in a canyon; it will promise you back. (*Oathen*)
- ◇ 69. Five meals a day, and the sixth is the one that eats you. (*Fatlands*)
- ◇ 70. Never answer *come in*, not even to your mother, not even if it is your mother. (*Fast*)
- ◇ 71. The lamp-oil is low and the lamplighter's lying. (*Vigil*)
- ◇ 72. Travel in Grace, trade in Plenty, pray in Carving, stay home in Lack. (*Rim*)
- ◇ 73. A stitch in time keeps nine. (*Sallowreach*)
- ◇ 74. Whatever walks out of the sea knows your name; you're not obliged to know its. (*Brinehollow*)
- ◇ 75. Knock once for a visitor, twice for a midwife, three times for what you don't know. (*Cradlewrack*)
- ◇ 76. The rain kept its word for six hundred years; mind that you keep yours for six. (*Oathen*)
- ◇ 77. A hungry man is honest; a full man is a liar; there are no full men. (*Fatlands*)
- ◇ 78. Hunger is honest. (*Fast*)
- ◇ 79. Blink once and you're rude; blink twice and you're gone. (*Vigil*)
- ◇ 80. The Company owns the road, the inns, the tolls, and the weather, if you ask a Company man. (*Rim*)
- ◇ 81. Better a finished fool than a Kept sage. (*Sallowreach*)
- ◇ 82. The pier grows a mile a year and the sea goes two. (*Brinehollow*)
- ◇ 83. Count the fingers; then count them again; then decide if it matters. (*Cradlewrack*)
- ◇ 84. Silence is the only thing in Tacit that costs nothing. (*Oathen*)
- ◇ 85. Don't make bread of your friends; make sausage, it keeps. (*Fatlands*)
- ◇ 86. A fourth-time yes is courtesy; a first-time yes is a funeral. (*Fast*)

- ◇ 87. Hold hands on the stair; it's harder to fall asleep holding a hand. (*Vigil*)
- ◇ 88. Every inn has a chair facing the wall, and nobody who built it can tell you why. (*Rim*)
- ◇ 89. Every rope has two ends, and only one of them is yours. (*Brinehollow*)
- ◇ 90. The dead grow nothing; the dead grow everything; it depends on the soil. (*Fatlands*)
- ◇ 91. *Turn of Grace*. At Gristmoot you can buy anything but a straight answer and a dead man. (*Rim*)

PLENTY

The fat remembers the fire best.

– A FATLANDS COOK'S SAYING, AND THE HOTTEST SEASON'S

- ◇ 92. *The Beaching*. Read the brides' names loud on the Headland, so nobody hears what they're humming. (*Brinebollow*)
- ◇ 93. Haul and hold, and do not look. (*Brinebollow*)
- ◇ 94. *Corve Night*. If a window's bricked, it was bricked for a reason; if it's bricked from the inside, it was bricked for a worse one. (*Fast*)
- ◇ 95. Plenty is the season the flies hold Court. (*Sallowreach*)
- ◇ 96. The fields sweat so the farmers don't have to. (*Fatlands*)
- ◇ 97. Summer nights are short; that's the only kind thing anyone can say about them. (*Vigil*)
- ◇ 98. A twelve-year-old's first word is chosen by a lawyer and regretted by a bride. (*Oathen*)
- ◇ 99. The midwife fasts on Hollan's Day, so the questions come out clean. (*Cradlewrack*)
- ◇ 100. In Plenty, carry water; in Lack, carry bread; on the Rim, carry both and a knife. (*Rim*)
- ◇ 101. Shut the Kept in and the flies out, and pray they don't swap. (*Sallowreach*)
- ◇ 102. Four days the Fathom took to die; four days the devout eat nothing; four hours they last. (*Brinebollow*)
- ◇ 103. What grows fastest in the heat grows teeth soonest. (*Fatlands*)
- ◇ 104. At the Pinching Fair, the bruises are the souvenirs. (*Vigil*)
- ◇ 105. A word unbitted is a dog let off the rope. (*Oathen*)
- ◇ 106. Born in the heat, born hungry; born in the frost, born old. (*Cradlewrack*)
- ◇ 107. A hot road and a cool inn and an empty chair: two out of three is luck. (*Rim*)
- ◇ 108. Nobody looks well in Plenty; everybody looks heavy. (*Fatlands*)
- ◇ 109. If the hedge is trimmed and the house is empty, somebody's still at home. (*Fast*)
- ◇ 110. The smudge-pot is the poor man's cedar. (*Sallowreach*)
- ◇ 111. The sea's not leaving, it's moving in. (*Brinebollow*)
- ◇ 112. Pinch me. (*Vigil*)
- ◇ 113. A broken man tells no lies; he can't afford them. (*Oathen*)
- ◇ 114. Cut the cord and you're a person; keep it and you're a family. (*Cradlewrack*)
- ◇ 115. The Belch blows from the south, and it means what it smells like. (*Fatlands*)
- ◇ 116. Never take the last bed in a waystation, nor the first, nor the one with the chair turned round. (*Rim*)
- ◇ 117. Nobody here is waiting to die; we are all waiting to be allowed. (*Sallowreach*)
- ◇ 118. Eat in the shade, and if the shade moves, don't follow it. (*Fast*)
- ◇ 119. Sweating Night: sleep in the field if you must, but sleep face down. (*Fatlands*)
- ◇ 120. A stranger who bails well is no stranger. (*Brinebollow*)
- ◇ 121. Every hour's a little longer than the last, and so is every sermon. (*Vigil*)
- ◇ 122. Some things are born to be named; some things are born to be counted; some things are born to be quick about. (*Cradlewrack*)
- ◇ 123. The canyon repeats everything except your apology. (*Oathen*)
- ◇ 124. Better a Company toll than a Fatlands welcome. (*Rim*)
- ◇ 125. A long life is the worst thing you can wish a friend. (*Sallowreach*)
- ◇ 126. Marry a man who can sleep on rope. (*Brinebollow*)
- ◇ 127. Every pot has a granny in it. (*Fatlands*)
- ◇ 128. No hearth, no harm. (*Fast*)
- ◇ 129. A soft voice is a slow knife. (*Vigil*)
- ◇ 130. Fingers don't count; everybody knows fingers don't count; count your fingers. (*Oathen*)
- ◇ 131. A well that gives birth has run dry of everything else. (*Cradlewrack*)
- ◇ 132. The cure is always two days down the road, and the road is always two days long. (*Rim*)
- ◇ 133. What you can't bury, sell; what you can't sell, shelve; what you can't shelve, sing to. (*Sallowreach*)
- ◇ 134. Love is wanting to feed someone; hate is wanting to eat them; marriage is both. (*Fatlands*)
- ◇ 135. A bowl of seawater for the dead, a cup of fresh for the living, and don't mix them up at supper. (*Brinebollow*)
- ◇ 136. Whoever stays awake longest gets to tell it. (*Vigil*)
- ◇ 137. Keep your knife and your mouth both wrapped. (*Oathen*)
- ◇ 138. A born-grown man has no childhood, so give him yours to borrow. (*Cradlewrack*)
- ◇ 139. The Unfed are the only clean people on the Table, and they will tell you so by lunchtime. (*Rim*)
- ◇ 140. Thin is holy; thinner is holier; thinnest is buried. (*Fast*)
- ◇ 141. In the fen the fire never goes out, and neither does the argument. (*Sallowreach*)
- ◇ 142. A hill never says no. (*Fatlands*)
- ◇ 143. Keep the rope short and the love long. (*Brinebollow*)

- ◇ 144. Lie down, and the city will lie down on top of you. (*Vigil*)
- ◇ 145. If you must swear, swear by the weather; it's the one thing already broken. (*Oathen*)
- ◇ 146. The highlands have two kinds of house: the bricked and the visited. (*Cradlewrack*)
- ◇ 147. A Rim innkeeper's three words: paid, fed, out. (*Rim*)
- ◇ 148. Nobody's full, but some are fuller. (*Fatlands*)
- ◇ 149. Never trust a man who smells of nothing. (*Sallowreach*)
- ◇ 150. Measure twice, ration once. (*Fast*)
- ◇ 151. Don't ask the Tenanted where they went; ask them where they're going, and don't wait for the answer. (*Brinehollow*)
- ◇ 152. Lidless rule, lidded weep. (*Vigil*)
- ◇ 153. A promise is a bone you lend to the god. (*Oathen*)
- ◇ 154. Mothers' names in the ledger, and footnotes for the rest. (*Cradlewrack*)
- ◇ 155. The Washing: if the walk-stone's clean in the morning, don't ask who washed it, and don't thank them. (*Rim*)
- ◇ 156. A thin man has a secret. (*Fatlands*)
- ◇ 157. Whoever pays for the Closing never gets one. (*Sallowreach*)
- ◇ 158. Everybody coughs; nobody listens. (*Brinehollow*)
- ◇ 159. Stand up to eat, stand up to pray, and stand up when the god walks by. (*Fast*)
- ◇ 160. A tin roof is a friend in the rain. (*Vigil*)
- ◇ 161. Speak in Tacit and the whole canyon is your witness. (*Oathen*)
- ◇ 162. The cradle and the coffin are the same size if you wait. (*Cradlewrack*)
- ◇ 163. The road is round so nobody ever has to go back. (*Rim*)
- ◇ 164. Field-fed and fat is the best a body can be. (*Fatlands*)
- ◇ 165. Dunmere wept; the rest of the fen wept with envy. (*Sallowreach*)
- ◇ 166. Salt on your lips at waking; kiss someone before it's sea. (*Brinehollow*)
- ◇ 167. Seen by one is a dream; seen by a street is news; seen by the city is law. (*Vigil*)
- ◇ 168. The Mute King's nod means yes, no, and come back in a month. (*Oathen*)
- ◇ 169. Every nine days, the whole country holds its breath and counts. (*Cradlewrack*)
- ◇ 170. If you smell custard, ring the bell. (*Fast*)
- ◇ 171. Hot meat travels badly, and hot money worse. (*Rim*)
- ◇ 172. Don't tell the trees you're pruning them. (*Fatlands*)
- ◇ 173. The Lofts are full of good listeners. (*Sallowreach*)
- ◇ 174. Everything in the sea is going somewhere, and so is the sea. (*Brinehollow*)
- ◇ 175. Two words make a marriage: the second one is me. (*Vigil*)

- ◇ 176. Wish for nothing out loud. (*Oathen*)
- ◇ 177. A door left open is an invitation; a door propped open is a policy. (*Cradlewrack*)
- ◇ 178. An empty belly hears the god further off. (*Fast*)
- ◇ 179. Fruit with a pit of bone is still fruit. (*Fatlands*)
- ◇ 180. The fat remembers the fire best. (*Fatlands*)
- ◇ 181. A grey hand is a closed door with a price on it. (*Sallowreach*)
- ◇ 182. *Turn of Plenty*. Bottles of the Keep at Gristmoot: two lacks a bottle, and the bottle keeps the lacks. (*Rim*)

CARVING

Carving is for the knife, Lack is for the bone.

– RIM SAYING

- ◇ 183. *Yellowing*. A leaf that falls in the fen is luck; keep it in a box, and don't let it hear you leave. (*Sallowreach*)
- ◇ 184. The Reaping is wolves, and there are no wolves, and mind you're in by dusk. (*Fatlands*)
- ◇ 185. Carving is for the knife, Lack is for the bone. (*Rim*)
- ◇ 186. Marbling Morning: run barefoot on the white, and don't run far. (*Fatlands*)
- ◇ 187. The Closed Week keeps the marriage and the country both. (*Cradlewrack*)
- ◇ 188. Cut it on the Ledger and it's cut in you. (*Oathen*)
- ◇ 189. Low Water: watch them sing from the rail, and hold the rail. (*Brinehollow*)
- ◇ 190. Every hour of Carving is a little lazier than the one before. (*Vigil*)
- ◇ 191. *Short Night*. Read the names of the left-off all night, and leave nobody off the reading. (*Fast*)
- ◇ 192. Gold light and no harvest: that's the heartland every day. (*Fast*)
- ◇ 193. He ate well, we said, and we meant he tasted good. (*Fatlands*)
- ◇ 194. The rot is slow, but it has all the time in the world, and so have you. (*Sallowreach*)
- ◇ 195. Count the tide-posts, and leave a space for yourself. (*Brinehollow*)
- ◇ 196. Shout on the Grey Ninth for the eleven hundred, and shout once more for the one nobody counted. (*Vigil*)
- ◇ 197. A word carved is a word kept; a word miscut is a man broken. (*Oathen*)
- ◇ 198. The pangs come closer, so stand further apart. (*Cradlewrack*)
- ◇ 199. The meat market at Gristmoot: buy by the barrel, and never ask the barrel. (*Rim*)
- ◇ 200. The field remembers who fed it. (*Fatlands*)
- ◇ 201. What's shelved is not forgotten; it's filed. (*Sallowreach*)
- ◇ 202. A rope cut in the night is the saddest thing that can happen to a bed. (*Brinehollow*)
- ◇ 203. Never trust a mild afternoon. (*Vigil*)
- ◇ 204. A Clausewright's love letter has an index. (*Oathen*)
- ◇ 205. The Dilation's wider every time you look, so look less. (*Cradlewrack*)
- ◇ 206. The god in the middle is lonely; that's not your problem. (*Fast*)
- ◇ 207. Every barrel from the Chute is stamped twice, and both stamps are lying. (*Rim*)
- ◇ 208. In by dusk, and if you're not, then we'll eat you anyway at Harvest Home. (*Fatlands*)
- ◇ 209. Hush the child, but never shut the window on the Shut House side. (*Sallowreach*)
- ◇ 210. Whatever you drop on the Uncovered belongs to the next tide. (*Brinehollow*)
- ◇ 211. Sixty thousand beds and every one of them made. (*Vigil*)
- ◇ 212. Ask a question and you've made no promise; ask a fool a question and you've made his fortune. (*Oathen*)
- ◇ 213. A hand without a body is still somebody's hand. (*Cradlewrack*)
- ◇ 214. The Lists are not a holy day; everyone attends. (*Fatlands*)
- ◇ 215. A Crumb-Runner is spat at and fed from in the same hour. (*Fast*)
- ◇ 216. Every land curses the Company and every land pays the toll. (*Rim*)
- ◇ 217. May you finish. (*Sallowreach*)
- ◇ 218. A Called man walks with his face to the warm wind; don't stand in his way, stand in his shoes. (*Brinehollow*)
- ◇ 219. Sleep is a debt, and the city is the debtor, and the eye is collecting. (*Vigil*)
- ◇ 220. Say *as I now intend*, and intend very little. (*Oathen*)
- ◇ 221. Every crowning brings up something; most of it's clay. (*Cradlewrack*)
- ◇ 222. The scarecrow in the far field is nearer than last year; that's all anyone will say. (*Fatlands*)
- ◇ 223. A warm front in the Fast means company. (*Fast*)
- ◇ 224. On the Rim, a man's land is the last thing he tells you and the first thing you guess. (*Rim*)
- ◇ 225. A candle that feels itself burn gives the steadiest light. (*Sallowreach*)
- ◇ 226. The sea writes its letters on the cellar stairs, in kelp. (*Brinehollow*)
- ◇ 227. Two pinches make a friend; three make a marriage; four make a Waker. (*Vigil*)
- ◇ 228. The Forsworn are honest because they've run out of anything else to be. (*Oathen*)
- ◇ 229. Mother, Mother, shut my eyes. (*Cradlewrack*)
- ◇ 230. Fasting is treason, so fast in secret, and eat in public, and hate both. (*Fatlands*)
- ◇ 231. No hearth in the house, no table in the kitchen, no chair you can't carry. (*Fast*)
- ◇ 232. The cheapest inn on the Rim is the one with the most graves out back. (*Rim*)

- ◇ 233. An argument in the fen outlives the house it started in.
(*Sallowreach*)
- ◇ 234. The Admiralty hangs men for saying stranded, so say
aground. (*Brinehollow*)
- ◇ 235. What's seen in the Seeming is seen; what's seen alone is a
symptom. (*Vigil*)
- ◇ 236. Oathen trusts nobody, so the whole Table trusts Oathen.
(*Oathen*)
- ◇ 237. A midwife's knife is called the Second Opinion, and there
is no third. (*Cradlewrack*)
- ◇ 238. Every Laden grandmother is a good field and a poor
listener. (*Fatlands*)
- ◇ 239. If you hear plates go down behind you, don't turn round
to count them. (*Fast*)
- ◇ 240. A Company receipt is the only paper that outlives its
signer. (*Rim*)
- ◇ 241. The Unvacated hold the deeds, and the young hold the
Unvacated, and the deeds hold everyone. (*Sallowreach*)
- ◇ 242. Better Called than Tenanted, says the widow; better
Tenanted than Called, says the wife. (*Brinehollow*)
- ◇ 243. Lamps for the living, mirrors for the dead, and tin for the
roof between them. (*Vigil*)
- ◇ 244. Better a slow tongue than a short leg. (*Oathen*)
- ◇ 245. The Barren Order begins nothing, and it's the only order
that's growing. (*Cradlewrack*)
- ◇ 246. The dusk shift pays double, and nobody has ever collected.
(*Fatlands*)
- ◇ 247. An Unfed's thanks is three noes and a nod. (*Fast*)
- ◇ 248. When the stage is late, the passengers are early somewhere
else. (*Rim*)
- ◇ 249. A Kept man's mouth is the last thing to go, more's the pity.
(*Sallowreach*)
- ◇ 250. Count west windows and you'll know who's next.
(*Brinehollow*)
- ◇ 251. Nobody in the Vigil has seen a star; nobody misses what
they've never been allowed. (*Vigil*)
- ◇ 252. Little promises break little bones. (*Oathen*)
- ◇ 253. The waters come up without rain; the people go down
without reason. (*Cradlewrack*)
- ◇ 254. Don't marry into a family with a hill. (*Fatlands*)
- ◇ 255. Whatever is laid is laid for you. (*Fast*)
- ◇ 256. Seven spokes on the Company wheel, and a hub with
nothing in it. (*Rim*)
- ◇ 257. Every jar on the long shelf is listening. (*Sallowreach*)
- ◇ 258. The Netwatch hooks gentle and hauls hard. (*Brinehollow*)
- ◇ 259. Don't count sheep. (*Vigil*)

- ◇ 260. The Bench drafts in the dark and signs in the light.
(*Oathen*)
- ◇ 261. Whatever it is, it isn't you. (*Cradlewrack*)
- ◇ 262. The hungrier the guest, the sweeter the host; the sweeter
the host, the hungrier the field. (*Fatlands*)
- ◇ 263. Hollow is a holy place, until it's yours. (*Fast*)
- ◇ 264. Buy cures on the Rim and you buy someone else's curse in
a nicer bottle. (*Rim*)
- ◇ 265. Whatever's in a Hush is quiet, and whatever's quiet is in a
Hush. (*Sallowreach*)
- ◇ 266. Lay the drowned face down; they'll look up at the gulls if
you don't. (*Brinehollow*)
- ◇ 267. A lid is a door you wear. (*Vigil*)
- ◇ 268. Your word is your bone. (*Oathen*)
- ◇ 269. Ten fingers to the count, and if you've eleven, count slower.
(*Cradlewrack*)
- ◇ 270. Granny Cracknel keeps the teeth, so mind your manners at
the mill. (*Fatlands*)
- ◇ 271. A rouse-tooth falls out by Carving; a rouse-heart stops by
Lack. (*Vigil*)
- ◇ 272. Ask nothing of the chair you were not offered. (*Fast*)
- ◇ 273. *Turn of Carving.* A Rim winter is three months of barrels
and nine of debt. (*Rim*)

LACK

Lack keep away.

– THE GRACE SAID WITH STRANGERS IN EVERY LAND, AND THE SAYING FOR
TABLENIGHT

- ◇ 274. Lack is the season with the honest name. (*Rim*)
- ◇ 275. There is no winter in the fen, because winter is an ending. (*Sallowreach*)
- ◇ 276. The cold makes the Called walk faster. (*Brinebollow*)
- ◇ 277. Long nights are long; the Vigil has no other news. (*Vigil*)
- ◇ 278. Marbling melts by noon, but the fat in the ground remembers. (*Fatlands*)
- ◇ 279. In Lack, the Pantry list is read standing, and heard sitting down. (*Fast*)
- ◇ 280. Frost on the lintel, a pang in the hill, and the door ajar again. (*Cradlewrack*)
- ◇ 281. A cold wind carries words further; keep your mouth in your scarf. (*Oathen*)
- ◇ 282. Never answer a knock on a licked-clean night; never answer it twice. (*Rim*)
- ◇ 283. Cold ears hear the Lofts better. (*Sallowreach*)
- ◇ 284. Tie the knot twice in Lack; the sea's lonelier in the dark. (*Brinebollow*)
- ◇ 285. Ice on the tin roof is a lullaby with teeth. (*Vigil*)
- ◇ 286. Five meals in Lack, and the fifth one cold. (*Fatlands*)
- ◇ 287. A quarter-measure less is still a measure. (*Fast*)
- ◇ 288. A child born in Lack is born with a coat on; check under it. (*Cradlewrack*)
- ◇ 289. Frost cracks stone and promises both. (*Oathen*)
- ◇ 290. The thin market at Gristmoot: double prices, half bread, whole lies. (*Rim*)
- ◇ 291. A Kept man doesn't feel the cold, but he hears his own joints in it. (*Sallowreach*)
- ◇ 292. Ice in the bucket at dawn means bail faster, not less. (*Brinebollow*)
- ◇ 293. Cold is the Waker's best friend; warmth is the room's. (*Vigil*)
- ◇ 294. A Laden hill steams in Lack like a pudding cooling. (*Fatlands*)
- ◇ 295. Hunger in Lack is only Grace that came too early. (*Fast*)
- ◇ 296. The Tally is read at dusk, so the dark can listen too. (*Cradlewrack*)
- ◇ 297. The canyon is quietest in Lack, and listens hardest. (*Oathen*)
- ◇ 298. The Company buys grain for the Fast at the turn of Lack and sells it at the turn of Grace. (*Rim*)
- ◇ 299. Smoke the house, keep the Kept, and never let the fire go out; it couldn't anyway. (*Sallowreach*)
- ◇ 300. A drowned man is warmer than a Called one. (*Brinebollow*)
- ◇ 301. Wrap up warm, but not too warm. (*Vigil*)
- ◇ 302. The orchard sleeps in Lack, but it sleeps with one eye open. (*Fatlands*)
- ◇ 303. Snow on the road is the god's tablecloth; don't sit on it. (*Fast*)
- ◇ 304. Brick the room at dusk and say goodnight to it at dawn. (*Cradlewrack*)
- ◇ 305. A frozen word comes back in the thaw. (*Oathen*)
- ◇ 306. The longer the night, the more chairs at the inn. (*Rim*)
- ◇ 307. Long life to you; I mean it badly. (*Sallowreach*)
- ◇ 308. In the coldest Lack the sea came back for a night, and everyone went to look, and that was the year of the walking. (*Brinebollow*)
- ◇ 309. Rouse in Lack is sweeter and kills quicker. (*Vigil*)
- ◇ 310. Fast for Tablenight if you like; you'll eat by noon. (*Fatlands*)
- ◇ 311. Keep your back to the door and your face to the cold. (*Fast*)
- ◇ 312. A door that freezes shut is the only miracle in the highlands. (*Cradlewrack*)
- ◇ 313. The eve of the silence is the loudest night in the canyons; everybody's saying goodbye. (*Oathen*)
- ◇ 314. A Rim inn on a Lack night has three noises: the fire, the drinkers, and the one at the window. (*Rim*)
- ◇ 315. Every jar in the Jar Room wants a word with you. (*Sallowreach*)
- ◇ 316. Set a bowl of seawater at the table's head and don't watch it. (*Brinebollow*)
- ◇ 317. Count aloud in the dark minute; if someone else is counting with you, stop. (*Vigil*)
- ◇ 318. Nobody has ever made it to sundown, and nobody has ever stopped trying. (*Fatlands*)
- ◇ 319. *The Night of Ears.* Lay your ear on the warm sand and say nothing; it already knows. (*Oathen*)
- ◇ 320. *Tablenight.* Lack keep away. (*Every land*)
- ◇ 321. *The First Morning.* Cut the cord at first bell and say come down, then. (*Sallowreach*)
- ◇ 322. The day after Tablenight is the hungriest day of the year, and the most polite. (*Rim*)
- ◇ 323. What came to the open door on Tablenight is in the house now; feed it nicely. (*Cradlewrack*)
- ◇ 324. The bowl was dry in the morning, and nobody drank it. (*Brinebollow*)

- ◇ 325. The lamps come back on, and everyone counts who's still holding hands. (*Vigil*)
- ◇ 326. Oathen speaks again on the morning after, and the first thing it says is *if able*. (*Oathen*)
- ◇ 327. The dead didn't taste it, and we didn't either, and we said it was lovely. (*Sallowreach*)
- ◇ 328. The fields are frozen, but the furrows are warm under; don't kneel. (*Fatlands*)
- ◇ 329. A plate laid in an empty house in Lack is laid for the house. (*Fast*)
- ◇ 330. The coldest seat at the Groaning Board is the one facing the wall. (*Rim*)
- ◇ 331. Mittens in Lack; mittens in Plenty; mittens in your coffin, if you ever get one. (*Sallowreach*)
- ◇ 332. What freezes in the chest comes up in pieces. (*Brinehollow*)
- ◇ 333. A Vigil child knows three hundred bells and no stars. (*Vigil*)
- ◇ 334. The weight you lose in Lack the Board finds in Grace. (*Fatlands*)
- ◇ 335. A crust left on the sill is an invitation, no matter what you meant. (*Fast*)
- ◇ 336. Every pang in Lack brings up something that's cold, and some of it's glad to see you. (*Cradlewrack*)
- ◇ 337. A man who says *always* had better mean it in Lack. (*Oathen*)
- ◇ 338. Cures are cheapest in Lack, because the sellers can't wait. (*Rim*)
- ◇ 339. A shelved man is a patient man. (*Sallowreach*)
- ◇ 340. No sea, no fish, no ships, no war; the Admiralty has never been more ready. (*Brinehollow*)
- ◇ 341. Better a slap at the door than a bed in the Row. (*Vigil*)
- ◇ 342. In Lack the dusk shift is short, and the Reaping is not. (*Fatlands*)
- ◇ 343. The Unfed don't feast; they remember not feasting, together. (*Fast*)
- ◇ 344. *Turn of Lack*. What the Company sells in the thin market it bought from the dead at the meat one. (*Rim*)
- ◇ 345. Not yet, said the first child, and the country's been saying it since. (*Cradlewrack*)
- ◇ 346. The old ones of the canyons die quiet, and leave nothing behind them but conditions. (*Oathen*)
- ◇ 347. The Sump bubbles in patterns; don't read them aloud. (*Sallowreach*)
- ◇ 348. A widower in Lack sleeps with two ropes and wakes with one. (*Brinehollow*)
- ◇ 349. Warm milk is a crime and a kindness. (*Vigil*)
- ◇ 350. Every Fatlander dreams of being full, and wakes up hungry, and calls it breakfast. (*Fatlands*)
- ◇ 351. The Abstinents have the keys, and the keys have the Abstinents. (*Fast*)
- ◇ 352. On the Rim the year ends twice: once on Tablenight, once when the bill comes. (*Rim*)
- ◇ 353. The Lofts whisper louder in the cold, and lately they're whispering the same word. (*Sallowreach*)
- ◇ 354. Haul for Mam and haul for hope. (*Brinehollow*)
- ◇ 355. Close one eye and you're half asleep; close the other and you're a citizen of the room. (*Vigil*)
- ◇ 356. We'll sit at board and say your name. (*Fatlands*)
- ◇ 357. *The Nine Days begin*. A quarter-measure less today, to remember the hill. (*Fast*)
- ◇ 358. On the second of the Nine, the old ones shake like a lid on a pot. (*Fast*)
- ◇ 359. On the third of the Nine, chew nothing and call it supper. (*Fast*)
- ◇ 360. Whatever is born in the last days of Lack is born to the year that's coming, and it knows. (*Cradlewrack*)
- ◇ 361. The fifth day of the Nine, stand on whoever you must. (*Fast*)
- ◇ 362. The year's last oaths are the cheapest; the Bench is tired. (*Oathen*)
- ◇ 363. The seventh day is not said. (*Fast*)
- ◇ 364. The last night of Lack is the longest in the fen, because it doesn't end there either. (*Sallowreach*)
- ◇ 365. *The ninth of the Nine*. Say it with your lips if you can't say it aloud: no, thank you. (*Fast*)



The almanac leaves out the eighth of every list. I asked the printer why. He said the compilers asked him to. I asked the compilers. They said the printer did.

A CUTWRIGHT OF QUIRE, IN A LETTER TO A COLLEAGUE

▼ GRAFFITI OF THE RIM

The house fed me once. It was good.

— SCRATCHED UNDER THE HOUSE RULES AT THIMBLE CROSS

The Rim Road is two thousand four hundred miles of fitted grey stone, and every mile of it has been written on. Carters scratch their marks on milestones with a nail; Crumb-Runners chalk their codes on the backs of tollhouses; lovers carve the walls of privies; the condemned, the Called, the Reckoners, the Second Table and the cults of every land leave signs for each other in places the Company's whitewash crews never quite reach. The Company paints over what it can find. It cannot find most of it, and some of it comes back through the paint.

Each line below gives the text as it is scratched, where it is found, and what it means to those who know. Guests who learn to read the Rim's walls (a scene with a Crumb-Runner, a Lineman of the College, a Netwatch officer, or any carter who has done the full circuit) gain +2 to **Search and Instinct** for finding trouble, shelter, or a contact at any waystation, because the walls are telling them.

THE NORTHERN STRETCH: FOGMOUTH TO LAMPWICK

- ◇ **"Hum for me."** *Scratched on the back of the red-line post at the Drop, outside Fogmouth, low down, where a person sitting on the Sallowreach side could reach.* The Kept who come to the Drop to see their living kin off cannot cross; they ask the living to carry the Ferrying Song's hum across the line and let it finish on the far side. A hum finished south of the line is the nearest thing to a Closing the poor can afford.
- ◇ **"MAY YOU FINISH — and you, and you, and you."** *Painted on the Fogmouth gate-arch, renewed every Grace in a different hand.* A blessing, the fen's politest. The repetitions are a Finishers' count: one *and you* for every pilgrim who walked into a Hush that year. The arch is getting crowded.
- ◇ **A pair of closed eyes, carved, with a nail driven through each lid.** *On milestones from Fogmouth south to the Weeping Post.* The mark of Marrow Jack's part-runners: a Kept limb is for sale nearby. The nails mean the seller knows the owner can feel it.
- ◇ **"6 V. 9 L. 0 W."** *Pencilled inside the door of the Inkborn's privy, Quire.* A Lineman's tally of three College ledgers: six Vane-descended bloodlines entered at the Course this year, nine Lung-lines, no Wendles. Every Lineman who reads it adds to it. The Provost has had the door replaced four times.
- ◇ **"It's not deafness."** *Chalked on the Weeping Post's chapel step, in a careful surveyor's hand.* Edda Thrush, the Hushwalker, passed this way. Those who follow her say the chalk does not wash off in the weep-rain, and that standing on it, you hear nothing at all for a moment, and then something listening.

- ◇ **A bowl, upside down, scratched with a stone.** *On the walls of the Weeping Post, by the hundred.* The Purgation's mark: *here a Penitent brought something up.* An upright bowl means a hall is near and will feed you thin soup. An upside-down bowl means the thing that came up was sold on this spot, and the buyer may still be in the inn.
- ◇ **"LAMB."** *Scratched very small on the inside of a lamp-glass at Lampwick Halt, where the Company keeps a hundred lamps burning for Vigil merchants.* A Bedded mark: this inn has a cellar with no lamp in it, and a Shepherd who will sit with you if you want to lie down. Wakers who find it smash the glass and fine the house. The Halt goes through a great many lamp-glasses.
- ◇ **"Pip owes me a pinch."** *Scrawled in a child's hand on the studded wall of the nudgers' yard, Lampwick Halt.* A nudgers' debt-wall; a child who has been pinched awake by another and not repaid writes it here. Some of the names have been there for years, and the children who wrote them are in the Dormitory, and the Halt's nudgers still honour them: when they pass the wall, they pinch the name.
- ◇ **Three short lines and a long one, repeated: |||| ||||.** *Scratched along the coping of the Halt's east wall.* A Seemer's record: on these nights, the travellers lodged here all hallucinated the same thing. The long line means it was the tall figure laying a table. The marks have been growing more frequent since 638.
- ◇ **"The hours are longer here. Ask Maud."** *Chiselled small into the face of the Lampwick milestone.* Maud Sexton's pendulum measurements, as passed from mouth to mouth by the clock-menders of the plateau. Travellers who time the walk between this stone and the next by a good watch find it takes a little longer every year, and the distance has not changed.

THE EASTERN STRETCH: MUMCHANCE TO WANTING POST

- ◇ **"IF ABLE."** *Carved deep into the lintel of Mumchance, the quietest inn in the world.* An Oathen joke and a warning. Every promise made under this lintel is, by local custom, understood to be conditional, and the innkeeper believes (and the Bench has not ruled otherwise) that the carving makes it so. Oatheners come a long way to say something unwise under it.
- ◇ **A hand drawn with two fingers bent back.** *Scratched on the felted walls of Mumchance's taproom, under the felt.* A Sureties' mark: a professional who will carry your oath for a fee is drinking here. The number of bent fingers is the number of defaults the Surety can still survive.

- ◇ **“Say less.”** *On the Treaty Stair, on almost every step, in a thousand hands.* What every Oathen child is taught. Foreign clerks carrying contracts down to Jessamy Quill’s office scratch it with their own nails as they go, partly as a joke, partly as a prayer. Nobody has scratched it on the last step, outside her door. Nobody will say why.
- ◇ **A fist with the thumb between the fingers.** *Scratched on the long stone wall at Quillhouse, among the travellers’ carved conditions.* The Forsworn’s sign. A traveller who has broken a promise and carries the break visibly is welcome in the Breakdowns; the sign points down-canyon, and someone will meet you.
- ◇ **“I promised her I’d come back. I came back. Somebody tell her.”** *Cut into the Quillhouse wall in an Oathen hand, without a single condition, dated 627.* An oath kept, recorded by the man who kept it. Nobody knows who *her* is. Oatheners stop and touch it with two fingers, as they touch a handtalk poem, because a promise kept without a condition is the rarest thing in their country.
- ◇ **“WE CARRY OUR OWN.”** *Scratched on the inside face of the Hem, opposite Wanting Post, where only someone stepping over the Hem from the Fast side would see it.* The Reckoners’ word, and their road-sign: a band crossed here going out. If the line under it has a number, that is how many came back. Most of the numbers are smaller than the bands.
- ◇ **“no thank you no thank you no thank you”** *Written in charcoal around the inside rim of the water-trough at Wanting Post.* An Unfed child’s work, renewed by other children. The Fast’s children believe that a trough with the Decline written round it cannot be filled by anyone but the Company. They are wrong. Some mornings it is found full of warm milk.
- ◇ **A small circle with eight short lines around it.** *Cut on the doorpost of the Company factor’s office at Wanting Post, and on doorposts at four other stations.* Nobody admits to it. The Company says it is a wheel and the vandal miscounted the spokes. The Hostwatch say that it appears on the doorposts of buildings where, within a month, a table is found laid inside. The factor at Wanting Post has had his doorpost replaced. The mark was on the new one in the morning.
- ◇ **“BREAD → 2 mi.”** *Chalked on the Saltlick Cross lamp-post that faces the heartland road.* A Crumb-Runner’s code for a cache of grain hidden off the road. Or a trap. Real Crumb-Runner caches are marked with an arrow pointing *away* from the bread, because if you smell bread in the Fast, you walk into the wind. A Rim traveller who follows this arrow will find a table two miles in, laid.
- ◇ **“This one was mine. Pray for the next one.”** *Scratched with a blade on the inner wall at Saltlick Cross, where the old heartland road runs straight in toward Hallowboard.* Written by a Tablebreaker after his four-hundredth table, and copied since by

others after theirs. The first one is in the hand of Decline Marsh. He has not been seen at the Cross since the four hundred and first.

THE SOUTHERN STRETCH: THIMBLE CROSS TO TOLL NINE

- ◇ **“The house fed me once. It was good.”** *Scratched under the house rules above the dicing-board at Thimble Cross.* A ruined gambler’s last line. The rest of it reads *I lost the rest of my life here anyway, but it was very good soup.* The innkeeper has never painted it out; he says it is the best advertisement he has.
- ◇ **Nine strokes, then a tenth through them.** *On each of the nine stone markers in the little graveyard behind Thimble Cross.* A Rim carters’ count: nine travellers buried here, and the tenth stroke means *one of them got up.* Nobody agrees which. The graveyard is the only one on the Rim that has its grass cut, and nobody on the staff cuts it.
- ◇ **“YOU LOOK HEAVY.”** *Carved, with love, into the six-hundred-seat table at the Groaning Board.* The Fatlands’ kindest compliment. Drovers carve it beside the place where a friend sat, after that friend’s wake. There are three hundred and twelve of them. Rim travellers who sit at a carved place are served first, and given the best cut, and watched.
- ◇ **A two-tined fork, very small, scratched beside a window-latch.** *At the Groaning Board and nine other inns.* A Second Table sign: a Taster or Trencherman lodged in this room and found the inn safe for a dinner. If there is a line under it, the dinner happened. If there are two lines, someone at the dinner did not finish their plate.
- ◇ **“Barrel 4417 — notch.”** *Pencilled inside a cooper’s stave in the Chute’s yard, and copied onto the yard wall.* Quartermaster Ivo Stockpot’s private sign, imitated by the yard-gangs: this barrel is one he would not eat from himself. The gangs mark the wall too, so the carters will know. The wall is very full of notches.
- ◇ **“Long Count: Low Tilt 41. Gristle End 17. Furrowby 9.”** *Chalked on the back wall of a Gristmoot sausage-stall, renewed every Carving.* Pell Hogget’s tally of the Reaping, copied from village to village. Stallholders rub it out when the Bailiffs come by and chalk it up again afterward, a little higher. The numbers are always higher.
- ◇ **A dripping spoon.** *Scratched on the doorposts of Gristmoot cookshops.* A Second Helping sign: this cook is of the faith, and will feed you as an act of love, and may ask, very sweetly, if you would like to be part of the next meal. Most Gristmoot cookshops have one. Some have scraped it off, and the scraping is the same shape.
- ◇ **“Who counts the counters?”** *Scratched on the lintel of Toll Nine, the Company’s windowless counting-house.* A clerk’s joke, or a clerk’s confession. Inside Toll Nine, according to those who have worked there, the Company keeps a real ledger pricing the

end of each land, and the clerks who copy it are not let out until the copy is finished. Someone scratched this on the way in.

- ◇ **“Sallowreach 9. Vigil 11. Cradlewrack ?”** *Scratched faint into the stone of Toll Nine’s west wall, at waist height.* A copy of the summary page of that ledger, in years. Somebody got out with it in their head. The question mark has been gone over many times, by many hands, deeper each time.
- ◇ **“MEAT IS MEAT.”** *Painted in red on the Chute’s gate, in letters a yard high, and painted out every week.* The Renderers’ Union’s unofficial motto and the Fatlands’ answer to every other land’s disgust. Under the paint, if the light is right, there is an older line in a different hand: *meat was someone.*

THE WESTERN STRETCH: SALTBRIDGE TO KNOCKING GATE

- ◇ **“BONE: MIXED.”** *Stencilled on the sealed carts at Saltbridge, and scratched by carters on the bridge parapet.* The stamp on the bone that comes up from the Chute to the Company’s Cure-House to be minted into lacks. Carters who scratch it on the parapet are making a joke about money. Every lack on the Table is somebody. The carters say *mixed* means *you’ll never know who.*
 - ◇ **A rope tied in a lover’s knot, carved.** *On the eleventh arch of Brackwater Bridge, the one over where the river used to run before it followed the sea out.* A Wreckwife’s mark: a woman lives near here whose spouse came back Tenanted, and she will talk to another. The Wreckwives say that on the anniversary of the Beaching the carved knots are found wet.
 - ◇ **“Subject appeared expected.”** *Scratched hundreds of times along the inn wall at Lowmark Spur.* The Netwatch’s standard phrase for the Called, written in their logs thousands of times. Netwatch officers on leave scratch it here, once for each Called they could not stop, and nobody knows whether they mean it as mourning or as a joke. They do not know either.
 - ◇ **“West is the way home.”** *In salt crystals, as if scratched with a wet finger, on the inside of the Lowmark Spur inn’s west windows.* Nobody writes it. The staff wipe it off every morning. It forms again overnight, on the glass, from the inside. The wardens watch which guests stand at those windows, and the guests who read the line aloud are the ones they watch hardest.
 - ◇ **“Borrow a bucket, leave a name.”** *Painted above the rack of bail-buckets at the Lowmark Spur inn, kept for coast travellers who forgot their own.* The rule is genuine: you scratch your name on the rack when you take a bucket and cross it out when you bring it back. The names not crossed out belong to travellers who were Called somewhere on the road inland. The innkeeper keeps the oldest ones uncrossed on purpose, and on Tablenight sets their buckets out by the west door.
 - ◇ **“There’s one of us on every hook.”** *Chalked by children on the walls of the Spur, in the skipping-rhyme’s rhythm, with hopscotch squares beneath.* The sixth line of the hauling song’s burden, as
- skipped in the Mile. Some of the chalk is in a child’s hand. Some of it says *one of them.* The children say they did not write those.
 - ◇ **“Not yet.”** *Scratched very small on the inside of the Open Door’s curtain-rails at Knocking Gate, the inn with no doors.* The first words ever spoken by a Cradlewrack newborn, in Kest in 94 A.G. Highland travellers scratch it as a prayer on the way out of the country: let whatever is in me not come yet, not here, not until I am home. Marshal Breech’s men check every traveler for signs of carrying, and they read the rails.
 - ◇ **Three knocks, cut as three short notches, then a door drawn ajar.** *On milestones from Knocking Gate north to the Weeping Post.* A highland warning: something has been born on the road near here, and was not answered by a midwife, and is walking. The more ajar the door is drawn, the bigger it has grown.
 - ◇ **“Mam, I’m sorry. I did it on the Rim so it wouldn’t hold.”** *Scratched on the wall of a privy at Knocking Gate, dated 633.* Petra Quick runs expectant mothers across the Rim so they can deliver somewhere the rule does not hold. She has found that it holds: the country goes with them. This line was written by one of hers. Underneath, in another hand, months later: *It held.*
 - ◇ **“8.”** *Scratched on the Hem itself, the knee-high wall facing the Fast, at intervals the length of the ring, by no one anybody has seen.* There is one every hundred miles or so, all the way round, in the same size and the same depth, in stone that the Company says has not been recut since it was laid. The Company’s crews grind them out every year. They do not come back. They are simply found again, a little way along. Rim folk do not discuss them, and step over the Hem, when they must, a little way from the nearest one.

▼ BEDTIME STORIES OF THE SEVEN LANDS

Tell me the one about the hand again. No, the real one. No, the one where it gets in.

– A CHILD OF KEST, AT BEDTIME

Every land tells its children stories at night, even the Vigil, where night is a lamp-lit stretch of the same long day and the stories are told to keep the child awake rather than to send it off. The seven stories below are the commonest of each land, as a parent tells them at the bedside, word for word as they were taken down by a College clerk making a survey of nursery-lore in 630 and 631. After each is the true event the story grew from, as the College's own ledgers record it. Parents do not tell that part. Most of them do not know it.

Some of them do, and tell the story anyway, because a story is the only safe way to tell a child what happened.

Each story ends with a short note for the Carver: what happens when a Guest tells it, or hears it, at the table.

GRANNY WICK AND THE FLY KING



As told in the Sinks of Lastgate, by a mother to two children in a shared cot, with the shutters latched and a smudge-pot going on the sill.

Once upon a time, in a tall thin house on the Sinks, there lived a Granny called Granny Wick, who had been Kept for two hundred years, and she was the oldest thing in the house, older than the stairs. She was very tidy. Her stitches were black and small, and her jaw was wired with silver wire, and in Restitching Week the Seamers came and sewed her up as neat as a parcel, and she smelled of cedar for a fortnight, and then she smelled of Granny.

Granny Wick sat in the window, in the big chair, with her mittens on, and she told the children stories, and she never once complained. Not once. Only, every night, when the children kissed her, she would say, very quietly, open the shutter for me, my lamb. Just a crack. Just tonight.

And the children would say, no, Granny, it's the Shutter Days, the flies are out, and they would latch it tight, and kiss her, and go to bed. And Granny Wick would say, never mind, my lamb. May you finish.

Now, outside the shutter, in the Shutter Days, there lived the Fly King. He was very tall and very thin and he had a coat made of a thousand thousand wings, all humming, and a crown of bluebottles, and he was terribly polite. He had been courting Granny Wick for a hundred years. Every Plenty he came and stood outside her window in the warm dark and

hummed to her, and she hummed back, and the children never heard.

One night the littlest one, whose name was Moss, could not sleep, and she came down the stairs and found Granny Wick crying. Kept people cannot cry, because their eyes have gone dry, so it was only the shape of crying, but Moss knew it.

What's the matter, Granny?

Oh, my lamb, said Granny Wick. I am so very tired of the stairs. And the Fly King has asked me to dance, and I've no shutter to dance through.

And Moss loved her Granny very much. So she climbed up on the sill, and she unlatched the shutter, just a crack, just that night.

In came the Fly King, humming, in his coat of a thousand thousand wings. He bowed to Granny Wick, very low, and he bowed to Moss, and he said, thank you, little one. You have a kind heart. And he held out his hand, and Granny Wick took off one mitten, and put her grey hand in his.

And they danced. They danced round the kitchen and up the stairs and down again, and every time they turned, a little bit of Granny Wick went away on a wing, a crumb, a thread, a stitch, carried off by one of the Fly King's thousand thousand courtiers, and Granny Wick laughed and laughed, and she got lighter and lighter, and smaller and smaller, until at the last she was as light as a moth, and the Fly King lifted her up, and they went out of the window together into the warm dark, humming.

In the morning there was nobody in the big chair. There were only two mittens, one on the cushion and one on the floor. And Mam cried and cried, and the Court came and fined the house a whole lack, and Moss was sent to bed without supper.

But that night, when Moss lay in bed, she heard a humming at the shutter. And it was not one voice, it was a thousand thousand voices, very small, and every one of them was Granny Wick's, and every one of them was saying, thank you, my lamb. Thank you. Thank you. Because in the fen nothing ends, not even a Granny; she had only gone very small, and very many, and very far.

So that is why, my darlings, you must never, ever swat a fly in Plenty. Because it might be Granny. And that is why you latch the shutter tight in the Shutter Days, and kiss your Kept goodnight, and never, ever open it, however nicely they ask. Because the Fly King is still out there, in his coat of wings, and he is very polite, and he is courting all of them.

Now go to sleep. No, leave the smudge-pot. Leave it. Goodnight.

THE TRUE EVENT

In the Shutter Days of 487 A.G., in a tenement on Clench Row in the Sinks, a Kept woman named Otilie Wrayburn, two hundred and eleven years upright, persuaded her great-great-great-granddaughter, a girl of eight called Mossy Wrayburn, to unlatch

the shutter of her room for one night. A Black Noon was moving through the Sinks. The family found Otilie in the morning stripped by the swarm to wire, lacquer and bone, and wholly aware: the Seamers' report records that the flies had taken everything soft, and laid in what they did not take, and that she spoke throughout the restitching, saying only *thank you*. The Mortuary Court fined the household one lack for an *unlicensed attempt at finishing*, and passed the Shutter Ordinance of 488, under which shutters in the Shutter Days are latched from the outside by the parish. What was left of Otilie Wrayburn was Set Aside in the Lofts in 489. Old Bettany Shroud's night-book records that she still says *thank you* whenever a fly lands on her shelf, and that lately, like all the others, she has begun to whisper something else. Mossy Wrayburn lived to be ninety-one, and was Kept, and asked every one of her own descendants, every Shutter Day for a century, to open the shutter, and nobody ever did.

At the Table. A Sallowreacher Guest who hears this story told by a Kept relative, and understands what is being asked, faces **Dread 2**. A Guest who opens a shutter for a Kept person who asks, in the Shutter Days, may give that person the nearest thing to a Closing the poor can have: the Black Noon finishes nothing, but the Kept who go out with the flies are, the fen believes, dancing. It costs the Guest 2 Fray and the household's good name.

THE BOY WHO WANTED TO BE FULL



As told in Low Tilt, by a father to a boy of six, between the fourth and fifth meals of the day, with a heel of toothed-wheat bread in the boy's fist.

Once there was a boy called Ned Dumpling, and he was the hungriest boy in all the south. He ate his five meals and he ate his mam's five meals, and he ate the crusts off the board and the dripping out of the pan and the candle-ends out of the chapel, and still his belly said more, Ned, more.

So one morning Ned Dumpling put on his boots and went out to find somebody who could tell him how to be full.

First he went to the Miller. The Miller was as wide as his own millstone, and he was eating bread made of his own flour, with the teeth still in. Miller, Miller, said Ned, how do I get full? And the Miller laughed so hard his chair cracked, and said, Full? Nobody's full, boy. There's no such word. And he gave Ned a loaf, and Ned ate it on the road, and he was just as hungry.

Then he went to the Bailiff. The Bailiff had a funnel and a ladle and a kind soft face. Bailiff, Bailiff, said Ned, how do I get full? And the Bailiff patted his head and said, Full is against the law, lad. It'd mean you could stop. And he poured Ned a ladle of gravy, and Ned drank it, and he was just as hungry.

Then he went to Old Mother Mound, who was a hill at the end of the lane, a little green hill with an apple tree on top of her and a mouth in her side. Mother Mound, Mother Mound, said Ned, how do I get full? And Old Mother Mound opened her mouth very wide, and Ned could see down and down and down into the warm dark, and she said, in a voice like soil settling, I've been asking that for forty years, poppet. When you find out, come and tell me.

And Ned Dumpling sat down on the side of the lane and cried, because he was so hungry, and nobody in the whole south knew how to be full.

Now, in the far field, the one past the last hedge, there stood a Scarecrow. Nobody had put it there. It had a hat and a coat and a face made of a sack, and it stood with its back to the village, and every Carving it was a little nearer. And the Scarecrow heard Ned crying, and it turned round, very slowly, which scarecrows are not supposed to do, and it said:

Ned Dumpling. I know where it is.

Where what is? said Ned.

The pudding, said the Scarecrow. The great pudding, at the bottom of the furrow. Everyone who eats it is full forever. Come at dusk, and I'll show you.

So Ned Dumpling went home and ate his fifth meal, and when the sun went down red over the fields, and his mam was busy at the copper, he slipped out of the back door, and over the last hedge, and into the far field, where the Scarecrow was waiting.

Lie down in the furrow, said the Scarecrow, and close your eyes, and open your mouth.

And Ned lay down in the warm brown furrow, and the field was soft as a feather bed, and it went up and down under him, slow, like breathing. And he closed his eyes, and he opened his mouth. And the furrow folded over him like a blanket, the way your mam tucks you in, all warm and heavy and sweet.

And for the first time in his whole life, Ned Dumpling was full.

In the morning they looked for him, and they didn't find him. But the next Grace, the wheat in the far field came up taller and sweeter than any wheat in the south, gold to the ear, with little white teeth all smiling in rows. And Ned's mam cut it, and milled it, and baked a loaf, and when she ate it she wasn't hungry for a whole hour. A whole hour! Nobody in the south had ever heard of such a thing. She sat by the window for the whole hour, very still, with her hands in her lap, and she said it was the best hour of her life.

So that is the story of Ned Dumpling, who found out how to be full.

And that is why, my lad, you come in by dusk. Every night. However the Scarecrow asks. Unless you want to be full.

Do you want to be full?

No. Good lad. Eat your bread.

THE TRUE EVENT

The story is told across the plains, but the College traces it to the parish orphan-house at Furrowby, in Low Tilt, in the bad Carving of 517 A.G., when the Feasting Laws' fines for under-feeding fell on houses whether or not they had food to give. The matron, Dorcas Breadwell, could not feed her forty-one charges five meals a day and was fined twice in a month. On the third occasion she sent the hungriest boys out to glean the far field at dusk, telling them this story, which she claimed afterward to have invented to give them heart. Eleven did not come back. The far field yielded that next Grace at a rate the Board's assessors called *unexampled*, and an assessor named Varn Sweetbread the Elder, grandfather of the present Cullmaster, wrote a memorandum on the coincidence of yield and absence which the Board filed under *agriculture*. The office of the Cullmasters was established in 519. The orphan-house at Furrowby was fined again the following Carving, for under-feeding, and closed. Its far field is still the best in the parish. The eleven gave the Board its policy and saved their house nothing.

At the Table. A Fatlander Guest of the Appetite or deeper who hears this story told at dusk must make a **Caul + Resolve** check (Hard 14) or go to the window and look toward the far fields until someone speaks their name. A Guest who repeats it to a Cullmaster's man and mentions Furrowby will find that the man knows the name, and the year, and is very interested in who taught the Guest both.

THE GIRL WHO HELD THE ROPE



As told in the Mile, by a grandmother to a girl of seven, while tying the girl's anchoring-rope to the bed for the night; the knots are tied as the story goes.

Once, in the hungry time, before the sea went away, there was a girl called Jenny Rope, and she was going to be married to a boy called Orry, the handsomest boy on the whole coast, who could swim like a seal and sing like a kettle.

Now the Fathom was lying off the beach, big as a hill and grey as a slate, and it wouldn't come in to be eaten, no matter how the people pulled. And the Sounders came up out of the water with their ears all bleeding and said: the Fathom wants a keepsake. Seven of your best, your youngest, your promised. Send them out on the ropes. And one of the seven they chose was Orry.

So on the night before, Jenny Rope took a piece of hemp, so, and she tied it round Orry's wrist, so, in a lover's knot, like

this one, see, over and under and through and back, and she held the other end in her own two hands. And she said, Orry, I'm holding the end. You go where you have to go. But I am holding the end.

And Orry kissed her and walked out on the hook-line into the dark water, hand over hand, singing, and went in under the Fathom's great grey side, into a door that opened for him, and he was gone.

And Jenny Rope stood on the shingle and held the end.

All night the haulers pulled, and the song went haul and hold, haul and hold, and the water came pouring out of the Fathom, and people fell down and were laid out on the stones. And Jenny Rope held the end. Her hands bled. Her feet froze. Her mam came and said let go, Jenny, he's gone, and Jenny Rope said I'm holding the end.

And at the turn of the tide, when it was darkest, she felt the rope go tug. Tug, tug. Just like that.

So Jenny Rope went in after him.

She went hand over hand along the rope, into the water, under the grey side, through the door that opened, and inside the Fathom it was dark and cold and silver, and there were rooms, great soft rooms like the inside of a shell, and the water was up to her knees, and she could hear singing a long way in. And she held the rope, and followed it, room after room, deeper and deeper, in the dark, until she came to the end of the rope.

And there was Orry, at the end of the rope, sitting in the silver dark, with his wedding shirt on, and he looked up and smiled at her.

You came, he said.

I was holding the end, said Jenny Rope.

And she took his hand, the one with the knot on it, and she led him back, room after room, along the rope, out through the door, up through the water, onto the shingle, just as the sun came up. And the Fathom came in on the tide, and the people ate, and the hungry time was over. And Jenny Rope and Orry

were married on the beach, with the knot still tied, and they never untied it, not ever, not even when they were old.

And that's why, my duck, at every wedding on the coast, they tie the lover's knot. And that's why we tie you to your bed at night, over and under and through and back, by somebody who loves you. So that if you go walking in the night, out to the water, there's somebody holding the end.

There. That's the last knot. Who's holding the end?

That's right. Gran is.

THE TRUE EVENT

Orry Weir was one of the seven Hook-Brides of the Beaching, given by the north-shore village of Weirholm and tied to a hook-line at the wrist with a lover's knot. The chronicles of the Lung-lines record that his betrothed, a girl of nineteen whose name they do not give, followed the line in after him during the night, hand over hand, into the god's gill-openings. She was found at dawn among the founders of the Lung-lines, in the flooded chambers of Dromm's lungs, where they had spent the night eating raw in the dark, by touch, with the water to their knees. She was carried out half-drowned with Ondric Vasht and the rest. In her hand was Orry's wrist-knot, still tied, and nothing else of him was ever found. The Vasht chronicle's struck sentence says that *the lights were full of sweetmeats*, and that every one of those who went in ate in the dark and blessed the god for its provision. She lived to be seventy-eight. She bailed more than a gallon at every dawn and dusk of her life, more than any Scrapling on the coast, and the Debt chapels say she was bailing Orry. She never married. The knot is in the Admiralty's Sounding Hall in a case, labelled *a relic of the Brides*. The Weirholm story calls her Jenny Rope. Her own family called her nothing at all, afterward.

At the Table. Telling this story while tying a sleeper's anchoring-rope gives the sleeper +2 against the pull that night. A Guest who has read the Vasht chronicle, or Abiah Steep's letter, and then hears the story told to a child, faces **Dread 2**, and must decide whether to say anything.

COUNT THE SHEEP, BRYONY



As told on the Slope, by a hired nudger of fourteen to a girl of five, sitting up on the sloped floor of a tenement at the twenty-second bell, with a pin in the nudger's hand.

Eyes open. Eyes open, Bryony. That's it. I'll tell you the one about the sheep, and you keep your eyes on me the whole time,

and if they shut I'll pin you, and you'll say thank you. Ready?

Once, in the soft old days, before the lamps, there was a girl called Bryony, the same as you, and she was a shepherd's girl up on the plateau, and she had a hundred sheep. White ones. Fat ones. And every night her da said to her, Bryony, count them in. So she stood at the gate of the pen, and the sheep

came over the hill, and one by one they jumped over the gate into the pen, and she counted. One, two, three. All the way to a hundred. And then she shut the gate and went to bed, and slept like a stone.

Eyes open.

Then one year the bad thing happened, the First Night, and her da lay down and didn't get up, and her mam lay down and didn't get up, and Bryony was all alone with the sheep. And she was so tired. You know the tired. Like a hand on top of your head, pushing.

So she went out to count the sheep in, because her da always said to. And the sheep came over the hill, white and fat, and jumped the gate, one, two, three. And when she got to a hundred, there was another one. A hundred and one. And another. A hundred and two. And they kept coming, white and soft and woolly, jumping the gate, and she counted and counted, because her da said to, and her eyes went heavy, and heavier.

And she looked into the pen.

And the pen was very long. Longer than a pen should be. Long and dim, like a room, with lamps burning low along the walls. And all the sheep were lying down in it, in rows, in the warm, breathing all together, in and out. And at the far end of the pen there was a shepherd.

He was very big. Bigger than the hill. And he was sitting in the dark at the end, with his hands on his knees, and he had one great eye in the middle of his face, and it was shut.

Eyes open, Bryony.

And the shepherd said, in a voice like a pillow, Keep counting, little one. When the pen is full, I'll open my eye, and look at all my sheep, and then we'll all go home.

And Bryony was so tired. And the sheep were so soft. And she wanted to see the shepherd open his eye. So she kept counting. A thousand. Ten thousand. Fifty thousand. Sixty thousand, nearly. And every sheep that jumped the gate lay down in a row and went to sleep, breathing in and out with all the others.

And the shepherd's eyelid fluttered. Just a little. Like a moth.

And Bryony, the clever girl, the brave girl, she took her da's shearing-pin out of her pocket, and she stuck it in her own thumb, hard, like this.

Yes, like that. Say thank you.

And she woke up. And she was standing at the gate of the pen, in the grey morning, and the pen was empty, and there was nobody at the end of it, and her thumb was bleeding. And she knew the number. The number of sheep. She'd counted them all, right to the edge. And she ran all the way to the city, to the people with lamps, and she told them.

And the lamp-people said thank you, Bryony. And they gave her a lovely bed.

Eyes open.

So that's why we never count sheep, not in your head, not ever. Because they jump into the long pen, and the long pen is nearly full. And if you have to count, you count them out. Out, Bryony. Over the gate and away. Sixty, fifty-nine, fifty-eight. Out of the pen. Never in.

That's it. Count them out. I'll pin you at the bell.

THE TRUE EVENT

In 401 A.G. a Dream-Diver of the Watch named Bryony Lisle went under on the tether, and was dragged up after a dive of nineteen minutes, longer than anyone had lived through, and said she had the number: the count of sleepers at which the eye in the long room opens. The Watch had her say it once, to three officials, in a sealed room on the Nodding Stair. One of them wrote it down. One was charged to remember it. One, the Matron of the Dormitory, took it in her head back to the beds, and it has passed from Matron to Matron ever since. Bryony Lisle was then given warm milk and a bed, and her bed was added to the count, so that she could never be made to say it again to anyone else. She is Bed 8,012. The official who wrote it down burned the paper the same evening and walked through the Pillow fence before the morning bell. The other went mad by the Seeming within the year, and spent the rest of his life counting aloud, backward, in the Glass House. The Slope's nursery story began within a generation. The hired nudgers tell it best, because they have to keep the child awake to the end of it.

At the Table. In the Vigil, telling this story to a Weary listener and having them *count the sheep out* backward from sixty, aloud, removes **1 Weariness** from the listener, once a day, as a nudger's pin would; it is a technique the Slope's nudgers swear by. Counting them *in*, aloud, past sixty, is a scene of comfort (+1 Weariness) for everyone listening. A Guest who reaches Bed 8,012 in the Dormitory and looks at Bryony Lisle's lips will find them moving, very slightly, in a count. It is not going up.

THE LITTLE HAND THAT KNOCKED



As told in Kest, by a mother to two children in a bricked room, after the night-mason has laid the last course and before the candle is out.

There. That's the last brick, and nothing can get in, and you're both in, and I'm in, and the rest is out. Snug as stones. Now, which one? The hand? Again?

All right. Once upon a time, high in the red hills, a woman lay down to bear, and the midwife came with her basin and her apron, and asked the first question. What is it? And what came out was a hand. Only a hand. A little one, a left one, warm and pink and wriggling, and all its fingernails perfect.

And the midwife asked the second question, very quietly, and the mother said, let it stay. So it stayed.

The little hand was a good hand. It could knit, and it could scratch backs, and it could pat a cheek. But it was lonely. Because everyone else in the house had a body, and the little hand had only itself. So one night, when the pang had passed and the doors were all drifting open, the little hand climbed down off the cot and went out of the open door to look for the rest of itself.

It walked on its fingers, tip-tap, tip-tap, down the lane, and it came to the first house, and it knocked. Low down on the door, right at the bottom, where a hand would knock if it had no arm. Knock.

And a voice said, who's there?

A hand, said the little hand. Have you got the rest of me?

And the voice said, not here, and knocked back once. Knock. And the little hand went on.

It went to every house in Kest. Tip-tap. Knock. Not here. Knock. Only once, in a house at the bottom of the town, a woman opened the door, because she thought it was her own little one come home. And the hand looked up at her, and she looked down at it, and she said, you're not mine. And the hand said, no. But you've got two, and it took hold of her finger, very gently, and it would not let go, and in the morning the woman's left hand was gone from the wrist, as neat as a midwife's knot, and the little hand had a friend. So the little hand went on with its friend. And it went out of Kest, and up the hills, and down the ravines, all through the highlands, knocking, knocking. And in one house it found a foot, all alone, that had been born just like the hand; and the foot said,

I'm looking too, and they went on together. And in another house they found an ear, and in another a length of back that crawled, and in another a whole arm with no hand on the end of it, and the arm and the hand looked at each other, and they fit.

Click. Like a key.

And they all went on together, a bigger and bigger thing, knocking on doors, looking for the rest. And it's out there still, my darlings. Walking through the highlands at night. Getting bigger. Every pang it finds a little more of itself.

So if ever you hear a knock in the night, low down on the door, right at the bottom, where a hand would knock, you mustn't open it. You mustn't. You knock back, once, like this, knock, and you say, nice and clear, not here. And it'll go on to the next house.

And one day, when it's found every bit of itself, all its hands and all its feet and its ears and its back and its mouth, it won't knock on houses any more. It'll go up to the big round hole in the middle of the hills, and kneel down at the edge, and it'll knock on that.

And then we'll see what answers.

Now. Candle out. What do we say if we hear a knock?

That's right. Not here.

Goodnight. The brick's sound. Nothing gets in.

THE TRUE EVENT

In 500 A.G. a midwife of the Attendance at Mortar Rise named Wenna Clay was keeping, in a lined basket under her bed, two Parts she had been ordered to give the Second Opinion and had not: a warm left forearm born to a tanner's widow in Rudge, and a hand, a left one, born to a shepherd's daughter of Tarnbrow thirty miles away. One night in Carving she found them in the basket joined at the wrist, the skin knitted without a seam. She took the joined thing to the Lying-In, where the Attendance's surgeons established over the following month that Parts from unrelated families fit each other, everywhere, exactly; this is the event called the Gathering of Parts. The joined arm was kept at the Lying-In under glass. It knocked on the glass, softly, at the height of a door's lowest panel, at every pang until 612, when it was stolen, and the Assemblers have never admitted to taking it. Wenna Clay was given the Going Back for disobedience. Dov Marrin's assembled figure in the Assemblers' Barn has a left arm whose hand is missing at the wrist, and the

Barn's keepers report that on pang nights the stump taps, very gently, on the boards.

At the Table. In Cradlewrack, a Guest who answers a low knock in the night with one knock and *not here* is left alone: no roll. A Guest who opens the door, or answers *who's there?*, faces whatever

the Carver has been saving. A Guest who knows where Hester Lowe keeps the hand she bore, and tells this story near her, will make an enemy who has promised to kill anyone who comes for it.

THE BOY WHO PROMISED THE PLATE



As told in Tacit, in writing, on a slate, by a father to a bitted boy of nine; the father writes a line, the boy reads it and wipes it, and the father writes the next. Copied by the College clerk from the slates before they were wiped, with the father's leave, if able.

Once there was a boy called Ash who lived high on the Sunward Wall, and he had a little sister called Wren, and he loved her more than figs.

In the year of this story, children did not wear the bit. Their mouths were free. They could say anything. Imagine it. It was a frightening time.

One Lack, Wren took the fever. She lay in her cot and burned, and she would not eat, not bread, not figs, not honey. And Ash sat by her and said, what would you eat, Wren? Anything. Tell me.

And Wren looked out of the window at the Plate, which was full that night and white and round over the canyon, and she said, I would eat that.

And Ash said, I promise I will bring you the Plate to eat.

You know what happened then. The god inside him heard. What it heard was so.

That night, nothing. The next night, Ash's little finger cracked, like a twig, because the Plate was in the sky and not in Wren's cot. The night after that, the next finger. Every night he did not keep his promise, another bone in him went, a little at a time, as the god counted.

His mother held a lamp up to the window and said, there, Wren, there's the Plate, and the god did not believe her. His father baked a round white loaf and set it in the cot, and the god did not believe him either. The lawyers of the street came and stood about the cot in a row, and drafted, and argued, and went home, and in the night another bone went. Ash did not cry out. He had promised enough.

So Ash climbed. He climbed to the top of the Sunward Wall, where the canyon ends and the sky starts, and he stretched up

his hands to the Plate, and it was very far, and his fingers were broken. And he sat down on the top of the world and he wept, and the canyon wept back at him, over and over, because canyons repeat everything.

And up there, on the rim, there was an old woman sitting on a stone. She was a Clausewright, the oldest one there ever was, so old that she had used up all her words but a very few, and she was saving those.

She looked at Ash's fingers. She looked at the Plate. And she spent four of her words on him. She said:

Bring her the Plate.

And she handed him a bowl. A plain clay bowl. And she poured into it water from her own flask, and set it down on the stone in front of him, and Ash looked down.

And there, in the bowl, round and white and full, was the Plate.

So Ash carried the bowl down. All the way down the Sunward Wall, a thousand steps, with his broken fingers, without spilling a drop, and the Plate lay in the water the whole way, and it did not go out. And he set it down on Wren's cot, and he said, I brought you the Plate. And the god inside him listened, and it heard, and it was so: he had brought the Plate. And it let him go.

And Wren sat up, and she drank the Plate out of the bowl, all of it, in one long drink, cold and white and sweet. And her fever went out of her like a lamp. And in the morning she was well, and Ash's fingers were mended, every one.

So: remember. A word is a bone. Say less. But if you must promise, think first, and promise something you can carry down the stairs.

Now wipe the slate. That is the end. If able.

THE TRUE EVENT

In Lack of 214 A.G., a boy of eleven in Tacit named Ashe Varro, unbitted, as all children then were, promised his sister Wrenna, who

was dying of the canyon fever, that he would bring her the moon. There was no Clausewright on the rim. Over nine nights his body broke to match: first the fingers, then the hands, then the bones of the forearms, while his family tried every interpretation the street's lawyers could devise, a lamp held up to her window, a round white loaf, a mirror. None was accepted. On the tenth night, the god in him having found nothing that would serve, his eyes clouded white and round, perfectly round, like two small plates, and he could see nothing ever afterward, and it is said that his sister, looking into them, said they were beautiful. She died the next day. The fever would have taken her whatever he had promised. The Bench of Clauses passed the Muzzling the following year, requiring all children to be bitted until twelve. Ashe Varro lived to be sixty and taught handtalk to bitted children in Low Dray, and never spoke again. The story's Clausewright, the old woman who saved her

words, does not appear in any record. The Quiet believe she was invented by Ashe himself, in handtalk, for the children he taught, because he wanted one story in Oathen where a promise could be kept by being clever.

At the Table. An Oathener Guest who has made a rash promise and hears this story told may roll **Tongue + Clause** at Grim (18) to find, as Ash did, an interpretation the god will accept; the Carver must agree that the interpretation is honest. A success keeps the oath. A failure costs the next bone. The story is also how every Oathen child learns that a rash promise has an *if able* in it somewhere; the father writes *if able* on the slate at the end, and the boy is supposed to notice.

THE CRUST ON THE SILL



As told in Wanting, by a mother to a girl of eight, both standing, the girl in her sleeping-shift, in a room with no hearth, before the girl lies down on her board; the Unfed tell stories standing.

Once there was a girl called Tarry, the same as your aunt, and she lived in a cold stone house in the heartland, with her mam and her da and her brothers, and they were very thin and very good.

One night in Lack, Tarry saved the crust of her one meal, the way you're not supposed to, and she put it on the windowsill for the birds, because she felt sorry for them.

In the morning the crust was gone. And in its place, on the sill, there was a better crust. Soft, and white, and warm, as if it had come out of an oven, though there was no oven anywhere in the whole Fast.

And Tarry looked at it, and she said, No, thank you. Like a good girl. And she left it.

That night, she put her own crust on the sill again. And in the morning, there was a bun. A sweet one, with a glaze on it, shining. And Tarry said, No, thank you. No, thank you. And she left it.

The next night, she put her crust on the sill. And in the morning there was a pie. A whole pie, with steam coming out of the slits, and the smell came in through the shutter and went all through the house, and her brothers woke up and their mouths were wet. And Tarry said, No, thank you. No,

thank you. No, thank you. And her mam came and threw the pie in the snow.

And the next night, Tarry didn't put anything on the sill. But in the morning, when she opened the shutter, there was a table in the yard. A long table, with a white cloth, and candles lit, and dishes on it, all steaming, and four chairs, and a fifth chair pulled out, and at the head of the table there stood somebody very tall, stooping, with a kind face that you couldn't quite see. And it was warm. The snow had all melted round it, like a hem.

And the tall one said, Tarry. You've been so kind to me. Won't you come in?

And her brothers went to the window. And her mam and da went to the window. And they were so hungry. And they looked at Tarry.

And Tarry said, No, thank you.

And the tall one said, please.

And Tarry said, No, thank you.

And the tall one said, there's plenty. There's always plenty. Please.

And Tarry said, No, thank you.

And then, my love, the tall one asked her a fourth time. It asked very softly, the way you'd ask a person who was dying. And everyone knows that on the fourth time, it's manners to say yes.

And Tarry said it a fourth time. No, thank you.

And the tall one stood very still. And then it bowed to her, low, the way it bowed to us on the hill, and it began to cry. Its tears were warm and they ran down onto the table and the candles went out. And it picked up the whole table, cloth and candles and pie, and folded it up like a letter, and walked away into the gold, stooping, and it never came back to that house again.

And Tarry's mam held her so tight her ribs creaked. And they were hungry for the rest of their lives, all of them, and they were clean. And that is the happiest ending there is.

So. If anything is left on the sill, what do you say?

That's right. Four times. Even on the fourth. Especially on the fourth.

Lie down now. Back to the door.

THE TRUE EVENT

In the winter of 43 into 44 A.G., in the village later called Corve Hatch, the youngest daughter of Abel Corve, a girl named Tarry Corve, left the crust of her ration on the windowsill on several nights running, for the birds. Her elder sister Stint, who did not sit and whose descendants live in Wanting and Hillward, later testified

to the Abstinent that the crusts were replaced, and with better things, and that Tarry hid them from the family and shared them with her brothers. In Lack of 44 the family found a table laid in their own kitchen. They were very hungry. Stint was outside fetching snow to melt when they sat. She came in to find her mother, her father, Tarry and the three boys at the table, eating from empty plates and smiling, and they asked her to sit, and she said no, three times, and on the fourth she was not asked again: the chair at the table had been pushed in. The neighbours watched the family through the window for eleven years before they understood it could not be undone, and bricked the window up from outside. The Corve kin stand at the bricked window one night a year, on Corve Night, with their backs to it. Every visitor adds a brick. Stint Corve told this story to her own children with Tarry's name in it and a different ending. She never said which part was the lie.

At the Table. An Unfed Guest who tells this story to a child, standing, gains +1 **Want**. A Guest who hears it told within sight of one of Orrum's tables gains +2 on the next Invitation check. A Guest who goes to Corve Hatch and listens at the bricked window hears, among the Corve voices calling *cousin, cousin, there's plenty*, one small voice saying *No, thank you*, three times, and then, after a long pause, nothing at all. **Dread 3.**

A **STORY** IS THE ONLY SAFE WAY TO TELL A **CHILD** WHAT
HAPPENED. THAT IS WHY **EVERY STORY** ON THE
TABLE HAS A **BETTER ENDING** THAN THE
TRUTH, AND WHY **EVERY CHILD**, SOONER OR
LATER, ASKS FOR THE REAL ONE.

[BRAM HOLLIN, THE LAST MOURNER]



PART THREE

FOOD AND PLAY

What is eaten, what is carried, and what is played for stakes.



CHAPTER 6

THE TABLE'S COOKBOOK

We were hungry. Say it plainly. We were hungry, and they were there.
– FIRST LINE OF EVERY HISTORY WRITTEN ON THE TABLE, AND, IN
GRISTMOOT, OF EVERY COOKERY BOOK

Eat while it's warm. It won't be.
– FATLANDS PROVERB, STITCHED ON OVEN-CLOTHS

Preface to The Receipts of the Seven Tables and the Road Between, gathered by Odo Pellance, under-cook of the Company inn at Saltlick Cross, in the twenty-sixth year of his service, 641 A.G. The manuscript was bought at the Gristmoot rag-stall bound in oilcloth, with a crust of reed-bread pressed between the last two pages like a flower.

I have cooked for every kind of mouth there is. I have cooked for Fatlanders who ate the plate's glaze off when the stew was gone, and for an Oathen notary who looked at my roast for a quarter of an hour and then signed, slowly, if able, and did not touch it. I have cooked for the Kept, who chew for company and spit into a blue dish, and who always, always say it was lovely, because what else is there for them to say. I have set a cold supper on the step for an Unfed boy and watched him walk past it three times before he would take it on the fourth, and then eat it facing the stable wall, with tears on him, as if I had hit him.

A cook on the Rim learns two things early. The first is that every land eats its god, still, every day, a little, and calls it supper. The second is that nobody on the Table has ever once been properly full, and that the ones who say they are are lying or are Seated.

I have written down what they eat and how they eat it and what they say before and after. I have put in the curses where I know them, because a receipt without its curse is half a receipt. Where a dish is wicked I have said so. Where it is only sad I have said that too. Where I have eaten it myself I have marked it with a small cross, and there are more crosses than I would like.

On the Inn at the Crossroads: we burn the table. We do not read the card. I want that written down here, in my own hand, before anything else. We burn the table.

I have been at Saltlick twenty-six years. The chair rents for a platter a night now. I have never once seen it empty at dusk.

This chapter is a cookbook in two voices. The first is the Table's own: the receipts, rites, curses and manners of seven lands and the Rim Road between them, set out dish by dish as the cooks of the Long Grace would set them out, with what the food does to those who eat it. The second voice is ours. Every dish ends with a box headed **For Your Table**, which is a real recipe, for real and ordinary food, made from ingredients found in any market, to be cooked and eaten on game night. The wake-pie of the Fatlands is, at your table, a beef and ale stew. Lady Aspic's blinking jelly is a red-wine jelly with grapes in it. The ration-bread of the Fast is an oatcake. The horror is all in the fiction; the food is just food, and it is good.

A RECIPT WITHOUT ITS CURSE IS HALF A RECIPT.

[ODO PELLANCE, UNDER-COOK OF SALTICK CROSS]

▼ HOW TO USE THIS COOKBOOK

Each land has its own section, opened by its sigil and by a short account of its **table manners**: how its people sit (or stand), what they say, what they will not eat, and what will get a guest thrown out, broken, needled or served. Then come five or six dishes. Each dish has four parts and a box:

- ◇ **The receipt**, in an in-world hand, set as fiction. These are not instructions anyone should follow. Several of them are crimes.
- ◇ **Lore**, the story, ritual or curse the dish carries: who first made it, who still does, and what happened at the table where it went wrong.

- ◇ **Rules**, for the dish in play: its Taint (see the Rim Market chapter), any effect it has on Hunger, Flesh, Fray or the land's own tracks (Weariness, Pangs, Want), and the Dread check, if any, for eating it, watching it eaten, or knowing what it is.
- ◇ **Hook**, a scene or adventure seed that begins at the plate.
- ◇ **For Your Table**, a real recipe themed to the dish, with quantities and steps, for players to cook and share.

A NOTE ON THE REAL RECIPES

Every For Your Table recipe is ordinary home cooking: no rare ingredients, nothing dangerous, nothing that is not normal food. Quantities are given in metric and cups; oven temperatures in Celsius with Fahrenheit and gas mark. Recipes serve four to six unless stated, which is a party plus a Carver. Check your guests for allergies before game night: several dishes use nuts, gluten, dairy, eggs, shellfish or fish, and each box says so. Where a recipe uses wine, beer or spirit, an alcohol-free swap is given; the drinks marked "for adults" are for adults. Handle hot sugar, hot oil and sharp knives with the care you would give a Hand-line's ungloved fingers. And do not, whatever the fiction says, eat anything that bites back.

COOKING IN PLAY

Characters cook, and on the Table cooking is a craft with consequences. To cook any dish in this chapter properly, a character rolls **Eye + Craft** against the dish's listed Difficulty (most are Routine 10; wake dishes, jellies and anything of a god are Hard 14 or worse). A character who knows the land's own way of cooking it (a native, or anyone who has eaten it at the source) gains +2.

- ◇ **Success**. The dish is made and has its listed effect.
- ◇ **Helping**. For each Helping, one diner of the cook's choice gains an extra benefit: -1 Fray, or 1 Flesh healed, or +1 to their next Persuade roll at that table.
- ◇ **Grace (doubles on a success)**. The dish is remembered. Everyone at the table gains -1 Fray, and the cook gains a reputation in that land: +2 to Persuade anyone who ate it, for a season.
- ◇ **Lack (doubles on a failure)**. The dish carries its curse. Every dish below says what that is.

A shared meal. A party that sits (or stands, in the Fast and the Vigil) to a proper meal together, with the grace said, removes one level of Starving, or one Pang in the Fast, and each character may roll Caul + Resolve (Routine 10) to shed 1 Fray. Only once a day. In the Fatlands, ordinary food never satisfies: the Starving level goes, but Hunger does not, and a Fatlander who eats a full meal and is still hungry is simply a Fatlander.

Eating the god. Anything grown in a Godeater soil, coughed from a Godeater lung, or carved from a Godeater body carries Taint, as given in the Rim Market chapter. Foreign gods are worse. An Unfed character who eats Tainted food of a Godeater land risks Seasoning; three marks and they are Returned. Several dishes below are perfectly safe. Several are sold as safe and are not. The receipt usually knows the difference. The cook does not always say.



Every pot has a granny in it.

FATLANDS PROVERB, SAID FONDLY

▼ THE GRACE IN SEVEN FORMS

Lack keep away.

— SAID BEFORE EATING WITH ANY STRANGER, EVERYWHERE ON THE TABLE

Nobody on the Table eats with a stranger without first saying *Lack keep away*. Skipping it is the universal insult: worse than spitting, worse in some lands than a blade. But the grace is never only the three words. Every land has added to it, cut from it, signed it, slapped it or refused it, and a traveller who learns the seven forms eats in seven countries as a guest instead of a suspect.

In play. Saying a land's own grace correctly at its table gives +1 to every Persuade and Hagggle roll with the hosts for the rest of the meal. Saying the common grace only is courteous and gives nothing. Saying no grace at all with strangers is an insult: -2 to all social rolls at that table, and in some lands, worse, as each form below notes.

THE FEN GRACE (SALLOWREACH)

Lack keep away. May we all finish. Said by the eldest upright person at the table, who is often dead. If the eldest's jaw no longer holds, the next eldest says it on their behalf, standing beside their chair with one hand on the back of it. The Kept at table do not eat but answer *finish* with a click. To say *long life* after the grace is the worst curse in the north, and a guest who does it by mistake (it is the commonest toast on the Rim) will find every Kept head at the table turned slowly toward them, and the meal going on in silence. Dread 1, the first time.

THE FIELD GRACE (THE FATLANDS)

Thank you, Long Acre. Thank you, Hessop's Rise. Thank you, Granny Dunn's Meadow. Every Fatlands meal begins by thanking the fields by name, the fields the food came from, which are very often the household's own dead, Seated, as hills. Strangers add *Lack keep away* at the end. The grace ends, after the meal, with the plate wiped clean with bread. A guest who leaves a smear is fined; a guest who does not thank the field is thought to be either a Thin or a thief, and a Bailiff may be called. Five times a day.

THE DRY GRACE (BRINEHOLLOW)

Lack keep away, and keep you dry. Said with the bail-bucket at the foot of the chair, after everyone has bailed, because it is unforgivable to cough brine at the table. The answer is *and you*. At the Lantern on Mile Nine and every Mile inn, no table on the west wall is laid after dusk, and nobody says the grace facing west, because a word said toward the sea is said to the sea. In houses that have lost someone to the Calling, a pause is left after *dry*, the length of a breath, for whoever is not there.

THE WAKING GRACE (THE VIGIL)

Lack keep away, said with the eyes open, wide, every eye at the table on every other eye, and followed at once by a flat-handed slap on the table, loud enough to rattle the sharp-rimmed bowls. In the rich houses of the Height the slap is a ritual of great elegance, done with a jewelled paddle. On the Slope it is done with a fist. A guest who blinks during the grace is pinched by their neighbours, hard, as a kindness. A guest who closes their eyes to pray, as is the custom in some lands of the Rim, is needled.

THE KNOCKING GRACE (CRADLEWRACK)

The table is knocked three times before anyone sits, to warn whatever is under it. Then: *Lack keep away, and let it stay*. The highland addition is older than the Gorging and its meaning has drifted. Once it meant *let the Lack stay away*. Now every highlander means something else by it, privately, and looks at the door while they say it. A guest who sits before the knocking is regarded with real horror; it is like opening a bricked room without leave. A guest who does not look at the door is thought to be very brave or very foreign.

THE SIGNED GRACE (OATHEN)

In Oathen the grace is signed in handtalk, which is held not to bind: the left hand flat, palm down, and drawn away from the mouth. It is said aloud only when foreigners are at table, and then very slowly, with three exits: *Lack keep away, if able; as I now intend; barring weather*. Nothing more is said for the length of the meal. To praise the food aloud is a grave error, because *this is delicious* is a statement, and the god weighs statements; a foreigner who said *best meal of my life* at a Tacit table was found the following morning unable to taste anything, ever again. Weight 1.

THE DECLINE (THE FAST)

The Unfed do not say grace. They refuse it. Before eating, standing, facing a wall, an Unfed says *No, thank you* three times, quietly, to nobody, and then eats what they carried themselves. The Decline is the whole of their table-rite and the whole of their last rites, and to hear it said in the dusk of a Wanting yard by a hundred people at once, all facing outward, is a thing travellers do not forget. An Unfed who hears a Godeater say *Lack keep away* will sometimes add, under their breath, *it didn't*.

THE GRACE BELL (THE RIM)

On the Rim Road the common grace is said at noon at the Grace Bell, when three miles of Gristmoot stalls stop at once and every person turns to the nearest stranger and says it, face to face. It is the one moment of the day on the Rim when nobody is selling anything. Company inns ring a smaller bell at supper. The Company's own *Book of Usages* adds one instruction to the grace, and it is followed by every inn-keeper from Fogmouth to Wanting Post: *Count the chairs before the grace. Count them again after.*

THE LINE THAT IS NOT SAID

The oldest grace-stones on the Table, at the corners of Fatlands fields and in the walls of the Witnessing Vaults and on the lintel of the Empty Chair, carry the grace carved in Table-speech, and every one of them is longer than the grace anyone says. After *Lack keep away* there is a further line, and in every case it has been chiselled out: by different tools, in different centuries, leaving a rough pale scar the length of perhaps five words. Grandfather Peat, the bog body of the Sump, will say the common grace if asked, in his dead dialect, and then stops, with his mouth open, as if waiting for someone else to say the rest. A character who studies the scars (Eye + Lore, Dire 22) can make out the shape of one word only, which in the old script might be *guest* or might be *chair*. Carvers should not say which. A character who works out that it is the same word in all seven lands makes a Dread 2 check, and from then on, at every meal, notices how many chairs there are.

▼ SALLOWREACH: THE KEPT TABLE



The Kept to be helped to spit into the blue dish, not the good one.

– TABLENIGHT BILL OF FARE, NEEDLE STREET, 640 A.G.

Food in the north is sour, smoked and quick. The living eat eel that will not stop moving, reed-bread from the fen-margins, mushroom from the peat, and pickled everything, because vinegar is the one thing in Sallowreach that makes rot stop and think. Imported Fatlands meat is feast food. Stilled meat, closed by a licensed butcher's touch, is a luxury, the only properly dead flesh in the country, and tastes, northerners say, of quiet. The Kept do not need to eat, and most of them still come to table, and chew, and spit, and say that it is lovely.

TABLE MANNERS IN THE NORTH

- ◇ **The eldest upright says grace.** Even if the eldest upright cannot keep their jaw on. The family waits.
- ◇ **Set a place for every Kept in the house,** including the ones in the attic. Plates for the shelved are carried to the Lofts in the morning.
- ◇ **The blue dish** stands in the middle of every northern table, for the Kept to spit into. Never put food on it. Never use it for bones. Visitors from the Fatlands have eaten from it and the story is still told on the Landing.
- ◇ **Eat fast, with the back teeth,** and do not talk while chewing eel. It gives them a chance.
- ◇ **Never close the lid on someone else's pot.** Closing is the Hand-lines' business, and a guest who puts a lid on the host's dish has insulted the host's blood. A guest who shuts a Kept diner's eyes for them, even kindly, has committed a mortal offence.
- ◇ **Do not wish anyone long life.** Do not say *I could eat that forever*. Do not say *it's to die for*, say *it would finish me*, which is the highest praise there is.
- ◇ **Bring vinegar or perfume.** A guest who smells of nothing is either a Closer or rude.



Mam says don't give it to visitors. I say let them learn.

THE LATEST HAND IN THE MALLORY RECEIPT-BOOK,
WEIR ROW

LIVELY EEL IN SOUR

From a fishwife's slate on the Landing, Lastgate, chalked fresh each morning and wiped each night, Carving 641.

EEL. LIVELY. DON'T ASK HOW LONG.

Pot boiling hard: sour, vinegar, dill. Eel behind the head with a rag. Four pieces, quick, on the block, before they find each other. Lid on, stone on lid. Boil the length of the Closing Hymn. Pieces that climb the side go back with the spoon. Reed-bread, a pickle, eat it standing if you like. Don't lie down after.

TWO CRUMBS THE PLATE. FOUR IF IT'S STILL GOING.

Lore. No fen-eel has died in six hundred and forty-one years, and the Sump is full of them, the same eels, pulled up and boiled and eaten and passed and returned to the water, round and round, which the fishwives of the Landing say is why the eels of the north know the way home. Cut, they try to rejoin; boiled, they knock on the lid. Eaten, they keep moving in the belly for an hour or so, which northerners regard as a pleasant warmth and foreigners regard as the worst hour of their lives. The cure is to drink a cup of *sour*, the peat-smoked beer, and walk about. The worst thing a northern mother can say to a lazy child is *you'll lie down after eel, you will*.

Rules. Difficulty Routine 10 to cook. No Taint for a Sallowreacher. For anyone else: Taint 1 Dread, the first time (the knocking). A diner who lies down within an hour of eating it must make a Gut + Endure roll (Hard 14) or lose 1 Flesh and the rest of the night, as the pieces argue. On a cook's **Lack**, two pieces found each other in the pot, and one bowl has a whole eel in it, quite unhurt, and very interested in the diner.

Hook. A fishwife on the Landing will swear on her mother's jaw that the eel she sold the party this morning has come back. She knows it by a nick in its fin. It has come back eleven times this year, and each time it is a little longer, and this morning it had a ring on, a gold ring, Lastgate-made, engraved inside with the name of a woman sunk in the Sump in a weighted sack in 588.

FOR YOUR TABLE – FISH IN DARK BEER WITH DILL AND MUSTARD

Serves 4. Time: 35 minutes. Contains fish, gluten (beer), mustard. The eel's knock is replaced by the crackle of the beer; nothing in the pot will move.

- ◇ 4 fillets of firm white fish (cod, haddock or hake), about 150 g / 5 oz each
- ◇ 1 tbsp butter and 1 tbsp oil
- ◇ 1 onion, finely sliced
- ◇ 250 ml / 1 cup dark beer or stout (or alcohol-free stout, or chicken stock)
- ◇ 2 tbsp cider vinegar
- ◇ 1 tbsp wholegrain mustard
- ◇ 1 tsp brown sugar
- ◇ 4 tbsp crème fraîche or sour cream
- ◇ a large handful of fresh dill, chopped
- ◇ salt and black pepper; rye bread and gherkins to serve

Melt the butter with the oil in a wide frying pan with a lid. Soften the onion over a medium heat for 8–10 minutes until golden. Pour in the beer and vinegar, stir in the mustard and sugar, and let it bubble for 5 minutes until reduced by about a third.

Season the fish and lay it in the sauce. Cover with the lid (a stone on top is optional) and simmer gently for 6–8 minutes until the fish flakes when pressed. Lift the fish onto warm plates. Stir the crème fraîche and most of the dill into the pan, warm through without boiling, and taste for salt.

Spoon the sauce over the fish, scatter the rest of the dill, and serve with dark rye bread and a gherkin on the side. Eat it quickly, with the back teeth, and do not lie down after.

Lore. Reed-bread is the north's daily loaf, but the Dish for the Dead is its sacrament: the same black bread, made a little richer, broken by the youngest child of the house and laid at every Kept place at the Tablenight banquet. The custom is older than Keeping. Bram Hollin, the Last Mourner, says that before the Gorging the loaf was laid on the closed eyes of the dead so that Ossel would know the household had fed them to the end. Now the dead do not close, and the loaf goes up to the Lofts, and the Wardens stack the Tablenight bread along the ends of the shelves, where it does not go stale, because nothing in Sallowreach finishes, so that some of the loaves in the oldest Lofts are three hundred years old and still smell faintly of caraway. The Loft-Wardens eat them when they are hungry. Old Bettany Shroud says they taste of being remembered.

Rules. Routine 10. No Taint, unless the loaf has been on a Loft shelf: a Loft-loaf carries Taint 1 Regrowth (Ossel) and, to the eater, the whispering of the shelved for one night, which counts as a Dread 1 check and gives one true answer to any question asked of the dead in the Lofts. On a cook's **Lack**, the loaf will not finish baking. It stays warm and damp in the middle for ever.

Hook. Old Bettany Shroud wants the party to carry the Tablenight basket to the ninth storey of the Lofts, where the shelved are oldest. The basket holds forty loaves. The ninth storey has forty-one shelves. On the forty-first is someone who has no family, who was shelved without a label, and who has been asking, for two hundred years, in a voice like paper, whether anyone has brought the bread yet.

REED-BREAD FOR THE DEAD

From the receipt-book of the Mallory house, Weir Row, in Gran Mallory's hand, which is very old, and in places sewn back into the page where the paper tore.

For the Dish for the Dead you want the black reed-flour from the far margin and none of your Rim white. Rye if you must. A cup of old sour to wake it. Caraway, a palmful, and the treacle, and a spoon of ash from the peat so it bakes dark as a shut door. Knead it with the heel of the hand and not the fingers, the fingers being for other things. It rises slow. Everything here does. Bake it till it knocks back.

One loaf at every Kept place on Tablenight. The youngest breaks it. Nobody eats it. It goes up to the Lofts at dawn, in the basket, for the shelved, who cannot eat it either, but who can smell it, and who say thank you, all of them, at once, which is a sound you do not want to hear twice.

FOR YOUR TABLE – BLACK RYE BREAD

Makes 1 large loaf. Time: 30 minutes active, 3–4 hours rising, 50 minutes baking. Contains gluten.

- ◇ 300 g / 2½ cups dark rye flour
- ◇ 200 g / 1⅔ cups strong white bread flour
- ◇ 7 g / 1 sachet (2¼ tsp) fast-action dried yeast
- ◇ 1½ tsp salt
- ◇ 1 tbsp caraway seeds, plus extra for the top
- ◇ 1 tbsp cocoa powder (for colour; it will not taste of chocolate)
- ◇ 2 tbsp black treacle or molasses
- ◇ 350 ml / 1½ cups warm water (or half water, half dark beer)
- ◇ 1 tbsp vegetable oil

Mix the flours, yeast, salt, caraway and cocoa in a large bowl. Stir the treacle into the warm water until dissolved, then pour it in with the oil and mix to a sticky dough. Rye dough is heavy and tacky; do not add much extra flour. Knead on a lightly floured surface with the heel of your hand for 8 minutes. It will not become smooth and springy like white bread. That is correct.

Shape into a round, set it on a baking tray lined with baking paper, cover loosely with an oiled sheet of cling film, and leave somewhere warm for 2–3 hours until noticeably puffed. Rye rises slowly. Everything here does.

Heat the oven to 200°C / 400°F / gas 6. Brush the loaf with water, scatter caraway, and slash a cross in the top. Bake 45–50 minutes until dark and hollow-sounding when knocked underneath. Cool completely on a rack before slicing, at least an hour. Serve thin, with butter, gherkins and cheese, and lay one slice at the empty chair.

and Seamers say they can tell a family by the way it draws the lashes. In the houses of the Hand-lines the pie is never cut by a living hand. A Kept servant cuts it, slowly, because the pastry eye must not be opened by the knife, and the slice must be taken from the side; to cut through the eye is to wish the god awake, and in 633, the year of Dunmere, the cook of House Vane cut through it by accident, and that winter, people say, was when Osric Vane's fingers grew their sixth joints.

Rules. Hard 14 to cook well (the pastry eye). No Taint to a northerner; Fatlands mutton carries Taint 1 Hunger to everyone else, which most people do not notice. A pie served with the eye properly shut at a Tablenight banquet gives every living diner –1 Fray. On a cook's **Lack** the eye bakes open, and every Hand-line at the table must make a Caul + Resolve roll (Hard 14) or feel their Want to close it, now, with their fingers.

Hook. The pie-shop of Widow Alder on Tanner's Boards has made the House Vane Tablenight pie for a hundred and ten years. This year the order came with a pastry-stamp for the eye, cut in ivory, very old, sent down from the Vane wing in a lead box. The eye on the stamp is open. The Widow wants to know whether to use it, and who in the locked wing could possibly have carved it with fingers like that.

TABLENIGHT PIE WITH A CLOSED EYE

From the Needle Street bill of fare, Tablenight 640, in the kitchen chalk: the second course, with a note.

SECOND — Pie of Fatlands mutton and fen-mushroom, with a crust made to look like a closed eye.

(Note on the slate beneath, in the mother's hand:) The eye is SHUT. Lashes down. Do the lid with the back of the knife, not the point. Last year Teal did it open, for a joke, and Great-Grandfather would not come down from the attic for a week, and the flies were dreadful, and we lost a Plate's rent in vinegar. SHUT, Teal.

Lore. The Tablenight pie is the centrepiece of the northern banquet for the dead: imported mutton, the fattest that can be afforded, with fen-mushroom and pickled onion under a lid decorated with a pastry eye, closed. The closed eye is Ossel's, the Closing Hand's, as it was carved on the old fen-shrines: the god that shut everything that finished. Every house in Lastgate makes the eye a little differently,

FOR YOUR TABLE – LAMB AND MUSHROOM PIE

Serves 6. Time: 2½ hours (most of it simmering). Contains gluten, dairy, egg, celery (in stock).

- ◇ 900 g / 2 lb lamb shoulder or neck, diced
- ◇ 2 tbsp plain flour, seasoned with salt and pepper
- ◇ 2 tbsp oil
- ◇ 1 large onion, chopped, and 12 small pickled or fresh silverskin onions
- ◇ 250 g / 9 oz chestnut mushrooms, quartered
- ◇ 2 garlic cloves, crushed
- ◇ 1 tbsp tomato purée and 1 tbsp Worcestershire sauce
- ◇ 500 ml / 2 cups lamb or beef stock
- ◇ 2 sprigs thyme and 1 bay leaf
- ◇ 1 tbsp malt or red wine vinegar
- ◇ 320 g / 11 oz ready-rolled puff pastry
- ◇ 1 egg, beaten

Toss the lamb in the seasoned flour. Brown it in batches in the oil in a heavy casserole and set aside. Soften the chopped onion in the same pan for 5 minutes, add the mushrooms and garlic and cook until the mushrooms colour. Stir in the purée and Worcestershire, return the lamb, pour in the stock, add the herbs and small onions, cover and simmer very gently for 1½ hours until the lamb is tender. Stir in the vinegar, taste, and cool for at least 20 minutes.

Heat the oven to 200°C / 400°F / gas 6. Spoon the filling into a pie dish, lay the pastry over, trim, and crimp the edges. With leftover pastry, cut an almond-shaped eyelid and a fan of thin strips for lashes, laid downward. Press them on top, so the eye is shut. Brush everything with egg, cut a small steam hole somewhere that is not the eye, and bake 30–35 minutes until deep gold. Serve the first slice from the side.

UNDYING CHEESE

A cheese-seller's label, pasted to the rind of a decade-wheel from the Brinemoss dairies, still legible after forty years.

BRINEMOSS DECADE CHEESE. *Laid down: Lack 601. To be opened: at a Setting Aside, a marriage, or a Closing, and not before, and not for less. The cheese will continue to ripen once cut. This is not a fault. Keep it in a cool place, in a lidded crock, with the lid weighted, away from the Kept, who like it, and away from children, who should not hear it.*

Lore. Nothing in Sallowreach finishes ripening. A cheese made in the north goes on maturing for as long as anyone keeps it, deeper and sharper and softer every year, until the oldest wheels in the cellars of the Upper Boards are not so much food as weather, and have to be cut with a wire and eaten with a spoon. The dairies of Brinemoss sell them by the decade. Families lay a wheel down at a

birth and open it at a Setting Aside, so that the old one's shelving is marked by a cheese exactly as old as they are, and the family eats it at the wrapping, crumbled on reed-bread, in silence, while the linen goes up over the face. The rind is dusted with peat-ash to keep it black. The oldest wheels hum faintly. The Brinemoss dairy-wives say it is the cultures. The cultures, in Sallowreach, do not die either.

Rules. Routine 10 to serve; a decade-wheel costs 1 L, sold by the decade. No Taint to northerners. To others, a wheel more than fifty years old carries Taint 1 Regrowth (Ossel) and a Dread 1 check, because of the hum. A wedge of decade-cheese eaten at a Setting Aside lets each diner recover 1 Fray: grief, here, is supposed to be shared, and to taste of something. On a **Lack**, the wheel is opened too young, and the family will not forgive the party for it.

Hook. A cheese-merchant of the Upper Boards has the oldest wheel in the north in his cellar: laid down in 2 A.G., in the Glad Century, when the first generation had not yet begun to come apart. He wants to sell it to a Second Table buyer for an extraordinary sum. The wheel is not humming any more. It is speaking, in a dialect only Grandfather Peat understands, and what it says is the guest list.

FOR YOUR TABLE – ASH-CRUSTED LABNEH CHEESE

Makes about 12 small balls. Time: 15 minutes, plus 24–36 hours straining. Contains dairy, sesame. A soft fresh cheese made from yogurt, rolled in black seeds so it looks as if it has been dusted with peat-ash.

- ◇ 1 kg / 2 lb full-fat plain yogurt (or Greek yogurt)
- ◇ 1 tsp salt
- ◇ 3 tbsp black sesame seeds, or a mix of black sesame and nigella (black onion) seeds
- ◇ 1 tbsp dried thyme or za'atar
- ◇ olive oil, to cover

Stir the salt into the yogurt. Line a sieve with a double layer of muslin or a clean thin tea towel and set it over a bowl. Spoon in the yogurt, gather the cloth over the top, and set it in the fridge for 24 hours (36 for a firmer cheese). Whey will drain out into the bowl; this is the cheese ripening, slowly, as northern cheese does.

Unwrap the thick labneh. With lightly oiled hands, roll it into walnut-sized balls and set them on a tray in the fridge for an hour to firm. Mix the black seeds and thyme on a plate and roll each ball until it is coated dark all over.

Pack the balls into a clean jar and cover with olive oil. Keep in the fridge and eat within a week. Serve on black rye bread with honey or a pickle, and do not listen at the jar.

BURNT HONEY CAKES FOR THE KEPT

From the Needle Street bill of fare, Tablenight 640: the sweet course.

SWEET — Burnt honey cakes. The Kept to be helped to spit into the blue dish, not the good one.

(From a letter found under a Loft shelf, in a Kept woman's wired hand, addressed to her granddaughter, who was eleven, and never sent:) Burn the honey properly, my love, till it smokes and smells like the chandler's on a wet night. Your mother never burns it enough. She is afraid of it. When I was alive the cakes were the one thing I could taste at Tablenight, the only one, because burnt things are nearly finished, and the tongue knows. I could taste them right up until about the year you were born. I want you to know I still say it was lovely. I want you to know it was.

Lore. The Tablenight sweet is a small dark cake made with honey boiled until it burns, bitter at the edges and sticky in the middle. Kept tongues lose taste a generation or two after death, but they hold on to bitterness longest, and burnt honey is the last flavour most of the Kept remember. A family therefore makes the cakes darker every year as its oldest dead go on, and in the houses of the Unvacated, whose elders are four hundred years in the chair, the Tablenight cakes are black as peat and taste, to the living, of ash and smoke and nothing else; and the Kept chew them, slowly, very slowly, with their eyes shut, which is the only time a Kept northerner is permitted to shut their eyes in company, because no one can bear to tell them not to.

Rules. Routine 10. No Taint. A Kept character who eats a properly burnt honey cake (the cook's roll must show at least one Helping) tastes something for the first time in years and recovers 2 Fray. A living diner who watches them do it makes a Dread 1 check, and if they fail it, they weep. On a cook's **Lack**, the honey is not burnt enough, and the Kept at the table say it was lovely, and the living know.

Hook. Henna Farrow, the Widow Unmade, sets her dead husband's place every evening. This Tablenight she wants the party to help her bake the cakes so dark that he will taste them and, tasting them, remember who she is. She has petitioned for his Closing forty-one times. She has never asked him. She wants him to taste something first.

FOR YOUR TABLE – BURNT HONEY CAKES

Makes 12 small cakes. Time: 50 minutes. Contains gluten, dairy, egg. "Burnt" here means deeply caramelised, not blackened: dark, bitter-edged and sticky.

- ◇ 175 g / ½ cup + 2 tbsp runny honey, plus 2 tbsp for glazing
- ◇ 125 g / ½ cup + 1 tbsp butter
- ◇ 75 g / ⅓ cup dark brown sugar
- ◇ 2 eggs, beaten
- ◇ 200 g / 1½ cups self-raising flour
- ◇ 1 tsp ground ginger and ½ tsp ground cinnamon
- ◇ a pinch of salt and 1 tbsp milk

Heat the oven to 180°C / 350°F / gas 4 and line a 12-hole muffin tin with paper cases. Put the honey in a small heavy saucepan over a medium heat and let it bubble, without stirring, for 4–6 minutes, swirling the pan, until it darkens to the colour of strong tea and smells toasted. Do not walk away; hot honey burns skin as badly as sugar. Take it off the heat and carefully add the butter and sugar (it will spit), stirring until melted. Cool for 10 minutes.

Beat in the eggs, then fold in the flour, spices, salt and milk until just combined. Divide among the cases and bake 18–20 minutes until risen and springy. While still hot, brush each top with the extra honey, warmed. Serve cold, at a Tablenight table, with one left on the plate at the empty chair.

MOTHER GALL'S PICKLE

A receipt written on the inside of a barrel-lid in Mother Gall's cellar on the Sump margin, where four hundred paid-up customers float in her brine, wide awake. The lid is used to cover a crock of onions in the kitchen above. The writing is upside down.

For onions: vinegar, salt, a little sugar, peppercorns, bay. Bring it to the boil and pour it on hot. They will keep a year.

For eggs: the same, with beet for the colour.

For gentlemen: see the other lid.

Lore. Mother Gall, the fen witch who pickles, can keep a body sound for a century in the right brine, and her cellar holds four hundred customers in barrels, paid in advance, all wide awake. Upstairs, she pickles onions, beetroot, fen-mushroom, cucumbers from the Rim and the eggs of birds that never stop sitting on them, and sells them on the Landing from a cart, and they are the best pickles in Sallowreach. Her customers below can smell the vinegar through the floorboards when she makes a batch. The richer barrels have a little brass speaking-tube to the kitchen, and they talk to her while she works, and she answers, and a jar of Mother Gall's pickle is said to carry, faintly, the sound of conversation. Fen children put them to their ears like shells.

Rules. Routine 10. No Taint, upstairs. +1 to resist Dread from rot and smell for a scene after eating, as fen-vinegar. Mother Gall's pickle-brine from the *other* lid is a different matter entirely (20 L, Scarce, keeps a corpse sound for a year; see the Rim Market chapter). On a cook's **Lack**, the jar was filled from the wrong barrel.

Hook. A jar of Mother Gall's pickled onions bought on the Landing goes on whispering after it is opened. One of the voices is giving very precise directions to a barrel in the cellar, and the barrel's speaking-tube has been stopped up with wax, from the inside, and the person in it has a name the Court would very much like back.

FOR YOUR TABLE – QUICK VINEGAR PICKLES

Makes 2 medium jars. Time: 20 minutes, plus 1 day to steep. Vegan. Keeps 3–4 weeks in the fridge.

- ◇ 2 red onions, thinly sliced, and 1 cucumber, thinly sliced (or 300 g / 10 oz small shallots, peeled)
- ◇ 1 small raw beetroot, peeled and cut in thin matchsticks (optional, for colour)
- ◇ 300 ml / 1¼ cups cider vinegar or white wine vinegar
- ◇ 150 ml / ⅔ cup water
- ◇ 2 tbsp sugar and 2 tsp salt
- ◇ 1 tsp black peppercorns, 1 tsp mustard seeds, 2 bay leaves
- ◇ a few sprigs of dill

Wash two jars and their lids in hot soapy water and rinse well. Pack the sliced vegetables and dill into the jars, mixing in the beetroot if using, which will turn everything a deep red.

Put the vinegar, water, sugar, salt, peppercorns, mustard seeds and bay in a saucepan and bring to the boil, stirring until the sugar dissolves. Carefully pour the hot liquid over the vegetables to cover them completely. Let them cool, lid them, and refrigerate.

They are good after an hour and better after a day. Serve beside the fish, the rye bread and the cheese, and hold one to your ear, if you like.

▼ THE FATLANDS: THE TABLE THAT EATS BACK



Nobody's full, but some are fuller.

– FATLANDS PROVERB

Fatland cooking is lavish, rich and brown: pies and puddings, roasts and dripping, sausages fat as a forearm, gravy on everything. All of it is grown in Ummer's flesh, all of it is delicious, and none of it satisfies. Five meals a day are law. The dead are served at the wake. The wheat has teeth.

TABLE MANNERS ON THE PLAINS

- ◇ **Five meals:** Firstbite, Elevesens, Midday, Fourth Plate, Supper. Travellers must comply. Bailiffs inspect inns with a ladle.
- ◇ **Thank the field by name** before every meal, and wipe the plate clean with bread after. A smear is a fine. Leaving food is a fine. Refusing a meal is sedition.
- ◇ **Feed your neighbour.** It is courteous to put food on the plate of the person beside you, by hand, before your own. Lovers do it with their fingers. Bailiffs do it with a funnel, gently.
- ◇ **Compliment the body.** *You look heavy* is the kindest thing there is. *You look well* means nothing. *You look thin* is said only to start a fight.
- ◇ **Never ask what it was.** At a wake, never ask which part. At an inn, never ask whose. The question is answered, sooner or later, by the taste.
- ◇ **Do not thank the cook.** Thank the field. The cook is only the one who brought it to the table.



STAMPED AND DECLARED. TAINT ONE. GOOD
FOR GROWING CHILDREN.

BOARD OF PLENTY PLACARD, OVER EVERY BREAD-
BIN IN SATED

THE WAKE STEW OF LONG ACRE

From a printed wake-bill of the Dunn family of Long Acre, Carving 639, "Given for Our Father, Josse Dunn, Eleven Hundred Pounds, Who Was Good to Us." The bill is folded small and kept, the College notes, in the salt-box under the marriage bed.

FOR THOSE WHO SAT UP: The Stew of the Shin and Shoulder, after the old Long Acre way, as Father liked it himself: browned in his own dripping, with turnips and onions from his field, and the dark ale he brewed, and simmered the whole night through while we sang. Served at dawn in the field-bowls, with name-loaf. Everyone is to have two helpings, as he would have wanted. Everyone will want three.

Lore. The grand wake-bills of the Gut-lines list nine removes and candied fingers in a ribboned box. Ordinary families serve the wake stew: the tough working cuts, browned in the deceased's dripping and simmered through the night of the wake while the household sits up and sings, and served at dawn to everyone who stayed. It is the dish most Fatlanders mean when they say a person *ate well*. It is also the dish most Fatlanders taste, in dreams, for the rest of their lives: because nothing satisfies, but a wake stew comes nearest, and in the Leanings people say you are never so nearly full as on the morning you eat your mother. The Thin call that the cruellest thing Ummer ever did.

Rules. Hard 14 (a night's simmering). Taint 1 Hunger, and for a non-Fatlander a Dread 2 check the first time they learn what it is (Dread 1 thereafter). A Fatlander who eats a kinsman's wake stew loses 1d6 Hunger, as a Sop, and gains a dream of the deceased that night which tells them one thing the dead knew. A non-Fatlander of Cut 1+ gains 1 Hunger: the meat is looking for somewhere to be hungry from. On a **Lack**, the cook has jointed the wrong body, and someone at the table recognises a birthmark.

Hook. Pell Hogget's tally shows Long Acre one smaller every Carving. This year the Dunns have held two wakes, and the second wake-bill names nobody: *For the One We Found in the Furrow*. The stew was the best in living memory. Nobody in the village will say who it was, and the Dunn children keep setting an extra bowl at dawn.

FOR YOUR TABLE – BEEF AND ALE STEW WITH TURNIPS

Serves 6. Time: 3½ hours (mostly in the oven). Contains gluten (ale, flour), celery (stock).

- ◇ 1.2 kg / 2½ lb beef shin or chuck, in large chunks
- ◇ 3 tbsp plain flour, seasoned with salt and pepper
- ◇ 3 tbsp beef dripping or oil
- ◇ 2 onions, cut in wedges
- ◇ 3 carrots and 2 small turnips (or 1 swede), in chunks
- ◇ 2 garlic cloves, crushed
- ◇ 2 tbsp tomato purée
- ◇ 500 ml / 2 cups dark ale (or alcohol-free ale, or more stock)
- ◇ 400 ml / 1½ cups beef stock
- ◇ 2 bay leaves, 4 sprigs thyme, 1 tbsp brown sugar, 1 tbsp Worcestershire sauce

Heat the oven to 150°C / 300°F / gas 2. Toss the beef in the flour. Brown it well in batches in the dripping in a large lidded casserole; take your time, because the brown is the flavour. Set aside. Fry the onions for 5 minutes, add the carrots, turnips and garlic, stir in the purée, then return the beef with any loose flour.

Pour in the ale and stock, add the herbs, sugar and Worcestershire, and bring to a simmer. Cover and cook in the oven for 3 hours, until the beef falls apart at a spoon. Taste and season. Serve in deep bowls with bread to wipe them clean, and thank the field.

THE TOOTHED LOAF

A notice in Granny Cracknel's hand, nailed to the door of her mill at Low Tilt, under eleven hundred sets of teeth sorted by village.

FLOUR, MILLED TWICE, TEETH OUT. A CRUMB THE POUND.

FLOUR, MILLED ONCE, SOME TEETH. HALF A CRUMB. FOR THE POOR AND THE BRAVE.

TEETH: NOT FOR SALE. DON'T ASK. IF YOU THINK YOU KNOW WHOSE THEY ARE, COME IN AND SIT DOWN AND HAVE A CUP OF SOMETHING AND TELL ME ABOUT THEM.

Lore. Since the Tooth Harvest of 204 A.G., Fatlands wheat has come up with teeth in the ear: small, white, perfect, mostly molars, set in the husk like seed. The Board ruled it a new and superior strain. Millers grind them out, mostly. A cheap loaf still has the odd one, and Fatland children thread the ones they find on string and wear them, and the poor say a loaf with a tooth in it is lucky, and the rich say nothing, because they know what the Cutwrights found when they compared the teeth to the Reaping lists of each village, and Granny Cracknel has known it for longer. Bread baked with the

teeth left in will bite. Granny bakes those for widows, to set in the window.

Rules. Routine 10. Taint 1 Hunger (the common loaf). A diner who finds a tooth in their slice (roll a d10; on a 1) may keep it, and a Hard (14) Eye + Search of the tooth against Cracknel's wall will name the village it came from. A biting loaf (teeth left in) is a relic: see the Rim Market chapter. On a **Lack**, the loaf bites the cook (attack +4, damage 1).

Hook. Tansy Lard, the Gleaner, has brought Granny Cracknel a tooth from her own bread with a small gold filling in it. Her mother had a gold filling. Her mother was Reaped. Tansy has planted a root with her mother's birthmark behind the house. She wants to know whether, if she bakes the tooth into a loaf and eats it, her mother will be inside her, or only gone.

FOR YOUR TABLE – SEEDED WHOLEMEAL LOAF WITH "TEETH"

Makes 1 loaf. Time: 20 minutes active, 2 hours rising, 40 minutes baking. Contains gluten, nuts (almonds), seeds. The teeth are blanched almonds and pumpkin seeds pressed into the crust.

- ◇ 350 g / 3 cups wholemeal bread flour and 150 g / 1¼ cups strong white bread flour
- ◇ 7 g / 1 sachet fast-action dried yeast and 1½ tsp salt
- ◇ 1 tbsp honey and 2 tbsp olive oil
- ◇ 330 ml / 1½ cups warm water
- ◇ 75 g / ½ cup mixed sunflower and pumpkin seeds, plus extra for the top
- ◇ about 20 whole blanched almonds (or extra pumpkin seeds for a nut-free loaf)

Mix the flours, yeast, salt and seeds. Add the honey, oil and warm water and mix to a soft dough. Knead 10 minutes until smooth and elastic, then cover and leave in a warm place for an hour until doubled.

Knock back, shape into a long oval and set on a lined baking tray. Brush with water and press the almonds into the top in two rows, pointed ends up, like a row of molars; scatter more seeds between them. Cover loosely and leave 45 minutes to rise again.

Bake at 220°C / 425°F / gas 7 for 30–35 minutes until it sounds hollow underneath. Cool before slicing. Tell your guests that one slice has a real tooth in it. It does not. Watch them chew.

LADY ASPIC'S JELLY

From the guest-book of the Gallery of Lady Aspic Dellamore, Sated: an entry by a Vigil visitor, Plenty 640, written very small.

She served it at the end, on a cut-glass stand. Red wine jelly, she said, a little dessert after the gallery. It trembled. It was perfectly clear, garnet-coloured, and set in it were grapes,

black ones, halved, cut side out, looking at me. Then one of them blinked. She laughed, the cold musical laugh, and said, "Oh, they all do that. It's the gelatine. One renders it from the very best people." I ate it. I ate all of it. I am on the Lid now and I have not slept in eleven years and I still see that plate when the lamps flicker, all of those grapes, turning to follow the spoon.

Lore. Lady Aspic Dellamore is a Gut-line chef whose specialty is preservation. Her rivals are set in clear golden jelly in her gallery, garnished, and blinking. The jelly keeps them; the Gut-line blood keeps them hungry; they watch visitors eat. The dessert she serves after the tour is made from the same stock-pot, set with wine, sweetened, and studded with whatever the gallery has shed that season. A jar sells on the Rim for thirty lacks, and it blinks. Her kitchen staff say she is working on a new piece and has been measuring Dame Marrable. Her rivals say nothing, but their eyes go to the door when Dame Marrable's name is spoken.

Rules. Dire 22 to make Lady Aspic's way (and illegal outside Sated). Taint 2 Hunger, 1 Dread. A spoonful lets the eater see, for one scene, through the eyes of whoever the jelly was rendered from, if they are still kept; most are in the Gallery, and are watching the Lady. On a **Lack**, the jelly sets around the cook's spoon-hand, and does not let go for a day.

Hook. A gelatine-jar from the Gallery, bought at Gristmoot, contains one eye that is not from the gallery at all: grey, lidless, Vigil-born, an Eye-line's. Lady Aspic does not keep Vigilants. Someone has been selling her stock, and the Envoy Castellan Dray, the Warden's man in Lastgate, has recently lost an aide.

FOR YOUR TABLE – RED WINE JELLY WITH GRAPES

Serves 6. Time: 20 minutes, plus 6 hours setting. Contains alcohol (or use the juice swap), gelatine (not vegetarian; use agar for a vegetarian version, following the packet). Not suitable for children unless made with juice.

- ◇ 500 ml / 2 cups fruity red wine (or red grape juice, which needs only 2 tbsp sugar)
- ◇ 250 ml / 1 cup water
- ◇ 125 g / $\frac{3}{4}$ cup caster sugar
- ◇ 1 strip orange peel, 1 cinnamon stick, 2 cloves
- ◇ 4 sheets leaf gelatine (or 1 sachet / $2\frac{1}{2}$ tsp powdered gelatine, set per packet for 750 ml)
- ◇ 200 g / 7 oz seedless black grapes, halved, plus a few blueberries
- ◇ whipped cream to serve

Soak the gelatine leaves in cold water for 5 minutes. Gently warm the wine, water, sugar, peel and spices in a pan until the sugar dissolves, then let it steep off the heat for 10 minutes. Strain. Squeeze the gelatine and stir it into the warm liquid until completely dissolved. (Warming the wine drives off a little of the alcohol, but not all of it.)

Pour a thin layer into a glass bowl or six glasses and chill 20 minutes until just tacky. Arrange the grape halves cut side out against the glass, like eyes, then pour in the rest of the jelly. Chill at least 6 hours until set. Serve with cream. Some of the grapes, in the right light, will seem to follow the spoon.

BLEEDING ORCHARD PEARS

From the pruning-book of Marigold Chine, keeper of the oldest grove in the Bleeding Orchards, who refused the deafening.

Picked the Hollin row today. They screamed when I took them, as they do, but softer, because I sang. The fruit has a skin and then a fat layer and then the white flesh and then, in the middle, a pit of bone, small, warm. You poach them in the blood-wine the trees give at pruning, with clove, and the colour goes right through to the bone. They heal a cut, eaten. They heal more than that, I think. Today when I sang the trees sang back. In my voice. Not in tune with me. In tune with something under the ground.

Lore. The ten thousand acres of the Bleeding Orchards bear fruit with a skin, a fat layer and a pit of bone, and the trees scream at pruning. Orchard-keepers go deaf young, by choice. The fruit is sold everywhere on the Rim for two crumbs, and it heals: a pear eaten whole closes a cut. Poached in the dark sap the trees weep at pruning (sold as *blood-wine*, though it is not wine) the pears turn red to the core, and are the sweet course at every Gut-line wedding,

where bride and groom feed each other a half each and swallow the bone-pit together, for luck, and so that they will root side by side.

Rules. Routine 10. Taint 1 Hunger; heals 1 Flesh (2 if poached in blood-wine, which adds Taint 1 Regrowth (Ummer)). A pair who share a pear and swallow the pits at a wedding may, once in their lives, each Partake on the other's behalf. On a **Lack**, the pit is not bone. It is a tooth, and it is a child's.

Hook. Marigold Chine's trees have begun to sing in tune with something under the oldest grove. She wants someone to dig, in Carving, with spades, at night, while she sings the trees quiet. What is under the grove has a mouth, and it has been eating the windfalls for six hundred years, and it is Seated, and it is not Ummer, and it is not alone.

FOR YOUR TABLE – PEARS POACHED IN SPICED RED JUICE

Serves 6. Time: 45 minutes. Vegan; gluten-free. Alcohol-free as written (use half red wine if you prefer, for adults).

- ◇ 6 firm pears, peeled, stalks left on
- ◇ 750 ml / 3 cups red grape juice, cranberry juice or blackcurrant cordial diluted to strength
- ◇ 100 g / ½ cup sugar (less if using sweet juice)
- ◇ 1 cinnamon stick, 4 cloves, 2 star anise, 1 strip lemon peel
- ◇ Greek yogurt, cream or vanilla ice cream to serve

Slice a thin piece off the base of each pear so it stands upright. Put the juice, sugar and spices in a saucepan just large enough to hold the pears snugly, and heat until the sugar dissolves. Lower in the pears, lying on their sides, and add water if needed to nearly cover.

Simmer gently, turning now and then, for 20–30 minutes until a knife slides into them easily. Lift the pears out. Boil the liquid hard for 10 minutes until syrupy and dark. Stand the pears in bowls and spoon the syrup over. They will be red to the core. Serve warm or cold with cream. If you listen at the pan while they simmer, the hiss is very nearly a song.

PANTRY-DOOR PUDDING (THE BROKEN FAST)

From the parish register of Hessop's Cross, Tablenight 637, in the Bailiff's hand.

Pantry locked at dawn and keys given to the priest. Silence kept. By the fourth bell the children were screaming. By the sixth the priest was sitting on the keys. At the eighth Widow Pargeter broke the pantry door with the coal-axe, and was cheered, and the village fell to, and the pudding was had, the old Tablenight pudding of the stale bread and the dripping and the custard and the dried fruit, made the night before by every house so as to be ready for the breaking, which every house denies. Sundown not reached. Not in living memory. Not in

the records. The Board will be informed. The Board was at its own pudding by the fifth bell.

Lore. On Tablenight the whole of the Fatlands attempts a one-day fast in penance for the Meal. Pantries are locked, keys given to the priest. No village has ever made it to sundown. By dusk there is a riot of eating, shameful and joyful, in every village on the plain, and the dish of the riot is the Pantry-Door Pudding: stale bread, fat, custard and fruit, made the night before, in every house, in secret, by people who swear every year that this year they will not need it. It is the only Fatlands dish whose making is a lie. The Thin call it the Pudding of the Board. Corder Lank, who has eaten nothing but water and ash for six years, is said to have stood in the square at Sated one Tablenight and watched the whole city break its fast, and to have wept, not from contempt, but from hunger, the first time anyone has seen him show it.

Rules. Routine 10. Taint 1 Hunger. A character who fasts on Tablenight in the Fatlands makes a Caul + Resolve roll each bell after noon, starting at Routine 10 and rising one step each bell; the first failure, they eat. A character who makes it to sundown (nobody ever has) gains +2 Want if Unfed, or loses 1 Regrowth if a Fatlander, and is reported to the Board as a Thin. On a cook's **Lack**, the pudding is eaten before the pantry door is broken, by someone in the house, alone, in the dark, and nobody will say who.

Hook. The Thin have heard that the village of Sorrel Meadow intends, this Tablenight, to make it to sundown: they have sent away their children, bricked the pantry, and drowned the keys in a well. The Board has sent the Bailiff Dunmow Fatt with his funnel and ladle of office, gently. The Thin want the party to keep him out until dusk. The village wants it too, until about the sixth bell.

FOR YOUR TABLE – BREAD AND BUTTER PUDDING WITH DRIED FRUIT

Serves 6. Time: 1 hour 15 minutes (plus 30 minutes soaking).
Contains gluten, dairy, egg. Best made from bread a day or two old,
as the Fatlanders do, in secret, the night before.

- ◇ 8–10 slices of day-old white bread or brioche, crusts on
- ◇ 50 g / 3½ tbsp soft butter, plus extra for the dish
- ◇ 75 g / ½ cup mixed dried fruit (raisins, sultanas, chopped apricots)
- ◇ 3 eggs and 2 egg yolks
- ◇ 300 ml / 1¼ cups whole milk and 200 ml / ¾ cup double cream
- ◇ 75 g / ½ cup caster sugar, plus 1 tbsp demerara for the top
- ◇ 1 tsp vanilla extract, ½ tsp ground cinnamon, a grating of nutmeg

Butter a medium baking dish. Butter the bread on one side and cut each slice into triangles. Layer them in the dish, buttered side up, scattering the dried fruit between the layers.

Whisk the eggs, yolks, milk, cream, sugar, vanilla and spices together. Pour slowly over the bread, pressing it down so it soaks. Leave 30 minutes (or cover and refrigerate overnight). Heat the oven to 170°C / 340°F / gas 3.

Scatter the demerara over the top. Set the dish in a roasting tin and pour hot water into the tin to come halfway up its sides. Bake 40–45 minutes until puffed, golden and just set in the middle. Serve warm, at dusk, after failing to wait.

▼ BRINEHOLLOW: THE COLD TABLE



Hot soup (by request only, and we'll look at you).

– CHALKED ON THE BOARD AT THE LANTERN, MILE NINE, LOWMARK

Brinehollow eats what the Uncovered gives and what the Rim Road sells. Fish, once daily bread, is now a luxury hauled nineteen miles down the Mile in wet barrels. The poor dig cockles from the drying mud, safe for those who bail and poison to the dry. Meals are cold and salty. Hot food is thought a little vulgar, like shouting. Salt is everywhere and costs nothing; sweet water costs a bail-token a cup.

TABLE MANNERS ON THE COAST

- ◇ **Bail before you sit.** Everyone coughs the morning or evening tide into their own bucket before the grace. To bail at table is unforgivable.
- ◇ **No west tables after dusk.** Do not sit facing west to eat. Do not toast toward the sea.
- ◇ **Do not remark on breathing.** Not the rattle, not the gurgle, not the long pause before a Tenanted diner swallows. Do not ask a returned person where they went, or whether they are hungry, or what they used to like.
- ◇ **Eat it cold.** To ask for hot food is to ask to be looked at.
- ◇ **Leave the head on the fish** and turn it to face inland on the plate, toward the Rim.
- ◇ **The empty bowl.** In houses that have lost someone to the Calling, a bowl of seawater stands at the head of the table on Tablenight, and nobody sits there, and nobody drinks from it, and in the morning it is checked.



Every man I take upstairs wants me to tie him to the bed after. Not for that. Just to sleep.

ROSEN, WHO WORKS THE ROOMS ABOVE THE LAST RAIL

Crack the crust at the table with the back of the knife. The Justices eat with their fingers, slowly, and they eat the eyes first, and they are always, always courteous to the cook, and thank the cook by name, and ask after the cook's mother, who walked into the sea in 629, by name.

Lore. Salt-baking is the oldest way of cooking fish on the coast: a whole fish buried in wet salt and baked hard, the crust broken at the table. Since 240, when the Admiralty began appointing the Tenanted as judges, salt-baked fish has been the dish of the Drowned Bench. The Justices take it every evening, cold, the same fish, in the same order; and the Lowmark cooks say that the Tenanted eat it not as food but as a kind of homecoming, cracking the salt the way a diver cracks the surface, and that the noise of the Justices at supper, through the Hall wall, is the sound of nine people very quietly breathing water.

Rules. Routine 10 to bake; a whole fish costs 1 L on the Mile. No Taint, unless the salt is wetted with bail-water (Taint 1 Regrowth (Dromm) to non-Brinehollowers). A diner who eats a salt-baked fish with a Tenanted host and keeps every manner above gains +2 to their next Persuade roll before the Drowned Bench. On a cook's **Lack**, the fish's eye follows the diner, and a Tenanted diner across the table notices, and smiles.

Hook. Justice Maren Oake has sent her fish back. In four hundred years of Bench suppers, no Tenanted has ever refused a dish. The cook wants to know what was wrong with it. The answer, if the party looks, is that the fish was caught in the Trench, far out, where the water is still deep and going down, and the Justice recognised it, and does not wish to eat a colleague.

THE DROWNED BENCH FISH

From the kitchen-book of the Hall of the Drowned Bench, Lowmark, where the Tenanted judges dine. The cook is not Tenanted. The cook has asked to be moved.

Whole fish, one to each Justice, scaled and gutted but the head on. Bury it in salt wetted with brine from the Justices' own morning bail, packed close, like a man under a cairn. Bake.

FOR YOUR TABLE – SALT-BAKED WHOLE FISH

Serves 4. Time: 45 minutes. Contains fish, egg (whites). Not salty to eat, despite the salt: the crust seals the fish and is cracked away and discarded.

- ◇ 1 whole sea bass, sea bream or trout, about 1 kg / 2¼ lb, scaled and gutted, head on (ask the fishmonger)
- ◇ 1.5 kg / 3 lb coarse sea salt or kosher salt
- ◇ 3 egg whites
- ◇ 1 lemon, sliced, a few sprigs of fennel fronds or dill, 2 bay leaves
- ◇ good olive oil, lemon wedges and boiled new potatoes to serve

Heat the oven to 220°C / 425°F / gas 7. Rinse and pat the fish dry and stuff the cavity with lemon slices and herbs. Mix the salt with the egg whites and a splash of water until it feels like damp sand.

Spread a third of the salt on a large baking tray in a layer a little longer than the fish. Lay the fish on it and pack the rest of the salt over and around it, pressing firmly, so the fish is entirely buried (the tail may peek out). Bake 30 minutes for a 1 kg fish.

Bring it to the table in its crust. Crack the crust with the back of a heavy spoon and lift it away in pieces. Peel back the skin and lift the white flesh off the bone. Dress with olive oil and lemon. Turn the head inland.

KELP-BREAD FROM THE CELLAR TIDE

A note pinned inside a cellar door on the Middle Mile, Lowmark, by a landlady, for her lodgers.

The tide comes up the cellar stair twice a day. It leaves kelp on the steps. You may take the kelp for bread, it is free, it is clean, it is the same kelp the whole Mile eats. You may NOT go down past the fourth step while the water is up, whatever you hear. Mr. Ambry went down past the fourth step in Lack and the tide went out and he did not. If you hear him, he is not asking for bread.

Lore. In every cellar in Brinehollow, however far inland, water rises twice a day and drains away, leaving kelp on the stairs. The poor of the Mile gather it, dry it on the roof-lines, grind it, and bake it into a grey, close-crumbed, salty bread that keeps for a week and tastes of low tide. Kelp-bread is the commonest loaf on the coast. It is also, the Salt Assay's leaked reports suggest, made of a sea that is not there: the indoor tide is fed from somewhere, and the kelp it leaves grows nowhere in the shallows. Brenna Kelp, the Salt Assayer, took her surname from her grandmother's bakery, and has not eaten the bread since she counted the buckets.

Rules. Routine 10; 3 c a loaf. No Taint to Brinehollowers; Taint 1 Regrowth (Dromm) to others, who start, after a week of it, to

taste salt on waking. On a cook's **Lack**, the cellar tide was gathered from below the fourth step, and the bread is still wet in the middle, and moves a little, and the person who bakes it hears their own name called from the cellar that night.

Hook. A bakery on the Raw Mile has begun to sell kelp-bread that never goes stale. The baker's cellar has no tide any more: her cellar water stopped coming up in Plenty. But she bakes every morning, and her kelp is fresh, and she will not say where she gets it, and her son, who was Called last year, has not been seen to come back, but someone has been leaving the kelp on her step.

FOR YOUR TABLE – SEAWEED AND CHEDDAR SODA BREAD

Makes 1 loaf. Time: 15 minutes, 40 minutes baking. Contains gluten, dairy. Soda bread needs no yeast and no rising: mix, shape, bake.

- ◇ 450 g / 3¼ cups plain flour (or half plain, half wholemeal)
- ◇ 1 tsp bicarbonate of soda and 1 tsp salt
- ◇ 2 sheets of dried nori (sushi seaweed), snipped into small pieces with scissors, or 2 tbsp dried seaweed flakes
- ◇ 100 g / 1 cup mature cheddar, grated
- ◇ 400 ml / 1⅔ cups buttermilk (or milk with 1 tbsp lemon juice stirred in and left 10 minutes)

Heat the oven to 200°C / 400°F / gas 6 and dust a baking tray with flour. Mix the flour, soda, salt, seaweed and three-quarters of the cheese in a bowl. Make a well, pour in most of the buttermilk, and mix quickly with a fork to a soft, slightly sticky dough, adding the rest of the buttermilk if dry.

Tip onto a floured surface and shape into a round with floured hands; do not knead. Set it on the tray, cut a deep cross in the top, and scatter the rest of the cheese. Bake 35–40 minutes until it sounds hollow when tapped underneath. Eat the same day, with salted butter, cold, as is proper.

COLD GULL WITH KELP RELISH

The Lashings' way with gull, told to a Rim cook by Tolly Brack, the Bailer Boy, eleven, while he bailed the cook's landlady.

You salt it a night. Then you roast it and then you let it go cold, cold like the water, and you eat it with the green stuff. My gran says gulls used to follow the boats. Now they follow the bodies. The ones on the flats. That's why they're so fat. She says don't think about that, Tolly, just eat it. I don't. I just eat it. Cough now, missus. Bit more. There. That's blue. You've got a while yet.

Lore. Gulls are the meat of the Lashings, where the pier-poor live roped to the pilings. The dead of Brinehollow, those who die of

ordinary causes, are laid face-down on the Uncovered, weighted with stones, for a tide that no longer comes; the bodies lie in long rows on the salt flats, and the gulls are fat. Everyone on the Mile knows what the gulls have been eating. Gull is salted overnight in bail-water, roasted, and eaten cold with a sharp green relish of kelp, sorrel and vinegar. It is the cheapest meat on the coast and the Lashings eat it every day, and the custom, when a gull is served, is to say the name of someone laid out on the flats, so that it is at least a kind of visit.

Rules. Routine 10; 3 c. Taint 1 Dread to a diner who knows what the gulls eat (Dread 1 check, once). A Brinehollower who says a dead name over the gull and eats it may, that night, dream one memory of that person. On a **Lack**, the gull was taken from the flats near the Longslab, where gulls will not land, and so it was not a gull.

Hook. The rows of the dead on the Uncovered flats have been counted by the Lashings' gull-catchers for a century, because the catchers set their snares among them. This season there are more bodies than burials. The extras are face-up. They are Tenanted, and they are not dead, and they are lying very still among the dead, waiting for the tide.

FOR YOUR TABLE – COLD ROAST BRINED CHICKEN WITH GREEN RELISH

Serves 4–6. Time: 30 minutes active, overnight brining, 1½ hours roasting, plus cooling. Contains nothing common beyond the chicken; check stock for allergens if using.

- ◇ 1 whole chicken, about 1.6 kg / 3½ lb
- ◇ for the brine: 2 litres / 8 cups cold water, 120 g / ½ cup salt, 2 tbsp sugar, 2 bay leaves, 1 tsp peppercorns
- ◇ 1 tbsp olive oil
- ◇ for the relish: a large bunch of parsley, a small bunch of dill, 1 sheet of nori torn small (optional), 2 tbsp capers, 2 gherkins, 1 small shallot, 2 tbsp cider vinegar, 6 tbsp olive oil

Stir the salt and sugar into the water until dissolved, add the bay and peppercorns, and submerge the chicken in a large pot or bag. Refrigerate overnight (8–12 hours, no longer).

Heat the oven to 200°C / 400°F / gas 6. Rinse the chicken, pat it very dry, rub with oil and roast 1 hour 20 minutes, until the juices run clear when the thickest part of the thigh is pierced (75°C / 165°F on a thermometer). Rest, then cool and refrigerate until cold.

For the relish, chop the herbs, nori, capers, gherkins and shallot very finely together, then stir in the vinegar and oil and season. Carve the cold chicken and serve with the relish, cold bread and a cold beer. Say a name.

Uncovered cockles, a bowl, raw (bailers only; dry folk ask for the pot) — 1 c.

(Under it, a note in a Rim Road auditor's hand, from the margin of Reeve Calder Stokes's expense-book:) Ordered the pot, as advised. Very good. Cider, onion, a little cream. The bailers at the next bench ate theirs raw from the shell and watched me eat mine cooked, and one of them said to the others, quite kindly, "He'll be on raw by Lack." This morning I tasted salt.

Lore. The cockles dug from the drying Uncovered are safe raw for anyone who bails, and poison to the dry: so the inns of the Mile serve two bowls, raw for the coast and stewed in cider for foreigners, and the change from the pot to the raw is how Mile folk know a stranger has turned. Cockle-diggers say the shells are older than the Gorging and should be dead. They are not. They have been waiting under the mud for six centuries for the sea to come back, and when they are opened they are always, always facing west.

Rules. Routine 10; 1 c. Raw: Taint 1 Regrowth (Dromm) to any non-Brinehollower, who must also make a Gut + Feast roll (Hard 14) or be sick for a day. Cooked: safe, no Taint. A character who orders raw without being a bailer is assumed by everyone on the Mile to be Called already. On a **Lack**, one shell has a pearl, and the pearl is an eye.

Hook. Reeve Calder Stokes, the Company auditor with dry lungs, has been in Lowmark three months and this morning tasted salt. Tonight he has ordered the cockles raw. He asks the party to sit with him while he eats them and to tell him, honestly, whether he is still himself afterward. He has written his own name on a slip of paper to compare the hand.

UNCOVERED COCKLES

From the Lantern board, Mile Nine, Carving 641.

FOR YOUR TABLE – MUSSELS IN CIDER WITH CREAM

Serves 4 as a starter, 2 as a main. Time: 30 minutes. Contains shellfish (molluscs), dairy, alcohol (or use the swap). Shellfish safety: buy from a fishmonger, cook the same day, and throw away any mussels that are cracked or that stay open when tapped before cooking, and any that stay shut after cooking.

- ◇ 1 kg / 2¼ lb fresh mussels
- ◇ 1 tbsp butter
- ◇ 2 shallots and 2 garlic cloves, finely chopped
- ◇ 200 ml / ¾ cup dry cider (or apple juice with 1 tbsp cider vinegar, or fish stock)
- ◇ 4 tbsp double cream
- ◇ a handful of parsley, chopped; crusty bread to serve

Rinse the mussels under cold water, pull off any stringy beards, and discard any broken or open ones that do not close when tapped sharply.

Melt the butter in a large pan with a lid and soften the shallots and garlic for 3 minutes. Turn the heat to high, tip in the mussels and cider, cover and steam 4–5 minutes, shaking the pan, until the shells have opened. Discard any that have stayed shut.

Lift the mussels into warm bowls. Stir the cream and parsley into the pan juices, bubble for a minute, and pour over. Serve with bread for the broth and a bucket for the shells, which is only proper.

KNOT-ROLLS FOR THE KNOTTING

From a Lashings household book, the receipt for the Knotting, in early Grace, when every rope in the house is replaced.

Make the dough the night before. On the morning, every rope in the house comes down, and the new ones go up, and while the men splice, the children tie the bread: one roll for every knot in the house, tied in the same knot as the rope it stands for, bowline for the bed, clove hitch for the cistern-ring, hangman's for nothing, never, not in this house. Salt on top. Bake. Eat them all by dusk, every knot, so the new ropes hold. If a roll comes out of the oven untied, someone sleeps in the middle of the bed that year, between two others.

Lore. Brinehollowers sleep roped, chained or weighted to the bed, because on certain nights a person will stand up, walk to the shore, and keep walking. Every household replaces every rope at the Knotting, in early Grace, and the feast-bread of the day is a salted roll tied in the same knot as each rope in the house. Children learn their knots on bread before they learn them on hemp. A roll that unties in the oven is the worst of omens; families who see it tie the person the rope belongs to with a second rope that year, and some of them still lose that person, and keep the untied roll, dried hard as wood, in the rope-box by the bed.

Rules. Routine 10 (Hard 14 for the full set of a large household's knots). No Taint. A character who eats the knot-roll for their own rope at the Knotting gains +1 to resist the Calling for the season. On a **Lack**, one roll unties: the Carver notes whose, and the next Calling of the campaign will come for that character first.

Hook. At the Knotting on the Middle Mile, a widow has baked a knot-roll for her Called husband's rope, though his rope was cut and shared out at his rope funeral two years ago. The roll came out of the oven tied in a knot nobody on the Mile can name. It is the knot on the anchor-cable of a ship that has stood on props for forty years, and the knot is new.

FOR YOUR TABLE – SALTED KNOT ROLLS

Makes 12 rolls. Time: 30 minutes active, 1½ hours rising, 20 minutes baking. Contains gluten, dairy, egg.

- ◇ 500 g / 4 cups strong white bread flour
- ◇ 7 g / 1 sachet fast-action dried yeast, 1 tsp salt, 1 tbsp sugar
- ◇ 300 ml / 1¼ cups warm milk (or half milk, half water)
- ◇ 40 g / 3 tbsp soft butter
- ◇ 1 egg, beaten, and flaky sea salt for the tops

Mix the flour, yeast, salt and sugar. Add the warm milk and butter and mix to a soft dough. Knead 10 minutes until smooth and elastic. Cover and leave in a warm place for an hour until doubled.

Knock back and divide into 12 pieces. Roll each into a rope about 25 cm / 10 in long and tie it in a knot: a simple overhand knot, a figure-of-eight, or a loose bowline if you know one, tucking the ends under. Set them on lined trays, cover and leave 30 minutes to puff. Heat the oven to 200°C / 400°F / gas 6.

Brush with beaten egg, scatter flaky salt, and bake 15–18 minutes until deep gold. Cool slightly. Eat them all by dusk, every knot. If one comes untied in the oven, eat that one first, and say nothing.

▼ THE VIGIL: THE STANDING TABLE



A full belly is a bed.

— VIGIL PROVERB, AND THE FIRST LINE OF THE HOUSEHOLD ORDINANCES FOR THE TABLE

Meals in the Vigil are small, frequent, cold and sour, because warmth, fullness and comfort are lethal. Pickled roots, hard bread, Fatlands salt-meat, vinegar, sorrel, smoked cliff-goat. Warm milk is illegal. Sugar is rationed. Soup is served lukewarm, by law. Rouse, the bitter black stimulant, is taken hourly, and is the closest thing the city has to a cuisine.

TABLE MANNERS ON THE LID

- ◆ **Eat standing.** There is no chair in the city with more than one leg and no table at sitting height.
- ◆ **Eyes open for the grace,** and slap the table after it. Pinch a neighbour who blinks.
- ◆ **Sharp rims.** Rich households eat from vessels with sharp rims, so the lip is pricked at every sip. Do not complain of it. It is a courtesy.
- ◆ **Never finish.** A family that finishes its soup has eaten its watch. Leave a mouthful, and pour it on the step for the ones who have gone to the room.
- ◆ **Never offer seconds.** Never say *rest a moment and digest*. Never praise a dish as *comforting*. To serve a guest a warm, heavy meal is attempted murder, and is prosecuted as such.
- ◆ **A pin with the bread.** Hosts lay a pin beside each plate. Guests use it on themselves between courses. Refusing it is unthinkable.



*TABS. TABS. HONEST TABS. THEY HOLD AN
HOUR IF YOU HOLD ON.*

PATTER ON THE SLOPE

ROUSE

*From the price-board of a coffee-house on Lampwrights' Row,
under the brightest lamps in the world.*

ROUSE, BREWED, A CUP — 1 c. ROUSE, DOUBLE — 2 c.
ROUSE, HEIGHT-STRENGTH, BLACK AS THE ROOM —
5 c, ask for the glass. STAREMOSS FOR THE TEETH, A
QUID — 2 c.

*NO SITTING. NO SUGAR AFTER THE SIXTH BELL. NO
SLOPE-CUT HERE, WE KNOW WHAT'S IN IT.*

*(Chalked below by a customer:) Teeth go first. Then the heart.
Then the hours get longer. Cheers.*

Lore. Since the Rouse Patent of 390, the Vigil has stayed awake on a bitter black stimulant brewed from roasted root, bark and things Dr. Aldous Crane will not name. It is taken hourly. The dose has risen every decade. Teeth go first, then the heart. The Apothecary-General knows where the dose curve ends: a point at which the amount needed to stay awake is the amount that stops the heart, and it is eleven years off. Coffee-houses are the Vigil's public life, and their regulars stand at the counters all night in the lamp-glare and the clatter, talking, talking, because to stop talking is to begin to drift. On the Slope the rouse is cut with bottled Brinehollow brine, because it is cheap and it works, and the customers stay awake and start, slowly, to walk west.

Rules. See the Rim Market chapter (Drugs): a cup removes 2 Weariness; Addiction Hard 14. Slope rouse adds Taint 1 Regrowth (Dromm). A character who drinks rouse brewed by a skilled hand (cook's roll with a Helping) gains +1 Eye for the hour as well. On a **Lack**, the brew is the strength of the dose eleven years from now: Gut + Endure (Grim 18) or suffer Ruin, as rouse-heart.

Hook. Rook Quarter-Bell, the Slope dealer, has a new supply that holds for three hours. His customers do not walk west. They walk toward the Dormitory, all of them, at the same bell, and stand at the fence, and stare at Bed One with their eyes wide open, mouthing along.

FOR YOUR TABLE – ICED BLACK “ROUSE” WITH ORANGE AND CARDAMOM

Makes 4 small glasses. Time: 10 minutes, plus chilling. Contains caffeine (use decaffeinated coffee for children and late games). Vegan.

- ◇ 500 ml / 2 cups strong black coffee, freshly brewed (or decaf)
- ◇ 4 green cardamom pods, lightly crushed, and 1 strip orange peel
- ◇ 2–3 tbsp dark brown sugar or maple syrup, to taste
- ◇ ice, orange slices, and a little cold milk or oat milk for those who need it

Pour the hot coffee over the cardamom and orange peel in a jug, stir in the sugar, and leave 10 minutes to steep. Strain, cool, and chill until cold.

Serve over ice in small glasses with a thin slice of orange. It is bitter, dark and sharp. Serve it at the table’s hour bell, every hour, and slap the table before drinking. Players at Weariness 5 or more may have a second glass. Nobody may sit down.

LAWFUL SOUP

From the Watch’s Household Ordinances for the Table, 344, chapter the third, still read aloud to brides.

Take sorrel, two handfuls, and a root of bitter kale, and a cup of vinegar, and a bone of cliff-goat if you have one and a stone if you have not. Boil in a pot without a lid, stirring, standing, for the length of the Waking Hymn twice. Set it on the sill and count to three hundred. Test it with the inside of the wrist: it must be no warmer than the wrist. Serve in a bowl with a broken rim. Eat standing. Do not finish it.

Lore. Lawful Soup is the Vigil’s household staple, and its recipe is a statute. It must be sour, green, and no warmer than the wrist, because hot soup is the oldest killer in the city: on the Grey Ninth, the Shouting Day remembers, a whole ward of the Slope went to the room together after a charity kitchen served a thick hot broth in a snowfall. The bowls are broken at the rim on purpose. The mouthful left at the bottom is poured on the doorstep for the Counted, and the Slope’s stray cats, which are bred to yowl, drink it. Sister Vesper Null’s Bedded serve soup hot, in whole bowls, in their quiet rooms, which is how the Wakers find them.

Rules. Routine 10. No Taint. Lawful Soup adds no Weariness for being a meal. Hot soup, in the Vigil, counts as a scene of comfort: +1 Weariness to every diner, +2 on a Yawn day. On a cook’s **Lack**, the soup is too warm, and nobody notices until the third spoonful.

Hook. A charity kitchen on the Slope serves Lawful Soup to the poor every bell, free, from a great iron pot. Its regulars are the most alert people in the ward. Its cook has a lid on the pot. Inspector

Hale Grimmer has forty blink-murders on his books, and the kitchen’s bell-sheets show that every killer ate there the morning of the deed.

FOR YOUR TABLE – COOL GREEN SOUP WITH LEMON

Serves 4. Time: 30 minutes, plus cooling. Vegetarian (vegan with oil instead of butter and no yogurt). Gluten-free.

- ◇ 1 tbsp butter or oil, 1 onion and 1 celery stick, chopped
- ◇ 1 medium potato, peeled and diced
- ◇ 750 ml / 3 cups vegetable stock
- ◇ 200 g / 7 oz spinach (or sorrel, if you can find it, which makes it properly sour)
- ◇ a small bunch of parsley and a few sprigs of mint
- ◇ juice of 1 lemon, plus zest
- ◇ salt and pepper; plain yogurt to serve

Soften the onion and celery in the butter for 5 minutes. Add the potato and stock and simmer 15 minutes until the potato is tender. Stir in the spinach, parsley and mint and cook 2 minutes until just wilted.

Blend until smooth, then stir in the lemon juice and zest and season well. It should be bright and sour. Leave it to cool to room temperature (or chill it on a hot evening). Serve in small bowls with a swirl of yogurt, at the temperature of the inside of your wrist. Leave a spoonful in the bottom.

CLATTER-CAKE

A Vigil nursery rhyme, chanted while chewing.

Crack goes the clatter-cake, crunch goes the grit,

Bite it and break it and don’t you sit,

Crumbs on the collar and stones in the bread,

Chew till your teeth hurt and you won’t go to bed.

Lore. Clatter-cake is a Vigil biscuit baked twice, hard as a roof-tile and studded with grit, nut-shell and sugar-crystal so that it cracks loudly in the mouth and hurts a little. It is sold on every corner for 2 c, given to children at the Coming-Heavy, and carried by Wakers on patrol. The Slope bakers once baked actual gravel into it; the Watch’s Ordinance of 512 limits the grit to *such as will not break a sound tooth*, and the Slope, whose teeth are not sound, ignores it. On the Rim, clatter-cake is sold to Vigil travellers at the Bakers’ Mile in Gristmoot, where foreigners buy it as a curiosity and break their teeth.

Rules. Routine 10. No Taint. Eating a clatter-cake removes 1 Weariness, once per scene, as a pinch; it is the pinch’s pain, in biscuit form. On a cook’s **Lack**, a piece of real grit cracks a molar (1 Flesh, and –1 to Persuade until it is seen to).

Hook. Pip Eleven-Bell, the street nudger of nine, is selling clatter-cake on the Slope because nobody has paid her for two weeks. She has begun to blink. The cake she sells is soft. She has been baking it without grit, so that her customers can sleep a little, she says, the way she sometimes does now, on her feet, in the room with the eye, where it is warm.

FOR YOUR TABLE – CRUNCHY ALMOND AND SEED BISCOTTI

Makes about 24. Time: 1 hour 10 minutes. Contains gluten, egg, nuts (almonds), seeds. Twice-baked, very hard, and wonderful with the iced rouse.

- ◇ 250 g / 2 cups plain flour
- ◇ 1 tsp baking powder and a pinch of salt
- ◇ 150 g / ¾ cup caster sugar
- ◇ 2 eggs and 1 tsp vanilla extract, zest of 1 orange
- ◇ 100 g / ¾ cup whole almonds (or hazelnuts), roughly chopped
- ◇ 2 tbsp sunflower or pumpkin seeds, 2 tbsp demerara sugar

Heat the oven to 180°C / 350°F / gas 4 and line a baking tray. Mix the flour, baking powder, salt and sugar. Beat in the eggs, vanilla and zest to make a stiff, sticky dough; work in the nuts and seeds with floured hands.

Shape into two logs about 5 cm / 2 in wide and 2 cm / ¾ in high on the tray, a hand apart, and scatter with demerara. Bake 25 minutes until firm and pale gold. Cool 10 minutes, then slice on the diagonal into 1 cm / ½ in slices with a serrated knife. Lay the slices flat and bake 10 minutes more on each side until dry and crisp. Cool fully. They clatter.

PINCHMARKET PEPPERS

A cry of the Pinchmarket, where pain is sold by the pin.

Peppers! Peppers! Blistered on the iron! Nine sweet and one to wake you! Who's the lucky one? Who's the lucky one? Only a crumb, and a crumb more for the one you'll never forget!

Lore. The Pinchmarket sells pain as a service: pins by the dozen, slaps by the hour, Jack Tenterhook's exquisite needle for those who can pay. Its street-food is the waking-pepper: small green peppers blistered on an iron and salted, sold in paper cones, of which most are mild and one in every nine or ten is ferociously hot. Vigilants eat them in rings, passing the cone, and the one who gets the hot pepper is the one who stays awake longest that bell, and is cheered. Lovers share a cone as a test. Wakers buy them by the sack. The game is called *Lucky*, and the Slope children play it with real peppers when they can and with pins when they cannot.

Rules. Routine 10. No Taint. A cone shared among a party: each diner rolls a d10; on a 1, they have the hot one, and lose 2 Weariness

(and cannot speak for a minute). On a cook's **Lack**, every pepper is mild. Nobody stays awake. Roll blink checks.

Hook. Corwin Half-Bell, the only sleeper who ever came back, will not describe the long room with the eye. But he plays *Lucky* every bell at the same Pinchmarket stall, and he always gets the hot one, every time, and he says, through his tears, that it is the only thing that tastes like being awake. The stall-keeper wants to know how he does it, and is frightened of the answer.

FOR YOUR TABLE – BLISTERED PADRÓN PEPPERS WITH SEA SALT

Serves 4–6 as a snack. Time: 10 minutes. Vegan; gluten-free. Padrón (or shishito) peppers are mostly mild, but about one in ten is hot: the game is built in. Have water, bread or yogurt on hand for whoever gets the hot one.

- ◇ 250 g / 9 oz Padrón or shishito peppers
- ◇ 2 tbsp olive oil
- ◇ flaky sea salt and a wedge of lemon

Rinse the peppers and dry them very well (water in hot oil will spit). Heat the oil in a large heavy frying pan over a high heat until shimmering. Add the peppers in a single layer and cook, turning occasionally with tongs, for 4–6 minutes until blistered and blackened in patches and softened.

Tip into a bowl or paper cone, scatter generously with flaky salt and a squeeze of lemon, and pass them round the table. Hold each by the stalk and eat it whole. Whoever gets the hot one stays awake longest. Cheer them.

CONTRABAND MILK

From a seized handbill of the Bedded, Slope, Lack 640; the Wakers burned four hundred copies and kept one.

COME IN OUT OF THE LIGHT. There is a room on Thimble Lane where the floor is level, and the lamps are low, and the milk is warm, with honey, and nutmeg, the way your grandmother made it on the Easy Centuries' last night. Sister Vesper will pour it for you herself. You do not have to drink it. You do not have to lie down. You only have to hold the cup, and feel how warm it is, and remember. The eye is kind. The room is home. Come in.

Lore. Warm milk has been illegal in the Vigil since the Waking Laws of 342: of all the comforts of the world, it is the one the Watch fears most, because it was the drink of the last night of the Easy Centuries, when the city lay down. The Bedded, who preach that sleep is a homecoming, serve it in their quiet rooms, honeyed and spiced, in thick round cups with whole rims. Possession of a milk-pan is a Lantern sentence. Smugglers bring it up the plateau road in cold flasks, and it is warmed in secret on the Slope over lamp-flames,

and the smell of hot milk and nutmeg in a Vigil stairwell is enough to make a Waker draw his needle.

Rules. Routine 10. No Taint. A cup of warm milk in the Vigil is a scene of comfort: +2 Weariness at once, and an immediate blink check. Outside the Vigil, it is simply lovely, and a Vigilant who drinks it on the Rim must make a Dread 1 check, because their body knows what it is before they do. On a cook's **Lack** in the Vigil, the drinker does not come back from the blink.

Hook. Sister Vesper Null looks more rested than anyone in the city, and nobody can explain it. Her milk comes up the plateau road from a farm near Gristmoot, and the farm's dairy is Seated: an old Laden matriarch whose hill gives milk from a spring in its side. Lady Oriel Stroud, the Warden's lidded daughter, has been drinking it, in her hidden rooms, and closing her eyes.

FOR YOUR TABLE – WARM HONEY AND NUTMEG MILK

Serves 4. Time: 10 minutes. Contains dairy (use oat milk for a dairy-free cup). The perfect last drink of the evening, outside the Vigil.

- ◇ 1 litre / 4 cups whole milk (or oat milk)
- ◇ 3 tbsp honey, to taste
- ◇ 1 cinnamon stick and ½ tsp vanilla extract
- ◇ freshly grated nutmeg

Warm the milk with the honey, cinnamon and vanilla in a saucepan over a gentle heat, stirring, until steaming but not boiling. Take out the cinnamon.

Pour into thick mugs and grate nutmeg over the top. Serve it at the end of the session, after the last scene is done, with the lamps turned down. You may close your eyes. Here, it is safe.

▼ CRADLEWRACK: THE KNOCKING TABLE



Lack keep away, and let it stay.

— THE HIGHLAND GRACE

Highland food is plain and red: mutton and lamb above all, since the ewes drop four times a year; clay-baked bread with a pink crust; oats, nettles, and rose-coloured salt from the warm springs, which tastes faintly of blood. Lamb is so cheap the poor eat it daily and the rich serve it never. Eggs are not eaten: too many hens' eggs in the highlands have been found to contain things looking back.

TABLE MANNERS IN THE HIGHLANDS

- ◆ **Knock three times on the table before sitting**, to warn whatever is underneath. Knock on the pot before lifting the lid. Knock on the bread before breaking it.
- ◆ **Look at the door during the grace.** Doors do not stay shut here; a diner who has their back to an open door at supper is either a fool or a midwife.
- ◆ **No eggs.** Do not bring eggs as a gift. Do not ask why.
- ◆ **Never ask what is in a dish before the cook has said.** It is the Midwife's First Question, and only an Attendant may ask it.
- ◆ **The plate nearest the door** belongs to whatever comes in. On Tablenight it is laid for real. On other nights it is laid as a habit, with an empty plate, and nobody sits in that chair, ever, not even when the house is full.
- ◆ **The unnamed child eats last.** A child under its naming-year is fed after everyone else, from the edge of the pot, so that if anything is wrong with the food, the household knows before the child does. Highlanders call this kindness.

◇
*SHOULDER, ROAST, 1 L. — LIGHTS &
SWEETBREADS, 3 c. — POSSET, A HORN, 1 c. —
NO ODD-FOLD MEAT SOLD HERE, ASK AT THE
BACK.*

BRAZIER-STALL BOARD IN THE SHAMBLES, KEST

THE NAMING-FEAST STEW (THE SECOND MEAL)

From the household book of the Gorse family, Tarnbrow, at the naming of the Third of Gorse, Carving 640, in the mother's hand.

A year and a day. She stays. The Attendant came at dawn and asked the Two Questions again and answered them again, and she still stays, and so we may name her, and we have, and her name is Wren. We had the crock down from the cold-shelf where it has sat in salt since the night she came, and the copper on, and the lamb, the onions, the barley, the rose-salt, all in, and the crock last. I took the first spoon, as is right. Then her father. Then the grandmothers. Then everyone. It tasted of iron and onions and of the night she was born, and I cried, and everyone said I was only tired. Wren had bread and milk. She kept looking at the pot.

Lore. A child is not named for a year in Cradlewreck, until it is clear what it is. At the naming the family eats the afterbirth, kept salted in a crock since the delivery and stewed in the copper with lamb, onions and barley, everyone taking a spoon starting with the mother, in memory of the first Meal, when the highland people ate the caul of Vey and ended the Lack. This is the Second Meal, and the rest of the Table finds it harder to stomach than anything the highlands do. The Caul-lines eat their children's cauls raw, from a silver dish, and do not speak of it. There is a darker version, told in whispers in the Odd Fold: the naming-feast for a child that was returned, a child the Attendance's late Second Opinion did not permit, where the family eats what they kept in the crock and says the name anyway, once, into the pot.

Rules. Hard 14 (the old way). The lamb is clean; the crock is Taint 1 Regrowth (Vey) to non-Cradlewrackers and Dread 2 the first time for any foreigner who learns what it is. A family who eats a proper naming-feast gains +2 to all Rites and Resolve rolls made to protect the named child for a year. On a cook's **Lack**, the crock was not the child's, and the child at the end of the table, who has never spoken, says *thank you* in an adult voice.

Hook. Ruth Ninefold, the name-broker of Kest, holds the naming-right to a child born in the Dilation's rim-town. The naming-year is up. The family has prepared the Second Meal. The crock, when they took it down, was empty, and licked clean, and the child is very well, and its first word was *more*.

FOR YOUR TABLE – LAMB, ONION AND BARLEY STEW

Serves 6. Time: 2 hours. Contains gluten (barley), celery (stock). Plain, red and filling, as highland food should be; the crock stays on the shelf.

- ◇ 900 g / 2 lb lamb neck fillet or shoulder, diced
- ◇ 2 tbsp oil and 1 tbsp butter
- ◇ 3 onions, sliced
- ◇ 2 carrots and 1 small swede or 2 parsnips, diced
- ◇ 2 garlic cloves, crushed
- ◇ 1 tbsp tomato purée and 1 tsp sweet paprika
- ◇ 1.2 litres / 5 cups lamb or chicken stock
- ◇ 125 g / ½ cup pearl barley, rinsed
- ◇ 2 sprigs rosemary, 1 bay leaf; pink Himalayan salt or ordinary salt, and pepper

Brown the lamb in the oil in batches in a large pot; set aside. Lower the heat, add the butter and onions, and cook slowly for 15 minutes until soft and golden. Add the carrots, swede and garlic for 5 minutes, then stir in the purée and paprika.

Return the lamb, pour in the stock, add the barley and herbs, and bring to a simmer. Cover and cook gently for 1¼ hours, stirring now and then, until the lamb is tender and the barley soft and plump. Season with the pink salt. Knock three times on the lid before lifting it. Everyone takes a spoon, starting with whoever cooked it.

CLAY-BREAD

A shepherd's instruction, as recorded by the Tally-house of Kest from Josiah Fenn, the Man Who Bore, who now follows tracks across the highlands and bakes his bread wherever he stops.

You dig a hole by the fire and you line it with the red clay, wet, and you put the dough in a pot and pack the clay round the pot and bury it in the embers, and you wait. It comes out with a pink crust. It stays warm a day. My mother said the clay is warm because the ground is warm and the ground is warm because it is carrying. I didn't believe her. Then I carried. Now I believe everything. The tracks are bigger again this morning. The bread is still warm.

Lore. Highland bread is set in a pot of wet red clay and buried in the embers, and comes out with a pink crust, and stays warm for a day, which the Rim regards as a pleasant oddity and the highlands

regard as the soil showing its temperature. The red earth of Cradlewrack is warm to the touch everywhere, smells of iron, and dilates, over weeks, into crownings. Bakers in Kest say the dough rises faster in pang-week and must be watched, and that in the week before a pang, if the loaf is not knocked on as it comes from the clay, it will sometimes be found to have opened, in the night, from the inside, very neatly, along a seam.

Rules. Routine 10; 2 c. No Taint to highlanders; to others, Taint 1 Regrowth (Vey), only if eaten in pang-week. A clay-loaf stays warm a day: a traveller who carries one through cold weather gains +1 to Endure against cold. On a cook's **Lack**, the loaf opens in the night.

Hook. Maddier Rudge, head of the watch at the Dilation, says the hole has a pulse. Lately the clay-bread of the rim-town has begun to come out of the embers in perfect rounds, all the same size, with a soft spot on top that beats. She wants the party to eat one, in front of her, and tell her if they can feel it in their stomachs, keeping time with the hole.

FOR YOUR TABLE – NO-KNEAD BEETROOT POT BREAD

Makes 1 round loaf. Time: 15 minutes active, 12–18 hours rising, 50 minutes baking. Contains gluten. Baked in a lidded cast-iron pot (a Dutch oven), as the highlanders bake in clay. The beetroot makes the crumb pink.

- ◇ 450 g / 3¾ cups strong white bread flour
- ◇ 1½ tsp salt and ¼ tsp fast-action dried yeast
- ◇ 1 medium cooked beetroot (not pickled), grated very finely, about 100 g / 3½ oz
- ◇ about 300 ml / 1¼ cups lukewarm water

In a large bowl mix the flour, salt and yeast. Stir in the beetroot and enough water to make a shaggy, sticky dough. Cover the bowl and leave at room temperature for 12–18 hours, until bubbly and more than doubled.

Turn out onto a well-floured surface and fold it over on itself a few times into a ball. Set it on a sheet of baking paper, dust with flour, cover and rest 1 hour. Meanwhile put a lidded cast-iron pot in the oven and heat to 230°C / 450°F / gas 8 for 30 minutes.

Using oven gloves, lift out the very hot pot, lower the dough in on its paper, put the lid on and bake 30 minutes. Remove the lid and bake 15–20 minutes more until the crust is deep and pinkish-brown. Cool on a rack. Knock on it before breaking.

POSSET

From a horn-seller's cry on the Rimwatch road at Knocking Gate.

Posset! Warm posset, a horn a crumb! Ewe's milk curdled with spring-salt and a drop of the hard stuff! Warms you through,

sets you up, settles a pang! Posset for the road! Posset for the carrying! Don't ask whose ewe! Don't ask whose milk!

Lore. Posset is the national drink of the highlands: warm ewe's milk curdled with rose spring-salt and spirit, drunk from a horn at every crossroads stall. Midwives give it to bearers after a delivery, Assemblers give it to the Parts they are joining (a horn of posset poured over a new join is said to make it take), and the Foundling Companies are issued it in the morning, warm, before drill, since the born-grown have no mothers to remember and posset is the nearest thing the state can offer. Second-milk, from who knows what, makes a posset that sells for a lack a horn, and that nobody admits to having drunk.

Rules. Routine 10; 1 c a horn. No Taint, unless made with second-milk (Taint 1 Regrowth (Vey)). A horn of posset after a pang, a birth or a Ruin removes 1 Fray from anyone who drinks it in company. On a cook's **Lack**, the posset sets in the horn into the shape of a small hand.

Hook. General Tibb, commander of the Foundling Companies, born six years ago a grown man mid-stride, has a private terror of the day he turns seven. He has begun refusing his morning posset. His quartermaster thinks it is poisoned. Tibb thinks it is worse: that it tastes, for the first time, like something he remembers, and he has nothing he should be able to remember.

FOR YOUR TABLE – LEMON POSSET

Serves 6. Time: 15 minutes, plus 3 hours chilling. Contains dairy. The real dish that shares the name: cream set with lemon, silky and sharp.

- ◇ 600 ml / 2½ cups double (heavy) cream
- ◇ 150 g / ¾ cup caster sugar
- ◇ juice of 3 lemons (about 90 ml / 6 tbsp), plus zest of 1
- ◇ raspberries and shortbread or the biscotti, to serve

Put the cream and sugar in a saucepan and bring slowly to the boil, stirring until the sugar dissolves. Let it bubble gently for 3 minutes, stirring so it does not catch.

Take off the heat and stir in the lemon juice and zest. It will thicken a little at once. Cool for 10 minutes, stir, then pour into six small glasses or cups. Chill at least 3 hours until set. Serve with a few raspberries, red as clay, on top.

PANGDAY BROTH

The counting-song of Pangday, sung by highland families in the strongest room of the house while the earth contracts, with a pot of green broth kept off the fire for after.

*One and the cups shake, two and the door,
Three and the lamp swings, four and the floor,*

*Five for the waters and six for the crown,
Seven we hold it, eight we lie down,
Nine and we breathe and the broth's on the fire,
Out we go after to see what came by her.*

Lore. Every nine days now, at the first tremor, work stops and highland families gather in the strongest room to sing the counting-song and wait out the sixty seconds of the pang. Afterward they go out to see what the waters have brought up out of the ground, and come home, and eat the Pangday broth, a green soup of nettles, oats and spring-salt, made beforehand and set aside, because nobody cooks during a pang. Lark Ninedays, who times the pangs for the state, has been called Lark Thirtydays and Lark Nineteendays and Lark Twelvedays in her life, and each time she changed her name she made a pot of the broth and ate it alone, and wrote the new interval on the lid.

Rules. Routine 10. No Taint. Eating Pangday broth with others after a pang lets each diner recover 1 Fray, as the shared meal rule, without a roll. On a cook's **Lack**, the broth is left on the fire through the pang, and the pot is found afterward with its lid open from the inside, and empty.

Hook. Lark Ninedays has made a new pot of broth. She has not yet written on the lid. She asks the party to sit with her and eat it, and wait for the next pang, and count, because she has done the arithmetic, and she wants witnesses when she writes the number down, and she does not want to be alone when she reads it.

FOR YOUR TABLE – WATERCRESS (OR NETTLE) AND OAT SOUP

Serves 4. Time: 30 minutes. Vegetarian; contains oats (gluten unless certified gluten-free) and dairy (optional cream). If you forage nettles, use young tops in spring, wear gloves to pick and wash them, and cook them thoroughly; cooking removes the sting. Watercress or spinach work just as well and need no gloves.

- ◇ 1 tbsp butter or oil, 1 onion and 1 leek, sliced
- ◇ 2 tbsp rolled oats
- ◇ 1 litre / 4 cups vegetable or chicken stock
- ◇ 150 g / 5 oz watercress (or young nettle tops, or spinach)
- ◇ salt, pepper and a grating of nutmeg; a little cream to serve

Softens the onion and leek in the butter for 8 minutes. Stir in the oats, pour in the stock and simmer 10 minutes. Add the watercress (or nettles) and simmer 3–5 minutes (nettles 5 minutes) until wilted and dark green.

Blend until smooth. Season with salt, pepper and nutmeg. Reheat gently and serve with a swirl of cream. Make it before the game starts, and keep it off the heat until the first pang.

KNOCKER'S THUMBS (FOR THE PLATE NEAREST THE DOOR)

A Tarnbrow custom, as the grandmothers tell it to brides.

Leave the door wide on Tablenight and lay the plate nearest it. Put on it the little red cakes with the thumb-knock in, one for every door in the house. If the plate is clean in the morning, don't wash it. Don't ask who did. If one cake is left, look at which door it was for, and brick that door that night, and every night for a year.

Lore. On Tablenight every door in Cradlewrack is propped wide open until dawn, so that nothing can be said to have broken in, and a place is laid at the table nearest the door for whatever comes. Usually nothing does. The plate holds *knocker's thumbs*: small round cakes, each pressed with a thumb and filled with red jam, one for every door in the house, because a thumb-press is the oldest highland knock, and the cakes are a way of knocking on every door at once on the one night they are open. Agnes Latch, the Doorwright, whose best door held for nineteen days, leaves her plate empty on Tablenight. She says she does not want to give anything a reason.

Rules. Routine 10. No Taint. A household that lays the plate properly on Tablenight gains +2 to all rolls to keep shut, or keep safe, whatever is behind its doors for the next season. If the plate is clean at dawn, the Carver decides who ate: usually a neighbour's child or a stray. Usually. On a cook's **Lack**, the plate is clean and the house has one more door than it did.

Hook. Old Hinge, keeper of the Sill, the door on the hill that stands in its frame with no wall around it, lays a plate of knocker's thumbs at the Sill every Tablenight. In forty years the plate has never been touched. This year one cake is gone. The thumbprint on the remaining cakes, which Old Hinge pressed himself, has been pressed again, from underneath.

FOR YOUR TABLE – JAM THUMBPRINT BISCUITS

Makes about 20. Time: 40 minutes. Contains gluten, dairy, egg (yolk). A good job for younger players: everyone presses their own thumb.

- ◇ 150 g / $\frac{3}{4}$ cup soft unsalted butter
- ◇ 75 g / $\frac{1}{3}$ cup caster sugar
- ◇ 1 egg yolk and 1 tsp vanilla extract
- ◇ 200 g / $1\frac{2}{3}$ cups plain flour and a pinch of salt
- ◇ 5 tbsp raspberry or strawberry jam

Heat the oven to 180°C / 350°F / gas 4 and line two baking trays. Beat the butter and sugar until pale and fluffy, then beat in the yolk and vanilla. Mix in the flour and salt to a soft dough.

Roll into walnut-sized balls and set them a little apart on the trays. Press each firmly in the middle with your thumb to make a deep well (three knocks first, if you like). Fill each well with a little jam.

Bake 12–15 minutes until pale golden at the edges. Cool on the tray for 5 minutes (the jam is very hot), then on a rack. Lay one for every door in the house on a plate by the door.

▼ OATHEN: THE SILENT TABLE



A full mouth, an empty hand.

– OATHEN PROVERB

Oatheners eat goat, canyon lizard, flatbread baked on hot stones, dried figs, and a sour green cheese aged in the river caves. Water is law: every household's cistern-share is sworn yearly at the Rain Shrine, and stealing water is the only theft the Bench treats as a crime against the god. Meals are eaten in silence. Wine is rare and feared, because drunkenness makes promises.

TABLE MANNERS IN THE CANYONS

- ◇ **Silence.** Nothing is said at an Oathen table that does not need saying. Prices, passing and pleasantries are handtalk, which is held not to bind, and which lately does.
- ◇ **Do not praise the food aloud.** *This is delicious* is a statement. *I could eat this every day* is a vow. *I'll never eat anything better* is a very dangerous vow. Sign appreciation: two fingers touched to the lips and drawn away.
- ◇ **Do not promise to come again.** Say *if able*.
- ◇ **Thumb-rings off.** Rings are worn on the thumbs, one for every oath outstanding. A guest removes them at table and sets them beside the plate, so the host can see how much the guest owes, and seat them accordingly. A guest with no rings is seated last, because nobody trusts them.
- ◇ **The cup is not refilled unasked,** and is asked for by turning it upside down. A guest who drinks more than three cups of wine has their cup taken away by the host, kindly, and is watched for the rest of the night, in case they say something.



*FIGS, DRIED, A CRUMB THE HANDFUL. FRESH
THIS MORNING, I AM TOLD.*

STALL-BOARD IN THE FELT MARKET; THE 'I AM
TOLD' IN A DIFFERENT HAND, ADDED AFTER THE
BREAD-WOMAN'S FINGER

THE SILENT SUPPER

A Tablenight table-card of the Galleries of Tacit, set at each place in the felted dining-room; it is the only writing permitted on the table that day, and it is unsigned, because a signed card would be a promise.

The pot will be set in the middle. There is bread. Eat with the right hand. Pass with the left. Nothing need be asked for. Nothing need be thanked. Nothing will be said. For one day, nobody owes anybody anything. You are whole. Eat.

Lore. In the ninth winter of the Lack the canyon people ate Tolm, the Witness, over three nights in the Gullet without a word, because anything said in front of it would have counted. Oathen's Tablenight remembers it: twenty-four hours in which no one in the country makes a sound, and the only day Oatheners feel safe. The meal of the day is the Silent Supper, a single pot of chickpeas, dates and spice set in the middle of the table, eaten with bread and the right hand, in perfect quiet. It is the happiest meal of the year. Enemies sit at one pot. Couples who have not touched in years hold hands under the table. Nothing can be promised, so nothing can be broken; and old people say that at the Silent Supper they can feel, for one day, how it was before the god was in them, listening.

Rules. Routine 10. No Taint. An Oathener who sits the whole Silent Supper without a sound recovers 3 Fray and may remove one Breaking-penalty for a day: the body unclenches. A foreigner who speaks at it is not punished; they are simply removed, gently, and the pot is thrown away, and the family will not meet their eyes for a year. On a cook's **Lack**, someone laughs.

Hook. At the Silent Supper in the house of Sorrin Vael, the Chief Clausewright, a guest is found at dawn dead at the pot, quite peacefully, her hand still in the bread. Nobody made a sound all day. Nobody can be asked anything until sundown without breaking the silence of the most powerful house in Tacit. The party has until sundown to find out what was in her bowl, by looking alone.

FOR YOUR TABLE – CHICKPEA, DATE AND SPICE STEW

Serves 6. Time: 45 minutes. Vegan; gluten-free (check stock). Eat it from a shared pot with flatbread, in silence, if your table can manage it.

- ◇ 2 tbsp olive oil, 2 onions, chopped, and 3 garlic cloves, crushed
- ◇ 1 tbsp grated fresh ginger
- ◇ 2 tsp ground cumin, 2 tsp ground coriander, 1 tsp ground cinnamon, 1 tsp smoked paprika
- ◇ 2 × 400 g / 14 oz tins chickpeas, drained
- ◇ 1 × 400 g / 14 oz tin chopped tomatoes
- ◇ 500 ml / 2 cups vegetable stock
- ◇ 100 g / ½ cup dates, pitted and chopped, and 2 tbsp dried apricots, chopped
- ◇ 1 tbsp lemon juice; fresh coriander or parsley and toasted almonds (optional) to serve

Warm the oil in a wide pan and soften the onions over a medium heat for 10 minutes. Add the garlic, ginger and spices and stir for a minute until fragrant.

Add the chickpeas, tomatoes, stock, dates and apricots. Simmer, uncovered, for 25 minutes, stirring now and then, until thick and glossy; the dates will melt into the sauce. Stir in the lemon juice and season. Scatter herbs and almonds. Set the pot in the middle of the table. Sign the grace. Eat.

Hook. The bread-woman of the Felt Market has written a new line on her slate: FLATBREAD. THE LAST BATCH. It is the first unqualified statement anyone has seen her make. Her stones are cold. Her hands are perfectly whole. She will not say what she means, and the Breakdowns have started to queue.

FOR YOUR TABLE – SKILLET FLATBREADS

Makes 8. Time: 30 minutes (plus 30 minutes resting). Contains gluten, dairy (yogurt). No oven needed: a hot dry frying pan stands in for the canyon stones.

- ◇ 300 g / 2½ cups plain flour, plus extra for dusting
- ◇ 1 tsp baking powder and ½ tsp salt
- ◇ 250 g / 1 cup plain yogurt (or 200 ml water and 2 tbsp olive oil for vegan)
- ◇ 1 tbsp olive oil; melted butter with garlic and herbs, or za’atar, to finish

Mix the flour, baking powder and salt, then stir in the yogurt and oil to a soft dough. Knead briefly until smooth, cover and rest 30 minutes.

Divide into 8 balls and roll each out thinly, about the size of a side plate. Heat a heavy frying pan over a medium-high heat with no oil. Cook each flatbread 1–2 minutes a side until puffed and spotted brown.

Brush with garlic butter or a little oil and za’atar, and keep warm in a clean tea towel. Pass them round with the left hand.

CANYON FLATBREAD

A bread-woman’s slate in the Felt Market, Tacit. She speaks only through the slate.

FLATBREAD, STONE-BAKED, 2 c. CHEAPER THAN YESTERDAY, AS FAR AS I KNOW. BEST IN THE MARKET, IN MY OPINION. MY OPINION IS NOT A PROMISE. ASK THE CHEESE-MAN, HIS OPINION ISN’T EITHER.

Lore. Oathen bread is unleavened or barely risen, slapped thin and baked on hot stones in the canyon ovens, and eaten with everything, in silence. Bread-sellers in the Felt Market are the most careful speakers in a careful city, because a baker makes a hundred small claims a day about freshness, price and quality, and the god weighs every one. The bread-woman whose finger broke over *fresh this morning* still bakes. She has learned to say *I am told*. The canyons honour bakers as they honour Clausewrights: both make something every day that can be held to account.

Rules. Routine 10; 2 c. No Taint. A character who sells or praises food in Oathen in an unqualified statement takes a Weight 1 Breaking if it is untrue; a character who learns the bakers’ conditional patter (Tongue + Clause, Routine 10) never needs to. On a cook’s **Lack**, the baker said *these won’t burn*.

RIVER-CAVE GREEN CHEESE WITH FIGS

From a cheese-cellar ledger of the river caves below Tacit, where the green cheeses ripen in the dark and the damp, and where by Bench order no one may speak above a whisper, because the caves carry.

Laid down: forty wheels, goat, Carving 638, under the Elder’s Seal. Turned: weekly. Spoken over: never. (Margin, in a later hand:) Wheel nineteen was spoken over by the boy Asher, who said into the cave, without thinking, “This one will be the best.” It has been the best. It will not stop being the best. It has grown to three times its size. It is the best. Please send someone.

Lore. The sour green cheese of Oathen is goat’s cheese washed in herb-brine and aged in the river caves, in the damp and the dark, where its rind goes green and its heart goes soft and tangy. It is eaten with dried figs and flatbread at the end of every meal, the fig first, then the cheese, then a sip of water, and is said to clean the mouth of anything said at the table. Cheese-wardens may not speak in the caves above a whisper, because the caves carry, and a word spoken

over a wheel can bind the cheese: wheels have been known to keep promises made over them, to their makers' ruin.

Rules. Routine 10; 3 c a wedge. No Taint. Eating fig and green cheese after a meal gives +1 to the next Clause roll the eater makes that day; it is said to clear the tongue. On a cook's **Lack**, someone spoke over the wheel.

Hook. Wheel nineteen in the river caves is still the best, and still growing. It now fills a chamber. The Bench of Clauses has spent a season drafting a sentence that will release it, and needs someone to go into the cave, whisper it, and then eat the first slice, so that the promise ends where it is kept.

FOR YOUR TABLE – HERB-MARINATED FETA WITH HONEYED FIGS

Serves 6 as a starter or cheese course. Time: 15 minutes, plus at least 2 hours marinating. Vegetarian; gluten-free. Contains dairy.

- ◇ 2 × 200 g / 7 oz blocks feta, cut in 2 cm / ¾ in cubes
- ◇ 200 ml / ¾ cup good olive oil
- ◇ zest of 1 lemon, 1 garlic clove (thinly sliced), 1 tsp chilli flakes (optional)
- ◇ 2 tbsp chopped parsley, mint and dill, and 1 tsp dried oregano
- ◇ 6 dried or fresh figs, halved, and 1 tbsp honey; flatbreads to serve

Put the feta in a clean jar or dish. Warm the oil gently with the lemon zest, garlic and chilli for 3 minutes (do not let it fry), then cool, stir in the herbs and pour over the cheese. Cover and leave in the fridge for at least 2 hours, or up to 3 days. Bring to room temperature before serving.

Warm the figs in a dry pan for 2 minutes, cut side down, then drizzle with honey. Serve the green-flecked cheese in its oil with the figs and flatbread. Fig first, then cheese. No speeches.

LIZARD ON A STICK

A cry from the Breakdowns, the slum of the Forsworn on the canyon floor, where people speak freely because they have nothing left to break.

LIZARD! HOT LIZARD! BEST IN TACIT, I SWEAR IT, AND LOOK, I'M STILL STANDING! What've I got to lose, friend? Already lost the knees! Lizard on a stick, a crumb a stick, cumin and lemon, eat it walking, eat it talking, eat it shouting, down here nobody's listening, down here it's only us!

Lore. Roast canyon lizard is the poor man's meat of Oathen, and the street food of the Breakdowns, where the Forsworn sell it on skewers to anyone who will come down. The Forsworn are the only people in Oathen who shout their wares, and swear by them, because they have already broken and have nothing left to break; and the upper tiers come down to the Breakdowns at dusk, in veils, to buy lizard and hear people talk. Brakk, Voice of the Forsworn,

whose ribs opened outward like a book and stayed that way, eats his lizard with his chest open to the air, and invites the gentry to watch. They do. They come back every week. They say it is the lizard.

Rules. Routine 10; 1 c. No Taint. Eating in the Breakdowns, among the Forsworn, while they talk freely, is a Dread 1 check for an Oathener the first time (all those words, unguarded) and gives +2 to any Persuade roll with the Forsworn for the rest of the night. On a cook's **Lack**, the lizard was a Breakdowns pet, and its owner is a Surety, and will collect.

Hook. A veiled lady of the Heights buys lizard from the same Breakdowns stall every evening, and every evening asks the stall-keeper, in handtalk, to say one sentence for her, aloud, unconditionally, so she can hear what it sounds like. Tonight she has asked him to say *I love you*. He is Forsworn. He has nothing left to break, he thinks. He is wrong by one thing.

FOR YOUR TABLE – CUMIN AND LEMON CHICKEN SKEWERS

Serves 4–6. Time: 30 minutes, plus 1 hour marinating. Gluten-free. Contains dairy (yogurt). If using wooden skewers, soak them in water for 30 minutes first so they do not burn.

- ◇ 700 g / 1½ lb boneless chicken thighs, in 3 cm / 1¼ in pieces
- ◇ 4 tbsp plain yogurt and 2 tbsp olive oil
- ◇ 2 tsp ground cumin, 1 tsp smoked paprika, ½ tsp ground cinnamon
- ◇ 2 garlic cloves, crushed, zest and juice of 1 lemon, 1 tsp salt
- ◇ lemon wedges and chopped parsley to serve

Mix everything but the chicken in a bowl, then add the chicken and stir to coat. Cover and refrigerate for at least 1 hour (up to overnight).

Thread the chicken onto skewers. Cook under a hot grill, on a griddle pan or on a barbecue for 10–12 minutes, turning, until charred at the edges and cooked through with no pink inside. Squeeze over lemon and scatter parsley. Eat them walking, talking, or shouting, as the Breakdowns do.

THE LATE RAIN LOAF

From the private daybook of Yusra Thole, Rainwarden, keeper of the Kept Rain, who has said nothing aloud for a month. The book is written in a careful hand, and every sentence has been read over three times before the next was begun.

The first day of Grace. The sky white. Nothing.

The second day. The Rain-keepers of the high basin met at the shrine, the eldest houses, the heart-eaters' line. Old Corrin Esk offered himself. He said the god had kept its word six hundred and forty years and that perhaps it wanted something of us, a surety, and that he would stand surety for the rain. They did it at the shrine, in silence. They did it properly. They baked the

loaf from what was left, with figs and honey, the old rain-loaf, and shared it, everyone in the basin, a mouthful each, I among them, because I am Rainwarden, and it was my duty. It tasted of figs and honey.

The third day. Nothing.

The fourth day. Rain. It came at dawn, as it always comes. It was the same rain. It came three days late because it was three days late, and Corrin is in all of us, and it made no difference at all. I cannot write that it made no difference. I have just written it. I am still whole. So it is true.

Lore. Before it died, Tolm promised the canyons rain on the first day of Grace, and a god's word outlives the god. The Kept Rain has fallen on that day for six hundred and forty years. This year it came three days late. In the high basin, the Rain-keepers, who descend from those who ate the god's great slow heart, revived the oldest and worst rite they had: a surety for the god's word, sworn in a body. Corrin Esk, eighty years old and the eldest of the line, gave himself, and was killed at the shrine in silence, and his household baked the rain-loaf of figs and honey and the flour of his bones, and every family of the basin ate a mouthful. The rain came on the fourth day, as it would have in any case. The Bench has sealed the record. Yusra Thole, who ate, knows that it was worthless, and cannot say so, because saying so would be true.

Rules. The rain-loaf of the old rite is Dire 22 and a capital crime. A mouthful is Taint 1 Regrowth (Tolm) and a Dread 3 check for anyone who knows what it was; a Rain-keeper who ate it has Corrin Esk's voice, faintly, half a breath behind their own, for the rest of their life. The ordinary rain-loaf of Grace, made with figs, dates and honey and nothing else, is Routine 10 and carries no Taint. On a cook's **Lack**, the loaf is made on the right day and the rain does not come at all.

Hook. Yusra Thole has been silent a month, and the silence is being noticed. She has written a single page and wants it carried to the Bench by someone who is not an Oathener and who can read it aloud without it binding: it says that the god's word has slipped, that the surety was worthless, and that next year the rain-keepers mean to offer three.

FOR YOUR TABLE – DATE, FIG AND WALNUT TEA LOAF

Makes 1 loaf (10 slices). Time: 20 minutes, plus soaking, 1 hour baking. Contains gluten, egg, nuts (walnuts; leave out for nut-free). The rain-loaf as it ought to be: dark, sticky, sweet, made of nothing but fruit and flour.

- ◇ 150 g / 1 cup pitted dates and 100 g / ¾ cup dried figs, chopped
- ◇ 250 ml / 1 cup hot strong black tea
- ◇ 1 tsp bicarbonate of soda
- ◇ 75 g / ⅓ cup soft brown sugar and 2 tbsp honey
- ◇ 1 egg, beaten, and 50 g / 3½ tbsp melted butter
- ◇ 225 g / 1¾ cups self-raising flour, ½ tsp mixed spice
- ◇ 60 g / ½ cup walnuts, roughly chopped

Put the dates and figs in a bowl, pour over the hot tea, stir in the bicarbonate (it will fizz) and leave 30 minutes. Heat the oven to 170°C / 340°F / gas 3 and line a 900 g / 2 lb loaf tin.

Stir the sugar, honey, egg and melted butter into the fruit, then fold in the flour, spice and walnuts. Scrape into the tin and bake 55–65 minutes until risen and a skewer comes out clean. Cool in the tin 10 minutes, then on a rack. Slice thick and spread with butter. Serve it on the first rainy day of spring, which will come when it comes.

▼ THE FAST: THE TABLE THAT IS NOT LAID



Never eat what you did not carry yourself.

– THE THIRD OF THE FIVE RULES, TAUGHT BEFORE LETTERS

Nothing grows in the Fast. Seed rots, hens stop laying at the border, and bread baked from Rim flour in a Fast oven rises, browns, smells correct, and is ash inside when broken. Every mouthful is carried in from the Rim, pooled in the Pantry at Wanting, and rationed. The Unfed eat once a day, cold, standing, facing a wall, without visible pleasure. The only food the land itself offers is the god's.

TABLE MANNERS IN THE FAST

- ◇ **There is no table.** Unfed homes have no hearth, no oven and no dining table. Food is eaten from the hand, standing, against a wall or facing open sky. A spoon is a luxury and a fork is a disgrace.
- ◇ **The Decline.** Refuse every offer three times. Accept on the fourth. Accepting on the first is a scandal; a host who offers only three times is mean.
- ◇ **Carry your own.** Bring your own water in your own flask to every meeting. Never eat what another person made for you without the full Decline, and never eat what nobody made at all.
- ◇ **No pleasure.** To close the eyes while eating is obscene. To make a sound of appreciation is a confession. An Unfed who catches themselves enjoying a mouthful spits it into their hand, looks at it, and eats it again slowly as penance.
- ◇ **Never say Come in.** Never answer it. Never thank a chair.
- ◇ **Never feed another.** Giving your own food to someone else is a crime in the Fast, because it confuses the ledgers, and because it is hospitality.



It smells like your mother's.

THE WORST THING ONE UNFED CAN SAY TO
ANOTHER

FAST RATION-BREAD

A ration chit of the Pantry at Wanting, printed on grey card, stamped, and initialled by Mother Stint Avery.

PANTRY OF THE ABSTINENT. ONE MEASURE. Bearer: Hartsell, Yield (and household, 1). Value: one half-ration, grey loaf or oat equivalent, Rim-baked, carried. To be eaten cold. To be eaten standing. To be eaten by the bearer and by no other. Not transferable. Not to be fed. Not to be enjoyed.

(On the back, in pencil, very small:) Four months of grain for six months of winter. I have decided which villages. God forgive me. No. Not that one. Not any of them.

Lore. Fast ration-bread is a grey, dense, flat loaf or oatake, baked on the Rim at the far end of the Bakers' Mile in Gristmoot, from Company flour bought on credit, and hauled in by the Crumb-Runners, who are spat on in the street by the people it feeds. It is joyless by design. Mother Stint Avery weighs out every measure. Elder Forbear Wend has starved eleven people by leaving their names off a list, and prays for each by name. The grey loaf is the Unfed's whole cuisine, and they are proud of it the way soldiers are proud of a scar; and every Unfed child, at some point, holds one up to the light and wonders what it would taste like warm, and is slapped for wondering.

Rules. Routine 10. No Taint (Rim-grown). Eaten cold and standing: –1 Hunger for Godeaters, or counts as a Pantry measure for Pangs (no change). An Unfed who eats a ration-bread cold, standing, facing a wall, after saying the Decline, may roll Caul + Resolve (Routine 10) to gain +1 Want. On a cook's **Lack**, the loaf was baked inside the Fast, and is ash.

Hook. Tarry Moss, the Crumb-Runner, counts his cargo daily down to the bean and has never eaten a mouthful of it. This week the count is up, not down: there are more loaves on his cart than he loaded at Gristmoot, and they are warm, and they smell faintly of butter, and he has to decide, before he reaches Wanting, whether to tell Mother Stint.

FOR YOUR TABLE – PLAIN OATCAKES

Makes about 16. Time: 35 minutes. Contains oats (use certified gluten-free oats for coeliacs) and dairy (or use oil). Plain, cold and honest. Good with cheese, better with butter, best eaten standing up facing a wall, if you are playing the Unfed.

- ◇ 225 g / 2¼ cups medium oatmeal or rolled oats blitzed briefly in a blender
- ◇ ½ tsp salt and ¼ tsp bicarbonate of soda
- ◇ 30 g / 2 tbsp butter (or 2 tbsp oil), melted
- ◇ about 100 ml / ⅓ cup + 1 tbsp hot water

Heat the oven to 180°C / 350°F / gas 4 and line a baking tray. Mix the oatmeal, salt and soda in a bowl. Add the melted butter and enough hot water to make a firm, slightly sticky dough.

Dust the worktop with oatmeal and roll the dough out about 4 mm / ¼ in thick. Cut into rounds with a 6 cm / 2½ in cutter (or into triangles with a knife), re-rolling the scraps. Bake on the tray for 20–25 minutes, turning once, until dry and just golden at the edges. Cool on a rack. Say *No, thank you* three times before eating. Accept on the fourth.

ORRUM'S TABLE BREAD

From the report of Spare Tolland of the Hostwatch, who has followed Orrum at a mile's distance for thirty years and never seen its face.

Table at the crossroads of the Brindle road, laid for one, at dusk. I stood off at eighty paces and wrote down what was on it, as is my duty. A white cloth. A candle. A pat of butter beaded with cold, on a blue dish. A loaf. The loaf was small and round and brown and shining on top as if it had been brushed with something, and split along the top where it had risen, and steam was coming out of the split. I could smell it at eighty paces. I could smell the yeast in it. I could smell that it was still a little underdone in the very middle, the way my mother made it, because she always took it out too soon, because we were always too hungry to wait. The place card had my name on it. My mother's hand. I stood there till dawn. I am writing this at Wax Halt. I have eaten my ration. It was grey, and cold, and I chewed it forty times, and it was not that.

Lore. At every one of Orrum's tables there is bread. Nobody living who has tasted it has got up again, save Lent Ashby, who cannot taste anything now. The Hostwatch reports agree on what it looks like (small, round, glazed, split and steaming, with cold butter beaded on a blue dish) and on nothing else, because to every watcher it smells like the bread of the person who loved them first. The Tablebreakers put an axe through the table before anyone can

sit. An Orrum crumb, picked off the cloth before the axe fell, is a relic that keeps the holder from feeling hungry, and smells of fresh bread for six hundred years. Verger Sober Osmond lays a place at the Empty Chair every night against all law, and every morning the plate is clean, and he believes that this is why the god has stayed gentle.

Rules. Orrum's bread cannot be cooked; it can only be offered. Smelling it on the wind is an Invitation check at Routine 10; seeing it on a laid table, Hard 14; seeing it with a place card in a loved hand, Grim 18 (add Pangs). A character who eats it is a guest of Orrum, and does not get up (see the Fast chapter: the Seating). A non-Unfed character who eats it must pass an Impossible (26) Caul + Resolve roll or sit at the next table they see, forever.

Hook. Abstain Rooke, called Abby, eleven, raised on the rules, has been leaving a crust on her windowsill at night. Each morning it has been replaced with something better. This morning it was a small round loaf, glazed, split, steaming, with cold butter on a blue dish, and a card. The card does not have her name on it. It has her dead grandmother's, and the words *for when you visit*.

FOR YOUR TABLE – SOFT GLAZED DINNER ROLLS WITH HONEY BUTTER

Makes 12. Time: 30 minutes active, 1½ hours rising, 20 minutes baking. Contains gluten, dairy, egg. The best bread in this book. At your table, you may sit down and eat it. You may even get up again afterward.

- ◇ 500 g / 4 cups strong white bread flour
- ◇ 7 g / 1 sachet fast-action dried yeast, 1 tsp salt, 2 tbsp sugar
- ◇ 250 ml / 1 cup warm whole milk
- ◇ 1 egg, beaten, plus 1 more beaten with 1 tbsp milk for the glaze
- ◇ 50 g / 3½ tbsp soft butter
- ◇ for the honey butter: 100 g / 7 tbsp soft salted butter beaten with 2 tbsp honey

Mix the flour, yeast, salt and sugar. Add the warm milk, egg and butter, and mix to a soft, slightly sticky dough. Knead 10 minutes until smooth, silky and elastic. Cover and leave in a warm place about 1 hour until doubled.

Knock back and divide into 12 equal pieces. Roll each into a tight smooth ball and set them, just touching, in a buttered 23 × 33 cm / 9 × 13 in tin. Cover and leave 30–40 minutes until puffed. Heat the oven to 190°C / 375°F / gas 5.

Brush gently with the egg glaze and bake 18–22 minutes until deep golden and shining. Brush with a little melted butter as they come out. Serve warm, torn apart at the table, with the honey butter cold on a blue dish. Set one roll on a plate at the empty chair, and do not look at it too long.

CRUMB-RUNNER'S POCKET-BREAD

Overheard at the far end of the Bakers' Mile, Gristmoot, between a Crumb-Runner and a Fatlands baker's girl, who

had offered him a bun.

“No, thank you.” “Go on.” “No, thank you.” “Go on, love, it’s free.” “No, thank you.” (A pause.) “Will you have a bun?” “Yes. Thank you.” (He put it in his pocket. He did not eat it. He paid for forty grey loaves and pushed the cart east. The girl watched him all the way to the turn. Her mother said, “Leave him, he’s one of them.” The girl said, “He took it, though.”)

Lore. The Crumb-Runners bring food in from the Rim by night, despised, and are the only reason anyone in the Fast is alive. On the road they eat pocket-bread: hard bars of oats, seeds and dried fruit pressed together and carried in a coat pocket for weeks, eaten one bite an hour, walking. *Carry your own* is the Fast’s whole philosophy of food, and the pocket-bread is its purest form: no table, no host, no fire, nobody’s hand but your own. The Runners say a bar of it is the only meal on the Table with no god in it at all, not even the god of the cook.

Rules. Routine 10 to make. No Taint. A week’s pocket-bread counts as trail rations (safe, dull) and lets an Unfed character resist the smell of baking on the wind (Invitation checks at Routine) at +2, since they have something of their own in their mouth. On a cook’s **Lack**, someone else made it, and slipped it in your pocket, and you did not notice.

Hook. A Crumb-Runner’s cart has been found on the Wanting road with its runner gone and its load untouched, and the grain counted to the bean. In his coat, folded over the back of the cart, is a pocket-bread with a single bite out of it. The bite was not taken with human teeth. It was taken very politely, from the corner, by something with a great many of them, that wanted only a taste of what he carried.

FOR YOUR TABLE – NO-BAKE OAT, SEED AND FRUIT BARS

Makes 12 bars. Time: 20 minutes, plus 2 hours chilling. Contains oats (gluten unless certified free), seeds; may contain nuts if you add them. A good thing to prepare ahead and hand round at the start of a session.

- ◇ 200 g / 2 cups rolled oats
- ◇ 75 g / ½ cup mixed seeds (sunflower, pumpkin, sesame)
- ◇ 100 g / ¾ cup chopped dried fruit (dates, apricots, raisins)
- ◇ 100 g / 7 tbsp butter (or coconut oil)
- ◇ 4 tbsp honey or golden syrup and 50 g / ¼ cup light brown sugar
- ◇ a pinch of salt and ½ tsp cinnamon

Line a 20 cm / 8 in square tin with baking paper. Toast the oats and seeds in a dry frying pan for 4–5 minutes, stirring, until fragrant, then tip into a bowl with the dried fruit.

Melt the butter, honey and sugar in a small pan and bubble for 2 minutes, stirring. Pour over the oat mix with the salt and cinnamon and stir until everything is coated. Press very firmly into the tin with the back of a spoon. Chill 2 hours, then cut into bars. Wrap each in paper. Carry your own.

COLD YARD POTTAGE

The Cold Yard rule, painted on the wall of every cooking-yard in Wanting.

FIRE ON. POT ON. POT WARM. FIRE OUT. STAMP IT. NOBODY SITS. NOBODY STAYS. NOBODY SAYS IT SMELLS GOOD. EAT FROM THE HAND. YARD EMPTY BY THE BELL.

Lore. An oven in the Fast is the god’s, so the Unfed cook outdoors on bare ground in the Cold Yards, quickly, and stamp the fire out the moment the pot is warm, and eat the pottage from their hands, standing, before it cools, and then walk away. A Cold Yard pottage is lentils, a little barley or oats, whatever the Pantry measure holds, and salt, warmed but never properly cooked, and never, ever left on a lit fire, because a fire left burning in the Fast is a hearth, and a hearth is an invitation. Every Unfed has a story of a Cold Yard where someone left the fire a little too long, and the pot began to smell better than it should, and when they came back the yard had a table in it.

Rules. Routine 10. No Taint. Counts as a full ration if made from Pantry dried goods (–1 Pang). A cook who leaves the fire burning past the pot’s warming must make a Caul + Resolve roll (Hard 14); on a failure, the smell of baking begins, and every Unfed character within sight makes an Invitation check at Routine 10. On a **Lack**, the pottage is the best thing anyone in the yard has ever eaten, and two of them sit down on the ground.

Hook. In the Cold Yard behind the Lean End in Wanting, someone has been building a fire at night and leaving it lit. It is never found burning; only warm ash, a ring of stones, and, each morning, a little closer to the ring, the marks of chair-legs in the frost.

FOR YOUR TABLE – RED LENTIL POTTAGE

Serves 4–6. Time: 35 minutes. Vegan; gluten-free (check stock). Thick, warming and very cheap: the opposite of a ration, in every way but the price.

- ◇ 2 tbsp olive oil, 1 onion, 1 carrot and 1 celery stick, finely chopped
- ◇ 2 garlic cloves, crushed, 1 tsp ground cumin, 1 tsp ground turmeric
- ◇ 250 g / 1¼ cups red lentils, rinsed
- ◇ 1.2 litres / 5 cups vegetable stock
- ◇ 1 × 400 g / 14 oz tin chopped tomatoes
- ◇ juice of ½ lemon; salt and pepper; a handful of spinach (optional)

Soften the onion, carrot and celery in the oil for 8 minutes. Stir in the garlic and spices for a minute. Add the lentils, stock and tomatoes and bring to the boil, then simmer 20–25 minutes, stirring often, until the lentils have collapsed into a thick pottage.

Stir in the spinach, if using, and the lemon juice, and season well. Serve in mugs, to be drunk standing, or in bowls with oatcakes. Turn the hob off the moment it is done. Do not leave it on.

THE PLUM ON THE SILL

From the notebook kept by Dr. Mercy Thrane, physician of starvation, in which she asks each of her Unfed patients to name the one food they cannot stop thinking about.

Case 41. Woman, 30s, Pangs 6, two missed rations. Food: “a plum on a sill.” Clarified: a plum, red-black, split, warm from the sun, on the windowsill of a Rim inn she passed at eight years old. She did not take it. She has thought of it every day for twenty-five years. She describes the bloom on its skin. She describes a wasp. She describes the sticky crack in its side. Last week she found a plum on the sill of her own house in Wanting. In Lack. Split. Warm. With a wasp. She did not take it. She asked me, with a perfectly level face, how many times she will be asked.

Lore. Every Unfed has one food they cannot stop thinking about: a smell from a Rim inn window at eight years old, a sugared almond a poacher once held to their lips, a plum on a sill. The Unfed are trained out of craving, but the cracks remain, and the god knows them. Orrum’s tables serve, to each guest, the best thing they have ever been offered or the thing they have wanted longest, and the

Hostwatch have noted that in the last three years, in Wanting, the things that appear on sills have begun to be very precise.

Rules. An Unfed PC should write their one food on the sheet (see the Fast chapter, *Playing the Hunger*). When it appears, unbidden, it is an Invitation check at Hard 14 (Grim 18 if it is exactly as remembered), plus Pangs. A character who refuses it gains +2 Want. A character who eats it, if it was the god’s, is a guest. If it was not the god’s (the Carver knows) nothing happens, and that is somehow worse, because now they will never know.

Hook. Dr. Mercy Thrane wants help with an experiment. She will set a plum (Rim-grown, bought, clean, honest) on the sill of case 41 and watch from across the yard. If the woman takes it and nothing happens, the doctor believes she can prove that the hunger itself can be fed, that some of what calls is only want. If the woman takes it and something does happen, the doctor would like the party to be standing closer than she is.

FOR YOUR TABLE – ROASTED PLUMS WITH OAT CRUMBLE

Serves 4–6. Time: 40 minutes. Contains gluten (unless using gluten-free oats and flour), dairy. Warm, dark and sticky; the thing on the sill.

- ◇ 8 ripe plums, halved and stoned
- ◇ 3 tbsp honey or brown sugar, ½ tsp cinnamon, zest of 1 orange
- ◇ for the crumble: 60 g / ½ cup plain flour, 50 g / ½ cup rolled oats, 50 g / ¼ cup demerara sugar, 50 g / 3½ tbsp cold butter, diced
- ◇ Greek yogurt, custard or cream to serve

Heat the oven to 190°C / 375°F / gas 5. Lay the plums cut side up in a baking dish. Drizzle with honey, sprinkle with cinnamon and orange zest.

Rub the butter into the flour with your fingertips until it looks like breadcrumbs, then stir in the oats and sugar. Scatter the crumble over and around the plums.

Bake 25–30 minutes until the plums are soft and bubbling and the crumble is golden. Serve warm with yogurt or cream. Leave one plum, split and shining, on a saucer on the windowsill. If it is gone in the morning, do not ask.

▼ THE RIM: THE ROAD'S TABLE



Count the chairs before the grace. Count them again after.

– THE COMPANY'S BOOK OF USAGES, INSTRUCTION TO INN-KEEPERS

The Rim is not a road with markets on it. It is a market with a road through it, and its kitchens feed every land at once: Fatlands meat at the Groaning Board, kelp-bread for the west, clatter-cake for the Lid, grey loaves for the Crumb-Runners at the far end of the Bakers' Mile. Rim cooks sell "safe" food, which means food they will swear is not of any god, and nobody believes them. The Company inns have one rule above their kitchen doors, and it is not about food.

TABLE MANNERS ON THE ROAD

- ◇ **Say the grace to the nearest stranger**, face to face, at the Grace Bell. It is the one moment of the Rim day when nobody is selling anything.
- ◇ **Every land's manners, at once.** A Rim common room seats an Unfed facing the wall, a Vigilant standing at the bar, an Oathener in silence, a Fatlander on their third supper and a Kept northerner chewing for company. The Rim rule is to let each eat their way, and to say nothing about anybody's mouth.
- ◇ **Pay before you eat.** Not after. On the Rim, a meal eaten before it is paid for is a guest's meal, and the Company does not want anyone at its tables to be a guest.
- ◇ **Do not take the free loaf** at Gristmoot unless you mean to stay a week. The house takes wagers.
- ◇ **Count the chairs.** Before the grace and after. If the number has changed, leave the money on the table and go.



*HOT LOAF FREE AT THE DOOR. WAGERS
TAKEN.*

CHALKED BY THE DOOR OF THE FULL MEASURE,
GRISTMOOT

THE STRANGER'S LOAF

The Gristmoot welcome, said at every inn door, with the loaf held out in a cloth.

Come for a week. Everyone does. (And from the wager-slate inside the Full Measure, chalked fresh each morning:) Vigil glass-wife, 8 st 4, came Moot-day: house says she stays. 3 to 1. Oathen paper-man, very thin, says nothing: house says he

stays. Evens. Unfed boy with a cart: house says no. 20 to 1. (He refused the loaf thrice. We offered a fourth. He took it and put it in his pocket. Ask Bastable whether that counts.)

Lore. Every inn door in Gristmoot gives every stranger a hot loaf of toothed-wheat bread, free, and the house takes wagers on whether the stranger will stay. The house nearly always wins. Fatlands bread carries Ummer's Hunger, and the first loaf, hot, at the door, after a long dry road out of Oathen, is the one that most travellers never get over. They stay a day, then a week, then for the Moot; they weigh in heavier at the gate each time; and some of them end up behind the stockyards after Last Bell, sold by the pound. A Stranger's Loaf refused and carried away unbroken is a relic that lets its bearer always leave. Gristmoot innkeepers pay well to have one back. The house does not like to lose.

Rules. Routine 10. Taint 1 Hunger. A character who eats the Stranger's Loaf in Gristmoot must make a Caul + Resolve roll (Hard 14) to leave the town within a week; each further day they stay raises the difficulty by one step. An Unfed character takes it on the fourth offer without penalty, and may carry it unbroken as the relic. On a cook's **Lack**, the loaf has a tooth in it, and the tooth has a filling, and the filling is Oathen work.

Hook. The house at the Full Measure has taken a wager on the party. The odds are chalked by the door. Someone has bet four platters that one of them, by name, will not leave Gristmoot alive; and the bettor, according to Toll-Reeve Bastable Crumb's ledger, is the party's own employer.

FOR YOUR TABLE – CHEESE AND CHIVE SCONES (THE HOT LOAF AT THE DOOR)

Makes 8. Time: 30 minutes. Contains gluten, dairy, egg. Quick, hot and buttery: hand one to each player at the door as they arrive.

- ◇ 225 g / 1¾ cups self-raising flour, plus extra for dusting
- ◇ 1 tsp baking powder, ½ tsp salt, ½ tsp mustard powder
- ◇ 50 g / 3½ tbsp cold butter, diced
- ◇ 100 g / 1 cup mature cheddar, grated, and 2 tbsp chopped chives
- ◇ 1 egg and about 100 ml / ⅓ cup + 1 tbsp milk, plus extra milk to glaze

Heat the oven to 220°C / 425°F / gas 7 and flour a baking tray. Mix the flour, baking powder, salt and mustard, then rub in the butter with your fingertips until it looks like breadcrumbs. Stir in most of the cheese and the chives.

Beat the egg with the milk, pour most of it in, and mix lightly with a knife to a soft dough, adding the rest if dry. Pat out on a floured surface to 3 cm / 1¼ in thick and cut 8 rounds, re-patting the scraps. Do not twist the cutter.

Set on the tray, brush with milk, top with the remaining cheese and bake 12–15 minutes until risen and golden. Serve hot at the door, wrapped in a cloth. Take wagers.

SAUSAGE BY THE YARD

The patter of Mardy Haunch, Sausage-Wife of Gristmoot, whose stall is the widest on the Rim.

Sausage by the yard! By the yard, by the fathom, by the mile if you've the purse for it! Pork, honestly pork, I swear it on my mother's meat which is in me! Beef! Orchard-pig! The Long Acre special, don't ask, you'll want three! You, love, from the Lid, you're thin as a pin, come here, come here, have a yard, have it in batter, have it in the hole, my treat, no, no, my treat, you look heavy already, you'll be back.

Lore. Mardy Haunch sells sausage by the yard from the widest stall on the Rim, a single unbroken coil pulled off a drum and cut at the customer's word. Her most famous dish is the yard baked whole in a great tray of batter, which Gristmoot calls *sausage in the hole* and serves at every Moot-day supper. Her sausage is very good, and its origin is stamped over twice, and the Renderers' Union knows exactly what is in each coil, and Mistress Brisket Annalow has never once stopped a barrel of Mardy's. A coil tattooed in blue with crossed anchors and a name was sold off her drum in Plenty, and a Brinehollow rope-wife on the next stall recognised the name.

Rules. Routine 10. Taint 1 Hunger. A full yard eaten in one sitting counts as two meals for the Feasting Laws. On a cook's **Lack**, roll on What's in the Barrel? (Rim Market chapter) for what is in the coil.

Hook. The rope-wife on the next stall has bought the tattooed sausage and will not let it be eaten. She wants it buried at sea, properly, with a rope funeral. The sea is nineteen miles from the end of the Mile, and she wants the party to carry it there, and to say, at the edge of the Trench, *the line held, the sea was stronger*, because it did not, and it was not, and she needs someone to lie for her.

FOR YOUR TABLE – TOAD IN THE HOLE WITH ONION GRAVY

Serves 4–6. Time: 1 hour. Contains gluten, egg, dairy. Use your favourite sausages, vegetarian or meat; the batter puffs up dramatically around them.

- ◇ 8–12 good sausages
- ◇ 2 tbsp vegetable oil or beef dripping
- ◇ for the batter: 140 g / 1 cup + 2 tbsp plain flour, 4 eggs, 200 ml / ¾ cup milk, ½ tsp salt
- ◇ for the gravy: 2 onions, thinly sliced, 1 tbsp butter, 1 tbsp flour, 400 ml / 1⅓ cups beef or vegetable stock, 1 tsp Worcestershire sauce

Whisk the flour, eggs, milk and salt to a smooth batter the thickness of cream. Rest it 30 minutes. Heat the oven to 220°C / 425°F / gas 7.

Put the oil and sausages in a roasting tin (about 30 × 20 cm / 12 × 8 in) and roast 15 minutes until browning and the fat is very hot. Working quickly and carefully, take the tin out, pour the batter around the sausages, and return it to the oven at once. Bake 25–30 minutes until risen and deep golden. Do not open the oven door for the first 20 minutes.

Meanwhile, cook the onions slowly in the butter for 20 minutes until soft and brown, stir in the flour, then the stock and Worcestershire, and simmer until thick. Serve the toad in big squares with the gravy. You look heavy already.

SWORN SOUP

A notarised menu-card of the Company inn at Toll Nine, sworn before Jessamy Quill, Notary of the Rim Road, and framed above the kitchen hatch.

I, the undersigned cook of this house, as I now intend, if able, barring weather, do swear that the soup of this house is made of: hen, Rim-reared; leeks, onion, carrot, celery, parsley, Rim-grown; barley; salt; water from the Company cistern; and nothing else whatever, of any land, of any god, of any person. Sworn at Tacit, Plenty 637. (Beneath, a smaller card:) The cook's hands are both still on. Judge for yourselves.

Lore. The Rim Road Company swears all its contracts in Oathen, where they cannot be broken; and a few of its inns, for a price, have had their cooks swear their soup. A Sworn Soup is a plain chicken broth with vegetables and barley, and it is the only dish on the Table

that is certainly, provably, of no god at all, because the cook's body is the guarantee. It costs four times what it should. Envoy Prudence Lowell of the Fast eats nothing else on the Rim. Fatlanders find it tasteless. Travellers with failing Regrowth order it by the gallon, and nothing happens, which is exactly what they paid for.

Rules. Routine 10 to make; to swear it, a Clausewright and a trip to Tacit. Sworn Soup carries no Taint, guaranteed: an Unfed may eat it without the Decline's full form (twice is enough), and it is the one safe meal for a character avoiding Seasoning. A character who eats Sworn Soup after a Taint meal does not purge the Taint; they only feel better. On a cook's **Lack**, the cook's thumb is in it. Nobody can be sure what else the god counted.

Hook. The cook at Toll Nine has lost both thumbs this morning. The soup is the same as ever; the hens, leeks and barley are clean. But the Company cistern under the counting-house, where the factor goes alone each week with a measuring rod, has something in it that the Company would very much like nobody to know about, and the god, it seems, has counted it as an ingredient.

FOR YOUR TABLE – CHICKEN, LEEK AND BARLEY SOUP

Serves 6. Time: 1½ hours. Contains gluten (barley), celery. Honest and plain, as sworn.

- ◇ 1 tbsp butter and 1 tbsp oil
- ◇ 2 leeks, sliced, 1 onion, 2 carrots and 2 celery sticks, diced
- ◇ 2 garlic cloves, crushed
- ◇ 4 bone-in chicken thighs (about 600 g / 1½ lb), skin removed
- ◇ 1.75 litres / 7 cups chicken stock
- ◇ 75 g / ⅓ cup pearl barley, rinsed
- ◇ 2 bay leaves, a few sprigs of thyme, a handful of chopped parsley; salt and pepper

Melt the butter with the oil in a large pot and soften the leeks, onion, carrots and celery for 10 minutes. Add the garlic for a minute. Lay in the chicken, pour over the stock, add the barley, bay and thyme, and bring to a gentle simmer.

Cover and simmer 1 hour, until the chicken falls from the bone and the barley is tender. Lift out the chicken, shred the meat with two forks (discard the bones), and return it to the pot. Remove the bay and thyme stalks, season, and stir in the parsley. Swear to it.

RIM PUNCH

The drinks-board of the Long Farewell at Fogmouth, where Tam Ruddock's clients wait to cross north into Sallowreach so that they will not die.

FEN-GIN, 3 c. (The bottle never quite empties.) SALTWICK GIN, 3 c. (There is sweet water in it.) MARROW-BRANDY, 3 L. (Do not ask.) FIG-SPIRIT, 2 c. (You will say something you

mean.) RIM PUNCH, HOT, 1 c. (Apples. Honey. Spice. Safe. Have two. It's a long wait.)

Lore. Every land has a spirit that does something to the drinker: fen-gin that never empties, marrow-brandy that steadies the will and wakes the Hunger, fig-spirit that loosens Oathen tongues into true sentences, Saltwick gin with sweet water in it. The Rim has punch: hot apple, honey and spice, sometimes with a slug of whatever the traveller brought, ladled from a copper on every common-room hob along the road. It is drunk by the dying in the back room of the Long Farewell, while they wait for Tam Ruddock's boat across the border, where they will not die. He has never told one of them what happens next. He makes the punch himself, and makes it very good, and sleeps badly.

Rules. Routine 10. No Taint (unless the traveller adds their own land's spirit, which carries its own). A cup of hot punch in a Rim common room, with company, gives +1 to the shared-meal Fray roll. On a cook's **Lack**, someone has added marrow-brandy, and everyone at the table gains 1 Hunger and feels braver than they should.

Hook. Idony Pask, the Tourist, came north with a wasting sickness so she would not die of it. She did not die. She can never leave. She has paid Tam Ruddock to carry a letter south to the Long Farewell, to be read aloud to the next room of waiting clients over their punch. It is very short, and it is the truth, and Tam would like the party to stop him delivering it, or to help him, and has not decided which.

FOR YOUR TABLE – HOT SPICED APPLE PUNCH

Serves 8. Time: 20 minutes. Vegan; alcohol-free. Adults may add a splash of dark rum or brandy to their own cup, as Rim travellers add their own land's spirit.

- ◇ 1.5 litres / 6 cups cloudy apple juice
- ◇ 500 ml / 2 cups cranberry juice (or more apple juice)
- ◇ 2 tbsp honey or brown sugar, to taste
- ◇ 2 cinnamon sticks, 6 cloves, 3 star anise, 4 slices of fresh ginger
- ◇ 1 orange, sliced into rounds, and 1 apple, thinly sliced

Put everything in a large pan and warm gently for 15 minutes, without boiling, until fragrant. Taste and add more honey if needed.

Ladle into mugs, leaving the spices behind, with a slice of orange in each. Keep it on the lowest heat for refills through the evening. It's a long wait.

THE CROSSROADS PASTY

A note left under a burnt table-leg in the yard of the Company inn at Saltlick Cross, in an inn-keeper's hand, Carving 641.

We burned the table as instructed. We did not read the card. We did not. But there was a pasty on the plate, wrapped in a cloth, and it was still warm after the table was ash, and my girl, who is seven, picked it up before I could stop her, because she thought it was ours. She did not eat it. She held it. She held it all night. In the morning it was cold and she would not give it up. It is cold now. It is just a pasty. Isn't it? She has put it on the windowsill, and laid a place beside it. She says it is for the man who comes in at night and counts the chairs, so he will not be hungry, so he will go somewhere else.

Lore. The pasty is the Rim's own food: meat or cheese and potato and onion in a crimped crust, carried in the hand, eaten walking, food that needs no table. Travellers on the Rim prefer it above all other meals in the last three years, since Company inn-keepers began to find tables laid in their common rooms at dawn, because a pasty can be eaten anywhere, standing, in the yard, on the road, and nobody need pull out a chair. In some inns, nobody sits to eat at all any more. At Saltlick Cross the chair rents for a platter a night, and the renters, mostly Fatlands pilgrims, eat pasties on the way to it, as the last food they will carry themselves.

Rules. Routine 10. No Taint (Rim-grown), unless made with Fatlands meat (Taint 1 Hunger). A character eating a pasty on foot, without sitting, cannot be the subject of an Invitation check that turn: they have their own food in their own hand. On a cook's **Lack**, the pasty is still warm in the morning.

Hook. The inn-keeper's girl at Saltlick Cross has laid a place on the windowsill every night for a week, with a cold pasty and a card in her own hand. Every morning the pasty is gone. Every morning the chair in the common room, the rented one, has been pushed in a little further, as if someone polite has been told, by a child, that there is no room, and is waiting to be asked properly.

FOR YOUR TABLE – CHEESE, POTATO AND ONION PASTIES

Makes 6. Time: 1 hour 15 minutes. Contains gluten, dairy, egg. Vegetarian. Made with ready-made pastry to keep things simple.

- ◇ 2 × 320 g / 11 oz packs ready-rolled shortcrust pastry
- ◇ 2 medium potatoes (about 350 g / 12 oz), peeled and cut in 1 cm / ½ in dice
- ◇ 1 onion, finely chopped, and 1 tbsp butter
- ◇ 150 g / 1½ cups mature cheddar, grated
- ◇ 1 tsp wholegrain mustard, 1 tbsp chopped parsley, salt and plenty of black pepper
- ◇ 1 egg, beaten

Boil the potatoes in salted water for 6–8 minutes until just tender; drain and cool. Soften the onion in the butter for 8 minutes. Mix the potato, onion, cheese, mustard, parsley and seasoning.

Heat the oven to 200°C / 400°F / gas 6 and line a tray. Cut six 15 cm / 6 in circles from the pastry (use a small plate as a guide). Spoon filling onto one half of each, brush the edge with egg, fold over and press to seal; crimp by twisting the edge over itself with your fingers.

Brush with egg, cut a small slit in each, and bake 25–30 minutes until golden. Cool a little before eating; the filling is hot. Eat it standing, in your hand, anywhere at all.

▼WHAT'S FOR SUPPER AT THE INN

Pay before you eat. Not after.

— THE COMPANY'S BOOK OF USAGES

When the party sits (or stands) down to supper at any Company inn per head, in a good season. The catch is what the cook did not say. or roadside cookshop on the Rim, roll a d20, or choose. The price is

D20	SUPPER	PRICE	THE CATCH
1	Honest pottage of Rim lentils and barley	2 c	None. It is exactly what it says. The party will not believe it.
2	Sworn Soup, under a framed oath	4 c	The cook has nine fingers. Ask about the tenth.
3	Sausage by the yard, in batter	5 c	One link is tattooed. Roll on What's in the Barrel?
4	Cold gull with kelp relish, for the west-bound	3 c	The cook says a dead name over each plate and will not say whose.
5	Lively eel in sour, a north-road special	4 c	One piece climbs out of the bowl and goes under the table.
6	Toothed loaf and dripping, free with ale	1 c	Taint 1 Hunger. A tooth in the second slice (d10: 1).
7	Lamb stew with pink salt, from the highland road	3 c	The cook knocks on the pot before every ladle and looks at the door.
8	Chickpeas and flatbread, eaten in silence	3 c	An Oathen notary at the next table is writing down everything the party says.
9	Lawful Soup, lukewarm, sharp-rimmed bowls	2 c	A Vigil pilgrim has stood at the bar for three days, eyes wide, and has just begun to smile.
10	Roast of something, "Fatlands, declared"	6 c	The stamp has been stamped over twice. The meat cooks faster on the side away from the fire.
11	Wake-bill leftovers, sold cheap	2 c	A printed bill is folded under the plate. The deceased's name is the cook's.
12	Cheese and potato pasty, in the yard	3 c	Nobody in the inn is sitting down. Nobody will say why.
13	Salt-baked fish with the head on	1 L	The head faces west on every plate, though the cook turned it inland.
14	Mussels in cider, for the dry	5 c	The bailers at the bar are betting on which of the party orders them raw next week.
15	Undying cheese and black bread	4 c	The cheese is laid down in 412. It hums. A Kept guest asks for the rind.
16	Pantry-door pudding, out of season	3 c	It is not Tablenight. Somebody in the kitchen is practising.
17	Red-wine jelly with grapes, "from Sated"	2 L	One grape turns to follow the spoon. Taint 2 Hunger, 1 Dread, if it is real.
18	Grey ration-bread, cold, standing	1 c	An Unfed boy declines it three times on the party's behalf, and is offended when they eat it on the second.
19	A feast the party did not order, already on the table	free	The bill has been settled. The cloth is white. There is one more chair than the party. Count them.
20	Nothing. The kitchen is shut and the cook is gone	—	The fire is still warm. The table in the common room is laid. There is a card at each place.

RUNNING THE INN SUPPER

Use the table to make every stop on the road a scene. Most rolls are harmless and strange; the party should eat a dozen suppers on the Rim before one of them goes properly wrong, so that the 19 and the 20 land hard when they come. On a 19 or 20, every Unfed character makes an Invitation check (Hard 14, plus Pangs), and every other character makes a Dread 1 check on noticing the chairs. The Company's instruction is to burn the table and not read the card. Not all inn-keepers obey, and the party may not want to either.

▼TABLENIGHT AT YOUR TABLE



On that night, in every house, the table is laid.

— OF THE FAST, ON TABLENIGHT

Tablenight is the longest night of Lack, the anniversary of the Gorging. Sallowreach holds a banquet for its dead. The Fatlands fast and fail. Brinehollow leaves a bowl of seawater at the table's head and the west door unbarred. The Vigil puts out its lamps for one minute. Cradlewrack props every door open and lays the plate nearest it. Oathen says nothing for a day. The Fast stands outdoors with its back to every door while every table in the land is laid behind it.

This section is a menu and a running order for a **Tablenight game night**: a long session (or a one-shot) with real food, cooked from this chapter, served course by course in step with the game. It works for any adventure, and best for one set on or near Tablenight itself. It is planned for five players and a Carver. Halve or double as needed.

THE MENU

A bill of fare for Tablenight, to be chalked on a slate and propped by the door where the players come in.

AT THE DOOR — Cheese and chive scones, hot, wrapped in a cloth. The Stranger's Loaf. Come for a week. Everyone does.

TO BEGIN — The grace, in seven forms. Black rye bread, ash-crusted cheese, and Mother Gall's pickles, for the Kept Table.

FIRST REMOVE — Salt-baked fish, cracked at the table. Seaweed soda bread. A bowl of water at the head, for whoever might come home.

SECOND REMOVE — The Silent Supper: chickpeas and dates from one pot, with skillet flatbreads. Eaten in silence, for one course.

THE GREAT REMOVE — Lamb and mushroom pie with the closed eye, or beef and ale wake stew, with Pinchmarket

peppers to keep the table awake.

SWEETS — Red-wine jelly with grapes that watch. Burnt honey cakes. Knocker's thumbs on a plate by the door.

AT MIDNIGHT — Hot spiced punch. May we all finish.

AT THE END — Warm honey milk, the lamps turned down. Oatcakes for anyone who would rather not.

AT THE EMPTY CHAIR — One of everything. Nobody sits there. Nobody asks.

THE DAY BEFORE

- ◇ **Make the jelly** (it needs 6 hours to set) and the **pickles** (better after a day).
- ◇ **Strain the labneh** for the ash-crusted cheese (24 hours).
- ◇ **Make the wake stew** if serving it; stews are better the next day. Or make the **pie filling** and refrigerate it.
- ◇ **Bake the burnt honey cakes, the biscotti and the oatcakes.** All keep in tins.
- ◇ **Start the beetroot pot bread** if you are ambitious (it rises overnight).

THE MORNING

- ◇ **Bake the black rye bread** (it needs an afternoon to rise and an hour to cool).
- ◇ **Make the chickpea stew** (it reheats perfectly).
- ◇ **Roll the labneh** in its black seeds.
- ◇ **Make the jam thumbprints** with whoever is around to press a thumb.

THE RUNNING ORDER

TIME	AT THE TABLE	IN THE GAME	WHAT TO DO
Arrival	Hot scones at the door; the slate by the door	Character creation or recap	Hand every player a scone wrapped in a cloth. Say <i>Come for a week</i> . Take wagers on who leaves last.
First hour	The grace; rye, cheese, pickles	The opening scene	Have each player say the grace of their character's land. Set the empty chair now, with a plate.

TIME	AT THE TABLE	IN THE GAME	WHAT TO DO
Second hour	Salt-baked fish, cracked at the table; soda bread	The first trouble	Crack the crust as the first horror lands. Put a bowl of water at the head of the table.
The quiet course	Chickpea stew and flatbreads	A silent scene: a search, a vigil, a wait	For one course, nobody at the real table speaks: the scene is played in gestures, notes and dice. It is harder and better than it sounds.
The Great Remove	Pie or stew, and the peppers	The crisis	Pass the peppers whenever someone flags. Whoever gets the hot one gets a bonus die on their next roll.
Sweets	Jelly, honey cakes, thumbprints	The turn	Put the thumbprints on a plate by the door. If any are gone at the end, do not ask.
Midnight	Hot punch	The climax, or a cliffhanger	At midnight, stop the game. Turn off the lights for one minute, as the Vigil does. Everyone counts aloud, together, to sixty. Then <i>May we all finish</i> , and drink.
The end	Warm milk, lamps down; oatcakes	Epilogues	Each player says what their character ate on Tablenight, and what they did not eat, and why.

THE EMPTY CHAIR

Every Tablenight on the Table has an empty place in it: the chair at the end of the old northern tables that nobody may sit in; the bowl of seawater at Brinehollow's head; the plate nearest the door in the highlands; the table laid behind the backs of the Unfed. At your Tablenight, set one more chair than you need, with a plate, a glass, and a little of every course. Nobody sits there. Do not explain it. If a player asks who it is for, the Carver says, *it was always so*, and *it would be rude to sit there*, and changes the subject. At the end of the night, count the chairs. Then count them again.

KEEPING GAME NIGHT SAFE AND KIND

Ask about allergies and dietary needs when you invite people, and label the dishes that contain nuts, gluten, dairy, egg, fish or shellfish. Keep a non-alcoholic punch for everyone and let adults add their own. Have one thing on the table (the oatcakes, the scones, the soda bread) that almost everyone can eat. Agree before you start how dark the evening's fiction will go, and remember that the horror is in the book and the food is just food: a player who wants to skip the wake-bill and just eat the stew is doing Tablenight exactly right.

The last page of The Receipts of the Seven Tables and the Road Between, in Odo Pellance's hand, which is unsteady here, and written, the College's clerk notes, in a different ink from the rest, very fresh, though the book had been on the rag-stall for a season.

I have eaten everything in this book and I am still hungry. Everyone is. That is the one true receipt on the Table, and I

have saved it for the end.

Last night at Saltlick a man came in at the common-room door very late, very tall, stooping under the lintel, and stood a long time at the end of the long table with his hat in his hands, counting the chairs. He was polite. He was warm; you could feel it across the room, like a banked oven. He did not sit. When he had counted, he looked at me, and he looked so tired, and so kind, and so sorry, and he said that there would be one more for supper soon, and that he hoped I would not mind laying for them, since he could not, since it was not his place to; and he asked me, very courteously, whether I knew what they liked.

I said I did not know who he meant.

He said, no, and that was the trouble, nobody did, nobody had asked in such a long time.

Then he was gone and the chair at the end was pulled out, and it is still pulled out, and I have not pushed it in, and I have been sitting in the kitchen all night writing this by the banked fire with my back to the door, trying to think of a dish for someone whose name has been chiselled off every grace-stone on the Table, and every receipt I know is a receipt for a god we ate, and I cannot think of a single thing to serve that it has not already had.

Lack keep away. Lack keep away. Lack keep away.

It didn't.

CHAPTER 7

POCKET AND
SHELF

Trinkets of the Table

Show me what a man carries and I will tell you what he is afraid of. Show me what his widow kept and I will tell you whether she was right to be.

— NAN PICKERING, LIMB-BROKER, TO A BUYER AT GRISTMOOT

FROM THE DAY-BOOK OF THE LOST-PROPERTY CUPBOARD AT THE WEeping POST WAYSTATION, RIM ROAD COMPANY, KEPT BY UNDER-WARDEN IBBET LUSK. THE CUPBOARD IS A PRESS OF NINE SHELVES UNDER THE STAIR. BY COMPANY RULE, ANYTHING LEFT BEHIND IS KEPT A YEAR AND A DAY AND THEN SOLD, FOR THE POOR-BOX, AT THE CARVING FAIR.

Third of Grace. Found in the snug, under the settle: one glove, grey kid, Sallowreach make, sewn shut at the wrist with the hand still in it. The hand is not attached to anything. It is warm. Shelved, top, at the back, wrapped in a bar-towel. Note: it has moved to the front by evening. Moved it back.

Fifth of Grace. Left in Room Six by the Vigil gentleman who paid in tabs: a hatpin, very long, the head a little enamel eye, open. On the shaft, scratched with a needle, sixty-one small notches. The chambermaid says he sat up all night pricking his thumb with it and saying the numbers. Shelved, middle.

Ninth of Grace. In the yard, after the Fatlands drovers left: a child's milk tooth on a string. Not a child's. Too many roots. Shelved, middle, in a cup.

Tenth of Grace. A bail-bucket, small, tin, painted with two names and a heart, one name scratched out. Left on the mounting block by a Brinehollow woman going east. She did not forget it. I saw her put it down and look at it and walk away. Shelved, bottom.

Eleventh of Grace. A bit. Child's, leather, Oathen, very worn on the left side where it was chewed. Inside the strap, burnt with a hot nail: SHE SAID SHE WOULD. Shelved, middle.

Twelfth of Grace. A cord, three yards, dried, plaited back on itself like a rope. Found tied to the leg of the bed in Room Two. Tied very well. Could not be untied. Cut it. It bled a little, which I have not written down anywhere else. Shelved, bottom, in a basin.

Fourteenth of Grace. A place card, stiff, cream, gilt edge. Found on the common-room table at dawn, set square at the head, where nobody sits. No name on it. Only one mark, very old, that the Oathen notary who was staying would not look at twice. Shelved, top, face down. Gone by evening. Nobody has been under the stair.

(In a later hand, the Warden's:) Lusk, you are not to keep a day-book of this cupboard any longer. Sell the lot at the fair. Burn the card if it comes back. (Below that, Lusk again:) It came back. It is in the cupboard. I have shelved it, top, face down, and I have put a plate in front of it, because I did not know what else to do.

Everyone on the Table carries something they cannot explain to a stranger. The Lastgate porter has a black wax breath in his cheek, sucked smooth, a twelfth of a twelfth of a death he will never afford. The Netwatch hooker has a knotted cord around her wrist, one knot for every face she pulled out of the surf. The Unfed child has her one toy, a stone the size of an egg, which she is not allowed to pretend is food. These are **trinkets**: small things with no price worth haggling over and a story worth a night's drinking.

This chapter is a cupboard of them. It opens with a d100 table of trinkets from every land and the Rim, each a single line with a hint of the story behind it. It then gives eleven d20 tables for more particular searches: what the dead have in their pockets in each of the seven lands, what the bereaved keep, the charms people trust that do not work, the toys of children, and the things the cautious sew into their hems. It closes with twelve **Trinkets with a Story**, written up at length, with lore, rules and a hook, for the Carver who wants a small thing to open into a large one.



A trinket is a sentence with the rest of the page torn off.

CUTWRIGHT MARGINAL NOTE, ON THE EVIDENCE OF POCKETS

USING TRINKETS

At creation. Every Guest begins play with one trinket, rolled on the d100 table or chosen. The player and the Carver decide together where it came from, but the player should leave at least one question about it unanswered. The Carver will answer it later, and not always kindly. A Guest from one land may perfectly well carry a trinket from another: the Rim Road moves everything, and most trinkets are bought, found, stolen or inherited from someone who was not their maker.

In play. A trinket has no rules value unless the Carver gives it one. Most never need one. But once per story, when a trinket becomes important in a scene (it is recognized, it is the thing that proves who you are, it is the last thing you have to give), the player may **tell the trinket**: say, in a sentence or two, what it means. If the telling is good, the Guest gains +2 on one roll in that scene that the trinket could plausibly touch, or recovers 1 Fray. This is the same small mercy as the Strength of the Dead and, like it, it is meant to be earned with a story rather than spent like a coin.

As clues. The tables of pockets and hems are for the Carver above all. A corpse is a document. A dead woman's pockets in Lowmark tell you whether she was Called or pushed; a Kept man's

lining in Lastgate tells you who has been paying his Seamer. When the Guests search a body, a room or a bundle, roll on the matching table and let the result be true. Several results are written to open a scene by themselves.

Selling them. Trinkets are worth almost nothing, a crumb to a lack, unless they are something more. A Hard (14) Eye + Lore roll tells whether a trinket is godflesh (and so carries Taint, as given in the Rim Market chapter) or only ordinary sorrow. The ones that are godflesh are marked in the text; most are not. Most trinkets are only the things people keep because they cannot keep the people.

LAND TAGS

Each trinket on the d100 table carries a land tag: Sallowreach, the Fatlands, Brinehollow, the Vigil, Cradlewrack, Oathen, the Fast, or the Rim (the Road itself, its inns and its Company). The tag says where the thing was made or where its story belongs, not where it is found. When the Guests rummage in a place, the Carver may reroll results whose tag would make no sense there, or may keep them: a Vigil hatpin in a Fatlands wake-house is a better story than a Fatlands spoon.

▼ THE HUNDRED TRINKETS

Roll d100, or let the player read down the list until something catches.

D100	TRINKET	LAND
01	A black wax breath, a twelfth of a minute of Closing, sucked smooth and kept in the cheek; the owner's grandmother saved fifty-nine others and died, properly, in a Hush, for free.	Sallowreach
02	A tooth from the toothed wheat, drilled and strung on gut; it is a human molar, and it has a filling of Vigil silver.	Fatlands
03	A bail-bucket the size of a thimble, a lovers' token; the other name painted on it has been scraped off and painted back on, three times.	Brinehollow
04	A pin, very fine, its head a bead of blue glass, offered to a guest on arrival in a Height household and never given back.	Vigil
05	A brass door-latch with no door, the bolt shot; it is still locked, and nobody has found a way to unlock a latch that is attached to nothing.	Cradlewrack
06	A tally-stick from the Breakdowns, notched to record a debt of seven; someone has carved a mouth on it, sewn shut with wire.	Oathen
07	A ration chit of unbleached cloth, stamped with an empty bowl, never redeemed; the name on it was struck from the Pantry list the week it was issued.	Fast

D100	TRINKET	LAND
08	A wage-chit stamped with the wheel and the number of a waystation that the Company insists has never existed.	Rim
09	A lacquered glove-stretcher of coffin-wood, the kind Closers use, with nine notches carved on each finger.	Sallowreach
10	A wooden spoon, scorched, from a wake; the handle is carved with the name of the dead man and, below it, <i>he ate well</i> .	Fatlands
11	A length of anchor-rope, cut clean, with the knot still tied; it is the rope that held, the one night the knife came.	Brinehollow
12	A stub of a Lampwrights' Row candle that will not light, kept because it was burning in the window of the house where somebody's mother went down.	Vigil
13	A baby's first-year bracelet from the Tally-house, with no name on the tag, only a number and the word <i>returned</i> .	Cradlewrack
14	A small clay tablet of conditional phrases for travellers, "if able," "barring weather," worn smooth at the line that says "I will come back."	Oathen
15	A carved bone the size of a thumb, an Unfed child's one toy, chewed at one end by a child who was told it was not food.	Fast
16	A Rim Road Company menu from Thimble Cross, Tablenight 638, with nine courses listed and the ninth crossed out in a different ink.	Rim
17	A thimble of human fingerbone, polished, from a Seamer who kept her own finger for the purpose when it came loose.	Sallowreach
18	A pound of meat scrip, greased, from 600 A.G., when a pound was worth a lack; on the back, a list of eleven names in a child's hand, the last one underlined.	Fatlands
19	A shell, alive, of no known species, kept in a stoppered vial of brine; it was coughed up at a dawn bailing, and it has grown.	Brinehollow
20	A Watch-house rattle, one of the small kind given to children, with one of its peas replaced by a human tooth.	Vigil
21	A cord-knife, the Attendance's, tiny and very sharp, with a blood-groove; the handle is wrapped in a scrap of someone's caul.	Cradlewrack
22	A bit-buckle, gold, from a Sayer's muzzle, stolen or sold; the leather it held has been cut, not unbuckled.	Oathen
23	A Tablebreaker's axe-wedge, the iron block that holds the head on, stamped with a tally of four hundred small strokes.	Fast
24	A platter, a Company bone tablet worth twenty lacks, snapped across the seal; it was broken on purpose, by someone who wanted the debt it paid to be unpaid.	Rim
25	A Loft label, linen, inked with a name, a family and a date of Setting Aside, 297 A.G., cut from a shelf by someone who could not bear to read to her any more.	Sallowreach
26	A Weighing token, lead, stamped with a number of pounds that no living person could weigh.	Fatlands
27	A Netwatch tally, the lead token paid for a Called person dragged home alive, with <i>ALIVE</i> scratched on it, and then a question mark.	Brinehollow
28	A pair of spectacles with the lenses painted over in white lead and a tiny pinhole in each; a lidless noble's sleeping-mask, or something like one.	Vigil
29	A key, brass, warm, to a door the owner bricked up on the night of the Year of Doors and has never opened.	Cradlewrack
30	A page torn from a marriage vow, page thirty-one of forty, with one clause circled: <i>in the event that either party is no longer recognisably the party</i> .	Oathen
31	A place card, cream, gilt-edged, with the owner's name on it in a hand they have never been able to identify.	Fast
32	A pewter tankard from a Rim inn, with a dent the exact shape of a human eye socket.	Rim
33	A flask of cedar oil, the rich man's perfume, three drops left; carried by a porter who once, for an hour, was mistaken for a lord.	Sallowreach
34	A fruit-pit from the Bleeding Orchards, hard and pale, that is clearly a small bone; it has been rubbed for luck until it shines.	Fatlands
35	A pocket compass that points west, always, whatever is done to it; its needle is a sliver of something grey.	Brinehollow
36	A nudger's lead, a short leather cord with a loop at each end, one loop cut, the other still knotted around a dried, delicate wrist-bone.	Vigil
37	A wax seal from a naming-right, voided by the Attendance; the right was to name a twin that was not, in the end, a twin.	Cradlewrack
38	A small polished stone from Sworn Gorge, which, held to the ear, repeats one syllable over and over.	Oathen
39	A fork, silver, very old, bent double by hands that refused to use it; from the Empty Chair, or so the seller swore.	Fast
40	A Company bone-slate with a child's drawing on it: the Rim Road as a circle, and in the middle, a tall stick-figure laying a table.	Rim

D100	TRINKET	LAND
41	A mitten, lead-lined, child-sized, of the kind the Appetite-struck of the Hand-lines wear; inside, a child's drawing of an open door, scribbled out.	Sallowreach
42	A recipe card for wake-pie in a grandmother's hand, the ingredients written as names.	Fatlands
43	A bottle of Dry Jonah's tonic, emptied; the label promises <i>Sea Air for Inland Lungs</i> , and the bottle smells, very faintly, of somebody's breath.	Brinehollow
44	A rouse-tab from 600 A.G., stamped with a large, proud eye; it would hold an hour then and hold nothing now, and it is the last one an old man's wife ever took.	Vigil
45	A tiny knitted bonnet sized for something no bigger than a hen's egg, beautifully made, with a hole for one ear.	Cradlewrack
46	A handtalk primer, child's, with the sign for <i>promise</i> inked out on every page.	Oathen
47	A hearth-stone, a single brick from a fireplace that the owner's great-grandfather pulled out of his house with his bare hands.	Fast
48	A Reckoner's list, a strip of linen with seven family names, five crossed through; the two that remain are the owner's mother's and father's.	Fast
49	A hollow lack, a bone coin with a cavity drilled in it and a tiny folded paper inside reading <i>I am not dead, I am in Sated, do not come.</i>	Rim
50	A Sump bubble caught in glass: a little blown globe with a breath of fen air inside it, sealed by a glassblower who swore it was his drowned father's.	Sallowreach
51	A Cullmaster's dusk-list, a single page, folded small; one name on it has been cut out with a penknife and the hole is the shape of a person.	Fatlands
52	A wedding bucket's handle, the rest of the bucket lost; the bride was Called on her wedding night and walked west carrying it.	Brinehollow
53	A blink-murder confession, unsigned, in the owner's own handwriting, which they do not remember writing.	Vigil
54	A milk tooth, perfectly ordinary, in a box labelled <i>from the Part, age three.</i>	Cradlewrack
55	A Surety's flaying-proof: a square inch of tattooed skin, brown script, a stranger's bond, sold after her death to pay her own.	Oathen
56	A crust of bread, hard as stone, which the owner found on a windowsill one morning in place of the crust they had left; it has not gone mouldy in eleven years.	Fast
57	A waystation key-fob, wood, Room Nine, from an inn on the Rim that has only eight rooms.	Rim
58	A tallow candle, one of Wick Tallow's, never lit; the buyer could not, after he heard it hum.	Sallowreach
59	A Thin rebel's ash-spoon, very small, for eating ash, its bowl worn to a sliver.	Fatlands
60	A whistle carved from a gull bone that makes no sound in air and a terrible one under water.	Brinehollow
61	A brass bell from a Waking-house door, its clapper removed and kept separately, in a different pocket.	Vigil
62	A doorwright's sample hinge, one of Agnes Latch's, stamped <i>19 days.</i>	Cradlewrack
63	An oath written on a fig leaf, dried; it is held that writing does not bind, and the owner has carried it for nine years to be sure.	Oathen
64	A Hostwatch map, a scrap of hide with a dotted line of warm ground running from the Fast to the owner's home village.	Fast
65	A Company bond-tag, brass, with a number, the wheel, and <i>as long as the wheel turns</i> ; the bonded man it belonged to walked off the Road and broke at the knees.	Rim
66	A Seamer's needle of grey bone, not a fish-bone, curved, very strong; it was made from a Hand-line finger.	Sallowreach
67	A Board of Plenty fine-receipt for <i>leaving food upon the plate, one carrot, half</i> ; from a child of six.	Fatlands
68	A sounding-lead, the weight a ship drops to find the bottom, with a scrap of tallow in its hollow end that took a print of the sea floor; the print is a hand.	Brinehollow
69	A Dream-Diver's tether-ring, iron, marked with forty notches, worn on the inside where a rope wore it.	Vigil
70	A Foundling's identity-plate from a regiment of the born-grown, with a birth date four years ago and a rank of sergeant.	Cradlewrack
71	A coin of the Mute King, minted with his face and an open hand where his mouth should be.	Oathen
72	An Unfed mother's dusk bell, the small brass one rung at the door for a year for a Seated child, its year long over and its clapper wrapped in wool.	Fast

D100	TRINKET	LAND
73	A slice of hardtack from a Rim post-coach ration, stamped with the Company wheel and the date 412 A.G., that does not seem to have aged.	Rim
74	A small jar of Mother Gall's pickling brine, with a receipt for <i>one barrel, paid in full, to be opened 740 A.G.</i>	Sallowreach
75	A Second Helping communion wafer of rendered fat, embossed with the words <i>Eat and Be Eaten</i> , kept by someone who did not go back.	Fatlands
76	A Tenanted judge's discarded quill, still damp after forty years, that writes in two inks at once.	Brinehollow
77	A sheet of Seeming record, the official form for a hallucination seen by a whole street, filled in and stamped: <i>a woman with no face selling bread.</i>	Vigil
78	A finger-length of dried living cord, an Uncut's, given as a love-token; it still twitches toward its owner.	Cradlewrack
79	A Clausewright's seal-ring with an Exit engraved inside the band: <i>as I now intend.</i>	Oathen
80	A wooden plate, the only plate the owner has ever been given, from a Crumb-Runner who said it was not a gift and should not be thanked for.	Fast
81	A Purgation emetic in a paper twist, untouched, the owner's mother's, from the night she ate at a stranger's table and did not purge in time.	Rim
82	A death-license, forged, very good, for a person whose name has been left blank.	Sallowreach
83	A child's tooth-shaped whistle carved from toothed-wheat root, which, blown, makes the sound of a field at dusk.	Fatlands
84	A cork float from a Called man's net, with his name burnt in it; it washes up, wherever its owner goes, in the nearest basin.	Brinehollow
85	A pillowcase, linen, stolen from the Dormitory, that has never been slept on and still smells of sleep.	Vigil
86	A Tally-house birth extract listing a mother, a father, and, under <i>borne by</i> , a well.	Cradlewrack
87	A tongue-depressor of ivory from the Muzzling clinics, with a child's bite-marks deep in it.	Oathen
88	A Portion Stone chip, from the stones the first Unfed set out on the bare hill to count the dead of the Refusal.	Fast
89	A deck of Rim cards with the eights removed, all four, and each of the remaining cards marked in the corner with a tiny eighth chair.	Rim
90	A Loft-Warden's reading-ribbon, the kind used to mark a place in a book read aloud to the shelved; the book is lost, and the ribbon still whispers its page number.	Sallowreach
91	A pair of drover's boots, small, with the soles worn through on the toes; the herd they followed walked on two legs when nobody was watching.	Fatlands
92	A dried starfish with six arms, one of which is a human finger, very small.	Brinehollow
93	A brass hourglass from the Pendulum Hall that takes longer to run each time it is turned.	Vigil
94	A tiny bone door, carved, hinged, the size of a fingernail, that a child was born holding.	Cradlewrack
95	A muzzle of soft leather, child-sized, unworn, bought before a daughter's birth by a father who made it with love and never heard her voice.	Oathen
96	A pebble from Hallowboard, warm, from the eighth side of the stone table, which nobody else in the Fast will touch.	Fast
97	A Company inn-sign in miniature, a pewter brooch of a table with a knife and fork; the knife has been filed off.	Rim
98	A jaw-click dictionary, a little folding card of the clicks and their meanings used by interpreters for the Kept, with <i>I want to finish</i> underlined in red.	Sallowreach
99	A marbled stone from the first frost of a Carving, white veins in red, which grows slightly warmer when it is held near a field.	Fatlands
100	A tiny carved table with eight chairs, beautifully made, from a box of old salvage; seven chairs are glued in place, and one is missing, and the owner keeps finding it, and losing it again.	Rim

◇
*Eight shillings for the lot, sir, and the little table
thrown in. No, I don't know where the chair went. It
does that.*

A PEDLAR OF SALVAGE AT GRISTMOOT

▼WHAT'S IN A DEAD PERSON'S POCKETS

The dead are the most honest witnesses on the Table, except in Sallowreach, where they are also the most talkative. Each table below is for a body found in that land, or the body of someone

from that land found anywhere. Roll once for the main find; roll twice more and take the lesser results as small change, string and lint. Several results are the beginnings of scenes.



SALLOWREACH: THE POCKETS OF

THE KEPT

In Sallowreach a “dead person” may be lying there quite awake, watching you go through their coat. Ask first. It is the law, and it is good manners.

D20	IN THE POCKETS
1	A jar of breath-tokens with a slotted lid, three filled of sixty; the body has been saving for its own Closing for a century.
2	A Seamer's receipt for a new left foot, <i>not original, fitted 588</i> , and an older receipt for the same foot, <i>original, reattached 412</i> .
3	A sprig of rosemary, a twist of vinegar-rag and a scrap of cedar shaving; three classes of smell, one coat.
4	A finger, not the body's own, wrapped in a handkerchief; the body cannot explain it, and it does not match any Seamer's register.
5	A letter to a son, written in 431, re-dated in fresh ink every year since, never sent.
6	Lead mittens, folded, too small; a Hand-line child's, which the body was paid to dispose of and did not.
7	A page of a Loft-Warden's ledger of whispers: forty lines, all the same word, which has been scratched out so hard the paper is through.
8	A small dried flower from Dunmere Hush, perfect, which makes no sound when crushed; not the rustle a dried flower makes, nothing at all.
9	Teeth, loose, the body's own, in a twist of paper labelled <i>for the Seamer, Tuesday</i> .
10	A forged minute of Closing with the Regent's signature spelled wrong.
11	A pocket-book of jaw-clicks, the body's own private code, so it can still talk to its wife after her jaw went.
12	Maggots, in a tin, labelled <i>Justice Lathe's, borrowed</i> .
13	A ticket for the Finishing Post with a pilgrimage date six weeks from now.
14	A list of the forty-one petitions its widow has filed for its Closing, copied out neatly by the body itself.
15	A Tallow candle-stub and a receipt from Wick Tallow's shop: <i>rendering, one, unclaimed, your uncle</i> .
16	A key to a Loft shelf, numbered, and a note: <i>read to her, she likes the sea ones</i> .
17	A child's milk-tooth, a lock of hair and a seven-year-old's drawing, labelled <i>Nell</i> , from the undercity, with a price.
18	Earth from outside the border, kept in a twist of oilcloth: a pinch of the country it can never visit.

D20	IN THE POCKETS
19	Nothing at all; its pockets were cut out long ago, and its hands are not its own, and the hands remember picking pockets.
20	A Closer's glove, empty, which is warm, and which flexes its fingers once when it is touched.



THE FATLANDS: POCKETS OF THE

EATEN

There are no graves in the south. A body found with its pockets intact has not yet been to its wake, and someone is waiting for it, plate in hand.

D20	IN THE POCKETS
1	Food. Always food first: a cold chop, half a pie, a fistful of sweet toothed-wheat biscuits; the body died eating, and its jaw is still working.
2	A Board fine-book, every page stamped, for <i>insufficient appetite</i> , which in the Fatlands is suspicious.
3	A Reaping tally in the hand of Pell Hogget's copyists, with this year's number written in and a line drawn under it.
4	Lead shot, a great deal of it, sewn into the coat: a man who wanted to vote heavier at the Weighing.
5	A dusk-shift summons from the Cullmasters, for tonight.
6	Ash in a twist of paper and a tin cup of water: one of the Thin, who has starved down to the bone and died of it, or been caught.
7	A wake invitation for tomorrow noon. The name on it is the body's own.
8	A root, small, with a birthmark on it, wrapped in a wet cloth to keep it alive.
9	A Renderers' Union card, lapsed, and a barrel-mark written on the back with a notch beside it.
10	A spoon, tied to the wrist with a cord, because the owner could no longer remember to pick one up.
11	Seed, a handful, from a field the owner's grandmother became.
12	A letter home to the Fast from a pilgrim of Osanna Blythe's, saying <i>I am almost there, and I am so hungry, and it smells like bread</i> .
13	A thumb-length of Ummer's fat in waxed paper, white and sweet, Taint 1 Hunger; the body's last meal was going to be this.
14	A set of false teeth made of toothed-wheat teeth. Good ones; somebody's.
15	A funnel.
16	A meat scrip of the side denomination, a fortune, stained, with a hole in it the shape of a bite.
17	A Second Helping pledge-card, signed in blood, promising <i>one hand, the left, at the next feast</i> . The left hand is missing.
18	A notched barrel-stamp, Quartermaster Stockpot's mark, stolen or given.
19	A child's gleanings sack, empty, with a girl's name embroidered on it, and a smaller sack inside, with a smaller name.
20	Soil in every pocket, warm, moving a little, packed in so tightly that the seams have split; there are roots in the cloth.



BRINEHOLLOW: POCKETS OF THE

DROWNED AND THE DRY

Bodies are rare on the coast. The Called go west and do not leave much behind. When one is found on the Uncovered, Netwatch law says to turn out the pockets before anybody says the name aloud.

D20	IN THE POCKETS
1	Water. The pockets are full of it, and it is warm, and it is still coming.
2	A bail-bucket, small, with a hole punched in the bottom: a person who did not want to bail any more.
3	A length of anchor-rope, cut, and in the other pocket the knife that cut it, and the hand that held the knife is the body's own.
4	Shells, dozens, all the same species, none of them known, all of them alive and closing tight when touched.
5	A Netwatch tally, earned, and a scrap of paper on which the hooker wrote the name of the one they dragged home.
6	A pier-note for nine yards of the Mile not yet built.
7	A tide-table for the body's own lungs, written in a Wreckwife's careful hand.
8	The key to a cistern, and on the key-ring a little tin label: <i>bis dinner, six bells</i> .
9	Salt crystals the size of teeth, which turn out, under a lens, to be teeth.
10	A sketch of a stone table with eight chairs, on wet paper, with a heading: <i>Lobbett's Drop, bearing west by south, nineteen hours walking</i> .
11	A Deepening lantern, small, its wick drowned, and a hymn sheet.
12	A letter of complaint to the Salt Assay about <i>the numbers</i> , unsent.
13	A Tenanted judge's ruling on a land dispute, which the body won, and which says at the bottom, in the second ink, <i>you will not need it</i> .
14	Kelp from the cellar stairs, wrapped like a keepsake.
15	A pair of glass ear-stoppers for pressure days, one cracked, and blood in the cracked one.
16	A wedding ring, coughed up at the dawn bailing, still with a little shell growing on it.
17	A Netwatch hook-head, broken off its pole, with a scrap of oilskin still on the barb.
18	A hand-drawn map of the Hanging Abbey with one anchorite's chain marked in red, and a note: <i>he says he will open his lock for me</i> .
19	Nothing but a smooth grey stone, very heavy, the size of a fist, in every pocket; someone wanted this body to stay under.
20	A ticket for the <i>Follow</i> , Dagna Hull's iron vessel, berth 412 of 900, and a farewell letter that has not been written yet; only the date and <i>Dear</i> .



THE VIGIL: POCKETS OF THE

AWAKE

A dead Vigilant is almost always a dead Vigilant who could not stop; the heart goes, from rouse, at fifty, at forty, younger on the Slope. Their pockets are a record of the last hours of a long day.

D20	IN THE POCKETS
1	Rouse-tabs, many, loose, and the teeth that rouse took, kept together in the same pocket.
2	A pin-case with forty pins, each one bent from use, and a forty-first, straight, unused, saved.
3	A nudger's contract, three years left to run, for a child whose name is followed by <i>bell-hours owed: 1,140</i> .
4	A Seeming form, filled out but not filed, describing a figure laying a table in the street.
5	A Dormitory visitor's pass for Bed 40,112.
6	A note in their own hand: <i>if you are reading this I blinked; I did not mean it; tell Hale Grimmer it was the same way</i> .
7	A tiny bottle of Brinehollow brine, cheap rouse-cutting, and sand in the hems that smells of the sea.
8	A pillow-feather, one, hidden in a locket.
9	Eye-drops in a phial and a soft brush: a lidless servant, or a lidless lord in a servant's coat.

D20	IN THE POCKETS
10	A Tuckers' receipt, <i>one minute, guarded, returned</i> , and the guard's thumbprint in soot.
11	A mirror the size of a lack, for checking that one's eyes are still open.
12	Bells, little ones, sewn into the cuffs, so that nodding hands would ring.
13	A lullaby, written down, the words crossed out one by one as though someone was trying very hard to forget it.
14	A map of the long room in the dream, paced out, thirty paces from the eye, with a mark where a voice spoke.
15	A page from the Hourkeeper's pendulum log, stolen: <i>the hour of the third bell, Plenty 641, sixty-one minutes and nine seconds</i> .
16	A slapping-glove, the polite kind, kid leather, very worn on the palm.
17	A child's drawing of a bed, which is contraband.
18	Lamp-oil in a hip flask, for drinking, which is the last thing the Slope does when the rouse runs out.
19	A key to a room in the Glass House, the yawners' quarantine, and a mask with the mouth sewn shut.
20	Nothing at all; the body has been laid out in the street, on its back, eyes closed, hands folded, by someone who wanted to give it the one thing the city could not.



CRADLEWRACK: POCKETS OF THE

BORN

In the highlands, ask first whether the body is the body or only the part of it you can see; and check for cords.

D20	IN THE POCKETS
1	A neck-kit: needle, gut thread and a little mirror, for restitching wounds that open in the night.
2	A brick, and a trowel, and a pot of lime: someone who meant to brick themselves in tonight.
3	A naming-right certificate for a birth not due for three months, bought for two lacks.
4	A Tally extract with the body's own birth recorded twice, in two different years, to two different mothers.
5	A tiny hand, wrapped in swaddling, warm, holding the body's finger even now.
6	The pang-interval, chalked on a slate, and crossed out, and chalked again, smaller each time.
7	An Agnes Latch door-key and a promise in writing from the doorwright: <i>holds, or your money back</i> .
8	A hymn of the Barren Order, and a surgeon's bill for the cutting.
9	A cord-clamp of horn, still clamped on nothing.
10	A drawing of the Assemblers' figure, measured, with the left hand coloured in by someone hopeful.
11	A lock of white hair, and a note: <i>my son's, aged one</i> .
12	A Foundling Company pay-chit, and a list of <i>things children do</i> copied out to learn, with <i>play</i> underlined.
13	A knocker, small, unscrewed from a door, kept so that the door could never again be knocked on.
14	A wet-nurse's receipt from Dolour Pym for a month of feeding <i>the one with the voice</i> .
15	Clay from the rim of the Dilation, warm, with a faint, slow pulse in it.
16	A Second Opinion's warrant, blank, with the Attendance's seal. Someone stole this to fill in a name.
17	A half-sentence written on a scrap of paper, <i>and when the door is open</i> , and an offer of reward for whoever has the rest.
18	Swaddling bands, very long, for something very long.

D20	IN THE POCKETS
19	A midwife's tally-pin and a fetal skull the size of a walnut with too many sutures.
20	A door, folded somehow, a whole cupboard door, in a coat pocket that should not hold it; it is ajar.



OATHEN: POCKETS OF THE

SWORN

An Oathener's pockets are full of paper. Read it carefully. Any of it may still bind someone.

D20	IN THE POCKETS
1	A sworn note, unpaid, backed by the issuer's left eye.
2	A bit, iron, for an Appetite-struck relative, with the key on a separate string.
3	A slate and chalk for silent talk, the last words on it <i>if able</i> .
4	Tally-sticks from the Breakdowns, which are held not to bind, and which the body seems to have been chewing.
5	A list of every promise the body made in the last year, each with an Exit beside it, in their own careful hand; one has no Exit.
6	A Surety's fee-receipt for standing behind <i>one marriage, forty pages</i> .
7	A wax plug for each ear, used in echoing gorges.
8	A fragment of the Ledger, a flake of red stone with three carved words on it, chipped from the cliff by a tourist.
9	A finger, the body's own, lost to a broken promise, kept in a little velvet bag.
10	A copy of the Mute King's latest gesture, drawn in nine panels, with the Bench's forty-page reading folded inside.
11	A lie, written down, sealed in wax, never spoken: the body wanted to know what it would feel like to own one.
12	A rain-cup, empty, from the Kept Rain of this year, three days late.
13	Handtalk rings, the copper finger-bands that make signing clearer across a canyon, two of them snapped.
14	A marriage contract with one clause underlined: <i>the parties shall not speak of the well</i> .
15	A child's first sentence after the bit came off, on a card, framed in silver: <i>I will try</i> .
16	Teeth, loose, the price of a lie.
17	A note from Grandam Cess: <i>paid in full; the larger oath to be called in at my pleasure</i> .
18	A small gold coin with Tolm's ear on it, from before the Gorging.
19	A breaking-bill: a Clausewright's invoice for the drafting of a defence for the body's broken promise, which the god did not accept.
20	A card bearing two words, which the body was carrying from Sworn Gorge to the Bench; whoever reads them aloud is bound by an oath they do not know.



THE FAST: POCKETS OF THE

UNFED

Unfed pockets are lean. What is in them was carried, every crumb, and carried far.

D20	IN THE POCKETS
1	Half an oatcake, wrapped, untouched, saved for tomorrow, for three weeks of tomorrows.
2	A ration chit and a list of who else in the household was struck off.
3	A stone, egg-sized, smooth: a child's toy, carried by an adult.
4	A place card with the body's own name.
5	A Reckoner's tally of high-Cut bloodlines, with a smear of someone's blood on the last name.
6	A Crumb-Runner's grain-count in a tiny ledger, down to the bean, and a line at the bottom: <i>ate none</i> .
7	A little brass bell, a dusk-bell, and a name.
8	Honey cake, iced, perfect, warm. The body did not carry this.
9	A Hostwatch chalk-stick for marking warm ground, worn to a nub.
10	A silver fork, which the body refused to use, kept to prove it.
11	A splinter of an axed table, sharp, the wood still warm.
12	A letter from a Fatlands cousin begging the body to come south and eat.
13	The Five Rules, written on a strip of cloth, in a child's hand, for an adult who was forgetting them.
14	A seed. One. Green at the tip.
15	A poacher's price-slate with the body's own weight on it, in bone.
16	Crumbs on the lips, crumbs in every pocket, crumbs in the seams, and nothing in the stomach at all.
17	A copy of Meek Garrity's seating plan, in a hand that has copied it many times.
18	A Decline-cord: three knots, for <i>no, thank you</i> thrice, and a fourth knot, half-tied.
19	A napkin, linen, folded into a crown, from a table that was laid for them.
20	An invitation, engraved, to dinner, at a house that has stood empty for six hundred years, <i>eight o'clock, do not dress</i> .

▼ KEEPSAKES OF THE BEREAVED

Every land grieves in its own shape. What the mourners keep tells the Guests who was loved, how they were lost, and whether the

mourning has gone wrong. Use this table for a widow's drawer, a Wreckwife's shelf, a Loft-Warden's desk, or a parent's coat.

D20	KEEPSAKE	WHERE IT IS KEPT
1	A plait of hair cut from a Kept husband in the year he was still handsome, tied with the ribbon from his first restitching.	Sallowreach
2	The marrow-spoon from a wake, given to the most beloved; it was never washed.	Fatlands
3	The cut end of an anchor-rope, wrapped in a bride's veil.	Brinehollow
4	A bed number, painted on a slate, and a chair beside the Dormitory row, carried there daily for eleven years.	Vigil
5	The first-year bracelet of a child who was returned and did not come home, worn on the mother's ankle, under the stocking, where the Attendance will not look.	Cradlewrack
6	A widow's copy of a forty-page marriage vow, with the clause <i>until death</i> circled, and beside it, in her hand, <i>be kept it</i> .	Oathen
7	A crust left on a sill each night for a child who was Seated, replaced each morning with something better, which the mother cannot bring herself to eat or throw away.	Fast
8	A death-license, bought and paid for and never used, because when the Closer came, the widow found she could not let him do it.	Sallowreach
9	A jar of rendered fat, labelled with a name and a date, on the top shelf of the larder, <i>not for cooking</i> .	Fatlands
10	A pair of shoes, left at the high-water mark, filled with sand by the tide; the family will not empty them.	Brinehollow

D20	KEEPSAKE	WHERE IT IS KEPT
11	A nudger's pin, kept by the one who was nudged, from the night the nudger fell asleep first.	Vigil
12	The knocker from the door of the room where it happened; the door has been bricked over, but the knocker was saved, and is knocked on, softly, on the anniversary.	Cradlewrack
13	A bitten bit: the leather muzzle a child chewed through in her last illness, saying something that nobody will repeat.	Oathen
14	A tablebreaker's axe, cleaned and hung on the wall, and a place card tucked into the bindings with the dead man's name in his mother's handwriting.	Fast
15	Forty years of letters read aloud to someone on a Loft shelf, bound into a book, with the answers the shelf whispered written in the margins.	Sallowreach
16	A field. The whole field. The bereaved has stopped planting it and sits at its edge in the evenings, and it is warm.	Fatlands
17	A bowl of seawater at the head of the table, changed every day for nine years instead of once a year.	Brinehollow
18	The last words of a sleeper's mouth, written down by the Matron's clerk and sold to the family for a season's Bed-Due.	Vigil
19	A Part, in a jar, which the bereaved is quite sure is the dead person come back, and which grasps at the glass when they come home.	Cradlewrack
20	A promise, given by the dead and never kept, on a scrap of paper in a locket; the bereaved checks it every morning for blood.	Oathen

THEY SAY KEEP **NOTHING.** THEY SAY THE DEAD WANT TO BE LET
GO. **THOSE PEOPLE** HAVE **NEVER** BEEN TO
LASTGATE, WHERE THE DEAD ARE **STANDING** IN
THE HALL WITH **THEIR** HATS ON, **ASKING WHERE** YOU
PUT **THEIR THINGS.**

[HENNA FARROW, THE WIDOW UNMADE, TO A RIM ROAD MOURNER]

▼CHARMS AND WARDS (THAT DON'T WORK)

The trade in cures never ends, and below the trade in cures is the trade in charms, which is cheaper, and fails more pleasantly. Every land has its little protections. None of the ones on this table does what it says. A Hard (14) Eye + Lore roll knows that; a Guest who

carries one anyway may, at the Carver's option, take +1 on a Dread check while it is in hand, because believing in a thing is not nothing. On a Lack on that check the charm breaks, and with it something in the believer: gain 1 extra Fray.

D20	CHARM	WHAT IT IS MEANT TO DO
1	A grey glove-finger stuffed with salt and cedar.	Turn aside a Closer's touch. It has been tested. Ask the families of the testers.
2	A Thin rebel's knotted string, one knot per day of fasting, tied round the belly.	Shrink the hunger. It shrinks the belly, and the hunger stays the same size.
3	A west-facing door painted shut with tar and fish-blood.	Keep out the Calling. The Called go out of the windows, or the chimney, or through the wall of the cellar where the indoor tide comes in.
4	A rouse-tab worn under the tongue at all times, never swallowed.	Prevent the blink. It dissolves. It always dissolves.

D20	CHARM	WHAT IT IS MEANT TO DO
5	An open-weave basket hung over the cradle, so that whatever comes through the night-door will be caught in it.	Catch what comes. It has caught things. Nobody has opened it to see.
6	A word written on the inside of the wrist in ink and licked off before speaking.	Take back a careless promise. Tolm does not read wrists.
7	A stone placed in the mouth before entering any house, so that nothing can be offered and nothing accepted.	Turn the Host. The Host is patient. It waits for you to take the stone out to breathe.
8	A Hand-line lady's nail-paring, bought from her maid.	Grant an easy death. In the north, it grants nothing. Outside the north, it does not need to.
9	A sugar-mouse left in the far field at dusk.	Feed the Reaping instead of the family. The Reaping does not eat sugar.
10	Iron filings sewn into the sleeves to weigh down the arms.	Keep a sleeper from rising to walk west. It holds the arms. It does not hold the legs.
11	A Waker's needle-tip, blunted, hung at the throat.	Ward off sleep. People sleep in it. Whole streets of people went down in their needles.
12	A circle of red clay drawn on the belly of anyone who has had false labour.	Keep it false. The circle opens, a crack at a time, along with whatever is under it.
13	A handtalk sign, <i>no</i> , held with the left hand while speaking with the mouth.	Cancel the words. The hand is the next thing to break.
14	A crumb from an axed table, carried in the cheek.	Make you smell of refusal, so the Host passes you by. It makes you smell of crumbs.
15	A Rim Road waystation's grace, <i>Lack keep away</i> , painted round the rim of a bowl.	Make any meal safe. It is very well painted.
16	A small bag of Sump-mud, from the bottom of the fen.	Make the wearer unkillable outside Sallowreach. Sold on the Rim at a high price, to soldiers. The soldiers do not return to complain.
17	A drop of a Tenanted judge's sweat, in oil.	Make the wearer impossible to lie to. It makes them believe everyone is lying, which is a different thing, and quite as useful in Lowmark.
18	A cast of a newborn's first word, made in wax, of a child who said <i>not yet</i> .	Delay a birth until a midwife can come. Some births are delayed. They come all at once, later.
19	A lock of the Fasting Girl's hair, sold in every market on the Rim.	Kill the hunger, as hers was killed. There is not that much hair in the world. These are horse.
20	A little enamel table with eight chairs, all pushed in, worn on a chain.	Keep the eighth chair empty. Nobody quite says what this charm is for, only that it is very old, and that it is sold by people who will not take payment for it.



Of course it doesn't work, dear. Nothing works. That's why it's only two crumbs.

WIDOW PROSPER GAMMAGE, CURE-SELLER OF GRISTMOOT

▼ CHILDREN'S TOYS

The children of the Table play, everywhere, with whatever the god has left them. The toys on this table may be found in an abandoned nursery, in a pedlar's tray, in a dead child's grave-goods (where there

are graves), or in the fist of a child who should not have it. Treat with care; the Carver should imply rather than dwell.

D20	TOY	LAND
1	A rag doll with its mouth and eyes stitched shut, in the fashion of a well-kept grandmother, and a tiny Seamer's kit to restitch her.	Sallowreach
2	A clay pig, glazed red, with a slot in its back for meat scrip and a slot in its belly to take it out.	Fatlands

D20	TOY	LAND
3	A toy bail-bucket on a string, for practice coughing, with a tin fish painted at the bottom so the child knows when it is empty.	Brinehollow
4	A spinning top that never falls while it is watched and falls at once if every eye in the room closes.	Vigil
5	A rattle made from a door-hinge, so that babies learn the sound before they learn the danger.	Cradlewrack
6	A set of handtalk finger-puppets, each one wearing a tiny bit.	Oathen
7	A stone, egg-sized, smooth; the Unfed child's one toy, which she is not allowed to pretend is food, and which she sometimes holds against her cheek at night as though it were warm.	Fast
8	A Kept-doll: a jointed wooden figure with every joint wired, designed to fall apart and be put back together, and a lid-shaped box to keep the pieces in.	Sallowreach
9	A tiny scale and weights, for playing at the Weighing; the child's favourite doll always wins, because she is stuffed with lead.	Fatlands
10	A paper ship, folded from an Admiralty notice, set to sail in the cellar on the indoor tide.	Brinehollow
11	A cup-and-ball with a bell on the cup, so a child who nods loses the game loudly.	Vigil
12	A wooden baby in a wooden mother that opens, and inside the baby another, and inside that another, and the smallest is a hand.	Cradlewrack
13	A whistle that makes no sound, given to children so they have something to blow while they are learning not to talk.	Oathen
14	A kite of grey cloth, flown at dusk in the Fast on the day the warm front comes, so that children can see which way the god is walking.	Fast
15	A set of marbles made from Sump-glass, each with a bubble in it that, in the right light, looks like a face.	Sallowreach
16	A corn dolly with teeth in its ears.	Fatlands
17	A pair of tin stilts, for wading, painted with the high-water marks of a sea long gone.	Brinehollow
18	A pinwheel on a stick, carried by street-nudgers to keep their hands moving and their charge looking.	Vigil
19	A skipping rope of dried cord that, when nobody is holding the ends, slowly coils toward the nearest woman.	Cradlewrack
20	A tiny tea-set, a cup and a saucer and a little plate, forbidden in the Fast; this one was left on a doorstep there, beautifully wrapped, with a card.	Fast



*The little ones play at Weighing, and the littlest is
always the Chairman, and they push her about in a
barrow. It is the sweetest thing.*

A NURSEMAID OF SATED

▼ THINGS SEWN INTO HEMS

The cautious of the Table sew the things they must not lose, or must not be caught with, into the hems of coats, the waistbands of

skirts and the soles of boots. A Hard (14) Eye + Search finds a sewn hem. A Grace finds the second thing sewn in behind the first.

D20	SEWN IN	WHY
1	Three minutes of Closing, flat, in a shoulder-seam.	A whole family's savings, carried by the one member who can leave the country, to sell where it is worth less.
2	Lead weights, flattened, round the whole hem of a skirt.	To weigh more at the Weighing; or to sink; the coat does not say which.
3	A rope's end, knotted, and a note: <i>tie me if I stand</i> .	A Brinehollower travelling without family, asking strangers for help in the only way that does not need to be said aloud.
4	A row of pins, points outward, round the inside of a collar.	So that nodding forward hurts. Vigil travellers wear these on long Rim journeys.

D20	SEWN IN	WHY
5	A strip of caul, dried, folded like a bandage.	Taken from a noble's birth by a midwife who was told to burn it. It is worth more than the coat, and more than the woman wearing it.
6	A sworn note backed by the wearer's own hands.	So that if the wearer is robbed of it, the robber has nothing; and if the wearer breaks the promise in it, the hands go anyway.
7	Oatcake crumbs, a pinch, in every seam.	An Unfed habit: never be without food you carried yourself, however little.
8	A Company platter, sewn into the sole.	Twenty lacks, for a bribe at the border.
9	A forged College certificate of Cut, one lower than the truth.	To stay off the Reckoners' lists and away from the Second Table's.
10	A tooth, human, in a little pocket made for it.	A Farlands traveller's own milk tooth, sewn in by a mother, so that if the Reaping takes them on the road there will be something left to serve.
11	A letter to the Drowned Bench, explaining why the wearer is not Tenanted, <i>in case anyone asks</i> .	Because people do ask, and the Tenanted cannot lie, and the wearer can.
12	A list of every door the wearer has shut behind them in the last month.	A Cradlewrack precaution, to check against in the morning.
13	A tongue-shaped silver plate.	An Oathen trick: something to bite down on, so that the mouth stays shut when the Appetite rises.
14	A map of the warm ground between the wearer's village and the Rim, inked on silk.	A Hostwatch map, for running away by.
15	A small knife of grey bone with <i>the Sweet</i> scratched on the handle.	A Second Table Carver's mark, carried by someone who should not have it; possibly a thief, possibly a servant, possibly a Carver travelling quietly.
16	A pinch of Hush-dust in a fold of lead foil.	Death in a pinch, for the wearer, if the north will not let them finish any other way. The wearer is not in the north. They are going home.
17	A single eyelash, very long, in a paper envelope.	A lash from the eye of Iss, a relic, worth a fortune, carried by someone who has not slept in a week for fear of losing it.
18	Fifty lacks in bone, quilted flat into a child's coat, and the child's name sewn in red beneath.	The mother's whole fortune, sent with a child who was being sent somewhere safer. The coat is here. The child is not.
19	A rag with <i>come in</i> written on it in a careful, old-fashioned hand.	Nobody knows. It was not sewn there by the wearer. The stitches are very fine.
20	A place card, folded in four, bearing no name at all, only a single mark in the oldest Table-speech.	The wearer found it at their own table, one morning, and sewed it into their coat so that it would not be found at anyone else's. It is warm.

▼ TRINKETS WITH A STORY

The twelve trinkets below are written up at length. Each can be dropped into a Guest's pocket at creation, found on a body, sold across a stall at Gristmoot, or left in the lost-property cupboard of

the Weeping Post. Each has its lore, its rules (if it has any), and a hook for the Carver who wants it to open up.



THE FIFTY-NINTH CROCK

A stoneware crock, brown-glazed, the size of a man's head, with a lid of grey slate cut with sixty narrow slots. Fifty-nine slots hold a lacquered minute of Closing, each one a sliver of coffin-wood with

Regent Grue's signature and a license number. The sixtieth slot is empty and has been empty, the family says, since 509 A.G.

The crock belonged to the Doweys of Lower Pilings, porters for eleven generations, who saved toward the Closing of their founder, Aunt Merriel Dowe, who was Kept in the Glad Century and had been coming apart since before the War of the Heirs. Every Dowe

child was told that when the crock was full, Aunt Merriel would be allowed. Every slot filled was a supper. In 509 the fifty-ninth went in, and the family carried the crock to the Hall of Closings to ask, humbly, if the Court would accept fifty-nine and a promise. The Court counted the minutes, slowly, checked every number against the register, found the thirty-first forged, removed it, and sent the crock home with fifty-eight. The family saved for another eighty years and replaced it. By then the fifty-fourth had been found forged as well. This has happened, the Doweys say, four times. The Court is never wrong about forgeries. The Court also prints the minutes.

Aunt Merriel is still in the house, on a chair by the hearth, mostly wire. When a slot is filled she claps, which sounds like sticks. The last Doweys sold the crock to pay her own Seamer's bill and walked into the Finishing Post with the Finishers in the spring of 640.



BRAWNLEY'S SHOE

A child's shoe of good red leather, the sole hardly worn, a little silver buckle in the shape of a wheat-ear. It is the right shoe. It is always cold, even in the Belch, and it smells of the far field at dusk: turned earth, warm fat, and something sweet underneath.

In Carving of 618 the village of Brawnley in Low Tilth, frightened by its own count, gave a child to the field. Nobody would call it that. The Cullmaster for the district, a man named Harl Peasgood, preached at the meeting-house that the Reaping was hunger and that hunger could be satisfied, and that if the village chose one, freely, and sent her out at dusk dressed for a wake, the field would be full and would take nobody else that season. They chose by lot, as such things are chosen. The lot fell on a miller's daughter named Pippa Ash, eight years old. Her mother dressed her in her best, with new red shoes, and walked her to the far furrow herself, and Pippa stood there, as she had been told, facing the Scarecrow, until the others had counted a hundred, and then the field was empty, and one shoe was standing upright in the furrow.

The Reaping took twelve from Brawnley that Carving. Its usual number was nine. Harl Peasgood was one of them. The shoe was given back to the mother, who kept it in the oven, where it is warm,

RULES: The fifty-nine minutes are worth about 3,800 lacks at the Court's rate, and they are all genuine; a Grim (18) Eye + Reckoning roll against the Court's register proves it. Whoever brings the crock to the Hall of Closings with one more minute will find, on a Hard (14) Tongue + Clause roll, that the Court cannot refuse it, because a crock has never before been returned with every number checked in advance. On a failure, a clerk discovers one forged, whatever the truth.

HOOK: Aunt Merriel has asked, through an interpreter of jaw-clicks, for the crock back. She does not want to be Closed. She wants to know which of her great-grandchildren forged the minutes that were taken out, because the Court gave each one back to her, privately, every time, with the name of the forger on the reverse. She has four. All four names are of children who are still alive, and one of them now sits on the Mortuary Court.

for twenty years, and then walked out to the same furrow herself, in the left shoe.

RULES: The shoe carries Taint 1 Dread (a cold thing that smells of the field). Anyone who holds it at dusk in the Fatlands knows, without a roll, the direction of the nearest Reaping that night. It is the only known instrument that can tell, and the Cullmasters would pay 300 lacks for it, or have it taken.

HOOK: Pell Hogget's tally shows that Brawnley has lost exactly twelve every Carving since 618. Not nine, not ten. Twelve. Somebody in the village has been choosing by lot every year since, quietly, to keep the number from rising; the lot has fallen, every year, on a family that has not been told it was drawn. The Guests are in Brawnley in the week of the drawing, and somebody has just bought them a drink.



*We gave her up so the rest would be spared, and we
were not spared, and she was not spared, and we have
gone on doing it since, because what else would it have
been for?*

BRAWNLEY MEETING-HOUSE, OVERHEARD



THE UNWASHED MARROW-SPOON

A long, narrow spoon of horn, the kind used at a Fatlands wake to scoop the marrow from the long bones and feed it to the most beloved of the dead. The bowl is stained dark gold and has never been washed. Wake custom says the marrow-spoon is given to its eater to keep, and is washed only when that person is themselves served, so that the last mouthful they ate is the last mouthful the spoon ever held.

This one was given to a boy of fourteen at his father's wake in Sated in 590, and the boy, who is now an old man and a Bonded Hand of the Rim Road Company, has never been served, because he left the Fatlands to escape being served, and there is no wake on the Rim. The spoon still tastes of his father. Not of marrow: of his father, of the specific man, the pipe-smoke and the bad tooth and

the rum, so that the old man can lick it and be, for a moment, sitting on his father's knee.

He has let other people lick it. Some of them have wept. One of them, a Second Helping celebrant, offered him two hundred lacks for it.

RULES: Taint 1 Hunger. Licking the spoon gives the taste of the last person served with it, so precisely that a Hard (14) Eye + Feast roll can name a stranger's age, trade, health and last meal from it. Used on a different dead person's marrow, it changes allegiance at once, and the old flavour is gone for ever.

HOOK: The old man is dying, on the Rim, outside the Fatlands, where no one will serve him. He wants the Guests to carry him home to Sated alive, so that his own children can do it properly, with the spoon. His children have been told he died thirty years ago, and they have already held his wake, with somebody else.



WESTWARD

A brass pocket compass in a case of sharkskin, the lid engraved with a Brinehollow ship under full sail and the motto *Home Is Down*. The needle points west. It does not point to the west of the compass; it points to the west, wherever that is, however the case is turned, even indoors, even underground, even on the Rim Road on the far side of the Fast, where west is through the middle of the world. Under a lens the needle is a sliver of grey bone, faintly ridged, with a pore at one end.

It belonged to a Netwatch officer called Hollis Teague, a hooker with nineteen years on the Raw Mile and a reputation for always knowing where the Called would walk in. He used the compass for it. On calling nights he would stand on the pier with the lid open,

watching the needle, and when it trembled, he knew the Called were moving and which way. He pulled two hundred and seven people off the shore. In the winter of 633, his wife was Called. He had the compass open in his hand. It was pointing at her. He followed it out across the Uncovered for nine miles before the Netwatch caught up with him and roped him, and he spent the next eight years in the cistern of his own house, Tenanted, writing letters to the Admiralty in two inks about the error of their charts.

RULES: The compass carries Taint 2 Regrowth (Dromm, foreign to all but Brinehollowers). Holding it open gives +2 to any roll to track the Called, find water, or navigate the Uncovered. Each night it is kept within reach, a Brinehollower who carries it must resist The West at +2 Difficulty.

HOOK: The needle has started, in the last month, to point slightly downward.



THE SIXTY-FIRST NOTCH

A hatpin, eleven inches long, the shaft of good steel, the head a bead of enamel painted as a small open eye. Along the shaft, scratched with a needle, are sixty-one tiny notches. It was left in Room Six of the Weeping Post by a Vigil gentleman who paid in tabs, and it is the work of one of the Hourkeeper's under-clerks, Absalom Ferrule, who carried the pendulum count from the Pendulum Hall to the Watch of Watches every bell for nine years.

Each notch is a minute. Ferrule began by marking the hour as sixty notches, as an hour should be. In 637 he added the sixty-first, a very small one, because the pendulums said so. He was told to remove it. He did not. In 640 he came down to the Rim with leave to visit a sister in Brinehollow and a pin in his hat, and sat up at the Weeping Post through the night, pricking his thumb at the sixty-first notch, saying the numbers aloud, until the chambermaid fetched the warden. He left before dawn without the pin. He never reached his sister. He was found two days later at the Netwatch line on the Raw Mile, standing on the last pier with his eyes open and

his face toward the Trench, perfectly awake, and he said he was waiting for the hour to end.

RULES: Pricking the thumb with the sixty-first notch removes 2 Weariness and adds 1 Fray, because for one second the pricker feels how long the hour actually is. Anyone who uses it more than once in a day begins to count the minutes of every hour aloud.



THE PILLOWCASE

A pillowcase of fine grey linen, darned at one corner, with a laundry-mark in red thread: *D. 40,112*. It is a Dormitory pillowcase, and it has been on the head of a sleeper. Nobody in the Vigil may legally own one. It has never been washed, and it smells of sleep: warm hair, warm skin, the indefinable, heavy, clean smell of a room where someone has been unconscious for a long time. People who have never slept, and there are many in the Vigil, have wept at the smell and not known why.

It was taken from Bed 40,112 by the sleeper's mother, Odile Farthing, in 637, when the boy in it had grown too large for it, and the Dormitory changed his linen to the larger size. She asked for the old case and was refused. She took it anyway, under her skirt, and carried it home, and for four years has pressed her face into it each

HOOK: Maud Sexton, the Hourkeeper, wants the pin back; it is the only record of the stretching that was made outside her office and cannot be suppressed. The Watch of Watches wants it destroyed. Ferrule's sister in Brinehollow wants to know why her brother walked west, when the god of the west is not his god.

evening for exactly as long as she can stand. Then she sold it, to a Tucker on the Slope, for enough rouse to stay awake for her son's birthday. The Tucker sold it on. It has passed through nine hands since and is now on the Rim, in a box of salvage, being sold as *a curiosity of the Vigil*.

RULES: Taint 1 Regrowth (Iss). Anyone who presses their face to it gains 2 Weariness and makes a blink check at Hard (14). A blink with the case pressed to the face goes, unmistakably, to the long room, and for that second the blinker is lying in Bed 40,112, and somebody very large is lying beside them, smiling.

HOOK: Odile has asked the Guests to find it and bring it back. She does not want to smell it. She wants to put it back on his pillow, because last week the Matron's clerk told her that the boy has begun, in his sleep, to turn his head from side to side as if he were looking for something.



THE LITTLE BONE DOOR

A door the size of a thumbnail, carved from a single piece of bone, with a frame, a lintel, two hinges no thicker than a hair, and a latch. Its maker is unknown; it was born. A baby in Rudge, a girl, came into the world on the third night of a pang in 619 holding it in her fist, so tightly that the midwife had to open the fingers one at a time. The Attendance asked the Two Questions of the child and permitted her, and asked them of the door and were unsure, and permitted it, provisionally. It was entered in the Tally as a birth: *a door, bone, twin to the above*.

The door was shut when it was born. It has been opening. A Rudge clay-digger with a lens measured the gap each year, and then each season, and now each pang, and it widens a hair's breadth every pang, which is to say every nine days. Through the gap there is

nothing visible but dark, and a draught, warm and faintly salt, like the air that comes off the Dilation. The girl, now twenty-two, says that when the door is fully open she will be able to go home. She does not say where home is. She has carried the door in her mouth for safety since she was a child and has worn a groove in her back teeth with it.

RULES: Taint 2 Regrowth (Vey). Anyone who looks through the gap for more than a moment must make a Dread 2 check, because they see an eye on the other side, looking back, and the eye is their own. Anyone in Cradlewrack carrying the door finds every door they pass ajar.

HOOK: The girl has been murdered, and the door is missing. The Attendance wants it found before the next pang. The Assemblers want it for the figure, which lacks a voice and a left hand, and which, they say, also lacks a way out.



A LIE IN WAX

A ball of red sealing wax the size of a walnut, with a strip of paper rolled inside it; the seal on the outside is the mark of the Murmuring House, where the Bench of Clauses keeps its witnessed silences. It is a lie. A single sentence, untrue, written down by a Tongue-line cadet of the House of Esk in 588, who wanted to know, before he died, what it would be to own a falsehood. He wrote it, sealed it without reading it back, and gave it to the Murmuring House to keep, and the House, which had never been asked to keep a lie before, kept it, because no law said it could not.

In Oathen, writing has been held not to bind. It is now binding a little, at half Weight, as everyone knows. The lie in the wax has been gaining weight as the widening goes on. The Clausewrights who examined it in 640 report that the wax is warm, that the paper inside can be heard rustling, and that the cadet, now an old man of the

Breakdowns, has begun to lose his teeth, one a year, without any promise to account for it.

Nobody knows what the lie says. The cadet does not remember. If it is unsealed and read aloud in Oathen, it becomes a spoken lie, and someone will break: the reader, or the writer, or the god, who has never before been asked to listen to a falsehood it was holding in its hand.

RULES: Unread, it carries Taint 1 Dread. Read aloud in Oathen, it is a lie of Weight 3; the reader breaks at the mouth, and the writer breaks again. Read aloud outside Oathen, it is only words. A Sayer could make it true.

HOOK: The Bench wants it destroyed, which is a decision that would itself need to be sworn. Tavish Crook, called Loophole, wants to buy it, and has asked, in questions, whether the Guests would like to be rich. And the cadet has sent word that he remembers, now, what he wrote; it was a sentence about the rain.



THE BETTER CRUST

A crust of bread, the heel of a dark loaf, hard as fired clay, wrapped in a square of clean white napkin. It is perfect: no mould, no staleness beyond hardness, and when broken (it has been broken, once, and the halves fit), the crumb inside is soft and warm and smells of a kitchen on a winter morning. It has been eleven years since it was baked.

It came from Wanting, from the window of a widow named Lessen Hode who, the winter after her daughter was Seated, broke the rule and left a crust on her sill. She did it for the reason everyone does: so that if the child was hungry, there would be something there. In the morning it had been taken, and in its place was this, wrapped in this napkin, still warm. She did not eat it. She did not throw it away. She did not leave anything on the sill again. She kept it under her pillow for eleven years and every morning, before the

Decline, she held it to her face and smelled the kitchen her daughter is sitting in.

Abstain Rooke, called Abby, has been leaving crusts on her own sill for a month and has been getting back better things. When she heard about the widow's crust she went to see it, and the widow, who is dying, gave it to her.

RULES: The Better Crust is an offer, and the Unfed treat it as one. Any Unfed who holds it must make an Invitation check at Routine 10 each night it is in their keeping; any who eats it is Seated, wherever they are, at a table that appears around them. Godeaters who eat it are fed, perfectly, completely, for the first time in their lives, and lose all Hunger, and from then on find all other food tasteless.

HOOK: Lessen Hode has died. Abby has the crust. Tonight there is a table in the street outside Abby's house, laid for two, with two cards; one says *Abstain*, and the other says the name of the widow's daughter.



THE ROOM NINE KEY

A key-fob of polished elm, carved in the Company style with the wheel on one side and, on the other, a number: 9. The key on its ring is iron, old, heavy, good for a mortice lock. It was found by a Bonded Hand on the floor of the stable at the Hollow Halt, a

waystation of the eastern Rim that has eight guest-rooms and has never had nine.

The Hollow Halt's ledgers go back to 402. The Company's builder's plans show an inn of eight rooms, on two floors, four and four. There is, however, a ninth door. It is in the upper corridor, at the end, where the corridor should end in a window. It is painted

the same as the others. It has no number on it. It has a lock. The key fits it.

Nobody has opened it. The warden of the Hollow Halt, a careful Oathener named Tamsin Orle, swore when she took the post that she would keep the house in good order and turn no paying guest away; she has decided, on reflection, that an unnumbered door is not a room, and has had it painted over, twice, and both times found it clean in the morning. On busy nights, when all eight rooms are let and travellers are sleeping in the common room, guests have

been heard to say that they saw a light under the ninth door, and smelled supper, and heard a chair being drawn back from a table.

RULES: None, until it is used. When the key is turned, the Carver should run the room as an Orrum table laid for one more than the party, with the Invitation checks of the Fast chapter, Dread 3 to stand in the doorway.

HOOK: The Bonded Hand who found the key sold it to a Guest for three lacks. Next morning the Company issued a notice offering three hundred for its return, no questions asked, and Jessamy Quill's seal was on the notice.



THE MISSING CHAIR

A carving of a round table, dark wood, polished by long handling, about the width of a palm, with eight little chairs around it, each no bigger than a fingertip, each perfectly made, down to the turned legs and the carved slats of the backs. Seven chairs are glued firmly in place, pushed in. The eighth socket is empty. The owner, whoever the owner currently is, keeps finding the eighth chair: in a coat pocket, in a boot, on a windowsill, under the pillow, on the plate at breakfast. It is always pulled out, facing the table. And whenever the owner puts it in its socket and turns away, it is gone again.

Salvagers say it came up out of the Uncovered in Cray Lobbett's net, years before he found the table at the place that now bears his name. Collectors on the Rim say it is Fast-work, from a temple of Orrum, before the Gorging. A Cutwright in Quire who examined it says only that the wood is no wood she knows, that there are tool-marks on the table's eighth side where a figure carved in relief has been chiselled away, and that the chiselling is newer than the table by a great deal and older than the College by more.

RULES: Owning it costs nothing. Losing it is impossible; it returns. Each time the eighth chair is found, the owner makes a Dread 1 check. On a Lack, the owner finds the chair at a real table, a full-sized one, pulled out, with nobody in it, and the people at that table do not see it at all.

HOOK: Do not explain it. Let the chair keep turning up. Let it turn up at Thimble Cross, at the Long Table, at a Second Table dinner beside the empty chair of the Head. Let somebody at last glue it into place, and in the morning let all eight chairs be gone, and the table bare, and a smell of cold in the room like a door opened onto winter.



There is no eighth chair. Put it back.

NOTE PINNED TO A CURIOSITY IN A GRISTMOOT
SALVAGE STALL, IN THE STALLHOLDER'S HAND, AND
UNDER IT, IN ANOTHER: IT WAS NEVER THERE TO
PUT BACK



MARROW JACK'S GLOVE

A man's glove of black kid, Lastgate make, very good, lined in grey silk, with the right hand still inside it. The hand is Kept: cold, grey at the nails, slightly soft at the knuckles, entirely alive. It grips. It is the right hand of a Lastgate notary, a Kept man named Absolon Wray, which was taken from him on a Loft shelf in 629, while he lay Set Aside and dreaming, by the part-thief called Marrow Jack, and sold to a back-alley Seamer, and from the Seamer to a glover who thought it would make a fine curiosity.

The hand still writes. Give it a pen and it writes notarial hands, Lastgate formulae, sworn copies of documents the notary witnessed in the three hundred years before his shelving. And Absolon Wray, on his shelf, can feel everything it does. The Loft-Wardens have written down what he whispers, these twelve years: the names of everyone who has held his hand, and what they had it write.

RULES: Taint 2 Dread (it is a living hand in a glove). Anyone who gives the hand a pen may make a Hard (14) Eye + Clause roll to have it reproduce any Lastgate document Wray witnessed before 597; the copy is in his hand and passes as genuine. Each use, Wray feels it; each use, a Loft-Warden writes the user's name down.

HOOK: Wray witnessed the Licensing of 301, the first written record of the Hand-lines' bargain with the Court, of which the original was lost. Jory Welt of the Heirs would give anything for a

copy. So would the Regent, to burn it. And Wray, on his shelf, has begun to whisper that he wants his hand back, and that he knows the name of the person who is holding it right now.



CHAPTER 8

GAMES OF THE TABLE

The house fed me once. It was good. I lost the rest of my life here anyway, but it was very good soup.

— SCRATCHED BENEATH THE GRACE-AND-LACK HOUSE RULES, TAPROOM OF THIMBLE CROSS

DEPOSITION OF JOSSE HAVERICK, WARDEN OF THIMBLE CROSS, TO A COMPANY INQUIRY AT SALTBRIDGE, 640 A.G., CONCERNING A GAME OF CHANCE PLAYED ON COMPANY PREMISES AGAINST COMPANY RULE. SWORN, WITH EXITS.

I state, if able, that the game in question was played in the taproom between the second and fifth bells of the night of the twelfth of Carving. I state that I did not stop it, as I now intend to explain. The players were five. Two drovers of the Fatlands, a Brinehollow woman with a rope at her wrist, an old Kept man of Sallowreach travelling under licence to his border and no further, and a gentleman of the Vigil who did not give his name and did not blink. The game was Grace-and-Lack. It is always Grace-and-Lack.

The stakes, as I understood them at the first bell, were coin. At the second bell they were coin and a bail-bucket. At the third, the drovers had staked their dusk shifts, which is to say their places on a Cullmaster's list, which is a thing that can be traded in the south, and the Brinehollow woman had staked her rope. At the fourth bell the old Kept man staked his own Closing: a license, paid for, in his coat, for which his family had saved two hundred years. He lost it to the Vigil gentleman on a pair of fours. I state that I have never seen a man so happy to lose. He said, through his interpreter, that he had been afraid to use it.

At the fifth bell the Vigil gentleman, who now held a Closing he could not use, a rope he did not need, two places in a field at dusk, and a Kept man's two hundred years, staked all of it on one throw against the Brinehollow woman's oath on her drowned husband. She threw two tens. I did not stop it. I state that nobody could have.

She tore up the license. She gave the drovers back their dusk shifts, which they did not want. She kept the rope. She would not say what the oath had been. The Vigil gentleman went up to his room, and in the morning he was asleep in his chair, and he did not wake, and the chambermaid says that he was smiling.

The people of the Table play. They play in the Loft-galleries of Lastgate with cards that have been in the same game for a hundred years; on the props of the Dry Fleet with knucklebones that are not all sheep's; in the Pinchmarket with a deck that keeps them awake; in the silent galleries of Tacit with dominoes that make no sound on felt. They play for coin, and then for what they have instead of coin, and on the Table what people have instead of coin is very strange.

This chapter gives eleven games of the Table with **full rules that can be played at the real table**, using ordinary dice, a standard deck of cards, dominoes, coins or pebbles. Each game comes with its history, who plays it and where, how it is cheated, what is staked on it, and the horror that has grown up around it. It opens with rules for **gambling in play**: how to resolve a game quickly with the Grace Roll when you would rather not play it out, what can be staked, how cheats are caught, how debts are collected in each land, and what happens when someone stakes an oath on the dead.



Every game on the Table is the same game. Somebody puts something on the board that they cannot afford to lose, and somebody else wants it. The dice only decide the order.

HONOR PYLE, SURETY-BROKER OF MUMCHANCE

▼ GAMBLING IN PLAY

PLAYING IT OUT OR ROLLING IT

A game in the fiction can be handled in three ways, and the Carver should choose by how much the game matters.

◇ **Play it for real.** Get out the dice, the cards or the pebbles and play the game in this chapter, the Carver taking the parts of the other players at the board. This is the best choice for a game that

is a scene in itself: a wager with the Second Table, a hand of Who Finishes against the Regent's clerk, Grace-and-Lack for a Kept man's license. A short game played for real takes ten minutes and is remembered for years. Players may still roll to cheat, to read a tell, or to Partake (see below).

◇ **Roll it.** Each player rolls the pair given for that game (*Quick roll* in each game's entry) as an opposed roll; the highest total wins.

Pure games of chance are rolled on 2d10 alone, with no Attribute or Skill: the Table’s dice are honest even if its people are not. Helpings in the opposed roll mean the winner took more than the stake from the losers, or won it with style, or noticed something about them while they lost.

- ◇ **Let it run.** A night of gambling in the background is a single roll: **Tongue + Haggle** or **Eye + Reckoning** (the player’s choice), Hard (14). Success: break even, or win a little (a lack per Helping). Failure: lose a day’s cost of living. Lack: lose much more, and be offered credit. Grace: win, and be noticed by someone who matters.

RUNG	STAKE	EXAMPLES	COST OF LOSING
1	Coin	lacks, crumbs, platters, regional money	money
2	Goods	a weapon, a bail-bucket, a crock of minutes, rouse	kit, and the regional money it stood for
3	Service	a day’s labour, a shift on watch, a dusk shift, a nudging	time, and sometimes your life
4	Body	a sworn note backed by a hand; a Surety’s fee; a Kept limb	Flesh; a permanent mark
5	Kin	a naming-right, a bed in the Dormitory, a share in a wake, a Kept relative	a Dread check; the family’s opinion
6	The Dead	an oath on the dead, the remains of the dead, the dead themselves	see below

Every land has rules against the lower rungs, and every land breaks them. The Thimble Cross chalkboard forbids rungs 4 to 6 by name, which tells you how often they are played.

CHEATING

Every game in this chapter lists the common cheats. To cheat, roll **Hand + Filch** (for marked cards, loaded dice, palmed pebbles) or **Tongue + Deceive** (for false counts, false promises, signals to a partner) against the most watchful opponent’s **Eye + Search** (or **Eye + Instinct**, for a lie). If the game is being played for real, a successful cheat lets the player do one thing the rules forbid: look at a card, set a die to a chosen face, move a pebble. If the game is rolled, a successful cheat adds +4 to the cheat’s game roll.

A failed cheat is not always noticed. The opponent who beats the cheat’s roll *knows*, and may say so or hold the knowledge for later. A **Lack** on a cheat is caught in public, and the consequences are those of the land, as in the table below. A **Grace** on a cheat goes so well that the cheat is believed to be lucky, and the next game in that house will be harder to win honestly, because everyone is now watching the lucky one.

LAND	HOW IT IS COLLECTED	WHEN IT GOES BAD
Sallowreach	The debt never dies, because nobody does; it passes to the debtor’s Kept self and is collected in parts.	A Kept creditor sells the debt by the limb at auction.
Fatlands	The debtor is read onto a Cullmaster’s list and walks the far field at dusk.	The debt is struck off in full. The debtor is not.
Brinehollow	Impressment into the Dry Fleet, a year for every hundred lacks.	The debt is sold to the Raw Mile, where pier-haulers die.
Vigil	Paid in waking hours: the debtor or their child nudges for the creditor, by the bell.	A nudger who sleeps is delivered to the Dormitory, and the family billed a new Bed-Due.

WHAT CAN BE STAKED

The Table gambles in layers. A game begins with coin and, if nobody leaves, works its way down through the ladder. The Carver may use this to pace a gambling scene: each hour of play, the stakes go one rung lower.

PARTAKING AT THE BOARD

The god in the blood wants to win as much as its host does, and Partaking is the oldest cheat on the Table. A Guest who Partakes during a game adds the Tooth as normal to a game roll, or, in a game played for real, may reroll any one die of their own, or look at one hidden card or one closed hand. Every house has a rule against it, and every house can tell: each land’s Tooth has its tell, as the Lands chapters describe (cold fingers, a growling belly, a yawn through the room, a drip of salt at the nose, a door swinging open, a half-second echo, a smell of bread). Anyone at the board may roll **Eye + Instinct**, Hard (14), to see it. An Unfed Guest’s **Gnaw** (the Empty Tooth) has no tell at all, which is why the Unfed are not welcome at the dicing-boards of the Rim, and why they are rarely asked twice.

DEBTS

A gambling debt is a debt like any other on the Table, and each land collects it in its own way. When a Guest owes and cannot pay, roll on, or read, the land’s row.

LAND	HOW IT IS COLLECTED	WHEN IT GOES BAD
Cradlewrack	Paid in naming-rights: the creditor names the debtor's next birth, of any kind.	The debtor bears it.
Oathen	Every wager in Oathen is a promise. Default is a Breaking at the wager's Weight.	The Surety who stood for it breaks too, and comes to visit.
Fast	No coin; debts are in chits, and a defaulter's name is quietly left off the next list.	Murder by omission. Nobody's hands are dirty.
Rim	The Company buys the debt and ships the debtor as cargo, on a sworn manifest.	Nobody knows who buys. The manifests are sworn.

OATHS ON THE DEAD AS STAKES

The deepest stake on the Table is a dead person. It can be laid down in three ways.

- ◇ **Staking the oath.** A Guest who has sworn an oath on the dead may stake the oath itself: if they lose, they must release the winner's choice of their own sworn purpose and swear a new oath on the same dead, drafted by the winner. Releasing an oath this way is not a deliberate breach, because the dead were wagered and lost, but the dead do not like it: gain 2 Fray, and the next Visitation the Carver rolls for that dead person comes without the courtesy of a broken oath to explain it. The new oath grants the Strength of the Dead as normal. It is, however, the winner's oath, and the winner wrote it.
- ◇ **Swearing as the stake.** The loser swears, at the board, an oath on their own dead, drafted by the winner, at once. This is an ordinary Oath on the Dead in every respect, Strength and Breaking and Visitation, except that it was sworn under duress, and the dead know it: the Strength is +1, not +2. Oatheners will not play for this stake. Sureties will not stand for it. Everybody else does it constantly.
- ◇ **Staking the dead themselves.** A Kept grandmother, a Loft shelf, a share in a wake, a sleeper's bed and the Bed-Due with it, a Seated relative's place at the Long Table, the location of a body. The winner gets what the dead are worth in the land where they lie, which may be a great deal. The loser makes a Dread 3 check at the moment of losing, and a Guest who has staked their own

dead gains the Fray even on a success: a minimum of 1, as always, and the knowledge that they did it.

An oath sworn at a board over a desecrated corpse (a Kept man's severed hand, the plate at a wake, a body pulled from the surf and robbed) binds twice as hard, as the Oaths on the Dead rules say. The Rim Road's worst houses keep a corpse in the cellar for this purpose. The Thimble Cross chalkboard forbids it, which, again, tells you something.

CHASING

A Guest who has lost more than a week's cost of living in a single sitting must roll **Caul + Resolve**, Routine (10), to get up from the board. On a failure they stay for one more round, one rung lower on the ladder of stakes. On a Lack, the god in their blood has noticed the game, and the next roll is made with a Tooth whether they wished to Partake or not. A Guest who reaches rung 6 in a single sitting, and loses, gains a Derangement of the player's choice from the Common Madnesses if they Break within the week; it will be about luck.



It is not the losing. It is the next throw. There is always a next throw, and in that throw, I win back everything, including Mam.

A FATLANDS DROVER, AT THE WEEPING POST,
BEFORE HIS DUSK SHIFT

▼ GRACE - AND - LACK



The great dice game of the Rim Road, played in every taproom from Thimble Cross to the Weeping Post, on Company premises, against Company rule. It is older than the Company. Every Cutwright on the Table insists that it is older than the Gorging, because the dice used are the Table's own: two ten-sided bones, cut

from the knuckles of oxen, numbered one to ten with drilled pips, and thrown together from a leather cup. The doubles are named for the meal. A pair on a winning throw is a **Grace**; a pair on a losing throw, a **Lack**. Two ones is **Licked Clean**, two tens a **Second Helping**. Scholars argue whether the game borrowed its words from

the Table's oldest grace or the grace from the game. The Purgation preaches that the game is a blasphemy, a mockery of the meal. The Purgation's preachers are among the best players on the road.

Who and where. Everyone. Drovers, Bonded Hands, couriers, pilgrims, Netwatch on leave, Kept men at their border with an interpreter, Cutwrights on circuit. The inns of the Rim keep a dicing-board in the taproom: a shallow tray of oak lined with green felt and edged with a lip so the bones cannot escape, and a house cup that may not be refused.

What you need. Two ten-sided dice (numbered 1 to 10; on a die numbered 0 to 9, the 0 counts as 10) and a cup. Coins, pebbles or counters for stakes. Three to eight players.

THE RULES

- ◇ **The House.** One player is the House, who banks the game. The first House is whoever holds the cup; thereafter, see step 6.
- ◇ **The stake.** Every other player, a punter, puts a stake in front of them. Rim houses set a minimum (a crumb) and a maximum (whatever the House can cover).
- ◇ **The House throws.** The House throws both dice from the cup, once. The total is the **House's mark**. If the House throws **Licked Clean** (two ones), the House pays every punter even money at once and the round is over. If the House throws a **Second Helping** (two tens), every punter loses their stake at once, unless a punter chooses to throw anyway and also throws two tens (see below).
- ◇ **The punters throw.** Each punter in turn, going left, throws both dice from the cup, once. Compare their total to the House's mark.
- ◇ **Higher than the mark:** the punter wins; the House pays even money (stake for stake).
- ◇ **Equal to or lower than the mark:** the punter loses the stake to the House. (A tie goes to the House: whoever is keeping things as they are wins.)
- ◇ **A pair on a winning throw (a Grace):** the House pays double, and stands the punter a drink.
- ◇ **A pair on a losing throw (a Lack):** the punter pays double, and stands the House a drink, *and drinks it in front of everybody*, which is to say, the punter must buy the House's drink and the House may make them watch it drunk.
- ◇ **Licked Clean (two ones):** the punter loses double, whatever the House threw.
- ◇ **Second Helping (two tens):** the punter wins double, whatever the House threw, *even if the House threw two tens*.
- ◇ **Settling.** Stakes are paid or taken as each punter throws.
- ◇ **Passing the cup.** The House keeps the bank until it has been **cleared** (every punter beat it in a single round) or has banked five

rounds, whichever comes first. Then the cup passes to the left, and the new House banks.

Grace-and-Lack favours the House by a little: about one throw in fifteen, House and punter tie, and the tie goes to the House. That is why the House rotates. It is also why Rim inns like to bank the game themselves, and why the Thimble Cross chalkboard says *even if Jem is throwing*.

The Biting Game. In rougher houses, a punter may **Partake** before throwing: they double their stake and add one six-sided die, the Tooth, to their total. If the Tooth shows a 1, the god bit back: the punter loses the doubled stake whatever they threw, and the House takes a drink at the punter's expense. The Tooth never counts toward a pair. This is the version played at the Weeping Post on Tablenight and nowhere respectable. It is the version Guests will want to play.

Quick roll. Pure chance: 2d10 against the House's 2d10, ties to the House.

Cheating. Loaded bones, weighted toward the tens with a bead of lead under the one face, are called *fat dice* on the Rim and are sold at Gristmoot for two lacks a pair. They are detected by dropping them in a glass of water, which every honest house keeps on the counter for the purpose. A cup with a false bottom, a *tureen*, lets the thrower set the bones rather than throw them. The commonest cheat is the House's own: a House that throws its mark with a bad cup can always see its own dice first. That is why the cup is the house cup and may not be refused.

Stakes. Coin, everywhere. On the Rim, below coin, every rung of the ladder. The Thimble Cross board forbids wagering kin, the Kept, licenses, places in Mother Gall's queue and dusk shifts, which are the five things most commonly wagered at Thimble Cross.

The horror around it. On Tablenight at the Weeping Post, the house leaves an empty place at the dicing-board, with a stake in front of it: one lack, very old, worn smooth on one face. The House throws for it as for any punter, from the cup, and the warden's boy throws the empty place's dice. Nobody remembers why. Nobody will stop. In 638 the empty place threw two tens, a Second Helping, and the warden paid out double, two lacks, onto the felt in front of the empty chair. In the morning the coins were gone, and the chair had been pulled out, and the warden would not let anyone push it back in for a year.



Throw from the cup, not the hand. The hand remembers what it wants.

RIM SAYING

▼ THE LAST PLATE



The Fatlands eating contest is not a game of who can eat the most. Everyone in the south can eat without end; the hunger does not care for the stomach. It is a game of who can eat the most *before the Split*: before the belly, which in a Fatlander is a bag the god has stretched for six centuries, finally gives at a seam. The Board of Plenty calls the contest a civic festivity and licenses it at every Weighing fair. The Renderers' Union sponsors the plates. The Second Helping sends its celebrants to sing at the table's foot. And the crowd bets, heavily, on who will push back the plate and who will Split, because in the Fatlands both are worth watching.

The contest proper uses real food and real bellies, and is no business of anybody at a real table. What is played at a real table is the **wager** on it, which the drovers of Gristmoot play with dice in the long evenings on the road, when there is no contest to bet on, because the betting is the part they love.

Who and where. Drovers, renderers, Board clerks, Weighing-fair crowds; in Sated, on the long benches of the Gravy Steps, every night of Plenty. Gut-line nobles sponsor eaters as other lands' lords sponsor fighters, and keep stables of them.

What you need. Six-sided dice: three per eater, plus one more. A cup or a hand to hide dice under. Coins or pebbles. Two to six players; each player is an **eater**. Others may join as **bettors** only.

THE RULES

- ◇ **The Seam.** Each eater rolls 3d6 in secret, under a cup or a hand, looks at the total, and keeps it hidden. Add 15. This is their **Seam**: the point past which their belly will split. (Seams run from 18 to 33.) Nobody else may know it.
- ◇ **The book.** Before the first course, every player and bettor may stake on any eater to win. Eaters may stake on themselves. All stakes go into one pot.
- ◇ **The courses.** In each course, the server (any player; it does not matter who) calls *Plate!* Every eater still at the table either **eats** or **pushes back**. All decide at once: each eater holds a die in a closed fist, and on the call opens it; a die in the hand means *eat*, an empty hand means *push back*.
- ◇ **Eating.** Each eater who eats rolls one d6, openly, and adds it to their running **Plates** total, which everyone can see. A **6 is the Second Plate**: the eater must roll again and add that too, and keep going on further 6s. Nobody in the Fatlands has ever stopped at one plate.
- ◇ **The Split.** If an eater's Plates total ever goes **above** their Seam, they reveal their Seam and are **Split**: they are out of the contest

and have lost. (In the Fatlands, it is announced as *he ate well*.)

- ◇ **Pushing back.** An eater who pushes back is out of the eating, keeps their Plates total, and may not return. But leaving food on the plate is a fine in the south: each course that passes while any other eater is still eating, a pushed-back eater pays one coin into the pot.
- ◇ **The end.** When every eater has pushed back or Split, the eater with the highest Plates total who did not Split wins. Ties are settled by a last plate each, rolled together, highest wins, Second Plates counting. If every eater Split, the pot goes to the server, as is the Board's right.
- ◇ **Paying out.** The pot is divided among those who staked on the winner, in proportion to their stakes. If nobody staked on the winner, the winner takes it all.
- ◇ **The side bet.** At any time, a bettor may stake on a named eater to *Split*. If that eater Splits, the side bet pays two to one from the pot; if not, the stake goes into the pot.

Quick roll. Each eater rolls Gut + Feast, opposed; the highest wins, and the lowest Splits on a Lack. Bettors roll Eye + Instinct, Hard (14), to back the right eater.

Cheating. At a real contest: emetics in the sleeve (a Purgation emetic taken between courses lets an eater go on long after their Seam; it is treason in the south, under the Feasting Laws, to purge), lead in the belly-band to look heavier and frighten the book, or a cook bribed to serve one eater the lean cuts. At the dice game: peeking at another eater's Seam, or a fat die for the Plates, which is suicide at the Second Plate rule and therefore loaded the other way, toward the ones. Experienced drovers say the best cheat is to watch the eater's face when the 6 comes up; nobody can hide what they feel about a Second Plate.

Stakes. Meat scrip, by the pound and the side. Below scrip, dusk shifts, which trade on the benches of the Gravy Steps for a hundred lacks a head in Carving. A sponsored eater who wins brings their Gut-line patron a stone of weight at the next Weighing, because winners are fed by the crowd for a week afterward, and the patron owns the eater's weight.

The horror around it. The Split is not a figure of speech. A Fatlander's stomach, after six hundred years of the god, does not burst like a man's; it opens, along a seam that runs from the breastbone to the navel, softly, the way a ripe fig opens, and what is inside is not only food. Dr. Emmerich Paunch has attended forty Splits and published nothing, because what he found in the forty

bellies matches the plumb line he once lowered into a Gut-line stomach: the bottom is never reached. Split eaters seldom die at once. They are carried off the table still eating, and served at their own wake the next day, which the Board licenses as a single event to save on the paperwork. The Second Helping holds that the Split is the holiest death in the world, and Brother Glut has volunteered for the Weighing contest of 641, and has a large following of bettors, and has told them, beaming, that he will push back for no one.

▼ HOOK AND HAUL



The Netwatch play knucklebones on the pier between hauls. They play it on the night watch, sitting on the boards in oilskins with their hooks laid by and the lanterns turned low so as not to dazzle themselves for the shore, and they play it fast, because at any moment the bell can go, and the Called will be walking. It is a game of hands, and the Netwatch say it keeps the hands quick for the rope. There are two games: **Haul**, the old skill game with five bones, and **Tally**, a throwing game with four, for stakes. Both use the knucklebones of sheep, and every Netwatch hooker carries a bag of five.

A Netwatch bag of five is often, in fact, a bag of six. The sixth bone is smaller, and is kept separate, in its own twist of oilcloth, and is not a sheep's.

Who and where. The Netwatch, on the Raw Mile and the Middle Mile and every pier of the coast; the children of the Mile, who learn Haul before they learn their letters; the impressed men of the Dry Fleet, who play Tally on the decks of ships that will never sail, for their rations.

What you need. For Haul: five small stones, knucklebones, jacks or dice, and a flat surface. For Tally: four six-sided dice and a cup. Two or more players.

HAUL: THE RULES

- ◇ **The throw.** The player scatters all five bones on the boards with one hand. They then pick up any one bone: this is the **float**.
- ◇ **Ones (the Single Haul).** The player tosses the float straight up, picks up *one* bone from the boards with the same hand, and catches the float before it lands, all with one hand. The picked-up bone is set aside. Repeat until all four are hauled.
- ◇ **Twos (Man and Wife).** Scatter the four again. Toss the float; pick up two at once; catch. Twice.
- ◇ **Threes (the Family and the Lodger).** Toss; pick up three; catch. Toss; pick up the last one; catch. (The player may do the one first and the three second.)

◇
Weighing fair, Sated. Eater Number Four: Dorry Plumb, Gut-line patron the House of Brawn, eleven plates last year and still here. Book: four to one. Split: evens.

CHALKBOARD, THE GRAVY STEPS

- ◇ **Fours (the Whole House).** Toss; sweep up all four at once; catch.
- ◇ **The Rope.** Scatter four. Toss the float, slap the boards once with the flat of the hand, then pick up one bone, and catch. Repeat for all four. The slap is the bell.
- ◇ **The Count.** Hold all five in the palm. Toss them all up, turn the hand over, and catch as many as possible on the back of the hand. Toss those up from the back and catch them in the palm. The number caught is the player's **count**, scored at the end.
- ◇ **Missing.** A player who drops the float, touches a bone they are not picking up, or fails to pick up the right number, has **let go**: their turn ends, and on their next turn they begin again at the stage they let go in.
- ◇ **Winning.** The first player to finish the Count wins. If two finish in the same round of turns, the higher count wins. Children of the Mile play that the loser must stand at the end of the pier facing east, not west, until the next game is over.

TALLY: THE RULES

- ◇ **Stakes.** Every player puts one stake in the pot each round.
- ◇ **The throw.** In turn, each player throws four six-sided dice from the cup.
- ◇ **Reading the throw.**
- ◇ **The Hook:** a 1, a 3, a 4 and a 6, in any order. The thrower takes the whole pot at once, and the round ends.
- ◇ **The Drowned:** all four dice the same. The thrower pays one more stake into the pot and is out of the round.
- ◇ **Anything else:** score the total of the four dice.
- ◇ **The end of the round.** If nobody threw the Hook, the highest total takes the pot. Players who tie for highest throw again, between themselves only.

The Hook comes up about one throw in fifty-four; the Drowned about one in two hundred and sixteen. The Netwatch say that both

are luckier than the job.

Quick roll. Haul: Hand + Filch, opposed. Tally: pure chance, 2d10.

Cheating. At Haul, a player may hide a sixth bone in the palm and drop it, or palm one of the four so that the Whole House is only three. The old hookers watch hands, and catch it on Eye + Search. At Tally, the bones are not dice, and any Netwatch officer can file a bone flat on one face in an hour on the pier. Filed bones are called *anchored*, and an anchored bag is thrown in the sea, which is miles away, so in practice it is thrown off the end of the pier onto the Uncovered, where it lies.

Stakes. Netwatch tallies (the lead tokens paid for a Called person dragged home alive), bail-tokens, a cup of sweet water, and, above all, **the first hook**: the loser of the night's last game goes first into the surf with the rope on the next calling, which is where hookers

die. The first hook is the only stake the Netwatch will not trade for coin, and it is staked every night.

The horror around it. The sixth bone. Everyone in the Netwatch has one, and nobody will say whose, and it is never played; it lies in its oilcloth while the five are thrown. In the years of the Hook-Brides, and before, when the coast drew lots for those it would give to the sea, it drew them with knucklebones, because every house had a set and because a knucklebone does not lie. The bone that came up was kept. It went to the family, who kept it, and passed it down. The Netwatch carry the sixth bones of every family on the coast who drew in those years, and they say, if pressed, that it is so that someone remembers. Lieutenant Sable Reef's sixth bone has started, this year, to be found in the bag with the other five, in the morning, though she wrapped it separately. When she plays with it in the bag, she always throws the Hook.

▼ N O D



The great card game of the Vigil is a game of staying awake, played by people who have stayed awake for their whole lives, against a deck that is trying to make them sleep. It is played in every waking-house on the Slope and every salon on the Height, at the Pinchmarket stalls between customers, in the Watch of Watches between debates; the Warden-Prime is said to play it with her attendants, holding her cards at arm's length so that they do not blur. It is taught to children as a lesson. It is played by adults as a kind of prayer. The last player awake wins everyone else's rouse.

Who and where. Everyone in the Vigil, and Vigil travellers on the Rim, who carry a pack of Nod cards in the same pocket as their pins. The Wakers play it in the Rattlehouse on shift, and a Waker who loses is needled by the winner, which is held to be a kindness.

What you need. A standard deck of fifty-two cards, shuffled. Counters for **tabs** (rouse-tabs; coins or pebbles will do): five per player. Pencil and paper, or a die, to track Weariness. Two to six players.

THE RULES

- ◆ **Setting up.** Each player begins with five tabs and a Weariness of 0. The deck is placed face-down in the middle. A space beside it is the **pot**.
- ◆ **The watch.** On your turn, you must turn over the top card of the deck and lay it face-up in front of you, in your **row**. Your **Weariness** is the total of the cards in your row: number cards count their number (2 to 10); face cards and aces count as below. Time passes; nobody may refuse a card.

- ◆ **Jack: the Yawn.** It counts 0 for you. Every *other* player must immediately turn over a card from the deck and add it to their own row, as though it were their turn. (Their new cards' effects happen too, except that a Yawn caught from a Yawn spreads no further.)
- ◆ **Queen: the Lullaby.** It counts 0 for you. Choose another player: they must turn over two cards at their next turn instead of one.
- ◆ **King: the Waker.** It counts 0 for you. You may take the highest card from any player's row and add it to your own, or discard it from the game. (A good Waker hurts you for your own good, or hurts someone else for theirs.)
- ◆ **Ace: Rouse in the Street.** It counts 1. Take one tab from the pot, if there are any there.
- ◆ **Taking rouse.** Once on each of your turns, after you have turned your card, you may take rouse: pay tabs into the pot, then discard the highest card in your row from the game. The **first** time you take rouse in a game, it costs 1 tab. The second time, 2. The third time, 3. And so on. Rouse fails, and the dose goes up. Keep a tally.
- ◆ **Blinking.** If the card you turn is of the same rank as a number card already in your row, you **blink**: you may not take rouse this turn, and you must close your eyes until your next turn begins. While your eyes are shut, any one other player may move one card from your row to theirs or theirs to yours (the player to your left has the first right to do so). Players with their eyes open may not tell you what happened. Open your eyes at your next turn and see.

- ◇ **Going down.** If your Weariness reaches **21 or more** at the end of your turn (after any rouse), you are **asleep**. Lay your cards face-down, put all your remaining tabs in the pot, and leave the game. You go to the room. Say nothing more for the rest of the game.
- ◇ **Winning.** The last player awake takes the pot. If the deck runs out, everyone still awake turns over their row and the lowest Weariness takes the pot; ties split it.

Quick roll. Caul + Resolve, opposed; ties to whoever has taken fewer tabs of real rouse today. A Vigilant player with Weariness 5 or more takes -2.

Cheating. A marked King (a *friend*) is the commonest cheat. A **real blink** is the second: Nod players are notorious for passing cards while somebody's eyes are shut, and the Pinchmarket version allows it, while the Height version forbids it and forbids it in vain. Some players deliberately stay at a high Weariness so as to invite Lullabies, and keep a stack of Aces up their sleeve.

Stakes. Rouse-tabs, always, which is to say waking hours. The losers' tabs go to the winner. On the Slope, where a family's rouse for the week is in one tin, a father who plays Nod after his shift and loses has lost his children's wakefulness, and they will go down on their feet at the hiring-board, and the Wakers will bring them home or not.

The horror around it. It is held in the Vigil that the dream does not happen in the game, that a player who is asleep in Nod is only out, only resting, and that the closing of the eyes in a blink is safe because it is a game. This belief is necessary, because Nod is played everywhere, at every hour, by people who are always one bad afternoon from a real blink, and the game asks them to close their

eyes for whole turns at a time. Inspector Hale Grimmer has noted that seven of his forty-one blink-murders were committed during games of Nod, by players who had been asked to close their eyes and had done so, and had come back with a card in their hand that had not been there before, and a dead person across the table. In each case the card was a Queen.



Don't be shy, love. Close them. It's only the game.

PINCHMARKET CARD-SHARP, TO A RIM TRAVELLER

▼ KNOCK AND OPEN, AND NINE DAYS



The children of Kest have two great games, played in every lane and courtyard of the round red city: a **clapping game** for two, *Knock and Open*, and a **skipping game** for a crowd, *Nine Days*. Both are about the same thing. Both are forbidden by the Attendance in the week of a pang, and both are played most in that week, because the children of Kest, like all children, know very well what the adults are afraid of, and practise it.

Who and where. Children of every station, in every highland town; the Foundling Companies, who were never children and learn the games as part of their training in *things children do*; Ambrose, the Eldest Infant, who claims to remember the games being invented and says the words were different then.

What you need. For Knock and Open, two players and their hands. For Nine Days, a long rope (twelve feet or more), two turners and as many jumpers as like.

KNOCK AND OPEN: THE RULES

Two players face each other and keep a steady rhythm through the rhyme. Each beat is one move, in this order, repeating:

- ◇ Clap your own hands together.
- ◇ Clap right hands with your partner.
- ◇ Clap your own hands together.
- ◇ Clap left hands with your partner.
- ◇ Clap your own hands together.

- ◇ Both hands with your partner.
- ◇ **Knock:** make a loose fist and knock knuckles to your partner's knuckles, both hands, twice (one beat).
- ◇ Pause one beat, hands held open, palms facing each other, a finger's breadth apart.

The partners chant the rhyme, one line to each full round of eight beats:

*Knock on the door, and who is there?
A little one with no hair.
Knock on the door, and what's its name?
Not for a year, and not the same.
Knock on the door, and is it shut?
Bricked and mortared, all but the cut.
Knock on the door, and what comes through?
OPEN!*

On **OPEN!** both players stop in the pause position, palms a finger's breadth apart, and hold perfectly still. The first to move, flinch, laugh or let their palms touch has been **born**, and loses the round. If neither moves for a slow count of nine (the watchers count), both are **kept**, and the game begins again, faster. Each new round is faster than the last; the children call it *the interval closing*. A player born three times is out, and the winner plays the next challenger.

NINE DAYS: THE RULES

Two turners turn the long rope in a steady arc. Jumpers run in one at a time and skip. The whole crowd chants, and the count goes down:

*Thirty days and the hill is warm,
twenty days and the clay is torn,
fifteen days and the waters run,
ten days, nine days, here it comes,
nine, eight, seven, six, five, four,
three, two, one, and OPEN THE DOOR!*

- ◇ **Running in.** The first jumper runs in on *thirty*; each other jumper must run in on one of the following counted words (*twenty, fifteen, ten, nine*), one per word.

- ◇ **The pang.** On every number from *nine* to *one*, the turners turn faster.
- ◇ **Crowning.** On **OPEN THE DOOR**, every jumper must run out of the rope on the side facing the turner on the left (the *mother's side*). Any jumper who is caught by the rope, trips, or runs out on the wrong side is **kept in**: they become a turner for the next game, and the turner they replace becomes a jumper.
- ◇ **Scoring.** Jumpers keep a count of games they come out clean. A player who comes out clean nine games running is **born whole** and may choose the next verse's name (Kest children add verses with names in them: *ten days, nine days, here comes Tibb*).

Quick roll. Knock and Open: Caul + Resolve, opposed, to hold still. Nine Days: Lung + Athletics, Routine (10), rising by 2 each verse.

Cheating. At Knock and Open, the commonest cheat is to blow on your partner's palms during the pause. At Nine Days, a bad turner may slow the rope for a friend or catch an enemy on *five*. Both are thought very low.

Stakes. Ribbons, buttons, sweets. Older children play for **namings**: the loser of Knock and Open must let the winner choose their name for the rest of the day, and use it. Children whose names are not yet given, who are under a year, are held by their siblings and played *for*, and the name won for them is sometimes the one they keep.

The horror around it. The Attendance forbids both games in a pang-week because, in 598, a Knock and Open game in the Kest courtyard called the Low Wall was stopped at **OPEN!** by two girls of eight who held the pause, palms a finger's breadth apart, for a count of nine, and then a count of ninety, and then until the watching children ran for their mothers, and the mothers came, and found the girls still standing palm to palm, perfectly still, smiling at each other, and between their palms, in the finger's breadth of air, something small and wet that had not been there before, and which, when the mothers pulled the girls apart, dropped to the cobbles and crawled, quickly, toward the nearest door. The Attendance permitted it. It is in the Tally. Both girls are midwives now. They do not play.



Hold still, hold still, the door's not shut; hold still, hold still, and mind the cut.

KEST SKIPPING-CHANT, THE SLOW VERSE

▼ CLAUSES, AND PROMISE-CHESS



Oatheners do not chat, and they do not play games of chance, because a wager is a promise and a lost wager is a Breaking. What they play instead are games of silence and intention. The commonest is **Clauses**, a game of dominoes played without a sound, on felt, in the galleries of Tacit, in which each player may vow where their next tile will go and is held to it, not by the god, but by the rules. The Clausewrights' own game is **promise-chess**, which is ordinary chess with one Oathen rule added, and is said to be the hardest game on the Table. Both are taught to children while they are still bitted, and are played by the Bench of Clauses in its long recesses. Mute Kings play Clauses well. It is thought proper that they should.

Who and where. Everyone in Oathen who can afford a set of dominoes, which are carved from canyon goat-bone and are, in a good house, very old. The Forsworn of the Breakdowns play with tally-sticks marked in pips. Promise-chess is played at the Bench, in Quillhouse, and wherever Clausewrights meet.

What you need. For Clauses: a double-six set of dominoes, laid face-down and shuffled (the **boneyard**); a handful of pebbles (**witnesses**); two to four players. For promise-chess: a chess set, paper and pencil, two players.

CLAUSES: THE RULES

- ◇ **Silence.** No player may make any sound from the first tile to the last. A player who speaks, laughs, hums or coughs aloud forfeits the hand and scores nothing for it. (Bitted children are therefore the best players.) Handtalk is forbidden too. Pointing is allowed.
- ◇ **The draw.** Each player draws seven tiles (with two players) or five (with three or four). The rest stay face-down as the boneyard.
- ◇ **The opening.** The player holding the highest double sets it down. Play passes to the left.
- ◇ **Laying.** On your turn, lay one tile at either open end of the line, matching pips to pips. If you cannot, draw from the boneyard until you can; if the boneyard is empty and you still cannot, pass.
- ◇ **The vow.** After laying a tile, you may **vow** by placing one of your pebbles on either open end of the line. This says, silently: *my next tile will be laid here*. You may vow only once per turn and only one vow may be yours on the table at a time.
- ◇ **Keeping the vow.** At your next turn, if you have a vow on the table, you must lay at that end if you can. If you can, do so, take your pebble back, and also take one **witness** from the common

pile and set it in front of you: you kept your word. If another player has laid on that end in the meantime, the vow still holds on whatever end now stands there.

- ◇ **Breaking the vow.** If you cannot lay at your vowed end, you must draw from the boneyard until you can. If the boneyard runs out and you still cannot, you are **broken**: return all your witnesses to the common pile, turn one tile in your hand face-up on the table in front of you (it stays in your hand, exposed, for the rest of the hand), and you may not vow again this hand.
- ◇ **Going out.** The first player to lay their last tile wins the hand and scores the total pips left in all other players' hands, plus **5 for each witness** they hold. Every other player scores 5 for each witness they hold, and broken players score nothing at all. If the game blocks (nobody can lay and the boneyard is empty), the player with the fewest pips in hand goes out.
- ◇ **The match.** Play to 100, or to whatever the Bench has agreed in advance, with Exits.

PROMISE-CHESS: THE RULES

Ordinary chess, with one addition. At the end of each of your turns, write down, secretly, on a folded slip, the move you **promise** to make on your next turn (for example, *knight to f3*). On your next turn, unfold the slip. If the promised move is legal, you must make it. If it is not legal (the square is now occupied by your own piece, the piece was taken, the move would leave your king in check), you are **broken**: your opponent removes one of your pieces of their choice other than the king, and you may then make any legal move. You may write *I make no promise* instead of a move; if you do, your opponent may make two moves on their next turn. (Oatheners consider this rule generous.)

Quick roll. Clauses: Eye + Reckoning, opposed. Promise-chess: Tongue + Clause, opposed, because the game is about drafting.

Cheating. Clauses: marking the backs of the tiles with a fingernail, or a cough at the right moment to make an opponent forfeit (a Grim cheat; nobody may say whose cough it was, because to say so would be speech). Promise-chess: an ambiguous slip, *the knight to the bright square*, which an Oathener will dispute in silence for an hour.

Stakes. None, officially. Oatheners will not wager, because a wager is a promise. In fact they play for **favours unspoken**: the loser does something the winner indicates by pointing, and the thing is never said aloud, and so, the players hope, never binds. Since the

widening began, and pointing has come to count a little, Clauses-players in Tacit have started to lose fingers.

The horror around it. In 640, a match of Clauses was played in the Stilled Gallery between two Clausewrights of the Bench to settle, without speech, a question of drafting for the Sayer's sentence. Both players were Tongue-line, and both were near the Course. The match went on for nine days in absolute silence. The

Bench's clerks noted that neither player broke a vow in all that time. On the ninth day one of them placed a pebble on an open end, and the other, unable to lay there, drew the boneyard dry, and was broken; and in the gallery outside, the clerks heard a long, wet sound, like a book being opened by force. The broken player's ribs had opened outward. The clerk who records it notes that the rules of Clauses are only rules. He notes it twice.

▼ THE FOURTH ASKING



The Unfed are not allowed games with plates, but they are allowed this one, because it is a game about saying no. Two players face each other: one offers, and one declines, three times, as is proper, and on the fourth asking chooses. The offer is held in a closed fist. It may be something good, or nothing, or the **crumb**, which is the one thing in the game that must never be taken. Children play it with pebbles and a bean. Elders of the Abstinent play it with ration chits. The Reckoners play it with knives in the fist, for training; the Tablebreakers play it, they say, with real bread.

Who and where. Everyone in Wanting, in every household, after the Decline and before the cold meal; Crumb-Runners on the Hungry Lane to pass the night; Unfed exiles on the Rim, who teach it to Godeaters and watch, with satisfaction, how badly they play.

What you need. Twenty pebbles per player, one bean or black stone per player (the **crumb**), and twenty more pebbles in a common bowl (the **Pantry**). Two players; for more, play in turn around a circle, each player asking the player to their left.

THE RULES

- ♦ **The asking.** The Asker turns away, hides 0, 1, 2 or 3 of their own pebbles **or** their crumb (not both) in a closed fist, and turns back, holding out the fist. *Will you have it?*
- ♦ **The Decline.** The Refuser must say *No, thank you*. The Asker may then put their hand behind their back and change what is in it (or pretend to), and ask again. This happens three times: three askings, three declines. The Refuser may watch the Asker's face, arms and shoulders, and the Asker may say anything at all about what is in the fist, truthfully or not, between askings.
- ♦ **Accepting early.** The Refuser may break custom and accept on the first, second or third asking instead of declining. This is a **scandal**. If they accept on the first asking, they receive three times what is in the fist (from the Asker's pebbles; if the Asker runs short, from the Pantry); on the second asking, twice. On the third, once. But if the fist holds the crumb, the scandal is

total; see *Seated*, below, with the penalty multiplied the same way.

- ♦ **The fourth asking.** On the fourth asking, the Refuser chooses: **accept** or **decline**.
- ♦ **Accept:** the Asker opens the fist. If it holds pebbles, the Refuser takes them. If it holds the crumb, the Refuser is **Seated**: they pay 5 pebbles to the Asker (10 or 15 for a scandal), and must sit out the next round, saying nothing, smiling.
- ♦ **Decline:** the Refuser takes one pebble from the Pantry (their **Want**) and the Asker reveals the fist. If it held the crumb, the Refuser also takes one pebble from the Asker: they refused rightly.
- ♦ **Changing places.** Asker and Refuser swap, and play again.
- ♦ **The lean season.** When the Pantry is empty, declining earns nothing more. The lists have been cut.
- ♦ **The end.** Play ends when every player has asked ten times, or when one player has no pebbles left. The player with the most pebbles wins. The player with no pebbles left is **off the list**, and must stand with their back to the game until it is over.

Quick roll. Eye + Instinct against the Asker's Tongue + Deceive.

Cheating. Asking with an empty fist and a bean palmed in the other hand, to swap in at the last moment; for an Unfed, this is cheating twice, since it is a false offer. Godeaters who play it Partake to see through the fist, and an Unfed opponent who sees their tell will not play with them again.

Stakes. Pebbles, chits, and among the Reckoners, the order of the raid: the winner chooses who goes in first. Among the young, it is played for the right to be the one who says *No, thank you* to a stranger at the gate, which Unfed children consider an honour.

The horror around it. Unfed children are warned never to play the Fourth Asking with anyone they did not see arrive. Every family has the story of the child who played it in the dusk at the edge of the village, with a tall, kind, stooping stranger, and declined three times,

beautifully, and on the fourth asking, accepted, because the stranger’s fist was warm and smelled of honey, and because the stranger had said, between askings, *you have refused so well, and for so long, and you are so hungry*. Abstain Rooke, called Abby, has played the game this year more than any child in Wanting. She says she is getting good at it. She says she has been asked, lately, by someone who never puts the crumb in their hand at all, and who always seems sad when she declines.

▼ WHO IS SERVED



The Second Table does not gamble. It draws lots. At every practice dinner, before the courses come, the Carver of the table shuffles a deck of course-cards and deals them round, and the dozen at the table pass the cards among themselves, drawing blind from one another’s hands, pairing courses and laying them down, until one member is left holding the **Dish**. The holder of the Dish does not carve at the next dinner and does not choose their course. The holder of the Dish, in the great meal to come, will be served last, and will take what is left. It is the most dreaded card in the Second Table’s world, and the Trenchermen draw it with grace, and smile, and dab their mouths with their napkins, and are seen afterward, by their servants, sitting very still in their carriages.

That is what the Second Table says the game is for. Its Scullions say that in the old days, and perhaps now, the Dish went not to a

◇

He asked me four times, and I said no three times, and then I thought, what’s the fourth for, then, if not for yes?

A CHILD OF WANTING, BEFORE THE BELL

member but to the candidate brought to dinner that evening, who sat in the game and drew with the others and did not know what the cards meant.

Who and where. The Second Table, in every land, at every practice dinner; its servants, below stairs, who play it with an ordinary deck because they have heard of it; and the children of great houses, who play it under the name *Old Mutton* and do not know what they are playing.

What you need. From a standard deck, take the Aces through Sevens of all four suits (twenty-eight cards), and add one Queen (the **Dish**; traditionally the Queen of Spades). Three to eight players.

THE COURSES

CARD	COURSE	CARD	COURSE
Ace	the Hand	Five	the Sweet
Two	the Fish	Six	the Word
Three	the Bread	Seven	the Host
Four	the Lid	Queen	the Dish

THE RULES

- ◇ **The deal.** The Carver (dealer) shuffles and deals all twenty-nine cards face-down around the table. Some players will hold more than others.
- ◇ **The first serving.** Every player looks at their hand and lays down, face-up, every pair of the same rank they hold, naming the course aloud: *the Fish, served*. (A player holding three of a rank lays down two and keeps one.)
- ◇ **Drawing.** Beginning on the Carver’s left, each player in turn holds out their hand fanned and face-down to the player on their left, who draws one card blind from it. If it makes a pair, the drawer lays the pair down and names it. Then the drawer holds

- out their own hand to the next player, and so on around the table.
- ◇ **Rising from table.** A player with no cards left has **risen**, and is out of the game, safe. Drawing skips them.
 - ◇ **The Dish.** Play continues until every course is served and nothing pairable is left in anyone’s hand. Whoever holds the Queen is **served**.
 - ◇ **The Host.** The Sevens are paired and laid down like any course, but the Carver does not name them. The pair is set at the empty place, and is removed, unspoken, at the end of the game.

The blank line. At some tables, the Carver shuffles in a thirtieth card before the deal: a blank card, or a card from another deck, or

the Eight of any suit. It cannot be paired. When the game ends, the Carver collects it without looking at who held it. Members who ask what it is for are told that it is customary. Members who look at it, after the game, generally find that it was in their hand, and do not remember drawing it.

Quick roll. Pure chance: everyone rolls 2d10 and the lowest is served; or Eye + Instinct, opposed, for a member who watches faces as the cards are drawn.

Cheating. Marking the Queen's back with a fingernail, or holding it high in the fan where an incautious hand will draw it. A Carver who wants a particular member to draw the Dish deals it to them and watches who they offer it to; the Second Table's games are

rigged as often as not, and everyone knows it, and pretends not to, because to accuse a Carver of cheating at Who Is Served is to accuse them of choosing a guest to be eaten, which is the whole point of the Carver.

Stakes. Precedence at the meal to come. Below that, a wager nobody speaks: the holder of the Dish, if the table is short of practice, may be asked to volunteer a part of themselves for the next dinner. It is an honour. The Trencherman of the Bread at the Lastgate table, Sir Ambrose Tull, has drawn the Dish nine times in thirty years and has given, by now, the last three fingers of each hand, a kidney, and his left ear, all of which were served, and all of which were praised.

WHO IS SERVED  THE HAND Ace. Grey, nine-jointed, roasted in its glove. Pair it and lay it down: <i>the Hand, served.</i>	WHO IS SERVED  THE FISH Two. A consommé of the Fathom, clarified through linen, served cold with salt from the morning bailing.	WHO IS SERVED  THE BREAD Three. A small loaf of the toothed wheat, the teeth left in. Do not bite down.
WHO IS SERVED  THE LID Four. Two eyes of the Lidded, pickled; one each; do not chew.	WHO IS SERVED  THE SWEET Five. A custard of caul, set in a highland mould, with a crust of burnt sugar.	WHO IS SERVED  THE WORD Six. A sliver of tongue, laid on your own and let dissolve. You will not speak while you hold this card.



▼ WHO FINISHES



The card game of the north is a game about getting rid of everything you hold, in a country where nothing is ever allowed to end. Every player is trying to go out. Nobody may go out without a licence. And the player left holding cards at the end, the one who could not finish, pays everyone, and is called **the Kept** until the next hand, and is laughed at, kindly, by the dead. It is played in every tavern on the Lower Pilings, in the reading-rooms of the Lofts, on the barges of the Sump, and in the Room of the Long Argument, where a hand begun in 344 A.G. between four Unvacated aldermen has not yet finished, because none of them has drawn an Ace in two hundred and ninety-seven years, and none of them will agree to a new deal.

Who and where. The living and the Kept together, which is its charm: it is the one game on the Table at which the dead can play the living on equal terms, holding their cards in wooden racks when their fingers are no longer reliable, bidding by jaw-click through an interpreter. Loft-Wardens play it with the shelved, reading out the hand and placing the cards as the shelf whispers.

What you need. A standard deck of fifty-two cards. Three to six players. Coins or tokens.

THE RULES

- ♦ **Ranks.** From low to high: 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, Jack, Queen, King, **Ace**. The **2s** are **Stitches** and stand outside the ranks (see below). Suits do not matter.
- ♦ **The deal.** Deal out the whole deck, one at a time; some players may have one more card than others. In the first hand, the player holding the 3 of clubs leads. In later hands, the Kept leads.
- ♦ **Plays.** A play is a single card, a pair, a triple, four of a kind, or a **run** of three or more single cards in consecutive rank (for example 6, 7, 8; Stitches cannot be in a run).
- ♦ **The trick.** The leader lays down any play. Going left, each player must either beat it with a play of the same form (a higher single on a single, a higher pair on a pair, a run of the same length with a higher top card on a run) or pass. A player who passes may not play again in that trick. When every other player has passed, the last player to play takes the trick (the cards are set aside face-down) and leads the next.
- ♦ **Stitches.** On your turn in any trick, instead of following, you may play a single **2**. The trick ends at once and you take it, and lead.
- ♦ **The License.** If you take a trick in which the last card you played was an **Ace**, keep that Ace face-up in front of you instead of setting it aside. That is your **License**. You may hold only one.
- ♦ **Finishing.** You may not play the last card or cards of your hand unless (a) that final play contains an Ace, or (b) you hold a License. A Stitch can never be your final card. If you hold a License, you may finish with any play except a Stitch. Nothing else lets you finish. Players without a License who are down to their last few cards must keep them, and pass, and wait.
- ♦ **Restitching.** If it is your turn to lead, and every play you could make would empty your hand without the right to finish, you are **restitched**: the player on your left must give you any two

cards of their choosing from their own hand, and you then lead. (In Lastgate this is accompanied by a show of sympathy.)

- ◇ **Going out.** A player who plays their last cards has **finished**, and is out of the hand. Play continues without them. The first to finish is the **Closed**. Each later player to finish ranks below the one before.
- ◇ **The Kept.** When only one player still holds cards, that player is the **Kept**. The Kept pays one coin to every other player, and two to the Closed.
- ◇ **The Unvacated take their due.** Before the next hand begins, the Kept gives their two highest cards (Stitches count highest) to the Closed, and the Closed gives back any two cards they choose. The Kept leads.

Quick roll. Eye + Reckoning, opposed; the lowest is the Kept. A player who is themselves Kept rolls with +2: they have had a great deal of practice.

Cheating. Hiding a License up the sleeve (Kept players have a great deal of sleeve). An interpreter who misreports a Kept player's jaw-clicks, which is how most interpreters in Lastgate retire comfortably. Racks with a mirror at the back. And, among the Kept, the old trick of *dropping a finger*: a Kept player whose finger comes off at the right moment, onto the table, among the cards, has caused a disturbance in which anything can be swapped.

Stakes. Breaths and minutes of Closing, above all, so that every hand is in a small way a wager on death. Below that, Seamers' tokens, Loft visits, the right to keep great-grandfather for a season instead of a cousin, and, among the Kept themselves, parts: the Kept who loses the hand pays in fingers, which are passed around the table and fixed back on by the winner's Seamer, because nobody in Sallowreach owns their hands for ever.

The horror around it. In the Lack of 639, at a tavern called the Lid on the edge of Glovehall, a Kept tanner who had been losing at Who Finishes every night for a hundred and eighty years drew, for the first time, a hand of four Aces. The other players watched him lay them down, one trick after another, until he held one card, and a License, and laid the last card, and finished. Then he finished. He fell sideways off the bench and lay, for the first time in a hundred and eighty years, entirely still. There were no flies. There was no sound. The Lid is now the eastern edge of the Glovehall Hush, and the card table is inside it, with the hands still laid out, and the tanner's last card face-up in the middle, and the Finishers have begun to make pilgrimage there, in fours, to sit down at the table and deal.



I never finish. Fifty years at this table, and I never finish. It's the only thing in Lastgate I'm good at.

A KEPT PLAYER OF WHO FINISHES, LOWER PILINGS

▼ LACK KEEP AWAY, AND TABLE'S LAID



Every child on the Table knows a counting-out rhyme, and most of them know the same one, in seven dialects and with seven endings. It is chanted with a pointing finger, round a ring of children, one word to each child, and the child it lands on at the end *goes away*: steps out of the ring, safe. The ring counts again, and again, until one child is left. That child is **it**. In most lands, it is then *it* for **Table's Laid**, the commonest ring-game on the Table, which every adult played as a child and which every adult, if asked, finds that they would rather not watch.

Who and where. Children everywhere; in the Fast, in a version without chairs or tables, which is called Stand-Still and is played

with the same rhyme. Rim inns keep a set of stools for it in the yard.

What you need. For counting out, nothing. For Table's Laid, chairs, stools or chalk circles, one fewer than the number of players, set in a ring facing outward; plus **one more**, set a little apart from the ring, facing in, at its head.

THE RHYME

Lack keep away, Lack keep away,

who will eat with me today?

One for the hand and two for the tongue,

*three for the eye, and four for the lung,
five for the gut and six for the caul,
seven for the one who ate nothing at all,
and one for the chair, and the chair's pushed in,
and out goes you, and in comes him.*

Each land changes the last two lines. Sallowreach: *and one for the chair, and the chair is shut, and you may finish, and you may not.* The Fatlands: *and one for the chair, and the chair is fed, and out goes you, and in goes bread.* Brinehollow: *and one for the chair, and the chair is wet, and you go out, and you're not back yet.* The Vigil: *and one for the chair, and the chair's a bed, and out goes you, and you're in it instead.* Cradlewrack: *and one for the chair, and the chair's not born, and out goes you on the ninth day morn.* Oathen children do not chant it; they count it in handtalk, and the last two lines are a gesture, a hand pushing an empty space away. In the Fast, it is *and one for the chair, and you won't sit down, and no, thank you, and out of town.*

COUNTING OUT: THE RULES

- ◇ Children stand in a ring. The counter (the eldest, or whoever shouts first) stands in the ring too, and points to each child in turn, including themselves, going left, one word of the rhyme to each child.
- ◇ The child pointed to on the last word, *him* (or the land's last word), steps out. They are safe.
- ◇ The counter begins again with the next child in the ring, and counts again, until only one child remains. That child is *it*.

TABLE'S LAID: THE RULES

- ◇ **Setting the table.** Set out one chair fewer than the number of players in a ring, facing outward. Set one more chair apart from the ring, facing in toward it. This is the **head chair**.

- ◇ **The walk.** The player who is *it* stands apart and sings or shouts. Everyone else walks around the ring of chairs, slowly, in the direction of the sun, singing the rhyme. *It* may shout **Table's laid!** at any moment.
- ◇ **Sitting down.** At *Table's laid!* every walker must sit on a chair of the ring at once. The walker left without a chair has **missed supper**: they become *it* for the next round, and the old *it* joins the walk. Each round, *it* also removes one chair from the ring, so that the table gets shorter.
- ◇ **The end.** When only one chair remains in the ring and two walkers, the walker who sits in it is **fed**, and wins.
- ◇ **The head chair.** Nobody, at any time, may sit in the head chair. A player who does, by accident or for a dare, ends the game at once: every player must stop, and go home, without speaking, and not play again that day. Children are very strict about this rule, much stricter than about any other, and do not know why.

Quick roll. Lung + Athletics, Routine (10), for each round; the Carver may as well let the children win.

Cheating. Sitting before the call, if *it* has a tell. Pushing.

Stakes. None. It is a children's game.

The horror around it. Adults who watch Table's Laid from a window find, often, that they have counted the chairs. The ring always has one fewer than the walkers, as it should. The head chair is always one, as it should be. But the rhyme counts seven, and then *one for the chair*, and children who are asked who the chair is for say *for the one who's late*, and children who are asked who that is say they do not know, and children who are asked more than once begin to cry. In the old carvings of every land, on the lintels of the oldest granaries and the walls of the oldest shrines, children are shown playing a ring-game around a table, and there is an eighth chair at its head, and the figure sitting in it has been chiselled away. Cutwrights who study the carvings say that, in every one, the children are looking at the chair, and none of them is singing.

▼ BITE BACK



The drinking game of the Rim Road taverns, played with the Table's own dice and named for the god's habit of biting those who call on it. Every player on the Table knows the feeling the game imitates: the reach for something more, the extra die, the hunger it costs. Every land has its version. The Company forbids it on its premises, which is to say that the Company's premises are where it is played.

A note for the real table. Play Bite Back with whatever is in your cup: water, juice, tea, small beer. A sip is a sip. Nobody should ever be made to drink, and nobody should play it with strong drink, or anyone too young to choose. The game is just as good with tea, and the forfeits are the fun.

Who and where. Every waystation taproom on the Rim; Netwatch and Wakers on leave; Bonded Hands at the end of a forty-

mile day; Renderers' Union men at the Chute; and Vigil travellers, who play it with rouse, which is how many of them die.

What you need. Two ten-sided dice, two six-sided dice (the **Teeth**), a cup of something each. Paper for tallying **Hunger**. Three or more players.

THE RULES

- ◇ **The Bill.** The first player names a **Bill** for the player on their left: 10, 14, 18 or 22 (Routine, Hard, Grim, Dire).
- ◇ **The roll.** That player rolls 2d10. Before rolling, they may choose to **Partake**: roll one Tooth (a d6) as well and add it, or two Teeth if they have Partaken five times or more this game. Each Partaking marks 1 Hunger on their tally.
- ◇ **Paying the Bill.** If the total equals or beats the Bill, the roller has **paid**: they name the Bill for the next player. If not, they **owe**: they take a sip, and the next player faces the **same** Bill, and does not get to name one.
- ◇ **The god bit back.** Any Tooth showing a 1: the roller takes a sip and marks 1 more Hunger, whatever the total.
- ◇ **Grace.** If the two d10 show a pair and the roll paid, the roller hands out sips equal to the number on one die, among the other players as they like.
- ◇ **Lack.** If the two d10 show a pair and the roll owed, the roller takes sips equal to the number on one die, or swaps cups with the player of their choice and drinks from it.
- ◇ **Licked Clean.** Two 1s: the roller finishes their cup, and the next Bill is 22.
- ◇ **Second Helping.** Two 10s: everyone else sips, and the roller names any forfeit for any player (*speak only in conditionals, Oathen-fashion, until your next roll; no blinking until your next roll; say “may you finish” instead of “cheers”*).
- ◇ **Regrowth.** At **10 Hunger**, a player's tally is wiped and they have **regrown**: they must play the rest of the game under a **Want** chosen by the table (*you must eat whatever is offered; you must face west; you must close any door left open; you must open any door left shut; you must promise something every time you roll; you must say “no, thank you” three times before accepting anything*). A

player who regrows a second time is **Seated**, and leaves the game smiling, and must say nice things about everyone's dice until the end.

- ◇ **The end.** The game ends when the cups are dry or the players are. Nobody wins Bite Back. The Rim says that this is the whole point.

Quick roll. Gut + Feast, Hard (14), to remain upright; the Carver may decide that a Guest who Partakes for real during Bite Back has an audience.

Cheating. A rigged Tooth that never shows a 1 is called a *milk tooth* and is sold at Gristmoot, and every Rim house knows to check, by dropping the Teeth in the water glass beside the fat dice.

Stakes. Drinks, rounds, and the next day's head. Among the Bonded Hands, the player with the most Hunger at the end of the night stands the next night's watch.

The horror around it. At the Weeping Post, they play Bite Back with a chair left empty and a cup poured for it, as they do at Grace-and-Lack, because the habit has spread from one game to the other, as habits on the Rim do. When the empty chair's turn comes, the player on its right names the Bill, and the dice are rolled for it by the warden's boy, and the result is called aloud. If the chair owes, the boy sips from its cup. In the spring of 641 the chair paid every Bill it was set for nine nights running, and on the tenth night, a Rim Road courier of the Vigil who had not slept in a week named a Bill of 22 for it, as a joke, and the boy rolled two tens, and the room went quiet, and the courier, as the rules require, named a forfeit for any player at the table. He named it in a voice nobody recognised. Nobody will say what it was. The cup in front of the empty chair was empty in the morning, and the boy, the warden's son, Corley, aged eleven, has not eaten since, and says he is not hungry, and says that he is being fed.

◇
*Lack keep away, and keep the Tooth in its gum, and
keep the chair pushed in.*

RIM TOAST, BEFORE THE FIRST ROLL

▼ AT THE NEXT TABLE

The Guests are in a taproom, a waking-house, a Loft gallery or a Pinchmarket stall, and there is a game going on at the next table.

Roll d10, or choose.

D10 AT THE NEXT TABLE	
1	Grace-and-Lack. A Kept man of Sallowreach, at his border on licence, is losing coin to a Fatlands drover on purpose, so that he can be the Kept at Who Finishes later, because he is lonely.
2	The Last Plate, the dice version, between two Renderers' Union men, with a third man's dusk shift in the pot. The third man is not present. He does not know.

D10	AT THE NEXT TABLE
3	Hook and Haul. A Netwatch hooker on leave plays Tally alone, for no stake, throwing the Hook again and again, and keeping the sixth bone in her other hand, tightly.
4	Nod. A Vigil gentleman has blinked; the others are moving cards in his row, and grinning, and one of them is a Second Table Taster with a two-tined fork inside her collar.
5	Clauses. Two Oatheners in complete silence, a pebble on an open end, a Surety watching, sweating, very pale; she is standing for both of them.
6	The Fourth Asking. An Unfed Crumb-Runner and a child who is not from any land, in good clothes, with a warm hand. The Runner has declined three times and is looking at the fist.
7	Who Is Served. Six travellers in good coats, a seventh chair, a deck of twenty-nine cards; one of them invites the Guests to make up the numbers.
8	Who Finishes. A Loft-Warden reading out a hand to a parcel of linen on the bench beside her, and placing cards as the parcel whispers. The parcel is winning.
9	Bite Back. A table of Bonded Hands, an empty chair with a full cup, and a boy rolling for the chair, who looks up at the Guests and asks, politely, whether they would like to name its Bill.
10	Table's Laid, in the inn yard. Seven children walking round six stools, singing. At the head of the ring, set apart, facing in, the head chair. Somebody is sitting in it. The children have not noticed. They are still singing.



PART FOUR

THE DECKS

*Cards for when the dice go wrong, the god grows, the village breaks, and
the market lies.*

CHAPTER 9

THE LACK DECK
AND THE GRACE
DECK

Cut the deck, love. No, the other way. You always cut toward yourself on the Table. That way, whatever's on the bottom comes to you, and not to somebody who can't afford it.

— A CARD-WIFE AT THE FOURWAY INN, RIM ROAD, TO A COMPANY AUDITOR

PAINTED ON THE LID OF A CARD BOX FOUND IN THE LUGGAGE OF A DROWNED RIM ROAD FACTOR, LOWMARK CUSTOMS HOUSE, 638 A.G. THE BOX HELD TWO PACKS, ONE BLACK-BACKED AND ONE GILT, BOTH MUCH HANDLED.

BLACK IS FOR WHEN IT GOES WRONG. GOLD IS FOR WHEN IT GOES RIGHT. THEY ARE BOTH FOR WHEN IT GOES. Do not play with a man who cuts the gold first. Do not play at all east of Tacit. If a card turns up in this box that you did not put in, it is yours now; read it, then burn it, then count again.

Every Grace Roll that comes up doubles carries an omen. On a success it is a **Grace**, and on a failure it is a **Lack**, and the rules ask

the Carver to invent, on the spot, either the worst plausible complication or something better than anyone had a right to. Few Carvers can do that well at midnight, after the fourth Lack in a row, while two players argue about whether a Kept man can be bribed with his own fingers. These decks are for those nights: a stock of ready-made omens, in the Table's voice, to turn over, read aloud and play.

The **Lack Deck** holds 72 cards: 18 that can fall anywhere on the Table, 6 for each of the seven lands, and 12 that only fall in a fight. The **Grace Deck** holds 48: 12 general, 4 for each land, and 8 for the fight. Every card has a title, a few lines of what happens, and a **bold rules line** that says exactly what it does in the numbers. Each card is numbered, so a group without printed cards can roll on the tables at the end of each deck and look the card up in this chapter.

▼ HOW TO USE THE DECKS

DRAW ON THE PAIR

When a Grace Roll comes up doubles and fails, it is a Lack: the Carver may turn over the top card of the Lack Deck. When it comes up doubles and succeeds, it is a Grace: the player who rolled may turn over the top card of the Grace Deck. Licked Clean and Second Helping (double 1s and double 10s) draw exactly as any other Lack or Grace. The Carver serves the Lack and reads it aloud, in her own voice, to the whole table. The Guest receives the Grace and reads it aloud to everyone else, because on the Table good fortune is a thing people watch you eat.

The card replaces the improvised complication or boon. It does not replace the rest of the rules. A Lack while Partaking still costs 2 more Hunger. A Grace on an attack still inflicts a Mangling. A Lack on a Dread check still freezes, flees, screams, vomits or laughs. The card is laid on top of all that, like a garnish, and like most garnishes on the Table it may be the part that does the real damage.

You on a card means the Guest whose roll it was. Where a card names a stranger, the Carver picks someone fitting from the scene; the card is a seed, not a script. Dread, Fray, Hunger, Want, Pangs and Weariness work exactly as in *The Grace Roll* and the land chapters. Where a card and the core rules disagree, the card wins for that moment only.

TWO PILES: THE BOARD AND THE KNIFE

Build each deck as two piles. The **Board** is everything that is not a fight: the general cards, plus the cards of whichever land the scene takes place in. The **Knife** is the combat cards, kept separate and shuffled on their own.

- ◇ When a Lack or a Grace comes up on an **attack** or a **defense roll** in a fight (an attack, a grapple, a Bind, a Cast Into, breaking free, the Carver's call to dodge something unusual), draw from the Knife.
- ◇ Any other Lack or Grace, including one rolled in the middle of a fight (a Dread check when the Kept come up out of the water, a first-aid roll on a man holding his bowel in with both hands, a Yield), draws from the Board.

The Carver may also draw from the Knife for an adversary's Lack, reading *you* as *he* or *she*. It makes the enemy look like a person having a bad night.

LAND CARDS STAY HOME

Each land's cards go into the Board only while the scene is in that land. A Brinehollow card does not fall in Tacit; the canyons do not have a tide, whatever they have instead. When the company crosses a border, take the old land's cards out of the deck and the discard alike, and shuffle the new land's cards in. On the Rim Road itself,

between lands, play the general cards alone: the Road belongs to the Company, and the Company insists that nothing strange happens on it.

The land is where the scene is, not where the Guest was born. Where a land card names a native rule (a Calling roll, Weariness, a Weight of oath, an Invitation check), it applies to foreigners as written: a Vigilant in Brinehollow makes the Calling roll like anyone, and learns why the locals sleep roped. The Fast's cards fall on Godeaters and Unfed alike. The Host does not ask what you have eaten before it lays you a place.

THE PLATE, AND THE RESHUFFLE

Drawn cards go face up on a discard pile called **the Plate**, where everyone can see what has already been served. A card on the Plate cannot come up again until the reshuffle. Reshuffle the Board and the Knife together, Plate and all, when any of these happens:

- ◇ **The pile runs out.** Shuffle the Plate back in and carry on.
- ◇ **A new session begins.** The Table starts every night hungry.
- ◇ **A Guest's Regrowth rises.** The god has taken a step forward, and it stirs the pot. Reshuffle at once, before the next roll.
- ◇ **Tablenight**, in the fiction. On the longest night of Lack every omen is possible again, and some are likelier.
- ◇ **The company crosses a border** (swap the land cards, as above, and shuffle everything).

A card that says it stays with a Guest (a place card, a bed number, a Part in the pack, a debt) is taken off the Plate and given to that player, face up, in front of them. It returns to the deck when its business is finished.



Gold on the left, black on the right, and keep your hands where the Company can see them.

NOTICE ABOVE THE CARD TABLES, FOURWAY INN

OPTIONAL, ALWAYS

The decks are optional, wholly and at every moment. A Carver who has a better Lack in her mouth when the dice fall should say it and leave the deck alone. Some groups draw only for Lacks, or only in fights, or only when nobody can think of anything; some, the worst kind, draw every time and read the card in a funny voice. All of these are correct.

THE CARVER'S VETO

The Carver may veto any card she draws, for any reason, without explanation. Put the vetoed card on the bottom of its pile, not on the Plate, and draw again. If the second card is vetoed too, stop drawing and make the Lack or Grace up in the ordinary way. Never draw a third card. A deck that can be shopped from is not an omen; it is a menu.

A card that touches anything a player has said they will not play is vetoed without a word, as soon as it is turned over, before it is read. That is not a judgment call and does not count against the two draws.

The players have one refusal of their own, and only for the gold. **A Guest may refuse a Grace card** after hearing it, before anything on it happens. The card goes to the Plate and the roll is an ordinary Grace, made up by the Carver. An Unfed Guest who refuses gains **1 Want**, as for declining any offer of value. Nobody may refuse a Lack.



Every gift on the Table has a hook in it. The good ones only have the one.

WRECKWIFE SAYING, GANNET REACH

▼ PRINTING AND CUTTING

The cards in this chapter are laid out three to a row, at the width of an ordinary playing card. To make a deck:

- ◇ **Copy the pages at full size.** Do not shrink to fit. The card faces in this book are sized for the common poker card, about 63 by 88 millimetres (2.5 by 3.5 inches). Print on the heaviest card your printer will take; 250 to 300 grams is ideal. Plain paper will do if you sleeve it.

- ◇ **Cut along the borders** with a steel rule and a sharp knife on a cutting mat, or a guillotine if you have one. Round the corners with a corner-punch or a nail file. The card-wives of the Rim round theirs with their teeth, which is not recommended.
- ◇ **Back them.** Draw or print a single card back and copy it in a sheet of nine: for the Lack Deck an empty plate in gold on black, for the Grace Deck an empty plate in black on gold. Glue a sheet of backs behind each page of faces before cutting, so the edges

line up. If you do not want to glue, slide each face into a card sleeve in front of an old playing card: red-backed cards for the Lack Deck, blue for the Grace.

- ◇ **Mark the piles.** Each land card carries its land's name and number on the face; it helps to put a dot of colour on the corner as well, so land cards can be pulled quickly at a border. Combat cards are marked *Knife*. Keep each land's cards in a small envelope inside the box, with the land's sigil drawn on the flap.
- ◇ **Count them** before every session, as the box lid says. There should be 72 black and 48 gold. If there are more, someone at your table has been writing their own, which is the best thing that can happen to a deck and should be encouraged. Number

the new ones from 73 and 49 upward, and keep them out of the dice tables.

CARVER'S ADVICE: PACING THE BLACK

Bad dice can turn up four Lacks in an hour, and four cards in an hour is a pile-up, not a story. After the first card in a scene, consider making further Lacks yourself. One card per scene is a seasoning, two is a meal, three is the Fatlands. The Grace Deck needs no such rationing. Players remember every one, and talk about the ominous ones on the way home.

▼ THE LACK DECK

Seventy-two black cards. The first eighteen can fall anywhere on the Table. Then come six for each land, in the order of the core book, and last the twelve cards of the Knife. Each card's number is printed

on its face, after the deck's name, so that a group rolling instead of drawing can find it.

THE GENERAL LACKS



LACK · 01



LONG LIFE.

Someone says it to you, under their breath, the worst curse in the north. What you tried does not fail. It simply does not finish, and goes on not finishing. **The roll is neither success nor failure: the matter hangs, one step worse, and cannot be tried again until something changes.** In Sallowreach, take 1 Fray; you know this feeling.

LACK · 02



LACK KEEP AWAY (UNSAID)

You ate, or drank, or broke bread, and you did not say the grace. Everyone noticed. So did the kitchen. **-2 to Tongue rolls with everyone who saw, until you buy every one of them a meal (1 lack a head).** The next food you eat carries Taint 1, and tastes faintly of someone else's mouth.

LACK · 03



I PROMISE.

It is out of your mouth before you hear it, said with all your heart. **The Carver names one small thing you have just promised, aloud, in character. Keep it before the session ends or lose 1 Flesh to a visible mark: a split lip, a cracked nail.** In Oathen it binds at Weight 1, and no exits apply.

LACK · 04



YOUR TOOTH BITES

The god in you was watching, and it did not like what it saw, or it liked it very much. **Gain 2 Hunger** and show your land's bite at once, Partaking or not. **Unfed:** gain 1 Pang instead. **Blanks:** gain 1 Fray, as every godsigned person in the room turns to look at you.

LACK · 05



SECOND HELPING

The worst plausible thing happens. Then the Carver looks up and asks, kindly, "And?" The Carver imposes two complications instead of one. The second must be served on the first one's plate: it follows from it, and it is worse.

LACK · 06



THE BLINK

A gap. Two seconds, maybe three. When you come back your hands are wet, and everyone is looking at you. **Lost Time:** the Carver tells you one thing you did in the gap. You did it. Nobody will believe otherwise. A **Vigilant** also gains 1 Weariness, and smells lamp-smoke from the long room.

LACK · 07



SOMEBODY KEPT SCORE

A clerk, a Cutwright, a Reckoner, a child with a slate. Someone with a book saw exactly what you did, and wrote it down, and noted the colour of your blood. **The Carver** writes your name and the deed on a slip. Once, later, she plays it: a witness, a bill, a warrant, a raid. Then she tears it up.

LACK · 08



THE ROPE COMES LOOSE

Whatever you tied, you tied it badly, or something untied it. In **Cradlewrack** this is no surprise. In **Brinehollow** somebody walks west tonight. **One thing you secured this scene** (a knot, a lock, a bandage, a sleeping-rope, a prisoner's wrists) fails at the worst moment of the Carver's choosing before the session ends.

LACK · 09



COMPANY

You were not alone when you failed. There is a warmth at your back, like a stove in the next room, and a chair somewhere was pulled out. **For the rest of the scene every Dread check is one step harder.** The Carver may describe bread baking, nowhere. Nobody else smells it.

LACK · 10



WRONG NAME

You call someone by the wrong name, and it is a name you should not know: their dead child's, their first wife's, the one their god calls them. **–2 Tongue** with them for the session. If the one you misnamed is a **Guest**, they make a **Dread 1** check: you said it with such love.

LACK · 11



THE COUNT IS ONE SHORT

Count the purse, the bolts, the rations, the company. Count again. Still one short. **Lose one item of equipment or 1d6 lacks,** Carver's choice. It turns up later somewhere it should not be: in a grave, in a **Kept man's** mouth, on a laid table, beside a plate.

LACK · 12



LAID FOR YOU

Tonight, where you sleep, someone sets a place. A clean plate. A folded napkin. A card, in good handwriting, with your name. **Dread 2** for you when you find it. **The Unfed** must make an **Invitation** check at **Hard (14)**. Nothing else happens. Keep this card in front of you until a reshuffle. Yet.

LACK · 13



THE DEBT ARRIVES

Someone you owe is here, smiling, and it is not about money, or not only. **Within the hour** a creditor, kin or old wrong from your background arrives and wants paying: coin, a favour, an apology in public, a part. If you owe nothing, you do now. The Carver invents it, and it is real.

LACK · 14



SLIP OF THE KNIFE

The knife goes where knives go when you are tired. Now there is blood on the bread. **Take 2 damage**, ignoring Armor. Your blood is on something that matters: a contract, a meal, a child's sleeve, an altar. In the Fatlands, someone tastes it and tells you your Cut.

LACK · 15



THEY HEARD THAT

Through the wall, on the stair, behind the door you did not check. **Someone you love**, rely on or fear learns exactly what you just did or said, in your own words, before the scene ends. They do not raise it with you. Not yet.

LACK · 16



NOBODY THANKED THE CHAIR

You sat without looking. The chair was warm. In the Fast you would know not to thank it. You didn't, and something noticed that too. For the rest of the session, whenever you sit to eat, roll a d6. On a 1, the chair beside you pulls itself out, and nobody did it. Dread 1 each time.

LACK · 17



A BIT OF THE GOD

Your godsign shows: grey fingers, a wet cough, an unblinking stare, a word that echoes. For a scene anyone may **Read the Line** on you at +4. Reckoners within sight follow, or strike. Unfed and Blanks: your emptiness shows instead, and a poacher marks you.

LACK · 18



TOO KIND

A stranger steps in and makes it all right, completely, warmly, before you can stop them. **Ignore the complication**. Instead you owe that NPC a Debt, which they will name later. Refusing it, when they call, is a Dread 2 check and a public disgrace. On the Table, favours are paid in parts.

SALLOWREACH



Count your company before you eat and after. If the second number is bigger, leave. If it is smaller, leave faster.

RIM ROAD PROVERB



LACK · SALLOWREACH · 19



MAY YOU FINISH

A Kept stranger, polite and soft at the seams, decides you are the one who will get him a Closing. He follows you, begging, until you pay his upkeep (1 lack a day) or walk him to a Hush. -2 Stealth while he is with you. He smells. He apologises for it constantly.

LACK · SALLOWREACH · 20



BLACK NOON

The flies come in a front, a roaring dark wall, and every lamp goes out at once. **Darkness** for 1d6 rounds. Everyone swallows flies: Gut + Endure (Routine 10) or retch and lose the next action. They get in the ears. Some of them stay.

LACK · SALLOWREACH · 21



SHELVED

A clerk in the Lofts has you down as Set Aside. On paper you are wrapped, labelled and on the ninth storey. Until a clerk is bribed (20 lacks) or argued with (Tongue + Clause, Grim 18), you may not buy, sell, testify or be served in Lastgate. People speak to you slowly and loudly.

LACK · SALLOWREACH · 22



THE THREAD GIVES

Old guild thread, two centuries in the neck, parts like wet paper. The nearest Kept loses a part: a jaw, a hand, a face. It goes on talking. Dread 1 for all who see, Dread 2 if you liked them. The Seamers' Guild will send you the bill.

LACK · SALLOWREACH · 23



HUSH SOUND

A breath of a Hush passes over you. Your voice goes nowhere. Neither does your heartbeat. For the rest of the scene you make no sound at all: no word, no scream, no footfall. +2 Stealth; you cannot warn anyone. When it ends, take 1 Fray from how loud your own blood is.

LACK · SALLOWREACH · 24



THE MAGGOT RULES

A small matter of law, a judge who is mostly colony, a clerk translating the buzzing. It goes against you. Pay 2d6 lacks or spend a day in the Jar Room's waiting hall. A grey cloud of court flies follows you until you leave Sallowreach: -2 to Persuade.

THE FATLANDS



My husband came home again tonight. I set his place. I always will. I would only like, once, to be allowed to clear it.

HENNA FARROW, FORTY-SECOND PETITION TO THE MORTUARY COURT



LACK · FATLANDS · 25



LEAVE IT ON THE PLATE

You left food on your plate, and a Feasting Bailiff saw. He has a funnel and a ladle of office. He is gentle about it. Eat a full meal now (Taint 1 Hunger) or pay a 5-lack fine. Unfed who are fed by the funnel lose 1d6 Flesh to cramps and gain no Want: it was not refused.

LACK · FATLANDS · 26



TEETH IN THE BREAD

The loaf bites back. Take 1 damage and gain Taint 1 Hunger. Gut + Feast (Routine 10) or a tooth of yours chips on a tooth of its own: -1 Tongue for a week. A miller in the next village will pay 1 lack for whichever tooth is left in the crust.

LACK · FATLANDS · 27



VOLUNTEER

A farmhand takes your place on the dusk shift, so you won't have to. He doesn't come back. The next week the Cullmaster sends you anyway, as he was always going to. Gain 2 Fray. You have one dusk shift to work, in the far field, before you leave the Fatlands.

LACK · FATLANDS · 28



THE GROUND FLINCHES

The field gives under your boot, warm, and closes. Lung + Athletics (Hard 14) or you are held to the knee, as though Grappled, until dug free. The soil chews, very slowly: 1 damage a round, ignoring Armor. Your boot is not coming back.

LACK · FATLANDS · 29



ORIGIN STAMPED TWICE

The meat in front of you, or in your pack, has a birthmark you know. Dread 3. If you have already eaten some, the Carver tells you how it tasted, and it was good. Taint 2 Hunger. Unfed: an Invitation check at Hard (14), because it smells like home.

LACK · FATLANDS · 30



THE SCARECROW IS CLOSER

Away in the far field, a scarecrow stands with its back to you. Nobody put it up. Keep this card. Each further Lack you suffer this session, it is one field closer. On the third, it has turned round. The Carver decides what that means, and does not tell you first.

BRINEHOLLOW



Tally for Low Tilth, Carving, 640: the Ames boy, Widow Coll, two of the Pratt girls, the man who came about the roof. Tally for Carving, 641: I have stopped writing them in pairs.

PELL HOGGET'S TALLY, AS COPIED IN SALLET
BOTTOM



LACK · BRINEHOLLOW · 31



SALT IN THE THROAT

Your tide comes early, mid-word. Lose your next action coughing up a pint of cold brine and something small that wriggles. Outsiders: you taste salt for the first time, and from now on you will taste it every morning on waking.

LACK · BRINEHOLLOW · 32



THE ROPE WAS CUT

You wake ankle-deep in cold water, facing west, and your sleeping-rope is on the floor behind you with a clean end. Make a Calling roll at Hard (14). If nobody in the company woke with you, at Grim (18). Find out who cut it. It may have been you.

LACK · BRINEHOLLOW · 33



TWO VOICES

Someone you trust answers you in two tones at once, and the lower one finishes first. Dread 2. They do not notice. Nobody can tell you whether they were always like this, and asking is the rudest thing you can do on the coast.

LACK · BRINEHOLLOW · 34



INDOOR TIDE

Water comes up the cellar stair at the wrong hour and goes back down with something of yours. Lose one item you had set down: a map, a weapon, a lamp, a letter. The water leaves kelp, and a bail-bucket that is not yours, with a name burned in the bottom.

LACK · BRINEHOLLOW · 35



WHERE DID YOU GO?

You asked a Returned where they went, or you remarked on how someone breathes. The room goes silent: -4 to every Tongue roll here for the scene. The Returned answers you, courteously, in full. Dread 2, and tonight you dream of the Trench draining.

LACK · BRINEHOLLOW · 36



PRESSURE DAY

The air thickens until it creaks. Ears pop, then bleed. Windows bow inward. -2 to every roll for the scene for anyone without Lung-line blood. One window or bottle that matters to you bursts. Your nose bleeds salt.

THE VIGIL



I have pulled three hundred off the shingle. Every one of them looked back along the rope at me the same way. As if I had interrupted grace.

LIEUTENANT SABLE REEF OF THE NETWATCH



LACK · VIGIL · 37



CAUGHT YAWNING

You yawn, wide, in public. It goes round the street like a rumour. **Everyone in sight** rolls **Caul + Resolve (Routine 10)** or gains 1 **Weariness**. A Waker wants your name: pay 2 lacks or take the needle (1 damage, -2 **Weariness**, and a record).

LACK · VIGIL · 38



COMFORTABLE

The chair is soft. The room is warm. Somebody is telling a long, kind story, and the rain on the roof is too quiet. Gain 2 **Weariness** and make a blink check now.

LACK · VIGIL · 39



ON THE RECORD

The whole street sees something of you: you with blood to the elbows, you laying a table, you without eyes. It goes on the public record as news. Until it is disproven (a long task, 4 **Helpings**, **Tongue + Clause**), you are wanted for it. Mirela Sconce would like an interview.

LACK · VIGIL · 40



YOUR NUDGER NODS

The one keeping you awake, or the one you are keeping awake, is gone behind the eyes for a breath too long. Rouse them: **Hand + Brawl** or **Tongue + Intimidate (Hard 14)**. Fail, and they go under. A Dormitory porter arrives before the next bell with a stretcher and a number.

LACK · VIGIL · 41



THE HOUR IS LONGER

This hour is longer than the last one was. Ask the clocks. **Everything in this scene with a time limit** (a **Bill**, a bleeding wound, a dose of rouse, a fuse, a tide) advances one extra step.

LACK · VIGIL · 42



BED NUMBER

A Dormitory clerk presses a slip into your hand. A bed number. Nobody will say who reserved it. Keep this card: -1 to all blink checks while you carry it. Throw the slip away and it is back in your pocket at the next bell.

CRADLEWRACK


Pinch me.

THE VIGIL'S MARRIAGE VOW, ENTIRE



LACK · CRADLEWRACK · 43



THE DOOR WAS OPEN

Every door you shut this scene is open now, and you did not hear one of them go. **Something came through. The Carver chooses what is on your side of it, and whether it has been named.**

LACK · CRADLEWRACK · 44



YOUR SEAM OPENS

An old scar parts along the stitch, neat as a purse. **Lose 2 Flesh and bleed 1 a round until stitched (Hand + Stitching, Hard 14).** If you have no scars, you have one now, somewhere you cannot see without a mirror, and it is the shape of a mouth.

LACK · CRADLEWRACK · 45



REHEARSAL

The cramp folds you double: false labour, whoever and whatever you are. **Lose your next action and 1 Flesh. Strangers congratulate you. Somebody sends for a midwife, who comes with her apron and her knife.**

LACK · CRADLEWRACK · 46



FOUND PART

Something warm has crawled into your pack: a hand, an ear, a length of spine that curls when lifted. It will not be put down. **Keep this card. Assemblers will pay well; its mother would kill you for it. It holds your finger at night: Dread 1 on waking, each morning.**

LACK · CRADLEWRACK · 47



EARLY PANG

The ground contracts days before it should. **Everyone rolls Lung + Athletics (Hard 14) or falls prone. Roll for reopened wounds as at any pang. The room you are in has one more door than it had.**

LACK · CRADLEWRACK · 48



THE FIRST QUESTION

A midwife looks you up and down and asks it aloud: "What is it?" **Until you answer to her satisfaction (Tongue + Persuade, Grim 18), an apron and a knife called the Second Opinion follow you. Children do not knock before looking at you.**

OATHEN



First we ask what it is. Then we ask whether it stays.

THE MIDWIFE'S TWO QUESTIONS



LACK · OATHEN · 49



ECHO

Your last sentence comes back off the canyon wall. Twice. If it was a promise, it binds at +1 Weight. If it was not, the rock makes it one: the Carver rephrases it as a vow, at Weight 1, and it is yours.

LACK · OATHEN · 50



TALKATIVE

Somebody calls you talkative, in public, in Tacit. -2 Tongue in this town for the session. A Clausewright reviews everything you said today and finds one sentence that binds. The Carver picks it. Weight 1.

LACK · OATHEN · 51



HANDTALK SNAPS

A sign you made with your hands, idly, counted. One finger breaks with a sound like a dry twig: -1 Hand for fine work for two weeks. Nobody in Oathen will shake that hand. Mirren Osk would understand.

LACK · OATHEN · 52



MISCUT

A scribe writes down what you said, and miscuts it by one word. Writing is not supposed to count. The Carver chooses the word. Caul + Resolve (Hard 14): on a failure, it binds, at Weight 1, exactly as written.

LACK · OATHEN · 53



NAMED SURETY

By a clerk's slip, you are surety for a stranger's oath. You have never met him. He has a weak face. Until a long task clears it (3 Helpings, Tongue + Clause), if he breaks, so do you, at Weight 2, wherever you are.

LACK · OATHEN · 54



OVER MY DEAD BODY

You used a figure of speech. The Carver chooses the one you said ("I could eat a horse", "I'd kill for a drink", "I'll be right back") and the god takes it literally, at Weight 1. In the Course, at Weight 3.

THE FAST



Say less.

THE WHOLE OF OATHEN'S LAW, AS TAUGHT TO CHILDREN



LACK · FAST · 55



COME IN

A voice from a lit window, warm, tired, glad: “Come in.” Everyone who hears it makes an Invitation check at Grim (18); Godeaters roll Caul + Resolve the same. A failure is a step toward the door. The door is open. The bread is warm.

LACK · FAST · 56



SMELL OF BREAD

The wind turns, and smells of a kitchen. Walk into the wind, as the rule says, and lose the day’s travel; or make an Invitation check at Routine (10). The Unfed in the company look at you as if you had said something filthy.

LACK · FAST · 57



ACCEPTED ON THE FIRST

Without thinking, you took what was offered the first time it was offered: a cup, a coat, a seat by the fire. –4 Tongue with the Unfed for the session. Wanting will sell you nothing until you have publicly refused three things, three times each.

LACK · FAST · 58



THE HEARTH WAS LIT

You walked into a house where the hearth was already lit. The door is still open behind you. Dread 2. When you turn, there is a table, laid for exactly as many of you as there are, and one more.

LACK · FAST · 59



WARM GROUND

The frost is melted in a long stoop-shouldered track. The Host passed here within the hour. Lose 1 Pang or 1 Hunger: it feels like kindness. Every Invitation check you make for the rest of the day is at +2 Difficulty.

LACK · FAST · 60



THE CHALK CROSS

Someone has chalked a small cross between your shoulders: the Blank trade’s mark. Unfed and Blanks: a poacher tries to take you tonight, alive, and has brought good food for the road. Godeaters: they think you are carrying one, and will look.

THE KNIFE: COMBAT LACKS



No, thank you. No, thank you. No, thank you.

THE DECLINE, AS SAID AT EVERY UNFED DEATHBED

LACK · KNIFE · 61



STUCK IN THE BONE

It goes in, and it stays in: bone, a beam, a Kept man's ribs. Spend your next action wrenching it free (Gut + Labor, Hard 14) or fight empty-handed. If the one it is stuck in is still standing, they now have your weapon.

LACK · KNIFE · 62



BLOOD ON THE BREAD

The blow lands, hard and true, on someone you did not mean. Your attack hits the nearest bystander or ally instead, for full damage. If it is a stranger, they are somebody's kin, and the Carver will tell you whose.

LACK · KNIFE · 63



OVERREACH

You put your whole weight into it and the weight keeps going. The target makes a free attack against you at +2, now. If it hits, you are also prone.

LACK · KNIFE · 64



LOST GRIP

It flies from your hand, turning, and lands in the worst place in reach: a fire, the fen, a Laden's open mouth, a laid table. Your weapon is 1d6 paces away. To take it back from a table you must reach across a chair, and an Unfed must make an Invitation check to do it.

LACK · KNIFE · 65



YOUR OWN SWING

Your blade, your elbow, your own momentum, against your own body. Roll a d10 on the Mangling table and take the result yourself. The Carver narrates how you did it. Everyone who cares about you checks Dread 2.

LACK · KNIFE · 66



SLIPPED IN IT

Blood, brine, fat, gravy, something from the Sump. Down you go. You are prone. Until you wash, -2 to Stealth and Persuade, and dogs follow you down the street with great interest.

LACK · KNIFE · 67



IT BREAKS

The blade snaps, the haft splits, the string parts. The piece that came off is in someone. Your weapon is ruined. Roll a d6: on 1-3 the shard is in them, on 4-6 in you. 1 damage, ignoring Armor, and it will need cutting out.

LACK · KNIFE · 68



SOMEBODY'S MOTHER

In the crowd, a woman screams a name. It is the name of the one you are fighting. She is his mother. Anyone who strikes him again this fight makes a Dread 2 check first. If he falls, she comes for whoever did it.

LACK · KNIFE · 69



THE LAMP GOES OVER

Your swing, or your fall, takes the nearest light with it. Darkness at once. In 1d6 rounds, fire. In the Vigil, every Waker in the district is on the way, and they will blame whoever is still standing.

LACK · KNIFE · 70

THE FACE

For the first time, you see your enemy's face properly. They look like someone you love. Lose your next action and make a Dread 1 check. For the rest of the story you will see that face on every opponent you kill.

LACK · KNIFE · 71

THE TOOTH COMES UNINVITED

The god does not wait to be asked when there is blood. Roll a Tooth: it adds nothing, but you gain Hunger exactly as though you had Partaken, and suffer your land's bite on a 1. Unfed: gain 1 Pang.

LACK · KNIFE · 72

YIELDED TOO LATE

He drops his weapon and goes to his knees, begging, as your blow is already falling. Hand + Blades (Hard 14) to pull it. Fail, and it lands: full damage, and a Mangling if he lives. His friends will not check morale again this fight. They have seen what you are.

◇
A man on his knees is still a man. Remember that, after. You'll have time.

ABATE KELL, TABLEBREAKER, TO A YOUNGER AXE

ROLLING THE LACK

For groups without printed cards, roll for the Lack instead and read the card of that number in the lists above. Seventy-two is a d6 and a d12 together, read like a clock: the **d6 picks a band of twelve cards**, and the **d12 picks the card within it**. The card's number is $(d6 - 1) \times 12 + d12$: a 3 on the d6 and a 5 on the d12 is card 29, *Origin Stamped Twice*. (With a d8 and a d10 on hand, the arithmetic is worse; use the d6 and d12.)

D6	CARDS	WHAT FALLS THERE
1	01–12	General
2	13–24	General (13–18); Sallowreach (19–24)
3	25–36	The Fatlands (25–30); Brinehollow (31–36)
4	37–48	The Vigil (37–42); Cradlewrack (43–48)
5	49–60	Oathen (49–54); the Fast (55–60)
6	61–72	The Knife (combat only)

The full d72 obeys the same rules as the deck: if the number falls on a card that is not in play (another land's card, or a Knife card outside a fight), roll again. Faster, roll only what is in play:

- ◇ **In a fight, on an attack or defense:** roll a d12 and read cards 61 to 72.
- ◇ **Anywhere else, in a land:** roll a d6 and a d12. On a d6 of 1–3, read the general card numbered the same as the d12 (01–12). On

4–6, a d12 of 1–6 reads general cards 13–18 in order, and a d12 of 7–12 reads the land's six cards in order (7 is its first card, 12 its last).

- ◇ **On the Rim Road, between lands:** roll a d6 and a d12 as above, and on 4–6 with a d12 of 7–12, roll again.

A rolled card that is already on the Plate this session (keep a tally on scrap paper) is rolled again, as the deck would have it.

▼ THE GRACE DECK

Forty-eight gold cards. They are beautiful, and every one of them is a little wrong, because on the Table kindness usually is. Twelve fall anywhere; four belong to each land; eight are for the Knife. A Guest

may refuse any of them, as the rules above allow, and the Unfed are paid in Want for doing it.

THE GENERAL GRACES



GRACE · 01



MAY YOU FINISH

What you did is done, wholly and for good, as things were done before the Gorging. It cannot come undone: the lock stays locked, the wound stays closed, the argument is over, even in Cradlewrack. In Sallowreach a stranger weeps with envy and offers you 1d6 lacks to touch them.

GRACE · 02



ALMOST FULL

The next meal you eat is right. Not good: right. Remove 1d6 Hunger (Unfed: 1 Pang) and heal 2 Flesh. You will compare every meal for the rest of your life to this one, and every one will lose.

GRACE · 03



WANTED TO BELIEVE

They want to believe you, and so they do, entirely. The one you are dealing with believes what you said and will defend it to others for the rest of the story. If it was a lie, they will learn the truth one day. They will not be angry. Only sad.

GRACE · 04



THE LOCK WAS NEVER LOCKED

The guard was asleep. The page was already turned. The door was on the latch. Gain one extra Helping. Ask the Carver who left it open for you. She does not have to answer, and if she smiles, do not ask again.

GRACE · 05



A FACE REMEMBERED

Someone here will remember your face, kindly, for the rest of their life. Once, later, they help you without being asked, at exactly the right moment. It costs them something terrible, and you hear about it afterward.

GRACE · 06



THE HOUSE STANDS YOU A DRINK

A stranger at the next table raises a cup to you. You have never seen them. They know your name. Gain one extra Helping, and the next Guest to roll this scene adds +2. The drink is paid for. Do not ask by whom.

GRACE · 07



THE GOD TURNS OVER

The thing in your blood sighs, turns over, and sleeps. Remove 2 Hunger. For the rest of the scene, Partaking costs no Hunger and no Tooth bites. The next time you Partake after the scene, roll one more Tooth than you meant to. It woke hungry.

GRACE · 08



ORDINARY DECENCY

You see a stranger do a plain kind thing for no reason at all: a widow feeding a neighbour's children, a guard looking away. Remove 1d6 Fray. You will try to repay it. The Carver will make sure you cannot.

GRACE · 09



AS THOUGH EXPECTED

The flies part. The crowd parts. The rain parts. Doors are held. +2 to Stealth and Athletics for the scene, and nobody stops you. Dogs lower their heads as you pass. Somewhere, a place has been set for you, and everything here knows it.

GRACE · 10



AND SOMETHING BESIDES

You learn what you came for, and one thing more, true and unasked, about someone at this table. Gain one true answer. Then the Carver tells you, privately, a secret belonging to another Guest or a trusted NPC. You may never use it. You will never forget it.

GRACE · 11



CLEAN HANDS

No blood. No witness. No mark a Cutwright can read. Nobody will ever connect you with what you just did. Not even you: from now on, when you remember it, the hands are somebody else's.

GRACE · 12



LACK KEEP AWAY (SAID)

You said the grace, properly, and it held. For the rest of the session you know which food is safe. Once, cancel a Taint or a poison you swallow. Then you notice the plate beside yours: empty, clean, and warm.

SALLOWREACH



On the Table, a good day is one where you do not find out what it cost until tomorrow.

RIM ROAD PROVERB



GRACE · SALLOWREACH · 13



A STEADY LIGHT

A Tallow candle, made of somebody, gives you its light. +2 to Search for the session. It whispers the name of anyone hiding inside its glow. It does not want to go out. When it gutters at the end, it thanks you, and you recognise the voice.

GRACE · SALLOWREACH · 14



THE SHELF REMEMBERS

A woman shelved on the ninth storey heard everything, and tells you through the wrapping. Gain one true answer from the Carver. She asks you to come back and read to her. If you do not, she tells someone else something about you.

GRACE · SALLOWREACH · 15



THE UNLICENSED MERCY

For one breath, the Closing Hand is in yours. Once, now, you may let one Kept person finish: they go still, with a sigh, properly dead. It is a crime against the Court. Their family will love you, owe you and report you, in that order.

GRACE · SALLOWREACH · 16



SEWN RIGHT

The thread pulls through clean and the skin lies down like it was waiting. Heal 1d6 Flesh and stop one bleeding wound. The stitching is so fine that a Seamer asks to buy the scar, when you are finished with it.

THE FATLANDS



May you finish.

THE POLITE GREETING OF THE NORTH



GRACE · FATLANDS · 17



YOU LOOK HEAVY

Everyone who sees you today thinks you look heavy, which is to say beautiful. +2 Tongue with Fatlanders for the session. A Gut-line household sends a dinner invitation, gilt-edged. Declining it would be sedition.

GRACE · FATLANDS · 18



THE FIELD KNOWS YOUR NAME

You thanked the field by name, and it was the right name. The next time the Reaping would take you, it takes someone else. You will learn whom, at their wake, from the menu.

GRACE · FATLANDS · 19



THE HONEST CUT

You know, by smell and grain, exactly what this meat was. **If it was beast, eat it and heal 2 Flesh.** If it was not, you know whose it was, and you are spared tasting them. The Carver tells you which.

GRACE · FATLANDS · 20



FRUIT WITH A BONE PIT

An orchard tree lowers a branch to you, a fruit at the end of it, skinned and fat and warm. **Eat it: remove all Pangs or 1d6 Fray, and gain Taint 1 Hunger.** It is the best thing you have ever tasted, and it has a face, if you look.

BRINEHOLLOW



You look heavy, sister. You look so heavy.

THE KINDEST THING ONE FATLANDER CAN SAY TO ANOTHER



GRACE · BRINEHOLLOW · 21



SLACK WATER

For one tide the sea in you lies still. Until next dawn you need not bail and are immune to the Calling. You dream of a stone table far out on the seabed, and the chairs around it, all pushed in but one.

GRACE · BRINEHOLLOW · 22



FATHOM SENSE

You feel the depth of everything: water, wounds, lies. +2 to Search and Instinct for the scene, and you may ask one question about what lies beneath this place. The answer comes as pressure in your ears.

GRACE · BRINEHOLLOW · 23



A ROPE THROWN

Someone throws you a rope at the right moment: Netwatch, Wreckwife, a stranger with a boathook. You are pulled clear of whatever had you. They want nothing for it. They look at you the way they look at all the Called.

GRACE · BRINEHOLLOW · 24



THE TENANT'S COURTESY

A Tenanted person, calm and fair, offers help: a ruling, a secret of the Uncovered, safe passage. It is sincere. Gain the help. It asks, very politely, for the use of your left arm for one afternoon, someday. Saying yes is optional. Remembering is not.

THE VIGIL



The sea is not going out. It is going in.

THE LOWMARK TIDE-POST



GRACE · VIGIL · 25



PINCH ME

A stranger pinches your wrist at exactly the right moment, and stays. **Remove 3 Weariness.** They nudge you through the night unasked and leave at dawn without a word. You will look for them. You will not find them.

GRACE · VIGIL · 26



THE SEEMING AGREES

The street sees what you want it to: you as a Waker, a saint, nobody. **Gain one extra Helping** on a deception this scene, and it goes into the public record as news, which makes it true until disproven.

GRACE · VIGIL · 27



ROUSE THAT HOLDS

The dose takes, clean and bright. **Gain no Weariness this watch or the next, and +2 Eye** for the watch: every thread in a coat, every flicker in a face. All day your heartbeat is loud enough for others to hear.

GRACE · VIGIL · 28



THIRTY PACES

In a blink you are in the long room, close to the wall, and back. **Gain one true answer:** a name, a direction, a word from behind the lid. The eye did not open. You are sure the eye did not open.

CRADLEWRACK



*Rain on a roof is the most dangerous sound in the city.
Build in tin.*

BENEDIKT LOUR, THE ARCHITECT



GRACE · CRADLEWRACK · 29



THE DOOR HELD

A door you shut stays shut till dawn. Here. Everyone inside rests properly: double Flesh healed overnight, and 1 Fray removed. In the morning there are small handprints on the outside of the door, at every height.

GRACE · CRADLEWRACK · 30



FIRST BREATH

Something begins again. Try one failed task again at once, at +2. Somewhere in the highlands tonight, something is born with your face. The Tally will list it, under your mother's name.

GRACE · CRADLEWRACK · 31



BOTH QUESTIONS

A birth you witness goes right: "A child," and "Yes." Every witness removes 1d6 Fray. The child's first word, said clearly and at once, is your name.

GRACE · CRADLEWRACK · 32



THE HAND HOLDS YOURS

A small warm Part takes your finger and leads. +2 to Search and Wayfaring for the scene, and it always knows the way out. It does not let go when the scene ends. You will have to decide something about it.

OATHEN



Knock first. It isn't for you.

CRADLEWRACK MANNERS, TO VISITORS



GRACE · OATHEN · 33



THE GOOD CLAUSE

Your words had an exit in them you never put there. **One promise you have made, of any Weight, gains a condition the Carver drafts in your favour.** A Clausewright who hears of it offers to buy the phrasing.

GRACE · OATHEN · 34



BELIEVED

Everyone here believes you, completely, because here everything said is so. **+4 to your next Persuade or Deceive roll in Oathen.** If it was a lie, it is now carved on the Ledger, and will be there when the cliff falls.

GRACE · OATHEN · 35



A DROP OF THE KEPT RAIN

From a hard white sky, one drop, on your face. **Remove 1d6 Fray and heal 2 Flesh.** Somebody saw it. The Rainwarden would like a word, in writing, about why it chose you.

GRACE · OATHEN · 36



THE CANYON DOES NOT ANSWER

No echo. For the rest of the scene nothing you say binds unless you mean it to. **Speak freely, once in your life.** Afterward the quiet feels like a mouth that has closed on you.

THE FAST



If able. As I now intend. Barring death, illness or weather. Yes.

SORRIN VAEL, CHIEF CLAUSEWRIGHT, ACCEPTING A CUP OF WATER



GRACE · FAST · 37



NO, THANK YOU

Your refusal is heard, and accepted. Gain 2 Want (Godeaters: remove 2 Hunger). The table you did not sit at folds itself away, like a host who understands. Next time it will have learned your favourite dish.

GRACE · FAST · 38



A CRUST REPLACED

Good bread, warm, on the sill where you left none. Eat it: remove all Pangs (Godeaters: 1d6 Hunger). It is not Tainted. That is the frightening part. Eating what you did not carry breaks the third rule; the Unfed will know.

GRACE · FAST · 39



THE WARM TRACK

You find where the Host has walked, and where it is walking. You avoid it for the rest of the session without a roll. Once, at the edge of sight, something tall stops on a hill and waits for you to catch up. You do not.

GRACE · FAST · 40



THE BLANK CARD

Tonight's place card has no name on it. Every Invitation check you make this session is at -4 Difficulty. Tomorrow there will be a name on it, and you will know them.

THE KNIFE: COMBAT GRACES



If a chair is pulled out for you, do not thank it.

THE FIFTH RULE OF THE FAST

GRACE · KNIFE · 41



THROUGH THE JOINT

Your blade finds the gap the way a Renderer's does, without looking. **Add one extra Helping**, and choose the Mangling instead of rolling it. Butchers who see it nod. You dream of the sound.

GRACE · KNIFE · 42



THEY YIELD

Your enemy drops the weapon and begs, and the rest lose the stomach for it. **Every enemy** checks morale now, at Grim (18). The one on his knees calls you by name and asks after your mother.

GRACE · KNIFE · 43



THE BLOW TURNED

It strikes a buckle, a bone button, a little book in your coat. **Ignore the damage from the next hit** against you this fight. Afterward, look at what stopped it. It was a gift from someone dead.

GRACE · KNIFE · 44



SEEN COMING

You see the next blow before its owner has thought of it. **+4 Guard** until your next turn, and a free attack on anyone who misses you. The god in you is enjoying this, and you can feel it enjoying it.

GRACE · KNIFE · 45



THE LIGHT BEHIND YOU

Every lamp in the room is suddenly at your back. **Enemies suffer -2 to attack you** this round and the next, and you see every face clearly. You will see them all again tonight, when you close your eyes.

GRACE · KNIFE · 46



SECOND WIND

Breath comes back into you, sweet. **Heal 1d6 Flesh** and ignore Bloodied for the rest of the fight. Your breath smells of fresh bread. Someone across the room turns to look.

GRACE · KNIFE · 47



A CLEAN STROKE

If this blow kills, it kills quickly and well, as every killing should. **No Dread** check for the kill, no Stain, no Pall in any watching crowd. The dead face is peaceful. That bothers everyone more than blood would.

GRACE · KNIFE · 48



INTO THE WORSE THING

Your enemy stumbles back into the fire, the fen, the Hush, the crowning, the laid table. **As a free Cast Into**, with no roll. Whatever is down there is grateful, and remembers who sent it dinner.

◇
A good blow is a gift. Mind who it is from.

PURGATION TRACT, NAILED TO A WAYSTATION DOOR

ROLLING THE GRACE

Forty-eight is a d4 and a d12, read the same way as the Lack: the **d4 picks a band of twelve**, the **d12 the card within it**, and the card's number is $(d4 - 1) \times 12 + d12$. A 2 on the d4 and a 9 on the d12 is card 21, *Slack Water*. With no d4, roll a d6 and reroll 5s and 6s; or roll a d6 and a d8 and read $(d6 - 1) \times 8 + d8$, which gives the same 48 by a different road.

D4	CARDS	WHAT FALLS THERE
1	01–12	General
2	13–24	Sallowreach (13–16); the Fatlands (17–20); Brinehollow (21–24)
3	25–36	The Vigil (25–28); Cradlewrack (29–32); Oathen (33–36)
4	37–48	The Fast (37–40); the Knife (41–48, combat only)

As with the Lack, reroll any number that is not in play, or roll only what is:

- ◇ **In a fight, on an attack or defense:** roll a d8 and read cards 41 to 48.
- ◇ **Anywhere else, in a land:** roll a d6 and a d8. On a d6 of 1–3, read general card 01–08 by the d8. On 4–6, a d8 of 1–4 reads

general cards 09–12 in order, and 5–8 reads the land's four cards in order.

- ◇ **On the Rim Road, between lands:** roll a d12 and read the general cards alone.

A Grace refused is still a Grace served. Put its number on the tally with the rest.

CHAPTER 10

THE HUNGER, PALL, TABLENIGHT AND MARKET DECKS

Shuffle it, love. It's all been dealt before. You're only finding out the order.

— A CARD-SHARP AT THE FULL MEASURE, GRISTMOOT, TO A BRINEHOLLOW
PILOT WHO ASKED WHAT HE WAS PLAYING



Four decks follow. Each one replaces a moment at the table where the Carver would otherwise reach for a d10 table and read out a line: the moment a Guest's god takes a step forward, the moment a village fails its Turn, the long night of Tablenight, and the moment a purse opens at a stall nobody has vouched for. A card is a better instrument for these moments than a die, for one reason. A card can be handed across the table. The player holds it, reads it, keeps it, and

it stays on their side of the table for the rest of the campaign, face-up beside the character sheet, where everyone can see what the god did.



*Every land is certain its own luck is honest. Every
land has a deck it doesn't let strangers cut.*

RIM ROAD SAYING

USING THE DECKS

None of these cards replaces a roll. The Grace Roll still decides whether a Guest succeeds, the Turn still decides whether a village holds, Hunger still fills at 10. The cards tell you *what it means*: what the body did, what the village did, what the night brought, what the stall was really selling. Where a card gives a rules effect it is in **bold**, and it uses the numbers of the core rules exactly: Difficulties of Routine 10, Hard 14, Grim 18, Dire 22 and Impossible 26; Dread ratings 1 to 5; Hunger, Regrowth, Fray, Pall, Steadiness, Hold, Want and Pangs as the Rules chapter and the land chapters define them.

- ◇ **The Hunger Deck** is seventy cards, ten for each of the seven lands. A Guest draws one each time Hunger fills and Regrowth rises. It is kept.
- ◇ **The Pall Deck** is thirty-six cards in three bands of twelve. The Carver draws one each week a community fails its Turn.
- ◇ **The Tablenight Deck** is thirty cards. It comes out of the box once a year, at dusk on the longest night of Lack, and goes back in at dawn.
- ◇ **The Market Deck** is thirty-six cards. The Carver draws one, in secret, when a Guest buys from a stall nobody can vouch for.

DECK	CARDS	DRAWN BY	WHEN	KEPT?
Hunger	70	The player	Regrowth rises	Yes, for good
Pall	36	The Carver	A failed Turn	Until the event ends
Tablenight	30	Both	Dusk to dawn, Tablenight only	Until dawn
Market	36	The Carver, secretly	A doubtful purchase	Until it betrays you

No cards? Every deck below is printed in order, so it doubles as a table. For the Hunger Deck roll a d10 down the land's ten cards, rerolling any the Guest already holds. For the Pall Deck roll a d12 down the community's band. For the Tablenight Deck roll a d10 and a d6: on a d6 of 1–2 read the d10 against the first ten cards, 3–4

the second ten, 5–6 the last ten. For the Market Deck roll a d6 and a d6 and read them as tens and units of a number from 11 to 66, counting down the thirty-six cards in order: 11–16 are the first six cards, 21–26 the next six, and so on to 61–66. Cross off what is used. Cards are better. Players remember a thing they were handed.

▼ PRINTING THE DECKS

The card pages are laid out three to a row. Print them on the heaviest card stock your printer will take (250 gsm or more), single-sided, and cut along the gutters. Each card is sized to fit a standard poker sleeve (63 × 88 mm), and sleeving is recommended for the Hunger Deck, which will be handled for years and will, in most groups, end up with gravy on it.

Give each deck its own back so they cannot be mixed in a hurry. The suggested backs, if you draw or print your own, are these:

- ◇ **Hunger:** a white plate on black, with a single bite out of the rim.
- ◇ **Pall:** a row of roofs against a grey sky, every chimney cold.
- ◇ **Tablenight:** a chair, seen from behind, turned to face a wall.

- ◇ **Market:** a lack coin, shut-mouth face, with the little crack at the corner of the lips.

Print the Hunger Deck's seven land sections on seven tints of card if you can (fen-green, wheat-gold, slate-blue, lamp-amber, clay-red, canyon-ochre, and for the Fast a clean, pressed white), so that a player can find their land's stack by colour. Keep each Guest's drawn Hunger cards in a small envelope clipped to their sheet between sessions. When a Guest is Seated, give the player the envelope. Some groups bury it. One group known to the authors bakes it into a loaf at the wake session and nobody eats the slice with the card in it, and nobody throws it away either.

CARVER'S ADVICE: THE CARD IS NOT A VERDICT

A drawn card is a suggestion with authority, not a law. If a Hunger card describes a change that collides with something already established (a Guest who has lost the hand the card would grey), move the change to the nearest part that makes sense, keep the rules effect, and say so out loud. If a Pall card names a figure the community does not have (a Celebrant in a village with no chapel), give the role to whoever holds it in fact: the midwife, the oldest man, the Netwatch sergeant. If a Market card does not fit what was bought, hold it back and play it on the next purchase that it does fit. The only thing a Carver should never do with a card is soften what it says the god does. The god does not soften.

▼ THE HUNGER DECK

It doesn't come back the same way twice. That's how you know it's alive. Dead things repeat.

– DR. HALLORAN QUEASE, CATALOGUE ENTRY NO. 402

The Rules chapter says it plainly: when Hunger reaches 10, Regrowth rises by 1, Hunger empties, and *something in the body is different now, and it does not change back*. The Hunger Deck is that something. It turns the most important moment a Guest will have in a session into a physical object, dealt from the god's own stack, and it makes every Guest of the same land different from every other. Two Sallowreachers at the Course both have grey hands. Only one of them has no smell, and only the other has Kept following her to market.

DRAWING

- ◆ **When Hunger fills and Regrowth rises**, stop play. The player shuffles their land's ten cards, minus any they already hold, and draws one. They read it aloud. The Carver describes it happening, now, at the table, in the scene. Let it breathe.
- ◆ **The change is permanent**. The card goes face-up beside the character sheet and stays there. Its rules effect applies from this moment until the Guest is Seated. Nothing on the Table reverses it. (A Purger's Grace that rolls Regrowth back by one does not return the card; the god takes a step back, and leaves its footprint.)
- ◆ **A Guest never draws the same card twice**. Ten cards are exactly enough for ten steps, from the first rise of the Taste to the last rise of the Brink. A Scrapling who begins at Regrowth 0 takes their first step into the Taste without a card, showing only the land's Taste tell from its chapter. If a Guest ever reaches for the stack and finds it empty, they are at Regrowth 11, the Carver has already told them so, and the next time Hunger fills there will be no card. There will be the Seating.
- ◆ **Stage scales the description, never the rules**. The cards are not stages. The stage says how far the god has come; the card says where it came through *this* time. A Guest at the Taste who draws a Course-looking card has the first, small, deniable version of it (a knuckle, not a hand; a cupful in the lungs, not a cistern), and it will grow at every stage that follows. A Guest at the Brink who

draws a Taste-looking card has it as the god's afterthought, total and at once. The rules effect is the same either way.

- ◆ **Foreign points**. When Taint from another land's god gives a Guest a point of foreign Regrowth (see the Rim Market), they draw from *that land's* stack instead of their own, and mark the card *foreign*. Two gods are now leaving marks on one body. The Carver may spend a foreign card, once per session, to make it flare for a scene.
- ◆ **The Returned** (Unfed who have eaten a god) draw from the stack of the land whose god they ate. Their Regrowth rises by 2 each time Hunger empties: they draw two cards, and the second is always the worse, by the player's own judgment, read aloud.
- ◆ **The Unfed** have no Regrowth and draw from the Fast's ten cards on different triggers, given with that stack.

◆

I kept the cards in a tin. Nine of them. My wife counted them every night while I was asleep, which I never was, and I listened to her count, and when she got to nine she'd stop, and breathe, and put the lid on.

A HAND-LINE CLERK OF THE LOFTS, REGROWTH 10

THE HUNGER DECK AT THE TABLE

The best moments with this deck are quiet ones. Do not draw at the end of a session in a rush; draw at the moment it happens, mid-fight if need be, and pause the fight. Ask the player where the character feels it first. Ask who sees it. The other players should be invited to say what their Guests notice: it is in the companions' faces that the change becomes real. If the player wants to, let them hide the card, face-down beside the sheet, and play the Guest concealing it, until someone sees. The Carver always knows what it says. So, eventually, does everyone.

SALLOWREACH: OSSEL, THE CLOSING



Ossel comes back as an ending. Its marks are cold, grey, silent, and finished, and the Kept of the fen can smell every one of them.

Sallowreach Guests draw these ten.

HUNGER · SALLOWREACH  THE EXTRA JOINT In the night a finger grew. Your right forefinger has a new knuckle between the second joint and the nail, and it bends backward with a dry click like a beetle turning over. Rings will not fit. You slit your gloves. +1 Filch. Anyone who sees it flex makes a Dread 1 check.	HUNGER · SALLOWREACH  RINSED You stop smelling of anything. Sweat, soap, breath, the warm salt of a palm: gone. Your pillow smells rinsed, like air after snow. Flies cross the room rather than pass you. Dogs will not come. +1 Stealth against beasts. –1 Persuade with anyone who must sleep beside you; they cannot tell if you are there.	HUNGER · SALLOWREACH  THE LOW LID Your left eyelid grows cold and heavy and sits a fingerbreadth lower than the right, as if someone had begun to close it and been interrupted. It is the first part of you that is ready. You always know whether any eye within ten paces is open or shut, even in darkness. –1 to Search by sight.
HUNGER · SALLOWREACH  ASH NAILS Your nails go black from the root, thick and dull as horn, and stop growing. Where they scratch living skin they leave white lines that never redden. One tears off on a door; the bed beneath is smooth grey slate and does not bleed. Unarmed blows deal 2. Kept people flinch from your bare hands.	HUNGER · SALLOWREACH  THE SWALLOWED ENDING You reach the end of a sentence and the end is gone, and everyone listening has lost it too. It will happen again. Once per session the Carver may end something you are saying, and nobody will remember where it was going. Once per session you may do the same to someone else, by touch, without a roll or cost.	HUNGER · SALLOWREACH  THE FOOTSTEP IN THE CHEST Your heartbeat stops carrying. A Seamer laying an ear to your chest hears nothing, then, a long way off, one step, as of someone walking toward her who never arrives. Your pulse is a clock in an empty house. +1 Stealth. Anyone treating your wounds rolls at –2: they cannot tell if you are dying.
HUNGER · SALLOWREACH  GREY TO THE WRIST The grey crosses your wrist overnight like a tide-line. The skin above it is smooth, seamless, shining, and the lines of your palms are gone. Lastgate palmists say a palm with no lines is a life already finished. Your hands feel no heat: you will burn them without knowing, and the Carver will tell you when. +1 Rites to Close.	HUNGER · SALLOWREACH  THE PILE ON THE PILLOW Flies within an arm's length fall out of the air and do not get up. Each morning there is a small dry pile of them on your pillow, neat as swept ash. In Sallowreach, anyone who sees the pile knows what you are. Every Kept who learns of it will come, sooner or later, and ask you to finish them.	HUNGER · SALLOWREACH  THE FOLLOWING The Kept begin to follow you at a distance, the way starving dogs follow a butcher's cart. Each morning one more stands outside your door in the drizzle, smelling of the fen, holding its hat. In Sallowreach, 1d3 Kept attend you each day. They will carry, fetch and lie for you. Each dusk, one asks to be closed.

HUNGER · SALLOWREACH



WHAT NOBODY CALLS A SMILE

Your face smooths at the edges like a face seen through fog, and at rest your mouth curves very gently upward. You cannot feel it. In the mirror it looks content. **Anyone who watches you sleep makes a Dread 1 check.** +1 Intimidate. -1 Persuade when comforting the grieving; they know that look.

THE FATLANDS: UMMER, THE FIELD



Ummers come back as soil: warmth, appetite, roots, and things *heavy*, and some families clap. Fatlands Guests draw these ten. living in the folds. Fatlanders call every one of these cards *getting*

HUNGER · FATLANDS



THE NIGHT MOUTH

You wake chewing. The pillow-corner, a bootlace, the inside of your own cheek, scarred now into ridges like a ploughed field. You do not remember the dream, only the taste of soil. You may eat leather, wax, paper and tallow as food. Each morning the Carver names one small thing of yours that is gone.

HUNGER · FATLANDS



THE LOAM THUMB

The pad of your left thumb goes soft and cool and slightly granular. Press it and it crumbles at the surface, dark and moist, smelling of rain on a ploughed field, and fills slowly back from beneath. Your thumbprint no longer holds its shape: it is worthless on any Oathen note. Heal 1 extra Flesh after a night on bare soil.

HUNGER · FATLANDS



THE FIRST SHOOT

A pale green shoot uncurls from the crease of your elbow. Pluck it and it bleeds a bead of sweet sap and is back by morning. Washers say it is luck. They say it brightly. +1 Wayfaring to find food or water in any field. Bees find you: -1 Stealth outdoors in Plenty and Carving.

HUNGER · FATLANDS



THE WARM BED

Your body runs hot. Your bed is warm a full day after you leave it, and nothing kept under it spoils. Bread rises faster in your kitchen. Your companions sleep against you in Lack and do not say why. **Ignore the first night's cold penalty each week. Food carried on your body keeps one day longer.**

HUNGER · FATLANDS



THE BILL OF FARE

Your eyes begin to rest on people the way a cook reads a menu: the back of a farmhand's neck in the sun, a soft inner elbow reaching for the salt. It is not malice. It is older. **+1 Search to judge weight, weakness and wounds. -1 Persuade with anyone who catches you looking.**

HUNGER · FATLANDS



THE LODGER

Something lives in you now. An earthworm, pink and fat and slow, in the deep fold under your arm. When it is picked out you ask, politely, for it back. You eat it. There will be others. **Any lover or Seamer who finds them checks Dread 1. Once per session, eat what lives in you to remove 1 Hunger.**

HUNGER · FATLANDS



STRAW

Your hair coarsens overnight into something fibrous and dry and the colour of stubble, and it rustles when you turn your head. It will not take dye. It will not lie flat. Mice nest in the brush you leave on the sill. **-1 Stealth in silence. +1 Endure against cold.**

HUNGER · FATLANDS



THREADS

Pale threads, fine as hair, grow from the soles of your feet. Stand an hour on bare earth and they go down into it, and it feels like being tucked in. **You cannot be knocked prone while standing on soil. After an hour standing still on bare ground, leaving costs 1 Flesh or a Caul + Resolve roll at Routine.**

HUNGER · FATLANDS



SUNDAY SWEAT

You sweat a clear, sweet, faintly sticky fluid that smells of roasting and rising dough. Bees come. Flies come. Fatlanders breathe it in and smile and touch your arm. **+1 Persuade with Fatlanders, who think you smell like a Sunday. -2 Stealth against anyone with a nose.**

HUNGER · FATLANDS



THE NAMES IN THE FURROW

When you walk a Fatlands field at dusk you feel its pulse through your boots, and you know, without wanting to, the names of everyone Reaped into it. The wheat leans when you say them. **You learn the name of anyone Reaped into ground you cross. Each new name is 1 Fray the first time you hear it.**

BRINEHOLLOW: DROMM, THE DEPTH



Dromm comes back as weight and water and the patient pull of the west. Every mark is a little more of the deep moved into the house. Brinehollow Guests draw these ten.

HUNGER · BRINEHOLLOW



SALT AT THE CORNERS

Every morning there is a fine white crust at the corners of your mouth, as if you had slept on a beach in the wind. Your lips split and sting. Your kisses taste of the sea. +1 Endure against thirst. Anyone who kisses you hears surf in their sleep for a night.

HUNGER · BRINEHOLLOW



THE SLOSH

Your lungs have begun to keep a cupful. When you turn over in bed it shifts in your chest like a half-full cask rolled on a cart. The first breath after bailing makes you sick. Hold your breath one minute longer per point of Gut. -1 Athletics when running. Bailing takes twice as long.

HUNGER · BRINEHOLLOW



BLACK WATER EYES

Your pupils swell until there is almost no iris left, black and wet and deep, and in lamplight they shine green like a cat's. Children stare. Mirrors are unpleasant. See in dim light as if it were day. -1 to all rolls in strong sunlight or the lamplit streets of the Vigil.

HUNGER · BRINEHOLLOW



SKATE PLATES

A patch of grey skin, pebbled and cold as wet slate, spreads down your spine to the small of your back, raised like the plates of a skate. It cracks and weeps clear fluid if you go a day dry. +1 Endure against cold. Dry folk who see your back make a Dread 1 check.

HUNGER · BRINEHOLLOW



THE SECOND REGISTER

Your voice drops and gains an undertone, like a second speaker standing just behind you, a beat slow. It is worse in small rooms. It is worst when you say someone's name. +1 Intimidate. -2 Deceive: the two voices rarely agree.

HUNGER · BRINEHOLLOW



THE SHELL

You cough up a pink, whorled shell, small as a fingernail, and alive. It grew in the wall of your lung. Another is growing. Once a month you cough one up. Any Brinehollow Seamer who sees it knows your stage. Dr. Reave pays 5 lacks each and keeps them in a jar.

HUNGER · BRINEHOLLOW



WEED IN THE BATH

Your hair comes away in the basin in long dark ropes that drift on the water like weed. By the next season you are bald, and the scalp is grey and smooth. **Every Brinehollower knows the look: -1 Deceive about your stage with them. +1 Athletics when swimming.**

HUNGER · BRINEHOLLOW



THE WEIGHT

You are heavier than your size. Floorboards complain. Horses balk at you. Ferryman look at you, then at the waterline, and charge double. **+2 to resist being moved, knocked down or carried off. -1 Athletics. You sink in mud to the knee.**

HUNGER · BRINEHOLLOW



STILL RIBS

Your chest stops needing to rise. You take a breath when you remember, perhaps once a minute, and the stillness of your ribs is the thing people notice from across a room. **+1 Stealth. Dry folk who watch you for a minute make a Dread 1 check.**

HUNGER · BRINEHOLLOW



NORTH FOR A COMPASS

You hear your name in every silence, not as a memory but as a direction, the way a compass hears north. It is patient. It is kind. It is very old. **You always know which way the western sea lies. The West Want is one step harder to resist at dusk.**

THE VIGIL: ISS, THE REST



Iss comes back as rest, and rest in the Vigil is the enemy. Its marks are lids and yawns and lost seconds, and the slow terrible comfort

that makes the people around you lie down. Vigil Guests draw these ten.

HUNGER · VIGIL



THIN LIDS

Your eyelids go translucent. Shut them and the world is still there, dim and red, like a hand held to a lamp. You will never know true dark again. **+1 Instinct** against anything that comes while you rest. **Dread** checks against what is in front of you are one step harder.

HUNGER · VIGIL



THE BRUISE BENEATH

The skin under your eyes goes raw and purple from rubbing and will not heal; it cracks at the corners and weeps a little in the cold. On the Slope it is a badge. On the Rim, mothers pull children out of your way. **+1 Intimidate**. **–1 Persuade** with strangers outside the Vigil.

HUNGER · VIGIL



THE LONG YAWN

Your yawn goes too wide and too long. The jaw cracks out of its socket and clicks back, eyes streaming, and the yawn goes through the room like a rumour. You do not choose when. **Once per scene**, the Carver may make you yawn: everyone in earshot with **Weariness 3+** makes a **Routine Caul** + **Resolve** roll or gains 1 **Weariness**.

HUNGER · VIGIL



CLEAN LINEN

You smell of clean linen, always: starched, sun-dried, a bed just turned down. The Bedded turn their heads in the street. A Ward Sergeant sniffs, and holds out his hand for your blink-book. **+1 Persuade** with the Bedded and the exhausted. In the Vigil, the Watch stops you once a day.

HUNGER · VIGIL



LAID STRAIGHT

After every blink you find something near you laid very straight: a fork, a pen, a knife, its handle turned toward the nearest person. You never see yourself do it. **+1 Craft**: your hands are neat now. Anyone who notices the laid things checks **Dread 1**, and remembers.

HUNGER · VIGIL



THE LEFT LID GOES

Your left lid thins, then draws back over a season like a burnt page curling from its edge, and is gone. The eye is naked, wide and wet and permanently looking. **+1 Search**. That eye must be wetted every half hour or you suffer **–1** to all Eye rolls. You cannot wink, wince or weep on that side.

HUNGER · VIGIL



ONE NIGHT, PERFECTLY

You remember one night completely now, every second of it, every face, every sound: the worst one. It plays whenever you are still. **Once per session**, recall any detail of any scene you have witnessed, exactly. A night's rest removes no **Fray** from you unless someone holds your hand through it.

HUNGER · VIGIL



NUZZLING

You lean into warmth without deciding to: a bakehouse wall, a stove, the cheek of whoever is beside you, eyes half shut. In the Vigil it is grounds for divorce. **Gain 1 Weariness** whenever you touch something warm for a full minute. **+1 Persuade** with Fatlanders, who think it is sweet.

HUNGER · VIGIL



YOUR NUMBER

Behind your eyes, when they are open too long, you see rows of beds, numbered, warm, breathing. One is empty and has a number, and you know it. So, you suspect, does the Dormitory. **+1 Reckoning**. Write the number on your sheet. If you are ever Counted, that is your bed.

HUNGER · VIGIL



THE SLOW BREATH

Your breathing slows to the rhythm of the Dormitory, and the people around you start to breathe with it. Babies go quiet in your presence. Dogs lie down. +2 Persuade to calm the frightened. Anyone who shares a room with you for a night gains 1 Weariness.

CRADLEWRACK: VEY, THE OPENING



Vey comes back as beginning: pangs, waters, openings, things carried and things delivered. In any body, of any sex, at any age. Cradlewrack Guests draw these ten.

HUNGER · CRADLEWRACK



THE OLD SCAR OPENS

Your oldest scar goes pink, then lipped and moist, and at each pang it dilates a little and weeps clear salt water that smells of the springs. Seamers stitch it. By morning the gut has dissolved. It never closes. +1 Godsign. Anyone who sees it open makes a Dread 1 check.

HUNGER · CRADLEWRACK



THE INTERVAL

Cramps roll low in your belly in waves with gaps between, whatever you are, and you count them without wanting to. The gaps are getting shorter. **At the start of each session the Carver secretly sets your interval in hours. During a pang, -2 to all rolls for one round. +1 Instinct to feel a quake coming.**

HUNGER · CRADLEWRACK



THE WATERS

Once a week, without warning, a sudden warm flood of clear salt fluid from no clear source, soaking through your clothes and the chair and the boards. It smells of the springs. It is always at the worst time. **The Carver chooses when. -2 Persuade in polite company for the scene. You leave a trail.**

HUNGER · CRADLEWRACK



THE WIDENING

Your hips widen over a month. At night the bones of your pelvis groan apart like a door on old hinges, and your gait becomes the rolling walk of the eighth month. –1

Athletics. +1 Labor: you carry low and strong. Your clothes must be let out (3 lacks).

HUNGER · CRADLEWRACK



THE LATCH THREE ROOMS AWAY

You hear every latch in a house: lifting, catching, a door easing open three rooms away. You cannot sleep in a room whose door is shut unless someone else shut it. **+1 Search for hidden doors, hatches and compartments. A night behind a door you closed yourself is no rest.**

HUNGER · CRADLEWRACK



FIRST LINES

You begin things and cannot end them. Your pack fills with half-sewn shirts, first lines of letters, songs that stop at the turn. You set out on roads at dawn and come back by noon. **Once per session, reroll the first roll of any task. You can never make the last roll of a Long Task: someone else must finish it.**

HUNGER · CRADLEWRACK



CARRIED

Your belly hardens and swells for nine days. On the tenth you deliver, quickly and alone, a warm smooth stone with your own thumbprint in it. Highland law says the Attendance must be told. **While you carry the stone, +1 Endure. Throw it away and it is by your door at dawn.**

HUNGER · CRADLEWRACK



THE SECOND OPENING

A second opening, where the body has no business having one, low on the flank under the ribs: round, lipped, moist, and breathing. You keep it bandaged. **It hears: +1 Instinct to know if something living is beyond a wall. Anyone who unbandages it makes a Dread 2 check.**

HUNGER · CRADLEWRACK



THE GATHERING

You cannot throw away a piece of anything that was alive: nail parings, a pulled tooth, a cut-off braid. You keep them in a crock. In markets, Parts in their jars turn slowly toward you. **+1 Haggle when buying Parts. Any severed Part within ten paces moves toward you, by inches, when nobody watches.**

HUNGER · CRADLEWRACK



THE VOICE UNDERNEATH

Something inside you has begun to talk, in a small, earnest voice, about what it will do when it arrives: whom it will visit first, which doors it will open. **Once per session, ask it one question about anything beginning nearby; it answers truly. Each answer costs 1 Fray.**

OATHEN: TOLM, THE WITNESS



Tolm comes back as an ear and a tongue. Its marks are echoes, ringing, swearing, and a body that grows more ears than it needs.

Oathen Guests draw these ten.

HUNGER · OATHEN



THE CLERK BEHIND THE EAR

Everything you say comes back half a second late, close behind your ear, a little flatter, like a tired clerk reading it back for the record. You hear how it sounds. +1 Clause. In echoing places, any lie you tell comes back aloud for others to hear: -2 Deceive.

HUNGER · OATHEN



WET SLATE

Whenever a promise is made within earshot, even whispered, even in a language you do not speak, your mouth floods with the taste of wet slate and your back teeth ache. You know when anyone within earshot makes a promise. +1 Instinct to read intentions.

HUNGER · OATHEN



THE RINGING

Your ears ring when anyone near you lies. In a market it never stops. In a family it never stops. You learn to live in the high thin whine of it, the way millers live in the grinding. +2 to detect a lie spoken in your hearing. -1 to all Eye rolls in crowds.

HUNGER · OATHEN



SWORN IN SLEEP

You swear in your sleep. Whoever shares your room lies rigid and tries not to hear. You wake not knowing what you promised, or to whom, or on whose bones. Each session the Carver writes one Weight 1 oath you swore in the night, and reveals it when it binds.

HUNGER · OATHEN



THE LIVER TONGUE

Your tongue thickens and darkens, mottled the colour of raw liver, heavy and cool and faintly ridged, and rests against your teeth even in silence. The Bench's men measure your jaw with their eyes. +1 Intimidate. -1 Persuade: you lisp. A bit fits you now, and someone will offer one.

HUNGER · OATHEN



AN EAR AT THE WRIST

A pucker on the inside of your wrist opens over a week: pink, folded, perfectly formed. It turns toward voices. It weeps clear fluid when anyone near you makes a vow. +1 Search by hearing. Anyone who holds your hand makes a Dread 1 check; it turns toward their mouth.

HUNGER · OATHEN



THE UNDERVOICE

A second voice has grown beneath yours, half a step lower, and sometimes it says your next word a moment before you do. Sometimes it says a different one. **+1 Rites.** **Once per session the Carver may choose your next word for you, and you say it.**

HUNGER · OATHEN



FIGURES BITE

You said you were frozen and there was frost on your lashes. You said you could eat a horse and your companions watched you look at one. Your figures of speech have teeth. **Once per day the Carver may make one figure of speech you utter come true, in a small way. Witnesses check Dread 1.**

HUNGER · OATHEN



MOUTHING ALONG

You mouth other people's words as they say them, and you know how their sentences end before they do. It makes you unbearable at dinner. It makes you very good at the Bench. **+1 to oppose any Deceive. -1 Persuade: nobody likes being finished.**

HUNGER · OATHEN



THE WEIGHT IN THE THROAT

A pressure has settled behind your teeth, a heat in the throat like a sneeze held back, and only something heavy, said aloud and witnessed, eases it. **If a day passes without you swearing an oath of Weight 1 or more, gain 1 Hunger at dusk.**

THE FAST: ORRUM, THE HOST



The Unfed have no god in their blood, no Hunger track and no Regrowth. What they have is hunger itself, and a Host who has noticed. The Fast's ten cards are not the god coming through the body. They are the body paying for the Refusal, and Orrum taking note of the bill.

When the Unfed draw. An Unfed Guest draws one card from the Fast's stack the first time each story that their **Want reaches 10** (Hollow) and they survive the night of the laid table, and the first time in their life their **Pangs reach Wasting (7)**. The cards are

permanent, as all Hunger cards are. A Blank who has never eaten a god draws nothing; they have nothing to pay with and nobody keeping count. A Returned no longer draws from the Fast: the Host has struck them off its list.



Hunger is honest. It writes its name on you, and it spells it right.

AN ABSTINENT ELDER OF WANTING

HUNGER · FAST



WHITE FINGERTIPS

Two fingertips on your left hand go white and dead in a hard wind and never come back. You can hold them in a candle flame and feel nothing. Other Unfed see them and nod. +1 Endure against cold. -1 Filch.

HUNGER · FAST



THE PEGS

Your gums draw back from your teeth until they stand out like pegs on a board. One loosens, and you keep it in your wax tin, as is proper. Godeaters stare at your smile. +1 Intimidate. -1 Persuade with anyone who has never gone hungry.

HUNGER · FAST



THE GRANDMOTHER'S RECIPES

You recite recipes at night that you were never taught, in an old woman's warm voice: crackling, gravy with a little port in it, seed cake with caraway. Every one is from a table the Host has laid. +1 Lore about Orrum and his tables. Invitation checks against the smell of baking are 2 harder.

HUNGER · FAST



WINDFALL BREATH

Your breath smells of nail varnish and windfall apples: the smell of a body burning itself for warmth. Fatlanders catch it from across a yard and come over with a plate. Any Fatlander who smells it must resist The Hollow. Refusing them gains you +1 Want, once per day.

HUNGER · FAST



SPELLED RIGHT

You wake to find your secret name, the one you were given for refusal and have never once said aloud, written in frost on the inside of your window in a fine round hand. Every letter is correct. Place cards bearing your name are Dire 22 to refuse, not Grim 18.

HUNGER · FAST



THE HIP SORES

Sores open on your hips where you lie on the bare floor, and they will not close: two raw wet coins of red that stick to your blanket. You learn to sleep sitting up against a wall, as the old ones do. You recover 1 less Flesh from any night's rest. +1 Resolve against comfort offered as a bed.

HUNGER · FAST



THE WARM GROUND

You feel the earth to the west of you as warm, as a hand feels a hearth across a room, and you know without looking which way the nearest laid table lies. You always know the direction of the nearest of the Host's tables. Contagion checks for Walking West are one step harder for you.

HUNGER · FAST



GONE QUIET

You stop feeling hungry. Not less: not at all. Every Unfed knows this is the worst sign, and you know it, and you feel nothing about it. From now on the Carver tracks your Pangs secretly, and tells you your state only when you reach Brink.

HUNGER · FAST



HAIR IN THE COMB

Your hair comes away in handfuls, and you keep it in a cloth so that nothing of you is wasted. One morning the cloth is empty. Somewhere ahead, on a laid table, your hair is woven into the white linen like a darn. When you find it, make a Dread 2 check.

HUNGER · FAST



LIGHT AS KINDLING

You weigh less than your coat. Wind leans on you. A friend lifts you over a stile without trying and goes pale, because it is exactly how the Seated come up out of their chairs. +1 Stealth and Athletics. -1 Labor. Your Flesh maximum falls by 1.

▼ THE PALL DECK

You don't hear a village go. You hear it stop calling names through the wall, one house at a time.

— LIEUTENANT SABLE REEF, NETWATCH

The Pall is a community's Fray: 0 to 20, with a Steadiness of 0 to 5 that holds it together, and a weekly **Turn** of 2d10 + Steadiness against 10 + the Pall. The Rules chapter gives the Carver d10 tables of events for each band. The Pall Deck replaces those tables with thirty-six weekly events, each with a rule that pushes the Pall up or down and a choice that puts the Guests in the middle of it. It is meant for a community the Guests are going to stay in long enough to love, which is to say, long enough to watch it go.

DRAWING

- ◇ **Sort the deck into its three bands:** Uneasy (Pall 5–9), Feverish (10–14) and Broken (15–19). Each band is twelve cards. A Whole community (0–4) draws nothing; it grieves what it has to grieve, and holds.
- ◇ **Once a week, roll the Turn.** On a **success**, the community holds: the Pall falls by 1 and no card is drawn, except at Broken, where one card is drawn even on a success, as the Rules say.
- ◇ **On a failure**, the Pall rises by 1 and the Carver draws one card from the community's current band, then applies it. The card's own Pall change is *in addition* to the 1 for the failed Turn.
- ◇ **On a Lack**, the Pall rises by 2. Draw two cards from the band, read both, and play the worse.
- ◇ **On a Grace**, draw nothing. The Pall falls by 2, and the Carver describes the decency the Guests witness, as the Rules describe.
- ◇ **A drawn card is set face-up in front of the Carver's screen** for the week it covers, so the players can see the shape of what the village is doing. Most cards ask the Guests to choose. Let them

argue about it. A card that has run its course goes to the bottom of its band.

- ◇ **If the band changes mid-week** because of a card, the next week's draw is from the new band. A community that crosses into Lost at Pall 20 belongs to the god; put the deck away.

CARVER'S ADVICE: TRAGEDY, NOT SPECTACLE

Several cards in the Broken band describe people answering the Pull. Run them as the Rules chapter asks: the camera stays on the people left behind, never on the act. These cards never say how anyone was lost, and you should not either. Say what is missing: the made beds, the rinsed buckets, the cat that needs feeding, the hand that let go. Give the grief room. Check in with your players before you bring out the Broken band, and after. If anyone at the table needs a card set aside, set it aside, and draw again.

◇

A village has a Fray the same as a man. The difference is that a man can be held down till dawn.

SISTER WREN ABBOTSLEY OF THE HANGING ABBEY,
IN A LETTER TO THE NETWATCH

UNEASY (PALL 5–9)

Rumour, locked doors, quarrels. The community still looks like itself in daylight. These are the cards of the first cracks.

PALL · UNEASY



THE WELL TASTES WRONG

Someone says the common well tastes of salt, or iron, or a god, and by evening half the street is carrying water from a stream a mile off. Nobody has tested it. Nobody wants to. **Pall +1. If a Guest drinks from the well in public and nothing happens, Pall -1. If something does, Pall +2.**

PALL · UNEASY



WHO SAW THE TALL MAN

A rumour runs that a tall, stooping figure was seen at dusk looking in at windows, its warm breath fogging the glass, counting. Three people swear to it. Two of them were not there. **Pall +1. If the next card drawn is Feverish, it is a shared Seeming of this figure, whatever the card says.**

PALL · UNEASY



THE RED DOOR

The house where last month's Break happened had its door painted red, by nobody. This week a second door is red. Then four. The painters are copying something they do not understand. **Steadiness -1 while the painting continues. Catching a painter: Eye + Search, Hard 14. Each painter is someone the village trusts.**

PALL · UNEASY



THE CELEBRANT STOPS

The village's Celebrant does not hold the rite this week. He stands at the altar a long time and then says he no longer knows who is listening, and goes home. **No rite this week can lower the Pall unless a Guest leads it: Tongue + Rites, Hard 14. Success: Pall -1, and Steadiness +1 for the season.**

PALL · UNEASY



BREAD UNDER THE BOARDS

A family is found hoarding: flour, salt-fish, and a side of meat whose provenance nobody asks, under the floorboards. By nightfall three other families have started their own. **Pall +1. The next feast lowers the Pall only if the hoards are shared out. Persuading the hoarders: Tongue + Persuade, Hard 14.**

PALL · UNEASY



THE NEW WORDS

The children's counting game in the square has changed its words. It counts houses now, and the rhyme ends on one of them. The children do not know who taught it to them. **Guests who hear it to the end make a Dread 1 check. The house it ends on is the subject of the next Broken card, if one is ever drawn.**

PALL · UNEASY



THE DENUNCIATION

An old man denounces his neighbour to the Netwatch, the Wakers, the Board or the Bench, as Tenanted, or blinking, or Seasoned, or forsworn. His evidence is that she has been kind to him lately. **The Guests are asked to deliver her. Doing so: Pall -1, and they owe the village nothing. Refusing: Pall +1, and the authorities hear of it.**

PALL · UNEASY



SUPPER IN THE BARN

A preacher arrives (a Deepener, a Bedded sister, a Second Helping brother, a Finisher) and holds a supper in the long barn. Warm bread. Kind words. Twelve go. **A cult forms with Hold 1 over 1d6 households. Each week it is not opposed, Pall +1 and its Hold rises by 1 on one household.**

PALL · UNEASY



A QUARREL OVER A SPADE

Two old friends come to blows over a borrowed spade. One loses an eye. Neither can say, a day later, how it started, and both are sure the other is not himself. **Pall +1. A Guest who sits them down together (Tongue + Persuade, Hard 14) cancels it. Fail, and both men share a Derangement for a week.**

PALL · UNEASY



THE CELLAR

A family moves its oldest member into the cellar and puts a bolt on the outside. They will not say why. At night something down there sings the old grace, perfectly, with every name in it, and one more name that nobody can hear clearly. Pall +1. A Guest who goes down checks Dread 2.

PALL · UNEASY



POLITELY, PLEASE GO

The elder comes to the Guests' lodging with his hat in his hands and asks them, very politely, to leave. Things started when they arrived. He is sorry. He weeps a little. **If the Guests go, the community's next Turn is at -2. If they stay, Pall +1, and every Haggles in the village is Hard for the rest of the season.**

PALL · UNEASY



THE WIDOW'S LOAF

A widow who has lost everyone bakes for the whole street, and leaves a loaf on each step, and asks nothing. People eat it and cry and then come out of their doors and talk. **Pall -1. Note her name. If she is ever lost to the Pull or to violence while the Guests are here, Pall +3.**

cards of a place that has stopped trusting its own eyes.

FEVERISH (PALL 10-14)

Shared Seemings, witch-hunts, scapegoats. Contagion checks in the community are at Dread 3 and cults gain +2 to Hold. These are the

PALL · FEVERISH



THE TABLE IN THE SQUARE

The whole street wakes at the second bell and goes to its windows, and sees a tall figure laying a long white cloth in the square, and a chair pulled out. At dawn there is nothing. Everybody saw it. Pall +1. Each Guest makes a Dread 2 check; on a failure at Fray 5+, they share the Seeming as a Derangement for a week.

PALL · FEVERISH



SHE IS NOT MY WIFE

A man stands in the square and says his wife has been replaced. She eats differently, he says. She sleeps on the wrong side. By evening four husbands agree about their own. The women are locked in the chapel. Pall +2. **The Guests must judge. Freeing the women: Pall -1, and the husbands now say the Guests are impostors too.**

PALL · FEVERISH



THE SCAPEGOAT

The village chooses someone to blame: a Blank, a foreigner, the Seamer's apprentice, one of the Guests. There is no evidence. There does not need to be. Pall +1 each week the scapegoat stays among them. **If they are harmed, Pall +2. If a Guest takes their place, Pall -2, and that Guest is not safe here.**

PALL · FEVERISH



THEY CAME OUT SINGING

The preacher's barn holds thirty now. They come out at dawn singing in thirds, arms linked, and do not stop for a day. Their children sing too. **The cult gains Hold +1 on every household it has touched. Driving out its leader justly: Pall -2. Killing the leader: Pall +2, and a martyr.**

PALL · FEVERISH



THE HAT

The village begins drawing lots, at night, for something it will not name. Every household puts a name in a felt hat. One of the Guests' names is in the hat; nobody will say who put it there. **Pall +1. If the Guests do not learn what the lot is for within the week, the next card is drawn from the Broken band.**

PALL · FEVERISH



FOR THEIR OWN GOOD

A story arrives from the next village: a house burned with a family in it, *for their own good*, because the god was in them. On Tuesday someone here tries the same, and is stopped by the smell of oil in time. On Friday, someone else. **Pall +2. Finding who poured the oil: Eye + Search, Grim 18.**

PALL · FEVERISH



CHALK ON THE LINTEL

The Guests come home to find a sign chalked on the lintel of their lodging: a plate with a bite out of it. By the next morning it is on every door they have visited. **Pall +1. Every NPC in the village now treats the Guests at Hold 0 or worse. Washing the chalk off is taken as a confession.**

PALL · FEVERISH



THE INVENTED PUNISHMENT

A woman confesses in the square to eating her husband's portion in Lack. The crowd invents a punishment on the spot: her hands are pressed to the bakehouse oven door, and held there, while she screams the grace. **Pall +2. Witnesses check Dread 2. Intervening turns the crowd: a mob, Threat 2, Flesh 30.**

PALL · FEVERISH



THE ELDER HAS BEEN SPOKEN TO

The village elder announces at the morning count that the god has spoken to him in the night, and it told him what it wants, and it was very reasonable. He will tell everyone on Sunday. **Pall +2 unless the Guests expose him before then (Tongue + Persuade, Hard 14, against a crowd that wants him to be right).**

PALL · FEVERISH



GRACE SAID OVER THE MILLER

They find the miller at the crossroads at dawn, sitting at a trestle, his chest opened and his heart set on a plate in front of him, a fork laid straight beside it. Seven candles. Someone said grace. **Pall +2. Dread 3 to see. The killers are the village's most respected; learning it is Eye + Search, Grim 18. Exposing them justly: Pall -2.**

PALL · FEVERISH



DUSK MOB

At dusk a crowd forms with no leader and no object, torches and cleavers, and walks one way and then the other, looking for something to happen to. **Pall +1. A Guest who gives the mob an object decides what happens tonight. A Guest who sends it home (Tongue + Intimidate, Grim 18) lowers the Pall by 1.**

PALL · FEVERISH



THE BELL RUNG FOR THE LIVING

Someone rings the passing-bell at midnight, the long slow strokes for the dead, and keeps ringing: one stroke for each person in the village. Eighty-one strokes. The village has eighty. **Pall +1. Everyone counts. Every Guest makes a Dread 2 check. Nobody can find the ringer. The rope is warm.**

BROKEN (PALL 15-19)

Clusters of loss; the Pull goes through the streets. At Broken a card is drawn every week, even on a successful Turn. These are the cards

of a community that is losing people to the god faster than it can mourn them. Run every one as tragedy.

PALL · BROKEN  FOUR HOUSES The morning count goes unanswered on four houses. Their doors are open, their beds made, their bail-buckets and blink-books and ration-cloths set out neatly on the steps. Nobody saw them go. Pall +2. Dread 3. Dread 4 if the Guests knew them. Guests at Fray 5+ check Dread 2 or take the Pull as a shared Derangement.	PALL · BROKEN  THE HAND THAT LET GO A family answered the Pull together, holding hands and singing a nursery song. The eldest son, a man of twenty, let go of the hand and came back. He sits on his parents' step and has not spoken since. Pall +2. Any Guest who sits with him a week: Pall -1, and 1 Fray to that Guest each day.	PALL · BROKEN  THE PROCESSION The Celebrant leads a procession toward the god's place, singing. Half the village follows. The other half has barricaded the road, and some of them are holding their own grown children back by the coat. The Guests choose a side. Holding the procession is a scene: use the Holding On rules for each of 2d6 people.
PALL · BROKEN  PLEASE FEED THE CAT The midwife is gone, the one whose whole life was keeping people alive. A note in a careful hand on her table asks someone to feed the cat. Her bag is packed for a birth that is due tonight. Steadiness -1 permanently, unless a Guest with Stitching 2 or more takes her place for a season.	PALL · BROKEN  DRESSED FOR DINNER The graves are opened in the night, and the village dead are sat at a long table in the square, dressed in their best, their hands arranged on the cloth. Nobody will say who did it. Everybody's hands are dirty. There is one more chair than dead. Pall +1. Dread 3. Reburial with a rite: Pall -1d3.	PALL · BROKEN  THE GARLAND The council votes, by the old law, to offer the god what it wants. A young woman volunteers. They walk her to the god's place with a garland and a hymn. Next week nothing has changed. The god did not notice. Pall +3. Steadiness -1. Each Guest who did not try to stop it gains 1 Fray.

PALL · BROKEN



A SMALL KIND GIFT

Someone the Guests liked, helped, perhaps saved, is gone in the night. On the Guests' sill they left a gift: something small and kind and terrible, wrapped in a clean cloth. **Dread 4.**

The Carver chooses the gift from that person's life. **Pall +1.** Burying them without a body lowers it again.

PALL · BROKEN



NAMES AT THE DOOR

A rumour runs that the Guests can stop it. By morning a crowd stands at their door, begging, quietly, each with a name to give them: a son, a wife, a neighbour. **Each name a Guest accepts is a promise. Each kept by the story's end: Pall -1. Each broken: 1** Fray to that Guest, and the name comes back at a Visitation.

PALL · BROKEN



NOT MY CHILDREN

A mother insists all her children, grown and small, are impostors. Three neighbours agree about their own. They bring the children to the Guests in their coats with their bundles and ask them to take them away. **Pall +1.** Taking them: **Pall -1**, and the Guests now travel with 2d6 frightened children. Refusing: the Carver decides.

PALL · BROKEN



THE LOSERS OF THE VOTE

The surviving elders vote, solemnly and by the old law, to give the god what it wants. The vote is not unanimous. The eleven who voted against are locked in the chapel so they cannot leave. The key is with the Celebrant.

Pall +2. Freeing them is theft under the village's law. Leaving them is not forgiven.

PALL · BROKEN



A QUIET WEEK

Nothing happens. For a week, nothing at all. People are polite. Then a Cutwright arrives with a ledger and asks the Guests where they are going next, and writes it down. **No change.** The next village down the road begins at a Pall equal to half of this one's.

PALL · BROKEN



THE RITE FOR EVERYONE

The survivors decide, without the Celebrant, to hold one rite for all the named dead at once. It takes all night. Every name is said. Somebody has to say the names nobody else can. If the Guests help, **Pall -1d3** and the next Turn cannot fail. If they do not, the rite falls apart at midnight: **Pall +1.**

▼ THE TABLENIGHT DECK

Never answer a knock on a licked-clean night. Never answer it twice.

– RIM INNKEEPERS' RULE

Tablenight is the longest night of Lack and the anniversary of the Gorging, and every land keeps it differently: the banquet the Kept cannot taste, the fast no Fatlands village has ever finished, the west door unbarred, the lamps put out for a minute, the doors propped wide, the twenty-four silent hours of the canyons, the Unfed standing outside with their backs to every door while the table is laid in every house, and on the Rim Road, at every inn, one extra chair set at the table and turned to face the wall. The Tablenight Deck is thirty cards that exist for this one night. It lives in its own box. It comes out at dusk and goes back at dawn, and between Tablenights nobody touches it.

THE NIGHT IN FIVE WATCHES

Run Tablenight as a session of its own, or as the long middle of one. Divide the night into five watches: **Dusk**, **First Dark**, **the Gorging Hour** (midnight), **the Small Hours**, and **Dawn's Edge**.

- ◇ **At Dusk**, shuffle the deck and deal one card face-down in front of each Guest. This is their **Place**. Nobody looks at it yet. A player may turn their Place face-up at any moment of the night they choose, and must at Dawn's Edge if they have not. The card then happens to that Guest, there and then.
- ◇ **At each of the four later watches**, the Carver turns up one card from the top of the deck for the whole table, reads it aloud, and plays it.
- ◇ **Land cards** describe one land's custom. If the Guests are not in that land, someone of that land is with them (at the inn, in the

company, in the Guests' own number) keeping it, and the card happens to them, and through them to everyone in the room.

- ◇ **The night's own rules** hold throughout: on Tablenight a chair pulled out within reach is an Invitation check at Dire 22, the Rim inns' gates are shut from dusk to dawn, and nobody in a house says *come in* to anyone for any reason.
- ◇ **At dawn**, every card goes back in the box, face-down, whatever it said. Effects that last say so on the card. Everything else ends with the light, or at least stops.

CARVER'S ADVICE: THE LONGEST NIGHT

This is the session in which the campaign's hints are allowed to stand a little closer to the lamp. The extra chair, the extra plate, the grace with a gap in it, the frost-writing with a line left blank: let the players notice them, and let them ask, and do not answer. Nothing on these cards states what the empty place is for. The innkeepers do not know. The Hostwatch have stopped asking. The deck is built so that the Carver never has to say anything more than what is on the card, and the players will do the rest themselves, at three in the morning, with the lamp low, and they will be close.

◇

*My knees went at about the third hour. My neighbours
held me up till dawn. You don't fall on Tablenight.
You'd fall forward, and forward is in.*

A THINWICK WIDOW

TABLENIGHT



THE EXTRA CHAIR

The innkeeper sets one chair more than there are guests, and turns it to face the wall. Nobody sits near it. It is for the one who isn't coming, she says, and changes the subject. A Guest who turns it round finds it facing the wall again within the hour. Until dawn, that Guest's Teeth bite back on a 1 or a 2.

TABLENIGHT



DO NOT SAY COME IN

A knock at the shut gate. A voice outside, cold, tired, belonging to someone a Guest knows and loves and who cannot possibly be here, asks to be let in out of the snow. It asks by name. Any Guest who says "come in," for any reason, to anyone, tonight: the Carver writes it down, says nothing, and keeps the note.

TABLENIGHT



THE GATE AFTER DUSK

A woman and an old man stand at the shut gate in the snow, too late, freezing. They do not ask to come in. Opening it without a word is allowed; the Carver rolls a d6 in secret and never says what a 6 means. Leave them, and at dawn there are footprints only one way.

TABLENIGHT



THE BANQUET THEY CANNOT TASTE

The Sallowreach custom: the living cook a banquet for their Kept dead, who cannot taste it, and everyone pretends. A Kept grandmother turns to a Guest and asks what the goose tastes like. Tell her. Tongue + Persuade, Hard 14: success, she weeps for joy and everyone at the table removes 1 Fray. Failure: she knows. Dread 2.

TABLENIGHT



NOBODY REACHES SUNDOWN

The Fatlands keep a one-day fast on Tablenight, in penance. No village has ever reached sundown. Somebody always breaks first, and is cheered, and everyone eats. Each Fatlander present rolls Caul + Resolve, Hard 14, at each watch, or eats. The first to break is the night's hero. The last loses 1 Flesh and gains 2 Hunger at dawn.

TABLENIGHT



THE WEST DOOR

The Brinehollow custom: a bowl of seawater at the head of the table, and the west door unbarred until dawn, for whoever comes home. In the small hours, wet footprints cross the floor to the bowl, and stop. Dread 2. At dawn the bowl is empty and the cloth beneath it dry. Every Brinehollower present resists The West at Hard.

TABLENIGHT



ONE MINUTE OF DARK

The Vigil custom: every lamp put out for a single minute, everyone holding hands in the dark and counting aloud together to sixty. At fifty-eight there is one voice too many. At sixty it does not stop. Every Vigilant present makes a blink check at Hard. Everyone else makes a Dread 2 check. Light the lamps: count the hands.

TABLENIGHT



EVERY DOOR WIDE

The Cradlewrack custom: every door in the house propped open until dawn, so that nothing can be said to have broken in. At First Dark, something comes in. It has not broken anything. It is sitting in the kitchen. The Carver decides what it is. It must be let stay until dawn, by the custom. Dread 2 for anyone who goes to look.

TABLENIGHT



THE SILENT DAY

The Oathen custom: twenty-four hours without a sound, the only day the canyon-folk feel safe. Tonight, anything said aloud in the room is heard by everyone and witnessed by the god. Every word spoken aloud before dawn binds its speaker as a Weight 1 oath, read in its most literal sense.

TABLÉNIGHT



BACKS TO EVERY DOOR

The Unfed custom: everyone stands outdoors from dusk to dawn, holding hands, backs to every door, while the table is laid in every house behind them. The smell makes people faint. You do not fall. Each watch, Gut + Endure, Hard 14, to stay standing. A Guest who falls falls forward, and makes an Invitation check at Dire 22.

TABLÉNIGHT



YOUR CARD

Beside your plate, a folded cream card, your name on it in brown ink the colour of dried gravy, in a hand that loved you. Spelled correctly. Unfed: Invitation check, Dire 22. Others: Caul + Resolve, Grim 18, or sit at the next table you see. Burning it does nothing.

TABLÉNIGHT



THE OLD GRACE

An old woman says the grace from before the Gorging, the one nobody knows. She names the Providers, seven of them. Then her lips move once more, on nothing, and she says amen. A Guest who listens for the missing word: Eye + Lore, Grim 18. Success: you hear it and lose it at once. 1 Fray. The Carver notes the date.

TABLÉNIGHT



ONE PLATE TOO MANY

At the Gorging Hour there is a plate in front of the chair that faces the wall. Clean. Polished. Nobody laid it. The innkeeper's hands are shaking. Do not count the plates aloud. A Guest who counts them makes a Dread 3 check. A Guest who removes the plate finds it there again when they look back.

TABLÉNIGHT



THE GORGING HOUR

At midnight, the hour the stories say the gods were eaten, every god in every blood on the Table turns over in its sleep at once. You feel yours roll toward the door. Every Guest with Cut 1 or more gains 1 Hunger. Every Unfed gains 1 Want. Every Blank, for one breath, hears seven heartbeats in the room that are not theirs.

TABLÉNIGHT



CARRIED BREAD

A stranger at the table, a Crumb-Runner by the look of her coat, takes a hard heel of bread from her own pack and breaks it and gives each Guest a piece, and says nothing. It was carried. It is safe. Each Guest who eats removes 2 Fray. An Unfed must refuse three times first, and does, and then accepts, and remembers.

TABLÉNIGHT



THE CHAIR FACES THE TABLE

At Dawn's Edge the extra chair is facing the table. Nobody turned it. It will not turn back: it is as if it were nailed to the floor, and it is not. The innkeeper sits down on the step and weeps. Nothing else happens. The Carver writes the inn's name down. It matters later.

TABLÉNIGHT



THE SONG NOBODY FINISHES

The inn sings the old feast-song of the longest night, the one with the ox and the barley in it. The last verse nobody knows. A traveller in the corner sings it, beautifully, in a voice like a warm kitchen. Everyone present removes 1 Fray. At dawn the traveller is gone. Nobody can remember the verse, or their face.

TABLÉNIGHT



FROST ON THE GLASS

In the small hours, writing appears in the frost on the inside of the window: the name of everyone in the room, in a fine round hand, one under another. Below the last name is a space the length of a name, and nothing in it. Dread 2. Wiping the window does nothing; it frosts again, the same.

TABLÉNIGHT



THE EIGHT-SIDED PIN

A quiet couple at the next table wear the same small pin on their collars: a table, seen from above, with eight sides. They watch the extra chair all night with the expression of people waiting for a coach. **Eye + Lore, Hard 14:** you know it as the Second Table's sign. They will answer one question, kindly, and then ask one.

TABLÉNIGHT



THE NIGHT IS HUNGRY

Something in the long night wants your god to grow. **If any Guest's Hunger fills before dawn, they draw two Hunger cards instead of one and keep both, and their Regrowth still rises only by 1.** The god took the long way round.

TABLÉNIGHT



THE WALKER

Through the window, on the road, a figure in a nightshirt is walking west through the snow, barefoot, steady, singing under its breath. It is someone the Guests have met. **Stopping them is a scene under the Holding On rules, in Lack, at night, outdoors.** Letting them go: Dread 4 at dawn, when you know where they went.

TABLÉNIGHT



THE TURN AT DAWN

If the Guests are in a community with a Pall, its Turn is rolled tonight, at dawn, whatever day of the week it is. **On Tablenight a Grace lowers the Pall by 3 and a Lack raises it by 3.** Draw from the Pall Deck as normal on a failure.

TABLÉNIGHT



THE STALL THAT IS OPEN

Every market on the Rim is shut tonight. One stall is open anyway: a clean white cloth, a smell of fresh bread, nobody behind it, and something on the cloth for each Guest. **Taking it:** draw a Market card for that Guest, and it is a Relic. **Leaving it:** it is in your pack at dawn.

TABLÉNIGHT



THE DEAD HEAR BETTER

On the longest night the dead are close. Every Oath on the Dead a Guest carries comes due a little. **Each Guest with an unkept Oath on the Dead receives a Visitation before dawn, as the land's rules describe.** Any oath sworn on the dead tonight binds at +1 Weight.

TABLÉNIGHT



THE LAST RED OX

An old drover by the fire tells how his great-grandfather ate the last red ox on the ninth Tablenight and sang over it, and how his father wept, and how they all thought it was for the ox. **Everyone who listens to the end removes 1 Fray.** The drover asks the Guests, once, what they think it was really for.

TABLÉNIGHT



THREE, ONE, THREE

At the Gorging Hour, a knock on the inside of the wall: three, then one, then three. Then on the floor. Then on the underside of the table, under a Guest's plate. **Dread 2.** A Cradlewracker present knows the knock and will not say what it means. Knocking back is a mistake, and the Carver may keep it.

TABLÉNIGHT



THE LONGEST COLD

The cold tonight is the cold of the ninth winter. The fire burns and gives nothing; the breath freezes on the blankets. **Every Guest suffers -1 to all rolls until dawn unless they share warmth with someone.** Those who do remove 1 Fray at dawn and are, for good or ill, closer.

TABLENIGHT



A LACK UNDER THE PLATE

The Rim custom: a coin hidden under each plate, for luck in the year. Under yours is a lack that is wrong. It tastes of nothing and it is warm. **Eye + Lore, Grim 18: it is Blank bone, and somebody was killed for it. Spending it is Dread 1. Keeping it brings you a dream of whose it was.**

TABLENIGHT



THE VISITOR AT THE HEAD OF THE TABLE

In the small hours, a Guest wakes and sees a tall shape at the head of the table, stooping under the beam, laying the cloth very gently so as not to wake anyone. It looks up. **Invitation check, or Caul + Resolve for the non-Unfed, at Dire 22. Success: it apologises, and is gone. Failure: you are sitting down.**

TABLENIGHT



THE CHAIR TURNED TO THE WALL

Lay this card face-down at the empty side of the table, beside the extra chair. Nobody reads it again tonight. Nobody touches it. **At dawn, look at it. If it is face-up, nobody turned it. Put it back in the box with the others.**

▼ THE MARKET DECK

If it is cheap, it is false. If it is dear, it is false and you paid for the privilege.

– LOWMARK SPUR PROVERB

The Rim Market is the Table's great leveller: every land's money, every land's goods, every land's lies on one long road. The Rim Market chapter gives the rules for Availability, Counterfeit Goods, Taint and Relics. The Market Deck is what happens when those rules meet a purse. It holds thirty-six surprises in four suits: **Counterfeit** (twelve cards: the thing is not what it was sold as), **Taint** (eight: the thing is exactly what it was sold as, and something more), **Relic** (eight: the thing knows you), and **Seller** (eight: the problem is the person behind the counter).

DRAWING

- ◇ **When to draw.** The Carver draws one Market card, secretly, whenever a Guest buys from a stall nobody can vouch for: any stall on a Lack day, any black market, Cure-Sellers' Lane at Gristmoot, anything behind the stockyards after Last Bell, any relic from any dealer. Draw also when a Hagggle roll comes up a Lack, and once for the company on any Moot-day, whether or not they buy, because the market will find them.
- ◇ **Spotting it.** Before money changes hands, a suspicious Guest may roll **Eye + Craft** (for goods) or **Eye + Lore** (for relics, coin and godflesh) against the item's Availability difficulty, as the Counterfeit Goods rules say. On a success, the Carver shows the card: the Guest sees the trick and may walk away, and the card goes to the bottom of the deck. A Helping shows the card *and* who is behind it. Seller cards are spotted with **Eye + Instinct** instead.
- ◇ **Playing it.** If the card is not spotted, the Carver keeps it face-down behind the screen, and plays it at once or, better, at the

worst moment within the same story. Most counterfeits are discovered later. That is the point of them.

- ◇ **Not every card fits.** If the drawn card cannot apply to what was bought, hold it and play it on the next purchase it does fit. If the Guests leave the market with a card unplayed, it follows them: the Carver may play it on anything they bought in that town.
- ◇ **The honest stall.** One card in the deck is an honest stall. It is the cruellest card in the deck, in its way. Read it carefully.

WHOSE BONES?

Many Market cards concern coin. Remember that the lack is salt-cured bone, and that a character who has studied the grain (Grim 18 Eye + Lore, once in their life) knows which coins in their purse were people. Such a Guest makes a Dread 1 check the first time they pay for a meal with a coin they know was a person, and after that, as the Rim Market chapter says, they stop counting. Market cards that put a person's bone in a Guest's purse should remind the player of that, and then let them spend it. Everybody does.



*Every fake on the Rim is real somewhere. That is how
you can tell the good ones.*

MISTER CUTLERY, CLOSING HIS CASE

COUNTERFEIT

MARKET · COUNTERFEIT



SWEATING CHANGE

Your change is perfect: good weight, true bite. A week later the coins are greasy and grey, and your purse sweats, and smells faintly of the fen, and flies follow you. Kept bone. **Spot it fresh: Eye + Reckoning, Hard 14. Pass it knowingly and the Company takes your thumb.**

MARKET · COUNTERFEIT



THE COIN THAT GROWS

One lack in your change is a hair thicker than it was. By next month it will not fit the string. It is Wrack bone, cut from a Part, and it is still growing, slowly, toward something. **Spot it: Eye + Reckoning, Hard 14. Kept for a season, it grows a tiny knuckle. Nobody will take it.**

MARKET · COUNTERFEIT



HORN AND HOOF

Half the coins you were paid are horn, pressed and dyed, too light in the hand. Touched with a hot needle they stink of a burnt stable. **Spot it: Eye + Reckoning, Routine 10. Discovered at the next inn, the innkeeper calls the wardens before you can explain.**

MARKET · COUNTERFEIT



IT PASSED A BITE

Brine-soaked chalk, cut and cured until it tastes right. It passes a merchant's bite. It fails a rain. The first shower turns your purse to white paste running down your leg. **Lose the value. In Oathen, where it rains once a year, it buys you anything until it does.**

MARKET · COUNTERFEIT



A FATHOM SHORT

The Netwatch night-rope is proved hemp, true knot, Ropewalk-stamped. It is also a fathom shorter than it says, measured with a Brinehollow wife's forearm, which is shorter than a Netwatch man's. **The first night it is tied to something far off, it does not reach. The Calling roll that night is Hard regardless.**

MARKET · COUNTERFEIT



SWEET WATER

The Purgation emetic, sealed with a brown thumbprint, is sugar-water with a pinch of mustard. It makes you retch a little and feel virtuous. It removes nothing. **The Hunger from the Tainted meal you took it for stays. You learn this the next time you Partake.**

MARKET · COUNTERFEIT



THE NOTE ON A DEAD MAN

A sworn note, Tacit paper, backed by the issuer's body, at a third of face value. The issuer died last Carving. The note is perfectly good. **It can be redeemed for one thing: his body, which the bearer may claim from the Witnessing Vaults, and must then house, feed the candles of, and keep.**

MARKET · COUNTERFEIT



THE WAX IS TALLOW

The Unfed wax tin is tallow scented with pine, and in the warmth of a nostril it melts, and the smell of bread comes straight through it. **The next Invitation check against a smell of baking is at +4 Difficulty. An Unfed who learns who sold it will walk a hundred miles to say so, three times.**

MARKET · COUNTERFEIT



A THUMB ON THE SCALE

The seller weighs honestly, with an honest scale, and you watch him do it. His left thumb is a Kept thumb sewn on in Lastgate, and it rests on the pan, and it is heavier than it looks. **Everything bought here was a fifth short. Eye + Search, Hard 14, to see the stitches. He is very sorry.**

MARKET · COUNTERFEIT



THE HOLLOW BIT

The iron bit is iron only on the outside. Inside is soft pine. Your swearer's jaw closes on it in the night with a crunch like a biscuit, and something is said, aloud, in the dark, before you reach the room. The Carver writes the oath. Weight 3. It binds.

MARKET · COUNTERFEIT



CUT LAMP OIL

Lamp oil cut with fen-water. It burns well for an hour and then gutters and spits and goes out, without warning, at about the third bell. **In the Vigil, everyone in the room makes a blink check at Hard when the light dies. Elsewhere, it is only dark.**

MARKET · COUNTERFEIT



OSSEL'S KNUCKLEBONES

Sold as the god's own knucklebones, wrapped in grey silk. They are a pig's, boiled and greyed with lye. The Finishers who bought the last set found out on the threshold of a Hush. **They do nothing. The Finishers want their money back from whoever holds them now.**

TAINT

MARKET · TAINT



THE GOOD SAUSAGE

The best sausage you have ever eaten, sworn safe on the cook's mother's bones. It is Fatlands field-meat, boiled grey to hide the marbling. **Taint 2 Hunger. You discover it when you cannot stop: Caul + Resolve, Hard 14, to leave the second one on the plate.**

MARKET · TAINT



GRANDMOTHER HONEY

Dark honey in a stoneware crock, at a great price, taken from hives kept on the flank of a Brink-Laden grandmother in the Fold. It tastes of a long life ending. **Taint 1 Regrowth (Ummer). Whoever eats it dreams of being a warm field, and of a hand feeding them, kneeling.**

MARKET · TAINT



GREY SALT

Fine grey salt, sold for curing, very cheap. It was boiled out of Brinehollow bail-water, coughed up at dawn by the Called. Your cured meat tastes of the deep. **Taint 1 Regrowth (Dromm) per week of eating it. Those who eat it begin, at dusk, to face west.**

MARKET · TAINT



THE WHIMPERING CANDLE

A fat yellow candle, beautifully made. When it is lit it gives a small sound, almost too low to hear, like someone trying not to cry in the next room. It is Kept tallow. **Dread 2** to burn it, **Dread 1** after the fifth night. A Sallowreacher knows whose it was.

MARKET · TAINT



WOOL THAT GREW IN A NIGHT

A red highland scarf, very warm, very soft, knitted from a fleece that grew in a single night. Wearing it, you leave doors open behind you and do not notice. **Taint 1** Regrowth (Vey) each week worn. In the lining, a shearer's hand has been sewn in, and in the cold it holds yours.

MARKET · TAINT



ROUSE, CUT WITH LINT

Strong rouse at a good price. The cutting agent is lint swept from the Dormitory floor, from under the rows. It keeps you awake. It also lets you see the long room, at the edge of your eye. **Taint 1** Regrowth (Iss). Each dose, **Dread 1**: someone in the room is lying down who is not there.

MARKET · TAINT



SLATE TEA

A smoky canyon tea, brewed from a lichen scraped off the walls of the Witnessing Vaults. It settles the stomach. For a day afterward your words come back to you half a second late. **Taint 1** Hunger (Tolm). Anything you promise while it is in you binds at **Weight 1**, whether you meant it or not.

MARKET · TAINT



WARMER ON YOUR SIDE

An ordinary Rim loaf from the Bakers' Mile, still warm. It stays warm. It is warmer on the side facing you. Somewhere in the dough is a single crumb picked off a laid table. **Dread 2** for an Unfed who handles it, and an Invitation check, **Hard 14**, to put it down.

RELIC

MARKET · RELIC



THE FINGER POINTS

In a jar on the back shelf, a grey nine-jointed Hand-line finger, still cold. As you pass, it turns in the brine, slowly, and points at you, and stays pointing. It was someone in your line. **Buy it (1,200 lacks) and it closes one thing for you, once. Leave it and it is sold to someone who wants to know where you are.**

MARKET · RELIC



THE JAR SAYS YOUR NAME

A jar of Tenanted brine, sold as a curiosity. Hold it to your ear and it is talking, very slowly, like a hull settling. It is saying your name. It has been saying it since before the stall opened. **Dread 2. Taint 3 Regrowth (Dromm) if bought. It knows where you were born, and the tide on that night.**

MARKET · RELIC



IT FITS

On the bit-seller's board, a silver bit dented with tooth-marks from the inside. Out of curiosity you set it to your mouth. It fits exactly. The tooth-marks are yours, chip and gap and all. **Dread 2. The bit-seller will not say where he got it. He will not sell it to you either. He is afraid to.**

MARKET · RELIC



THE EAR COMES HOME

A jar in a Seamer's booth: an ear, perfectly kept, with a Lying-In tag sewn to the lobe. The Tally number on the tag is yours. You were never told you surrendered anything. **Dread 3 for a Cradlewracker. Bought, it hears for you through walls. It also hears you.**

MARKET · RELIC



IN THE BOX OF ODDMENTS

A box of oddments, one lack the lot: buttons, a thimble, a bent spoon, and a small folded card in cream stock with your name on it in a fine round hand. **A place card. It is not for sale; it was always yours. Invitation check, or Caul + Resolve for the non-Unfed, at Grim 18.**

MARKET · RELIC



SOMEONE'S TEETH

A set of Granny Cracknel's matched teeth, milled from toothed wheat, labelled with a name you know. Held in the mouth for a night, they give the last meal and last sight of the person they were matched to. **Taint 1 Hunger, Dread 2. The last sight is your face.**

MARKET · RELIC



IT WAVES

A thief's Kept hand on a cork board, still twitching, sold to pick locks. As you pass, it lifts and waves, the little two-finger wave of someone you knew in another town, who always waved like that. **Dread 2. It picks locks at Threat 3. It does not want to be with anyone but you.**

MARKET · RELIC



THE PILLOW

A Dormitory pillow, smuggled down off the plateau, sold for sleepless nights. It smells of clean linen and, underneath, of someone you loved who is Counted. **Sleeping on it removes all Weariness. You dream of their bed, and they are restless in it, and glad to see you.**

SELLER

MARKET · SELLER



THE SELLER IS NOT ALIVE

The old man behind the counter has not breathed all morning. His hand, when you take the change, is cold and soft as dough. His wife does the talking and works his arm. The licence is in his name. **Say nothing and she weeps with gratitude. Say something and the Company seizes the stall, and her.**

MARKET · SELLER



IN YOUR COAT

The pedlar is, unmistakably, you: your face, your walk, your scar, your coat. He pays exactly what you ask without haggling and walks away into the crowd. **You are not wearing your coat. Eye + Instinct, Grim 18, to see which way he went. Nobody else noticed anything at all.**

MARKET · SELLER



PRICED IN FATHOMS

The rope-wife is kind and cheerful and drives a fair bargain. Under her voice, a beat slow, a second voice is pricing everything in fathoms, and in names. She is Tenanted. **She sells only to those heading west. If you buy, the second voice says thank you, and means something by it.**

MARKET · SELLER



THE FACE ON THE MOULD

The pie-man's newest mould is a face you know: the thin traveller who was weighed in at the gate just ahead of you yesterday. The pie-man says a man sells him moulds, behind the stockyards. **Eye + Search, Hard 14, to find where. Dread 2. He winks and gives you a pie.**

MARKET · SELLER



THE STEWARD BUYS

A tall, stooping servant in a clean apron wants to buy something of yours. He pays in warm bread, the best you have ever smelled, and will not take no three times, only twice. **Unfed: an Invitation check at Hard 14. Anyone who sells to him finds a place laid for them that night.**

MARKET · SELLER



FOR MY FATHER

A girl, alone, very polite, has followed a thing you bought for a hundred miles. Her father was the one who sold it, or the one it was cut from. She has his eyes. She has his money. **She would like it back. She offers twice what you paid. If you refuse, she waits outside your lodging, politely, every night.**

MARKET · SELLER



THE THUMB-JAR

The factor's clerk bites your coin and goes pale and calls the wardens. It is false, and you did not know, and the Company does not care. The thumb-jar for this year is nearly full. **Talk your way clear: Tongue + Persuade, Grim 18. Fail, and it is ten times the face value and a thumb.**

MARKET · SELLER



THE HONEST STALL

Everything here is genuine, untainted, fairly weighed, and cheap. The seller is a quiet young woman with clear eyes who will not eat in front of you. She is a Blank. **Buy anything at half price. Tomorrow the stall is empty and the Board's bounty-men are asking who bought from her.**



*Who's buying? Nobody's buying. Who's selling?
Nobody's selling. What's it cost? Everything, love.
Mind the gutter.*

PATTER BEHIND THE RENDERING YARDS, SATED



PART FIVE

THE LEXICON

Table-speech and its seven dialects, A to Z.



CHAPTER 11

THE LEXICON OF THE TABLE

A-K

A word is a portion. Before you use it, ask which part of the meal it came from, and who was left with the bones.

— OSWY LARKSPUR, CUTWRIGHT, KEEPER OF THE WORD-STACKS AT QUIRE,
PREFACE TO THE NINTH RECENSION OF THE *DICTIONARY OF TABLE-SPEECH*,
641 A.G.



▼ ON TABLE-SPEECH

Every people on the Table speaks one tongue and swears it speaks seven. Both claims are true. Table-speech is older than the Gorging, older than the Lack, older than the carvings with the eighth place chiselled out; the tally-priests of the Bone Dole wrote their lists in it, and so, six centuries later, does the factor who chalks the price of rope at Gristmoot. A fen porter and a canyon notary can understand one another perfectly. It is only that one of them will take an hour to say what the other refuses to say at all.

The College has kept this dictionary since 140 A.G., when the first Copyists found that they could not trace a bloodline without first knowing what its grandmothers had meant by *portion*, *board* and *company*. It has been revised nine times. Each revision is longer, because the Regrowth makes words faster than the College can file them, and each is sadder, because a language is a record of what its speakers needed to say, and lately they have needed to say some terrible things. What follows is the first half of the Ninth Recension, abridged for the road. It gives Common usage first, then the dialects, then the cant of trades, thieves, children and the dying. Where a word is not printed, that is not an oversight.

OF THE ROOT

Every student begins with *orr-*. From it come *orren*, to eat; *orrel*, to worship and also to give back; *orrib*, a shared meal; and *Orrum*, the Host, *the one at whose board*. In the oldest stratum of Table-speech there is no way to say *I worship* that does not also say *I eat*, nor any way to say *I eat* that does not admit you are at somebody's table. Scholars insist the words always shared a root. The Purgation insists this is the whole problem. The College insists on nothing, in print, and notes only that the root turns up in places it has no business being, as the reader will find under *abhor*, *corrib* and *horror*, and that it is pronounced at the back of the throat, rolled, the way a person clears the throat before saying grace.

HOW OATHENERS CONJUGATE

The canyon dialect has the richest verb in the language and the fewest occasions to use it. Where Common has one present tense,

Oathen has five moods, each a door out of the sentence. The **Bare** is the plain statement (*I come*), used aloud only by Sayers, by the dead in Testimony, and by fools once. The **Exit** adds *-ra*, rendered in Common as *if able* (*I come-ra*). The **Intended** adds *-ent*, rendered as *I now intend*. The **Hearsay** adds *-sed*, rendered *I am told*, and is the mood of all gossip and most prices. The **Weathered** adds *-wed*, rendered *barring weather*, and covers death, illness, flood and the late Rain. They stack, outermost exit first: a canyon child says *cumerentwed*, *I come, if able, as I now intend, barring weather*, before she can say *mother*. A sentence with no exit at all is called *naked* and is treated as Common treats an obscenity. Oathen has, in addition, a **Niche** tense for speaking of the dead, who Testify; it is the past tense with every verb turned into a question (*Did she keep it? Did she not?*), so that nothing said over a body can be held to be a claim. Handtalk has no tense and no mood whatever. That is one reason it was held not to bind.

HOW THE UNFED DECLINE

The Fast dialect declines its nouns by distance from the mouth. A thing you carried yourself takes the **Carried** case, marked *-own* (*breadown*, my-own-bread, safe to eat). A thing held out to you takes the **Offered** case, which can only be spoken negated (*nay-bread*, the bread I am not taking). A thing laid by the Host takes no case at all: the Unfed drop the noun and point with the chin (*there is a — on the sill*), and children are slapped for supplying the missing word. The verb *to accept* has no first-person present. *Come in* cannot be conjugated, only uttered, and is classed by Unfed grammarians as a curse and not a phrase. And the Decline, the threefold *No, thank you*, works as grammar: the first *no* is a particle of politeness, the second an emphatic, the third a closing; an offer made a fourth time is answered in what the Fast calls, without smiling, the *coat mood*, after the proverb that the fourth no is a yes in a nicer coat.

THE SEVEN TELLS

A trained ear can place a speaker within a sentence. The fen drawl of Sallowreach never finishes a word: final consonants are left hanging,

so that *May you finish* comes out *May you finis'*, a habit the College calls the *open end*. The Fatlander talks with a full mouth, literally and otherwise: vowels rounded by chewing, everything a diminutive (*a little drop of gravy-kin*), and praise always measured in weight. The Brinehollower's voice is wet before the dawn bail and hoarse after it, and has a gargle in the back vowels called the *salt-burr*; the coast counts in fathoms even on dry land. The Vigilant speaks in long slurred runs between rouse-stammers and marks time in bells; to a Vigilant, a pause is a medical event. The highlander of Cradlewrack places a small catch, the *knock*, before any word beginning with a vowel, so as not to enter it unannounced. The Oathener is clipped, verbless where possible, and ends every sentence in an exit. The Unfed puts the negative first (*No bread, thank you, none*) and has no polite word for *please*, since asking is a form of accepting. And the Rim speaks Rimmish, a pidgin of all seven, which a factor can use to sell you rope in four dialects at once.

HOW TO READ AN ENTRY

Each entry gives the headword, its part of speech and where it is used (*Common* means everywhere on the Table), and then its sense, its story where it has one, and its use in a sentence, set in italics. Cross-references point to other headwords, some of which will be found in the second half of this dictionary, L to Z. The College has added a few notes for those who must use these words in company; where a word can get you killed, the entry says so. Where a word has a dangerous older form, the entry gives the newer. Use the new one.

There are two words for guest. Use the new one.
SCHOOLROOM CORRECTION, EVERYWHERE

A TABLE OF SOUNDS

SPELLING	SAY IT	AS IN	NOTE
orr-	rolled at the back, like clearing the throat	<i>orren, Orrum</i>	the grace-sound; never swallow it
Ossel	OSS-ul	the Closing Hand	fen speakers leave the <i>l</i> hanging
Ummer	UM-mer, hummed	the Laden	a Fatlander says it as if tasting
Dromm	DROM, held long	the Fathom	the coast lowers the voice on it
Iss	ISS, softly	the Lidded	never said near a sleeper
Vey	VAY	the Opening	highlanders knock first: <i>'Vey</i>
Tolm	TOLM, the <i>l</i> sounded	the Witness	Oatheners sign it rather than say it
Sallowreach	SAL-oh-reech	the fen	the natives say <i>Sallow'</i>
Brinehollow	BRINE-hol-low	the coast	<i>Brine'</i> on the Mile
Cradlewrack	CRAY-dl-rack	the red hills	<i>the Wrack</i> to foreigners only
Oathen	OATH-en	the canyons	also <i>the Quiet Country</i>
Tacit	TASS-it	the canyon capital	a sandal drop is louder
Kest	KEST, with the knock	the highland capital	<i>'Kest</i>
Ludmere	LUD-meer	the Vigil's old name	said with a yawn, as a joke, once
Hallowboard	HAL-oh-bord	the eight-sided stone	the Unfed lower their eyes
Clausewright	CLAWZ-rite	a canyon lawyer	never <i>clause-writer</i> ; that is a clerk
Cutwright	CUT-rite	a genealogist of the College	a bleeding-lancet is implied
Tenanted	TEN-an-ted	the returned of the coast	lower the voice; they hear it

THE SHIBBOLETHS

The College keeps a short list of words that betray a speaker's land at once, used by wardens, poachers, Reckoners and the Netwatch. A

character passing as native of another land makes **Tongue + Lore** against Hard 14 whenever one comes up; a Lack means the slip is noticed by exactly the wrong person.

LAND	SAY THIS	NOT THIS	THE TELL
Sallowreach	<i>finis'</i>	<i>finish</i>	the open end

LAND	SAY THIS	NOT THIS	THE TELL
The Fatlands	<i>you look heavy</i>	<i>you look well</i>	weight is praise
Brinehollow	<i>keep dry</i>	<i>good morning</i>	mornings are wet
The Vigil	<i>what bell?</i>	<i>what time?</i>	there is no night
Cradlewrack	<i>'open</i>	<i>open</i>	the knock
Oathen	(a nod)	<i>yes</i>	yes is naked
The Fast	<i>no, thank you</i> (thrice)	<i>please</i>	asking is accepting

▼ A

A.G. *abbr., Common* *After Gorging*: the count of years since the Night of Seven Tables, now standing at 641. The fen says it as one sound, *ay-gee*, and the canyons will not say it at all, since a date is a kind of claim. Before 0 A.G. there are no numbered years, only the nine of the Lack, which are counted backward and named for what failed in them. *Born in four hundred A.G., dead in four hundred A.G., and still on the stoop*. See *Lack*, *the Long* and *Gorging*.

ABED *adv., Vigil, obscene* Lying down. In every other dialect *abed* means asleep or ill; on the Lid it is too filthy for the bell-sheets, and the Ordinances spell it *a—d*. Lovers whisper it. Wakers write it on charge sheets in red. *Caught abed* is the Vigil's equivalent of *caught in the act*, and covers the same territory, and worse.

ABHORR *v., Common (old), Fast* To refuse a meal that has been offered to you; to turn from the board. From *ab-*, away, and *orr-*, the board. In the Fast it is a verb of praise (*she abhorred three times, and on the fourth they wed*), and in every other land it has slid into meaning *to loathe*, which the Unfed take as proof that the Godeaters cannot tell disgust from good manners. The College's etymology is disputed by the College. See *Dedline*, *the*.

ABIDE *n., Fast* An Unfed given name, from the Refusal, meaning *to wait without eating*. Like all such names it is given on the day the infant first refuses something, usually the breast, which is why many Abides are three months old before they are anybody. Diminutive *Abby*, considered a little soft. See *Abstain* and *Forbear*.

ABSTAIN *n., Fast* The commonest girl's name in the Fast and the commonest insult in the Fatlands, where *a right Abstain* is any woman who leaves food on her plate. In the Fast the name is held by roughly one girl in nine, so that at any meeting of the Abstinent someone must specify *Abstain-of-the-Lean-End* or *Abstain-who-wept*. *Get your elbows off the table, Abstain, there is no table*.

ABSTINENT, THE *n., Fast* The council of elders at Wanting who hold the Pantry and decide, by the simple act of leaving a name off a list, who will eat this winter. Members are addressed as *Elder* and never thanked, since thanks imply a gift. To be *abstinented* is Rim slang for being quietly starved by a committee, and is applied with relish to anyone denied a Company pension. See *omission* and *Pantry*.

ABUNDANCE *n., Fatlands* A word the south uses for a field in which somebody's grandmother has been Seated, since the crop is always heavy there. *We've an abundance on the north slope* means the family has lost its matriarch to the ground and gained a very good acre. The proper response is congratulation, and a small cake.

ADMIRALTY *n., Brinehollow* The Tidal Admiralty: the navy that became a government, commanding four hundred warships standing on props in the mud. Hence *admiralty* (adj., Rim), describing any institution that drills daily for a world that has left it: *the Court is very admiralty about the Hushes*. A Brinehollow joke asks how many Admiralty captains it takes to sail a ship; the answer is *all of them, and they are waiting*.

AFTERS *n., Brinehollow, rude* The Tenanted; what comes back after the sea has had its meal. Said in the Chapel Reach rouse-houses and never on the Mile in daylight, because the afters hear very well and are perfectly

courteous about it, which is worse than if they were not. *Her husband? He's afters now. Brings her tea*. See *Tenanted*, *Passenger* and *Wreckwife*.

AFTERTASTE *n., Common* The memory a family keeps of the Kitchen Year; the thing in the house nobody mentions. Every old family has an aftertaste, and the Cutwrights can usually tell you what it is. *They're good people, the Strakes, but there's an aftertaste*. A family that has *lost its aftertaste* has forgotten what it did, and is held to be in danger of doing it again. See *trading tables* and *Kitchen Year*.

AFTWARD *adv., Sallowreach* In the fen, *after death*, used of the Kept as other dialects use *later in life*: *He took up the fiddle aftward and has been learning it two hundred years*. A fen child asked what she wants to be *aftward* is being asked what trade she will follow once she has stopped breathing, which is the longer career by some centuries.

AGUE-SALT *n., Brinehollow* Salt boiled from the bail-water of the Called on their last night ashore, believed to carry the pull and sold to the lovesick to make a sweetheart follow them. It does not make a sweetheart follow. It makes them stand at a west window. Illegal, cheap, and found in most wedding chests on the Mile.

ALEUSE *n., Sallowreach* (Pronounced *ALE-yoos*.) The interval in a fen tavern when the Kept patrons, who cannot drink, are brought a cup to hold for the sake of company and the living drink it for them. The custom is fond. The cups are refilled. The aleuse can last until morning, and a Kept regular in Weir Row has been holding the same pewter mug since 377.

ALEWAY *n., Rim* The gutter that runs down the middle of the floor of the Groaning Board and every Fatlands-style common room, carrying grease, spilt gravy and worse to the drain. *Gone down the aleway* means wasted, ruined, or rolled out of the inn at closing by six men. See *Groaning Board*.

ALREADY COUNTED *adj. phr., Vigil* Written off; as good as asleep. Originally said of a Vigilant who has been found lying down and carried to the Dormitory before their bed number is assigned; now said of any cause, love affair or ward of the Slope that has gone beyond help. *Don't bother nudging that one, he's Already Counted*. Said to a person's face, it is the cruellest thing on the Lid short of *sleep well*. See *Counted*, *the*.

AMBROSE'S BEARD *n., Cradlewrack* Anything that should get smaller and will not, or anything that is getting smaller and should not; from Ambrose, the Eldest Infant, born twelve years ago with a white beard and growing younger. *The interval is Ambrose's beard* means that the pangs are shortening. Highland mothers say it, gently, of a child who is learning too fast.

ANCHOR *v. and n., Brinehollow* To sleep tied, chained or weighted to the bed so that the Calling cannot walk you to the sea; the rope, chain or weight itself. Children are anchored to a parent's wrist until seven. The great domestic tragedy of the coast is a rope cut in the night, and the great domestic comedy is the husband who comes home late and has to be anchored by a wife who is still angry. *Anchor tight, love, and I'll see you at the count*. See *Anchorite* and *rope, to take the*.

ANCHORITE *n., Brinehollow* One of the order who chain themselves permanently to the cliff of the Hanging Abbey, so that the Calling can never take them. The Deepening calls them *nails*. Fishwives call any immovable old man *an anchorite*, especially at a dinner he will not leave.

Father Ebb has held fifty-one years on the same rock, and says it is not the chain that holds him.

AND LET IT STAY *phr., Cradlewrack* The highland half of the common grace, said after *Lack keep away* over every meal, and by the crowd at the Tally-steps when a birth is read out as *stays*. It is the most hopeful phrase in the red hills and the most frequently disappointed. See *Lack keep away* and *Questions, the Two*.

ANKLE-BITER *n., Cradlewrack, children's* A Part, especially a hand, that has got loose and crawls along the floor of a house at night, gripping whatever it finds. Highland children say it as other children say *bogey*; highland parents do not correct them, because it is accurate. *Feet up on the bench, there's an ankle-biter in the Gorses' scullery and it hasn't been found.* See *Part* and *Gathered*.

ANNALOW *v., Rim, Fatlands* To stop a thing with one word, completely, and in a way that suggests you know what was inside it. From Mistress Brisket Annalow of the Renderers' Union, who can halt every barrel on the Rim Road by saying so. *The factor tried to raise the toll and the drovers annalowed him.* A barrel that has been annalowed is one nobody will now open, at any price. See *Chute*.

ANNEX *v., Oathen* To put a terrible fact where nobody will be required to read it aloud. From the Clausewrights' practice of placing awkward provisions in an annexed opinion, page thirty-eight or so, which the parties swear they have read and need not recite. *The bride's mother wanted the word "living" in the bed clause; the drafter annexed his reasons.* In the Galleries, to say a family *keeps an annex* is to say it has a cellar.

APPETITE, THE *n., Common* The second stage of the Regrowth, between the Taste and the Course: the stage at which the body begins to want what the god wants and to do it without asking. In the fen it is the closing of lids; in the south, the eating of soil and hair; on the coast, the walking west; in the Vigil, the blink; in the highlands, the false labour; in the canyons, the compulsion to swear. *She's into her Appetite* is said of anyone with a new and embarrassing habit, and *a bit of Appetite* of anyone in love. See *Taste, the, Course, the* and *Want*.

APPLESKIN *n., Fatlands* The fine outer skin of an orchard fruit from the Bleeding Orchards, beneath which lies a layer of fat and, at the centre, a pit very like bone. As an endearment, a lover's skin: *my little appleskin*. As an insult, someone who is thin on the outside and fat within, that is, a hypocrite of the Thin. Orchard-keepers peel appleskins with their teeth and do not, as a rule, look at the pit.

APRON *n., Cradlewrack* A midwife of the Attendance, by the white apron of her office; also the Attendance as a whole. *Send for the apron* means that a birth has begun, or that someone is about to be judged, which in the highlands is the same summons. *An apron without a knife* is a midwife of the Late-faction. Children who see an apron in the lane go quiet and stand against the wall until it has passed. See *Opinion, Second* and *Attendance*.

ARCHPROVOST *n., College* The head of the Cutwrights' College, keeper of the Master Concordance at Quire; there is only one, and she bears no mark of office because she is known. The present Archprovost has had the extra chair removed from every room in Quire, which junior Copyists are forbidden to remark upon and remark upon constantly.

ARDENT *n., Fast, shameful* An old Unfed surname, once one of Orrum's names, and now borne by families that would rather it were not. Welcome Ardent, who walks a mile ahead of the Host laying its tables, is the reason. To call an Unfed *ardent* in the adjectival sense, eager, is a deadly insult. Compare *Blythe* and *Welcome*.

ARITHMETIC, THE *n., Brinehollow* The Salt Assay's forbidden finding that the volume of sea lost each year matches the number of the Tenanted. *Doing the arithmetic* on the Mile means drawing a conclusion the Admiralty has made illegal, and the phrase is said with a glance at the door. *I'm not saying, I'm just doing the arithmetic.* A clerk heard doing it aloud in an Admiralty office is reassigned to the far end of the pier.

ARREARS *n. pl., Sallowreach* The parts of a Kept relative that have come off and have not yet been restitched, pickled or sunk: a finger in the button-box, an ear in the vinegar crock, a jaw on the mantel awaiting the Seamer's spring visit. Every fen house has its arrears and every fen landlord asks about them before letting a room. *Gran's arrears are in the batbox, mind you don't sit on them.* See *Keeping* and *Seamer*.

AS I NOW INTEND *phr., Oathen* The second of the canyon exits, rendered in grammar as the Intended mood: a promise that binds only what the speaker means at the moment of speaking, so that a change of heart is not a Breaking. It does not protect against the god's reading of what one *now* intended, which is always more than one admits. *I will love you, as I now intend* is the canyon marriage vow in short, and the long form runs to forty pages. See *exit* and *If able*.

ASHBY *n., Fast* An old Unfed surname from before the Gorging, meaning *the farm by the ash trees*, and now, after Lent Ashby rose from the Host's table, a verb in the Hostwatch: *to ashby*, to get up from somewhere nobody gets up from. It is said of the impossible and never of anything good. *He ashbied out of the Lean House, and now there's a table laid wherever he sleeps.*

ASHMOUTH *n., Fatlands, Common* A member of the Thin, the outlawed fasters of the south, from their diet of water and ash. Fatland children are told that an ashmouth will kiss them and take their appetite away, and some of them wish one would. *Lock the larder, there's ashmouths in the hedge.* The Thin, who have no fondness for jokes, use the word of themselves with a certain bony pride.

ASK ME AGAIN *phr., Fast* The whole of an Unfed proposal of marriage, repeated over months by the proposer and answered by the beloved's threefold *No, thank you*, until the fourth asking is made and taken. Children play at it in the Cold Yards with pebbles. Used elsewhere on the Rim for any courtship that goes on too long: *Still at Ask-me-again with the cooper's widow, are you?* See *Decline, the* and *coat mood*.

ASPIC, IN *phr., Fatlands, Rim* Displayed, preserved, humiliated and still blinking. From Lady Aspic Dellamore's gallery of rivals, set in clear jelly, garnished, and awake. *The Board has the old Chairman's son in aspic: a title, a window seat, and nobody listening.* A Sated hostess who seats you facing the room where everyone can see you eat has *put you in aspic*.

ASSAY, THE SALT *n., Brinehollow* The Admiralty office that measures the falling sea, whose figures are a state secret. *To take the assay* of something, on the coast, is to measure exactly how bad it is and then not say. A man who visits a doctor and comes home silent has *taken his assay*. See *arithmetic, the*.

ASSEMBLER *n., Cradlewrack* A member of the sect that collects Parts from every family in the highlands and joins them into one figure, eleven feet long, lying in a barn near Rudge. Their slogan, chalked on walls, is *Every hand in the crock is somebody's baby*. To *assemble* a thing, in highland slang, is to make a whole of what should have been left in pieces: a marriage, an argument, a story. *Don't assemble it, Nan, let it lie.* See *Barn, the* and *Gathered*.

ASSENT-BONE *n., Oathen* A knucklebone carried by the canyon poor and laid on a table in place of saying *yes* to a bargain, since a bone set down is held not to bind. Merchants of the Felt Market accept it. The

Bench has never ruled on it, and since handtalk began to break, the price of a good assent-bone has doubled.

AT THE WINDOW *phr., Vigil* Gone somewhere that is not the room and not the street, for a whole watch, upright, eyes open, pinching one's own wrist in a steady rhythm; returned with nothing but the bruise and a smell of clean linen. It is not sleep. The Wakers call it malingering; the Hourkeeper believes it is where the lengthening hours are going. *Where's Mam? At the window again.* See *blink* and *Seeming*.

ATTEND *v., Cradlewrack* To be present at a birth as a midwife of the Attendance, with the right and duty of asking the Two Questions. The Attendance's single vow is *I will go into the room*; nobody has been known to break it, though many have died keeping it. *To attend* a matter is to settle it finally and without appeal. *I'll attend to your brother* is a threat in the red hills, and is meant as one. See *apron*.

ATTENDANCE, THE *n., Cradlewrack* The order of midwives who rule the highlands: judges, physicians, priests and executioners in one apron. The Attendance has never called itself a government, which is why it has never fallen. See *Attend*, *Opinion*, *Second* and *Lying*.

AUBREY'S KICK *n., Cradlewrack* A decision made by someone who cannot be seen, interpreted by someone who is tired. From Queen Dowager Sibyl Aubrey, who has carried the King Within for forty-four years and reports his kicks to the court: one for yes. Any order from on high whose source is doubtful: *Is that the Attendance's ruling, or is it Aubrey's kick?*

AUDITOR *n., Rim* A Company assessor sent to price a loss. *To be audited*, in Bonded Hands' slang, is to be costed by the Company and found more valuable as something else: a Bonded Hand who stole a platter and was *audited* is now on display at Treaty Stair. Reeve Calder

Stokes, sent to price Brinehollow, is the Rim's best-known auditor; the coast has begun to say he is *being audited himself*, since he tasted salt.

AWAKE-AND-SWORN *adj. phr., Vigil* The formula with which every Vigil contract opens, certifying that the party was not in a blink when they signed. Contracts lacking it may be voided by anyone who can produce a blink-book entry for that bell. Hence, in common speech, *genuinely meant: I love you, awake-and-sworn.* See *blink-book*.

AXE-MORNING *n., Fast* The dawn after Tablenight, when every Unfed household turns from the long cold standing, goes in, and breaks the table that has been laid in the house overnight. Every Unfed house owns an axe for no other purpose; it hangs by the door. Axe-morning is a day of quiet exhaustion and sweeping, of carrying out the splinters and the untouched food, and of counting who is not standing in the yard. Those not standing are usually found indoors, at the table, very happy.

AYE-COUGH *n., Brinehollow* A short dry cough given in place of an answer at the morning count, when a neighbour calls a name through the wall and the one called has not yet bailed. It means *still here, can't speak*. Silence means someone was Called. Two coughs means *still here, but come round*. A widow on the Mile can tell her whole street's health by its aye-coughs. See *count*, *the*.



The College is sometimes asked why a dictionary needs nine recensions. Because every time we finish one, someone finds a new way to say they are hungry.

OSWY LARKSPUR, AT THE INKHORN, QUIRE

▼ B

BAD DAY'S WAGE *n. phr., Rim* A human thigh-bone, among the coin-cutters of the Cure-House at Saltbridge, who get nineteen lacks from a good one. The phrase has crept out of the sheds into Rim speech for any profit that came out of someone: *He inherited the farm, poor lad, a bad day's wage.* See *bone-grain* and *shut-mouth*.

BAIL *v. and n., Brinehollow* To cough up, at dawn and dusk, the salt water that fills a Brinehollower's lungs from nowhere; the act and the water both. Children are taught to bail before they read. A good bail is a long wet heave over the bucket followed by a ragged first breath that tastes of the open sea. *Bail first, talk after* is the coast's answer to every question asked before sunrise. Figuratively, to confess: *Go on, bail it, what did you do?* See *bail-bucket*, *dry man* and *land-drowned*.

BAIL-BUCKET *n., Brinehollow* The small tin or tarred-leather pail every Brinehollower carries at the waist-rope for bailing. Losing one is like losing your shoes. Sweethearts exchange them; to give a girl your bucket is to propose, and to take it back is the end. *Bucketing*, the confiscation of an offender's bucket for a day and a night, is the coast's punishment for slander, and a bucketed woman crawling door to door at dusk, gargling, with her hands out, is a sight every child on the Mile has seen.

BAIL-TOKEN *n., Brinehollow* A lead disc stamped with a bucket, given by the parishes to those who bail the infirm, good for a cup of sweet water at an Admiralty cistern. Small change on the coast. *Not worth a bail-token* is said of a man who will not get out of bed to help his neighbour cough.

BAIT, THE *n., Common* The third and illegal doctrine: that the gods wanted to be eaten, that the Lack was theirs, and that this is how gods breed, by being swallowed by a people and growing back through ten thousand bodies instead of one. Outlawed in four lands and gaining ground in all seven. On the coast it is called *the Spawning*. Its believers are *Baiters* to their enemies and nothing at all to themselves. See *Theft, the* and *Gift, the*.

BAITER *n., Common, rude* A believer in the Bait. Also, in Fatlands kitchens, a cook who seasons too well, as if to make the eater want more than is good for them. The College, which is dominated by quiet Baiters, does not include itself in the definition. *Don't let the Baiters at the Weeping Post hear you say "seed."*

BARK SOUP *n., archaic* The food of the fifth and sixth years of the Lack, made of boiled inner bark, leather and belt. In the oldest songs it is the dish that grandmothers pushed across the table to the youngest child before they died. *To push the bark soup* means to give up one's share so that someone younger may live, and is said in four lands with a particular grief. See *Kitchen Year* and *eldest, to walk the*.

BARN, THE *n., Cradlewrack* The Assemblers' Barn near Rudge: guarded, lamplit, warm, and long, where four hundred Parts from four hundred families have been fitted into one figure that breathes. Visitors are not shown the far end. *The far end of the barn* is highland slang for the place in any story that the teller will not go. *What happened to your first husband, Marta? Far end of the barn.* See *Assembler*.

BARREN *n.*, *Cradlewrack* A member of the Barren Order, who have had themselves cut so they can bear nothing, and preach that the kindest thing a person can do is start nothing. Their numbers grow with every pang. *To go Barren* is to give up on a project, a love affair or a grudge before it can begin. Highland mothers say a quiet child *has a Barren look*, and mean it fondly, and are frightened.

BARROWS, THE *n.*, *Fast* The long chalk mounds on the hill at Hallowboard where those who starved at the Refusal lie, nine in ten of a whole people. The Unfed swear on them: *By the ones who stood*. A serious oath is sworn barefoot, standing in one's own ancestor's footprint in the trench. See *ones who stood*, *by the*.

BED ONE *n.*, *Vigil* The first bed in the Dormitory, in which Aveline Morne, a baker's daughter, lay down on the First Night of 341 and did not rise, and whose lips have lately begun to shape words. *Since Bed One* means *forever* on the Lid, and *to be Bed One* is to be the first to fall in any disaster. *Who'll be Bed One?* is the question asked at the start of a hard night shift, half joke. See *Counted, the* and *Dormitory*.

BEDDED, THE *n.*, *Vigil* The heretics who preach that sleep is a homecoming, that the eye in the long room is kind, and that the city is three hundred years late. Their prophet looks rested, which on the Lid is the most suspicious thing a face can do. *Don't talk Bedded at me* means *don't tell me it'll be all right*. See *Lullaby, the*.

BELCH, THE *n.*, *Fatlands* The hot wind of Plenty that comes up from the south smelling of rendering. Belch days are good for curing and bad for marriages. A Fatland child born on a Belch day is said to be *Belch-born*: loud, hungry and impossible to embarrass. See *Marbling* and *drip*.

BELL *n.*, *Vigil* The Vigil's unit of time, a quarter-hour struck by the city's bells to keep it awake, and by extension any measure of a life on the Lid. Slope children are named for the bell they were born at: Pip Eleven-Bell, Rook Quarter-Bell. *Which bell were you born at?* is the first question at a Vigil hiring, since the Ward-Sergeants hold that it tells you how tired a person will be. *What bell?* is the Vigil's *what time is it*, and the shibboleth that betrays a Vigilant abroad. See *bell-sheet* and *long bell*.

BELL-SHEET *n.*, *Vigil* The printed news of the Vigil, run off at every first bell and posted at the Bonfires: entered Seemings, Dormitory admissions, rouse prices, Breakings of the Waking Laws. A Vigilant who says *it was in the bell-sheet* means that it is officially true, whether or not it happened. See *Seeming* and *struck book*.

BELLYFUL *n.*, *Fatlands* A unit of time, the interval between two of the five lawful meals, roughly a fifth of the waking day. *I'll be a bellyful* means *I'll be back before the next meal*, and *two bellyfuls late* is very late indeed. A Fatland prisoner's sentence is reckoned in bellyfuls. Abroad, Fatlanders get hopelessly lost in other lands' clocks, since nowhere else is anyone hungry on schedule.

BENCH *n.*, *Oathen*, *Brinehollow* In the canyons, the Bench of Clauses, the council of Clausewrights that rules in practice under the Mute King, and whose members are *Benchers*. On the coast, the Drowned Bench, the judges of the Tenanted, whose verdicts are final and whose loyalty nobody questions aloud. *To go before the Bench* means a reckoning in either land, and in the Rim's mouth it means a lawsuit you will lose to someone who is not entirely human. See *Clausewright* and *Tenanted*.

BENCH, HONEST *n.*, *Rim* The long bench nearest the fire in every Company common room, where strangers of different lands are seated together by the factor's choice and not their own. It is a Rim saying that more marriages, partnerships and murders have begun on the honest bench than anywhere else on the Table. *We met on the honest bench* is

how half the Rim's mixed couples explain themselves, and how most of its poisonings are explained in court.

BILL, THE *n.*, *Common* What comes after the Long Grace: the reckoning, the gods grown back, the meal paid for. Priests of every doctrine use it; the poor use it as a shrug. *We'll all be at the Bill* means *we'll all die*, and *put it on the Bill* means *don't worry about it, it hardly matters now*. The Company, which owns all the other bills on the Table, does not care for the expression. See *Grace, the Long*.

BIT *n.*, *Oathen*, *Cradlewrack* (1) In Oathen, the soft leather muzzle worn by every child from the first tooth until twelve, decorated with beads, ribbons and family marks; also the iron bit of the Appetite-struck and the gold bit of a Sayer. Old family bits, worn by six generations, taste of all of them. *Better bitted than broken*. (2) In Cradlewrack, a pet word for an unnamed infant, along with *small* and *keep*, used through the naming-year so as not to love the thing too much before it is known what it is. See *Unbitting* and *naming-year*.

BIT BACK *v. phr.*, *Common* Of the god in the blood: to cost more than was meant. Said of Partaking when the Tooth comes up a single pip and the hunger rises twice. *I called on her and she bit back*. At the table, a Tooth showing 1 adds a further point of Hunger. Among the poor it has become a phrase for any help that costs more than it saves: *The moneylender bit back*. See *Tooth, the* and *Partake*.

BITE OF THE HOUSE *n. phr.*, *Rim* What a guest at a Company inn takes when they leave without returning the crumb they were given at the gate with their pinch of salt. A guest who has taken a bite of the house is not let in again, at that house or, by gossip, at any other on the Rim. Figuratively, any small ingratitude that ruins a reputation for good.

BITTERHOUSE *n.*, *Vigil* The Apothecary-General's works where rouse is compounded; hence *Bitterhouse black*, the sealed state cake, and *bitterhouse* as an adjective for anything harsh and necessary. *She's very bitterhouse with the children, but they're all still up*.

BLACK DRAUGHT *n.*, *Common* The emetic of the Purgation, administered at their altars to Penitents and retched up before the congregation; whatever comes up is held to the lamps and judged. It purges nothing of the god and everything else. *To take the Draught* is Rim slang for a public humiliation endured on purpose, such as a confession in a tavern or a marriage to a Fatlands heiress.

BLACK NOON *n.*, *Sallowreach* A front of flies thick enough to put out lamps, darkening the fen in the middle of the day. Fen almanacs predict them by counting flies on the inside of a windowpane at dawn. *Black Noon on Needle Street* means a crowd so dense you cannot see your hand. Kept elders are brought in off the stoops before a Black Noon, since the green-bottles favour the newly lacquered. See *Breath, the* and *weep*.

BLADE-MAN *n.*, *Rim* A thief of Company platters, so called from the shoulder blade from which each platter is cut. Blade-men are hanged at the post like murderers, since the Company regards a stolen platter as a stolen oath. *Watch him, he has a blade-man's hands*: long fingers, a scarred thumb, and an eye always on the wax.

BLANK *n.*, *Common* A person born with no godsign at all: Cut 0, a mouthful of nothing. Hunted in every land as saints, specimens or spare parts. A Blank's organs fetch a noble's ransom and their blood is said to quiet any Regrowth for a season; neither claim has been shown, and neither has slowed the trade. *Blank* is also a child's taunt for a slow learner, and a poacher's word for a good night's work. See *blank bone*, *Unfed* and *Seasoning*.

BLANK BONE *n.*, *Rim* Bone coin cut from the skeletons of Blanks or the Unfed: the only lacks with no god in them at all. Collectors pay

twenty times face value. They are almost always proof that someone was killed for their bones. *A blank-bone price* is an obscene price for something nobody should have sold.

BLESSING *n., archaic* Godsign, in the first generations after the Gorging, when it still looked like a gift: the fen elder who could not die, the Fatland field that rose in a week. The word survives in the Upper Boards and the Gut-lines as a polite term for the Course. *His lordship's blessing has reached his knees.* The poor have stopped using it. See *godsign*.

BLINK *n. and v., Vigil* A sleep of a second or two, on one's feet, mid-sentence, the mark of the Appetite in the Vigil; during a blink the sleeper is in the long room with the eye for exactly as long as they are out, and comes back having moved. *I blinked* is the Vigil's most frightening confession and its most common lie. *In a blink* means not quickly but dangerously. See *blink-book*, *blink-murder* and *room, the*.

BLINK-BOOK *n., Vigil* The small book in which a nudger records every blink of their charge, by bell, in their best hand; required by law in contracts of nudging and by the Registrar of the Seeming for every witness. A clean blink-book is the Vigil's certificate of good character. Forged ones are sold on the Slope at a crumb a page. *His blink-book's longer than his arm* is said of a man who is going down.

BLINK-MURDER *n., Vigil* A killing done by an ordinary person during a two-second sleep, with no memory after. The Wakers have forty such cases on file and the method is the same in each. The word is never used in front of the families. Ordinary Vigilants say instead that the killer *went to the window with a knife*. See *at the window*.

BLUE IN THE BUCKET *phr., Brinehollow* Half a proverb, *blue in the bucket, rope on the bed*: when a person's bail-water comes up tinged with blue, tie them tight tonight, because the Calling is near. Bailer-boys read the colour of the water at every door they bail. A man told his water is blue is being told, kindly, to say his goodbyes. See *Called, the*.

BLYTHE *n., Fast* An old surname of the heartland, once one of Orrum's names, now a family shame like *Ardent*, *Welcome* and *Mercy*. Osanna Blythe, who leads three hundred starving Fatlanders into the Fast to find the Host and sit down, has made the shame worse. To be *blythe*, in the Fast, is not to be cheerful; it is to be ready to say yes.

BOARD *n., Common, Fatlands* (1) In Old Table-speech, a table, especially the table of a Provider; cognate with *orr-*, the root of eating and worship. The phrase *at whose board* gives the Host his name. (2) In the Fatlands, the Board of Plenty, the government at Sated, whose members' votes are weighed. *The Board's appetite* is the south's phrase for taxation. Compare *Hallowboard* and *Groaning Board*.

BOARDING *n., Vigil* The Vigil's death rite: the one day a corpse is permitted to lie down, flat on a board in the public way, under a Boarding Licence, so that the neighbours may come and touch its closed eyes and envy it. *Don't board me yet* is said by any Vigilant accused of looking tired. To *board-envy* is to look too long at someone else's ease. See *licence* and *lie down, to*.

BOARDLESS *adj., Fast, Common* Without a table. In the Fast, the proper condition of every decent home, where the centre of the floor is left bare and worn smooth in a ring by people walking round it. On the Rim, *boardless* means homeless and is said with pity, which the Unfed find hilarious in their own unsmiling way. *A good boardless house, swept every morning*.

BOILING *n., Cradlewrack* One of the born-grown who walks out of the steam of the Coppers, the great laundries of Kest, naked and new, having been born of a vat in the night. The laundresses' rule: give it an apron

and walk it to the Crèche. *A boiling* is also highland slang for any grown man who behaves like he arrived last week, and for any idea nobody remembers having. See *born-grown* and *without bearer*.

BONE DOLE *n., Common* The seventh year of the Long Lack, when the governments of every land collected the dead and rendered them in public kitchens and gave out the meat by ration, and the first bone ration-discs were cut. It was the most orderly year of the famine. The College was born at a vat-side with a pen. *As fair as the Bone Dole* means scrupulously fair and utterly monstrous. See *lack* and *tally-priest*.

BONE-COUGH *n., Rim* The dry, gritty cough of the old coin-cutters of Saltbridge, whose lungs are full of the fine grey flour of sawn bone. The cutters say you can tell what a man cut by what he coughs. *Grandad's got the bone-cough* explains a family's comfortable circumstances and its silence on certain subjects.

BONE-GRAIN *n., Rim* The texture of a lack's face under a lamp, from which an expert can tell a cattle coin from a person coin. Learning to read it is a Grim 18 matter of Eye and Lore, and afterward the reader knows which coins in their purse were people, and spends them anyway. *I know the bone-grain on that one* means *I know where that money came from*.

BONE-LIFTING *n., Oathen* The theft of a witness from its niche in the Witnessing Vaults, by an oathbreaker who hopes a dead one removed can no longer Testify. It does not work. The bones Testify from wherever they are taken. The Keeners hate bone-lifters above all criminals. See *eating the witness* and *Keener*.

BONFIRE *n., Vigil* One of the great fires burning in the squares of the Vigil, around which the city gathers to hear the bell-sheets read, to marry, and to stand together through the long watches. *Bonfire weddings* are loud, bright and short. *To have it read at the Bonfire* is to make something public beyond retraction. See *Pinching, the*.

BORN-GROWN *adj. and n., Cradlewrack* Born as an adult, sometimes mid-stride, with no childhood and nobody to claim them; the stuff of the Foundling Companies, the state's only army. General Tibb was born six years ago as a man of thirty and has a private terror of the day he turns seven. *Born-grown* is said of any foreigner who seems to have come out of nowhere, fully opinionated. Abbreviated *g.* in the Tally. See *boiling* and *Foundling*.

BOTTLE-SEA *n., Rim, Vigil* Brinehollow bail-water bottled and sold inland as a tonic, chiefly by Dry Jonah Skerry, and cut into Vigil rouse on the Slope as *sea-cut*, because it holds longest. Its customers stay awake. They have also started walking west, four hundred miles from any coast. *Bottle-sea in the blood* is the Vigil's newest phrase for a neighbour who stands at the window facing the wrong way.

BOWSHOT *n., Rim* The width of the Company's jurisdiction on either side of the Rim Road, as granted by the Ring Charter of 71: within a bowshot of the road, no land's law runs, only the Company's three articles. *Within a bowshot* means *on neutral ground*; *a bowshot off* means *anything goes*. The Ditch Toll is charged on anyone sleeping within a bowshot, two crumbs a night, collected at dawn by whoever finds you.

BREAD WITHOUT SALT *n. phr., Common* A fool; someone with nothing in them to give a taste. The commonest insult on the Table after the omission of the grace. In Brinehollow it is softened to *dry bread*, since everything there is salted whether it likes it or not.

BREAD-COUSIN *n., archaic, Fatlands* A child one was traded with in the Kitchen Year: the cousin who walked across the village one way while you walked the other, holding a stranger's hand, and passed you in the lane, and did not look up. The word survives only in the oldest Fatlands

families, where it means a relative one is bound to by a debt that cannot be named. *The Strakes and the Hesks are bread-cousins* explains why two great houses never quarrel and never dine together. See *trading tables*.

BREAKDOWNS, THE *n.*, *Oathen* The low canyon slum on the floor of the gorge at Tacit where the Forsworn live, organized, angry and with very little left to lose. *Breakdown talk* is plain speech, without exits, of the kind only those with nothing left to break can afford. *He talks like the Breakdowns* is said of an honest man by people who mean it as a warning. See *Forsworn* and *Unread*.

BREAKING *n.*, *Oathen* The physical result of a broken promise in Oathen: the body breaks to match the oath, at once, with a sound, aptly and never fatally. A man who swore to stand by his brother and ran had both legs fold under him; a faithless wife's chest opened like a cupboard. *The Breakings* are the cases tried before Judge Thane Urraw, where the accused simply repeats the promise aloud and the court watches. See *Forsworn* and *Weight*.

BREATH *n.*, *Sallowreach* The smallest money of the north: a twelfth of a minute of Closing, about five lacks, issued as a stamped lead slip by the Mortuary Court. Families save breaths in a slotted crock under the hearth-board for the day they can afford to finish a grandmother. *Not worth a breath* means worthless in the strictest sense. See *licence*, *death*- and *minute*.

BREATH TOLL *n.*, *Rim* Five lacks a post, charged on any traveller showing godsign at the Course, since a Gut-line rooted in the road near the Chute in 604 and had to be dug around. Waived for Company officers. *Paying breath* is Rim slang for being visibly far gone, and is said of nobles behind their backs at every inn.

BREATH, THE *n.*, *Sallowreach* The fog over the fens, which has not lifted in living or unliving memory; warm, wet and sweet in the wrong way. A long dry wind off the southern road, a *sigh*, clears it for an hour and shows a white sky. *Lost in the Breath* means forgotten, or gone into the deep fen and still moving there a little. See *weep* and *dew-rot*.

BRICK *n. and v.*, *Cradlewrack* The brick that seals a dead kinsman's niche in a Stillyard wall, stamped with the family mark; also, to mortar a person into a room for the night, or into the Debt Wall for life. Oaths are sworn with a hand on a kinsman's brick. *Bricked is the only shut*. A bricked couple on their wedding night are broken out at dawn, which is lucky, since nothing came in. *Who's in the Brick?* is a lane game. See *Debt Wall*, *shut door*, *by the* and *Unbricking*.

BRINK, THE *n.*, *Common* The penultimate stage of Regrowth, between the Course and the Seating, when the god is close enough to touch and the person is a thin skin over it. *On the Brink* is said of anyone at the end of their tether, and *Brink-mad* of those whose godsign has driven them past help. Canyon mothers of Brink-mad sons keep a stone by the door of the room, not for the door. See *Seating*, *the*.

BRISKET'S WORD *n. phr.*, *Fatlands* A word that stops a trade. See *Annalow*. In the Renderers' yards it also means a secret everybody in the

Union knows and nobody repeats: *What's in the notched barrels?*
Brisket's word.

BUCKET-KISS *n.*, *Brinehollow* The exchange of bail-buckets between sweethearts; a betrothal. *They've bucket-kissed* means *they're engaged*. A bucket-kiss refused is a public humiliation, and a girl who keeps two buckets on her rope is talked about on the Mile.

BUCKETING *n.*, *Brinehollow* See *bail-bucket*. The punishment of the bucketless: a day and a night begging every neighbour to bail you, door to door, gargling. Used figuratively of any public begging: *The Admiralty went bucketing to the Company for timber*.

BURR-CLOTH *n.*, *Vigil* Coarse wool woven with dried thistle-heads, worn on the Lid so that every movement pricks. The rich wear *galled silk*, laced with fine wire. *Soft as burr-cloth* is a Vigil joke, and a *burr-cloth welcome* is a hospitable one, with a pin offered at the door.

BURYING, THE *n.*, *Fast* The first of Grace in the Fast, when families walk to the Barrows and cut the grass on them once, with knives, kneeling. It is the nearest thing the Unfed have to a festival of the dead, and nothing is eaten on the hill. See *Barrows*, *the*.

BUTCHER'S GRACE *n.*, *Fatlands* The apology a butcher says to each joint as it comes off the carcass, after the habit of Hob Gristle, the Honest Butcher, who can taste what a cut used to be, down to the name. Most butchers say it as a joke. In Sated, lately, fewer of them are laughing. *Say the butcher's grace over that, will you* is said of any meal of uncertain origin.

BY MY MOTHER'S MEAT *oath*, *Fatlands* The binding oath of the south, sworn with a mouthful of a dead relative's flesh held on the tongue: *By my mother's meat, which is in me*. To break it is to have eaten your mother for nothing. Families keep a little dried meat of their elders in a salt-box under the marriage bed against the day they must swear. An oath-breaker is set an empty plate at every meal for life. See *salt-box*.

BY THE LINE THAT DID NOT HOLD *oath*, *Brinehollow* The coast's binding oath, sworn with a piece of a Called person's rope held in the fist. To break it is to invite the Called one to come back for you, which people believe literally, and sometimes they are right: the Saltwick salt-merchant found drowned in two inches of cellar water, his brother's rope round his wrist, wet footprints going down the drain. See *name-rope*.



A foreigner asked me the fen word for widow. I told him we have one, but it is in the Lofts, on a shelf, and it still whispers.

A LASTGATE FERRYMAN, TO A LINEMAN
COLLECTING DIALECT



CAGE TOLL *n.*, *Rim* Three lacks a post on live cargo in a closed cart, no questions asked; introduced in 301, the year of the first recorded poaching out of the Fast. The most profitable toll on the Rim and the one the Company least likes discussed. Envoy Prudence Lowell reads it aloud at every Company congress, slowly, and stops. *Paid the cage* is poachers' slang for a successful run. See *poacher* and *Blank*.

CALLED, THE *n.*, *Brinehollow* Those whom the tide has pulled from their beds to walk to the shore and keep walking. Most are never seen again. Some come back weeks later, heavier, calm and courteous, and are the Tenanted. *She was Called* is the coast's whole funeral sentence; the rest is rope. It is rude to ask a returned person where they went. *Called* is also the children's game in which one child walks blindfold toward a

wall while the others try to drag them back. See *anchor*, *Blue in the bucket* and *Tenanted*.

CALLING *n.*, *Common* (1) The coast's word for the pull of the sea. (2) Everywhere else, a person's trade or station in life, as a Seamer, a Netwatch hooker, a Crumb-Runner; the College asks every applicant for a certificate their Calling, their land and their mother, in that order. Brinehollowers dislike the second sense and say *trade* instead. *What's your Calling? On the coast we don't ask.*

CANDLEKIN *n.*, *Sallowreach* One of Wick Tallow's candles, rendered from the unclaimed dead, which feel themselves burn and give a very steady light. *Reading by candlekin* means reading by the light of somebody you used to know, which half of Lastgate does. Fen children say a candlekin flame bends toward the person it loved. The Chandlers deny this. The children are right.

CARRIED CASE *n.*, *Fast grammar* The case of a noun one has carried oneself and may safely eat, marked *-own*: *breadown*, *waterown*. The Unfed hold it to be the only honest case in the language. *Carry your own* is both the proverb and the grammar lesson. See *Offered case* in the second half of this dictionary.

CARRIER *n.*, *Fast* The lowest rank of a Reckoner band: the one who bears the band's food and water on a raid, in a pack nobody else may open. The Carrier eats a full measure, which is more than anyone at home, and is resented accordingly. *To carry for someone*, in Wanting, is to do the unglamorous work of their crimes.

CARVER *n.*, *Common* A butcher who cuts at table; in the Second Table, the fourth rank, who leads a chapter in a land and keeps its knife of grey bone with a course-name on the handle. *Who's carving?* is a host's question in every land and, in the mouths of the poor, an accusation: *who decided this, and what did they keep for themselves?*

CARVING *n.*, *Common* (1) The third season, autumn, the season of slaughter, the Reaping and the Weighing. (2) In the trade in leavings, the cutting of a relic from a god-touched body, place or person, which the College classes as surgery, butchery or desecration depending on who is paying. (3) The Second Table's word for its rite. *Carving weather* is cold, clear and smells of iron. *She's in her Carving* means a woman of middle age, handsome and dangerous.

CAUL *n.*, *Cradlewrack* The membrane over the head of a newborn; in the highlands, the mark of the Caul-lines, who ate Vey's caul and are born veiled in a membrane that in the highest houses never comes off. They live behind it, speak through it, see the future through it, blurred. The caul of a Caul-line child is eaten raw from a silver dish at its naming. *Caul-mouthed* means speaking prophecy, or speaking nonsense very slowly. See *keep the veil*.

CERTAIN *adj.*, *Oathen* The second-worst thing you can call an Oathener, after *talkative*. A certain person is one who speaks without exits and therefore lives without spare limbs. *Don't be certain, love, you've only the two hands*. In the Breakdowns the word is reclaimed: Brakk is *the most certain man in the canyon*.

CHAIR, PULLED OUT *n. phr.*, *Common* The sign of an Orrum table: a chair drawn back for you. The Fifth Rule of the Fast says not to thank it. On the Rim, *a chair pulled out* means an offer too good to be honest. *That job had a chair pulled out*. On Tablenight the Company sets an extra chair at every table and turns it to face the wall. See *count the chairs* and *head of the table*.

CHAIRMAN'S FEET *n. phr.*, *Fatlands* A thing everybody can see and has agreed not to notice. From Chairman Obb Tullow, nineteen hundred pounds, whose feet rooted through the floor of his cart last

spring, a matter on which the Board voted not to remark. *The Chute's barrels are the Chairman's feet* says in five words what would get a man dusk-shifted in fifty.

CHERISH *v.*, *Oathen* In the canyon marriage contract: to wish the other well, and to act where able for the other's good, and to speak no ill of them before a third person save in a court, a sickroom or the Vaults. The standard contract adds that *cherish* does not require any feeling at any particular hour, since feeling is weather. A canyon husband who says *I cherish you* has said something enforceable and nothing romantic, and his wife will be moved to tears by it.

CHEWING-TIME *n.*, *Fatlands, children's* The Reaping, as small children of Low Tilth call it: the Carving dusks when people go missing from the fields. *Don't go out at Chewing-time*. They all do, once, on a dare. Grown Fatlanders do not use the word, but they do not correct it either. See *Reaping* in the second half of this dictionary.

CHIN, TO POINT WITH THE *v. phr.*, *Fast* To indicate a thing laid by the Host without naming it, since such things take no case in the Fast grammar. *There's a — on the step*, with a jerk of the chin, is the Unfed alarm. Children who say the word *cake* aloud at such a moment are slapped. Rim folk who have travelled in the Fast point with their chins for the rest of their lives, at anything they would rather not name.

CHUTE, THE *n.*, *Fatlands* The Renderers' Union's export depot on the Rim, where meat goes out by the thousand barrels a day with the origin stamped over twice. *Down the Chute* means sold abroad and never asked about. *Stamped twice* means of doubtful origin: a stamped-twice alibi, a stamped-twice grandfather. The bone of the Table's coin begins here, in carts marked BONE: MIXED. See *notch* and *Annalow*.

CISTERN-HUSBAND *n.*, *Brinehollow* A Tenanted spouse who sleeps in the house cistern, as the returned do, while the living spouse sleeps in the bed. The phrase is neutral on the Mile and obscene inland. *She keeps a cistern-husband and a bed-husband and ties herself between them, and nobody asks whose line holds whose*. See *Wreckwife*.

CLATTER-ROOF *n.*, *Vigil* A roof of loose tin built so that rain clatters on it instead of soothing, as rain on a sound roof is too restful for the Lid. *Living under a clatter-roof* means living with a nag, and is said fondly. A quiet roof is a scandal, reported to the Wakers by neighbours.

CLAUSEWRIGHT *n.*, *Oathen* A lawyer-priest of the Bench of Clauses, trained twenty years in drafting promises that can survive contact with reality. A Clausewright may speak a whole day without committing to anything, and is examined for rank by being questioned for a full day without a binding misstep. Never *clause-writer*, which is a clerk. *Get a Clausewright* is the canyon's answer to any proposal, including of marriage. See *exit* and *naked*.

CLEAN *adj.*, *Fast, Common* In the Fast, empty: *Empty plate, clean soul*. An Unfed who has eaten nothing that was offered is clean; one who has accepted is not, forever. On the Rim, *clean* means free of godsign, especially of a corpse sold for parts, and the poachers' price-lists say *clean* where a butcher's would say *fresh*. *Clean Through* is the Unfed's Knack of enduring hunger.

CLEAN THE PLATE *n. phr.*, *Fatlands* The Fatlands' Sop, eating until the god in the gut is quiet for a while; the hunger always comes back. As a curse, *May your plate be clean*, it is the worst thing one Fatlander can say to another: may you have nothing left, may your table be bare, may you be in the Fast. See *Sop*.

CLEARED *adj.*, *Common* Dead; the plate taken away. *Being deared* is death in most dialects. In Sallowreach, where nobody is cleared, it is said wistfully of the dead of other lands, and in the Fatlands, where the dead

are served, it has a second and literal meaning which the Fatlands enjoy explaining to foreigners at dinner.

CLOSE THE BOOK *v. phr., Sallowreach* To end an argument by force, or by a Closer's touch. From the Appetite of the Hand-lines, who close books, lids, shutters and eyes compulsively. *The Court closed the book on him* means a licensed death; *I'll close your book* is a fen threat that most of the people saying it cannot carry out. See *Closing*.

CLOSED HAND *n., Oathen, children's* A game of bitted children in which the loser is the first to answer a question. It is played in handtalk, at great speed, and children who are good at it grow up to be Clausewrights. *She's playing Closed Hand* is said of an adult who will not give a straight answer.

CLOSED WEEK *n., Cradlewrack* The days around each pang during which highland couples abstain, in the belief that whatever begins in pang-week begins wrong. With the interval now nine days, the closed week takes up the better part of the calendar, which the Barren Order considers a great evangelical success. See *pang*.

CLOSER *n., Sallowreach* A Hand-line noble who sells death by touch, under licence of the Mortuary Court; the Left Hand of the Court, Lady Corrow Vane, has finished eleven thousand. Closers wear black kid gloves sewn at the wrist. *Never offer to shake a Sallowreacher's hand*. In fen speech any expensive professional who ends a matter is a *closer*: a good divorce advocate, a hired fist, a priest who can finish a sermon.

CLOSING *n., Sallowreach* A licensed death by a Closer's touch, costing about four thousand lacks and rising; the only death available in the fen, and the most valuable thing a family can save for. *Saving for Gran's Closing* is the fen's equivalent of a dowry, a pension and a mortgage at once. See *licence, death-, breath and domestic licence*.

COAT MOOD *n., Fast grammar* The form in which an Unfed accepts an offer made a fourth time, after three proper refusals; after the proverb *The fourth no is a yes in a nicer coat*. Spoken lowered, with the eyes on the ground. Orrum, the Hostwatch note, has made hundreds of thousands of first, second and third offers in six centuries and has never once been known to make a fourth. See *Decline, the*.

COLD YARDS *n., Fast* The walled squares of beaten earth at the edge of Wanting where the Unfed cook, on bare ground under the open sky, putting the fire out the moment the pot is warm. *Cold Yard manners*: eating facing a wall, without expression or sound. *To meet in the Cold Yards* is to court.

COLDBED *n., Sallowreach, rude* A marriage carried on between the living and the Kept, and what passes between them behind the shutters, which the Court does not regulate and nobody discusses. Said only by the rude, and always in a lowered voice, and usually of a neighbour whose curtains are drawn in the afternoon. The polite fen has no word for it at all. See *setting-apart*.

COME IN *phr., Fast* The worst thing that can be said in the Fast, ranked by Unfed grammarians not as a phrase but as a curse; it cannot be conjugated, only uttered. The Second Rule says never to answer it. It is never punished, because it never needs to be: the Unfed will not cross the threshold of anyone who has said it, ever again. On the Rim, on Tablenight, nobody says *come in* to anyone until dawn. As a Fast curse it is complete in itself. *Come in*, said to an enemy, means *may you sit down at a table and never rise*.

COMING-HEAVY, THE *n., Vigil* The age, about four, at which a Vigil child born awake first yawns, rubs its eyes and asks in a small cross voice why it cannot lie down. That is when the Vigil loses its children. A wing

of the Dormitory called the Small Rows holds those it lost. The word is said quietly, and only of other people's children. See *starrer*.

COMPANY *n., Fast* (1) A warm front: the ground left warm where the Host has walked, by which the Unfed track it in the melted frost. *Company in the east field this morning*. (2) Elsewhere on the Table, guests at a meal. The Unfed find it both funny and frightening that the rest of the world uses their word for the god's footprints to mean *friends at dinner*. In the Kitchen Year, *company* had a third sense, which the College records and does not define.

CONCORDANCE, MASTER *n., College* The genealogical ledger of every bloodline on the Table, from the Meal to the present, kept in a vault under the library at Quire, cool with spring water. A new Copyist's first task is to copy their own line from it, by hand, back to the Meal, alone, which takes three days. Some weep. Some are sick into the channel. *It's in the Concordance* means *you cannot escape what your family did*.

CONFESSOR *n., Common* A priest of the Theft doctrine, who hears penitents ask forgiveness for the Meal, most famously at the Weeping Post, where travellers of two lands kneel in brown water. *To confess the Meal* is to apologize for something that happened before you were born and for which you are still, somehow, responsible: a family debt, a national border, a nose.

COPPERS, THE *n., Cradlewrack* The great laundries of Kest, where the aprons of the Attendance are boiled three times and the third water poured on the hill, and from whose steam the born-grown sometimes walk at night. *Out of the Coppers* means unexpectedly arrived and in need of clothes. See *boiling*.

COPYIST *n., College* The lowest rank of the College: grey gown, board at Quire, access to the open stacks, and an ink-black right thumb that never washes clean. *Inkthumb* is Rim slang for any clerk of the College. Copyists are taken young or by examination, and each gives a pint of blood on entering, which is tasted, graded and entered, so that the College knows exactly what they are, and how fast they are going.

CORRISH *n., Old Table-speech* A shared grave, literally *with-the-board*; the pit into which a household that had eaten together was laid together. The word dropped out of use after the Kitchen Year, when it acquired an ambiguity nobody could bear, and survives only in the oldest carvings and in the College's etymologies, where it is listed under *orr-* with a small mark meaning *do not read aloud to students under twelve*.

COUNT THE CHAIRS *v. phr., Rim, Common* To ask the forbidden question: how many gods, how many peoples, and who is missing. Every land has at some time made it a crime. *Don't count the chairs* means *leave it alone*, and is said to scholars, to children, and to anyone at a long table who seems to be counting. The Unfed proverb *Count your chairs* means the opposite: notice how many places are laid, and get out. See *Eighth, the*.

COUNT, THE *n., Brinehollow, Vigil, Rim* (1) In Brinehollow, the morning ritual of calling names through the wall to one's neighbours; silence means someone was Called. (2) In the Vigil, *the Count* of 401, when a diver brought back the number of sleepers at which the eye opens, said it once to three officials, and was added to it. (3) On the Rim, the Night Count of heads at dusk and dawn in every inn; if the dawn count is higher, nobody calls the wardens, the extra place at breakfast is set and left empty, and the page is burned at noon. See *aye-cough* and *Counted, the*.

COUNTED, THE *n., Vigil* The sleepers of the Dormitory, sixty thousand in numbered beds, breathing in time, who cannot be roused

and do not age. Called the Counted because there is a number of them at which the eye in the dream opens, and the number is a state secret, and the beds are nearly full. *By my mother's bed-rail*, with the hand on a Counted kinsman's bed, is the Vigil's oath on the dead. *To be counted* is to fall asleep for good. See *Bed One* and *Already Counted*.

COURSE, THE *n.*, *Common* The third stage of the Regrowth, at which the flesh changes and the person is visibly becoming something else: grey nine-jointed hands, a body rooted in loam, a chest that no longer needs to rise, lidless eyes, continual bearing, speech that comes true. *Far into her Course* is said of a noble, never of a friend. *He's coursing* is Rim slang for anyone ageing badly. See *Appetite, the* and *Brink, the*.

CRADLE TOLL *n.*, *Rim* Two lacks paid at Knocking Gate by a traveller with child leaving Cradlewrack, after the Marshal's inspection, if let through. *To pay the cradle* is slang for getting away with something under official eyes, and also, more bitterly, for discovering the country came with you. See *Knocking Gate*.

CRAKE, TO *v.*, *Oathen* To get a person to promise you something small. From Jude Crake, the state executioner, who owns no weapon, visits the condemned, talks pleasantly for an hour and leaves once they have promised him something small; it has never taken him longer than an hour. *She craked me* means *she got a promise out of me and now I'm going to break*. Canyon mothers warn children against friendly strangers who *talk crake*.

CROCK *n.*, *Cradlewrack, Sallowreach* (1) In the highlands, the earthenware crock in which a child's afterbirth is kept salted until the naming, when it is stewed and eaten by the family in the Second Meal. (2) In the fen, the stoneware crock under the hearth-board with sixty slots in the lid, in which a family saves breaths toward a minute and minutes toward a licence. *The crock's filling* means, in both lands, that something is coming due. See *Second Meal* and *breath*.

CROWNING *n.*, *Cradlewrack* A sinkhole in the highlands, dilating slowly over weeks into a perfect round opening, at whose rim people gather to see what comes up. *You'll know when it's crowning* is said of anything inevitable. The great crowning is the Dilation, a mile across and widening. See *Dilation, the* and *pang*.

CRUMB *n.*, *Common* A tenth of a lack: a pierced bone bead cut from knuckles, ribs and offcuts, strung in tens on a knotted cord called a loaf. Children are paid in crumbs, beggars ask for them, and every Oathen price-witness charges by them. *Crumb for the plate* is the beggar's cry on the Rim. The Vigil, which cannot see crumbs through its lamp-smoke, has no word for them. See *lack* and *loaf*.

CRUMB-RUNNER *n.*, *Fast* A smuggler who hauls food in from the Rim by night; despised in the Fast and the only reason anyone there is alive. Crumb-Runners are spat on in the street by the people their cargo feeds, and by long tradition never eat a mouthful of it. *Crumb-Runner thanks* is a spit at your feet from someone who needs you.

CRÈCHE, THE *n.*, *Cradlewrack* The house in Kest to which the born-grown are walked when they arrive without bearer: from the Coppers,

from the waters, from the crownings. They are given an apron and a number and, in due course, a place in the Foundling Companies. *Crèche-raised* means a person with no mother on the record, which in a land where descent runs through whoever bore you is a mark of great freedom and no standing at all.

CULL *n. and v.*, *Fatlands* The office of the Cullmasters, a quiet bureau of the Board of Plenty that holds the Reaping can be steered, and assigns vagrants, debtors and troublemakers to the dusk-shift in the far fields. *Culled* means sent to work at dusk. Cullmaster Varn Sweetbread thinks of it as agriculture. Sated children say *the Cull will get you* the way children elsewhere invoke a bogey, and they are, in this case, also accurate. See *dusk-shift*.

CUPBOARDED *adj.*, *Oathen* Of a faithless spouse: having had the chest open like a cupboard on breaking a marriage vow. *Her first husband's cupboarded* is a complete and devastating piece of canyon gossip. Brakk of the Breakdowns, whose ribs opened like a book, is the most famous cupboarded man in Oathen. See *Breaking* and *Forsworn*.

CURE NEXT DOOR *n. phr.*, *Common* The universal and universally failed belief that another land's curse might cure your own: Sallowreach's undeath for the sleepless, the Fast's emptiness for the starving, Oathen's binding word for everyone. *Every land is certain that the cure is next door*. *Looking for the cure next door* is said of any marriage, migration or medicine undertaken in desperation.

CURE-HOUSE *n.*, *Rim* The Company's mint at Saltbridge, where Fatlands bone is boiled, sawn, salted in Brinchollow bail-salt and stamped into lacks: the only lawful mint on the Table since 212. The steam can be smelled from the next post. The people of Saltbridge are famous for their good skin and their bad dreams. *Cure-House rich* means wealthy by a process nobody looks at closely. See *bone-cough*.

CUT *n.*, *Common* The measure of god in a person's blood, from 0 to 5: Blanks and the Unfed are 0, Scraplings 1, common folk 2, Prime Cuts 3, High Cuts 4 and 5. From the portion of the god one's ancestors ate. To ask someone's Cut politely is to ask *what portion* they come of; to ask it rudely is *what did your lot eat?* The High Cuts rule every land and are its most monstrous inhabitants. See *Hand-line*, *Gut-line* and *what portion?*

CUTWRIGHT *n.*, *College* A genealogist of the Cutwrights' College of the third rank, entitled to certify Cuts with a binding certificate valid in every land, and wearing a silver spoon on a chain; generally, any member of the College. The Cutwrights taste blood to grade it. *A Cutwright's smile* is the expression of someone who knows exactly what your grandmother did and is billing you for it.



*We are the only people on the Table who know exactly
what our grandparents smell like on the inside.*

LASTGATE SAYING, TOLD TO FOREIGNERS AT THE
LANDING TO WATCH THEIR FACES

▼ D

DANDLE-GRAN *n.*, *Sallowreach, children's* A Kept grandparent light enough, from long decay, to be carried about by a child; a fen nursery word. *Bring dandle-gran to the window, she likes the sigh*. Children are taught never to drop one, since it takes the Seamer a week to find all the pieces.

DAWN-VOICE *n.*, *Brinchollow* The thick, wet, gargling voice of a Brinchollower before the morning bail, considered intimate; only spouses and bailer-boys hear it. *She's heard his dawn-voice* means they are sleeping together. Compare *salt-burr*.

DEADWATCH, THE *n., Common* The rumoured bargain between the Vigil and Sallowreach: that the sleepless city might buy the secret of Keeping, be killed, and stand forever as a city of the dead who never need to sleep. *A Deadwatch bargain* is any cure worse than the disease. The Vigil's envoy has not sent home the report that the Kept cannot leave the fen.

DEAR *adj., Common* Costly; and beloved. In Table-speech the two senses have never separated, which the Kitchen Year rhyme puts plainly: *Father's too tough and Mother's too dear*. A Fatland grandmother who calls a child *my dear* is being affectionate and is also, children are told by older siblings, pricing them. *The lack is thin* is how the Table says bread has become dear.

DEBT WALL *n., Cradlewrack* The wall in the Stillyard at Kest lined with the living condemned, mortared into niches, fed bread and water through a slot for as long as their families pay. In the evenings the families sit beneath the slots and talk to them. *On the Wall* means imprisoned for life; *stop the bread* means to give up on someone. The slot-feeders say the Wall ticks at night like a kitchen full of cooling pans. See *brick*.

DEBT, THE *n., Brinchollow* The coast's name for the Theft doctrine: we stole the god of the deep and owe it everything, and the Calling is repayment. It is the faith of the Admiralty, the Anchorites and most of the old fishing towns. *Paying the Debt* is the coast's most respectable euphemism for being Called. Its liturgy includes the Lowering. See *Lending, the* and *Spawning, the*.

DECLINE, THE *n., Fast* The threefold *No, thank you* that is the proper Unfed answer to any offer of anything: a cup of water, a hand up a step, a seat, a compliment, a marriage proposal. Accepting on the fourth offer is good manners; accepting on the first is a scandal. It is also the whole of the last rites, said three times by the family standing around the walls with their backs to the body. *She took it on the first* means she has no shame. See *coat mood* and *abborr*.

DEEPENING, THE *n., Brinchollow* The cult that treats the Calling as a sacrament and walks in willingly at night, in procession, with lanterns, singing. Mother Limpet has baptized two thousand. The Anchorites call them *drowners*. *Gone Deepening* is the coast's gentlest euphemism for those who chose the sea; the College records it here as the grief it is, and notes that families who say it have usually found the rope cut from the inside. See *home, going*.

DEW-ROT *n., Sallowreach* The mist that settles overnight in the fen and leaves a tea-brown bloom on linen, skin and the newly lacquered. A fen housekeeper's first task each morning is to wipe the dew-rot from the Kept elders' faces. *Dew-rotten* means stale, of bread, gossip or a marriage. See *Breath, the* and *weep*.

DEW-WAKE *n., Sallowreach* A vigil sat by the living beside one who is dying in another land, kept by fen families with relatives abroad. Since the living of Sallowreach have no deathbeds of their own, a dew-wake is a rare and solemn excitement, and the neighbours come to watch someone finish. Bram Hollin, the Last Mourner, is hired to them at great expense.

DILATION, THE *n., Cradlewrack* The great crowning in the central highlands, a mile across and widening, now pulsing with the pangs; a town of watchers has grown up around the rim. Madder Rudge, head of the watch, says it has a pulse, and lately a second one under it. *Dilation-sick* means unable to stop looking at something terrible, and is said of the rim-folk, of the newly bereaved, and of scholars. See *crowning* and *pang*.

DIM *adj., Vigil, obscene* Not brightly lit. On the Lid, *dim* light is the most indecent condition a room can be in, and *dim talk* is talk of comfort, softness, warmth and rest, the pornography of the Vigil. Rouse-house walls are scrawled with dim words. *Keep it bright* is the Vigilant's way of saying *keep it clean*. See *nuzzling* and *abed*.

DISH-DOWN *n., Sallowreach* The small dish set at the elbow of a Kept diner into which they spit what they have chewed, since the Kept do not need to eat and many still sit at table for company. Polite households keep a lid on it. *Spit it in the dish-down* means *say it and be done*, and *chewed for the dish-down* means effort spent on nothing. Compare *aleuse*.

DIVVY *n., Rim, thieves' cant* The share-out of a poacher's or part-thief's take: so many kidneys, so much marrow, a pair of hands. From Old Table *dividing at board*. *Who's at the divvy?* is a question asked in the back rooms of Gristmoot and answered by a list of buyers, most of whom wear a silver fork inside the collar.

DOLE-BONE *n., Common* One of the first lacks, cut in the seventh year of the Lack for the public kitchens of the Bone Dole, from what bone the Dole had to hand. Yellower and smoother than any coin since. People who find one in their change spend it quickly; children call them *grandmother coins*. *Dole-bone luck* is luck that comes from somewhere you would rather not think about.

DOMESTIC LICENSE *n., Sallowreach* The doctrine invented by the Mortuary Court in 588 after Lady Imber Fallow finished her own father: that a Closing done within a Hand-line, upon a member of the line, by one of the line's own hands, is a private matter, licensed by blood. Since 588, forty-three Hand-line heads have *retired*. *Retired by domestic license* is fen slang for parricide in good families, and is said with a perfectly straight face.

DOOR *n., Common, Cradlewrack* In Cradlewrack, a thing that will not stay shut: doors drift open in the night, locks are found undone, wounds reopen. *Every door is a mother*. *A door shut* is a question asked. The Holder in the lintel-niche holds the door, children are told, and are not told which way. In the Fast, doors are hung to open outward so that no one inside can be said to have let anyone in. See *knock, Sill, the* and *Doorwright*.

DOORWRIGHT *n., Cradlewrack* A maker of doors meant to stay shut, a profession of one: Agnes Latch, whose best work held for nineteen days. Customers travel from Kest for a single quiet night. *A Latch night* is an unbroken sleep. *I'd sell the naming-right for a Latch door* is a common highland confession of exhaustion.

DORMITORY, THE *n., Vigil* The building the size of a district where the Counted lie in sixty thousand numbered beds, in rows, breathing in time, in complete silence. Fewer than two thousand beds remain empty. *Off to the Dormitory* is the Vigil's way of saying someone has died, though they have not, quite. The Matron who keeps it knows the number and walks the rows daily, counting. See *Counted, the*.

DOWAGER *n., Fatlands* A Seated Gut-line matriarch: a low green mound in the Dowager Hills outside Sated, still consulted on family matters. *Asking the Dowager* means seeking advice from an elder who will tell you something true and terrible and then ask for a meal. Dowager clay, a poultice of her soil, heals wounds, and in a week fine white roots come out of the scar and must be cut. See *bill* and *abundance*.

DOZER *n., Vigil, rude* A foreigner; anyone from a land where people sleep. *Watch your purse, there's dozers at the Halt*. Abroad, a Vigilant who

calls another land's people dozers is being nostalgic, envious and contemptuous in a single word.

DRAUGHT, TO TAKE THE *v. phr., Common* See *Black Draught*. To be publicly humiliated by choice.

DREAD *n., Common* The weight of a horror on the mind; in the College's usage, a scale from 1 (a rotting corpse) to 5 (a god's face), measuring how much it costs to look. *A Dread-two sort of morning* is a fen joke about seeing one's grandmother before she has been relacquered. At the table, a Dread check is Caul + Resolve against a difficulty set by the horror's rating. See *Fray*.

DREGS, THE *n., Rim* The last travellers left in an inn's common room after the Night Count, on a licked-clean night, when no one may leave until dawn; by extension any company one is stuck with. *We were the Dregs at Thimble Cross* is the opening of a hundred Rim stories, most of them about a knock that came in the right voice.

DRIP *n., Fatlands* Rain in the south: warm, heavy and fatty, leaving a film on standing water that cooks skim off and use. *Drip-fat* is a cheap cooking grease of the Leanings. *It's dripping* is said of an over-rich sermon, an over-rich suitor, or the sky.

DROMM *n., Brinchollow* The Fathom, god of the deep sea, of pressure, of what is kept under, dragged up the shingle at Longslab on ten thousand hooks, four days dying. Its name is said on the coast with the voice lowered, as if under water. *Dromm keep you* is a sailors' blessing that has become, since the Turning of the Tide, ambiguous. *Dromm-heavy* describes a pressure day, and a mood.

DROP, THE *n., Rim, Sallowreach* The red line painted across the Rim Road outside the gate at Fogmouth, renewed every Grace: north of it the Kept walk, south of it they fall, finished. Families come to the line to say goodbye to living relatives going abroad and hold hands over it. *Across the Drop* means abroad, for a Sallowreacher, and *walked the Drop* means went south to die on purpose, which some of the very old do, and their families stand on the north side and sing.

DROVER-CATTLE *n., Fatlands* Beasts walked to market by the drovers that the buyers call cattle and that walk on two legs when no one is watching the road. Sal Trotter has stopped naming hers. *Drover-cattle* is southern slang for any people sold under a polite name: debtors, poached Unfed, dusk-shift labour. The Head Toll charges them as animals, and nobody checks.

DROWNED BENCH *n., Brinchollow* See *Bench*. Its Justices are Tenanted, speak in two tones at once, and have never given an unjust verdict. *Drowned justice* is perfect fairness from something that is not on your side.

DROWNED STOREYS *n., Sallowreach* The lower levels of Lastgate, sunk under the fen over centuries and still inhabited, chiefly by the poor Kept and by the Smalls, the child-dead, who have their own society and their own queen. *From the Drowned Storeys* means from the bottom of society, and *a Storeys voice* is wet, slow and very old in a small body. See *Smalls*.

DROWNER *n., Brinchollow, rude* An Anchorite's word for a member of the Deepening; more broadly, anyone who encourages despair. *Don't listen to him, he's a downer*. The coast treats it as one of the few words that ends a friendship. See *Deepening, the*.

DROUSE-HOUSE *n., Vigil* A den of the Tuckers, where for a month's wage a citizen may sleep one guarded minute and be hauled back. Failures are delivered to the Dormitory steps before the next bell. *A drowse-house minute* is any pleasure bought at mortal risk. Old Nod, King of the Tuckers, has never tried his own product. See *Tucker*.

DROWSING ACT *n., Vigil* The section of the Waking Laws making it an offence to let anyone near you nod off. *Drowsing Act* is the Vigil's word for collective guilt: *the whole street's under the Drowsing Act for the Corley boy*. Prosecutions rose sharply in 640.

DRY MAN *n., Brinchollow* A person whose lungs do not fill: a foreigner, a Blank, or Dry Jonah Skerry, who for nineteen years was the only grown man on the Mile who did not bail. *A dry man drowns twice* means that a person who has never had to struggle will be undone by the first real trouble. Dry men are distrusted, pitied and, on the Gilt Mile, hired as clerks, since they can work through dawn.

DRY PAPER *n., Rim* An unsworn promissory note, written by a non-Oathener or outside Oathen, worth exactly what the issuer's honesty is worth, which is to say nowhere sensible. *Dry paper* is Rim slang for any assurance from a foreigner, a politician or a lover. *His word's dry paper*. See *sworn note* in the second half of this dictionary.

DUG *adj., Fatlands* Of a person: dug up as a root, a tuber, a crop, wearing a familiar birthmark or face. *Tansy Lard dug her mother* is the most famous case. Farmers who turn up something dug do not speak of it; they replant it behind the house, or they do not, and either choice is grieved. See *field-gotten*.

DUMB-BREAD *n., Oathen* The flat stone-baked bread eaten on Tablenight, the one day of the year no Oathener makes a sound; baked the night before, unsalted, so that nobody will be tempted to remark upon it. *Dumb-bread happiness* is the brief, total, speechless contentment of the canyon's one safe day. See *Tablenight* in the second half of this dictionary.

DUNMERE, TO *v., Sallowreach* To go silent all at once, completely, and stay that way. From Dunmere, the village that went silent overnight in 633 when everyone in it was simply and properly dead, and half the country wept with envy. *The tavern dunmered when the Closer walked in*. Birds fall at the edge of Dunmere Hush. See *Hush*.

DUSK ACRES *n., Fatlands* The far fields of the Cullmasters: a belt of Board land rotated each Carving, the most productive and most carefully ploughed in the country, each plot marked by a small numbered stone at its corner. In spring the Union's men walk them for calves. *Out on the Acres* means sent somewhere you do not come back from, and it is said only of others.

DUSK LIST *n., Fatlands* The roll of names the Cullmasters assign to the dusk-shift each Carving. To *be on the List* is the Fatland nightmare. To *put someone on the List* is the Fatland insult. To *buy off the List*, through Garrick Tripe or a dozen others, is the Fatland economy. See *Cull*.

DUSK-SHIFT *n., Fatlands* Labour in the far fields at dusk in Carving, assigned by the Cullmasters to vagrants, debtors and troublemakers; from which they return, mostly, with the debt worked off. Mostly. *Dusk-shifted* means disappeared by the state with paperwork. The Long Count marks a stroke with a cross-bar for each dusk-shifted who did not come back. See *Cull* and *Long Count*.



The Tally of births outruns the count of conceptions every year, and the gap is widening. Somewhere in the highlands there are eleven hundred people nobody carried.

RUFUS OCHRE, TALLYMAN, IN A LETTER TO THE COLLEGE, 640

EAR, NIGHT OF *n., Oathen* The eve of Tablenight, when pilgrims walk the Gullet barefoot and lay their ears to the warm sand to hear what the god is saying. *An Ear-night face* is the look of someone who has heard something they cannot repeat without binding themselves to it.

EASY BIRTHS *n., Cradlewrack* The ninety years after the Gorging when no highland mother died in childbed and no child was lost; ended by the First Word in Kest in 94. *Easy-birth talk* is optimism, and in the highlands it is considered unlucky, like counting a child before its naming-year.

EASY CENTURIES *n., Vigil* The three hundred and forty years after the Gorging when the Vigil, then Ludmere, was famous for its dreamers, oracles and soft beds; ended by the First Night. *Easy-century* is a Vigil adjective for anything old, soft and fatally attractive: an easy-century chair, an easy-century lover, an easy-century voice. A cushion found in a Height cellar is called *an easy-century piece* and burned in the square.

EASY-DOWN *n., Fast, children's* The Unfed nursery word for a Seated person at one of Orrum's tables: someone who sat down easily and will not get up. Children whisper it. Parents slap for it, since there is nothing easy about the Long Table, and then lie awake, because there is.

EAT WHILE IT'S WARM *proverb, Fatlands* In full, *Eat while it's warm; it won't be*. Seize the day; also, a reminder that the dead are served at their own wake and that the family should not dawdle. Said at weddings. Said at wakes. Said in the Renderers' yards by the foreman, with a different emphasis.

EATING THE WITNESS *n. phr., Oathen* The practice of an oathbreaker who grinds the bones of the dead they swore on into flour, bakes them into bread and eats it alone in silence, believing a witness swallowed cannot speak. The Keeners know nineteen cases since 500. In every one the dead Testified from inside, the voice coming up muffled and wet out of the oathbreaker's own belly in a crowded place. *If you put them in your mouth, that is where they will speak from*. See *bone-lifting*.

EBB *n., Brinehollow* The draining of the indoor tide that rises twice a day in every cellar of the coast, however far inland, and leaves kelp on the stairs. *At the ebb* means at the lowest point, and also in the cellar, which is where coast families find the things that the indoor tide has brought and left. *Ebb-gifts* are such things, and are not kept.

ECHO *n., Oathen* The great danger of the canyons: an oath repeated is an oath renewed, and a canyon will repeat anything, so that people have been bound three and four times over by their own voices coming back. Whole gorges are posted as silent. *Echo-sworn* means bound more times than you meant. *The canyon keeps the change* means that whatever you say comes back with interest. See *Sworn Gorge* in the second half of this dictionary.

ECHO-EAR *n., Oathen* The first stage of the Regrowth in the canyons: hearing one's own words repeated half a second late, as if someone were saying them back. The Echo-Eared can tell whether a statement bound its speaker, and at what Weight. *He's got the Echo-Ear* is said of a good listener, a good lawyer, and a man about to be gagged for his own safety.

ECHO-WARDEN *n., Oathen* A ranger who polices the silent gorges and hunts down old sworn words still bouncing in the deep rock, with felt, baffles and patience. *To ward an echo* is to stop a rumour before it reaches someone it binds. Halvar Stane has come close enough to the echo in Sworn Gorge to make out two words. He will not repeat them.

EIGHTH, THE *n., Common* The figure chiselled out of the eighth place in every old carving of the Providers, by different tools in different centuries. Nobody knows its name, its people, or who ate it, if anyone did. Every land has at some time made it a crime to ask. On the oldest temple floors, the stone in front of its recess is unworn. The College has nothing further to print under this head, and refers the reader to *count the chairs* and to *guest*.

ELBOW-CRESS *n., Fatlands* A pale green cress that grows in the creases of a Course-stage Gut-line's skin, in the folds at the elbow and the back of the knee, and is harvested by Washers and sold as a salad of great delicacy. *Elbow-cress money* is wealth got by living very close to the great. See *Washer* and *fold*.

ELDER *n., Fast* A member of the Abstinents; the only Unfed title, addressed to the old who hold the Pantry keys. Never followed by *thank you*. *Elder's measure* is a full ration, given only to those who have been on the council long enough to be too thin to need it.

ELDERS' LIST *n., Fast* The roll of households to be fed at the Pantry this winter. A name left off it is *omitted*. Elder Forbear Wend has starved eleven people by leaving their names off a list and prays for each by name. *Not on the list* is the Fast's most final sentence. See *omission* in the second half of this dictionary.

ELDEST, TO WALK THE *v. phr., Common* To give the best thing you have for nothing, knowing it will be for nothing, because doing nothing is worse. From the Eldest Walk of the eighth year of the Lack, when the Moot said *no house shall be spared* and the firstborn of every house walked singing to the boundary to give themselves to the hungry gods, and the gods did not eat, and the famine went on, and in the dark the families went out with sacks and knew their own by the clothes. The College records this as the purest example in the language of a word that is also a wound. *We walked the eldest on that harvest* means a sacrifice wasted, and everyone knew it would be.

EMETIC *n., Common* The fourth rank of the Purgation: leader of a hall, keeper of a lidded tin bowl, knower of the hidden houses. In common speech, any preacher who makes you sick: *We had an Emetic at the wedding*.

EMPTY BOWL *n., Fast* The stamp on a Pantry ration chit, and the sign of the Abstinents. *Under the empty bowl* means under Pantry rule; *to show the empty bowl* means to beg. In the Fatlands the empty bowl is an image of horror, painted on the doors of the Thin.

EMPTY CHAIR, THE *n., Fast* The last standing temple of Orrum, where Verger Sober Osmond lays one place nightly at the altar, against all law, and every morning the plate is clean. He believes this is why the god has stayed gentle. *To lay at the Empty Chair* is to appease something you cannot name, and the Unfed say it of anyone who pays protection, or tithes, or flatters a landlord.

EMPTY PLATE, CLEAN SOUL *proverb, Fast* The Unfed creed in four words. Said by the Abstinents at the Pantry window, by mothers to complaining children, and by Reckoners over the beds of the Gut-lines they have just emptied. See *clean*.

EMPTY TOOTH *n., Fast* The Unfed's answer to Partaking: a d6 added to a roll out of sheer endured hunger, the Gnaw, which costs no Hunger but, if it shows a 1, a Pang, *your body paid*. In speech, *the Empty Tooth* is the strength of the starving, the thing the Unfed have that the Godeaters do not, and they mention it often. See *Gnaw*.

ENDING *n.*, *Sallowreach* A word the polite fen will not say, as other lands will not say *sleep* or *come in*; in its place they say a *finis*’, a *closing*, or nothing. A song in Sallowreach has no last verse. A fen story stops; it does not end. *He used the E-word at dinner* is a fen social disaster, comparable to belching at a Closing. See *finish* and *open end*.

ENTERED *adj.*, *Vigil* Of a Seeming: matched on enough points by enough unconnected, awake witnesses of good character to be read at the Bonfires and filed in the Public Record, from which moment, for every purpose of law, it happened. *It was entered* is the Vigil’s highest form of *it’s true*. A Seeming *not entered did not occur*, and the citizen who insists otherwise is shown the struck book. See *Seeming* and *struck book*.

ENVY BOARD *n.*, *Vigil* The board on which a Vigil corpse is laid in the street for its one day of lying down; *to stand at the envy board* is to visit the dead, and *board-envy* is the feeling of the visitors. See *Boarding*.

EVENING NEWS *n.*, *Cradlewrack* The reading aloud of the Tally at dusk on the steps of the Tally-house in every town: births by number, by bearer, by the answers to the Two Questions. At *stays* the crowd murmurs *and let it stay*; at *surrendered* it says nothing; at the ruled line it turns its face away for a count of three. Mothers not yet read stand at the front. See *ruled line* and *Tally* in the second half of this dictionary.

EVERY POT HAS A GRANNY IN IT *proverb*, *Fatlands* Every family has its history; every dish has its source; do not inquire. Said cheerfully. The Fatlands say a great many dreadful things cheerfully, and the College notes that this proverb, unlike most, is meant literally in about a third of the households that use it.

WE-MAN *n.*, *Cradlewrack* A highland shepherd. The ewes drop endlessly in the red hills and lamb is so cheap the poor eat it daily; a ewe-man is accordingly poor, busy, and the most frequent witness to the

births that are not lambs. *Ask a ewe-man* means *ask someone who has seen the worst and still gets up at dawn*.

EXCHANGE, NAMING- *n.*, *Cradlewrack* The market under the Tally-house in Kest where naming-rights to unborn children are bought and sold by the hour on rumours from the birthing-rooms. *To buy on the Exchange* is to gamble on something you cannot see. Patter there runs fast: *Kest boy, ninth month, born talking, says “not yet,” falling, falling*. See *naming-right* in the second half of this dictionary.

EXIT *n.*, *Oathen* A clause of release in a canyon sentence: *if able, as I now intend, barring death, illness or weather, I am told, for today. A polite sentence is mostly exits*. *Check the exits* is the canyon’s *look before you leap*. A sentence with none is *naked*. An Oathener’s worth in company is the elegance of their exits; a Clausewright’s, their number. See *As I now intend*, *If able* and *Weathered mood*.

EYE-LINE *n.*, *Vigil* The nobility of the Vigil, who ate Iss’s eyes, still shut, and are now born without lids, which they call purity. Since 480 only the lidless may rule. Attendants wet the royal eyes with a brush every half minute. *Eye-line patience* is the stare of a person who has seen everything that ever happened in front of them and can forget none of it. A lidded Eye-line child is a deformity, and hidden. See *lidless*.



*I wrote the word for it in the margin of the
Concordance in pencil, very small, and then I rubbed
it out with my thumb, and the thumb has been cold
since.*

NOTE PINNED TO THE DOOR OF AN INKHORN
ROOM, QUIRE, 637; THE COLLEGE REMOVED IT

▼ F

FALSE LABOUR *n.*, *Cradlewrack* The Appetite of the highlands: labour pains in anyone, of any age or sex, with nothing to deliver. The body rehearses. *He’s in false labour about the harvest* means a man fretting over something not yet due. A household with three in false labour at once is said to be *rebearing*, and the neighbours stop calling round. See *Appetite*, *the*.

FAST, THE *n.*, *Common* The central heartland, the land that refused to eat its god, now almost empty, where Orrum the Host still walks and lays tables. Named for the fasting of the Refusal; the Unfed call it simply *the land*. *Gone into the Fast* means gone where nobody goes, and is said of the mad, the pilgrims, and the very hungry. Compare *fast, a* (to go without food), which in the Fatlands is treason. See *Unfed* and *Hallowboard*.

FASTING GIRL *n.*, *Fatlands* Wren Hollowell, a Blank of fifteen who has never felt hungry, and by extension any person whose existence is a scandal to the state. The Board has offered her weight in bone coin to whoever brings her in, and has not specified alive. *A fasting-girl bounty* is a price on someone’s head that does not mention the rest of them.

FAT-PILL *n.*, *Rim* A pill of rendered Gut-line tallow rolled in flour, sold to the thin, the Unfed and the convalescent to *put on a pound a day*. Taint 1 Hunger. An Unfed who takes a course risks Seasoning. *Selling fat-pills* is Rim slang for selling hope to people who should know better. See *Seasoning* in the second half of this dictionary.

FATHOM, THE *n.*, *Brinehollow* Dromm, god of the deep. Also a fathom, the coast’s unit of depth, used even on dry land for everything: *He’s three fathoms in debt, a five-fathom grief*. A Sounder of the ninth knot had gone down nine fathoms past the point where a diver’s eardrums burst. *To fathom* a person, on the coast, is not to understand them but to sink to their level.

FATT’S LADLE *n.*, *Fatlands* An official kindness that is also a coercion. From Bailiff Dunmow Fatt, enforcer of the Feasting Laws, who feeds the refusing gently with a ladle before reaching for the funnel. *The Board offered Fatt’s ladle* means a polite warning that will be followed by the Gavage.

FEAST *n.*, *Common* The skill of eating what should not be eaten: poisons, rot, drink, the inedible. In the College’s usage, also any meal at which more than one land’s dead are present. *A good Feast* is said of a man who can drink a Fatlander under the table, or of a woman who once ate her way out of a locked cellar, and both are admired on the Rim.

FEASTING LAWS *n.*, *Fatlands* The laws of the Board of Plenty requiring five meals a day; leaving food on the plate is a fine, refusing a meal is sedition, punishable by the Gavage. *By the Feasting Laws* is the south’s way of saying *by the book*. Enforced by Bailiff Dunmow Fatt with a funnel and a ladle of office, gently. See *Gavage*.

FEEDER *n.*, *Fatlands* A professional employed by the great Gut-line houses to feed a Course-stage noble who can no longer lift a spoon: a skilled, respected, well-paid and filthy trade. *She's a Feeder to the Loins* explains a woman's wealth and her forearms. The Feeder's apron is never washed, only replaced.

FEEDING *n.*, *Fast* The crime of giving one's own food to another, which the Abstinents forbid because it confuses the ledgers and, worse, because it is hospitality. Punished by a cut in measure. *Caught feeding* is an Unfed scandal of the kind other lands reserve for adultery, and it has much the same shape: a hidden kindness, a secret visit, a neighbour at the window. See *mouth-theft* in the second half of this dictionary.

FELT *v.*, *Oathen* To hang a room with felt so that nothing echoes, as every canyon home, inn and courtroom does. *Felt your mouth* means *be careful what you say*. A *felted marrying-room* is where canyon couples read their vows aloud, so that the canyon cannot say them back. *Unfelted* means reckless, exposed, and in Tacit's oldest families, slightly obscene.

FELT MARKET *n.*, *Oathen* The market of Tacit, where prices are chalked and the chalk carries exits: *FRESH THIS MORNING, I AM TOLD*. A *Felt Market answer* is a reply hedged so thoroughly it says nothing. Bone-dust was traced to a bakery near it in 641.

FEN *n.*, *Sallowreach* The grey country of Sallowreach, black water, reed and peat, full of everything that ever drowned in it, still moving a little. *A fen face* is pale, patient and smells of vinegar. *Fen-tired* is tired in a way that will never improve. *Fen-wise* is knowing that a problem *will keep*.

FEN-WIRE *n.*, *Sallowreach* The fine wire with which the Seamers hold the Kept together, Sallowreach's chief export after lacquer. *Held together with fen-wire* means barely holding on; it is said of governments, marriages and grandmothers. See *Seamer* in the second half of this dictionary.

FIELD *n.*, *Fatlands* Farmland, and also a relative: many of the best fields in the south are somebody's great-grandmother, Seated and grown into a low warm hill. The Fatland grace thanks the field by name before every meal. *The field remembers who fed it*. *Your mother's a good field* is a compliment to the crop and the woman both. See *hill* and *abundance*.

FIELD-GOTTEN *adj.*, *Fatlands* Of a child: conceived in the fields, especially at Plenty when the plains sweat; thought lucky, heavy and hungry from birth. Also of a child found in the fields, in a furrow, with no mother anybody can name. Both kinds are called lucky, aloud.

FIFTH MEAL *n.*, *Fatlands*, *Rim* The last of the five lawful meals of the day, eaten at night. *No Company house will refuse a Fatlander a fifth meal*. *At the fifth meal* means late, and also means a Fatlander's guard is down, which every assassin in Sated knows. Jem Crackle kills only in kitchens, and favours the fifth meal.

FIFTH, THE *n.*, *Fast* The Fifth Rule: if a chair is pulled out for you, do not thank it. *Remember the Fifth* is said to Unfed travellers leaving for the Rim, where everyone is polite to furniture. Compare *Five Rules*.

FILL *v.*, *Brinehollow* Of the lungs: to flood twice a day with salt water from nowhere. *I'm filling* means *it is nearly dusk and I must find my bucket*, and also *I can't take any more of this*. *Filled up* is the coast's word for someone land-drowned. See *bail*.

FINISH *v.*, *Sallowreach* To die properly, which in the fen nobody can do without a licence or a Hush. *May you finish* is the polite fen greeting, said *May you finis'*, leaving the last sound open, since nothing in the fen ends. *Long life* is the worst curse. *May we all finish* is the toast at midnight on Tablenight. *Finished* is the fen's highest praise for a piece of work, and its tenderest word for the dead. See *open end* and *Long life* in the second half of this dictionary.

FINISHER *n.*, *Sallowreach* A member of the death cult that makes pilgrimage to the Hushes and walks in singing; the Court calls it theft of a licensed good. Their numbers have tripled in a year. The College records the word here as a grief, not a recommendation: every Finisher leaves a family on the near side of the Hush, listening for the singing to stop, and it stops all at once, and there is no echo. See *Hush* and *Shut Eye* in the second half of this dictionary.

FIRE-WIDOW *n.*, *Oathen* One bound by a promise to the dying: from Asha Kindle, who promised her dying husband never to let the fire go out, thirty-one years ago, and has not slept more than an hour at a stretch since; the fire has grown particular about what it is fed. *A fire-widow's vow* is any deathbed promise, and canyon dying are discouraged by their families from asking for them.

FIRST BAIL *n.*, *Brinehollow* The infant's first coughing-up of brine, at the first dusk of its life, attended by the whole family; *go west without her*, they say to the sea, by custom. *Since my First Bail* means since birth. *She never had a First Bail* is said of the dry-lunged, and of the stillborn, gently.

FIRST NIGHT *n.*, *Vigil* The morning in 341 when a third of Ludmere did not get up, and by the third morning half. The survivors were those too frightened to lie down. *First-Night fear* is the healthy terror of comfort that keeps a Vigilant alive. *The Night of Lying Down*, its anniversary, is the city's great mourning. See *Bed One*.

FIRST WORD *n.*, *Cradlewrack* The words *Not yet*, said clearly by a newborn in Kest in 94 A.G., the first of the speaking-born. *A first-word child* is one born speaking; *sp.* in the Tally. *Not yet* has become the highland answer to any question about the future, said with a shrug, and is carved over the door of the Lying-In.

FIVE RULES *n.*, *Fast* The rules every Unfed child learns before letters: never enter a house where the hearth is already lit; never answer *come in*; never eat what you did not carry yourself; if you smell bread, walk into the wind; if a chair is pulled out for you, do not thank it. *Five-Rule clean* means scrupulous. *He's forgotten the Fifth* means he is being too polite to something.

FLINCH *n.*, *Fatlands* The movement of the ground when a Fatland well-digger strikes something living; any sign that a thing you thought was soil is not. *The field flinched* is said when a scheme is discovered. Well-diggers charge extra for a flinch, and more for a flinch with a voice.

FLY-FRONT *n.*, *Sallowreach* A moving mass of flies, the true weather of the fen, predicted by almanac-men who count flies on windowpanes at dawn; the worst is a Black Noon. *A fly-front coming* is fen slang for a creditor, a mother-in-law, or the Court. See *Black Noon*.

FOGMOUTH *n.*, *Rim* The northern Company station where the road from Lastgate meets the Rim and the Drop is painted across the road. *Fogmouth goodbyes* are farewells made across a line one party cannot cross; the beggars there are mostly living relatives of the Kept on the far side. See *Drop, the*.

FOLD *n.*, *Fatlands* A fold of flesh on a great Gut-line body, deep enough to hold summers of smell; the Washers who clean them speak of *the fourth fold of Madam's left side* as a place. *The Fold* is also the rich quarter of Sated, built for the very wide. *Deep in the fold* means in the confidence of the great, and in the dark. See *Washer* and *elbow-cress*.

FOLLOW, THE *n.*, *Brinehollow* The sealed iron vessel Dagna Hull is building to chase the sea down into the Trench; nine hundred volunteers are on its waiting list. *On the Follow list* is coast slang for someone who has given up on dry land and is waiting for a better way to go. The

College enters the phrase as it is used, with sorrow, and notes that the families of the list do not say it at all.

FOLLOW-TONGUE *n.*, *Brinehollow* The new cant of the volunteers for Dagna Hull's iron vessel, full of depth-words and Trench-words, spoken by people who have decided to leave. Parents on the Mile who hear their children using it hide the waist-ropes.

FOOT-PENNY *n.*, *Rim* The crumb paid at each Company post by a traveller on foot; also the cheapest bribe on the Rim. Children under seven pass free, which has made the Rim's foot-traffic notably full of very tall seven-year-olds from Cradlewrack.

FORBEAR *n.*, *Fast* An Unfed given name, from the Refusal, and the name of the eldest Elder of the Abstinent. Among the Unfed, a *forbear* is not an ancestor but anyone who once went without for your sake; one's forbears are counted by who starved so that you might eat. In every other dialect it means an ancestor, which the Unfed consider a revealing confusion.

FOREIGN ROW *n.*, *Rim* The stretch of any Rim market where goods of six lands are sold side by side, and where the cures are. A *Foreign Row cure* is quackery; *Foreign Row prices* are triple. The College's Linemen buy their ink there and pay what it asks, which says something about the College.

FORK, TWO-TINED *n.*, *Common* The badge of the Second Table, worn enamelled inside the collar on the road; members embroider a silver fork on their dinner veils and know one another at Rim inns by the way they hold their knives. *He holds his knife like a fork* means he is a noble who has been somewhere he should not. A fork is a disgrace in the Fast, where food is eaten from the hand. See *Trencherman* in the second half of this dictionary.

FORSWORN *n. and adj.*, *Oathen* One who has broken an oath and lives visibly broken: a reversed knee, a split jaw, a chest open like a cupboard. You can read a Forsworn person's whole moral history from across the street. They live in the Breakdowns, organized and plainspoken, and go bare where they broke, as a point of pride. *Forsworn paper* is a note backed by what already broke, worth nothing. *Let my open chest answer* means *never*. See *Breaking*, *Unread* and *cupboarded*.

FOUNDLING *n.*, *Cradlewrack* One of the born-grown, especially a soldier of the Foundling Companies, the state's only army, adults in body and a few years old in fact. Hired out on the Rim as caravan guards. *Foundling-brave* means brave without understanding, like a six-year-old with a sword and a man's arms. The born-grown do not like to arrest mothers. See *born-grown*.

FOURTH NO *n. phr.*, *Fast* Acceptance, offered properly. *The fourth no is a yes in a nicer coat*. An Unfed who wants something badly will go on refusing it with mounting pain until it is offered a fourth time, and many

a Fast love affair has died at the third offer for want of courage on the asking side. See *coat mood* and *Decline, the*.

FRAY *n.*, *Common* The wearing of the mind by horror, counted by the College physicians from 0 to 10, at which a person *breaks* and takes up a madness, and drops back to 3. *Frayed* means nervy; *fraying* means near the edge; a *fray-sharer* is one who has caught another's madness by watching it break, which on the Table is common, and getting commoner. See *Dread*.

FRESH AS A GLAD CENTURY FIDDLER *adj. phr.*, *Sallowreach* Hopelessly out of date. From the fiddlers of the first hundred years after the Gorging, who played at the dancing when it seemed a miracle that nobody died, and some of whom are still playing, in pieces, in the same taverns. *His jokes are fresh as a Glad Century fiddler*. See *Glad Century*.

FROST IS A FRIEND *proverb*, *Fast* Said gratefully on cold mornings in the Fast, since frost shows where the Host has walked, the warm ground melting it into a track. A morning without frost is an anxious one. See *company*.

FULL *adj.*, *Fatlands, lost* A word that no longer exists in the dialect of the south. *There is no word in our dialect for full. We had one. We ate it.* The joke is told at every Fatland table, and the College confirms it is true: the word appears in the earliest Fatland charters and in none after 204. In its place the south says *fuller*: *Nobody's full, but some are fuller*.

FUNNEL *n.*, *Fatlands* The badge of office of a Bailiff of the Feasting Laws, carried with a ladle; also the Gavage itself. *Funnelled* means force-fed, literally or figuratively: *the Board funnelled the new toll through in an afternoon*. Bailiff Dunmow Fatt is gentle about it, by every account.

FURROW-SONG *n.*, *Fatlands* The song orchard-keepers sing through the pruning season in the Bleeding Orchards, to cover the screaming; most keepers go deaf young, by choice, and sing badly. Marigold Chine's trees have begun to sing back, in tune, in her voice. *Singing furrow-song* means talking loudly to cover something.

FURROW-STONE *n.*, *Fatlands* The small numbered stone at the corner of each plot in the Dusk Acres. *His name's on a furrow-stone* means he was dusk-shifted. Children of the Leanings count furrow-stones on their way to school, and are not told what the numbers mean, and know.



Every dialect on the Table has a word for full except the one that needs it, and a word for hungry except the one that is. The Unfed just say alive.

MARGINAL NOTE IN A COPYIST'S HAND, NINTH RECENSION DRAFT

▼ G

GAG-NURSE *n.*, *Oathen* A nurse who sits with the Appetite-struck, who compulsively swear, ready to clamp a hand over the grille of their iron bit in the night. *It's never the oaths that get you. It's the little things you say on the stairs*. A canyon proverb calls the gag-nurse the only honest woman in Tacit, because she never lets anybody finish a sentence. See *sitter* in the second half of this dictionary.

GALLERY *n.*, *Oathen, Cradlewrack* In the canyons, a tier of dwellings cut in the cliff; the Galleries are the respectable quarters of Tacit, and

Gallery-bred means raised to speak in exits. In Morwen Hall in the highlands, the Veiled Galleries are where the Caul-lines live behind their membranes. *Gallery talk*, in either land, is talk that commits to nothing.

GATHERED *n.*, *Cradlewrack* A creature assembled of Parts that have found one another without the Assemblers' help: the size of a dog and the shape of no animal, hungry, wanting the parts it is missing. *Something's gathering in the ravine* is a highland warning not to walk home alone. See *Part* and *ankle-biter*.

GAVAGE *n.*, *Fatlands* Force-feeding by funnel, the punishment for refusing a meal; the means by which the Thin Rising of 455 was put down. *To be gaviged* is to have something forced on you for your own good: a husband, a sermon, a new tax. The Thin speak the word the way the Vigil speaks *sleep*. See *funnel* and *Feasting Laws*.

GENTLE *adj.*, *Fast* Of the Host: not yet doing anything worse than laying tables. *The god has stayed gentle* is the Verger's belief and the Fast's prayer. *Gentle as company* means kind in a way that will kill you. Unfed mothers do not call their children gentle.

GIFT, THE *n.*, *Common* The second doctrine: that the gods offered themselves out of love, and the Regrowth is a tragedy neither side wanted. On the coast it is *the Lending*. Its believers are soft-spoken, tired, and hated by both other camps. *A Gift face* is the expression of someone forgiving you for something you have not done yet. See *Theft*, *the* and *Bait*, *the*.

GILDED CELLS *n.*, *Oathen* The cells where the Sayers are kept, bitted in gold, whose words come true. *Gilded* in canyon speech means locked up for the good of everyone: *They've gilded the old man*, of a patriarch whose sons have taken his voice. See *Sayer* in the second half of this dictionary.

GILT MILE *n.*, *Brinehollow* The brokers' quarter of Lowmark, where pier-notes, mortgages on pier not yet built, are traded. *Gilt Mile promises* are speculation on a future the arithmetic forbids. See *arithmetic*, *the*.

GLAD CENTURY *n.*, *Sallowreach* The first hundred years after the Gorging, when nothing in the fen died and it looked like a miracle: no widows, no orphans, dancing. The dancing stopped when the first generation began to come apart. *A Glad Century marriage* is one that seems wonderful for the first decades and is unbearable for the next six hundred years. See *fresh as a Glad Century fiddler*.

GLASS HOUSE *n.*, *Vigil* The quarantine for contagious yawners, where Lukas Marre, whose yawn once put down a market square, lives masked and alone and apologizes through the pane. *Glassed* means quarantined, or socially cut: *After the Bonfire business, his family glassed him*.

GLOVE *n.*, *Sallowreach* Black kid sewn on at the wrist, worn by every Hand-line noble after the Appetite, and by Closers on duty. *Gloves off* in the fen is not a figure of speech for frankness but a threat of death. *Mittened* describes a Hand-line child at the Appetite, and by extension anyone who has been stopped from touching things. *Kid-gloved* means rich. See *Gloved*, *the*.

GLOVED, THE *n.*, *Sallowreach* Osric Vane, deep in the Course, whose grey hands have nine joints a finger, kept in lead mittens in a locked wing, asking politely to be used on the enemy. *To unglove* someone is to let a dangerous person do the thing they were made for. *A Gloved request* is a polite asking that everyone knows will one day be granted.

GLOVEHALL *n.*, *Sallowreach* The seat of the Closers in Lastgate, with a garden where pears grow that do not rot. *A Glovehall pear* is a thing too perfect to be natural and too expensive to refuse; also, in the Heirs' slang, a Closer's daughter.

GNAW, THE *n.*, *Fast* The Empty Tooth: the strength the Unfed draw from endured hunger, at the price of a Pang. *He's on the Gnaw* means a man is running on nothing and frightening to cross. Reckoners on a raid say it to one another instead of goodnight. See *Empty Tooth* and *Pang*.

GOB-BIT *n.*, *Oathen*, *children's* The bitted children's handtalk sign for an adult who talks too much: two fingers snapping shut over the mouth. Grown Oatheners who see a child make it at them blush to the collar.

GODEATER *n.*, *Fast*, *Common* What the Unfed call everyone else on the Table, with satisfaction. Also used of the High Cuts by the poor of six lands, without it. Rim folk in the Fast are asked early, as a courtesy, how their blood is coming along. *Godeater manners* means a full belly and no shame. See *Unfed*.

GODSIGN *n.*, *Common* The marks of an eaten god returning in a person: the Taste, the Appetite, the Course, the Brink. *Showing godsign* means visibly changing; *godsign in the family* is the Table's most common euphemism for madness, deformity and rank. The College grades godsign by tasting blood. *A Godsign man*, in the Rim's mouth, is one skilled in understanding and steering the god in his own veins, and is trusted by nobody.

GOING HOME *phr.*, *Brinehollow* The Deepening's word for the Calling, used by Mother Limpet at her night baptisms; never used by the Netwatch, who drag the Called back. The College records it as a euphemism of grief. A family that says their daughter *went home* has usually found her bed empty and the rope knotted from the inside. See *Deepening*, *the*.

GOING UNDER *n. phr.*, *Vigil* The state of the Dream-Divers, who go down into the long room on a tether and are dragged up by force; like sleep with the eyes open and the mind awake at the bottom of it, listening. Most divers manage three. Senna Vole has done forty, and on the last something behind the lid said her name. *Gone under* is said of a diver who did not come up, and of anyone lost to an obsession.

GOODWIFE'S LIE *n.*, *Common* The small falsehood every wife on the Table is said to tell daily, *I'm fine*; in Oathen it is a Weight 1 Breaking, the lips split at the corners in a thin line, and the husband sees it and says nothing. *A goodwife's lip* is a canyon woman's split mouth, and is not remarked upon.

GOR *interj.*, *Fatlands* An exclamation of delight at food, of great antiquity, said to be the first syllable of *Gorging*. Fatland children say it at every plate. Unfed visitors who hear it leave the room.

GORGING, THE *n.*, *Common* The killing and eating of the gods at the end of the ninth year of the Long Lack, on the Night of Seven Tables, or across a season; the event from which the years are counted and the world was shaped. From Old Table-speech *gor-orren*, the great eating, or so the College says; the canyons have no record of the word, since they did it in silence. *Since the Gorging* means *forever*. *A gorging* is any gluttoned feast, and is used in the Fatlands as a compliment and in the Fast as a curse.

GRACE *n.*, *Common* The words *Lack keep away*, said before eating with strangers, eyes lowered, hand flat on the table; skipping it is the universal insult. In Brinehollow, *and keep you dry*; in Cradlewrack, *and let it stay*; in the Vigil it is followed by a slap on the table; in Oathen it is signed; in the Fast it is said anyway, to the empty air. *Graceless* means a person who does not care if you starve. See *Lack keep away* in the second half of this dictionary.

GRACE *n.*, *Common* (1) Spring, the first season, when the Kept Rain falls in Oathen and the bricked rooms of the highlands are opened. (2) In the College's usage, a stroke of luck so complete it seems given: a doubled roll gone right. (3) The Long Grace: the age itself, six hundred and forty-one years between the meal and the bill, the breath a family holds before it is permitted to eat. *The Grace is ending* is said now in every land, and nobody laughs. See *Bill*, *the*.

GRACE ROLL *n.*, *College* The College physicians' term for any trial of a person's skill against the world. *Every throw's a Grace Roll* is a Rim

gambler's proverb, meaning that the gods are watching even when you play knucklebones for crumbs.

GRANDAM'S BARGAIN *n.*, *Oathen* A release from one oath bought by swearing a greater one over it; from Grandam Cess, the Vow-Eater of the back canyons, whose clients are free of what they came with and owe her something worse. Any cure that becomes a debt: *The Company's loan was a Grandam's bargain.*

GRANDMOTHER COIN *n.*, *Common* A Dole-bone; one of the oldest lacks, yellow and smooth. Children's word, used by adults when they want to avoid saying what grandmothers have to do with it. See *Dole-bone.*

GRANNY *n.*, *Fatlands* A grandmother, and any pot of stew of uncertain provenance. *Every pot has a granny in it. Granny's in the gravy* means a family secret has come out at dinner. Fatland children call the low warm hills around Sated *the grannies*, and leave flowers on them, and the hills like it.

GRAVE-TABLE *n.*, *Fast* A little table found laid beside a new Unfed grave in the morning, for one, with a candle burning. The family breaks it with an axe and buries the pieces. *A grave-table on him* means a man much mourned, by everyone, including the Host.

GRAVY *n.*, *Fatlands* A river; the rivers of the south run thick and warm and are called, without irony, gravies. The Brawn, which runs past Sated, is the Great Gravy, and its tributaries the Little Gravies. *Down the gravy* means downriver, or dead. *Gravy Row* is the market lane of Sated where the cookshops are.

GREEN-BOTTLE *n.*, *Sallowreach* The fat green fly of the fen, which favours the eyes of the newly lacquered. *Green-bottle eyes* means bright, wet and hungry, and is said of moneylenders. Fen children catch green-bottles in jars and race them, which is how most of them learn to count.

GREY HANDS *n. pl.*, *Sallowreach* The Course of the Hand-lines: hands gone grey, cold and many-jointed, whose touch finishes things. *Grey-handed* is an adjective of terrified respect, and also, in the Drowned Storeys, of a good pickpocket. See *Closer.*

GREY WINTER *n.*, *Cradlewrack* The worst thing that ever happened to the Barren Order, which was not violent. The Order will not describe it. *A grey winter* is highland slang for any calamity that comes as a long silence rather than a blow.

GRIEVOUS *adj.*, *College* Of a wound or an oath: past mending. *A grievous unmaking* is the canyon Bench's phrase for a Breaking that takes something that will not come back, as an eye or a voice. Rim surgeons have borrowed the word.

GRISTLE, HONEST *n.*, *Fatlands* A butcher who can taste what a cut used to be, down to the name; from Hob Gristle, ruined for his trade by his gift. *Don't be so Gristle about it* means *don't ask what's in the pie*. See *butcher's grace.*

GRISTMOOT *n.*, *Rim* The market town on the Fatlands bend of the Rim where the great market is held four times a year, at the turn of each season, for a Plate's length. *Gristmoot honest* means honest until noon,

which is when the pickpockets are cut down from the market cross so as not to put off the trade.

GROAN-BOY *n.*, *Rim* A potboy at a Company inn, who takes the crumbs left under plates for the next traveller's luck. *Fed the groan-boys* means one's charity went to the wrong people, as all charity on the Rim is said to do. See *Plate's share* in the second half of this dictionary.

GROANING BOARD *n.*, *Rim* The Company's largest inn, on the Fatlands stretch, with a common room seating six hundred at one table, a sloping floor whose gutter carries the grease away, and dishes excellent and unspecified. *A Groaning Board welcome* is a feast you will regret. Foreign guests are advised to eat lightly and not be at the far end when the wardens roll a Gut-line out at closing.

GRUB-GRAN *n.*, *Fatlands, children's* A Seated grandmother whose mouth still works; children are taken to visit and must feed her a little of their supper with their own hands. *Say bello to grub-gran.* The visits are fond. The children's hands are always counted afterward.

GRUE *n.*, *Sallowreach* A person who will not retire; from Ansel Grue, the Unvacated Regent, four hundred and twelve years old, three hundred of them in office, mostly wire, lacquer and habit. *The guild's run by a pair of Grues.* Fen Heirs chalk *GRUE* on the doors of the Unvacated as other nations chalk *TYRANT*. See *Unvacated* in the second half of this dictionary.

GUEST *n.*, *Common* One who is fed at another's table; the newer of the two words for it in Table-speech, and the only one this dictionary prints. In the Fast, *a guest of Orrum* is one who sat down and did not rise. Of the older word: it has no plural, is not printed in any dictionary on the Table, and appears in this one only as the gap below. *Use the new one.* See *Eighth, the* and *count the chairs.*

GULLET, THE *n.*, *Oathen* The deep ravine at the heart of the canyons where the Silent Supper was held and Tolm was eaten without a word; on the Night of Ears pilgrims walk it barefoot and lay their ears to the warm sand. *Down the Gullet* means said where the god can hear it.

GUT-DOWN *adj.*, *Fatlands* Of a Gut-line noble: past walking, carried by litter, dray or oxen. *The Chairman's been gut-down thirty years.* The Litter Toll on the Rim is charged by the bearer, and the south pays it gladly, as a mark of rank.

GUT-LINE *n.*, *Fatlands* The nobility of the south, who ate Ummer's stomach and entrails: the largest, the hungriest, the furthest along. Their estates are run from beds and then from the ground. *Gut-line* as an adjective means rich and hungry and rooted in place. *A Gut-line bargain* is one in which you will be digested slowly. See *Laden* and *Dowager.*



*My grandmother taught me come in as a swear-word
before she taught me my name. I was nine before I
learned that in other lands it is what you say to
friends. I was sick behind the inn.*

AN UNFED CRUMB-RUNNER, AT WANTING POST

▼ H

HALLOWBOARD *n.*, *Fast* The stone table of the Refusal on a bare hill at the exact centre of the continent: eight-sided, always clean, where Orrum laid itself down and the heartland would not eat. *To swear at*

Hallowboard is to swear barefoot in an ancestor's footprint in the chalk trench. The Unfed lower their eyes on saying the name; everyone else counts its sides and then wishes they had not. See *Barrows, the.*

HAND-LINE *n.*, *Sallowreach* The nobility of the fen, who are Ossel's hands; their touch, at the Course, is the only death available in Sallowreach, sold by licence for five hundred years. *Hand-line* as an adjective means aristocratic and deadly at once. *Hand-line hours* are the hours a Closer keeps: late, gloved, expensive. See *Closer*, *glove* and *domestic license*.

HANDTALK *n.*, *Oathen* The sign language used in the canyons for everything that matters little: prices, directions, gossip, jokes, flirtation; held not to bind. That belief is being tested, and fingers have started breaking. Oatheners sign with the left hand where they can, because it is the hand they can spare. *Handtalk love* is a flirtation nobody means, and since Mirren Osk's three fingers snapped, a dangerous one.

HANGING ABBEY *n.*, *Brinehollow* The Anchorites' cliff, hung with a thousand living monks in chains. *Hanging on like the Abbey* means enduring something unbearable on principle. Fishwives use it of difficult marriages. See *Anchorite*.

HANGING-DAY *n.*, *Rim* Any day at Gristmoot market, where pickpockets are hanged on the market cross in the morning and cut down by noon. *Every day's a hanging-day at Gristmoot* means *the law here is quick and not careful*.

HARDTACK-HYMN *n.*, *Rim* A dirge sung by Company caravanners on the long stretches of the Rim, to the rhythm of chewing ship's biscuit; most verses are about the Fast and what one sees over the Hem at dusk. Factors forbid the last verse.

HE'LL KEEP *phr.*, *Sallowreach* A problem can wait forever, since nothing in the fen ends. Said of a debt, a feud, a grandfather on the stoop, a leak. The most comforting and most damning phrase in the north. *The roof'll keep. Your father'll keep. I'll keep.*

HEAD OF THE TABLE *n. phr.*, *Rim* The chair at the head of the long table in every Company common room, in which nobody sits, not the factor, not a Spoke; it is the Company's chair, and nobody has ever seen the Company sit. *Who's at the head of the table?* on the Rim means *who really owns this?* and is not answered. Compare the Second Table's fifth rank, who presides from an empty chair.

HEARER *n.*, *Oathen* A priest of Tolm before the Gorging, forbidden to speak in the god's presence except to repeat, word for word, a vow someone had made, so the god could hear it twice. Their descendants are said to be the Keeners. The last Hearer's knotted cord is kept in the Ledger's sealed rooms and nobody can read it. *A Hearer* now means a person who repeats your words back to you to make them stick: a nagging spouse, a good teacher, an informer.

HEARSAY MOOD *n.*, *Oathen grammar* The canyon verb-form marked *-sed*, rendered *I am told*, in which all gossip, most prices and much testimony is spoken so as not to bind the speaker to its truth. *FRESH THIS MORNING, I AM TOLD*. A Hearsay man is a gossip; a Hearsay king, in the old songs, is a ruler who claims to know nothing of what his ministers do.

HEARTH-LIT *adj.*, *Fast* Of a house: with a fire already burning, which the First Rule says never to enter. *Hearth-lit* is an Unfed word for any trap that looks like welcome, and for any person who smiles too readily. *Her eyes were hearth-lit* is how an Unfed widow describes the stranger who took her son.

HEAVY *adj.*, *Fatlands* Beautiful, prosperous, healthy, good. *You look heavy* is the kindest thing one Fatlander can say to another; *you look well* means nothing. *A heavy man* is a man of weight in the Board's sense too, since votes are weighed. Heavy is the southern word of praise, and *light* its worst insult short of *thin*.

HEEL-PEBBLE *n.*, *Vigil* The small stone cobbled into the heel of every Vigil shoe so that each step hurts. *A heel-pebble friend* is a friend who keeps you sharp by making you uncomfortable, the best kind in the Vigil.

HEIRS, THE *n.*, *Sallowreach* The living young of the fen, permanently disinherited, since owners never die and a man of seventy is a minor while his father is upright. *An heir's chance* is no chance at all. Jory Welt, seventy-one, leads them, with a map of every Hush on his wall. *Heirloom*, in the fen, means a grudge.

HELPING *n.*, *Common* A second portion; in the College's physicians' usage, an extra effect won by doing a thing very well. *A second helping* is a second chance, and an unwise one. The Second Helping is the joyous Fatlands cult of the Bait whose prophet Brother Glut volunteers parts of himself. *Help yourself* is, in their mouths, a theological proposition.

HEM, THE *n.*, *Rim* The knee-high wall on the inner side of the Rim Road, facing the Fast. It does nothing; anyone can step over it. Nobody does. *Over the Hem* means beyond help, beyond law, beyond sense. Rim children dare each other to sit on it, and are pulled off by passing wardens, who do not explain.

HESSOP'S DISH *n.*, *Fatlands* A meal served at a wake at which the dead was much loved, and the family eats slowly, weeping and praising. From the Hessop household's famous wake of 611. *A Hessop's dish* is any task carried out with love and horror both. See *Wake* in the second half of this dictionary.

HICCUP-FAST *n.*, *Fatlands* The Fatlands' annual attempt, on Tablenight, to fast for one day in penance. Nobody has ever recorded a village that made it to sundown; most break before the second meal, with the hiccups. *A hiccup-fast* is any resolution that will not last past breakfast.

HIGH ADMIRAL'S BARNACLES *n. pl.*, *Brinehollow* Problems that do not exist, attended to with great ceremony: from High Admiral Corvin Sund, who has the hulls of his landlocked fleet scraped of barnacles that are not there. *Scraping barnacles* means busy work in a crisis. Saying *stranded* in his hearing is a hanging matter.

HIGH CUT *n.*, *Common* A person of Cut 4 or 5; the nobility of every land, the furthest along, the most monstrous, and the Reckoners' quarry. *High-cut manners* means appalling behaviour by someone you cannot touch. *High-cut cooking* means meat that has been somewhere expensive. See *Cut*.

HILL *n.*, *Fatlands* A Seated Gut-line or Laden person, become a low warm mound where things grow very well; some keep a mouth. Hills are consulted on marriages and hold title in law. *A hill never says no* is the south's warning about appetite. *Hill-speaker* is the title of one who interprets a hill's mouth to the family. *She's gone to hill* means she has finished becoming a place. See *Dowager* and *field*.

HOARDING *n.*, *Fast* The crime of keeping back part of a ration, punished by a cut in measure. Among the Unfed, *a boarder* is the equivalent of a miser elsewhere, and a child's crust under a mattress is a matter for the Elders. The College notes that Abstain Rooke, eleven, has been leaving her crust on the windowsill instead, which is not hoarding, and is worse.

HOGGET'S TALLY *n.*, *Fatlands* The Long Count of the Reaped, begun by Pell Hogget of Low Tilth and copied now in two hundred villages, on barn doors, in strokes. *On Hogget's tally* means taken by the fields. The marks: a stroke for each Reaped, a cross-barred stroke for each dusk-shifted who did not return, a circle for the Seated, and since 638 a

stroke with an open curve at the top, like a hand held out, for *taken by a bill*. See *Long Count* in the second half of this dictionary.

HOLD YOUR LINE *v. phr., Brinehollow* To keep faith; from the wedding vow *I will hold your line*, sworn as each partner knots the other's end of a shared anchoring rope. *Who's holding your line?* means *who loves you?* and also *who's making sure you don't walk into the sea?*, which on the coast is the same question. See *anchor*.

HOLDER, THE *n., Cradlewrack* The small faceless clay figure in the lintel-niche over every highland door, arms spread to either side, touched on going out and coming in. Nobody calls it Vey aloud. Children are told it holds the door, and are not told which way. *The Holder holds* is said when something terrible has not happened yet.

HOLDING-HOUSE *n., Rim* A place on the Rim where poached people are kept between the Hem and the buyer: a cellar, a barn, a back room at an inn with a reputation. *Stopping at a holding-house* is poachers' cant for a profitable night. Dr. Mercy Thrane keeps a list of them.

HOLLOW *adj. and n., Fast* The state of an Unfed at the end of Want, when hunger has emptied the self as well as the stomach; the Hollow are quiet, clear and unafraid, and are the ones who walk into the Host's houses calmly in the dark. The word is said with respect and dread. *She's hollowing* is said of a starving neighbour by those who will not share. See *Want* in the second half of this dictionary.

HOLLOW-BELL *n., Fast* The bell rung at the door of an Unfed house every dusk for a year after a child goes missing, calling its name, presumed Seated; then the ringing stops. *I heard the hollow-bell at the Danners'* is how a neighbour says a child is gone. The Unfed hold no funerals for the Seated. You cannot bury a guest who has not left.

HOME, GOING *phr., Brinehollow* See *going home*.

HONEY-TABLE *n., Fast, children's* One of Orrum's tables laid for children: the most beautiful, all honey and custard and little iced cakes, with a voice from the door that is always a mother's or a grandmother's. Unfed children who have seen one describe it to one another in whispers for years. *Honey-table voice* is how they describe any grown-up being too nice.

HONORABLE MAGGOT *n., Sallowreach* Justice Ever Lathe, a judge rotted down to bone and a resident colony, whose rulings are delivered in the buzzing and translated by a clerk; nobody is sure any longer which of them is deciding. *A maggot ruling* is any judgment whose true author is unknown. *Ask the maggots* means take it to a higher court that will not be human.

HOOK *n. and v., Brinehollow* The long boathook of the Netwatch, with which the Called are dragged back from the shore by night. *Hooked* means rescued against one's will. A *hooker*, on the coast, is a Netwatch patrolman, and the joke that follows from this in other lands has never once been found funny on the Mile.

HOPE-STEW *n., Fatlands* A thin dish of the Leanings made in hard years, said to taste of whatever the eater hopes it is. Since the Reaping doubled, the price of hope-stew in Sated has risen; nobody asks what it is cut with. See *Leanings* in the second half of this dictionary.

HORROR *n., Common* Dread, revulsion, a sight not to be borne. The College's etymology, which the College publishes with a small mark meaning *disputed*, derives it from Old Table-speech *h'orr-*, the breath drawn in before eating, the pause at the board before the first bite; that is, the Long Grace itself. Linemen like to say that every horror on the Table is only the moment before dinner. Students are asked not to repeat this in the Fast.

HOST, THE *n., Common* Orrum, god of the hearth, of welcome and the shared table; the only Provider not eaten, still walking the Fast, very tall, stooping under doorways, warm, laying tables wherever it passes with a chair pulled out. *The Host is laying* means a table has been found. *Host-kind* means kind in a way you must refuse. In the Fast it is not named indoors. See *company, come in* and *Steward*.

HOSTWATCH *n., Fast* Trackers who follow the god at a mile's distance and map the warm ground where it has walked, and who carry a bell on a cord at the belt that rings when the Host is near. In the last two years the bells have begun to ring on the Rim Road, at inns. *Ring the Hostwatch* is the Fast's alarm cry. *A Hostwatch face* is lonely, alert and very tired.

HOURLYKEEPER *n., Vigil* The mistress of the city's clocks, Maud Sexton, who has proved by pendulum that each hour is a little longer than the last. *Hourkeeper's arithmetic* is proof of something everyone can feel and nobody will admit. *The hours are long* is now a Vigil greeting, and not a complaint.

HOWL-WEEK *n., Cradlewrack* The week of the Grey Winter that the Barren Order does not describe; among highland midwives, any week in which more is born than can be attended. *A howl-week at the Lying-In* means the aprons are not sleeping and the Tally is being written in two hands.

HUM *v., Vigil* To make a low, continuous, soothing sound; forbidden at rouse-stalls, in nudgers' contracts and in public places, since humming is the beginning of a lullaby. *Don't hum at me* means *don't patronize me*. *No humming* is chalked on every stall in the Pinchmarket. See *Lullaby, the* in the second half of this dictionary.

HUNGER *n., Common* The appetite of the god in the blood, distinct from any want of food: a Fatlander can eat until the belly splits and still feel it. In the College's physicians' usage, a measure from 0 to 10 that rises when one calls on the god and, when full, pushes the Regrowth one step further. *My Hunger's up* means the god is close today. *Hunger is honest* is an Unfed proverb, said to end arguments. See *Partake* and *Sop* in the second half of this dictionary.

HUNGERBOUND *adj., Common* Under the god's compulsion; driven by Hunger to the land's Want. *Hungerbound* is used by physicians, and by the poor of every land of their lords. *They're not cruel, they're hungerbound* is the most generous thing said of the Gut-lines in the Leanings.

HUSH *n., Sallowreach* A patch of the fen where everything ends at once and stays ended: no rot, no flies, no echo, no sound. The first was Dunmere in 633; the largest is four miles across and growing, and the Hushes appear fastest near Hand-line estates. *Hushing* is used of a family whose elders are dying properly at last, and the neighbours are jealous. *Hushwalker* is the name for one who walked into a Hush and walked out, which happened once. The College records the Finishers' walking-in as a grief. See *Dunmere, to* and *Finisher*.

HUSH TOLL *n., Rim* One lack a post charged on corpses carried along the Rim, so named because the dead are silent in every land but one. The Kept are not corpses and pay as Foot, once. *Paying the hush* means taking someone home to be buried, and is a phrase of great tenderness on the road.

HUSH-MONEY *n., Rim* A bribe; but on the northern Rim also money paid to a Finisher family to keep quiet about a pilgrimage, so that the Court will not hear that a licensed good was stolen. Both senses are common at Fogmouth.

HUSH-PENNY *n.*, *Sallowreach* A lead token laid on the tongue of a Kept elder on feast days to keep them quiet during the reading; children call them *shut-eye pennies*. *He needs a hush-penny* is said of a bore. See *Shut-Eye pennies* in the second half of this dictionary.

HUSH-WATER *n.*, *Rim* Water said to be drawn from the edge of a Hush, sold as a cure for undeath and for noise. It is almost always fen water and does nothing; the real thing finishes whoever drinks it, which is a cure of sorts. *Selling Hush-water* means selling false peace.



I AM HERE *phr.*, *Oathen* The safest first words a canyon child can choose at the Unbitting, after twelve years in the leather, since they bind only to the present and are true as soon as said. Families who choose a motto instead are thought proud. *I am here* is also what the old say to the Keener at their own entombment, if they are still able to speak, and the Keener writes it on the niche.

I WILL GO INTO THE ROOM *phr.*, *Cradlewrack* The single vow of the Attendance, sworn by every apprentice midwife; the one vow in Cradlewrack nobody has ever been known to break, though many have died keeping it. Highlanders use it of any duty that must be done whatever is waiting on the far side of the door. *Someone has to go into the room*.

I WILL HOLD YOUR LINE *phr.*, *Brinehollow* The wedding vow of the coast. See *hold your line*.

ICE-PLATE *n.*, *Fast* A plate of frost on a field in the morning, unbroken, proving the Host has not walked there in the night. *An ice-plate morning* is a good one. *Breaking the ice-plate* means bringing bad news.

IDLE-HAND *n.*, *Sallowreach* A hand-line child's mitten, by which the nursery keeps the small Appetite-struck from closing everything in reach. *Put your idle-bands on* is the fen's *mind your manners*. A Hand-line governess's whole skill is getting mittens on children who do not want them.

IF ABLE *phr.*, *Oathen* The first and plainest of the canyon exits, the Exit mood, marked *-ra*: a promise conditional on being able to keep it. *I will come home, if able*. Spouses parting in the morning say *If able* and the other answers *Go on*, and by contract this binds neither. *If able* is carved on half the gravestones at Quillhouse, where travellers leave their conditions on the wall. See *exit*.

ILAN'S LOOK *n.*, *Oathen* The face of something that exists only because of a promise, and is beginning to fade now that the promiser is gone; from Ilan, the Oath-Child, nine, whose father died in the spring and who has become difficult to see. *He's got Ilan's look* is said of any orphan, kindly, and of any institution whose founder is dead, not kindly.

IMPOSTOR *n.*, *Common* The delusion, contagious on the Table, that a loved one has been replaced by something wearing their face. On the coast it is often not a delusion. *I'm not who you think* is the reply in the highland lane game *Who's in the Brick?*, at which everyone screams and runs. *The Impostors* is what physicians call the madness, and what Wreckwives call their husbands.

IN LACK *adj. phr.*, *Oathen* In canyon marriage law, the condition of a spouse who has ceased to wish the other well, and is held not to have broken the article of cherishing for one season while attempting, in good faith, a recovery of the wish. *They're in Lack* is the canyon's whole vocabulary for a failing marriage. There is no word after it, because there is no divorce.



It smells like your mother's.

THE WORST THING ONE UNFED CAN SAY TO
ANOTHER, AND THE MOST COMMON WARNING IN
THE FAST

IN SEEMING *adj. phr.*, *Vigil* Hallucinating, as every Vigilant does after enough waking. *I'm in Seeming* excuses a person who has just spoken to a lamp. If a whole street is in Seeming together, it is news. See *Seeming* in the second half of this dictionary.

INCISION-DAY *n.*, *Cradlewrack* The day a Tongue-line or Caul-line infant born with a sealed mouth or a closed caul is cut open, so it can feed. In the highlands it is kept quietly, like a birthday nobody sings at. Compare the canyon custom, the same in all but name.

INDOOR TIDE *n.*, *Brinehollow* The water that rises twice a day in every cellar of the coast, however far inland, and drains again, leaving kelp on the stairs. *The tide's in* is said when the house is full of relatives. *Below the tide line* means the cellar, and what is kept in it. See *ebb*.

INKTHUMB *n.*, *Rim*, *rude* A Copyist of the College, by the ink-black right thumb that never washes clean; by extension any clerk who knows more about your family than you would like. *Inkthumbs at the Inkborn* is how the Quire innkeepers describe their trade.

INTERVAL, THE *n.*, *Cradlewrack* The days between pangs, now nine. Everyone in the highlands knows it by heart, and children are named by it: Lark Thirtydays became Lark Ninedays. *What's the interval?* is a highland greeting. *Nine days* is said now as a farewell, in place of *good night*, with a shrug. See *pang*.

INVITATION *n.*, *Fast* In the College's physicians' usage, the pull the Host exerts on those who have smelled its bread, heard its voice, or seen their own name on a place card; measured, like Hunger, and as dangerous. *She's had an Invitation* is said of an Unfed who has begun to walk past houses slowly. See *place card* in the second half of this dictionary.

IRON BELLY *n.*, *Fatlands* The Taste of the Regrowth in the south: a stomach that can take anything, soil, tallow, leather, and does. *Iron-bellied* is a compliment to a child and an accusation against a merchant. The children who have it chew their sleeves.

ISS *n.*, *Vigil* The Lidded, god of sleep, eaten with its eyes still shut; it did not wake while they did it, a detail that has never stopped bothering the Vigil. Its name is said quietly and never near a sleeper. *By Iss* is a Vigil oath of extreme seriousness, sworn with eyes held open by the fingers. Vigil children are told that if they say the name three times with their eyes shut, the lid will lift.

IT WORKED ONCE *phr.*, *Common* The creed of the Second Table, engraved inside the band of a Trencherman's signet: when the gods finish regrowing, eat them again. In the mouths of the poor it has become a sneer at any scheme of the rich: *Another war? Well, it worked once*.

◇

*In the canyons I said if able to a Clausewright and he
smiled at me as if I'd handed him a knife and turned
my back.*

A RIM FACTOR, ON HIS FIRST SEASON AT
QUILLHOUSE



JACK, TO *v.*, *Sallowreach, Rim* To steal a part from a living or Kept body while it shelves or sleeps; from Marrow Jack, the part-thief of Lastgate, whose victims wake able to feel what their missing hands are being used for. *Jacked* means robbed of something you will feel the absence of forever. Fen mothers tell children who leave their arms outside the blanket that Marrow Jack will have them.

JANGLE *n.*, *Fast* The ringing of a Hostwatch bell at the belt, which means the Host is near. *I heard a jangle at the Rim inn* is a new and frightening sentence. *Jangle-sick* means nervous of every bell, and is common among Hostwatch widows.

JAR ROOM *n.*, *Sallowreach* The Court's prison: one shelf, very long. On quiet nights the low shelf ticks and taps like a roomful of people waiting. *Off to the Jar Room* is a fen parent's threat, not meant, and children who have been there on a school visit never need it said twice.

JAR, TO *v.*, *Sallowreach* To sentence a criminal to be Kept forever, in pieces, in a jar, on the long shelf of the Jar Room; the Court's ultimate punishment. The heads float in amber pickle with their hair drifting upward; the hands are jarred separately, a pair to a jar, and are the busy ones, drumming. *Jarred* is the fen's word for any sentence without end. A Sallowreacher who says *I'd sooner be jarred* means *never*. Ned Scurl asked to be jarred near a window.

JAW-CLICK *n.*, *Sallowreach* The speech of the Kept far gone, whose throats no longer work, conducted by clicks of the jaw and translated by hired interpreters; an argument begun in 212 is still being conducted this way, in a room in Lastgate. *Jaw-click lawyer* is a fen insult for a pettifogger. *I could hear his jaw clicking* means a man was furious and could not say so.

JAW-WIRE *n.*, *Sallowreach* The wire with which the oldest Kept jaws in Lastgate are bound shut until a promise falls due, under the oath sworn with a hand in a Kept parent's mouth; when the debt is broken, the wire is cut, and the parent may close their jaw. *Cut the jaw-wire* means *call in the debt*. See *oath on the dead* in the second half of this dictionary.

JELLY *n.*, *Fatlands* Aspic; in the mouths of Sated's gossips, the display of a rival. See *Aspic, in*. *Jellied* means trapped in a situation where everyone can see you and nobody will help.

JESSAMY'S WORD *n.*, *Rim* The witness on which every Company contract rests: Jessamy Quill, Notary of the Rim Road. If she dies or breaks, half the trade of the Table comes unbound in an afternoon. *As good as Jessamy's word* is the Rim's highest guarantee. *When Jessamy goes* is how factors say *at the end of the world*.

JOINING, THE *n.*, *Cradlewrack* The Assemblers' rite of fitting a new Part to the figure in the Barn. *A Joining* is also a highland wedding between families who had previously quarrelled over a Part, and the guests do not look too closely at the bride's sleeves.

JOINT *v.*, *Fatlands* To cut a carcass into its parts, a skill every Fatland child learns: how to joint a pig, a sheep and a person, and that the order is the same. *Joint it* means *break it down into manageable pieces*, and is said of tasks, problems and arguments. *Out of joint*, in the south, means badly butchered.

JOINTER *n.*, *Fatlands* A slaughterman of the Renderers' Union who works the wake-tables of families who cannot afford to carve their own dead. Respected, sad and well-fed. *A Jointer's grace* is a few kind words over the body before the knife.

JOLT *n.*, *Vigil* A dose of rouse taken in a hurry, dry, against the gum, when a blink has been felt coming. *Jolt-mouth* is the black, toothless smile of a Vigilant over forty. *I need a jolt* is the Vigil's *I need a drink*. See *rouse* in the second half of this dictionary.

JONAH, DRY *n.*, *Brinehollow* Captain Jonah Skerry, smuggler of bottled bail-water. *A dry Jonah* is any man who profits from a trouble that does not touch him. *Jonah's tonic* is bottle-sea. The Vigil has begun to dream about him, and does not know why. See *bottle-sea*.

JUDE'S HOUR *n.*, *Oathen* The hour Jude Crake, the Breaker, spends talking pleasantly with the condemned until they promise him something small; it has never taken longer. *Jude's hour* is any conversation in which someone is being drawn to their ruin by charm. See *Crake, to*.

JUDGE'S BUZZ *n.*, *Sallowreach* See *Honorable Maggot*. The buzzing in which Justice Lathe's verdicts are delivered. *I got the Judge's buzz* means *I got an answer I couldn't understand and must obey*.

JUG-GRAN *n.*, *Sallowreach, children's* A Kept relative so far gone that she is kept in a stoneware jug on the shelf and taken down on feast days to be read to. Fen children love their jug-grans, who are always pleased to see them and cannot stop them from eating sweets. See *Setting Aside* in the second half of this dictionary.

◇

I wish it would stop.

THE FIRST WORDS OF THE FIRST SAYER, 598 A.G.,
DURING A STORM; IT STOPPED, AND SO DID
EVERYTHING ELSE IN THE VALLEY

KEENER *n.*, *Oathen* A keeper of the Witnessing Vaults, where the canyon dead are entombed upright, faces outward, to witness the oaths of the living. Before a body is set in its niche the Keener asks the corpse, formally, whether each promise made to it in life was kept. The dead do not answer. Usually, Keeners hate bone-lifters above all criminals. *To keen* in the canyons does not mean to wail; it means to ask the dead a question and wait. See *Testify* in the second half of this dictionary.

KEEP *v.*, *Sallowreach* To go on existing after death, as all the fen does; to look after one's dead. *Keeping* is the family duty of holding the Kept together: six or seven generations share a house, grandmothers are restitched each spring, and the quarrel over whose turn it is to keep great-great-grandfather is the standard subject of fen comedy. *He'll keep* means a problem can wait forever. *Keep well* is not a fen blessing. See *Kept, the*.

KEEP *n.*, *Fast* An Unfed given name, from the Refusal, meaning *to hold back*. Marshal Keep Aldane holds the border against poachers and pilgrims. Fen travellers in the Fast find the name very funny once, and then never again, after someone explains.

KEEP DRY *phr.*, *Brinchollow* The coast's greeting and farewell, in place of *good morning*, since mornings on the coast are wet by definition. *Keep dry* to a Brinchollower betrays a foreigner who has learned the phrase; *keep you dry* is the grace's coastal ending. A coast mother says it to a child going out the door the way other mothers say *be careful*, and means *come back*.

KEEP THE VEIL *v. phr.*, *Cradlewrack* To marry within the house, as the Caul-lines do, so that the caul stays thick; the thicker the caul, the higher the line. The Cutwrights record these unions in a locked volume in a private shorthand whose key the College does not lend. In the lanes of Kest, *keeping the veil* is said, low, of any family that does not marry out, and of what that implies, and nothing more is said.

KEEP-SALT *n.*, *Rim* Salt from Mother Gall's pickling brine in the fen, said to keep a body sound and the soul in it; sold in the cure trade as a remedy for dying abroad. Mother Gall's cellar holds four hundred customers in barrels, paid up in advance, all wide awake. *Keep-salted* means preserved and conscious, and is how the fen describes a long, unhappy marriage.

KEEPER *n.*, *Fast* One of the party of the Abstinents who hold that the Unfed's duty is to refuse, endure and stay clean; opposed to the Reckoners, who carry the Refusal across the Rim on a blade. *A Keeper's patience* is the endurance of someone who will starve rather than act. Reckoners use it as an insult.

KEEPER-AWAKE *n.*, *Vigil* A wake-valet: a professional who keeps the rich awake by an artistry of tolerable pain. Jack Tenterhook, the best of them, was a torturer before, and says the only difference is the tipping. *She's had a keeper-awake since she was six* explains a Height lady's beautiful manners and the scars on her wrists.

KEEPINGS *n. pl.*, *Cradlewrack* Births that do not leave the body: a small perfect hand growing from the inside of an elbow, a cluster of fingers at the base of a spine, an ear opening in the side of a neck which hears, and which the bearer hears with. The Book of Questions has three hundred pages of cases. The Attendance may cut a keeping free, and it then becomes a Part, crawling, hungry, drawn to the others; and the place it was cut from remembers. *She has a keeping* is said in a lowered voice.

KEEPSAKE-STRIP *n.*, *Fatlands* The strip of a husband's wake-meat, dried hard as leather, kept in a little bone box by widows of the Leanings, to put on the tongue at night when they cannot sleep. *She's got him in a box* is said of a widow, fondly. To steal a keepsake-strip is considered, in the south, worse than murder, since murder only takes the living.

KELP, THE *n.*, *Brinchollow* Brenna Kelp, Salt Assayer, keeper of the falling number, who hid three copies of the arithmetic. *Doing a Kelp* means hiding the truth in three places so that the state cannot burn it all at once. See *arithmetic, the*.

KELP-STAIR *n.*, *Brinchollow* A cellar stair on the coast, slick with the weed the indoor tide leaves twice a day. *Mind the kelp-stair* is the coast's *watch your step*, and is said to anyone going down into a matter better left alone.

KEPT BONE *n.*, *Rim* Lack cut from the bones of the Kept, perfect in every respect except that it never stops decaying; in a few weeks it goes greasy and grey and smells faintly of the fen, and a purse of it sweats and draws flies. *Kept-bone money* is income that will rot. Fen counterfeiters swear the coin is untraceable. The flies trace it.

KEPT MAN'S WAGE *n. phr.*, *Sallowreach* Nothing at all; the wage of Kept labour, who do not need to eat and therefore, the fen employers argue, do not need to be paid. *Working for a Kept man's wage* is how the living poor of Lastgate describe their own pay, and why they hate the Unvacated.

KEPT RAIN *n.*, *Oathen* The rain Tolm promised the canyons on the first day of Grace before it died, which has fallen on that day for six hundred and forty years because a god's word outlives the god; this year it came three days late. *As sure as the Kept Rain* was the canyon's strongest guarantee. It is not said any longer. Yusra Thole, the Rainwarden, has said nothing at all for a month.

KEPT, THE *n.*, *Sallowreach* Those who have died in the fen and carried on, who outnumber the breathing nine to one: the mind stays, the pain stays, and the body goes on coming apart for centuries. A Kept person who steps across the border drops, finished, at once. *Kept* is the fen's neutral word for the dead and its tender word for the old. *Long kept* is a compliment. *Badly kept* is a reproach to a family. See *keep, arrears* and *Drop, the*.

KEPT-BREATH *n.*, *Rim* The bottled exhalation of a Kept elder, sold in the cure trade to the sleepless of the Vigil as a draught of deathless rest. It is fen air, warm, sweet in the wrong way, and smells faintly of the person. *Selling Kept-breath* means selling a dead man's promise.

KERB-HOUR *n.*, *Vigil* The one hour Vigil mourners are permitted to sit on the kerb beside a boarded corpse; the only lawful sitting in the city outside the Watch's benches. *She took her kerb-hour* means she grieved properly. *A kerb-hour friend* is one who sits with you in sorrow and stands at the bell. See *Boarding*.

KERCHIEF-BIT *n.*, *Oathen* A bit made of a folded kerchief, tied over the mouth of a foreigner at Mumchance who has been seen to be talkative; offered politely, with a card of safe phrases. *Take the kerchief* means *shut up before you break something*. Every year somebody refuses it and leaves on a stretcher.

KEST *n.*, *Cradlewrack* The highland capital and seat of the Attendance: a city of round red buildings without a single door that locks. Pronounced with the knock: *'Kest*. *A Kest door* is one that does not shut, and *Kest-*

shut means not shut at all. A Kest child is said to be born knocking. See *knock*.

KETTLE FURROW *n.*, *Fatlands* A village of the Leanings whose barn wall bears the oldest copy of Hogget's tally, kept in strokes since the Long Count began. *She's from Kettle Furrow* explains a Fatland exile's homesickness, since her mother is a slope near it. *Kettle Furrow sums* are counts that only go up.

KEYSTONE-MOTHER *n.*, *Cradlewrack* The eldest bearer in a household, through whom the whole Tally line runs; the most important person in any highland family. *She's the keystone* means everything depends on her. When a keystone-mother dies, the household is said to be *unbinged* for a year, whether or not the parish takes the doors. See *unbinging* in the second half of this dictionary.

KICK *n.*, *Cradlewrack* The King Within's means of government: one kick for yes, felt by the Queen Dowager, who has carried him forty-four years and reports to the court. The Book of Kicks records them. *Kick for it* means *vote*. She is ninety and very tired, and lately he has begun to answer questions nobody asked. See *Aubrey's kick*.

KICKER *n.*, *Cradlewrack*, *rude* A courtier who claims special insight into what the King Within wants. *The Kickers say he's for the war*. Sneered at by everyone who is not one. Compare *Aubrey's kick*.

KIN-KNIFE *n.*, *Fast* A killing within an Unfed family for a reason the Fast's own creed supplies: a son back from the Rim with buttoned sleeves, a sister who craves tallow, a cousin found to carry High Cut blood. The Abstinent will not omit for godsign. Families have sometimes decided that the Five Rules were not enough. *The kin-knife came out at the Danners'* is said, and nothing more. See *Standing* in the second half of this dictionary.

KIN-NAME *n.*, *Cradlewrack* The line of descent recorded in the Tally, which runs through whoever bore you; in many cases this requires a footnote. *What's your kin-name?* means *who carried you?*, and the answer may be a woman, a man, a grandfather, a well, a hill, or *without bearer*. Descent-fraud, claiming a bearer who did not bear you, is a great crime.

KIN-READER *n.*, *Fast* The third rank of a Reckoner band: the one who holds the stolen genealogies and plans which beds, in what order; marked by a stolen College quire. *A kin-reader* among the Unfed is also any gossip who knows too much about who married whom on the Rim. The College regards the title as theft and the work as excellent.

KINDLY *adj.*, *Brinehollow* Of a returned spouse: changed for the better, in the way that frightens. *He came back kinder* is the coast's most chilling sentence. A Wreckwife who says her husband is *very kindly now* is asking for help without asking. Sennet Gull keeps hers in the cistern, brings him his dinner, and has started to prefer him. See *Tenanted* and *after*s.

KING WITHIN *n.*, *Cradlewrack* The rightful king of the highlands, in the womb of the Queen Dowager for forty-four years, consulted on matters of state by kicks. *Rule like the King Within* means govern from somewhere nobody can see, by signs nobody can read, and *a King Within* is any heir who refuses to arrive.

KINSALE *n.*, *Rim*, *poachers' cant* The sale of one relative by another to a poacher or a parts-surgeon, which happens more often than the Rim admits, especially at the end of a long Lack. *Kinsale price* is the lowest price for anything, since the seller only wants it gone. Dr. Mercy Thrane has traced three kinsales to the same surgery. See *Cage Toll* and *Blank*.

KITCHEN YEAR *n.*, *Common* The sixth year of the Long Lack, the year the songs leave out, when the dead were kept at home and the pot was put on, and then the lots were drawn, and children were sent across

the village to cousins so that no one would have to eat their own. *Kitchen Year* is never said at a table. *That was before the Kitchen Year* means *before we were all guilty*. The College publishes its account only in cipher. See *trading tables*, *aftertaste* and *bread-cousin*.

KITCHEN, TO *v.*, *archaic*, *Common* To eat a dead kinsman at home in the sixth year of the Lack, before the Bone Dole made it a matter for the state; preserved in old depositions and in one Fatlands curse, *may your children kitchen you*, which is the worst thing anyone in the south has ever been heard to say, and is said perhaps once a generation, at a deathbed, by someone who has been wronged beyond bearing.

KITCHEN-BONES *n. pl.*, *Common* Bones of the Kitchen Year found by builders under hearthstones, cracked lengthwise for the marrow; a skull in a chimney-breast wrapped in a christening gown; a pot in a bricked canyon cupboard with a spoon still standing in it. Such finds are not reported. They are wrapped in clean cloth, by custom, and carried at night to the nearest crossroads and left. *Taking them to the crossroads* means burying an old shame without a word.

KNACKER *n.*, *Fatlands* A worker of the Renderers' Union who deals in the parts of a beast that cannot be sold as meat: hoof, horn, bone, and the long bones that go north in carts marked BONE: MIXED. *Knacker's arithmetic* is the reckoning that always comes out in the Union's favour. See *Chute*.

KNEE, OF THE *adj. phr.*, *Oathen*, *Rim* Of a canyon courier: died of a Breaking by arriving late, the knee reversing on a sworn delivery; the Fogmouth register of 641 records an Oathen courier dead *of the knee, having arrived*. *Of the knee* is used on the Rim for any death by duty. The Seal Toll is waived for couriers under an Oathen oath, since the Company will not delay a sworn word.

KNEEL-WATER *n.*, *Rim* The tea-brown pool at the Weeping Post where travellers of two lands kneel and ask forgiveness for the Meal. *To go to the kneel-water* is to apologize for something you did not personally do, at great length, in public. See *Confessor*.

KNIFE *n.*, *Fast*, *Cradlewrack* (1) The second rank of a Reckoner band: the one who enters the house, bearing the black-iron blade, unadorned. (2) In the highlands, the Second Opinion, the midwife's knife; *the Knife-faction* of the Attendance holds that it has kept the country together for six centuries. *Under the knife*, in either land, means judged and found unfit to continue. See *Opinion*, *Second* in the second half of this dictionary.

KNIFE-AND-EAR *n.*, *Oathen*, *children's* A counting game of bitted canyon children, played in handtalk, in which one child is the Ear and listens while the others sign promises, and the Knife points at the one whose fingers flinch. Mothers beat it out of their children, silently, in doorways, since a game about promises is no longer a game. See *Closed Hand*.

KNIFE-APRON *n.*, *Cradlewrack* The white apron of an Attendance midwife with the knife-case at the hip that nobody looks at directly; boiled three times in the Coppers, the third water poured on the hill. *She's put on the knife-apron* means a woman has taken up a terrible responsibility. Opinions develop a callus on the inside of the ring finger where the hook of the knife rests, and wear it like a brand.

KNIFE-FACTION *n.*, *Cradlewrack* The party within the Attendance led by Midwife-Paramount Orla Kest, holding that the Second Opinion has kept the country together for six centuries and must stay steady until the interval closes. Opposed by the Late-faction, who whisper that the knife was six centuries too late. *Knife-faction talk* is any argument that the old cruelty is the only safety.

KNOCK *n. and v., Cradlewrack* (1) The gravest courtesy of the highlands: one knocks before opening any door, to warn whatever is on the other side. *Knock first. It's not for your sake.* A greeting is three knocks. (2) The small catch in the throat with which highlanders begin any word that starts with a vowel, so as not to enter it unannounced; the tell of the dialect. (3) Mourners knock three times on a new brick in the Stillyard and do not wait for an answer. *She knocks four* is said of a dead woman who has begun to answer. See *brick* and *Knocking Gate*.

KNOCK-FOUR *n., Cradlewrack* A dead kinsman in a Stillyard wall who knocks back four times after a pang instead of the mourners' three: the beginning of a haunting, a birth, or both. Hobb Marl of Mortar Rise, on the Debt Wall for his brother's death, says his mother still knocks four, every pang. *Knock-four* is said of anything that should be finished and is not.

KNOCK-SHY *adj., Cradlewrack* Afraid to knock at a door for fear of what will answer; a condition of highland children after a pang, and of highland adults after a funeral. *Don't be knock-shy* is what an apprentice midwife is told on her first night, and then she goes into the room.

KNOCKING GATE *n., Rim* The Company station at the Cradlewrack border where Marshal Gideon Breech's men check every traveller for signs of carrying. Its inn, the Open Door, has no doors at all, only curtains, so that nothing can be accused of breaking in; visitors knock on the frames out of politeness, and occasionally something knocks back from inside an empty room. *Through Knocking Gate* means *got away*, and the highland proverb answers: *the country goes with you*.

KNOT *n., Brinehollow* The coast's whole morality. *Tie your own knot* means take care of yourself and trust no one else's rope. A *loose knot* is a

crime, punishable by bucketing. *A Sounder of the ninth knot* had dived nine fathoms past the bursting of the eardrums. A Rim inn near the coast charges a crumb a knot for tying a guest to the bed. *Knot-week* is the first week of a coast marriage, when the couple sleep roped to each other and nobody else.

KNOT CANYON *n., Oathen* A gorge of the back canyons, with lime-pits where bone-lifters dump the stolen dead; the bones Testify from there all the same. *Thrown in Knot Canyon* means hidden somewhere it will be found out anyway.

KNUCKLEBONES *n. pl., Common* The sheep's ankle-bones every house on the Table owns, for games and for drawing lots; in the Kitchen Year, the lots for the pot were drawn with them, because every house had a set and a knucklebone does not lie. The College holds a set from a Brinehollow cottage, yellow with handling, five bones and a sixth, smaller, separate, which is not a sheep's. *To throw the knucklebones* means to leave a hard choice to chance. Children play the game everywhere still, and say the old rhyme, and do not know what it means. See *Who's for the pot* in the second half of this dictionary.



The College has nothing further to print under this head.

THE WHOLE OF AN ENTRY IN THE NINTH
RECENSION, BETWEEN *GUEST* AND *GULLET*, STRUCK
FROM THE ABRIDGED EDITION BY ORDER OF THE
ARCHPROVOST



CHAPTER 12

THE LEXICON OF THE TABLE

L-Z

*A word is a mouthful you have agreed to share. Chew it before you swallow it, and know
whose it was.*

– PREFACE TO THE QUIRE WORD-BOOK, SECOND HALF, FOURTH RECENSION
(641 A.G.)

The second half of the College’s word-book picks up where the first left off, at the letter that begins *Lack*, which is as good a place as any to begin a description of the Table. Like its sister volume, it was compiled by Copyists and Linemen of the Cutwrights’ College on their rounds, from the mouths of innkeepers, Seamers, nudgers, Renderers, Clausewrights, Crumb-Runners, children at doorsteps and the dead on their shelves, and corrected (where the Compiler could bear to) against the College’s own ledgers. It is a working book. The College wants to know what people call things, because what people call a thing is what they are afraid it is.

The Compiler is a Cutwright of the Chapter-House at Quire, and has asked that her name be left off the title page, on the grounds that several of the words below are about people who would recognise it. Her marginal notes are kept, set off in brackets, because the Archprovost found them useful and because she would not let them be cut.

HOW TO READ AN ENTRY

Each entry gives the word, its kind (*n.* noun, *v.* verb, *adj.* adjective, *interj.* interjection, *phr.* phrase, *prov.* proverb, *excl.* oath or curse, *title, child.* nursery word, *cant* thieves’ or trade jargon), the land or road where it is heard (*common* means everywhere on the Table),

and a definition, often with an example *in italics* as it was overheard. **Bold** names point to another entry, in this half or the first. Words marked *cant* should not be used in front of the people they describe. Words marked *child.* should not be used in front of their mothers.



*I have written down every word they would say to me.
The ones they would not, I have written down too,
from behind doors.*

THE COMPILER, IN THE MARGIN OF THE L PROOFS

USING THE LEXICON AT THE TABLE

The Lexicon is a prop and a toolbox. Read an entry aloud as an NPC’s line; hand a player the insult their character would know; let a Guest who speaks a word correctly in the right land take +1 to a Persuade or Deceive roll there, and let a Guest who uses one wrongly (calling an Oathener *talkative*, wishing a fen-widow *long life*) face a Hard 14 Tongue + Persuade roll to undo it. Every few entries carries a hook: a name, a place, a rumor. Where an entry gives a rule, it uses the standard numbers.



LACK *n., common* 1. The nine-year famine before the Gorging, the **Long Lack**. 2. Winter, the fourth season. 3. Poverty, hunger and bad luck, which on the Table are one condition and need only one word. 4. On the dice, a failed roll showing doubles, the worst plausible complication. *Lack sat down at our table in my grandmother’s time and never got up* (a Rim way of saying a family has always been poor). See also **lack**, **Licked Clean**.

LACK *n., common* The bone coin: a salt-cured disc the width of a thumb-joint, pierced for the string, stamped with the Plate on one face and an empty circle on the other, worth a day’s bread. Ten **crumbs** to the lack, twenty lacks to the **platter**. Struck at Saltbridge since 212 A.G. from bone the Company calls cattle. *The lack is thin this year* means bread is dear. (Compiler: the empty circle is either “the bread to be bought” or a chair seen from above. I have looked at it from above. I recommend not doing so.)

LACK-BITTEN *adj., Rim* Of a coin: clipped at the edge by someone shaving bone dust to sell as tooth-powder. Of a person: thin in a way that shows at the wrists and the temples. *Lack-bitten lacks for lack-bitten folk* (said of the change in a Thimble Cross tavern).

LACK KEEP AWAY *phr., common* The grace said before eating with strangers, everywhere on the Table, and the oldest sentence anyone still

uses. Omitting it is the universal insult, worse than a blow, and in some inns a cause for the bill to be doubled. Said fast in the Fatlands, signed in Oathen, mouthed in the Vigil, and in the Fast followed by *and keep the Host away*, under the breath. See **grace**.

LACKLING *n., Rim, cant* A child born in the Lack season, held unlucky on the Rim and lucky in the Fast. Crumb-Runners prefer lacklings as carriers, because they are used to cold and expect nothing.

LADDER-HAND *n., Sallowreach* The lowest Loft-Warden: one lamp, one key to one hall, and a list of the Set-Aside to be read aloud to. Ladder-hands are mostly orphans and the very old. Their wage is three lacks a week and whatever the shelves whisper.

LADEN *n. and title, Fatlands* 1. Ummer, the eaten god, *the Laden*. 2. A Fatlander at **the Course**, swollen past proportion, feet rooting, skin gone soft and loamy. Among the Gut-lines it is a title, used on letters: *To the Laden Dame Marrable, at table*. Among Scraplings it is said with the hand over the mouth, as you might say *dying*. A Laden person who roots becomes a hill; see **Dowager Hills**, **Seating**.

LADLE *n., Fatlands* 1. A Bailiff’s badge of office, the lowest rank of the Board’s men, carried at the belt. 2. *v.* To force-feed under the Feasting Laws, gently or otherwise. *They ladled him at the crossroads and he*

thanked them for it after; he had no choice, his mouth was full. See **Gavage**.

LAIN BOOK *n.*, *Vigil* The ledger kept by Teodor Rell of the Slope, in which the notes the Lain-Down leave behind are copied out and sent with them to the Dormitory. It is the saddest book on the Table and the Watch has twice tried to have it burned. People queue on the Slope to read a page aloud, so that the note will have been heard once.

LAIN-DOWN *n.*, *Vigil* A Vigilant who lay down on purpose. The law says **voluntary rest** and fines the nudger; the city says *went to the room* and does not discuss it. Those left go and stand at the foot of the bed, which has a number and no grave, for the rest of their lives. *My brother is Lain-Down. No, he is well. He is at bed fifty-eight thousand. He looks very well.* See **Lain Book**.

LAIN LANE *n.*, *Vigil* Any street where a Lying-Down has happened; specifically the lane behind Gallow Street, where the neighbourhood walks the long way round by Thimble rather than pass it. *Don't go by the Lain Lane, love; take the stair.*

LAMP-FRIEND *n.*, *Vigil* A stranger you have stood beside under the same lamp for long enough to have seen the same Seeming. A lamp-friend has a claim on you for one favour. Lovers on the Slope begin as lamp-friends; the phrase is also used, bitterly, for people who only know each other through shared hallucination.

LAMP-MEAT *n.*, *Vigil, cant* The tallow in the lamps of the Row and the poorer streets, which the Lamplighters' Guild buys from wherever it can. *Smell that? Lamp-meat. Somebody's uncle is lighting the corner.* (Compiler: the Guild calls it economy. Wick Tallow calls it a partnership.)

LANCING *n.*, *Rim* A massacre carried out by the **Purgation** against a high-Cut family, named for the lancet and the lancing-spear. Lancings are announced the night before by a pewter bowl left upturned on the doorstep. The family usually knows what the bowl means. The neighbours always do. The word is also used for any act of violence done *for someone's own good*, and the Vigil's Wakers have adopted it with pride.

LAND-DROWNED *adj.*, *Brinehollow* Drowned in bed for want of bailing, the lungs filled from the inside with sea that came from nowhere. The body is easy to know: the lips are white with salt and there is kelp in the throat. *Land-drowned* is the coast's commonest death and its least spoken of, because someone was supposed to wake them.

LARDLORD *n.*, *Fatlands, insult* A Gut-line landowner, heavy with rent and fat, who will not leave his bed to see the land he owns and could not if he wished. Said by tenant-farmers behind the hand, and once, in 455, through a speaking-trumpet in the square at Sated, after which the speaker was fed until he stopped.

LAST BELL *n.*, *Rim* The dusk bell that closes the lawful market at Gristmoot and other Company towns. What is sold after it is sold in the pens behind the stockyards, a bowshot and a half from Company law. *After Last Bell* is Rim slang for anything you do not want written down.

LAST CAKE *n.*, *Rim* The final thing a Crumb-Runner eats at Wanting Post before crossing inward with the grain, bought from the Company counter and never finished; the half left on the plate is for luck. Innkeepers at the Post keep the half-cakes on a shelf, by name, and throw them out only when the Runner comes back.

LASTGATE *n.*, *Sallowreach* The capital of the fens, on pilings, where the border road ends. Its lower storeys have been sinking for centuries and are inhabited all the way down. *Lastgate manners*: courtesy so slow that it takes a century to deliver an insult, and does.

LASTING *n.*, *Sallowreach* The dread of a living fen-child that she will never be allowed to finish. Mothers whisper *no Lasting for you* over cradles, as an Oathener would whisper *if able*. See **Long life**.

LAST VERSE *n.*, *Sallowreach* The final verse of a song, which in the fens does not exist, since nothing there can finish. Bram Hollin, the Last Mourner, knows the old funeral rite with its Last Verse, and is the only man alive who does. To *sing someone the Last Verse* is to Close them, or to wish it. A Last Verse heard sung aloud in Lastgate is a Dread 1 event; people weep in the street.

LEAN *n. and title, Fatlands* The second rank of **the Thin**: one who has been taught where the safe barns are and been given a share of the ash-bread. Also the Board's word for any fasting rebel, used in warrants. *Wanted: one Lean, sex uncertain, weight unrecorded, believed to be eating nothing in the Bleeding Orchards.*

LEAN HOUSE *n.*, *Fast* The building at the edge of Wanting where the omitted go when their names are left off the Pantry list, to lie down among others in the same case and wait, with dignity, in clean linen. It has never been full and never been empty. *She walked to the Lean House* is the Fast's commonest obituary.

LEAN LEVY *n.*, *Fatlands* A tax on the thin, assessed on the bones that can be counted from across a room. The Board calls it a tax on the withheld portion; the Thin call it a bounty on ribs. Levy-men carry callipers. *He paid the Lean Levy and still had money left; he couldn't have been very thin.*

LEATHERING *n.*, *Sallowreach* The stage of the long rot at which a Kept body has dried, darkened and toughened like an old saddle, around the second century of being upright. Leathered grandmothers are sharp as vinegar and hard to restitch, because the needle will not go through. *She's at the Leathering* means she is old, proud and impossible.

LEAVINGS *n.*, *common* Any part of a high-Cut body, a Seated place or a god-touched thing that still holds some of the god, and is cut, kept, traded and used: a ninth joint, a Laden pear, a Tenanted tear. The trade has its own book (*Seven Tables, The Carving Knife*). On the Rim the word also means simply what is left on the plate. *Leavings to the dogs and the dogs to the Board.*



*On the Rim, three words in five are about food, and
the other two are about who is going to pay for it.*

THE COMPILER

LEDGER, THE *n.*, *Oathen* The cliff face at Tacit into which every vow of public record has been carved: four miles long and growing by a yard a week. Scribes cut it by lamplight in the season of Carving. To *be on the Ledger* is to have made a public promise. To *be off the Ledger* is to be a child, a foreigner or a liar. A miscut on the Ledger in 640 broke a man who had kept his word perfectly, and nobody has explained it.

LEFT HAND, THE *title, Sallowreach* The chief Closer of the Mortuary Court, at present Lady Corrow Vane, whose gloves are sewn on. *Gone to the Left Hand* is a polite way of saying someone has bought a Closing and is, at last, about to be properly dead. Children play *Left Hand, Right Hand*, a touching game in which the one who is touched has to lie down and not get up until the next round.

LENDING, THE *n.*, *Brinehollow* The coast's name for the doctrine of the Gift: Dromm lent itself to the hungry, and the sea is coming back to collect what was lent. Lending-folk are gentle with the Tenanted. *It's not*

stealing if it was lent is what Lending-folk say of the Calling, and what nobody else on the coast can bear to hear.

LENDING A LIGHT *phr., Vigil* Keeping a stranger awake for a while, unpaid, as a kindness: walking beside them, pinching them, talking. *Lend us a light, mister, my nudger's gone.* It is the commonest beggar's line on the Slope and the commonest way robbers open a conversation.

LESSENING, THE *n., Vigil* The quiet party in the Watch of Watches that would like the number of the Counted to be reduced. Its members never say how. Its badge, never worn openly, is a pillow embroidered with a single stitch. *A Lessening sort of man* is a man you would not leave alone at a bedside.

LICENSER *title, Sallowreach* A clerk of the Mortuary Court who drafts and seals Closing licenses, and may move one name a season up the waiting list. Licensers are the most bribed people in the north and the most hated, after the dead.

LICKED CLEAN *adj. and n., common* 1. A new moon, the Plate empty; nobody sets out on a licked-clean night, doors are barred, plates are not counted. 2. On the dice, double ones: automatic failure and a Lack. 3. Utterly ruined, with nothing left on the bone. *We came back licked clean: no mules, no coin, and Harrow's left hand.*

LICKER *n., common, insult* A Scrapling, in the mouths of the high: one descended from those who licked the bones. Among Scraplings, the word is a boast at harvest and a fighting word in the mouth of anyone else. *Licker's luck:* little god, little to lose.

LID, THE *n., Vigil* 1. The plateau on which the city stands. 2. The great closed eye at the far end of the long dim room in the sleepers' dream. *Under the Lid* means asleep, gone. *Over the Lid* means abroad, anywhere but the Vigil. Divers who have come within thirty paces of the Lid say it is not quite shut.

LID-SALT *n., Vigil* The salt crust that forms on lidless eyes between wettings, scraped off by the Eye-Wetters and sold as a love-charm on the Slope. Real lid-salt from a noble eye fetches a lack a pinch. Most of it is scraped from the corners of beggars. See **tear-salt**.

LISTENER *n., several lands* A rank, or an office, in at least four orders: the Wreckwives (who listen at the wall for a Tenanted spouse's second voice), the Dream-Divers (who sit at the top of the tether and hear the diver's breath), the Barren Order, and the Echo-Wardens of Oathen. All four kinds of Listener go deaf in the end, in different ways.

LISTEN TWICE *phr., Oathen* Advice to anyone in the canyons: a thing you hear once may be a person; a thing you hear twice is an echo, and binds. *Listen twice before you nod.*

LISTS, THE *n., Fatlands* The reading of the Reaping's missing in every village square on Carving afternoons. Not a holy day; everyone attends. The reader is chosen by lot and may not stop to weep. *She went off the Lists* means she was found, which happens about once a decade, and was not glad of it.

LOFTS, THE *n., Sallowreach* The warehouses of the Set-Aside in Lastgate: nine storeys of shelving, forty thousand of the too-far-gone wrapped and labelled and awake, whispering. The sound is audible from the street. *Shelf-talk* is what the Lofts say; *Loft-wise* is what you are after a week of listening to it. Lately the whole building says one word. See **whisper-book**.

LONG COUNT, THE *n., Fatlands* Pell Hogget's tally of the Reaping, begun in Low Tilt and copied now in two hundred villages, on notched staves, on barn doors, in the backs of Feasting Law primers. The

numbers rise every year. *Keep the Long Count* is a Thin blessing and a Board offence.

LONG GRACE, THE *n., common* The age itself: the six hundred and forty-one years between the meal and the bill, a long pause like a grace said before eating, before the gods finish growing back. *The Grace is ending* is said at every bad harvest, late rain, odd birth and new Hush, and is said more often every year.

LONG LACK, THE *n., common* The nine years of famine before the Gorging, numbered backward by scholars (Lack 1 to Lack 9) and by nobody else at all. Each year has a name: the Thin Harvest, the Empty Nets, the Barren Stalls, the Ash Bread, the Leather Winter, the Kitchen Year, the Bone Dole, the Eldest Walk, the Turning. *As long as the Lack* means forever.

LONG LIFE *excl., Sallowreach* The worst curse in the fens, and the most dangerous thing a foreigner can say there by accident. Said to a Kept person it is a slap; said to a living one it is a threat. Fen children who quarrel say it to each other and are whipped. The proper wish is **May you finish**.

LONG TABLE, THE *n., Fast* The valley road where six hundred years of the Seated sit at one continuous table, nine miles end to end, lifting empty forks together. The sound of them chewing is like a herd grazing. *Gone to the Long Table* means lost to the Host. Do not look for anyone there for long. People who look for long enough find a chair.

LOOSE *adj., Sallowreach* Of the Kept: coming apart at a seam, in public. Falling loose has been a fineable offence since the Stitching Laws of 130 A.G. *He's gone loose at the jaw again, poor soul; fetch the Seamer and a cloth.* A *loose-parts man* is a part-thief or a back-alley seamer; see **Marrow Jack**.

LOSE THE BOTTOM *phr., Brinehollow* Originally a pilot's phrase, when the sounding-lead finds nothing. Now: to sense the pull, to stand too long at a west-facing window, to be on the way to being Called. Hask Tarn will not go near the places where he once lost the bottom, though they are dry land now.

LOWING *n., Fatlands, cant* Drovers' word for the sound Sal Trotter's herds make on the road at night, which is not quite the sound cattle make. *They were lowing in words again by the river.*

LOWMARK *n., Brinehollow* The capital: a pier-city nineteen miles long built out across the dry seabed after the retreating sea, a mile a year. Its quarters are called Miles, numbered from the old shore. *Living on the Twelfth Mile* is living in the slums; *living on the First* is living on the old money and the old smell.

LOW WATER *n., Brinehollow* The lowest tide of the year, in late Carving, when the Tenanted gather on the Uncovered and sing, and families watch from the rail of the Mile. *She sings at Low Water* means she is Tenanted. Ilse Marl's transcriptions of the singing, laid end to end, make a chart.

LULLABY, THE *n., Vigil* The Vigil's name for the doctrine of the Gift: Iss gave its sleep so that the city could be awake, and the room is where it keeps what it was given. The faith of most ordinary Vigilants, and the one hymn the Wakers allow to be hummed, never sung.

LUNG-LINES *n., Brinehollow* The noble houses descended from those who ate Dromm's lungs, chief among them the Vashts. They cannot breathe air for long, and hold court from glass tanks. *Lung-proud* means vain, and the poor of the Mile use it of anyone who holds their breath to look important.

LYING-IN *n.*, *Cradlewrack* Any confinement at all, of anyone, of any sex or age, for any reason, since in the highlands anyone may come to bear. *The Lying-In*, capitalised, is the Attendance's fortress hospital, where the

births nobody speaks about are taken. *She's gone to the Lying-In* is said of a woman who will not be seen again, and of her child, and of whatever it was.

▼ M

MAGGOT-WISE *adj.*, *Sallowreach* Wise in the way of the very old dead: slow, cold, entirely right and of no use to anyone living. From Justice Ever Lathe, the Honorable Maggot, whose rulings are buzzed and translated. *Maggot-wise counsel* is advice that will be correct in a century.

MAKE THEM LAST *phr.*, *Fast* What Unfed mothers say when they hand children a crust. Also the motto over the Pantry door. In the Vigil the same phrase is said of rouse-tabs, bitterly.

MAKING GOOD *n.*, *Fast* The Unfed rite by which an omitted household that has survived a winter without the Pantry is put back on the list, and must thank the Abstinents who left them off, by name, aloud, at the Pantry window. *She made good last Grace and has not spoken to Elder Wend since, except to say thank you.*

MANGLING *n.*, *common* The table of Injuries the body takes at Ruin. Physicians' slang: a *Mangling* is any wound bad enough that the surgeon reaches for the saw before the needle. *Mangled* in the fens is a compliment to a Seamer's work: so ruined that only a master could have made it stand.

MARBLING *n.*, *Fatlands* The first frost, when the fat in the soil whitens and the plains look like a cut of meat from horizon to horizon. On Marbling Morning children run barefoot on the white veins. Some years the veins form shapes. *Marbled* means rich and also means very old.

MARDY *adj.*, *child.*, *Fatlands* Sulky from hunger, which in the south is the only kind of sulk there is. *Don't be mardy, there's a fifth meal coming.* Fatland grandmothers say a mardy child has *the field in its belly*, and give it a heel of bread to chew while it cries.

MARROW-JACK *n.*, *Sallowreach, cant* Any part-thief: one who takes limbs from the Kept while they shelve or sleep and sells them to back-alley seamers. From the most notorious, whose victims wake able to feel what their missing hands are being used for. *Marrow-jacked*: missing a piece, and aware of it.

MARROW-MOUTH *n.*, *Fatlands, insult* A greedy person, one who cracks the bones at the wake before the family has had the joints. Also used, approvingly, of babies.

MARRYING THE WATER *phr.*, *Brinehollow* Being Called. A gentle phrase, said by the Deepening and by grandmothers. *She married the water in her sixtieth year and we think she was happy.* The Netwatch use it with contempt.

MATRON *title*, *Vigil* The Keeper of the Dormitory, at present Cecily Dorm, the only living person who knows the number. *Matron's count* is any total you are not allowed to hear. *Matron's pillow*: an act of mercy that the law calls murder. Nobody says the second phrase above a whisper.

MAY YOU FINISH *phr.*, *Sallowreach* The polite greeting and farewell of the fens. Said to the Kept with feeling, to the living with affection, to the Hand-lines with care, since from them it can sound like a request. The reply is *In time*. See **long life**.

MEAL-MOUTHED *adj.*, *Rim* Speaking of horror only in food-words, so as never to say it plainly: *she was cleared, he's been served, they were picked*. The Compiler is told she is meal-mouthed herself. The whole

Table is. The first line of every history says it plainly, and then nobody does again.

MEASURE *n.*, *Fast* The Pantry ration: one oatcake, a handful of grain, sometimes a strip of dried Rim fish, weighed out by Mother Stint Avery's clerks. *Short measure* is the worst thing that can happen in a winter. *Full measure*, said of a person, means honest. An Orrum table sometimes lays out a Measure, but whole, and hot, and buttered to the edges, the measure as it should have been.

MEASURE-BEARER *title*, *Fast* The lowest servant of the Pantry, who carries the day's rations to the window and is searched on the way in and the way out, by two clerks, every day of their life. *Honest as a Measure-Bearer*: honest because watched.

MEAT SCRIP *n.*, *Fatlands* The Board's money: greased paper slips redeemable for a weight of meat at any Board store (the pound, the stone, the side). Its value falls every Carving with the Reaping, and Pell Hogget's tally-keepers chart the two together. *Scrip-fat*: rich on paper. *Paid in scrip*: paid in somebody.

MEMBER *title*, *Fatlands* One who holds a vote on the Board of Plenty by weight. A Member is immune from the dusk shift. *He's Member size* is a compliment. *He's lost his seat* means he has lost forty pounds, or died, which in the Fatlands are about equally shameful.

MERCY *n.*, *Rim* 1. A Fast name, given to girls born in a hard winter. 2. In Purgation cant, the Black Draught, the emetic given free on Retching Day at the Weeping Post. *Take your Mercy* means drink and bring it up. Dr. Mercy Thrane, who is from the Fast, does not find this funny.

MERCY-PINCH *n.*, *Vigil* A pinch given to a child who has begun to blink, hard enough to bruise, by a stranger in the street. Mothers thank the stranger. The bruise is called a *kiss*.

MERE-LIGHT *n.*, *Sallowreach* The glow on the fen at night from Wick Tallow's candles drifting on cork, upright and lit, leaning their flames toward passing punts. Following a mere-light is a fen child's dare. Children who follow it come home in the morning and say the candle told them its name.

MIDDLE PLATE *n.*, *common* The second month of any season, named for the moon. Dates are given *the ninth of Middle Plenty*. *Middle-plated* is Rim slang for a person of no particular class, neither Scrapling nor Prime, a common Cut 2. See Appendix, *Numbers, Measures and Time*.

MIDWIFE *title*, *Cradlewrack* A member of the Attendance, judge, physician, priest and executioner in one apron, who asks the Two Questions at every birth and answers them herself. *The Midwife's Two Questions: What is it? Does it stay?* Highland children play Midwife with dolls, and the dolls do not always stay.



Fen children learn three words before they learn their names: shut, stitch, and finish. In that order, says Mother Gall, if they're lucky.

THE COMPILER

MILE *n.*, *Brinehollow* One of the numbered sections of Lowmark's pier-city. Each Mile has its own bell, its own netwatch post and its own reputation. *A Mile-cart* is the long rail-trolley that runs the length of the pier; *riding the Mile* is commuting, and also being slowly drawn west.

MILE-MAD *adj.*, *Brinehollow* Restless in the way of the poor of the far Miles: walking out to the pier's end at night to watch the water, which is always a little further off. Mile-madness is the Appetite of the coast, in the mouths of people who will not say *the pull*.

MITHER *v.*, *Brinehollow* To fuss over someone's bail-bucket: to check its rope, its rim, its smell, the colour of what is in it. Mothers mither. Sweethearts who have exchanged buckets mither each other. *Stop mithering, I coughed clean this morning.*

MITTENS *n.*, *Sallowreach* Worn by sufferers at the Appetite, to stop the compulsive closing of lids, books, shutters and the eyes of strangers. Wool for the Taste, leather for the Appetite, lead for the Course. *He's in his mittens* means he is not to be trusted near the infirm. Osric Vane's are lead and locked.

MOOT *n.*, *Rim* A Company market town, especially Gristmoot, where every stall-keeper on the road comes at last, and the Grace Bell at noon stops three miles of stalls so everyone can turn to the nearest stranger and say the grace. *Moot-honest*: honest only within earshot of the Weighhouse bell.

MORNING COUNT *n.*, *Brinehollow* The dawn calling of names through the party wall, house to house, the length of a street, so that silence will show who was Called in the night. *Missed the count* means dead or gone. In every party wall there is a worn place, sometimes carved as an ear, where the names are called. See **plank-ear**.

MORTUARY COURT *n.*, *Sallowreach* The council of the Hand-lines under the Unvacated Regent, sellers and hoarders of death. *To have friends at the Court* is to be expected to die on time. *Court-dead*: Closed by license, as opposed to Hush-dead or foreign-dead.

MOTHERED *adj.*, *Cradlewrack* Descended from a particular bearer, who may not have been a woman, or a person. *I am mothered of Hessa Gorse, and through her of the well at Rudge* is a respectable pedigree in the highlands, with a footnote.

MOTHER OF CORDS *title*, *Cradlewrack* The eldest of the **Uncut**, whose cord has grown down into the red clay and become a **Root**; through it she feels the pulse of the land, and says it has two beats now. *By the Mother of Cords* is an Uncut oath; it is taken holding someone else's cord.

MOTHER OF THE WATER *title*, *Brinehollow* The head of the **Deepening**, at present Mother Limpet, who has walked two thousand into the sea at night with lanterns and says she will follow when the last is safely under. *Mother-of-the-Water patience*: the patience of someone who is going to win.

MOTH-WIFE *n.*, *Vigil* A Seeming that walks: a woman made of moths, who comes down the lane dimming each lamp she passes and smelling of

flour. Several districts have entered her in the public record. She is said to stop in front of people who are about to blink for the last time.

MOURNER *n.*, *Sallowreach* A trade six centuries extinct: one paid to weep at a death, back when there were deaths. Bram Hollin is the last, and in demand now the Hushes have come. *Hire a mourner* is fen slang for *make a fuss*, and has suddenly stopped being a joke.

MOUTH, THE *n.*, *Fatlands* The opening a Seated Laden hill sometimes keeps: a warm damp crack in the turf that exhales and, on consultation days, speaks. *Going to the mouth* is asking a family hill for advice on a marriage. The advice is always right. The hill is always hungry. Bring something.

MOUTHFUL *n.*, *common* 1. A unit of time: as long as it takes to chew and swallow one mouthful, about a count of twenty. 2. A unit of speech in Oathen: the most one may say at once without a Clausewright, by custom about nine words. *Say it in a mouthful or not at all.* See Appendix.

MOUTHLESS *adj.*, *Fatlands* Of a Seated Laden hill: one that kept no mouth. The courts have ruled that a mouthless hill still holds title. Mouthless matriarchs are consulted by the laying-on of hands on warm turf, and their heirs report what they felt, which is convenient for the heirs.

MUCK-SWORN *adj.*, *Oathen*, *cant* Of an oath: made in the Breakdowns, by somebody already broken, and therefore cheap, since the swearer has little left to lose. *I'll take your muck-sworn word for it, Splint, and your other kneecap if it fails.*

MUMBLE-SWORN *adj.*, *Oathen* Bound by an oath you did not hear yourself make, as by an echo, a sleep-talk, or a Sayer's careless sentence. Mumble-sworn oaths are the commonest cause of Breakings among the poor, who sleep in shared galleries where the walls carry. The Bench has no remedy.

MUMCHANCE *n.*, *Rim* 1. The quietest inn in the world, where the Rim enters Oathen; orders on slates, the bill in chalk. 2. *adj.* Silent from caution, the proper state of a foreigner in the canyons. *Go mumchance at the border and stay that way till Quillbouse.*

MUTE KING *title*, *Oathen* The ruler of Oathen, chosen in infancy, bitted for life, and raised to govern by gesture, so as never to have promised anything. At present Ket the Ninth. *A Mute King's nod* is any ambiguous signal that a committee will argue about for weeks.

MUTES *n.*, *Sallowreach* The silent assistants who stood at the door at old funerals; revived, unsalaried, since the Hushes began, by children who charge a crumb to stand at a Closing looking sad. Real mutes are very good at it. Most of them are Smalls, and know what it is to be finished in part.

MUZZLING, THE *n.*, *Oathen* The law of 215 A.G. requiring children to be bitted until twelve, after a generation crippled by careless promises. The muzzle is soft leather and lined with felt. *Muzzled young* is said of someone who still thinks before they speak. See **Unbitting**.

▼ N

NAIL-AND-GLOVE *n.*, *Sallowreach* A tavern game played by Kept and living together: a glove is laid on the table, and players take turns driving a nail through its fingers, with a hand inside. The Kept may use their own hands. The living may not. *Nail-and-Glove odds*: odds that favor the dead.

NAME-LOAF *n.*, *Fatlands* The loaf baked for a child's naming, and baked again for its wake, with the name scored on the crust. Marrow on toasted name-loaf is the dish for the most beloved dead. *I knew him from name-loaf to wake-plate* means for his whole life.

NAME-ROPE *n.*, *Brinehollow* The anchoring rope a Brinehollower sleeps tied with, which carries a knot for every name in the family, so that whoever is Called pulls against all of them. *Cut from the name-rope*: disowned. On the Steps, marrying is *taking the rope*.

NAME-STRIP *n.*, *Sallowreach* The linen label sewn to the wrapping of one Set Aside on the shelves of the Lofts, or tied to a sack sunk in the Sump. Finishers carry pilgrims' name-strips into the Hushes, with Saint Ysmay's first. A name-strip torn off a Sump sack is the start of a ghost story and the end of an inheritance claim.

NAMING-EXCHANGE *n.*, *Cradlewrack* The ceremony at the end of a highland child's first year, when it is clear what it is and it is given a name in place of its Tally-place (*Third of the Gorse household*). Until then the child is called *bit*, *small* or *keep*. Some children are never named. Some are named and then the name is given back.

NAN CORPSE *n.*, *Sallowreach, child*. Any very old Kept relative too far gone to be anything but frightening and dear. *Nan Corpse wants a kiss*. Fen children use it fondly, and refuse the kiss.

NAY *interj.*, *Fast* No. The Unfed give the word three times to any offer and accept, if they accept, on the fourth. *Nay* is also a girl's name. To *nay-say* is to refuse well; to *nay-and-take* is to refuse three times and then take with an ugly eagerness, the commonest Unfed hypocrisy.

NEAR HAND *n.*, *Sallowreach* The hand of a Closer that touches, as opposed to the hand that holds the license. Hand-lines etiquette: one does not shake a Closer's near hand, and one does not let a child stand at the near side of a Hand-lines lady at table.

NEEDLE *n.*, *Vigil* A Waker's long needle, used under the nail, behind the ear, in the armpit, to keep the drowsing up. Also the second rank of the Wakers. *Needle-kissed*: freshly woken by force. *Needle-sweet*: grateful for pain, the proper Vigil manners. See **rattle**.

NEEDLE STREET *n.*, *Sallowreach* The Seamers' quarter of Lastgate, where Threaders board on cots and spare parts hang in shop windows with prices chalked on their palms. *Gone to Needle Street*: gone for repairs. *Needle Street price*: the price of something someone else has already paid for in pain.

NETWATCH *n.*, *Brinehollow* The Admiralty's night patrol, who hunt the Called along the shore with net, hook and rope, and drag them home. *Netted* means saved, against your will, and the Called who are netted look at the Netwatch in a way the Netwatch do not describe.

NIB *n.*, *Oathen, cant* A scribe's word for the writing implement, now said with dread since written words have begun to bind. *Mind your nib* means do not write it down. Ottoline Vant has broken all of hers.

NIBLET *n.*, *child.*, *Fatlands* A very small bite taken from a sibling, in play, at the table. The Feasting Laws have nothing to say about niblets. Mothers do. *No niblets, Tansy, your brother's not for eating*.



*Nobody is a person in Cradlewrack. There are eleven
of them on the Tally this year.*

THE COMPILER, WHO CHECKED

NICHE-RENT *n.*, *Oathen* The fee paid to keep a family's dead in their niche in the canyon wall, where their jaws can, if an oath sworn on them is broken, open and speak it aloud. Families in arrears have their dead moved to the common gallery, where anybody may swear on them.

NIGHT OF EARS *n.*, *Oathen* The eve of Tablenight, when pilgrims walk the Gullet barefoot and lay their ears to the warm sand to hear what it says. It says one word a minute. Yusra Thole carries a goatskin of Gullet sand that beats like a heart.

NIGHT OF SEVEN TABLES *n.*, *common* The Gorging itself, whether it took one night or a season. Six meals and one refusal, which make seven tables, which is an arithmetic the College has never liked. (Compiler: Seven tables. Eight Providers. I have stopped writing the sum in the margin because the Archprovost asked me to.)

NINE DAYS, THE *n.*, 1. *Fast*; 2. *Cradlewrack* 1. The last nine days of Lack in the Fast, during which each household eats a quarter-measure less each day, in memory of the Refusal. 2. The present interval between pangs in the highlands, used as a byword: *in nine days* means soon, and terribly. Lark Ninedays changes her name with the interval.

NINE-JOINT *n.*, *Sallowreach, insult* A Hand-line noble at the Course, whose fingers have grown extra knuckles. To call one so is a hanging offence; to call a clerk one is to say he grasps at too much. *Nine-joint luck*: the luck to finish whatever you touch, which nobody wants.

NOB *n.*, *Rim, cant* Any High Cut traveling incognito on the Road. Innkeepers know them by their gloves, their muzzles, their tanks or their smell. *Nob-water*: the extra charge for washing up after one.

NODD *n.*, *Vigil, insult* A sleepy person; a fool; a traitor. From Old Nod, King of the Tuckers. *Don't be a Nodd* is said to drowsing children, and is, to the Tuckers' delight, said in the voice of an advertisement.

NODDING STAIR *n.*, *Vigil* The Watch of Watches' council hall, built as one endless staircase so that no member can sit comfortably. *Gone up the Stair*: elected. *Nodding on the Stair*: corrupt, asleep at the wheel, or literally asleep, which is treason.

NO NAME *n.*, *Cradlewrack* A child whose Naming-Exchange never came, because the Attendance decided, at the end of the first year, that it was not a child. No Names are kept at the Lying-In, or at Dolour Pym's. *Born No Name, die No Name* is said of anything doomed from the start.

NO, THANK YOU *phr.*, *Fast* The first words taught to every Unfed child and the last rites of the Fast. Said three times to any offer. On the deathbed, said once, to whatever is offering. *She said her No-thank-you at dawn and went*. To say it once only and walk off is a scandal; to say it four times and then accept is good manners.

NOT YET *phr.*, *Cradlewrack* The first words ever spoken by a newborn, at Kest in 94 A.G. Now a midwife's blessing, said with the hand on the swollen belly of anyone, of any sex: *not yet, not yet*. Also what the King Within is believed to answer to every question about his birth, with one kick.

NUDGER *n.*, *Vigil* The person who keeps you awake: a spouse, a sibling, a hired child. Marriage is the promise to nudge, and the vow is two words. *Nudger-poor*: too poor to hire one. *She's my nudger* is the closest the Vigil comes to *she is my wife*. A person without one is **unwatched**.

NULLHOUSE *n.*, *Cradlewrack* The abbey of the Barren Order, whose brothers and sisters have had themselves cut so as to bear nothing, and preach an end to beginnings. *Nullhouse quiet* is the silence of a house where nothing will ever be born. The Grey Winter of the Order was not violent, and was worse.

NUZZLING *n.*, *Vigil, cant* Rouse-house slang for letting your nudger doze against your shoulder because you love them and they are so tired. It is grounds for divorce and a fine. Most marriages on the Slope survive on it.



OATCAKE *n.*, *Fast* The Pantry's daily bread: grey, Rim-grown, unsalted, joyless, eaten cold and standing. *Oatcake honest* means plain, true and no pleasure at all. An oatcake found hot and buttered on a windowsill is an Orrum sign. Do not eat it.

OATHBOUND *adj.*, *common* Under oath. In Oathen, redundant, since every sentence is. Elsewhere, said of anyone who seems to be acting against their own wishes. *He's oathbound to her, poor thing; he swore something at a wedding.*

OATHEN *n.*, *common* The eastern canyon land, which ate Tolm, the Witness. Also: *oathen*, *adj.*, Rim, of anything that cannot be undone. *That deal's oathen now.* *An oathen face:* a face that has never once said more than it meant.

OATH ON THE DEAD *n.*, *common* A promise sworn on a dead person's name, by the grave, the shelf, the hill, the bed or the bucket. Every Guest begins with one. The dead keep count. In Oathen it binds in the flesh like any oath, and when it is broken the corpse's jaw opens in its niche and says the oath aloud, loud enough to be heard a mile through rock. Elsewhere the dead are merely disappointed, which is said to be worse.

OFFAL-FOLK *n.*, *Fatlands*, *insult* Scraplings, in the mouths of Gut-line nobles: descended from those who got the tripes and lungs of Ummer and licked the bones after. Scraplings use it of themselves, with pride, at harvest.

OLD BREAKER *title*, *Fast* The most senior of the Tablebreakers, who has put an axe through more tables than anyone living and can tell by the smell of the gravy how long a table has been laid. Old Breakers do not live to be old.

OLD GRIEF *n.*, *Vigil* The hallucination that comes in the thirtieth year of waking and never leaves: a dead person in the corner of the room, in their good coat, perfectly ordinary. The city lists Old Grief as a Seeming of one, and does not enter it in the record, out of courtesy.

OMITTED, THE *n.*, *Fast* Those left off the Pantry list. They do not die by anyone's hand. They walk to the Lean House, or east to the Rim, or to a laid table. Their names are read all night at Pantry Close on Short Night. *Omitted* is never said of the living to their faces. The proper phrase is *between lists*.

ONE-CHAIR *adj.*, *Fast* Of a house: furnished with only enough seating for those who live there, and none for guests. All Unfed houses are one-chair. *A one-chair welcome* is no welcome at all, and the Unfed's best.

ONE GLOVE *n.*, *Sallowreach* A licensed Closer's sign, worn on the left hand only, so the right may be bared at work. *One-glove* is used of anyone in a dangerous trade: hangmen, lamplighters, Reckoners. To offer one glove to a lover is to offer death, a fen proposal.

ONE KICK FOR YES *phr.*, *Cradlewrack* The constitutional procedure by which the King Within, forty-four years in the womb, is consulted on matters of state. Two kicks have no official meaning. Lately there have been three, and the Lord Chamberlain writes them down without comment.

ON THE ROW *phr.*, *Vigil* Dead. From the Row, the street of furnaces and lamp-rendering where the dead of the Vigil go. *Rest is for the Row.*

OPEN BED *n.*, *Vigil* An unoccupied bed in the Dormitory. There are fewer than two thousand. *We've an open bed in the family* means one has been bought for someone, in advance, for when.

OPEN DOOR, THE *n.*, *common* 1. Cradlewrack's Tablenight custom of propping every door wide so that nothing can be said to break in. 2. The Company inn at Knocking Gate. 3. The phrase used by players and Carvers to pause a game. (Compiler: the last is not mine to define. I note only that it is a good custom.)



In Oathen a dictionary is a dangerous book. Every definition is a promise about what a word means. This is why theirs is three volumes of exceptions.

THE COMPILER

OPENER *n.*, *Cradlewrack*, *cant* A burglar, in a land where locks open themselves; that is, someone who does not need to be skilled. *Any fool's an opener in Kest.* Agnes Latch's doors make openers honest again for nineteen days.

OPEN-HAND *title*, *Oathen* The third rank of the Forsworn: one whose Breaking has left a hand that will not close. Open-Hands collect alms in the Breakdowns, which they cannot hold, and so the Breakdowns' children hold it for them. *Open-handed*, in the canyons, is not generosity.

OPEN HOUR *n.*, *Cradlewrack* The hour after a pang when every door in the country stands a finger's width ajar and nobody knows whether it was the pang or something else. *Meet me in the open hour* is a highland lover's line and a burglar's.

OPINION *title*, *Cradlewrack* A midwife licensed to carry the Second Opinion, the knife from which there is no appeal. *Get an Opinion:* settle a dispute permanently. Sabeth Thorne is the most trusted Opinion in the land, and last winter she hesitated.

ORB-WETTER *n.*, *Vigil* Old name for an Eye-Wetter, the attendant who brushes a lidless noble's eyes every half-minute. Now an insult for a flatterer. *She's been an orb-wetter to the Watch for thirty years and her brush has never once been dry.*

ORIEL-SIGHT *n.*, *Vigil* The forbidden pleasure of closing one's eyes for whole seconds, alone. From Lady Oriel Stroud, though nobody is supposed to know about her. *A bit of Oriel-sight* is what children call hiding behind their hands.

ORREL *v.*, *Table-speech* To worship; to give back; literally *to feed the board*. Used now almost only in prayers and in the Second Helping's hymns. *We orrel what we orren*, says Brother Glut, smiling, with his sleeve rolled up.

ORREN *v.*, *Table-speech* To eat; literally *to take at the board*. The root *orr-* is in **orrel**, **orrish**, and in **Orrum**, the Host's name, *the one at whose board*. (Compiler: the College teaches that the words for worship and eating share a root and always did. The Purgation says this is the whole problem. I say it is an etymology, and that etymologies are not to blame for anything.)

ORRISH *n.*, *Table-speech* A shared meal; literally *of the board*. Old-fashioned, and used now mostly for wakes in the Fatlands and the banquet for the dead on Tablenight in the fens. *An orrish* is a meal you cannot leave until it is finished. In the Fast the word is not used.

ORRUM *n., common* The Host; god of hearth, welcome and the shared table; the one Provider that was not eaten. It walks the Fast, very tall, stooping at doorways, warm, laying tables. Its name is not used in the Fast; the Unfed say *company*, *the warm front*, or nothing. *Orrum's weather* on the Rim: a still gold afternoon that smells of bread with no oven in sight.

OSSEL *n., common* The Closing Hand, god of death and endings, eaten in the fens last and slowest of all the gods. Not named aloud in Sallowreach, where people say *the Hand* or *what we had*. *Ossel's Mercy*: a proper death; the commonest prayer in the north, prayed to the god that was eaten precisely so that nothing would end.

OUTSIDER *n., Oathen* A foreigner, who can lie and stay whole. Envoy Dorian Sayce describes negotiating with them as a kind of nausea.

▼ P

PANG *n., Cradlewrack* A quake. The highlands are in labor, and the quakes are contractions. Everyone knows the interval by heart: a season a hundred years ago, thirty days within a lifetime, nine now. *Between pangs* means in a quiet time, which is to say never for long. *Pang-tired*: exhausted in the way only a whole country can be.

PANG-BELL *n., Cradlewrack* A small bell hung over highland doors that rings by itself a breath before each pang. Sold at six lacks on the Rim, where it rings before nothing and its owner feels foolish, and then one night it rings.

PANGDAY *n., Cradlewrack* The day of a pang, every nine days at present: work stops, the Tally is read, the waters are searched, the crownings are watched. The almanac calls it the only holy day that comes faster than the almanac can print.

PANG-HOUSE *n., Cradlewrack* A low round building of red clay at every crossroads, with no door, where travelers wait out a pang. People who shelter together in a pang-house are bound by custom to share their food until the next one, nine days later. Some marriages begin this way. Some feuds.

PANTRY, THE *n., Fast* The fortified granary at Wanting, the best-guarded building in the Fast, and the government: every scrap of food is imported, pooled and rationed by the Abstinent. *The Pantry gives and the Pantry lists*. Exile from the Pantry is a death sentence with no blood on anyone's hands.

PANTRY CLOSE *n., Fast* The square before the Pantry window in Wanting, where on Short Night in mid-Carving the names of every winter's omitted are read aloud all night. A standing crowd fills it from dusk. Nobody eats in Pantry Close, ever, not even on the steps.

PARTAKE *v., common* To call on the god in the blood before a deed, and take its strength, and feed it. The Partaker feels the Tooth come; the god sometimes bites back. *She partook at the door and the door came off*. In polite company: *to take a little*. In the Purgation: *to sin*. See **Tooth**, **Hunger**.

PARTS *n., Cradlewrack* Births that are only a piece: a living hand, a warm ear, a length of spine that crawls. They are healthy. They are drawn toward one another, and Parts from unrelated families fit. *Born a Part* is said of an incomplete person; *gathered of a Part* taken by the Assemblers. The Assemblers' great joined figure in the Barn is called Herself.

PEASE-FACE *n., Fatlands, child*. A child who will not eat, which in the south is a crisis. *Don't be such a pease-face, Bailiff Fatt will come with his*

Outsider talk: casual speech, exaggeration, sentences like *I'd kill for a drink*, which make Oatheners flinch.

OVERDONE *adj., common* Brave to the point of foolishness; burnt. The opposite of **underdone**. *Overdone and served*: died heroically and was eaten at the wake, a Fatlands compliment.

OX-BRIDE *n., Fatlands* A woman married to a Laden man who has begun to root, and who will have to decide whether a hill can be a husband. The courts say it can. *Wed to an ox and widowed by a hill* is a Fatlands phrase for a bad match that lasted.

OYSTER *n., Brinchollow, cant* A Tenanted person's original self, believed still alive somewhere inside, shut up like the meat in a shell. Wreckwives speak of trying to *open the oyster*. It never opens. Sennet Gull has stopped trying, which frightens her.

ladle. Bailiff Fatt has been known to come, and to be gentle about it.

PENNY-LID *n., Sallowreach* A coin laid on the eye of the Kept so they can sleep, or pretend to; it does not help. *Shut-Eye pennies*, sold by the Finishers, are said to work. They are laid on the eyes once and do not come off.

PEW-DEAD *adj., Sallowreach* Of a Kept parishioner who has sat in the same pew at the same chapel for so long that the Seamers have stitched them to the wood. *Pew-dead* families are rich in reputation and poor in seating.

PICKED *adj., Table-speech* Ruined; the bones left on the plate. *He's picked: the Board took the farm, the Cullmasters took his boy*. A *picker* is a debt collector, a carrion bird, or a Seamer's apprentice who takes the bad flesh off the Kept.

PIER-NOTE *n., Brinchollow* A bond issued by the Harbormistress's office against a length of future pier, payable when it is built. Pier-notes trade at a discount that rises every year, because the Harbormistress has calculated the year the timber runs out. *Good as a pier-note* means good for now.

PILLOW, THE *n., Vigil* A soft-floored hollow in the city where the ground gives underfoot and the air is warm. Nothing has ever been built on it. Children dare each other to stand on it for a count of ten. *Pillow-talk* in the Vigil is treason, sedition and Bedded preaching.

PIN *n., Vigil* A small steel pin offered to a guest on arrival, as other lands offer bread and salt. To refuse the pin is to say you trust your host to keep you awake. To use it on yourself in front of your host is the height of good manners. A jewelled pin is a betrothal gift.

PINCH-FRIEND *n., Vigil, child*. A child's best friend, the one they pinch and are pinched by. Pinch-friends hold a pinched finger through the night and swear by the bruise. *Pinch-friends forever* lasts, on the Slope, about eleven years.

PINCHING FAIR *n., Vigil* Midsummer in the Vigil: bells, needle-dances, wake-games, the city's loudest day. A traveler who pinches nobody at the Pinching Fair will be remembered, and not kindly.

PINCHMARKET *n., Vigil* The night market on the Slope where nudgers are hired by the hour, rouse is sold by the twist, and children like Pip Eleven-Bell stand on boxes calling *pinch a crumb, pinch a crumb*. Everything in the Pinchmarket is cheap except sleep, which is not for sale there.

PINCH ME *phr., Vigil* The Vigil's commonest endearment and its marriage vow, two words. *I love you; I trust you; I am afraid.* A child says it to a parent at the door. The dying say it, and their nudgers do. The Compiler was told it by a girl of nine in the Pinchmarket who wanted three crumbs, and paid them.

PINK WATER, THE *n., Fatlands* The stretch of the river Tull below the great slaughterhouses, where the gutters run so red that the water never runs clear. *Pink-water wages:* money from the killing trade. Children are told the Pink Water is where babies come from, which in the south is not a lie told to protect them but a lie told to protect the trade.

PLACE CARD *n., Fast* A card found on a laid Orrum table bearing a name, spelled correctly, in a hand the reader knows: a dead mother's, a grandmother's careful copperplate, one's own. First found in 638 A.G., bearing the finder's name. *I've had my card* means the Host has called for me, and I am keeping moving. Never pick one up. Never read one twice.



*We have twenty-one words for the tide in the chest.
We have none for the sea that is gone, because we will
not admit we need one.*

A BRINEHOLLOW SCHOOLMISTRESS, TO THE
COMPILER

PLAIN *adj., Oathen* The lowest weight of oath: an everyday promise, *I'll be back by dark.* Plain oaths break plainly: a twisted finger, a split lip. Oathen grades oaths Idle, Plain, Sworn, Solemn and Grave, and the grades are tattooed on Sureties in five shades of brown.

PLANK-EAR *n., Brinehollow* The worn place, sometimes carved into an ear, in a party wall where the morning count is called and answered. *Put your mouth to the plank-ear* means speak to your neighbor. Some plank-ears have answered when the house beyond was empty. Do not call a third time.

PLATE, THE *n., common* The moon. A full moon is *a full Plate*; waning, it is *being cleared*; a new moon is *licked clean*. The months are named for it: First, Middle and Last Plate of each season. *By the Plate* is a weak oath, fit for children and merchants. To *serve on the Plate* is to work nights.

PLATEHOLDER *title, Fatlands* A rank of the Second Helping: one who has been served at a feast and has offered a portion of themselves in return. Plateholders wear their bandages openly and are much admired in Sated. *Plateholder's cheer* is the radiant joy of the self-eaten.

PLATTER *n., common* Twenty lacks in a sealed bone tablet, issued by the Rim Road Company and sworn in Oathen as redeemable at any Company post. *Platter-folk:* the merchant class. *He'd sell his mother for a platter, and give change.*

POCKET-HUSH *n., Sallowreach, cant* A tiny Hush grown from a grey reed carried out of Dunmere in a box and planted somewhere: a windowbox, a cellar, a rival's garden. The Court says they do not exist. Finishers sell them. The silence in one is the size of a chair, and a bird that lands in it falls.

PORTION *n., common* 1. One's Cut, politely: *what portion do you come of?* 2. A share of the god, as at the Gorging: *the portions*, the families of the high Cuts. 3. In the game, experience spent between sessions. *Know your portion* means know your place, and is said by the high to the low.

POSSET *n., common* A sweet warm drink of milk curdled with wine or ale, given to the sick, the tired and the frightened. In the Vigil a posset is illegal, because it soothes. In Sallowreach it is given to the Kept on Tablenight, who cannot taste it, and pretend.

POT-DEAD *adj., Sallowreach* Of a Kept person: boiled down in the Grey Plague years for tallow, then found to be still aware in the vat, and kept in the pot by a family too poor to do anything else. Pot-dead are whispered to sing on Tablenight. *It's pot-dead, that tune:* a song that won't finish.

PRESSURE DAY *n., Brinehollow* A day when the air thickens until ears bleed and windows bow inward, as if the sea were sitting on the coast. Courts do not sit; Lung-lines princes come up from their tanks to breathe the heavy air. *A pressure-day temper:* the short fuse of someone whose ears are bleeding.

PRIME *n. and adj., common* A person of Cut 3: old gentry, the hungry middle. Primes marry upward and are eaten from below. *Prime cut*, in the Fatlands, means both a good piece of meat and a good marriage, and is said at weddings with an unfortunate wink.

PROOF, THE *n., Rim* The Purgation's name for any evidence that a god can be thrown up: a vomited stone, a bled child with less godsign than her brothers, a Lancing after which the Regrowth in a parish slowed. The Proof is always just around the corner. *Purgation Proof:* a promise of results, with a bowl.

PROVIDERS *n., common* The eight gods who lived bodily among the peoples before the Gorging: Ossel, Ummer, Dromm, Iss, Vey, Tolm, Orrum, and the one whose figure has been chiseled out of every carving by different tools in different centuries. *Provider* survives as a word for a good husband. Nobody uses it for a wife. It is bad luck to count them on your fingers.

PROVING, THE *n., Sallowreach* The Hand-lines rite, older than the Licensing, in which a young noble's hand is tested in the family chapel at dusk on some small living thing to see whether it finishes. *Proved* means grown up and dangerous. *Unproved* is said of a gloved young lord who has not yet killed anything, with affection.

PROXY-WAKE *n., Fatlands* A wake held for a person taken in the Reaping, with no body; the family serves a beast or a loaf, carved in the shape of the missing. The Board encourages proxy-wakes. The Thin say they are what the Board does instead of counting.

PUDDING *n., Fatlands* 1. A boiled suet dish. 2. A term of endearment. 3. Cullmaster cant for a vagrant assigned to the dusk shift. All three senses are used at the same table. Wakemother Pudding Hesk is named for the first.

PUDDLE-DEEP *adj., Brinehollow* Deeper than it looks, said of a person or a puddle; from the puddles that follow Old Wet Tom down corridors, into which children say you can look a long way. *Don't trust a puddle-deep man.*

PULL, THE *n., Brinehollow* The god's tide in a person: standing at west-facing windows, sleepwalking to wells and washbasins, the Appetite of the coast. *She's got the pull* is said low, the way other lands say *she's got the cough*. Wardens at Lowmark Spur watch travelers for it.

PULL-ROPE *n., Brinehollow* The rope hung from every bedhead on the coast, tied at night to wrist or ankle. *She cut her pull-rope* means she went into the sea willingly. A child found holding a cut pull-rope on a doorstep, waiting for someone to tie it again, is the coast's most common Dread 2 sight.

PURGATION *n., common* The cross-border movement that believes the gods can be thrown back up, by fasting, bleeding, emetic and, at the far end, by massacre of high-Cut families. *Purge-hall*: one of their soup kitchens. *Purged*: vomited, emptied, or killed in a **Lancing**, depending on who says it.

▼ Q

QUAFF-WAKE *n., Fatlands* A wake at which the dead are drunk rather than eaten: the dead rendered into a broth, for those who died too thin to carve. It is considered shameful to the family and kind to the dead.

QUARTER-MEASURE *n., Fast* One quarter of a Pantry Measure, the amount by which each household's ration falls each day in the Nine Days. *To live on quarter-measure* is to be dying respectably.

QUEEN OF THE SMALLS *title, Sallowreach* Little Nell Ash, who died at seven two hundred years ago and rules the child-dead of Lastgate's undercity with a two-century mind and a seven-year-old's idea of fairness. *A Queen-of-the-Small's ruling*: a judgement that is completely fair and completely unreasonable.

QUESTION, THE *n., Cradlewrack* The second of the Midwife's Two Questions, *Does it stay?*, which is the only one that matters. *Put the Question* means decide whether something shall live, and is used of business, marriages and puppies, by people who have never seen it put at a bedside.

QUICK *adj., Vigil* Awake; alive, in the Vigil's sense. *The quick and the Counted*. The Inquisitor of the Quick is the Wakers' officer who decides whether a sleeper was truly asleep or only resting their eyes. *Quick-proof*: a pin through the palm, offered in court.

QUICK-LOAF *n., Rim* Bread baked fast and badly at waystations for travelers, sold hot so that you eat it at the door before you notice. *Quick-loaf manners*: eating with strangers without saying the grace, because you were hungry. It is still an insult.

QUIET, THE *n., Oathen* An ascetic order that has given up speech, some by vow and some by knife. Its ranks run Hushed, Sealed, Tongueless, Stillmind, and the Abbess. Sister Verity Amn teaches that for the highest bloodlines, a promise made only in thought now binds. *Gone to the Quiet* is said of someone who will never be heard again, and is no longer always a joke.

▼ R

RATION CHIT *n., Fast* A square of unbleached cloth stamped with an empty bowl, entitling the bearer to one day's ration at the Pantry window. Issued by household, by name, by list. Cannot lawfully be sold and is sold constantly, at three lacks in Lack season. *Chit-sold*: a family that has sold its future to eat now.

RATTLE *n., Vigil* 1. The wooden rattle every Waker carries, swung under the ear of the drowsing. 2. The lowest rank of the Wakers. 3. The sound of tin roofs in rain, built loose on purpose so that rain will not soothe anyone. *Rattle-rich*: wealthy enough to afford a tin roof that is really loud.

RATTLE-BABY *n., Vigil* A baby born to a Waker family, given a rattle instead of a lullaby and pinched in the cradle. Rattle-babies grow up to

PURSE-TOOTH *n., Rim* A false tooth, hollow, in which a traveler keeps a platter rolled thin. Purse-tooth thieves work the Rim with pliers and a kind voice. *Pull a purse-tooth*: to rob someone who thought they were clever.

QUIET-KEEPER *n., Oathen* A household servant whose job is to sit with the children before the Unbitting and stop them making promises with their hands. Quiet-keepers are fierce, devoted and often Forsworn themselves, and some of them have lost fingers to save a child's.

QUIET SUPPER *n., Oathen* Any meal eaten in total silence, as on Tablenight and at the old Silent Supper of the Gorging. Oathen families hold a Quiet Supper to mark a death, a birth or a breaking. Guests who speak at one are asked to leave and to swear, in writing, that they will not come again.

QUILLHOUSE *n., Rim* The Company's eastern waystation on the high causeway across north Oathen: felted bridges, slates at every door, and the place where foreigners first learn to keep their mouths shut. *A Quillhouse silence* is the silence of someone who has just realized what they almost said.

QUILLON *n., Oathen, cant* The small cross-stroke a Clausewright adds beneath a written conditional to show it is meant as a door out of the sentence. Since writing began to bind, the quillon has been added to letters, shop signs and graffiti. Breakdowns wits write only quillons, and nothing above them.

QUILTING *n., Sallowreach* The patching of a Kept body with squares of other skin, bought from Needle Street, sewn in a pattern. A quilted grandmother is a family's pride. *She's more quilt than Gran* is said of the very old, kindly.

QUIRE *n., Rim* A ledger of the Cutwrights' College, bound in grey, recording a land's or a parish's Cuts across six centuries. A stolen quire is a Reckoner's target list. *Quired* means recorded, known, measured: *she's quired to the fourth decimal*. To *burn the quire* is to destroy the evidence of a bloodline.

QUIRE *n., Rim* The College's walled town of grey stone on a green hill on the northeastern Rim, holding the Master Concordance. *Quire-clever*: precise and unkind. (Compiler: I am from Quire. I contest only the second half of this.)

be Wakers or to run away to the Slope. *Rattle-baby manners*: rough, efficient, rather kind.

RATTLEHOUSE *n., Vigil* The Wakers' barracks and training-house, where recruits learn the precisely tolerable pain. Its walls are hung with needles, the way a smithy is hung with tongs. *Sent to the Rattlehouse*: arrested for dozing.

READING, THE *n., Oathen* The Forsworn custom of interpreting another person's Breakings, from across a street, as a moral biography: a wrist bent so, a jaw wired thus, a spine hooked. *I've read him* means I know exactly what he has broken. The Breakdowns teach children to read before they teach them letters.

REAPING, THE *n., Fatlands* The yearly vanishing, each Carving, of people who are out in the far field at dusk and are not back by morning. The official explanation is wolves. There are no wolves in the Fatlands. *Reaped* is said of the missing. *Reaping weather*: a warm, still evening in Carving with the fields breathing. See **Long Count**, **Cullmaster**.

RECKONER *n., common* A raider out of the Fast who crosses the Rim to kill the highest bloodlines of the Godeaters in their beds. Ranks: Carrier, Knife, Kin-Reader, Band-Captain, Reckoner-Captain. *A Reckoner's welcome*: a black-iron knife in the night. *To reckon* in the high Cuts' houses has stopped meaning *to count*.

RED LEDGER *n., Rim* Any record of deaths kept by someone who was not supposed to keep it: Pell Hogget's staves, Teodor Rell's Lain Book, the Assay's figures, Mercy Thrane's list of surgeries. *Keeping a red ledger* is dangerous everywhere and a crime in four lands.

REGROWTH *n., common* The return of an eaten god through its eaters, in stages: the Taste, the Appetite, the Course, the Brink, the Seating. Its marks are godsign. *Regrowth* is formal, used in the College and in sermons. People say *it's coming on her, she's turning, she's growing back*.

RELICT *n., Fast* The survivor of a family whose other members are Seated. Relicts visit the Long Table on feast days, from the verge. *A relict's portion*: the food of a family that has fewer mouths than it used to, carried home uneaten.

RENDERERS *n., Fatlands* The slaughter, salting and shipping trades, organized in a Union whose ranks run Hook, Jointer, Yardmaster, Stamper and Mistress. They know what is in every barrel that leaves the Chute. *Going through the joint* is their phrase for a killing done in a dispute.

RENDERING *n., Fatlands* The boiling of fat from carcasses for tallow, soap and lamp-oil; the trade of the Renderers' Union. *Rendered* means melted down, and also means explained in public to the point of ruin. *Rendering-house*: a slaughterhouse; and in Board cant, the Weighhouse cellars.

REST *n., Vigil* A forbidden word in polite company, as obscene as any curse. *Voluntary rest* is the law's term for the Lain-Down. *Rest well* is the Vigil's worst insult, a wish of death. Foreigners who say it on leaving an inn are stared at.

RESTITCHING *n., Sallowreach* The annual repair of the Kept at home in early Grace, the one joyful mass of the fen year. Families sit their grandmothers at the kitchen table, lay out thread, and sing. *Restitching Week* is when Seamers raise their prices and children learn to thread a needle.

RETCHING DAY *n., Rim* The anniversary of the Purgation's founding, when the halls give the Black Draught free at the Weeping Post and the road there is lined with the kneeling. *Retching Day promises*: resolutions made in a moment of physical misery and abandoned.

RETURNING *n., Cradlewrack* The great dread of highland parents: a child who grows younger, like Ambrose the Eldest Infant, back toward the cradle and through it. *She's returning* is said of a child whose teeth are coming out the wrong way.

RIBWALKER *n., Brinehollow* A thing on the Uncovered with too many ribs, the size of an ox, dragging itself toward the far water on fins of rotting leather. Salvagers name them; Ribwalker bellows are a Leaving. *A Ribwalker of a man*: someone long past dying who will not stop.

RIDDEN *adj., several lands* Possessed: of a Tenanted Brinehollower, of a Seemer seeing through someone else's eyes, of a Fatlander with the god's

appetite in charge. Polite people say *occupied*. The Compiler has heard *ridden* said, of a lord, by his own groom.



The sentence I heard most often on the Rim was I'm sorry, we don't say that here. I heard it in seven lands, about seven different words.

THE COMPILER

RIM, THE *n., common* The Rim Road, the ring of highway around the Fast's border along which all trade moves; and the inns, tolls and towns along it; and the Company that owns them. *On the Rim*: abroad, homeless, in trade. *Rim-born*: belonging to no land and every inn.

RIM-FEVER *n., Rim* The restless conviction, on long journeys, that the cure for your land is in the next one. Every land has it. Nothing has ever worked. *Rim-fever* is also the trade in cures itself, and the innkeepers' word for the travelers who keep it going.

RIND *n., Fatlands* The tough outer skin of the Laden in the Course, rough as bark, which their servants oil daily. *Old Mother Rind* is a Seated hill-woman whose advice is always right. *To rind* is to grow hard and old; *rinded* is used, admiringly, of a matriarch.

RING-CLOSER *n., Vigil* A Slope widow or widower who takes a dead nudger's place in a household's ring of watchers for the rest of their life, watched by whoever watched the dead. Said quietly, with a respect close to fear. See **closing the ring**.

RISING, THE *n., Fast* The day after the Nine Days, the anniversary of the day Orrum got up from Hallowboard. Nobody speaks above a whisper and nobody looks west. A traveler who answers *come in* on the Rising will be remembered.

ROOK *v., Vigil, cant* To cut rouse with something that works, especially bottled Brinehollow brine, after Rook Quarter-Bell. Rooked rouse keeps you awake. It also sets you walking west. *Rooked to the eyebrows* means awake, wet-lunged and heading for the coast.

ROOT *n., Cradlewrack* An Uncut elder whose cord has grown down into the clay. The long houses feel the land's pulse through their Roots. *To put down a Root* is to settle forever; the Fatlands say the same, and mean something worse.

ROOTKIN *n., Fatlands* Living things grown from the buried or Seated dead: roots with birthmarks, tubers with fingernails. Tansy Lard waters one behind her house. *Rootkin sap* is bottled and sold as a tonic for grief; it tastes of the person.

ROPE FUNERAL *n., Brinehollow* The rite for the Called who do not come back: the name-rope is cut, coiled, and burned on the Chapel Reach, and the knot that was theirs is kept by the eldest. *She had a rope funeral* means no body. *She had two* means she came back Tenanted and was buried twice.

ROPE-HOLDER *title, Fast* The Tablebreaker who holds the rope tied round the Axe's waist, to pull them back if they begin to sit. *To hold someone's rope* is to be the one person they trust not to let them sit down, and is the Fast's word for marriage, though nobody says so.

ROUND-HOUSE *n., Cradlewrack* The common highland dwelling: round, red clay, with no corners for anything to wait in and no door that locks. *Round-house bonest*: hiding nothing, because nothing can be hidden.

ROUSE *n., Vigil* The bitter black stimulant taken hourly. Teeth go first, then the heart. The dose has risen every decade since the Patent of 390 A.G. and the Apothecary-General knows where the curve ends. *Rouse-mouth*: black-stained teeth. *Rouse-poor*: unable to afford enough to stay awake, which is a death sentence by bed.

ROUSE-TAB *n., Vigil* The Vigil's small money: a pressed lozenge of rouse stamped with an open eye, nominally an hour awake and worth three crumbs. The only currency on the Table that suffers inflation of the body: the stamped eye gets smaller every season. *Paid in tabs* means paid in time.

ROW, THE *n., Vigil* The street of furnaces and lamp-rendering where the dead of the Vigil are taken and, it is said quietly, put to use. *He's on the Row*: he is dead. *Rest is for the Row*: a proverb said to anyone who complains of tiredness.

RUE-CHILD *n., Oathen* A person held at an age by their own childhood promise, like Little Rue, sixty-three in a child's body. Rue-children are

rare, sad and much consulted, because they remember everything. *Don't make a rue-child of him* is said to parents who extract promises from toddlers.

RUIN *n., common* What happens to a body when its Flesh runs out: an Injury from the Mangling and collapse. *Ruined* in common speech is a lady's word for having lost a limb. *She's in ruin*: she is down, still breathing, and the next blow kills, except in the fens, where nothing does.

RUNNER *n., Fast* A Crumb-Runner: a smuggler who brings food in from the Rim. Despised, spat upon in the street, and the only reason anyone in the Fast is alive. The Runners call their trade by the insult, the way a scarred man calls himself Scar.

RUST-HAND *n., Sallowreach, insult* A Seamer who uses cheap iron wire that rusts, staining the Kept a brown that never comes out. *Rust-handed work* is any shoddy job, especially one on a person.

▼ S

SALLOWREACH *n., common* The northern fen land, which ate Ossel, the Closing Hand, and where nothing dies. *Sallow* is fen-grey, the colour of a Kept cheek. *Sallowreach weather*: warm, wet, sweet in the wrong way, with flies.

SALTBRIDGE *n., Rim* The Company's Cure-House, the only lawful mint on the Table since 212 A.G., where Fatlands bone is cured in salt boiled from Brinehollow bail-water. *Saltbridge-new*: freshly minted, or freshly dead.

SALT-GIFT *n., Brinehollow* A pinch of salt from a bail-bucket, given to a departing traveler for luck. Refusing it is unkind. Accepting it is unwise, since it is, after all, a little of the sea, and the sea is going somewhere.

SALT MANNERS *n., Brinehollow* The coast's courtesy: do not mention how anyone sounds when they breathe, and do not ask a returned person where they went. *She has no salt manners* means she is a foreigner or a child. The Compiler was corrected four times in one morning.

SATED *n., Fatlands* The capital: wide doors, reinforced floors, ramps instead of stairs, and the smell of gravy from every drain. *Sated* is never used to mean full, since no one in the south has ever been full. *Sated-shaped*: enormous; a compliment.

SAYER *n., Oathen* A Tongue-line at the Seating, who does not describe the world. What they say, is. The few alive are kept bitted in gold in the Gilded Cells. *Sayer-sure*: absolutely certain; and *a Sayer's sentence* is any decision that cannot be undone. Lady Imre Dath is the one the Table means.

SCARECROW-SURE *adj., Fatlands* Surely coming, slowly. From the Scarecrow of Low Tilth, which stands in the far field with its back to the village, a few furrows closer each Carving. Last year someone saw it turn around. *Scarecrow-sure* is said of debts, death and the Board.

SCRAPLING *n., common* A descendant of those who got the scraps and licked the bones at the Gorging; Cut 1; the least changed people alive, and the poor of every land. Scraplings use the word of themselves without shame. *Scrap-luck* is the luck of having little god in you, which is the only luck the poor have.

SEAMER *n., Sallowreach* A stitcher, embalmer and wire-worker of the Guild that holds the population together. Ranks run Threader,

Journeyman, Seamer, Master of the Seam, Master Seamer. A Seamers' strike would be national collapse within a month. *Seamer's patience* is infinite, slow and paid by the hour.

SEATED, THE *n., Fast* Those who sat at Orrum's tables, and do not get up. They remain for decades eating from empty plates, smiling, wasting, praising the food, and invite you to join them, and mean it kindly. *Seated* is never used in the Fast to mean sitting down. The Unfed say they *took a chair* for that, if they say it at all.

SEATING *n., common* The last stage of the Regrowth, at which the god is in some real portion present again, wearing a person or a place: a Hush, a hill, a Tenant, a moving sleeper, a land in labor, a Sayer. *The Seating* in sermons; *the end* in kitchens. No land has reached a full one. Three are close.

SECOND FACE *n., Brinehollow* The other self that looks out through a Tenanted person's eyes: courteous, calm, very old. Wreckwives can see it in the half-second after a laugh. *I saw her Second Face at supper* is how a wife says she knows.

SECOND HELPING *n., common* 1. On the dice, double tens: an automatic success with a Grace. 2. A second chance, usually an unwise one. 3. *the Second Helping*, a joyous Fatlands cult of the Bait doctrine, who preach that the god wants to feed and be fed, and volunteer portions of themselves at table.

SECOND OPINION *n., Cradlewrack* The Attendance's knife, and any midwife who carries it. There is no appeal from it. *Getting a second opinion* in the highlands is not advice-seeking. It is an end.

SECOND TABLE *n., common* A hidden cult, mostly of nobles, whose one idea is: it worked once. When the gods finish regrowing, eat them again. Ranks: Scullion, Taster, Trencherman, Carver, and the Head of the Table, who presides from an empty chair. *Second-table talk*: any dinner conversation that suddenly becomes about appetite.

SEEMING, THE *n., Vigil* The hallucinations that come after enough waking, made a civic sense: when a whole street sees the same thing it is entered in the public record as news. *Seemer*: an official who reads and records them, like Mirela Sconce. This month eleven districts separately saw a tall figure laying a table in the street. It is entered.

SET-ASIDE, THE *n.*, *Sallowreach* The Kept who are too far gone to stand, wrapped, labelled and shelved in the Lofts, still aware. *Setting Aside* is the nearest thing to a funeral. Families visit on feast days and read aloud. Forty thousand of them whisper, and lately they all whisper the same word.

SHELF-TALK *n.*, *Sallowreach* What the Set-Aside say to the Loft-Wardens: recipes nobody has cooked in four hundred years, the true names of grandmothers, forgiveness, directions to doors. *Shelf-talk* is also what fen folk call gossip that has gone on so long it has become history.

SHOES TO THE DOOR *phr.*, *Vigil* The Lain-Down leave their shoes side by side, toes to the door, before they lie down. *Shoes to the door* is said of anyone who has given up, and is never said in front of their family. Vigilant children are taught to kick shoes over when they see them set so, and then to run for a Waker.

SHORT NIGHT *n.*, *Fast* Mid-Carving, when the names of every winter's omitted are read in Pantry Close from dusk to dawn. Called short because it never feels long enough to finish the list. It does not finish. The readers stop at dawn and begin there the next year.

SHUT EYE *title*, *Sallowreach* A senior Finisher, told where new Hushes form; the High Shut Eye is Sister Lorn, who has led nine hundred pilgrims into the silence and stayed outside every time. *Shut-Eye pennies* are laid on the eyes of the Kept and do not come off.

SHUT-MOUTH *n. and adj.*, *Oathen* A person of discretion; the highest compliment in the canyons. *A shut-mouth woman, may she live long and say little*. Its opposite is **talkative**, the worst insult in Oathen.

SHUTTER DAYS *n.*, *Sallowreach* The days of high Plenty when the Kept stay indoors while the flies breed, and smudge-pots burn in every street. *A Shutter-Day lover*: a sweetheart you see only when the dead are locked in.

SILL, THE *n.*, *Cradlewrack* A hilltop where a single door stands in its frame with no wall around it, ajar since the Gorging, a finger's width wider each year. Old Hinge tends it. *To stand at the Sill* is to be on the verge of anything. Nobody has looked through.

SINKS, THE *n.*, *Sallowreach* The lowest inhabited storeys of Lastgate, sunk below the fen, where the Heirs keep safehouses and the water comes in at the ankle. *Sink-born*: poor, damp and very hard to frighten.

SISTER OF THE LID *title*, *Vigil* A senior of the Bedded, who preach that sleep is a homecoming. Sisters of the Lid look rested. Nobody can explain it. *Lidsister*, on the Slope, means a woman who has helped someone lie down.

SITTER *n.*, *Fast* One who has taken a chair at a laid table, before they are known to be **Seated**: the first hours, when the family still believes they will get up. *Sitter's hope* is a hope everyone else has already given up.

SKIM *n.*, *Fatlands* The film that the drip-rain leaves on standing water, which cooks skim off and use. *Skimmed* means robbed of the best part. *Skim-fed*: poor.

SLATE-CLERK *title*, *Oathen* The lowest Clausewright, who takes down conditions in chalk on a slate so that they can be wiped away before they bind. *Slate-promise*: a provisional undertaking. Since written words began to bind, Slate-Clerks have begun losing fingers, and the Bench has ordered softer chalk.

SLEEP-CHEAT *n.*, *Vigil, cant* One who buys a minute from the Tuckers and comes back. The Tuckers' word for a satisfied customer, and the Wakers' word for a criminal. *A sleep-cheat's face*: the look of

someone who has seen the long room and the eye at the end of it, and will go back.



The fen word for kindness and the fen word for thread are the same word. The Seamers say this is no coincidence. The Heirs say that is what they would say.

THE COMPILER

SLOPE, THE *n.*, *Vigil* The slum quarter where rouse is cut thin, nudgers are cheap, and whole families go down in an afternoon. *Slope-tired*: past saving. *She's from the Slope* means she can stay awake on spite.

SMALLS, THE *n.*, *Sallowreach* The child-dead of Lastgate's undercity, ruled by Little Nell Ash, who calls all four hundred of their names every morning. *Small-wise*: old and young at once. The Smalls are not to be pitied to their faces, which they find patronising, and they bite.

SMUDGE *n.*, *Sallowreach* The smoke from the smudge-pots burnt in every street during the Shutter Days of high Plenty, when the Kept are shut in while the flies breed. *Smudge-faced*: poor, since the rich smell of cedar and the poor of themselves and smoke.

SNIFFER *title*, *Fast* The lowest Tablebreaker, a child or a light old woman sent ahead to smell for bread on the wind and turn into it, which is the one time in an Unfed life when walking toward the smell is right. Sniffers are lost more often than Axes. *Sniffer's nose*: the gift of knowing where the trouble is laid.

SOLD *adj.*, *Oathen* Of a principal who has knowingly defaulted on a Surety, so that another body broke in their place: no Surety in the land will stand for them again. The sold drift west along the Rim, where nobody can read the bruise-script on the people they broke.

SOP *n.*, *common* The act that quiets the god in the blood for a time and feeds the habit: closing, eating, bailing, staying awake, opening, swearing, refusing. *Taking a sop* is a confession; *sop-sick* is the state of one who sops too often and cannot stop.

SOUNDING *n.*, *Brinchollow* Taking the depth of a person: a physician's old practice of tapping a Brinchollower's chest to hear how much sea is in it. *She's sounding deep* means she is close to the Course. Dr. Isolde Reave's soundings have found current, and shells.

SPARE *n. and adj.*, *Fast* 1. A name for a child: Spare Tolland. 2. Thin, the proper Unfed body. 3. Poachers' cant for a captured Unfed sold for parts: *a spare, spares*. The three meanings are known to everyone in the Fast and Spare Tolland has stopped introducing himself.

SPAWNING, THE *n.*, *Brinchollow* The coast's name for the doctrine of the Bait: Dromm let itself be eaten as a fish lets itself be scattered, to breed. Illegal on the coast. *Spawny talk*: heresy, and also any argument that makes a horror sound like a plan.

SPEAKING-TRUMPET *n.*, *Oathen* A brass trumpet used by the Forsworn of the Breakdowns, who have nothing left to break, to shout across the canyon to the Bench. *Trumpet-honest*: truthful at great volume, from Brakk's habit.

SPLINT *title*, *Oathen* The fourth rank of the Forsworn: one so broken that they are held together by splints and boards, and lead a district of the Breakdowns. *Splint-proud* is said of anyone who wears their failures openly.

SPOKE *title, Rim* One of the seven on the Wheel, the Rim Road Company's ruling council, who wear a gold spoke at the throat. *Spoked* means bribed at the highest level. *There are seven Spokes and one hub*, says the Company, and does not say who sits at the hub.

SPOON-FORK *n., Rim* The two-tined enamel fork carried inside the coat by a Second Table **Taster**. Rim innkeepers who see one turn their own cutlery face down. *Spoon-fork smile*: the smile of a person who is about to ask what you are made of.

SPOON-READER *n., Rim* A fortune-teller who reads the scratches on a used spoon to tell what the eater wants. Every inn on the Rim has one. Most are frauds. The ones at Thimble Cross are not, and they have started refusing spoons with a certain pattern of wear, and will not say why.

STAIR-CLERK *title, Vigil* The lowest officer of the Watch of Watches, who carries papers up and down the Nodding Stair for eighteen hours a shift. *Stair-legs*: the thick calves of a Vigil civil servant.

STARERS *n., Vigil* Infants born lidless, paraded in open baskets on Starers' Day in early Grace with bells thrown in. Vigilants consider them a mercy of the god. Their mothers lean over the baskets and weep, and the weeping is described in the almanac as joy.

STARVED SAINT *n., Fast* An ascetic who eats nothing at all. A few have kept it up far longer than a body can. Sister Nay Corliss has not eaten in three years and wakes each morning with crumbs on her lips. *Saint-thin* is said of the very holy and of the dying, who are, in the Fast, often the same.

STEWARD, THE *title, Fast* Welcome Ardent, who walks a mile ahead of Orrum laying the tables: the first of the Unfed ever to accept, six hundred years ago, and the only guest offered a position. Polite, exhausted, and very much in want of relief. *To be offered stewardship* is a Rim euphemism for a promotion nobody can refuse or survive.

STILL-BORN TO THE DEEP *phr., Brinehollow* Of a child who drowned in the womb from its mother's tide, and was given to the sea unnamed. The household calls them so, and the tide-post of Fathomhouse carries their names in a column with no dates.

STITCHING-TITHE *n., Sallowreach* The tax a family pays to the Seamers' Guild for the upkeep of its dead, assessed per body per year. A household with seven generations upright may owe more than it earns. *Titbed to the thread*: bankrupted by grandparents.

STOPPING, THE *n., Oathen* What happened in 598 A.G. when the First Sayer said *I wish it would stop* during a storm. The storm stopped. So did everything else in the valley. *A Stopping* is any calamity caused by a careless word, and the valley is still there, stopped, and posted.

▼ T

TABLE, THE *n., common* 1. The known world, one round continent with a dead heartland. 2. Any table where strangers eat, which is why the world is said carefully. *All round the Table*: everywhere. *Under the Table*: dead, eaten, or a Second Table member, depending on the wink. (Compiler: In the oldest carvings the world and the board are drawn with one line. I have stopped asking which was drawn first.)

TABLEBREAD *n., Fast, child*. Bread found on a laid table. Unfed children are taught a rhyme about it: *Tablebread, Tablebread, warm as a bed, eat it and stay, and never be fed*. Abby Rooke leaves a crust on the windowsill and finds something better there in the morning.

STRANDED *adj., Brinehollow* The word High Admiral Corvin Sund will hang any officer for saying: of the fleet, on its props, fully crewed, four hundred ships on dry ground. Said everywhere else on the coast, of everything. *Don't call it stranded, call it waiting*.

STRANGER'S LOAF *n., Rim* A hot loaf given to every guest at the inn door in Company towns, especially at Gristmoot. The whole street watches to see whether you eat it, and whether you say the grace first. In the Fast, a stranger's loaf is something you must never eat, because you did not carry it.

STUFFED *adj., Fatlands* The Gut-lines' word for a Laden noble so swollen they can no longer leave the bed. Not an insult in the south. Elsewhere, a stuffed lord is a joke. In the Fatlands, it is a rank, and a stuffed lord's word outweighs a walking one's by law.

SUMP, THE *n., Sallowreach* The deep fen where those beyond stitching are sunk in weighted sacks. Bubbles rise in patterns. *Sump-talk*: the bubbling sound a too-far-gone Kept makes. *Sent to the Sump* is the fen's word for abandoned, and its cruelest.

SURETY *n., Oathen* One who takes on another's oath for a fee and carries the risk in their own body, tattooed from collarbone to ankle in brown script. *I stand for this word*. A Surety twenty years in the trade is rich and a ruin. *Surety-sure*: as certain as a debt someone else will pay in bone.

SWAB *title, Brinehollow* The lowest rank of the Tidal Admiralty, who scrapes the hulls of the dry fleet of barnacles that are not there. *Swab's errand*: pointless labor, faithfully done.

SWEATING NIGHT *n., Fatlands* The hottest night of Plenty, when villages sleep out in the warm fields. Couples conceive, and the children are called *field-gotten* and thought lucky. Some sleepers do not wake, and are found smiling. The Board does not count them in the Reaping.

SWEET WATER *n., Brinehollow* Fresh water, rain or well, as opposed to bail-water. *Sweet-water folk*: inlanders, foreigners. To *give sweet water* to a coughing stranger is a courtesy and an old charm against the pull.

SWORN GORGE *n., Oathen* A sealed ravine where an oath shouted in 419 A.G. has never stopped echoing. Anyone who hears it is bound by it. Nobody knows what it says. Halvar Stane has made out two words, and will not repeat them. *Sworn-Gorge debt*: an obligation whose terms nobody can remember.

SWORN NOTE *n., Oathen* A promissory note sworn aloud before a Clausewright and backed by the issuer's own body, named in the clause: *let my left hand answer*. The paper money of the eastern Table. A default snaps the named part wherever the issuer stands, and the bearer hears the snap at the back of the skull. See **dry paper**.

TABLEBREAKER *n., Fast* One of the bands who hunt Orrum's tables and smash them with axes before anyone can sit. Ranks: Sniffer, Axe, Rope-Holder, Breaker, Old Breaker. Dangerous, honored work. *A Tablebreaker's supper*: whatever you ate before you went out, cold, from the hand, quickly.

TABLENIGHT *n., common* The anniversary of the Gorging, the longest night of Lack, kept by every land differently: a banquet for the dead in the fens, a failed fast in the south, a bowl of seawater on the coast, a minute of darkness in the Vigil, open doors in the highlands, silence in the canyons, and the Fast standing outdoors with its back to every door. On the Rim, one extra chair is set at every table, turned to face the wall.

TABLENIGHT CHAIR *n., Rim* The extra chair set at every Rim table on Tablenight, turned to face the wall, *for the one who isn't coming*. Travelers who turn it round in the night find it turned to the wall again by morning. Do not ask the innkeeper. Do not count the chairs.

TABLE-SPEECH *n., common* The common tongue, older than the Gorging, spoken in every land: drawled and wet in the fens, clipped to almost nothing in Oathen, stretched and slurred in the Vigil. Rich in food-words used for everything. There are two words for *guest* in it. Everyone uses the newer.

TAKE A CHAIR *phr., Fast* To sit at one of Orrum's tables, and therefore to be lost. The Unfed never say *sit down*; they say *rest your legs*, or *squat*, and they mean the ground. *She took a chair* is the Fast's way of saying a person is gone to the Host.

TALKATIVE *adj., Oathen* The worst thing you can call someone in the canyons. Worse than *liar*, which in Oathen is a technical term. Foreigners who say *you're very quiet* as a compliment have been punched.

TALLOW-SAINT *n., Sallowreach* One of Wick Tallow's candles, made of the unclaimed dead, which feels itself burn and gives a very steady light. Half of Lastgate reads by people it used to know. *Reading by grandmother*: reading by a candle made from someone you knew. Some families sell their own.

TALLY, THE *n., Cradlewrack* The public ledger of every birth of every kind, read aloud each evening as the news. Rufus Ochre keeps it, and by his figures eleven hundred more were born last year than were carried by anyone or anything. *On the Tally*: alive and accounted for. *Off the Tally*: unaccounted for, which in the highlands is worse than dead.

TASTE, THE *n., common* The first stage of the Regrowth: small wrongnesses, dreams, cravings, a tell in the body. *She's got the Taste* is said of children who will not sleep with the door ajar, chew their sleeves, wake with salt on the lip, yawn too much, leave doors open, hear their words echo. Everyone has it a little. It is the season of the Taste on the whole Table.

TASTER *title, Rim* The second rank of the Second Table: one admitted to a practice dinner and permitted to eat what is served. Carries the two-tined fork. *A Taster's smile* is a smile with a question behind it about what you are made of.

TEAR-SALT *n., Vigil* Salt gathered from the eyes of the lidless Eye-lines, the most expensive seasoning on the Table; the Eye-lines eat it on everything. *Tear-salted* means rich beyond reason. Much tear-salt is lid-salt from beggars, and rich people cannot tell the difference, which pleases the beggars.

TEETH, THE *n., Fatlands* The toothed wheat, first harvested in 204 A.G. and ruled a superior strain. Granny Cracknel keeps the teeth from her milling, eleven hundred sets sorted by village, and says some of them match people she knew. *Teeth in the bread*: a bad harvest, or a good one.

TENANCY *n., Brinehollow* The legal status of a Tenanted person's property and marriage, which the Drowned Bench, being Tenanted, has ruled are unchanged. Wreckwives call a bad marriage *a tenancy* even when nobody has been Called.

TENANTED *adj. and n., Brinehollow* The Called who come back, weeks later, walking out of the surf heavier than they left, calm, courteous, the same face and the same memories, and someone else looking out. Polite people say *returned*. The Tenanted now sit on every court in the land, and are fair.

TENTERHOOKS *n., Vigil* The fine steel hooks a wake-valet uses to hold the skin of a client's eyelid taut, from Jack Tenterhook. *On*

tenterhooks: awake, in pain, and paying for it. The Compiler notes that the rest of the Table uses the phrase without knowing where it came from, and that this is how the Vigil gets into everything.

THEFT, THE *n., common* The oldest doctrine: we murdered them; the Regrowth is justice and we deserve it. In Brinehollow it is called the Debt. *Theft-minded*: guilty, ascetic, or just Purgation. A Theft sermon begins with *We were hungry, say it plainly*.

THIMBLE *n., Rim* Thimble Cross: a two-storey fieldstone inn of seventeen chimneys where the Rim bends round a lobe of the Fast. *A Thimble of*: a measure of drink. *Thimble-wise*: knowing where the Fast begins, to the yard.

THIN, THE *n., Fatlands* Outlawed fasters who believe starving the body starves the god. Gaunt, hunted, and the only people in the south who seem clear-headed. Ranks: Hollow, Lean, Gaunt, Bone, and the Thin Man, Corder Lank, unopposed. *Going thin* is treason since the Rising of 455.

THINNING *n., Fatlands* Losing weight; the gravest social disgrace in the south, worse than drink. *He's been thinning since his wife was reaped*. The Feasting Bailiffs watch the thinning. The Thin welcome them.



Talkative. In Oathen it means a person who will not live long. The canyon schoolmistresses write it on the slate on the first day, and the children are not allowed to say it, only to read it.

THE COMPILER

THINWICK *n., Fast* A hamlet of the Fast near the Hem where Decline Marsh and Scant Hollis grew up two doors apart. *Thinwick-raised*: hard, plain, devout and able to break a table with three blows. The houses of Thinwick have no hearths and no chairs, and one house now has a table, and nobody goes in.

THREADBARE *adj., Sallowreach* Of the Kept: so restitched that there is more thread than flesh. Captain Dace Morrow is threadbare and deserting in small pieces. *A threadbare argument*: one that has been going since 212 A.G. in a room in Lastgate.

THREE KNOCKS, THE *n., Cradlewrack* The knock you give before opening any door in the highlands, to warn whatever is on the other side: three, one, three. *Knock twice* means be very careful. Something on the other side of the Sill has begun knocking back in the same rhythm.

THUMB-RING *n., Oathen* A ring worn on the thumb by Clausewrights, one per hundred conditions in their longest treaty. Sorrin Vael wears four. *Twelve rings* is a boast that cannot, in Oathen, be made idly.

TIDE *n., Brinehollow* The sea inside the body: twice a day the lungs fill with salt water from nowhere, and it must be coughed out. Also the indoor tide in every cellar, rising twice a day and leaving kelp on the stairs. *Your tide's showing* means you are wheezing. *Tide-mates*: two who bail together.

TIDE-POST *n., Brinehollow* The carved post at every harbour on which the names of the Called are cut. The Lowmark post bears the old carving: *The sea is not going out. It is going in. On the post* means gone to the sea.

TIDIERS *n., Fast* The things the Hostwatch say keep the Fast's empty houses perfect: trimming the hedges, cleaning the windows, lighting the chimneys. Nobody has seen one whole. *Tidier-work*: housework done by no one. Unfed children who leave their beds unmade are told the Tidiers will come and make it.

TOAD-MOUTH *n., Oathen, insult* A person who says too much and grows ugly by it, from the Breakings of the jaw. Breakdowns children chant it at foreign travelers who chatter at the toll.

TOLL NINE *n., Rim* The Company's counting-house, long, low, windowless, on the southern Rim, where every ledger of the road is reckoned. *Toll-Nine faced*: expressionless, calculating, with skin the colour of no daylight.

TOLM *n., common* The Witness, god of oaths and true speech, eaten in silence in the canyons. What it heard was so. Its name is not said in Oathen, where it is still listening, from the inside. *Tolm hears you* is the most frightening thing an Oathen mother can say.

TONGUE-TAX *n., Oathen* The fee paid to a Clausewright to draft a sentence before saying it: one crumb a clause, a lack a promise, a platter a marriage. *Pay the tongue-tax* means think before you speak.

TOOTH, THE *n., common* The d6 added to a roll when a character Partakes: the god's strength in the blood. A Tooth showing 1 means the god bit back, and Hunger rises. *Show your teeth*: to Partake openly. *Toothy*: given to Partaking. *She's all teeth*: far gone, hungry, close to the Course.

TOUCH-TAX *n., Sallowreach* The license-levy on Closings, paid to the Court on top of the fee. A Closing costs about four thousand lacks. *Touch-tax* is also a lover's joke in the Hand-lines, who are said to pay it on every carress.

TRADE TABLES *v., Table-speech* To betray kin: from the Kitchen Year of the Long Lack, when families who could not bear to eat their own

exchanged their dead with neighbors. *She traded tables with her own sister*. The worst thing one can say of a family, in every land.

TREATY STAIR *n., Rim* The Company depot cut into a canyon wall at the head of the stair down to Tacit, where every contract is copied, sealed in wax and bone, and carried to Jessamy Quill. *Down the Stair*: sworn, irrevocable. *Up the Stair*: in the hands of the lawyers.

TRENCHERMAN *title, Rim* A full member of the Second Table, with a course name and a signet ring inscribed *It worked once* inside the band. *A trencherman's appetite* used to mean a hearty eater. In the high houses it no longer does.

TRIBE-TALK *n., Fatlands* Gossip among the Renderers about what is in the barrels. *Don't give me tripe-talk* means do not tell me what you know about the meat. Ivo Stockpot notches the barrels instead.

TUCKER *n., Vigil* A member of the criminal mercy that will, for a price, guard you while you sleep for sixty seconds and then haul you back. Their failures are delivered to the Dormitory steps before the next bell. *Tucked*: slept, paid for, and returned. *Tucked up*: not returned.

TUNNEL-TONGUE *n., Oathen, cant* A person who speaks only in questions, like Tavish Crook, called Loophole, who has never asserted or promised anything. *Don't tunnel-tongue me* means give me a straight answer, which in the canyons is a dangerous thing to ask.

TURNED *adj., Brinehollow* Of a person who has come back from the surf, or of milk, or of the tide in 512 A.G., the first year the sea did not come back. *Turned* is used of all three in the same breath on the Mile, and the joke is old and still not funny.

TWO COLUMNS *n., Rim* A Cutwright's ledger layout: one column for a family's known Cut, one for its suspected Cut. The second is always higher. *Two-column family*: a noble house with something to hide.

TWO WORDS *phr., Vigil* The marriage vow of the Vigil, which is *Pinch me*. *We've said our two words* means we are married. Elsewhere, *two words* is the Oathen maximum for a promise between strangers.

▼ U

UMMER *n., common* The Laden, god of harvest and plenty, eaten fastest of all the gods, its bones cracked for the marrow. Ummer was the god of feeding. Now it feeds. Not said aloud in the south, where people say *the field*. *Ummer-down*: the soft fuzz on new rootkin.

UNANSWERED, THE *n., Rim* The knock heard at the third hour of the night at Rim inns, on the door that faces the middle of the continent. Innkeepers do not answer it. *The Unanswered* is also what travelers call that door, and the custom is to sleep with your feet toward it, so that if it opens, you will be the first to know.

UNBITTING, THE *n., Oathen* The coming of age in Oathen, in Plenty, when twelve-year-olds have the muzzle removed in the Hall of Conditions and speak their first chosen words with a Clausewright present. The words are carved in the family niche. *Since my Unbitting* means since I became responsible for every sentence I have ever said.

UNBREAD *v., Fast, child*. To refuse food so politely that the offerer feels foolish. Unfed children practise unbreading on each other with pebbles. *She unbreaded the Envoy*: she refused the Rim's food on behalf of her people, and was admired.

UNBRICKING, THE *n., Cradlewrack* The first of Grace, when every bricked room is broken open at dawn, aired, and its contents Tallied.

Contents vary. *Unbricking surprises*: what was in there with you all winter.

UNCLEAN, THE *n., Fast* Any Unfed who has eaten Godeater food, whether by need, trickery or desire. Scour, the Returned, is Unclean. *Unclean* is shouted in the streets of Wanting and the shouted-at is left off the next list.

UNCOVERED, THE *n., Brinehollow* The exposed seabed, a new mile of it every year: weed forests gone to leather, wrecks standing upright, things with too many ribs, salvage, no law. *Uncovered* is said of anyone caught in a lie and of anyone who has lost their sea. Somewhere far out on it there is a stone table with eight chairs.

UNCUT, THE *n., Cradlewrack* People whose birth cords were never severed, who walk through life still attached to their mothers by yards of living cord and consider everyone else amputees. *Uncut kin*: inseparable. The Uncut call the rest of the Table *the Snipped*.

UNDERDONE *adj., Table-speech* Cowardly; not cooked through. The commonest insult on the Rim, said with a pinch of the cheek. *Underdone and overpriced*: a cowardly mercenary. See *overdone*.

UNDER-DRAFTER *title, Oathen* The second rank of the Clausewrights, who drafts conditions for others to swear. Under-Drafter

Lise Amberd is believed to have drafted more marriage vows than anyone living. *Under-drafted*: a contract that has a hole in it, found too late.

UNENDING DINNER, THE *n., Fatlands* Dame Suet Marrable's table, in continuous service for eighty-one years. Guests have been born at it and several have been served at it. *An Unending Dinner* is any social obligation from which you will not be allowed to rise.

UNFED, THE *n., Fast* The people of the Fast, descended from the survivors of the Refusal, the only people in the world with no god in their blood. They have Want where others have Hunger. *Unfed* is a title they wear with pride, and on the Rim an insult meaning *self-righteous*. They are the only innocent people on the Table, and they are insufferable about it.

UNFINISHED *adj., Sallowreach* Alive, in the fen sense: not finished. The polite fen term for all the Kept, all the living, and all songs. *We are all unfinished here*. Hushwalkers, on their return, call everyone outside the silence *unfinished*, with pity.

UNHINGING *n., Cradlewrack* The slow loosening of every door in a house in the weeks before a pang, which highland folk read as an omen. *She's unbinging* means she is losing her wits, and is said kindly.

UNKNOTTING, THE *n., Brinchollow* The cutting of a sleeper's name-rope in the night, deliberately, so that the pull will take them. It is a killing, and the coast prosecutes it as murder, when it can prove it, which is never. *An Unknotting marriage*: one partner is waiting for the other to be Called.

UNLAID *adj., Rim* Of a table: bare. The Rim's innkeepers keep their tables unlaid between meals, since a laid table with no one at it has come

to mean something. *Unlaid* is also used of a promise never made, and a person never buried.

UNMADE ROAD, THE *n., Oathen* The road behind Captain Renn Hold's pass, where four hundred soldiers who obeyed his order to retreat broke their oath to hold the pass and came apart. At dusk, strapped-together shapes are said to crawl uphill on it. *Unmade* means broken by obedience.

UNSEAMED *adj., Sallowreach* Of a Kept person whom no Seamer will touch: too poor, too rotten, or under a Court ban. The Unseamed come apart in public and are fined for it. *Unseamed* is a fen synonym for *outcast*.

UNVACATED, THE *n., Sallowreach* The oldest dead, who hold every title, deed and office in the fens, because owners never die and property never passes. Ansel Grue, the Regent, is the oldest. *An Unvacated house*: one where the grandparents will own you until about 760 A.G.

UNWATCHED *adj., Vigil* Without a nudger. The loneliest word in the language. *She's unwatched since the spring*. The unwatched go to the Pinchmarket, or to the Lying-Down, or rarely to the Tuckers.

UPPER BOARDS *n., Sallowreach* The highest, driest storeys of Lastgate, where the Hand-lines and the Closers keep houses that smell of cedar. *Upper-Boards perfume*: cedar over rot. *Boarded up*: risen in the world, and dead.

UPRIGHT *adj., Sallowreach* Of the Kept: still standing, still in office, still owning things. *Jory Welt is seventy and a minor, since his father is three hundred and upright*. *Upright* is the fen word for both *alive* and *respectable* and nobody notices the joke.



VASHTWATER *n., Brinchollow* Water that has been in a Lung-line prince's tank, sold after changing as a cure for the pull. It smells of breath. Prince Aurel's tank-water is a Leaving. *To drink Vashwater* is to toady.

VEILED *adj., Cradlewrack* Born in a caul that never comes off: the condition, and the dignity, of the highest Caul-line houses. The Veiled speak through the membrane and are held to be prophetic. *Veiled talk*: prophecy, blurry and red.

VELLUM *n., Oathen* Writing-skin. Since written words began to bind, scribes of the canyons have taken to writing on the skins of the dead, in hopes the dead will take the breaking. It does not work. *Vellum-sure*: written down, and therefore, now, dangerous.

VELVET-HAND *n., Sallowreach, cant* A Closer's gentle touch, and, by extension, any killing done kindly and for money. *Velvet-hand trade*: the black market in Closings, carried on by Hand-lines bastards and Pim Sorrel's imitators.

VERGE-TALK *n., Fast* Conversation with the Seated from the roadside. It is permitted and it is dangerous, because the Seated describe each course in detail, and people who listen too long pull out a chair. *Don't verge-talk me* means do not try to make me want something.

VEY *n., common* The Opening, god of birth, beginnings, doors and first breaths, the smallest of the Providers and the hardest to kill, because it kept starting again. Nobody calls it Vey aloud in Cradlewrack. They say *the Opening*, or *she*, or nothing, and knock first.

VIGIL, THE *n., common* The northeastern plateau city, once Ludmere, which ate Iss and has not slept since 341 A.G. *Vigil-eyed*: red-rimmed,

staring, unblinking. *To keep vigil* elsewhere on the Table means to sit with the dying. In the Vigil itself it means to live.

VIGIL-CANDLE *n., Rim* A candle burned at a sickbed. On the Rim, since the Vigil's trade with Sallowreach, vigil-candles are often Wick Tallow's, and the sick wake to hear the candle praying for them in a voice they almost know.

VINEGAR-KISS *n., Sallowreach* The kiss given to a Kept relative through a cloth soaked in vinegar, to cut the smell. Fen children are taught to give it without flinching. *A vinegar-kiss marriage*: a match of duty.

VISITING *n., Fast* Walking the verge of a road beside a laid table and talking to the Seated without sitting down. Permitted, because the road is not the table and the verge is not a chair. *A visiting family* is one with someone at the Long Table. They go on feast days, and come back thinner.

VOICE *title, Oathen* The leader of the Forsworn of the Breakdowns, at present Brakk, whose ribs opened outward like a book. *The Voice says* means the poor have made up their mind.

VOIDED, THE *n., Rim* The inner council of the Purgation, who claim to be empty of god, and show their scar, worn bare, as proof. *Voided* is said of anyone who claims to have no appetite, by people who do not believe them.

VOLUNTARY REST *n., Vigil* The law's phrase for the Lain-Down. The nudger is prosecuted for negligence and the family is fined. Nobody who has lost someone says it. It appears in the Vigil's statutes four hundred and eleven times.

VOW-EATER *n.*, *Oathen* A fixer who claims to release you from an oath by having you swear a greater one over it, like Grandam Cess. Her clients

are free of what they came with, and owe her something worse. *Vow-eaten*: in debt beyond bone.

▼ W

WAGE-CHIT *n.*, *Rim* A thin bone slip stamped with the Company wheel and a post-number, good for a bed, a meal or a drink at any Company house, worthless off the road. *Paid in chits* means owned by the Company. Bonded Hands who retire after forty years on the Rim tend to find they cannot afford to leave it.

WAKE *n.*, *Fatlands* The funeral of the south, the most sacred rite: the dead are served to the family, by the family, with the best plates. To be buried uneaten is the deepest insult to a life. Wake dishes have names (Hands in a Pie, Heart Seared Thin, Widow's Dripping, Marrow on Toast). *I'll see you at my wake* is a Fatlands lover's promise.

WAKEMOTHER *n.*, *Fatlands* The woman who cooks a wake: a master of the trade, paid in the best cut. Wakemother Pudding Hesk's glaze is a Leaving. *A wakemother's tenderness*: complete, practical and holding a cleaver.

WAKER *n.*, *Vigil* The Vigil's police, whose job is to hurt people for their own good, and who after three centuries are very skilled. Ranks run Rattle, Needle, Sergeant of the Ward, Inquisitor of the Quick, Captain. *Waker-kind*: cruel in your interest.

WAKE-VALET *n.*, *Vigil* Keeper-awake to the rich, an artist of the precisely tolerable pain, like Jack Tenterhook, who was a torturer before and says the only difference is the tipping. *Valeted*: kept awake beautifully. Wake-valets' pincers are silver.

WALKING WEST *phr.*, 1. *Brinehollow*; 2. *Fast* 1. The pull: sleepwalking toward the sea, or the brine-rouse users of the Vigil drifting to the coast four hundred miles away. 2. Leaving the Fast for the Rim, which is how it loses most of the people it does not starve. *She's walking west* is said of a quiet loss in both lands, and nobody likes to be asked which.

WALK IN SINGING *phr.*, *Sallowreach* To go into a Hush with the Finishers, in procession, in song, so that the last thing the world hears of you is a verse, which stops. *She walked in singing* is the proudest and saddest thing a fen family can say of one of its own, and the families of the Finishers say it more every year.

WALK-STONE *n.*, *common* The stone at the edge of every old village from which the Eldest Walk set out, still there in most places. Each is washed in the night, once a year, in late Plenty, by someone who will not say who. *Sitting on the walk-stone*: getting old. Children are forbidden to play on it, and do.

WALK THE ELDEST, TO *phr.*, *Table-speech* To make a sacrifice that is known to be wasted. From the Eldest Walk of the eighth year of the Long Lack, when in every land the old walked out into the cold so that the young might eat, and the young starved anyway, the next year, and the Lack did not lift for them. *We walked the eldest for that contract* means we gave up what we could not spare and got nothing. In the Fatlands they say it of every Lean Levy, and in the Fast of every winter's list.

WANT *n.*, *Fast* What the Unfed have where others have Hunger: the slow rising need, not of a god in the blood, but for the god outside the door. *To feel the Want* is to smell bread on the wind and turn into it, not away. *Want-proud*: hungry and boasting of it.

WANTING *n.*, *Fast* The Unfed's only real town: cold, plain and hearthless, on the eastern edge nearest the Rim, with the Pantry at its

heart and the Lean House at its edge. *Wanting-cold*: the specific chill of a house with no hearth.

WANTING POST *n.*, *Rim* The only Company station that faces the middle, at the head of the road into Wanting, where Crumb-Runners buy grain at a markup and are spat on for it. *Wanting-Post prices*: the cost of what you need from people who despise you for needing it.

WARM FRONT *n.*, *Fast* The god passing. The Unfed track Orrum by melted frost and warm ground, and call it *company*, or a *warm front*. *There's a warm front by the mill* means keep the children in, do not answer the door, and if you smell bread, walk into the wind.

WASHING, THE *n.*, *common* The night in late Plenty when each village's walk-stone is washed by someone who will not say who. It is a custom of every land, and nobody remembers starting it. *Washed and not told*: forgiven by somebody you do not know.

WATCH OF WATCHES *n.*, *Vigil* The Vigil's council, which sits in shifts around the clock and has not adjourned in two hundred years, on the Nodding Stair. *The Watch's watch*: the attendants who watch the Warden-Prime's eyes. *Who watches the Watch* is a proverb in the Vigil and a job title.

WATCH-SELF *n.*, *Vigil* The self that has gone on watching after the mind has failed: a long-waking Vigilant who works, walks and answers questions, and is not there. *My husband's watch-self brought me tea this morning* means he is gone, though he is awake.

WAX-SLATE *n.*, *Oathen* A board of wax and a stylus, for messages that can be smoothed away before they bind. Since writing began to count, wax-slates are scraped clean with frightening speed. *Wax-slate love*: a love affair conducted with deniability.

WEEP *n.*, *Sallowreach* Rain, which in the fens leaves a tea-coloured stain. *Weep-weather*: wet and warm. *Weep-stained*: of a person, old, faded, respectable. Lowlanders say that a fen woman who cries is *making her own weather*.

WEEPING POST, THE *n.*, *Rim* The waystation between Cradlewrack and Fogmouth, where weep-rain from the fens meets the warm salt springs of the red hills and the road is always wet; the Purgation's chief hall, where the Black Draught is given on Retching Day. *Weeping-Post wet*: soaked through, inside and out.

WEIGHING, THE *n.*, *Fatlands* The annual public weighing of the Board of Plenty, three days in Grace, at which each Member's vote is set by weight, with pie-stalls the length of Sated. *Weighed and found heavy*: approved. Garrick Tripe will fill your pockets with lead for a fee.

WELCOME *n.*, *Fast* A forbidden word. Orrum's Steward is called Welcome Ardent, which the Unfed find unbearable. *You are welcome* is never said in the Fast; the Unfed say *you are tolerated*, and mean it as warmly as anyone else means the other. See **No, thank you**.

WELL-CROWNED *adj.*, *Cradlewrack* Of a well: dilated into a crowning. *The well in the square has crowned* means something is coming up the rope hand over hand, knocking on the stones as it climbs. *Well-crowned* in Kest slang also means pregnant, of a man.

WEST DOOR *n.*, *Brinehollow* The door of a house that faces the sea, barred every night of the year but Tablenight, when it is left unbarred for

whoever might come home. *West-door news*: a return. *West-door niche*: the shrine by it where a bowl of seawater stands.



In every land the word for west means something. On the coast it means the sea. In the Fast it means away. In the Vigil it means walking. On the Rim, a Factor once told me, it means nothing, yet.

THE COMPILER

WET-LUNG *n.*, *Rim, insult* A Brinehollower, on the rest of the Rim.

They cough in public and spit salt. *Wet-lung manners*: wiping your mouth on your sleeve after bailing at table, which on the coast is perfectly polite.

WET-NURSE *n.*, *Cradlewrack* One who feeds what no one else will, like Dolour Pym, to whom the Attendance sends the births it permits but cannot look at. She loves all of them. Several have never let go. *Wet-nursed* means raised on pity and grown up strange.

WET TOM *n.*, *Brinehollow* Any very wet beggar; after Old Wet Tom, who has never been dry and on whom it rains indoors. *A Wet Tom*: a person followed by misfortune. Children who look into his puddles say they are much deeper than the floor.

WHEEL, THE *n.*, *Rim* The Company's symbol, and the seven-Spoked council that runs it. *On the wheel*: employed by the Company. *Broke on the wheel*: ruined by it, which is to say indebted to a Company inn for life.

WHISPER-BOOK *n.*, *Sallowreach* A Loft-Warden's ledger of what the Set-Aside whisper, kept hall by hall. Senior Wardens may sell what is in them. *It's in the whisper-books* means it is known by the dead and will be known by everyone, eventually.

WHISTLE *v.*, *Oathen* A forbidden act on Tablenight, when the whole country makes no sound for twenty-four hours. A whistler is shunned for a year. *To whistle on Tablenight* means to commit an outrage in innocence.

WHITE-GLOVE *adj.*, *Sallowreach* Of a Closer who has never yet closed anyone; and of any newcomer to a killing trade. *Still white-gloved*: virginal in murder.

WICK *n.*, *Vigil* The lowest Lamplighter, who trims the ten thousand lamps on long poles, burned at the wrist and coughing smoke. *Wick-thin*: underfed and burning. *Wick-talk*: the Lamplighters' cant, of which this Compiler learned only enough to know she was being insulted in it.

WICKERMAN *n.*, *Fatlands, child*. The scarecrow of any field, especially the one at Low Tilth. Fatlands children chant *Wickerman, wickerman, turn round and see*, and run before it can. In some villages they have stopped playing it.

WIDER TABLE *n.*, *Rim* The whole Table, in a sermon; also a Rim euphemism for the dead of all lands together, as in *gone to the wider table*. In the Fast, nobody says it.

WIDOW'S DRIPPING *n.*, *Fatlands* The first rendering of a wake, on hot bread; the widow skims it herself and weeps into it. *Widow's-dripping tears*: tears that are also seasoning. The phrase is used of all grief that has to be got through while cooking.

WIFE-BUCKET *n.*, *Brinehollow* The bail-bucket a sweetheart gives you, exchanged at betrothal. *She's still got his wife-bucket* means she has not remarried, though he is ten years in the sea. A Tenanted sweetheart's bucket is a Leaving, and the water in it does not go stale.

WINDOW-WARDEN *n.*, *Brinehollow* A neighborhood volunteer who walks the street at night looking for people standing at west-facing windows, and knocks to wake them. *A window-warden's knock* is a single soft tap. The Called hear it and do not turn.

WISHBONE *n.*, *Fatlands* The forked bone of a bird pulled between two eaters at a wake; whoever gets the larger piece gets the dead person's luck. In the Gut-lines, wishbones are pulled from more than birds. *Wishbone siblings*: brothers who have fought over an inheritance at the table itself.

WITNESS, THE *n.*, *common* 1. Tolm. 2. In Rim law, the person before whom a contract is sworn, at present Jessamy Quill. If she dies or breaks, half the trade of the Table comes unbound in an afternoon. *Witness-heavy*: the burden of being needed to remember.

WOLF-WARDEN *title*, *Fatlands* A Board officer appointed to protect the fields from wolves, of which there are none. Wolf-Wardens walk the dusk lines in white smocks with a lantern, and their lists are the Cullmasters' lists. *Wolf-Warden's leave*: the dusk shift.

WOLVES *n.*, *Fatlands, euphemism* The official cause of the Reaping. There are no wolves in the Fatlands. *Wolves took him* is said with a straight face by Board officials and with a look by everyone else. The Board employs Wolf-Wardens, who hunt nothing and are well paid.

WORD-BOUND *adj.*, *Oathen* Bound by your own words, in the flesh. The commonest Oathen adjective, applied to almost everyone. *Not word-bound* is said only of Blanks and foreigners, and of Cassian Wry, whom everyone asks to say something false, just to hear it.

WORSHIP *n.*, *common* In Table-speech the same root as eating; **orrel** and **orren**. A Fatlands priest says *come and worship*; a Fatlands child asks what is for supper. (Compiler: I have heard Purgation lecturers argue that if the words share a root, the deeds do. I have heard Second Table lecturers argue the same. I note that they agree on this and on nothing else.)

WRACK *n.*, *Cradlewrack* 1. The red clay highlands themselves, *the Wrack*. 2. Seaweed, in the speech of the highland coast. 3. Ruin, labor, pain. *In the wrack* means in labor, which in Cradlewrack may be said of anyone, and of the land.

WRECKWIFE *n.*, *Brinehollow* One of the sisterhood of those whose spouses came back Tenanted; they share advice on how to live with a stranger who knows your name. Ranks run Listener, Sister of the Line, Keeper of Names, Elder Wife, Widow-Mother. *Wreckwife's tea*: kept warm for two.

WRISTLET *n.*, *Rim* The iron wrist-ring of a Bonded Hand of the Company, which never comes off. *Wristleted*: in the Company's employ for life. Retired Hands rub the place where it was, years later, without knowing they do it.

WRIT OF WEIGHT *n.*, *Fatlands* The Board certificate recording a Member's weight and vote, renewed yearly. Forged Writs of Weight are the commonest fraud in Sated. *A Writ of Weight man*: one who is less than he claims.

WYRM-HOLE *n.*, *Brinehollow* A hole in the Uncovered where the mud has been pushed up from below, as if something had come out, or gone down. Salvagers mark them with painted stakes. *Gone down the wyrm-hole*: missing on the seabed.

▼ X

X *n.*, *Rim* The mark scratched on the door of a household struck from the Pantry list, by the Pantry clerks, so that the Runners know whom to sell to. *X-house*: a family between lists. Scraplings across the Table sign with an X; in the Fast, nobody does.

XENNOR *n.*, *Table-speech*, *archaic* An old word for the duty of hospitality owed to guests, found in carvings older than the Gorging and in the College's oldest quires. It is one of the two words for *guest-right*.

▼ Y

YARDMASTER *title*, *Fatlands* A Renderers' Union officer commanding a rendering-house, with a share of export profits. *Yardmaster's word*: final, and stamped twice.

YARD-WARDEN *n.*, *Sallowreach* A volunteer who watches the Lofts' yards at night so that nothing is carried out, or in. The yard-wardens are the first to hear the whispering change. Lately they have asked to be paid more.

YAWN, THE *n.*, *Vigil* The warm wind off the eastern plain. On Yawn days the Wakers double their patrols. *Yawn-weather*: dangerous comfort. *A yawn* in the Vigil is never small talk: it spreads through a room like a rumor and can put down a market. See **Glass House**.

YAWNER *n.*, *Vigil* One whose yawns are catching beyond reason, like Lukas Marre, who once put down a whole market square and lives in the Glass House, masked, alone. *Don't be a yawner* means do not spread despair.

YAWN-TAX *n.*, *Vigil* The fine for yawning in public on a Yawn day. It is a rouse-tab, paid on the spot to the nearest Waker. *He's paying the yawn-tax* means he is losing.

YELLOWING *n.*, *Sallowreach* The season in Carving when children gather the rare leaves that fall from the yellow trees of the fens, where leaves stay on the branch for decades, and keep them in boxes. A fallen leaf is the only thing in the north that has ever been allowed to finish. *A yellow-leaf child* is a fen child who has died properly, abroad, and is envied.

YES *interj.*, *Oathen* A promise. Oatheners avoid it. Sorrin Vael, Chief Clausewright, has not said an unqualified *yes* since boyhood, including

Nobody uses the older word. (Compiler: I have found it in one place only, written above a carving of a table, over the eighth seat, which is chiseled out.)

X-STITCH *n.*, *Sallowreach* The crossed stitch a Seamer uses to close a Kept person's mouth when the jaw has slipped its seam for good. *X-stitched* means silenced. Grandmothers who are X-stitched are said to hum.

to his wife. The polite form is *as I now intend*, or a nod, which is held not to bind, which is being tested.

YESTERBED *n.*, *Vigil*, *archaic* A bed, in the old Ludmere speech: *the thing from yesterday*. Used now only in nursery rhymes and by the Bedded, who say it with longing. *Yesterbed and yesterdream, never and never wake*.

YIELD *v.*, *Fast* To give way: to sit at the table, to answer *come in*, to accept on the first offer. *Yield* is also a girl's name, given in hope that she never will. Yield Hartsell has grown a single green sprout in dead soil, and told no one.

YOKE-OX *n.*, *Fatlands* One of the eight oxen that draw Chairman Obb Tullow's dray. The Chairman's feet rooted through the cart last spring. *Yoke-ox loyal*: going on pulling a thing that has stopped moving.

YOLK-EYED *adj.*, *Fatlands* Glazed and yellow from overeating, in the last hour of a Feasting Law supper. A compliment from a host. *Yolk-eyed and happy*: the ideal guest.

YOUNG-DEAD *n.*, *Sallowreach* A Kept person who died young and stayed young, like the Smalls. *Young-dead envy*: a living sibling growing older than their dead brother or sister, and the dead one's look as they do.

YOURSELF *pron.*, *Oathen* In Oathen courts, an accused person is addressed only as *yourself*, never by name, so that their name will not be bound to the sentence by accident before it is passed. *Yourself has broken* is the shortest verdict in the world.

▼ Z

ZEALOT-SALT *n.*, *Rim* The pinch of salt a Reckoner puts on their tongue before entering a house, so as to taste nothing of what is inside it. *Zealot-salted*: determined, joyless and armed.

ZERO *n.*, *Rim* A Rim factor's word, from the Company's counting-house, for the empty circle on the lack. Common folk do not use it. They say *a licked plate*, or *nothing on the board*. (Compiler: the College's counting-masters write the empty circle with a dot in the middle, which they say represents a seat. I asked whose. I was told it was a ledger convention.)

ZEST *n.*, *Fatlands* The crackling skin of the wake roast, given to the youngest at the table. *Full of zest*: lively, young, and soon to be served. Fatlands grandmothers say *give the zest to the little one*, and the little one is always pleased.

ZUZZ *n.*, *child.*, *Sallowreach* The buzzing sound of a Black Noon fly-front, and a nursery word for flies, which in the fens are the weather. *Zuzz-zuzz, here comes Justice* is a Lastgate skipping rhyme about the Honorable Maggot, and is sung at his door.

▼ APPENDIX: NUMBERS, MEASURES AND TIME

Count the coins, count the days, count the dead. Do not count the chairs.

– RIM ALMANAC, INSIDE COVER

Table-speech counts the way it eats. Its oldest number-words are the words of a shared meal, kept alive by market women, Tally-keepers, children’s rhymes and the College’s counting-masters, who use the old forms in ledgers because they cannot be mistaken for anything else. In daily speech, most people use plain numbers until a sum becomes frightening, and then fall back on the old words, as if they were gentler. They are not.

THE OLD COUNT

Every child on the Table learns the old count on the fingers, and every child is corrected at the same place. After *table*, which is seven, there is no word. The count goes *seven, and one more*, or *a full board*, and the finger is folded down without being named. Schoolmistresses in every land give the same reason, which is that it is unlucky. College counting-masters write the eighth figure as an empty circle with a dot in it and call it a ledger convention.

NUMBER	OLD WORD	LITERALLY	HEARD AS
0	a licked plate	nothing left	<i>we came home with a licked plate</i>
1	a bite	one mouthful	<i>a bite of a man</i> : a lone traveler
2	a pair	two at a board	<i>a pair of plates</i> : a married couple
3	a mess	three at a board	<i>a mess of Reckoners</i> : a raiding party
4	a corner	the four corners of a table	<i>a corner of days</i> : four days
5	a hand	the fingers	<i>a band of lacks</i>
6	a setting	the places at an old table	<i>a setting of chairs</i>
7	a table	the Seven Tables	<i>a table of dead</i> : seven graves
8	(not said)	a full board	the finger is folded, unnamed
9	a long	the nine years of the Lack	<i>a long of pangs</i> : nine pangs
10	a lack	ten crumbs	the market’s ten
12	a year of plates	the twelve months	a dozen
20	a platter	twenty lacks	a score
100	a feast	the old count of a lord’s hall	<i>a feast of soldiers</i>
1,000	a reaping	(Fatlands) a district’s yearly loss	said only in the south, and quietly

A counting rhyme, skipped to in Wanting, Lastgate, Kest and on the Mile, with the words changed in each:
A bite for the baby, a pair for the bed,
A mess for the soldiers, a corner for bread,
A hand for the beggar, a setting for kin,
A table for supper, and who’s coming in?
(Fold the finger, fold the finger, nobody’s there.)
A long for the hungry, a lack for the poor,
A platter for Plenty, and bar the back door.

◇
Children who name the eighth finger are not punished.
They are simply asked, very gently, where they heard it.
THE COMPILER

MEASURES

Every land weighs and measures by its own Rule, and the Company’s factors carry conversion slates. The common ones:

MEASURE	AMOUNT	LAND	NOTES
crumb	a tenth of a lack	common	a bone bead; the price-witness's fee
lack	a day's bread	common	salt-cured bone; ten crumbs
platter	twenty lacks	common	sealed tablet; sworn redeemable
pound-scrip	a pound of meat	Fatlands	7 crumbs at home, 3 abroad, falling
side	half a beast	Fatlands	meat scrip; about 25 lacks
rouse-tab	one hour awake (nominal)	Vigil	3 crumbs; holds twenty minutes now
ration chit	a day's Measure	the Fast	not for sale; sold at 3 lacks
Measure	a day's Pantry ration	the Fast	one oatcake and a handful of grain
quarter-measure	a quarter of that	the Fast	the daily cut of the Nine Days
stone	fourteen pounds	Fatlands	votes are counted in stones
hundredweight	a Deacon's vote	Fatlands	one vote per hundred pounds
fathom	six feet of rope	Brinehollow	rope is sold by the fathom on the Rim
Mile	a section of Lowmark	Brinehollow	one year's pier
bowshot and a half	the edge of Company law	Rim	measured yearly with a knotted rope
Rim-day	a day's wagon travel	Rim	about twenty miles; a hundred days round
mouthful (of speech)	about nine words	Oathen	the most said without a Clausewright
clause	one condition	Oathen	a crumb of tongue-tax each
shelf	one Set-Aside	Sallowreach	the Lofts count bodies in shelves
stitch-count	the Seamer's bill	Sallowreach	a crumb a stitch on Needle Street

TIME

The year is 641 A.G., After Gorging. The nine years before Year 0 are the Lack Years, numbered backward. The year turns on **Tablenight**, the longest night of Lack. It has four seasons, each

named for a part of a meal, and each season has three months named for the moon, the **Plate**. Dates are given as day, Plate and season: *the ninth of Middle Plenty*. There are no named weekdays; days are numbered within the Plate, and most people know the date by the Plate in the sky.

SEASON	MONTHS	OLD SENSE	WEATHER EVERYWHERE BUT HOME
Grace	First, Middle, Last Plate of Grace	the prayer before eating	spring; Oathen's Kept Rain on the first day
Plenty	First, Middle, Last Plate of Plenty	the meal itself	summer; the flies breed in the fens
Carving	First, Middle, Last Plate of Carving	the cutting of the joint	autumn; the Reaping; Low Water
Lack	First, Middle, Last Plate of Lack	the famine	winter; Tablenight at its deepest point

The phases of the Plate are counted by everyone and trusted by travelers: *a full Plate* is the time for markets and weddings; *being cleared* is the waning, when debts are called in; a new moon is *licked*

clean, and on licked-clean nights doors are barred, nobody travels and nobody counts the plates.

Shorter spans of time are measured by the meal and by each land's Rule:

SPAN	LENGTH	WHERE	EXAMPLE
a grace	as long as it takes to say <i>Lack keep away</i> , two breaths	common	<i>I'll be there in a grace</i>
a mouthful	a count of twenty	common	<i>wait a mouthful</i>
a blink	a second or two of sleep	Vigil	<i>two breaths is a long time</i>

SPAN	LENGTH	WHERE	EXAMPLE
a bell	a quarter of an hour	Vigil	the city's bells ring every bell; the hours are lengthening
a bail	half a day, dawn bail to dusk bail	Brinehollow	<i>two bails out</i> : a day's sailing, once
a sitting	an evening at table, about three hours	common	<i>a sitting's work</i>
a course	an hour, in the old Rim count	Rim	<i>three courses to Thimble</i>
a pang	the interval between quakes, now nine days	Cradlewrack	<i>see you in a pang</i>
a Plate	a month, new moon to new moon	common	<i>pay in a Plate</i>
a long	nine years	common, old	<i>as long as a long</i> : forever

The day itself is rung in Company towns by four bells: **First Bell** at dawn, **Grace Bell** at noon (when everyone turns to the nearest stranger and says the grace), **Weighing Bell** in mid-afternoon in the Fatlands, and **Last Bell** at dusk, after which nothing lawful is sold. In Oathen, the bells are replaced by flags, since a bell is a kind of voice. In Sallowreach the day has no last bell, only a first, rung every morning to remind the dead that they are still here.

◇
Maud Sexton's pendulum says each hour in the Vigil is a little longer than the last. The almanac has not been changed. The Company will not print a year that does not end.
THE COMPILER

▼ APPENDIX: FORMS OF ADDRESS BY LAND

What you call someone is a portion of what you owe them. A traveler who gets the forms right is fed. One who gets them wrong is remembered. The table below is the College's field-guide; it is short,

and wrong at the edges, and the Compiler was thrown out of three houses gathering it.

LAND	TO A SUPERIOR	TO AN EQUAL	TO A CHILD OR INFERIOR	NEVER SAY
Sallowreach	<i>Upright Sir, Upright Madam</i> ; to the Unvacated, <i>Elder</i>	the name, and <i>may you finish</i>	<i>small one</i> ; to the Kept young, by their age at death	<i>Long life</i>
Fatlands	<i>Your Weight</i> ; to a hill, <i>Eldest</i>	<i>heavy friend</i>	<i>pudding, little gut</i>	<i>You look thin; I'm full</i>
Brinehollow	by ship-rank (<i>Captain</i> , though never afloat); to the Bench, <i>Your Depth</i>	<i>neighbor</i> , through the wall	<i>little bucket</i>	<i>Where did you go?</i> , <i>stranded</i>
The Vigil	<i>Unblinking</i> ; to any officer, <i>Watcher</i>	<i>lamp-friend</i> ; to a spouse, <i>nudger</i>	<i>starer, pip</i>	<i>Rest well; you look rested</i>
Cradlewrack	<i>Mother</i> , to any midwife of any sex	by mother's name: <i>Hessa's Tam</i>	by Tally-place, or <i>bit, small, keep</i>	<i>What are you?</i> ; opening a door unknocked
Oathen	a bow, and <i>if it please</i> ; to the King, nothing	a nod	the bitted are spoken of, not to	an unconditioned <i>I promise</i> ; <i>talkative</i>
The Fast	<i>Elder</i> ; to the Abstinient, <i>Keeper of the List</i>	the Refusal-name: <i>Stint, Nay</i>	<i>little Nay, spare</i>	<i>Welcome; Come in; Sit down</i>
The Rim	<i>Factor, Waymaster, Spoke</i>	<i>road-friend</i>	<i>lad, lass, Hand</i>	anything that counts the chairs

GETTING THE FORMS WRONG

A Guest who uses the right form of address in a land for the first time in a scene gains +1 on their next Tongue roll there with that person. A Guest who says the *Never say* aloud must make a Hard 14 Tongue + Persuade roll to recover; on a failure, the listener's attitude worsens by one step, and on a Lack, something worse follows: in Oathen the words count; in the Fast someone hears *come in* and comes; in the Vigil the listener begins to yawn. The Carver should always let the player know the custom exists before the dice are rolled. The Guest may not.

◇

*In the fens I said good day, and was asked whose. In
Oathen I said good day, and was asked to swear to it.*

THE COMPILER

▼ APPENDIX: CURSES AND BLESSINGS

Every land swears by what it fears and blesses by what it lacks. The lists below were gathered over three years on the Rim, from the mouths of carters, nurses, Seamers, Renderers and children, and are given roughly in order of how often the Compiler heard them. The Compiler notes that the curses were easier to collect.

THIRTY CURSES

- ◇ *Long life to you.* (Sallowreach; the worst.)
- ◇ *May your hands stay warm.* (Sallowreach; that is, may you never be able to finish anything.)
- ◇ *May you be Set Aside on a high shelf, and nobody read to you.* (Sallowreach)
- ◇ *Sump take you, and the sack split.* (Sallowreach)
- ◇ *May you be full.* (Fatlands; that is, may you never be. Said with a smile.)
- ◇ *Reaped at dusk and served at dawn.* (Fatlands)
- ◇ *May your wake be cold and your family thin.* (Fatlands)
- ◇ *May the field know your name.* (Fatlands; whispered, and meant.)
- ◇ *Go marry the water.* (Brinehollow)
- ◇ *May your rope be cut by someone who loves you.* (Brinehollow)
- ◇ *Salt in your bread and sea in your bed.* (Brinehollow)
- ◇ *May you come back courteous.* (Brinehollow; that is, Tenanted.)
- ◇ *Rest well.* (Vigil)
- ◇ *May you sleep on a soft night.* (Vigil)
- ◇ *Bed one for you, and nobody at the foot.* (Vigil)
- ◇ *May your nudger blink.* (Vigil)
- ◇ *May every door you shut stand open.* (Cradlewrack)
- ◇ *May you bear.* (Cradlewrack; said to men, and meant literally.)
- ◇ *Unnamed and untallied.* (Cradlewrack)
- ◇ *May the Question go against you.* (Cradlewrack)
- ◇ *Be talkative.* (Oathen)

- ◇ *May your echo find you.* (Oathen)
- ◇ *May you be the Surety for your own word.* (Oathen)
- ◇ *Forsworn and well-read.* (Oathen; that is, broken in a way everyone can see.)
- ◇ *Come in.* (the Fast; said to an enemy's back, and then they run.)
- ◇ *May there be a card with your name on it.* (the Fast)
- ◇ *May you be welcome.* (the Fast; the worst.)
- ◇ *Lack sit by you.* (the Rim; the universal curse of poverty.)
- ◇ *May you eat without grace among strangers.* (common)
- ◇ *May someone count your chair.* (common; the most feared, and the Compiler has heard it said only twice.)

◇

*The worst curse is a blessing in the next land over.
That is the whole Rim, said a carter to me, and spat,
and said Lack keep away, though we were not eating.*

THE COMPILER

THIRTY BLESSINGS

- ◇ *Lack keep away.* (common; the grace before every meal with strangers.)
- ◇ *May you finish.* (Sallowreach)
- ◇ *A clean Closing and a quick one.* (Sallowreach)
- ◇ *Thread in your seams and vinegar in your cloth.* (Sallowreach)
- ◇ *May your leaves fall.* (Sallowreach; a blessing on a child.)
- ◇ *You look heavy.* (Fatlands; the kindest thing one can say.)
- ◇ *Five meals and a sixth.* (Fatlands)
- ◇ *May you be served with the best plates.* (Fatlands; a blessing on the old.)
- ◇ *May the field thank you by name.* (Fatlands)
- ◇ *Cough clean.* (Brinehollow; said at dawn.)
- ◇ *A good rope and a heavy bed.* (Brinehollow)

- ◇ *May they call your name and bear you answer.* (Brinehollow)
- ◇ *May you come home dry.* (Brinehollow)
- ◇ *Pinch me.* (Vigil; love, trust, fear.)
- ◇ *A sharp nudger and a loud roof.* (Vigil)
- ◇ *May the rouse bold.* (Vigil)
- ◇ *Stand for one, and one, and two.* (Vigil; from the Waking Hymn.)
- ◇ *Not yet.* (Cradlewrack; said over swollen bellies of any kind.)
- ◇ *Knock first, and be answered.* (Cradlewrack)
- ◇ *May what comes stay.* (Cradlewrack; said at a birth the Attendance has permitted.)
- ◇ *May your doors keep.* (Cradlewrack)
- ◇ *Say little.* (Oathen; a farewell.)
- ◇ *If able.* (Oathen; the polite reply to anything.)
- ◇ *May your word be light.* (Oathen; said to a child at the Unbitting.)
- ◇ *No, thank you.* (the Fast; said three times, as a blessing on the speaker.)
- ◇ *May you carry your own bread.* (the Fast)
- ◇ *Walk into the wind.* (the Fast; a farewell to travelers.)
- ◇ *Safe road and an unlaid table.* (the Rim)
- ◇ *May the chair stay to the wall.* (the Rim; on Tablenight.)
- ◇ *May your portion be small.* (common, among Scraplings; a blessing on a newborn, that it carry little god.)

I HAVE FINISHED THE WORD-BOOK. THAT IS THE
 ONLY THING IN MY LIFE I HAVE BEEN ALLOWED TO
 FINISH, AND I AM FROM THE NORTH, AND I DO NOT KNOW
 WHAT TO DO WITH MY HANDS.

[THE COMPILER, LAST LEAF OF THE L-Z PROOFS, QUIRE, LAST PLATE OF
 CARVING, 641]

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